

PONNI'S BELOVED

Volume 5: Epitome of Sacrifice



SUMEETHA MANIKANDAN

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Epitome of Sacrifice

Sumeetha Manikandan

Version 1.0

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About The Author

Sumeetha Manikandan is a top bestselling romance author whose novellas 'Perfect Groom' and 'These Lines of Mehendi' have been on the top of Amazon India charts ever since their publication. A bookaholic, thinker, feminist and daydreamer, she reads across genres and is a crazy fan of history, romance and science fiction novels.

An avid reader of historical novels, she has been translating Kalki Krishnamurthy's classic Tamil novel Ponniyin Selvan for the past ten years and hopes to translate more of his novels into English.

Sumeetha is married to filmmaker K.S. Manikandan and lives with her daughter in Chennai.

Acknowledgements

I would like to acknowledge my father, S. Vijayaraghavan, who used to tell me the story of Ponniyin Selvan every evening during dinner and fuelled my interest to read the book.

My aunt, Ranganayaki, who lent me her Ponniyin Selvan books all those years ago when I was in school. I still treasure them to this day.

Navin and Vidya Sigamany for publishing the first drafts of Ponni's Beloved on their website Zine 5.com almost ten years ago. I would like to thank Inderpreet Kaur Uppal for her stellar efforts in editing the first two volumes.

A very special thanks to my second editor, Dhivya Balaji, for editing the rest of the volumes, especially Volume 5. Her passion to retain the original essence of the novel matched mine and I was glad to find another kindred soul who loved these books as much as I do.

Eternal thanks to Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan, who encouraged me to resume the translation again. Writer and Journalist, Dhivakar Venkataraman, for providing valuable historical guidance for the cover page artwork.

Meenakshi Devaraj, an avid fan of the Ponniyin Selvan series, who rendered great help in translating Poonguzhali's song and the Devaram poems in this volume.

Friends like Raja King, Fowzia Iqbal, Abirami Baskaran, Sastha Prakash, Ramanujam Jaganathan, Thirukambigai Devi and countless others, who followed the translation avidly and promoted it among numerous groups.

I would also like to dedicate this book to all those fans who have been asking me for years to publish my translation, and to my

husband who claims to be the first among them.

A special dedication is due to Abirami Baskaran whose encouraging words were invaluable. She was one of many who left us all too soon. May her soul rest in peace.

Author's Note

Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan was the first Tamil novel that I read. To tell you the truth, I learnt to read Tamil using elementary school books just so that I could read this story.

They say that good books and great authors can transform lives. I have found it to be true in my case. I started translating this book ten years ago as a hobby and realized that I could write. Today, I am a freelance writer who makes a living out of writing, and I owe my profession to this novel!

Many authors have written phenomenal books in Tamil literature after Kalki Krishnamurthy, but Ponniyin Selvan remains the most popular book, widely read by many. Ponniyin Selvan has the right mixture of all things that makes an epic – political intrigue, conspiracy, betrayal, huge dollops of romance, infidelity, seduction, passion, alluring women, unrequited love, sacrifice and pure love.

Ponni's Beloved is an English translation, and as many readers have pointed out, no translation can do justice to the original. I have tried to capture the essence and soul of Kalki's writing in my translation.

I recently visited all the places (in India) that are mentioned in this novel. We started on Aadi 18 (Aug 3, 2019) for this trail trip almost in the footsteps of Vandiya Devan, and saw all the fascinating places that he mentions in the journey. I have included some of the photos in this volume.

Thank you,

Sumeetha Manikandan.

Note: For those who wish to sign up for this tour trail, do contact Tour Bee (7299646588). The tour trail was well organized and the

curator had many interesting stories about each place that we visited.

Foreword

Kalki Krishnamurthy's Ponniyin Selvan was serialized in the post-independence era and it ran for four long years. Talking about a golden era in Tamil history, it ensnared the imagination of a huge swathe of the Tamil population with people queuing in railway stations long before dawn to lay their hands on that week's edition of the Kalki magazine.

An entire generation dwelt upon the freshness of the novel and surprisingly it was not condemned to the recesses of the mind as a childhood fancy but continued to entice readers of subsequent generations as they were born and introduced to the Tamil language. The novel still has a colossal following but is bounded by the hedges of a language that is not easy to learn, it strictly remained out of the mainstream and well within the realms of the Tamil-speaking world.

Tamil people have been habitual migrants and the diaspora is spread over numerous countries. In today's generation, though many of them can speak fluent Tamil they lack the patience to read the Tamil script that is spread over 1000 pages of a novel. And that's when the need arises a need for a good translation.

When I read the novel late in my thirties, social media was just picking up and I was introduced to the yahoo group of Ponniyin Selvan fans around the year 2001. For the first time, readers from different age groups, and settled in different lands were congregating online.

It was there that I came across a translation of Ponniyin Selvan into English. (There had been one earlier in print but that left much to be desired for those who had read the original. In fact, at one point the earlier translator mentioned 'Maize' for the Tamil word Cholam. But it was pointed out in the group that Maize entered India 500 years after the storyline period.)

The online translation was a bold bid by a youngster. As much as the substance within, the attempt bedazzled a lot of us because for 40 years or more it was almost sacrilege to deal with Kalki's works. The one sequel in the market at that time had been mauled by the copyright owners!

Over the next decade, many of the members of the Yahoo group became novelists, biographers, bloggers, heritage activists and a host of history and literature-connected personalities. And I would like to list Sumeetha's translation of Kalki's work as a starting point for all this.

A translated work should remind us of the original and it should have the author's imprint on the words. I think Sumeetha comes out in flying colours on both fronts. I am sure her work would open up the genius of Kalki to many who were deprived of it all these days.

Biography of Venkatesh Ramakrishnan:

Author Venkatesh Ramakrishnan is a Chennai-based bilingual novelist from India. South Indian historical fiction is his forte. He has published three novels in Tamil, 2 of them are sequels to the famous Kalki Krishnamurthy novels *Ponniyin Selvan* and *Sivagamiyin Sabatham* respectively, with the titles *Kaviri Mainthan* and *Kanji Tharagai*. One of his other fictional works in Tamil is *Thillayil Oru Kollaikaran*. *Gods, Kings & Slaves. The Siege of Madurai* is his first novel in English.

Character List

CHOLA ROYAL FAMILY

Paranthaka I – Grandfather of Sundara Chola, Paranthaka I ruled from 907 to 955 CE.

Rajadhithan – Eldest son and heir apparent of Paranthaka I. Prince Rajadhithan died in the Thakkolam War (950 CE), after which the crown was passed on to his younger brother Gandaraditha Chola.

Gandaradithan – Son of Paranthaka I. Sundara Chola's uncle. He was the Chola king from 950 to 957 CE. He was known for his great devotion to Lord Shiva.

Sembiyanmadevi – King Gandaradithan's queen, known for her piety and devotion to Lord Shiva. She belongs to the clan of Mazhavarayar and married the king despite his advanced age.

Aringzhan Chola – Son of Paranthaka I, and the father of Sundara Chola. He reigned for a very short period (from 956 to 957 CE).

Kalyani – Wife of Aringzhan Chola and the mother of Sundara Chola. She belongs to the Vaithumbarayar clan and is famous for her beauty.

Madhuranthakan – Son of King Gandaradithan and Sembiyanmadevi, and the first cousin of Sundara Chola.

Paranthaka II (Sundara Chola) – Emperor of the Chola and Pandya kingdoms from 957 to 970 CE, when this story happens. His handsomeness earned him the popular epithet of 'Sundara Chola,' meaning Handsome Chola.

Vanamadevi – Consort of Paranthaka II and the empress of the Cholas, she is the mother of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan, Princess Kundavai, and Prince Arulmozhivarman. Her father is the noble chief Thirukkovalur Malayaman.

Aditya Karikalan – Eldest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, and crown prince to the Chola throne, Aditya Karikalan is a peerless warrior who defeated and killed the Pandya king and established Chola suzerainty over his kingdom.

Kundavai – Daughter of Sundara Chola and the younger sister of Aditya Karikalan. Kundavai is cherished throughout the kingdom for her wit, wisdom, grace, and intelligence. She lives in Pazhaiarai along with her companions and friends.

Arulmozhivarman – The youngest son of Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi, Arulmozhivarman is known throughout the kingdom as ‘Ponniyin Selvan.’ He later ascended the Chola throne as Raja Raja Cholan (985 - 1014 CE).

Noble Clans

PAZHUVUR CLAN

Periya Pazhuvetarayar – Lord Treasurer of the Chola kingdom and a peerless warrior who carried 64 battle scars on his body. He is the patriarch and the king of the powerful Pazhuvur clan and is an influential courtier and nobleman at the Chola court.

Nandini Devi – Queen and wife of Periya Pazhuvetarayar, Nandini is a young woman renowned for her beauty. Nandini’s antecedents are a mystery and her past life is shrouded in secrecy.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar – Also known as Kalanthaka Kanda, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is the younger brother of Periya Pazhuvetarayar and is the commander of the Thanjavur fort. A powerful man with a strong physique, he is also the father-in-law of Prince Madhuranthakan.

KODUMBALUR CLAN

Budivikrama Kesari – The commander of troops in Elangai, he is also known as Kodumbalur Periya Vellar. He is the patriarch of the Kodumbalur Clan.

Vanathi – A Kodumbalur princess and the niece of Budivikrama Kesari, Vanathi is also the cherished companion and friend of Princess Kundavai, who hopes to wed her to Prince Arulmozhivarman.

Kodumbalur Siriya Vellar – Father of Vanathi and the younger brother of Budivikrama Kesari, he died valiantly in Elangai after leading a campaign across the sea.

SAMBUVARAYAR CLAN

Singannar Sambuvarayar – A powerful lord who ruled over Kadambur.

Kandanmaran – Son of Sambuvarayar who also fought along with Aditya Karikalan in many wars.

Manimegalai – Daughter of Sambuvarayar and the sister of Kandanmaran.

MALAYAMAN CLAN

Thirukkovalur Malayaman – Patriarch of the Malayaman clan and the father-in-law of Sundara Chola. He is close to his oldest grandson Aditya Karikalan.

VANAR CLAN

Vandiya Devan – Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan is Aditya Karikalan's bodyguard, friend, and confidante.

PANDYA KING'S BODYGUARDS

Ravidasan – The ringleader of the Pandya Abathuuthavigal who wish to avenge the death of their king. He is also known as 'Mandiravadi.'

Soman Sambavan – One of the conspirators and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

Edupankari – One of the Pandya conspirators who works in the Kadambur palace and overhears the noblemen's plots about the Chola succession.

Devaralan – Also known as Parameshwaran, he is one of the Pandya Abathuuthavigal who works in the Kadambur palace.

OTHER IMPORTANT CHARACTERS

Anirudha Brahmarayar – Prime Minister of the Chola Kingdom, and Sundara Cholar's trusted childhood friend and confidante.

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi – A Vaishnavite and a spy who is also known as Thirumalai or Thirumalaiappan. He also claims to be Nandini Devi's foster brother.

Parthibendra Pallavan – Close confidante and friend of Aditya Karikalan and a scion of the old Pallava dynasty.

Kudanthai Jodhidar – An astrologer in Kudanthai (present-day Kumbakonam) who is patronized by Kundavai.

KARAIYAR FAMILY

Thyagavidanga Karaiyar – Guardian of Kodi Karai lighthouse and father Poonguzhali and her brother Murugayyan.

Mandakini – Older sister of Thyagavidanga Karaiyar and Poonguzhali's aunt. She is also the woman who Sundara Cholar falls

in love with while in Elangai. Many suspect her to be the mother of Nandini. Many also call her 'Oomai Rani' (translates to Mute Queen).

Vaani Ammai – Senthana Amuthan's deaf and mute mother, and the twin sister of Mandakini.

Senthana Amuthan – A devout Shaivite who provides flowers from his garden to Thallikullathar Temple; the son of Vaani Ammai.

Poonguzhali – Senthana Amuthan's cousin who lives in Kodi Karai; the boat girl who saves the life of Ponniyin Selvar.

Murugayyan – Poonguzhali's brother who is timid and under the control of his wife. He also plies his boat for his livelihood.

Rakkammal – Murugayyan's wife, who is also a Pandya rebel and a member of Ravidasan's gang.

Karuthiruman – A boatman who saves Mandakini and is in love with Vaani Ammai.

King Mahindan – King of Elangai who is presently hiding in Rohana mountains.

The Story So Far...

In the 10th Century AD, the glorious Cholas ruled over the land of Tamil Nadu with emperor Sundara Chola on the throne. Sundara Chola had become bedridden with paralysis and there was confusion all over the Kingdom about who would ascend the throne next. The emperor has two sons and one daughter. The eldest, Aditya Karikalan, was anointed the crown prince of the Kingdom but his uncle Madhuranthakan (whose father ruled prior to Sundara Chola) also wished to ascend the throne.

The story begins when Aditya Karikalan sends his trusted bodyguard and friend Vandiya Devan with two messages, one for the emperor and the other for his sister Princess Kundavai. Vandiya Devan learns at Kadambur that all the important noblemen of the court, led by the Pazhuvur brothers, are hatching a conspiracy to crown Prince Madhuranthakan as the next Emperor.

While on his journey, Vandiya Devan also meets a fat Vaishnavan named Azhwarkadiyan Nambi (also known as Thirumalai) who wants to meet with Periya Pazhuvetarayar's wife who was once his sister. Vandiya Devan uses Nambi's name to meet with Nandini and she gives him a signet ring to enter the fort. Nambi, in the meanwhile, finds out that a gang of Pandya bodyguards are hatching a murderous plan to kill Prince Aditya Karikalan who had beheaded their king, and they were being aided with gold right from the treasury of the Cholas by Nandini.

Vandiya Devan goes to Thanjavur and successfully delivers his messages to the emperor in private. Fort Commander Chinna Pazhuvetarayar suspects his intentions and tries to imprison him, but he escapes and ends up in Nandini's palace, where she tries to allure him with her seductive beauty. He escapes from the fort through the underground passage and saves Kandanmaran's life.

He meets Princess Kundavai and falls in love with her. Kundavai sends a message to Arulmozhivarman, her younger brother who is warring in Elangai, to come back home, and hands it over to Vandiya Devan.

Vandiya Devan goes to Kodi Karai and with the help of Poonguzhali, a boat girl, he goes to Elangai.

In Kanchipuram, Aditya Karikalan's grandsire advises him to bring his brother Arulmozhi back from Elangai. His friend Parthibendran agrees to go to Elangai. And before he leaves, Karikalan reveals how much he loved Nandini and how she had betrayed him by trying to save the life of Pandya King and then subsequently marrying the old man Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

Kundavai arrives in Thanjavur and her father confesses to her that he had once loved a deaf and mute woman in Elangai who later committed suicide by jumping from a lighthouse. The emperor believes that he sees her ghost in the night, but Kundavai suspects that Nandini is acting like her mother's spirit to learn the truth about her birth. She also learns that Nandini could be her own sister!

In Elangai, Vandiya Devan meets with Nambi again and they both set out to meet Prince Arulmozhi and successfully give him the messages. They also meet a deaf and mute woman who loves the prince as her own son and saves his life many times. Vandiya Devan is astonished by her resemblance to Nandini and suspects that she might be her mother.

They also receive news from the boat girl Poonguzhali that the emperor has sent two ships to imprison the prince on the charge that he tried to usurp the throne of Elangai for his own. The prince leaves along with Poonguzhali to meet the ships. The prince finds out that the ships that came to imprison him were destroyed by the Arabs, and that they have imprisoned Vandiya Devan. He sets out in Parthibendran's ship to rescue Vandiya Devan. During a fierce storm, Vandiya Devan kills the Arab pirates with the help of the Pandya gang who later escape, abandoning him on the ship. The

prince rescues him and later Poonguzhali rescues them both while they are lost at sea.

The prince contracts a shivering fever and is incoherent. Vandiya Devan and Poonguzhali take him along with Senthana Amuthan to Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam to treat his fever. In the meanwhile, Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Nandini, who are at Kodi Karai, learn that the prince is lost at sea. Parthibendran falls for the seductive allure of Nandini and is enamoured by her.

Vandiya Devan travels to Pazhaiarai to give Kundavai the news that the prince has arrived and is safe, though the rest of the kingdom thinks that he is dead. There are riots in Pazhaiarai when the news spreads. In the meanwhile, Nandini had sent Aditya Karikalan a message with Kandanmaran, asking him to meet at Kadambur to start peace talks and to wed Kandanmaran's sister to Aditya Karikalan. But Kundavai fears that it was a trap to kill him and sends Vandiya Devan to dissuade him from meeting Nandini.

Vandiya Devan and Nambi set out again to Kanchi. Kundavai meets Prince Arulmozhi and asks him to stay in the Viharam for a while.

In the meanwhile, Aditya Karikalan is on his way to Kadambur palace when his grandfather Malayaman tries to dissuade him unsuccessfully. Vandiya Devan and Nambi are near Kadambur Palace with their possessions washed away in the flood. They are trying to buy a horse to reach Aditya Karikalan before he arrives at Kadambur. They go to an isolated Ayyanar Temple to sleep when they see Edupankari coming there suddenly through an underground passage. Vandiya Devan travels through the passage and discovers that it ends in Kadambur Palace's hunters' chambers. He also discovers that the hunters' chambers open into women's anthappuram and learns that Nandini would be staying in that room. After a while, he hears Ravidasan and his gang approaching the hunters' chambers, leading him to hurriedly enter anthappuram where he encounters Manimegalai, Kandanmaran's sister.

Manimegalai had been in love with Vandiya Devan for a long time and has been resisting her brother's attempts to marry her off, first to Madhuranthakan and then to Aditya Karikalan. She demands an explanation from Vandiya Devan about his presence in the anthappuram. Vandiya Devan escapes from there through the terrace and jumps out of the palace where he meets Nambi. And together, they steal two horses and join Aditya Karikalan.

Aditya Karikalan gets a rousing welcome from Kadambur palace and the chieftains who had gathered, but his reckless behaviour and disrespectful attitude scare them out of their wits.

Near Kodi Karai, Poonguzhali and Senthana Amuthan are on their way to Nagapattinam when they spot Mandakini Devi in the woods. She had come there to know the fate of Ponniyin Selvar and Poonguzhali agrees to take her to the Viharam. Senthana Amuthan bids her goodbye and leaves for Thanjavur. While on their way, a few men kidnap Mandakini Devi and tie Poonguzhali to the boat. Senthana Amuthan rescues her and together they decide to follow the men who have abducted their aunt.

On the way to Thanjavur, a storm causes them to take refuge in a mandapam where they see the men who had abducted their aunt and they also see her sitting in the palanquin. Poonguzhali switches places with her and finds out that it was the Prime Minister who had hatched this plan to abduct Mandakini. Princess Kundavai, who comes to the prime minister's palace, convinces Poonguzhali to bring her aunt to the palace as they wished to unite the emperor with his lost love.

Poonguzhali agrees and tries to bring her to the prime minister's palace, but on the way, she sees Ravidasan and Soman Sambavan in the crowd and follows them to the underground chamber in Periya Pazhuvetarayar's palace. Mandakini learns that Soman Sambavan was planning to remain hidden in the underground dungeon until he finds the right time to assassinate Sundara Chola. She tries to frighten him while he is alone in the dungeon and comes out of the passageway, ending up in Sundara Chola's bedroom.

Sundara Chola, who is initially frightened by her presence, becomes furious when he learns that she had been alive all this while. That night, Mandakini is anxious about the assassin and she wakes up Poonguzhali and takes her into the underground chamber.

At Kadambur, Aditya Karikalan is openly discussing the conspiracy that the chieftains had hatched behind his back and laughs at their idea of dividing the empire. He demands that Periya Pazhuvetarayar bring Madhuranthakan to Kadambur to settle the issue of succession once and for all. Pazhuvetarayar decides to go to Thanjavur, but Nandini refuses to come with him, citing that she wants to protect his interest. Though he is filled with misgivings, Pazhuvetarayar starts for Thanjavur.

Nandini and Manimegalai go to Veera Narayana Dam to spend the day outdoors while Aditya Karikalan, Vandiya Devan, and others go to the nearby woods to hunt. While hunting down a wounded tiger, they follow it to the island where Nandini and Manimegalai were picnicking. There, Karikalan speaks to Nandini and seeks her forgiveness, telling her that she is Sundara Chola's daughter and his sister. Nandini refutes his claims as stories and blames Vandiya Devan for having lecherous thoughts about her. The four of them are forced to spend many hours together while a storm rages around them. Sambuvarayar brings a big ship to rescue them.

Chapter 1: Three Voices

Prince Arulmozhivarman had been waiting patiently for a long time. He was impatient to go to Thanjavur to meet his parents. He was also keen to prove to his father that he didn't conspire to snatch the throne of Elangai from Chola suzerainty and that he was innocent of the charges that were laid on him.

Nevertheless, he waited for a message from his dear sister before he left the sanctuary of the monastery. But it was difficult to pass time. Therefore, he took part in the daily prayers of the monks. He spent many hours looking at the beautiful paintings that were drawn on the walls of the monastery. He also took pleasure in discussing worldly affairs with the head monk, an old bikshu who had travelled to many far-away islands from China to Saavaga Theevu^[1]. The prince, who was fascinated by his travels, asked him to describe the places that he had been to, the people, and their culture....

He learned that the island of Kadaram^[2], known as the Sri Vijayam Kingdom, controlled many other small islands in the region. The prince asked the Bikshu to describe these kingdoms and the monk tirelessly told him everything that he knew about these places.

From environment to trade, people's habits, and customs, he told him many things. He also gave the prince a brief history of each kingdom and their ties to the old Pallava Kingdom, which resulted in a cultural exchange of arts and architecture. He also told him how the people there followed Buddhism but were also well-versed in the epics of the Hindu religion such as Ramayana and Mahabharata, and how they worshipped Hindu Gods as well. He also told him that the people had a special respect for Sage Agastya and worshipped him as the 'Father of Tamil Language' and had built many temples to honour him.

The prince committed to his memory all this information, especially the routes that would take him to these islands, and the

dangers that were inherent in the journey.

“Swami, is there any chance that you might visit these places again?”

“If the Lord Buddha wishes it, then I might visit them again. Why do you ask?”

“I wish to come along with you!”

“Prince, I am a monk who has forsaken this world. You are the son of the emperor. How can we travel together? It has been a huge responsibility to take care of you while you were here. Every minute, I fear that something untoward might happen....”

“Swami, I can lessen your burden by leaving immediately...”

“Prince, forgive me. I misspoke my fears. Taking care of your health and giving you sanctuary in this Viharam can in no way repay the benevolence and grace shown by your father and sister. You have helped us greatly by repairing and restoring our great old monasteries in Elangai and have also earned the respect and regard of our monastic leaders. They offered the throne of Elangai to you! Why did you refuse it? If you had become an independent king of that island kingdom, you would have your own fleet of ships and you can visit all these places on your own. You don’t have to follow this old monk....”

“Swami, have you read the epic poem ‘Maha Vamsam’ that chronicles the history of Elangai kings?”

“Ayya, what are you saying? How could I become the head of this monastery without studying it?”

“Forgive me, I wanted to ask you whether you can read it in its original language. The epic chronicles the despicable deeds of the Elangai royal family in their quest for power. The son imprisons the father to seize the throne, while the mother kills the son with poison.

A son throws the mother into the fire... and there is no need to talk about the uncles, father-in-law, stepmothers, and stepsisters... Didn't the Maha Vamsam talk about the atrocities that people did to each other just to grab the throne?"

"True, but never forget that these incidents were used to teach people never to falter away from the path of dharma. And if they do, what kind of consequences they would have to face? Maha Vamsam is a holy book that can help people walk the path of dharma..."

"Swami, I am not finding fault with the holy book. I am merely saying that it chronicles the evil actions of people who tried to seize the throne of Elangai. That's why I see nothing wrong in rejecting the said throne."

"No, it was a wrong decision. The monastic heads of Elangai wanted a dynastic change in the kingdom. The atrocities and the evils committed by the previous dynasties had to be punished. Through you, they wished to establish a new lineage for the kingdom. You rejected a rare opportunity wherein you could have helped to spread and protect our faith far and wide like Emperor Ashoka..."

"Swami, it is unfair to compare me, who is hiding in the sanctuary of your Viharam, with the mighty Emperor Ashoka. Truly, I am unworthy to be even your disciple and you are hoping that I would protect your faith..."

"Prince, you have great inner strength. If you could but accept the faith of Buddha, you will get the opportunity to become as great as Ashoka!"

"Right from a young age, I have enshrined Murugan, Ganapathy, Shiva, Parvathy, and Perumal in my heart. I cannot forsake them and embrace the faith of Buddha. Forgive me, Swami. When I asked to come with you on your travels, it was not my intention to travel as a Bikshu and spread the faith of Buddha. I merely wish to see all these places..."

“Prince, I mistook your intent. Forgive me. But it cannot be denied that there is a deep connection between the faith of Buddha and your dynasty. In the lore of Buddha, we believe that he was born as the Chola Emperor Sibi, who offered his flesh to a wounded pigeon. The kings of the Chola empire claim to have descended from this great emperor. That’s why you adorn the title ‘Sembiyan’ when you assume the throne. Never forget that!”

“I can’t forget it, Swami. My blood and flesh remind me every day that I belong to the dynasty from which Emperor Sibi and Manu Needhi Cholan were born. They remind me to forsake wealth and comfort and help people. I also have ancestors like Vijayalaya Chola and Karikala Vallavan who ask me to pick up my sword, gather my army, go on conquests, and find glory in war and expanding the empire. Kings like Aditha Cholan, who had built great temples, ask me to renovate temples and build huge structures for the abode of Gods. I feel as if I am being pulled in all directions. In many ways, it might be better if I could embrace the faith of Buddha. I would like to learn more about him.”

The Buddha Bikshu’s face brightened when he heard this and he said, “Prince, you already know a lot of Buddha. What’s there for me to teach you?”

“Explain that picture that is drawn on the wall. I see a prince getting up from the bed. Who is the woman lying beside him and the baby in the cradle? Why is he leaving and why is he looking worried?”

“Prince, when Buddha was young, he was called Siddhartha and he was a prince just like you. He was married to the beautiful Yashodhara, and they had a new-born son. His father, the King, was ready to hand over the responsibility of the kingdom to him but Siddhartha wished to find ways to reduce people’s misery. Therefore, he renounced his wife, his son, and all worldly pleasures. This picture shows how he left his family behind in the dead of the night. Prince, haven’t you heard of this story before?”

“Yes, I have heard it before. But nothing tells a story like a beautiful picture. It has been so vividly portrayed here that I feel like waking up Yashodara and warning her, ‘Look, Siddhartha is leaving you. Stop him.’ Alright, tell me about the next picture.”

The old bikshu thus patiently explained each picture to the Prince with great care. In his heart of hearts, he did nurse a hope that the prince would one day embrace the faith of Buddha and therefore took particular care in explaining Siddhartha’s life history to him. The last picture showed Siddhartha under the tree of enlightenment where he receives the wisdom of the world. After hearing the bikshu’s explanations about it, the prince said, “Gurudeva, If I were to express an opinion that is contrary to yours, would you get angry?”

“Prince, I am a monk who has renounced this world. There is no room for anger in my heart. Please speak your mind.”

“I do not believe that Siddhartha gained enlightenment under the Bodhi tree.”

“Prince, during Ashoka’s reign, a branch from this tree was brought to Elangai and was nurtured carefully. It grew into a large tree and it still exists in Anuradhapuram. I am sure you must have seen it yourself. Then why do you disbelieve this fact?”

“Gurudeva, I don’t dispute the fact that the Bodhi tree exists but I don’t believe that Siddhartha got enlightened when he sat under it. On the contrary, the day he left his beautiful wife and his new-born son and a kingdom that rightfully belonged to him, to alleviate the suffering of the people... that’s when he received enlightenment. The sacrifice that he made that day is unlike anything we have seen in any stories or epics. Rama gave up his kingdom and went to the forest because his father ordered him to do so. Bharata refused to accept the kingdom that came to him because he was devoted to Rama. King Harishchandra gave up his kingdom because he had given his word to Sage Vishwamitra. Emperor Sibi had to cut off his own flesh and offer it to the pigeon because he had given sanctuary

to it. Prince Siddhartha had no such compulsion. He didn't have to sacrifice anything to please someone. He still gave up everything and left everything behind. I don't think he did anything so wonderful after he became enlightened. That's why I have always believed that when Siddhartha left the palace, leaving behind his kingdom, wife, son and worldly comforts... that's when he became enlightened!"

The prince's explanation greatly endeared him to the bikshu. He said, "While there is much truth in what you said, Buddha did indeed find a solution to the miseries of this world when he sat and meditated under the tree. That's where he started preaching to the people."

"Swami, more than what he preached, I find that there is a great lesson to learn from his life. That's why I would like to follow his example. I told you a while ago that three types of voices are heard within me. I would like to free myself from them. Kindly accept me as your disciple!"

"Prince, to gain a disciple like yourself is like gaining a treasure but I am unsuited for this honour. Nor am I brave enough. You could petition the Council of Biskshus in Elangai for this!"

"I have no doubts about the fact that only you could be my Guru. But what is it that you were saying about being brave?"

"Yes, my prince. I am not brave enough to accept you as my disciple. For the past two days, a rumour has been spreading across Nagapattinam that you have been living here and that we are forcibly attempting to convert you to the faith of Buddha. This has angered many in the city and some are even trying to mobilize people to attack the Viharam over this outrage."

"Aha! What is this foolishness? Why should people object if I joined the faith of Buddha? Why would they consider it an outrage if I shaved my head and wore ochre robes? I am not even married... so they can't even blame me for abandoning my wife!"

“Ayya, the people are not angry with you, but they are outraged by the fact that we are trying to turn you into a bikshu. If a mere rumour can incense the people thus, then imagine what would happen if it happened for real? People will storm into this Viharam and turn it into dust. Under the benevolent rule of your father, we have been living happily for so long. We even recite a special prayer for his health and long life every day. We don’t want to ruin our peaceful life here. That’s why I said that I dare not accept you as my disciple.”

Even as spoke thus, a huge clamour of voices could be heard outside the Viharam. The old Bikshu heard the commotion silently and then said, “It looks like the people have come in thousands to prove the truth of my words. I know not how to allay their fears. Only Lord Buddha should show me the way.”

He was right. Thousands had gathered in front of the Viharam, standing as one, and their voices were raised in protest.

Chapter 2: Here comes Murugayyan

With growing trepidation, the prince and the bikshu heard the roar of people who were gathered outside. More and more people were convening, and their voices soared to the sky. As some minutes passed, the prince anguished over bringing such trouble on the gentle bikshus who had given him a second lease of life.

“Swami, I am sorry for bringing this trouble to your doorstep.”

“Prince, we are ready to face thousands of such troubles on your account. We are greatly indebted to your sister and father. And this is nothing in comparison to the help they have rendered us.”

“That’s not all. I don’t like this kind of subterfuge. I don’t want you to utter falsehoods for my sake. I would rather go out now and declare that I am staying here voluntarily, that you have healed me from a dangerous disease and given me a second lease of life. I don’t want this Viharam and its inmates to be subjected to any harm because of me.”

“Ayya, I don’t think that our actions would be construed thus. Your enemies have been going around the city, spreading rumours. Their intent is to force you to come out in the open. I don’t see any harm in hiding the fact that you are living here. Royal families have often been subjected to these situations. Didn’t the Pandavas live incognito for a year? Should we say Yudhishtira uttered falsehoods?”

“Gurudeva, I can’t debate with you and hope to win. But you mentioned the Pandavas and their year of being incognito. Yes, they had to stay hidden during this period because it was one of the conditions of the dice game they lost. I am not under any such duress. You talk about my enemies, but I would like to know who they are and why they are so against me. I have no wish to rule the kingdom. And when they hear me say it, they may no longer be my enemies; they may even become my friends. And I don’t want to

cause any more trouble for you and if people were to derive some satisfaction about the fact that I am alive, then let it be so. I don't see any harm in this."

"Prince! What you are saying is right, and I would probably act in the same manner if I were you. But we can't allow you to do it because we have given word to your dear sister. You have said that there is no one as intelligent and wise as your sister, Princess Kundavai, in the entire Chola clan. It is also my belief that there has been no other Princess as wise as your sister in any royal family. And she instructed us to give you sanctuary until she sends word, and we know that she wouldn't ask this of us unless there is a sound reason. Rumours abound around the kingdom that there is a conspiracy against your family and the emperor. We also know that the Pandyan conspirators are waiting for a chance to avenge their king. Many are worried that we are aiding these conspirators to wreak their vengeance and that's why they are gathering outside. This is not the right time to expose yourself. Think carefully. I would rather that we die at their hands than hand you over to them. We are not afraid for our skins. If we are harmed in your defence, then let it be so."

Just when he was saying this, a younger bikshu came to the room hurriedly and said, "Swami, the situation is getting out of hand. These people are shouting that they want to meet the prince. They are refusing to believe us when we insisted that he is not here. They want to come inside the Viharam and search on their own. If we don't give them a satisfying answer, I am afraid they will force their way inside!"

The senior bikshu stood with a resigned expression and said, "What answer can we give them? Only Lord Buddha, in his infinite compassion, can change their mind."

The prince interjected and said, "Gurudeva, please listen to me. Your disciples have already told the people that I am not here. In this situation, if I were to reveal myself, it will prove your disciples false and that might anger the people even more..."

“I am sure of it, and we are willing to bear the brunt of their anger.”

“I would rather prove their words to be true.”

“Prince, how is that possible? They have already uttered these falsehoods, there is no taking back the words!”

“Yes, there is. I can leave this Viharam before the people come here.”

“Aha! You want us to go back on our word to your sister just so we could keep our lives. We will not throw you out just to save ourselves.”

“Gurudeva, there is nothing despicable about this. Along the canal stands the Chola Palace at Anaimangalam. That’s where my sister stayed when she came here. I will go there and stay until these people leave. Later, when things have calmed down, I will come back here.”

The bikshu considered this idea and seemed to agree with it.

“Alright, this seems to be a reasonable solution and we don’t have to go back on our word to your sister, either. But what if there are people waiting along the canal? What if they see you?”

“Gurudeva, there is a solution for this. We can ask one of the people from the crowd to come inside the Viharam to search for the prince,” suggested the younger bikshu.

“What if he sees the prince inside and tells others about it?”

“We can delay him a bit while we take him around the Viharam. It’s going to be dark soon, and the prince can get away from here under the cover of darkness. That’s not the only danger that we face. There is a storm brewing in the sea and waves are rising high. Soon,

there will be torrential rains and we might escape our present troubles...”

“Don’t say that. Why should we pray for disasters just to get out of our troubles?” chided the older bikshu.

“Swami, I think we should do what your disciple is saying. We can ask one of the men standing outside to come inside the Viharam and search. I can even talk to this person and request him and ask him to cooperate with us.”

“We can try it. Two days ago, a boatman and his wife had come to the Viharam asking after you. They adamantly demanded an audience with you. The boatman’s wife shouted a lot...”

“Who are they? What was his name?”

“His name was Murugayyan. He is the son of Thyaga Vida Karaiyar in Kodikarai.”

“I know him well. He is very devoted to me. Why didn’t you bring him to me?”

“We thought that his wife would not cooperate with us and keep our secret. Now they both are there at the gates ahead of the crowd.”

“This is a lucky coincidence for us. Murugayyan will not listen to anybody else but me. Bring him to me. I will speak to him. He can come later in the evening and take me to the Chola Palace through the canal.”

“Prince, these are dangerous times. It would be prudent not to trust anybody completely. For the past two days, this boatman and his wife have been spreading rumours about you staying here.”

“That’s fine. In the present situation, we need somebody inside to search the Viharam. It might as well be him. I know that his wife

dominates him, but he will not listen to her if I request him to help me. If possible, please bring him here.”

After the senior bikshu acceded to this request, the younger bikshu went outside to speak to the crowd. The senior bikshu stayed a while and then said, “Prince, I am not at peace. I will go outside and see what’s happening. My blunders should not result in the destruction of this Viharam. And at the same time, no harm should befall you!”

Chapter 3: The Sea Rose

The scene outside the Viharam alarmed the bikshu. Thousands of people had gathered and were shouting themselves hoarse. He also realised that it would be easy to incite them into violence as many had come armed with spears, swords and sticks, and were raising them menacingly. Some even had come with iron hammers and their intent probably was to raze the Viharam to the ground. The bikshu knew that the town's populace had many reasons to destroy the Viharam. The Chola Kingdom and the island kingdom of Elangai have been in a constant state of war since the times of Emperor Paranthakan I. Many Chola soldiers have died in these wars and the people's anger over this had turned towards the faith of Buddha and the monks who live in the Viharam. The bikshu feared that the years of resentment against the Elangai wars had reached a tipping point by carefully planting wrong news.

When the people saw the bikshu, they clamoured to express their discontent and anger, "Give our prince back to us or we will demolish the Viharam!"

As their voices rose in protest, the bikshu noted that the sea, too, was roaring with violent waves lashing at the beach. He realized that the younger bikshu had been right. A violent storm was indeed brewing at sea, and it would soon strike the town. He thought that it would be pure luck if the Viharam survived the crowd's anger and nature's fury as well.

The young bikshu stepped in front of his Guru and tried to talk to the crowd, "Please, I beg you, listen to me. Our Guru is here. Do calm down. We can't allow everybody inside the Viharam, but I can take one or two people from among you with me, and they can search the place for the prince. But everyone here should accept what they say. Is this agreeable to you? So, who wants to come inside the Viharam?"

Hundreds of them shouted back, saying, “I will come inside!” “Let me in...”

The Young bikshu tried to calm them and said, “This is not helping anyone. Select one or two people from among you. Choose someone who has recently seen the prince, so it will be easy for them to recognize him if he is indeed here.”

That was when Rakkammal, who was in the forefront of the crowd, came forward and shouted, “We saw him recently. We will come inside.”

The Young bikshu saw them and asked Murugayyan, “Is she telling the truth?”

Murugayyan said, “Well, it is I who have seen the prince recently, not her. I saw him a month ago. When I had inadvertently made a blunder, I fell at his feet to seek his forgiveness and he forgave me. I still remember his compassionate smile and sweet words. I can recognize him easily.”

“Then you are the right person to come inside. Whatever your wife is saying is not far from the truth. Whatever you saw with your eyes, she feels that she has seen it, too. Now if I take you inside the Viharam to check the premises, she will accept whatever you have to say. I am sure she knows that we cannot allow a woman inside the monastery. Come with me, let’s go inside.”

Saying thus, he approached Murugayyan, took his hand, turned towards the crowd and said, “Here is the boatman, Murugayyan, who has met the prince recently. He will accompany me inside and search the monastery and report back his findings to you. Will you accept his word?”

The crowd was divided in its response. Some murmured their assent while others raised suspicions, “Is this a trick to fool us?”

Noticing that the crowd were not satisfied with this, the young bikshu declared, "My dear people, here is our Gurudeva. If you have any doubts, he will answer all your questions. In the meantime, I will take Murugayyan inside the monastery."

The senior bikshu stepped forward to view the crowd. His calm demeanour and stately features inspired respect and deference. They hesitated to bombard him with questions that they had been shooting towards the younger bikshu.

The old bikshu surveyed the crowd calmly for a few minutes and looked intently towards the sea rolling in the background. "My dear people, I know why you have come here. I know the extent of love and respect that you bear towards Prince Arulmozhiarman. Just like you, even we have immense love and respect towards him. The day we heard that he had drowned at sea, I stood here with tears flowing through my eyes. All those who follow the faith of Buddha are eternally indebted to the prince, as he has provided us with immense help. He has helped our faith by renovating and repairing the dilapidated monasteries and stupas in the ancient city of Anuradhapuram. How can we cause harm to such a prince? We have been praying for his survival and good health ever since we heard the news. We have more reasons to love and cherish the prince, trust me."

At that time, someone from the crowd cheekily said, "That's what scares us. What if your love for us goes overboard and you shave his head, hand him ochre clothes, and turn him into a monk, like yourself?"

Many around him laughed at that comment.

Hearing these words, the old Bikshu uncharacteristically got incensed and spoke without thought, "I will never force Prince Arulmozhiarman to become a monk or to embrace the faith of Buddha. Even if he were to express a desire to become a monk, I will never shave his head or hand him ochre clothes. The prince was born to rule and he has captured all our hearts. It would be unfair to

deny him to this world. This, I swear on the lotus feet of Lord Buddha! Buddham Gatchami! Dharmam Gatchami! Sangam Gatchami!”

The emotionally charged outburst from the old bikshu touched the hearts of the people. Some started crying while others were stunned into silence.

The old Bikshu continued, “My dear people, I hope I have allayed your fears about the prince. Now, it’s time for you to worry about your families and homes. We are now seeing a storm approaching our coast. This is unlike any other storm or cyclone we have seen in these parts. Turn around and see the sea!”

The people turned around to see where he was pointing and were aghast to see the rough sea waves coming towards the town to engulf their houses. The tides rose so high that even a tall structure like the Choodamani Viharam could be destroyed and drowned in its fury.

“Look at your homes,” said the old Bikshu.

The Viharam was situated to the north of Nagapattinam. From there, they could see the merchant buildings that stood nearest to the sea to trade with the ships and captains who came to the port. Beyond these buildings stood rows of houses of the people in the crowd. They could already see the sea charging within these streets, engulfing them with a fury they had never seen before.

“My dear people, we once heard that Kaveripattinam became prey to the sea’s anger. I will pray to Lord Buddha that such a fate does not wait for Nagapattinam now. Go back to your homes and try to save your children, parents, old people, and your possessions,” said the old bikshu, his voice faltering with fear and sorrow.

Hearing this, the crowd dispersed almost immediately, with some running towards their houses and others following them in a rush.

Within a few minutes, the courtyard was empty, with nary a soul around.

Murugayyan's wife Rakkammal alone stood there, saying, "What about my husband?"

"Nothing will happen to your husband. He will come back safe. You need to go now and save yourself."

"No! No! How can I leave without my husband? Let me also come inside."

"No! Women cannot enter our monastery. Don't you know that?"

Just then, a man appeared and approached Rakkammal hurriedly. He whispered something in her ears and started dragging her away from there. Rakkammal too hurried along with him without protests.

Who could that be? Why is she going with him? The old Bikshu wondered as he hurried inside to where the prince was waiting. Murugayyan was there, looking at the prince with a devoted expression and intently listening to him.

"Muruga! You need to come back here tonight and take me to Anaimangalam."

Hearing this, the old bikshu said, "Prince, you don't have to wait until tonight, the crowd outside has dispersed. You can leave immediately," and he related to the prince what had transpired outside.

"Gurudeva, if the crowd has dispersed, then why should I leave?" asked the prince.

"What if they come back? And didn't you promise us that you will not make liars out of us? I request you to keep your word!"

The old bikshu feared that the sea might soon claim the Viharam and drown it under the rising waters. That's why he wanted the prince to leave immediately. The Chola Palace in Anaimangalam was in the eastern direction and was therefore relatively safer than anywhere else. The palace was a sturdy building and could withstand the onslaught of the storm and the waters.

The prince accepted the old bikshu's advice and ordered the boat to be brought there immediately. In the meantime, the bikshu spoke to the rest of his disciples and said, "We serve Lord Buddha. Today we have seen a disaster unfolding in front of our eyes here. The people of Nagapattinam are in distress and they need our help. We have seen the sea water entering their houses, and many have lost their loved ones and their valuable possessions. I would like you all to go in all four directions and help the people in any way you can. Try and save as many people as possible from the wrath of the Sea God. I have become too old to come with you. I will stay here and take care of the evening prayers."

Hearing this, the disciples left the Viharam to do as their Guru bid them. Murugayyan got his boat through the canal and the prince took his leave from the old bikshu. As the boat left the Viharam, the old bikshu stood there for a long time, his face radiant and peaceful.

Chapter 4: Nandi Drowns

Even as the boat made its way through the canal, the prince saw that the water level was increasing every second, and Murugayyan was struggling to keep them afloat. The intensity of the storm was increasing as the strong winds whipped the trees around in a merry dance, resulting in many of them falling.

They were approaching the Nandi Mandapam and the prince noted that the water had risen above the Nandi's head! Alarmed by this, he said, "Murugayya! Stop the boat!"

Murugayyan stopped rowing, but he found it impossible to keep the boat still. The prince jumped from the boat onto the mandapam and with the help of a fallen tree, he climbed to the roof and surveyed the ravages of the storm. He saw sea water and fallen trees all around. He turned towards the north to know the state of the Viharam and saw that the waters had risen to the front steps of the building. The prince had a sudden realisation as to why the old bikshu had insisted that he leave, and he shook from head to toe.

"Murugayya, turn the boat around. Let's go back to the Viharam."

Murugayyan didn't argue; nor did he question the prince. His devotion was absolute. He silently turned the boat around and started rowing towards the Viharam. Though it took them less time than before to reach the Viharam, for the prince, every second felt endless.

When they reached the Viharam, they noticed that the sea had completely engulfed the structure. Unlike the monasteries of Sri Lanka, the Choodamani Viharam was not a gigantic structure. And in no time, the entire building would disappear under the rising waters.

The prince jumped from the boat onto the roof of a mandapam in the monastery that was not yet sunken. He started searching every

room on the upper floor where the water had risen to his chest. When his desperate search didn't yield any results, he came near the sunken statue of Gautam Buddha. Realising that the waters would soon completely engulf the statue, he took a deep breath and went underwater to search.

Holding the feet of Buddha, he found the old bikshu unconscious and barely breathing. Prising his hands away from the statue with great difficulty, the prince brought him above the water but found it hard to support the tall bikshu and swim out of the room.

"Murugayya! Murugayya!" he called, and the devoted boatman rowed his boat to the upper levels of the Viharam. Dragging the unconscious bikshu, the prince swam towards the boat with his legs trembling from fatigue.

Chapter 5: A Calf Torn Away from Its Cow

With great difficulty, the prince placed the old bikshu on the boat and climbed onto it. The little boat rocked madly, almost drowning them all. Murugayyan used all his experience and ingenuity to keep the boat afloat.

“Murugayya, row towards Anaimangalam Palace. Fast!” shouted the prince. The storm was at its peak, with roaring waves and a rushing gale. Murugayyan could not hear the prince’s words but understood what he was trying to say. He carefully navigated the small boat from shattering on the remnants of statues and spires that were fast drowning under the rushing waters. The prince wanted to help the boatman, but he was afraid that the bikshu might jump into the water and try to drown himself again. And just as he feared, the bikshu tried to free himself from the prince’s restraining hold. Just then, the giant Buddha statue in the Viharam was about to disappear under the rushing sea water.

The prince strengthened his hold on the bikshu, leading the monk to wonder how his patient had recovered his health so fast. He concluded that the prince’s resolve and determination must be lending him this strength now.

The boat moved away from the statue, but the bikshu couldn’t take his eye off it. Soon, the statue disappeared, and the bikshu turned toward the Prince and said, “Why did you do this?”

The prince leaned toward the Bikshu and said, “Gurudeva, I should be asking this question to you! How could you think about doing something like this?”

“Prince, this Viharam has been here for over 500 years now. It stood tall even during the times of Dharmapada Muni. Even the Pallavas, who were renowned for their devotion to Lord Shiva, didn’t cause harm to this monastery. To see it drown during my time is too

much for me to bear. Even if the waters recede, only a few stones will be left here. I have nothing to live for.”

“We can rebuild the Viharam again. With God’s grace, I can build the structure again but if I lose you, I can’t bring you back to life.”

They couldn’t talk anymore amidst the uproar of the sea. The scenes of destruction all around them rendered them silent in shock. All around them, they could see sails of broken ships and boats that were now a jumbled mess of rubble floating all around them. Fallen trees, household items, and many animals had been washed away and taken by the rushing waters. Unable to help anybody, the prince felt powerless and impotent.

Murugayyan didn’t look around and instead focussed his attention on navigating the boat towards the canal. The Viharam was situated near the sea and from there, the canals led them in the southern direction and deviated southwest for a few miles before it moved south again, where the Anaimangalam Palace stood.

This time around, when they came near the Nandi Mandapam, the statue of Nandi was completely drowned and sea water was lapping around the roof of the mandapam. The coconut grove around the mandapam was completely devastated. Most of the trees had fallen, and those that remained standing were dancing like puppets pulled by strings.

A small calf swam through the waters somehow and reached the roof of the mandapam and looked around, trembling in cold and fear and moored, ‘Amma...’

The distress of the lost calf reached those on the boat. Even as the prince wondered what would happen to the hapless calf, a large coconut tree fell on the mandapam, barely missing the calf. A large, displaced wave fell on the roof of the mandapam, and the calf fell into the water again. The prince, who was holding the bikshu, let go of his hand. Horrified, he was watching this sight and at that instant, the bikshu jumped into the water.

Stunned by the bikshu's actions, the prince tried to jump after him, only to be stopped by Murugayyan who threw his oar to hold him down. The prince tried to shake him off and angrily shouted, "let me go!"

But by then, the Bikshu had swum to the calf and was pulling it towards the boat. The prince directed the boat towards them, and they first got the calf inside the boat. Then the Bikshu climbed on. Frightened and shaken, the calf fell on its legs, shivering violently. The Bikshu sat next to it and held it lovingly.

"Gurudeva, a few moments ago, you wanted to sacrifice your life for Lord Buddha. If you had succeeded, could you have saved this helpless calf?" asked the prince.

"Prince, you stopped me from committing a sin. I am grateful to you. Saving this calf's life has provided me with some relief. Even if the Viharam is destroyed I won't worry about it much now."

"Gurudeva, how did you attain this equilibrium? Today so many people must have lost their lives – men, women, children, the infirm, and the old. So many horses, cows, and calves must have been swept away by the rushing seas. How can we help these people? What can we do to provide them with some relief?"

"Prince, we cannot stop nature. Can we stop a storm or the wind? We do not possess the power to control nature. In islands far from here, I have seen volcanoes belching fire and earthquakes shaking the ground. The only thing that we can do is to help people in any way we can."

"Gurudeva, why do these natural disasters occur? Maybe we cannot stop them from happening, but God has the power to prevent them from ever happening. Why does he subject us to these challenges and griefs?"

"Ponniyin Selva! You have asked a question that many mystics and sages have failed to answer. That's why Buddha doesn't talk

about God. Instead, he asks us only one thing. Help those in need and attain satisfaction and happiness through this service. That's the path to nirvana, he says."

As the boat moved towards the Anaimangalam Palace, the prince was immersed in his thoughts. He was comparing the edicts of Buddha, and their emphasis on serving the needy, with the teachings of his faith that also advocated the same. Both Shaivism and Vaishnavism held service to the needy as sacrosanct. Yet, one major difference between both belief systems is the unwavering faith in different forms of God. Shiva becomes the fearsome Rudra in one form, while Vishnu becomes all-compassionate and all-benevolent towards his followers. Parvathy is the calm and compassionate mother of all while she too becomes a ferocious Goddess Durga to vanquish her enemies. One God, yet different forms. But why not? A mother who lovingly caresses her child could also be the one who becomes angry and disciplines the child. That doesn't mean that the mother has no love for the child...

The boat reached the Anaimangalam Palace even as the sun set amidst gathering darkness. The rising waters had not entered the palace, so they were able to get very near the palace and Murugayyan was able to take the boat near the steps of the palace.

Until then, nature seemed to have had some consideration for the travellers. Even though the sea had entered the town and caused immense damage, it had not started raining yet. But it began now, just as they gained shelter. The palace guard stood at the entrance, holding a fire torch in hand. A few other people had also gathered there, seeking shelter. The guard noted the travellers in the boat and came towards them. The prince and the bikshu climbed out of the boat and slowly helped the calf onto the steps of the castle. When the guard saw the prince's face, he started running towards the boat and tried to fall at the prince's feet and his fire torch fell in the water.

"Prince, I was worried about the fate of the Choodamani Viharam. Thank God you came here."

“How did you know that I was staying in Choodamani Viharam?”

“When Princess Kundavai and Princess Vanathi told me about it, they requested me to not reveal it to anyone.”

“I would request the same from you. Who are these people gathered in front of the palace?”

“They are people from the nearby villages. The sea water has claimed their houses and they came here looking for shelter. I will drive them away...”

“Please don’t. Let them stay here. Provide them with food and water. Just don’t reveal that I am staying here. It’s good that your fire torch got extinguished. Take us to the upper levels through another way.”

Just as they entered the palace, it started raining heavily.

Chapter 6: Murugayyan Cries

The previous chapter's events happened simultaneously, just as Mandakini's palanquin was approaching Thanjavur fort, followed by Poonguzhali and Senthana Amuthan. This was the same day when a sudden storm hit the Veera Narayana Dam, interrupting Aditya Karikalan's hunt and Nandini's picnic.

That night, heavy rains poured continuously all over Nagapattinam and the nearby coastal villages. The devastation by the rain and the sea water had been immense and the people suffered huge losses of life, property, and livelihood. Despite the chaos that ensued, the Buddha bikshus of Choodamani Viharam followed their Gurudeva's instructions and tried to help as many people as possible. That night, the prince and the old bikshu sat discussing long into the night, talking about the loss that the people were suffering and about what can be done to alleviate them.

The first thing that the prince did was to call the palace steward to check the granary and learned that they had more than enough to feed the people of the village and the adjoining ones, too. Next, he checked the treasury and learned that they had 12 jars of gold coins sent by the dowager queen, Sembiyanmadevi, to renovate and rebuild Neelayathatchi Amman Temple.

"Gurudeva, here we have enough grains to provide food to the needy. Use all of it to help those who have lost their homes. You can use the gold coins to aid those who need to rebuild their homes and livelihood."

"I would gladly use the grains to feed the people, but how can we use the gold coins that were set aside for temple renovation by your grandmother? Wouldn't she be disappointed?"

"Gurudeva, I will explain to my grandmother. Don't worry about that. Today, I might be using this gold to help the poor, but tomorrow

I will gladden her heart by building hundreds of Shiva temples all around the kingdom. I will build a temple in Thanjavur that will be called 'Dakshina Meru' by our future generations. I will build temples that are so massive that even if the sea rushes in, they will not drown. I will build huge stupas that will provide shelter to people during natural disasters like this. I will rebuild the Choodamani Viharam with granite stones and make it into a sturdier structure so that it stands tall forever."

"Prince, your vision for the future is heartening to hear."

"Yes, I have always felt that I was born to accomplish great things. I have faced many dangers in my life and every time, by the grace of God, I have escaped. Even today, if this Murugayyan had not come to the Viharam at the right time, we might have been stranded when the sea rushed in."

"That is true. The Viharam was 500 years old, standing firm against the time. Who thought it would be claimed by the rushing sea! Through the grace of Lord Buddha, you escaped the wrath of the Sea God and saved this poor soul as well. Your wish to use the gold to help the people is noble and admirable. Lord Treasurer Periya Pazhuvetarayar might not be too happy to open the treasury for the people, but it would be easy to gain the benevolence of the dowager queen. It would be appropriate if you lead this effort instead of this old sanyasi."

"Gurudeva, if I lead this effort, I would be exposing myself and revealing my presence. You spoke about the Pandavas and the one year they spent living incognito. Similarly, Poyyamozhi Pulavar too, in his edicts, has said that whatever you speak should not cause harm to others. If by revealing myself, I could plunge this kingdom into turmoil, then it's best that I stay hidden. Therefore, if you can take this responsibility and help the people using the palace resources, that would help them better."

"Ponniyin Selva, my heart has undergone a change. I somehow feel that this might be the right opportunity for you to reveal yourself."

I think that is Lord Buddha's wish as well."

Just then, the prince heard a sobbing sound. It was Murugayyan, who was crying woefully. The prince went to him and asked, "Murugayya! What is this? Why are you crying?"

"My wife... my wife..." said the disconsolate Murugayyan, crying pitifully.

"Yes, we have completely forgotten about your wife. But there is nothing we could do in the middle of the night with the rains pouring down on us. Let the sun rise, we will go and search for your wife."

"Prince, I am not worried about her. She can survive even worse storms than this."

"Then why are you crying?"

The boatman said, "I suspected my wife of many things. I feared that she might harm you. It was she who forced me to come to Nagapattinam. She said that you were staying at the Viharam. I doubted her intentions, and I was wrong. Just now, you praised me saying that I came at the right moment to save you. But in truth, it was her doing. If she had not forced me, I might not have come. When I realized how wrong I was to suspect her, I felt like crying."

When the prince heard this, he felt an unfounded fear. He said, "Muruga! Your wife is a virtuous woman and suspecting her was wrong. But how did she know that I was at the Viharam?"

"When my aunt and sister left for Nagapattinam, my wife deduced from their actions that they were on their way to meet you."

"Your aunt?"

"Yes, prince. My mute aunt who saved your life in Elangai many times."

“Aha! What happened to them? You said they came to the Viharam! Do you know where they went?”

“Yes, when they started their journey, they were headed here. But they couldn’t complete it,” he said and started crying again.

With great difficulty, the prince consoled the man and pieced together the story that he was telling. When he learned that Mandakini had been kidnapped by some soldiers his anger knew no bounds. Rakkammal’s actions in trying to help her and the subsequent injuries that she suffered allayed some of his suspicions about her intentions. He now felt admiration and sympathy for the boatman’s wife.

“Gurudeva, did you hear this? In this world, if there is a goddess that I worship, it is Mandakini Devi. If anyone dares to harm her, I will never forgive them. I did not get angry even when the Pazhuvur brothers tried to imprison me. But if they even think of causing pain to Mandakini Devi, they will face my wrath. I will destroy them and their clan from the face of this Earth.

“I will not forgive my own parents if they had a hand in her kidnapping. I need to leave for Thanjavur immediately. I will travel incognito as a merchant and take Murugayyan as a companion. I cannot rest until I know that Mandakini Devi is safe.

“Gurudeva, I would like you to take responsibility for the relief work here. Do it in the name of Mandakini Devi, whose dedication to the faith of Buddha was absolute.”

The old bikshu didn’t argue with the prince about this and gave his assent.

The next day, the waters had receded, and rains had stopped but the devastation of the storm was huge. Most houses in Nagapattinam had lost their roofs and the rushing sea waters had demolished most of them. Many people were left with only a few walls of their homes. Dressed like a merchant, the prince carried a

bag as he walked through the streets of the city while Murugayyan carried a bigger bag on his head and accompanied him. Watching their progress was a woman who was hiding behind a fallen wall of a house. She waited patiently until they came near and then went near them before falling at the prince's feet. The woman was none other than Rakkammal. Murugayyan, in the meanwhile, tried to gain her attention but she didn't look at him at all.

“My Prince! You survived the storm. Ponniyin Selva! The gods are indeed merciful to have saved you from the sea. My eyes are blessed indeed!” She shouted, drawing the attention of all those who were on the streets.

Chapter 7: The People's Exuberance

The boatman Murugayyan tried his utmost to stop his wife. "Woman, stop this nonsense! What are you saying? Are you mad?"

"I am not mad. You are mad, and your father and your grandfather are mad. Don't you recognize him? He is the great warrior who conquered Elangai and made Mahindan run all the way to the mountains. Can't you see this is Prince Arulmozhi, whose life the Goddess Kaveri saved for the Chola people? If you can't recognize him, why are going with him? Where are you going?"

The prince intervened and said, "Woman, I think you are mistaken. I am a merchant from Elangai. I asked this man to come with me to show me the way around this city. If he is your husband, take him with you. Don't create a scene here."

Even as he spoke this, people had started gathering around them. The crowd was swelling with every second and had started intently staring at the disguised prince.

Hearing this, Rakkammal shouted, "Oh God! What has happened to Ponniyin Selvar? Did you lose your memory when you fell into the sea? Did those bikshus do something to you? Did they give you something to make you forget who you are? Is some witchcraft happening here? My Prince! Think carefully! You are not a merchant from Elangai. You are the son of Emperor Sundara Chola. You were born to rule. If you have doubts about it, why don't look at your palm carefully? You will see the divine conch and discus lines in your palm that indicate kingship!"

The prince immediately fisted his palms tightly and said, "Woman, can't you be silent?" He then turned towards Murugayyan and said, "What is this nonsense? Can't you silence her?"

Murugayyan neared his wife and said, “Rakkamma, I beg you, please be silent. The prince wanted to go to Thanjavur in disguise without anyone knowing about it.”

“Stupid man. Why didn’t you tell me this earlier? You said that the prince would never be at the Viharam. Will you still say the same thing? Ayyo! I made such a big mistake, especially when the Pazhuvur brothers are after your blood. My Prince, forgive me. It’s my love for you that made me act like this. Nonetheless, you do not worry about your disguise being revealed. You have devoted slaves like me, my husband and thousand others to protect you from any harm,” she said and turned towards the crowd that had gathered around them, demanding, “What do you say? Do you agree? Will we all protect the prince against his enemies? If any of you support the Pazhuvur brothers, come forward and reveal yourself. You will have to first kill me to reach the prince!”

The crowd that was listening to them with rapt attention then started shouting, “Long live Ponniyin Selvar!” “Long live the prince who conquered Elangai!” which attracted more people to gather around them. The town leader of Nagapattinam, who happened to be in the crowd, came forward and addressed the prince.

“Dear Prince, we heard rumours that you were staying at the Choodamani Viharam. We didn’t believe those rumours at first. Now it seems like they were true after all. Yesterday’s storm caused massive destruction in this town, and yet, one good thing that it did was to bring you out of that Viharam. For that, we will be eternally thankful to that storm. It is indeed our good fortune that you are here.”

Horried by the turn of events, the prince had to concede defeat and accept the fact that his disguise had indeed been unravelled.

“Ayya, I thank you for the love you bear towards me. I am very lucky to have come here indeed. However, I am on my way to Thanjavur on an important errand. That’s why I disguised myself as

a merchant... because I didn't want to stop anywhere. Kindly allow me to leave."

Hearing this, the crowd shouted, "No! The prince must stay here for a day and allow us to host him a feast."

Hearing that, the leader turned toward the prince and said, "Prince, did you hear that? Our people have immense love and admiration towards your person. You will have to stay here for a day at least and partake in the feast we will make in your honour. The bikshus were lucky to host you for a while, won't you be with us for at least a day? Yesterday, our townspeople thought that the bikshus were hiding you inside the Viharam and were ready to raze it to the ground. But the storm struck first and has fulfilled our intent. We heard that the Viharam got washed away..."

"Ayya, your accusations about the bikshus are wrong. I sought sanctuary in the Viharam and they graciously played hosts. When I was ill, they saved my life. I am deeply hurt to hear that the Viharam has washed away. One day, I will rebuild it for the bikshus; it's my duty."

"Aha! We didn't know anything about this. Now that we do, we will help in the rebuilding of the Viharam. But Prince, you will need to stay for a day and allow us to host you!"

The crowd echoed the leader's words and said, "Yes... stay for a day!!"

"Prince! Don't worry about the delay. We will help you make good progress from here. Yesterday's storm has caused havoc all over the Chola Kingdom. How far will you go on foot? All the rivers are in spate, and the roads are damaged. We will get you an elephant and come along with you to Thanjavur..."

Even as he was speaking, the prince noted that the crowds were swelling in thousands. His idea of travelling incognito had been foiled

by Rakkammal's foolish proclamations. He wondered furiously if she revealed his identity deliberately with an ulterior motive.

With his identity unmasked, it would be impossible to leave this place without offending its people who had just faced a devastating storm. He decided that he would stay until the afternoon and allow the people to prepare a feast. He could use this opportunity to provide relief for those affected by the storm.

Aha! Didn't my sister warn me that if I were to reveal my identity, the kingdom would plunge into chaos? How right she was! Truly, there is no one more intelligent than her in this world. All those who talk about their right to the throne should reflect and seriously think about giving it to Kundavai Devi.

As the prince stood there thinking, the crowd was growing by the minute, and they seemed enthusiastic and happy about his presence. The storm's devastation and their losses were forgotten as they revelled in the knowledge that their beloved prince was alive and amongst them now. Horses, elephants, palanquins, flags, and drums came on their own to welcome him formally.

"Ayya, I am bound by the love of the people. I cannot disappoint them. I will stay here until the afternoon and leave in the evening. I hope you will at least allow me to leave then."

An enthusiastic cheer spread through the people and they started playing their musical instruments. It took a while for them to move towards the Chola Palace. When they reached there, the prince couldn't even rest awhile. The news about his lucky escape from the sea had spread to the neighbouring villages and hundreds of people had rushed to the palace to see him.

The prince came out of the palace and met the people, enquiring about their well-being and the losses they had incurred in the storm. For many, he promised to arrange funds to help them rebuild their houses and livelihood as soon as he reached Thanjavur. He was surprised to see that the people were not so enthusiastic about what

he said. Instead, many were wondering when the reign of the Pazhuvur brothers will end. Some asked him about the emperor's health and about who would ascend the throne next.

Soon, the council of merchants who led the town affairs came there. A feast was getting ready for the prince and the crowd that had gathered there. Food grains, vegetables and other supplies that were not damaged in the storm came to the palace.

After the feast, the prince was ready to take leave. He stood on the balcony with folded hands, taking his leave from the people. A richly decorated elephant came to the palace entrance followed by soldiers on horses. Bullocks and bullock carts loaded with people stood ready to follow the elephant.

Though the prince was all smiling on the outside, he was a worried man inside. He was desperate to know what had happened to Mandakini Devi – a woman who he revered more than his own mother. He had initially thought of asking Rakkammal about her, but that woman had vanished in the crowds after the initial excitement. Murugayyan alone had somehow stuck to him and had come to the palace, battling the crowds. Even he didn't know what had happened to his wife.

The prince was also worried about another thing. The Pazhuvur brothers had already charged him with treason for trying to usurp the Elangai throne. What would they say if he appeared accompanied by thousands and thousands of people who were keen on putting him on the throne? Wouldn't their charge be justified? He had to somehow escape these crowds and their dear intentions.

The oldest of the merchant leaders, who was also the town caretaker, came forward and said, "Prince, this is a plea from the people of Nagapattinam and the surrounding villages. We are extremely worried about the emperor and his health. We have also heard that important chieftains and kings like the Pazhuvur brothers are conspiring against the emperor now. They wish to anoint Prince Madhuranthakan as their Emperor – he who has never been to a

battle. If he becomes the emperor, in truth, it will be the Pazhuvur brothers who will be reigning in the kingdom. We will become subjects of these kings and chieftains.

“The crown prince, Aditya Karikalan, is not coming to the Chola Kingdom since the past three years. We are hearing rumours of many reasons for his absence. We also heard that he wants to renounce the throne. If he doesn’t want to become the emperor, by rights, you need to ascend the throne. My dear people, what do you think? Am I saying the right thing?” asked the old man, turning towards the crowds.

Unsurprisingly, the crowd roared back, “Yes! We agree with you!!”

When the prince opened his mouth to reply, the cheers faded into a respectful silence immediately. “Ayya, I am elated to see the affection that you and this town’s people bear for me. But the way you are expressing it is not correct. My father, the emperor, is still alive. I wish you would pray that he lives long. And while he is still alive, why are we discussing who will ascend the throne next?”

“Prince, it is an honour-bound tradition among the Cholas to decide who will ascend the throne. Didn’t the Great Emperor Paranthaka decide who will succeed him? Isn’t that how your father came to the throne?”

“That is true. Then, shouldn’t the emperor decide this time too? Why are you and I discussing it?”

“Prince, if the emperor was independent enough to think and decide, I would have to agree with you. But isn’t he imprisoned in the Thanjavur Palace? To tell the truth, many of us are doubtful if he is even alive. We would like to come with you to Thanjavur to ascertain the same. We will also submit a petition saying that we would like you to ascend the throne next.”

When the town elder expressed his doubts about the emperor’s health, the prince realized that his intuition was telling him about

some unknown danger to the emperor. He also feared that he was so far away from his father that he could not possibly prevent the danger. The news that Mandakini Devi had been caught by some strangers kept niggling him. He wanted to break free and leave immediately, but that was not possible. Within a few minutes, he formulated a plan and decided what to do. He knew it was pointless to argue with the town elders and the people who had gathered there.

“Ayya, whatever you just told me has increased my worry. I need to see my father immediately. You can join me on this journey and come along to meet my father. We will abide by whatever the emperor decides about the succession.”

Excited about travelling with the prince, the townsmen brought an elephant forward. The prince climbed onto its back and started his journey again. Following him were thousands of people on foot.

Chapter 8: Pazhuvetarayar in a Boat

Periya Pazhuvetarayar left Kadambur the same morning when the storm had struck Nagapattinam. His entourage went along the Kollidam river and turned west. He didn't want to travel through the villages, therefore he had planned to cross the Kollidam near Thiruvaiyaru.

He was not travelling with his usual large entourage, either. He wanted to travel fast and didn't want many to know about it either, so he took only ten people along with him.

When he reached Thiruvaiyaru, the river was in spate, and the storm was intensifying. They couldn't take their horses in the boat. Pazhuvetarayar decided to leave the horses there and travel by boats. Even while they were in the middle of crossing the river, the flood water increased and tried to push their little boat eastwards while the wind tried to take it to the west, and the boatmen were trying to turn it towards the south. Caught between these forces, the boat swirled around, getting stuck in one place.

The storm didn't merely rage outside, there was another one within the Pazhuvetarayar's heart and mind that kept him preoccupied. He knew that, in front of Nandini, his senses reeled and he would always agree to whatever she said. Even with those things that he had found abhorrent all his life, if Nandini were to say them, they might seem like the right things to do and his mouth would automatically say, "Alright, let's do this." After giving his word thus, it would become impossible to back down on it.

Even now, when she had asked him to go to Thanjavur and bring Prince Madhuranthakan to Kadambur, he had agreed and left on the journey. But soon after he left Nandini's presence, he started having grave misgivings about it. For one thing, he hated leaving Nandini in Kadambur amidst young men of her age. He didn't think that Nandini would betray him, but he didn't really trust the young men.

There were many reasons for Periya Pazhuvetarayar to mistrust Kandan Maran, Vandiya Devan, and Aditya Karikalan. He could never forgive Kandan Maran for calling Nandini his daughter when they had met in the dark palace that led to the treasury. He was so angry that night that he instructed the palace guard to kill Kandan Maran while on his way out. He later regretted his impulsive order and was relieved that Kandan Maran had survived the attempt. But many questions rose in his mind now about how he survived and how the palace guard had died instead. Periya Pazhuvetarayar also couldn't forget the fact that following this adventure, Kandan Maran had stayed in his own palace under the care of Nandini.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar hadn't liked Vandiya Devan right from the beginning. The upstart youth met the Emperor in Thanjavur and had tried to warn him about something. Later, he escaped from the Fort, eluding his brother's forces and guards. His brother had warned him that Vandiya Devan might have had help from Nandini to escape from the Fort, but he had dismissed it. Vandiya Devan was a trusted messenger of Kundavai and the younger prince. Therefore, there could not be any connection between him and Nandini. Yet, when he pictured them together, a storm rose in his heart.

And then there was Aditya Karikalan. He had heard rumours about the prince's love for a priest's daughter, and many believed that it was Nandini. And now they had met and were in Kadambur under the same roof. He also knew that though Karikalan didn't respect his elders, and was a brute by nature, he was a scion of the Chola royal family whose reputation with women was well-known and spotless. He didn't think that Karikalan would covet another man's wife.

But what about Nandini herself? He had trusted her so much and had allowed her to do as she wished. What if she betrayed him? Will my brother's words come true?

'Will my brother's warnings come to pass? Will Nandini turn out to be a vile woman who betrays her husband? Was I a fool to believe her?'

While his head was swirling with such thoughts, his anger increased four-fold. He was conscious of the fact that he was amidst his soldiers, and that alone stopped him from slapping his head with his hands. Instead, he drew deep breaths and kept adjusting his voice, trying to keep calm.

Holding the boat tightly with both his hands, the Lord Treasure made a promise to himself, "I will learn the truth within two days and will not take any decisions without thinking over it thoroughly!"

Chapter 9: The River Bank Breaks

Unfortunately, the others in the boat had no inkling about Pazhuvetarayar's inner turmoil. They thought that he was agitated because they were caught in the storm. The Pazhuvur lord was known for his composure, especially in the face of danger. Seeing him visibly distressed unsettled his soldiers, and they looked for ways to save their lives if the boat capsized.

After struggling valiantly against the strong winds, the boat was pulled towards the east of the riverbank. Everyone in the boat heaved a sigh of relief, thinking that they were safe. Just then, a huge tree fell and was blown away by the wind into the river. The tree landed near the boat, displacing the water. The boatmen tried their utmost to move the boat away from it, but the force of water brought it towards the boat and the tree rammed the boat heavily. With a huge sound, the boat capsized drowning all the men aboard.

The soldiers on the boat were prepared for this eventuality and therefore were able to swim toward the riverbank and save themselves. Some managed to escape by clinging to the tree or anything else that was floating.

The Pazhuvur Lord's preoccupation had left him unprepared for this eventuality and when the boat capsized, he drowned, and the river currents dragged him through the flood. He was disoriented and confused by the sudden turn of events, and by the time he gained some sense of what was happening he couldn't find anyone from the boat around.

Realizing that the flood had brought him away from his bodyguards, he immediately took charge and started swimming against the tide. With powerful strokes, he swam towards the bank. And when he became tired, he floated for a while. He struggled to reach the bank, but the flood pulled him back into the river. After

struggling thus for over an hour, the river deposited him at the bank and the old man clung to the roots of the tree.

It was terribly dark all over. There were no lamps or firelight to indicate he was near some village. He figured that he might be near Kudanthai, and thought that if he could somehow reach the town...

The storm was at its zenith at that moment. The howling winds made puppets out of the trees as they whirled around with an eerie ghostly sound. All around him, he could hear trees falling, unable to bear the fury of the winds. Thunder and lightning ripped through the area and soon it started raining.

Looking around frantically, the Pazhuvur Lord searched for a temple or a mandapam where he could seek shelter for the night, and decide what to do further in the morning. With faltering steps, he walked slowly along the river bank in search of a sanctuary.

The inky bank darkness made it impossible to see what lay in front of him. Suddenly, there was water until his thighs and before he could realize where he was, a wall of water had engulfed him. He was at a point where the flood water had broken the bank and the water was flowing southwards. The force and depth of the water pushed him to the bottom. Even when the boat capsized, he recovered fast and was able to swim against the tide quickly. But this time around, he became more disoriented as the incoming flood waters and the river currents pulled him in different directions, rolling him in the water. He was blind and deaf, and utterly at a loss powerless to fight against the tide.

The pressure of the water suffocated him, and he felt as though someone was choking him. He prayed to his patron Goddess Durga, "Mother! Will I survive this? Nandini, you wretch, you are responsible for my death! No, you are innocent. I left you alone and defenceless amidst those scoundrels. No, what did I get by marrying you? Nothing. You beguiled my senses and I took pity on your situation. In the end, I am going to face an inglorious death in these flood waters. No one is going to find my body and honour me by building a

Pallipadai. No one is going to even find me. Even if my body reaches the bank, it will be feasted upon by dogs and jackals.

Within a few seconds, many such thoughts flashed through his mind and he lost consciousness.

He regained his senses when his head banged on something heavy. He felt as though he was holding a solid stone with both his hands. Somehow, he had been lifted from the bottom of the river and plonked on something solid. Grateful for this chance to survive, he used his last reserves of energy to prop himself from the running flood water. With great difficulty, he opened his eyes and found himself looking at a lighted lamp. And in it was the illuminated face of Shri Durga.

“Devi, your compassion is boundless indeed. You have ended my meaningless life in the Earthly plane and have taken me to your realm...”

Soon, the realization came back to him. No, he was not in the heavens but in a small temple that enshrined the Goddess Durga Parameshwari. He looked around the small temple and then heard the sound of the torrential rain and the wind. He wondered how the lamps of this small temple were still alight. He took it as a good sign.

Is this a sign that Goddess Durga favours us and will protect us no matter what happens? Indeed, my prayers and pooja have at last borne fruit!

The old man rose to his feet. His body shivered, chilled from long exposure to the water. He looked around and took a veil that hung there, using it to dry himself thoroughly. He then removed his wet clothes and used the veil to clothe himself.

At the sanctum, there were fruits, coconuts and sweet pongal kept as ‘prasadam’ for the goddess. It looked as though the Pujari had fled the temple during the flood.

The old man was happy about the fact that the Goddess had not only saved his life but was also providing him with nourishment to recover from his ordeal.

He decided that the temple was the best place to spend the night. Even though the flood waters were running dangerously close to the temple, the structure may not fall. He had no energy to seek another place for shelter that night so there were very few choices of shelter for him.

With great reverence, the old man approached the sanctum of the Goddess and partook in the feast that was spread there. He also carefully preserved the rest of the food. After eating, he stretched and lay down to sleep with his head facing the Goddess and slept deeply.

Chapter 10: Realization Dawns

Exhausted from his near-death experience after drowning in the flood waters, Pazhuvetarayar slept deeply. After a few hours, memories and dreams started appearing. He dreamt that Goddess Durga appeared before him and said, with her eyes flashing red, “Listen, Pazhuvetaraya! You and your clan are dear to me. Hence, I give this warning. That woman you have brought into your palace and home is a vile demoness who wants to destroy you and the Chola clan too. She is biding her time to fulfil her vow. If you do not remove her from your heart and home immediately, your clan will be dishonoured and shamed for generations to come...”

Pazhuvetarayar woke up with a start. His body was trembling from every limb. His dream felt so real, and yet he knew it must be ‘just a dream...’

The morning had dawned, and it seemed as though the storm had abated. But the sound of raging water could still be heard. He stood up and came out of the temple to see around him and what he saw was not encouraging.

There was water everywhere. Flood water was rushing all around the temple in all directions. At a distance, he spotted a wooded area and recognized it as the Thirupurambayam forest, where the Ganga King was enshrined as a fallen hero. He remembered the gory battle that was fought on the battlefield. He recalled the many great deeds that his forefathers had performed in that battle.

Am I dishonouring the glory of my ancestors through my actions and by loving Nandini? Did the Goddess warn me in vain or is there any truth to it?

He swore to be careful where Nandini was concerned and resolved to find out more about her past. But all that would be possible only if he could leave the temple. If he could reach the

village of Thirupurambayam he could seek some help. But how could he cross the flood water? The current of the water so strong that it could even carry away a mad elephant!

That the temple was still standing was a miracle. The force of the flood water was eroding the temple's foundations and could drag the rocks away at any time. Staying there for long was dangerous, but crossing the raging river with its influx of flood waters was impossible. Waiting for the water to recede would also be suicidal.

Thankfully, there was a way.

Opposite the temple was a huge neem tree that looked like it would fall at any time from the pressure of the flood water. If it fell, he could use it as a bridge to cross the river and reach the other bank. He resolved to watch the tree carefully and wait until it fell.

While he waited, he ate some more of the remaining prasadam and preserved the rest carefully. At least the Goddess had made sure he had enough sustenance to see through this ordeal.

He decided that there was nothing to gain from acting rashly. Obviously, there was some unfinished business that he had to complete. 'That's why the Goddess saved my life, and she will show the way out of this predicament too.'

He spent two days marooned at the temple. The storm had moved towards the west, wreaking havoc in its wake. But the trapped Pazhuvur Lord didn't find any relief. The flood water didn't abate and he felt that the water level flowing through the temple foundations had increased. He was not confident about walking or swimming through the water.

Finally, that evening, the neem tree fell, making a bridge towards the western bank of the river. Pazhuvetarayar immediately got ready to leave the temple. He fell to his knees and prayed hard to the Goddess. Just then, he heard a voice that startled him.

“Mandiravadi! Mandiravadi!” called out the voice from the outside. Then, it said, “Ravidasa! Ravidasa!”

He felt as though he had heard this voice somewhere before. He came out of the temple sanctum and stood behind the pillar of the outer mandapam to see who it was. A figure was standing on the fallen neem tree and was calling out, “Mandiravadi! Mandiravadi” and coming towards the temple.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar remembered the warning that his brother had given many times and felt that this might be an opportunity to learn the truth. The old man then did something that he had never done before. He lay down and pretended to be fast asleep.

He somehow knew that this must be the same Mandiravadi who had once come to visit Nandini. He was now determined to learn more about him and know what his relationship with Nandini was. Who could come in search of him, and that too here? Why were they searching for him? If he learned more about this then it would probably be easy to determine if Nandini was betraying his trust.

The man came inside the temple and approached the prone form of Pazhuvetarayar and tried to rouse him, “Ravidasa! Ravidasa!”

This voice was very familiar. The old man tried to remember where he had heard it before. He recalled Kadambur Palace and the man who had danced wildly as Devaralan.

What if we held his throat and made him spill the truth? No, he thought, let me wait. I may know more about the Mandiravadi from him.

“Mandiravadi! The sun hasn’t set yet, and here you are, fast asleep. Or are you dead and gone?” said the man, rolling Pazhuvetarayar’s body towards him. Pazhuvetarayar stayed still and played dead. Devaralan was astonished to see him there in that state. He rubbed his head and looked at the old man carefully. And

then with rising disbelief and astonishment he backed away and ran headlong towards the fallen tree to get away from him.

The old man got up slowly and watched with surprise as the man ran away from him. He felt that he had lost a golden opportunity to interrogate this man and learn more about Ravidasan. He followed the man albeit slowly, by clutching the roots of the tree, and reached the other end of the bank. There was a forest path where he spotted Devaralan's footsteps and started moving along the same path in pursuit.

It was already dark by then, and the forest was alive. The forest animals had been through a great ordeal and when the storm finally abated, they started coming out of their shelters in search of prey.

Yet, the Pazhuvur lord was determined to hunt down Devaralan and the Mandiravadi that he had apparently been searching for, even if he had to roam through the forest the entire day. After walking for about an hour, he saw a flickering light ahead of him. Since it was moving, he realized that someone was carrying a fire torch ahead of him. He started following the light and soon found that he was near a temple. It was indeed the Pallipadai temple of the fallen Ganga King Prathivipithan that was built to honour his brave deeds. He cautiously approached the temple and stood behind the wall and spied.

His efforts were not in vain. Both the men in the temple were talking, and loudly too!

"Mandiravadi, do you know how long I have been searching for you? I feared that you might have died and gone to Yama's abode."

The Mandiravadi Ravidasan laughed uproariously and said, "Why would Yama come for me when he will soon claim the lives of Sundara Chola and his children? By tomorrow they would all reach the abode of Yama!"

When he said this, dramatic thunder and lightning were splitting through the clouds.

Chapter 11: The Mandapam Falls

The old man looked carefully at the men in the bright glare of the lightning. He immediately recognized the Mandiravadi, who he had seen in his palace a few times. Nandini had described him as someone skilled at charms and sorcery, and his brother had warned him about the man many times. The other man was the wild dancer known as Devaralan from the Kadambur palace, but he seemed very familiar to the Pazhuvur Lord, as though he had seen him somewhere before. To him, he looked like Parameshwaran – an official from the Chola court he had thrown out.

It was him indeed. The memory had resurfaced!

“Ravidasa! You have been saying this for a long time. That our ‘time has come’ and that ‘Yama is nearing our enemies.’ But Yama seems to be coming for everybody else. Sundara Chola, who has been paralyzed on his bed for the past three years, is still lingering while Yama hesitates to even go near his sons. We tried our utmost at Elangai didn’t we?”

“That’s alright, my friend. Lord Yama is intelligent. He waits until the right opportunity to claim the lives of our enemies. He is going to strike them on the same day, and rid us of all three enemies simultaneously. It’s going to happen tomorrow. It’s good that you came here today. You are indeed Yama’s messenger. Why are you trembling like this? Did you fall into the flood water? Did you get the boat that I asked for?”

“I got the boat. It was difficult to bring it all the way here, saving it from the fury of the storm. Do you know how long I have been searching for you? Ravidasa, you asked me why I am trembling so. I will tell you. I saw Lord Yama himself in person. No... I saw Yama’s older brother. That’s why I am so frightened.”

“Parameshwara, what are you blabbering? What is this about Yama and his brother? Shouldn’t they fear us? Why are you so frightened?”

The Pazhuvur lord then realized that he had recognized Devaralan correctly as the errant official of the Chola Court, Parameshwaran. He also realized that Parameshwaran was referring to him as ‘Yama’s older brother’. His hands itched to hold the man’s throat and choke the truth out of him, but he held back his instincts. He wanted to listen further. They had not spoken about Nandini yet. He was intrigued by the Mandiravadi’s claims that Yama will soon come for Sundara Chola and his sons.

Could they be true? Was he declaring this prediction through astrology? Or was he indeed a sorcerer as Nandini had claimed many times? If his prediction came true, then all his problems would be solved in a stroke. There would be no need to split the kingdom into two. But this Parameshwaran... why was he involved with this Mandiravadi?

He then remembered that Parameshwaran had sworn vengeance on the Chola empire twenty years ago when he was ousted from his post. Just then, the Pazhuvur Lord heard his name come up in the conversation.

“Ravidasa, just as you asked, I came here this morning and was waiting for you. When you didn’t arrive, I started searching around the forest to see if you were marooned somewhere in the flood. There is a Durga temple near the Kollidam river, where the banks broke. It looked as though someone was sleeping there. I went there to check, and who did I find there? Periya Pazhuvetarayar!”

The Mandiravadi laughed uproariously. Hearing him, many birds took flight in fright while a few owls hooted, “Did you really see Pazhuvetarayar or his ghost?” he asked.

“No, it was not his ghost. The man himself was lying face down and when I rolled him over, I saw that it was him. Ravidasa, there

can't be two men like him. Same face, moustache, scars... everything."

"No, it's probably him. Yesterday, when he was crossing the Kollidam River, his boat capsized and his soldiers – those that escaped – are searching for him frantically. They fear that he might have died in the flood. Was he dead or alive when you saw him?"

"No, he was alive and breathing. He seemed to be in deep sleep from exhaustion."

"Fool! What did you do? You could have at least smashed a rock on his head..."

"Ravidasa, you know nothing about Pazhuvetarayar's head, then. If you smash a rock on his head, only the rock will break."

"Then you could have at least dragged him out to the flood waters and drowned him..."

"I got scared on seeing him there and panicked. It felt like I saw Lord Yama's elder brother. Even in Kadambur, when I had to dance in front of him, I was worried that he might recognise me..."

"Why are you trembling now about that?"

"Until he is alive, I will be scared and worried. I wish I had rolled him into the flood water instead of panicking and running!"

"Don't worry about it. In a way, if he is still alive, it would be advantageous to us. Once Sundara Chola and his sons die, the clansmen of Cholas will be divided into two factions under Pazhuvetarayar and Malayaman. This chaos would help our cause a lot. While they fight amongst themselves, we can secretly enlist and gather a Pandya army..."

"Ravidasa, many other things need to happen before we can realize these dreams. Sundara Chola and his sons must die. How do

you know that they will lose their lives tomorrow? Did you hear the news?”

“What news?”

“Arulmozhivarman is alive in Nagapattinam. People are gathering around him demanding that he become the next emperor. Didn’t you hear this?”

“I didn’t have to hear this from others. I knew this myself. Who do you think forced Arulmozhivarman to reveal himself from the Viharam? Our Revadasan’s daughter, Rakkammal, who is the wife of Murugayyan.”

“So, what of it? What have we gained by revealing Arulmozhivarman’s presence to the public? He will be surrounded by thousands of people henceforth. In Elangai, we couldn’t touch him with just four or five people protecting him.”

“It’s good that our efforts were foiled in Elangai. All three of our enemies will lose their lives on the same day.”

“Ravidasa, how can Yama approach the prince when he is surrounded by thousands of people? You didn’t tell me how!”

“Yama will approach him through the poisoned ‘elephant goad’. It will strike the prince at the right time. Parameshwara, the people of Nagapattinam are now bringing the prince on an elephant to Thanjavur. On the way, an accident will happen to the mahout and our Revadasan Gramavithan will become the mahout. You can imagine what will happen next!”

“Ravidasa, this is a brilliant plan indeed. Even if we assume that Gramavithan fulfils his mission, how can you be sure that Sundara Chola will die tomorrow? What have you arranged for him?”

“Soman Sambavan is waiting for him in Pazhuvetarayar’s treasure chamber, and a tunnel from there leads to the emperor’s

palace. He is ready there, bearing a spear. I have shown him where Sundara Chola lies. Even a blind man can throw a spear from that spot and kill the old man. I have told Soman Sambavan to wait until tomorrow to finish his mission...”

“Why? Wouldn’t it be better to complete it whenever the opportunity arose?”

“Fool! If Sundara Chola dies at the hands of an assassin, wouldn’t his sons become alert? That said, there is no use in killing that sick old man. What news of Kadambur palace? Whatever happens tomorrow at the palace is the most important mission for us.”

“Kadambur palace is as festive as ever. There is talk of marriage, love, and many other dramas. I am not very confident about that Pazhuvur queen, and I don’t know why you believe her so much!”

“She is not the Pazhuvur Queen, she is the Pandya Queen. Did our emperor not take her as his consort two days before he died? Have you forgotten that she too swore, along with us, to avenge the inglorious death of our emperor? Didn’t she crown the emperor’s son right here a week ago and receive the Pandya sword to wreak vengeance on his killer?”

“That’s true! But you should have seen your Pandya Queen when she returned from a pleasure trip at Veera Narayana Lake. She seemed elated...”

“How else can she fool people? There is none better than her in fooling people. If she were not skilled at this, it would be impossible to live in that Pazhuvetarayar’s palace for three years without arousing suspicions. Nor could we have progressed in our mission. When did Pazhuvetarayar leave Kadambur and why? Do you know?”

“I don’t know why he left. It was told that he will be bringing Madhuranthakan to Kadambur. He left yesterday morning. And soon

after, the princes went for a hunt and the princesses went to Veera Narayana Lake to have a bath and a picnic. They came back together, and there was much gaiety and laughter. If you had seen them all together, you wouldn't be so sure about her."

"Don't worry about it. Don't you see that she sent the old man away on purpose?"

"Who can discern what lies beneath a woman's heart? She might have sent the old man for many reasons. To seek vengeance or even to conduct her love liaisons..."

"What are you blabbering Parameshwara! Nandini has forgotten that old story. She carries venomous hate for Karikalan in her heart!"

"I am not talking about Karikalan. I am talking about his messenger, Vandiya Devan. Nandini has so far allowed him to escape multiple times, have you forgotten?"

The Mandiravadi laughed and said, "Yes, you will know soon enough why Vandiya Devan was repeatedly allowed to escape. When you know the truth, not just you... everyone, particularly Kundavai Devi, is going to be surprised. The man to whom she has lost her heart will be the one who will kill her dear brother."

"What are you saying, Ravidasa?! Will it be Vandiya Devan who kills Karikalan? Has he finally joined us?"

"Don't ask me anything more. It doesn't matter whose hand strikes Karikalan, he will fall to a Pandyan sword. And Vandiya Devan will be accused of his murder. What say you about our Queen's cunning ingenuity?"

"Let all this happen and then you ask me the same question."

"No matter what happens, Karikalan will fall tomorrow. Nandini will fulfil her vows and the promise she made on the pyre of our

glorious king. We need to make sure that we fulfil our responsibilities.”

“What’s our responsibility?”

“We need to wait outside the underground passage that comes out of Kadambur palace. As soon as she finishes her mission, Nandini will come out through that passage. We need to move fast and reach Kolli Malai without delays. We will stay there and watch the turmoil that happens in the Chola Kingdom. If possible....”

“If possible?”

“If possible, let’s loot the gold that is hoarded in Pazhuvetarayar’s treasure chamber. We will then finance the destruction of the Chola Kingdom with their own gold. We can use it to build our army too...” said Ravidasan and laughed again.

“If you have finished building your castles in the air, let’s see if can cross the Kollidam River first and reach Kadambur. Let the events in Kadambur unfold first just as you say, and then we will think about looting Pazhuvetarayar’s treasure chamber. What do you say? Shall we leave now?”

“No. Let’s leave in the morning and take the boat. By then, the winds will die down and the flood waters might recede too.”

“Then shall we stay here for the night?”

Ravidasan pondered on Devaralan’s question. Just then they could hear the howling of wolves and he involuntarily shivered.

“Why are you trembling with fear? They are just wolves...”

“If you had been buried in the quicksand up to your neck with snarling wolves waiting to feast on you, you too would tremble thus. I don’t fear a lion’s roar or a mad elephant’s rage, but I do fear the wolves... come, let us leave this godforsaken forest and spend the

night elsewhere. There must be some temple nearby or a guest house where we can seek shelter. Or else, we could even go to the Durga Temple near Kollidam where you found Pazhuvetarayar. If the old man is still there, we can finish him off by dragging him into the flood water. We would be doing him a favour. If he were alive after tomorrow, he is going to be much distressed by the turn of events.”

After listening to the entire conversation with rapt attention, rage rose in Pazhuvetarayar’s heart like a volcano. The woman he had loved and married against much opposition and ridicule wanted to avenge the death of Veera Pandyan. The fact that he had been betrayed and tricked by Nandini caused him unbearable sorrow.

He remembered the ties that bound him to the Chola clan. Sundara Chola’s grandmother was a woman from the Pazhuvur clan.

Then why did he end up hating them so much?

He then realized that whatever hatred and dislike he felt for Sundara Chola’s sons had come in recent years.

Just because of Karikalan’s disrespectful behaviour and the fact that I didn’t like Malayaman, how could I have allowed the Pandiyan rebels to shelter in my own home? I allowed them access to my palace, to the very treasure chamber using which they have been plotting the downfall of the Chola kingdom. Will the emperor and the princes die just as these scoundrels have plotted?

No, never! Not until there is breath left in my body. There are still 60 hours more to act in, and by then, I can travel to Kudanthai and send urgent messages to Thanjavur and Nagapattinam. After that, I will go straight to Kadambur. I will need to reach there before these wretches.

But why should I allow them to come to Kadambur? Why not kill them here? Wouldn’t that be ideal? I don’t have any weapons in my hand, but why bother with weapons when my arms are enough?!

They might have a small dagger hidden somewhere, but if I take them by surprise and strangle them, it might just work.

But is it prudent to fight these scoundrels here? What if they have more information that might be useful? Thanks to the grace of Durga Parameshwari, my boat capsized, and I was able to learn these dark secrets that have shrouded my life and mind so far. My first duty would be to ensure the safety of the emperor and his sons. More importantly, I should make sure nothing untoward happens to Karikalan in Kadambur. If I fail in that duty, the shame that I would bring upon my clan would be enough to kill me. I cannot allow that to happen. If Karikalan dies in the hands of Nandini, a woman I wed, there is no redemption for me.

Aha! How is it possible? Could such a beautiful woman mask the poison that she bears within? Her smile that could win over the three worlds... could it carry such vengeance within? Did I hear these scoundrels right? Could any of this be true?

While on the one hand, he was furious that he had been betrayed, in his heart of hearts, he was glad about one thing. Nandini might have deceived him, but her motive was not the love for another man. She didn't love Karikalan, Kandan Maran or Vandiya Devan. She merely used them as pawns and enticed them with her beauty so they would do her bidding.

This realization gave him some measure of comfort. He wanted to save Karikalan, not merely because it could affect his clan's reputation directly, but also to save Nandini from a heinous act.

Maybe she was being controlled by these scoundrels who were forcing her to do their bidding! And he hoped that he could change her mind and rescue her from them. This thought changed his mind and he decided to confront them and kill them and relieve Nandini of her oppressors.

Unconsciously, the old man cleared his throat as he would normally do after he had decided something. And in the silence of

the woods, it sounded like the growl of a lion. Ravidasan and Devaralan got up, startled, and cried out, "Who is there?"

The old man decided that there was no point in hiding anymore and he came out of his hiding place. The sudden appearance of his long, tall frame shocked the Pandya rebels out of their skin, and they stood staring at him with their mouths hanging open.

"I am Lord Yama's elder brother," the old man said cheekily and laughed uproariously. The vibrations of his familiar laughter were felt all around the woods and there was no doubt any more who the old man was. Immediately, Devaralan and Ravidasan tried to flee only to be grabbed by Pazhuvetarayar's arms. With his arms outstretched, he held both Ravidasan and Devaralan easily.

He knew that it would be impossible to tackle both men at the same time, so he pushed Devaralan to the ground on his stomach and placed one foot on his back to pin him down while he strangled Ravidasan. But Devaralan resisted, took out the dagger that he had with him, and tried to swipe Pazhuvetarayar's leg with it. Realizing what was happening, Pazhuvetarayar kicked his hand forcefully. The dagger fell far away and Devaralan's hand hung uselessly. In the scuffle, Pazhuvetarayar's leg had moved, and he wriggled and got up. With his one functioning hand, he tried to punch the old man but his punches were ineffective. Pazhuvetarayar's body was built like a brick wall and nothing could move him or even make an impact.

Ravidasan too was trying his utmost to escape from the Pazhuvur Lord, but he couldn't budge the iron grip of the old man. His eyes had started to bulge and soon he would lose consciousness and then his life. Scared for his life, he screamed, "Devarala, hurry... hurry climb on the top of the temple and push it down on him!"

Devaralan immediately ran and climbed the mandapam's roof. The dilapidated structure was caving in from one side. He moved towards the portion and pushed some loose stones. One of the stones came undone and along with that, an adjoining tree fell, too.

Realizing that the mandapam's roof was moving and could fall on him at any minute, Pazhuvetarayar raised his hand and tried to hold the moving stone with one hand while the other still held Ravidasan's throat.

With great difficulty, Ravidasan shook free of him and moved out of the way of the tumbling stones. The tree and the roof both fell on Pazhuvetarayar and he lost consciousness.

Chapter 12: The Comet Disappears

It took a long time for Pazhuvetarayar to regain consciousness. When he came to, he thought he was in the middle of a battlefield. He could hear the clanging of shields and swords and the rhythmic beating of drums and pipes that were declaring victory.

Thousands of voices were rising in shouts:

“Victory to the Great Pandya King!”

“May the enemies of the Pandyas fall!”

On the other side, countering voices were heard frantically shouting, “The Ganga King has fallen! Run! Run! Run for your life!” A few were trying to rally them around and prevent them from running but there was desperation in the air.

Suddenly, there was an eerie silence on the battlefield. Pazhuvetarayar looked around to see what had happened. He saw the paralyzed Vijayalaya Chola sitting on the shoulders of a tall soldier and holding two long, dangerously sharp swords.

“Chola soldiers! Stop running! Pallava soldiers, don’t run. Death is inevitable for all, whether we die here or in our beds. Come with me! Follow me! I will show you how to destroy the enemy,” he shouted.

Many on the battlefield, who had given up on fighting, stopped in their tracks to see this inspiring spectacle. The old man’s bravery, determination, and tenacious need to win motivated the tired and dejected soldiers to pick up their arms and attack anew with vigour and force.

The Chola and Pallava armies that had begun to retreat now began to advance with the old Vijayalaya Chola on the lead.

Pazhuvetarayar looked at him again and at the soldier who was bearing the old man and realized that it was himself. He had hoisted the old tiger on his shoulders! Together, when they charged, enemy soldiers fell in droves to the long sword of Vijayalaya Chola. Wherever they went, the heads of Pandya soldiers rolled.

What had been a sure defeat now turned into a huge victory for the Cholas. The Pandya army broke ranks and fled, much to the delight of the Chola soldiers. Victory drums started playing, declaring their victory over the enemies. Vijayalaya Chola sat next to the Pallava Emperor, and beside him stood Pazhuvetarayar.

The Pallava emperor declared to Vijayalaya Chola, "O brave king, you turned our fortunes today. We won only because of you. From this day, the Chola Kingdom will be independent. You and your descendants will henceforth be the independent kings of the Chola Kingdom!"

Vijayalaya Chola immediately turned towards Pazhuvetarayar, who was standing next to him and said, "Cousin, this victory was possible only because of you. I, therefore, declare you as the commander-in-chief of our forces and the treasurer of the Chola Kingdom. Your descendants can henceforth claim the title of 'Lord Treasurer' and be our commanders until they remain true to the Chola Kingdom."

Pazhuvetarayar, who stood bleeding from his face and body, beamed with exhilaration at Vijayalaya Chola.

Suddenly, that Pazhuvetarayar turned towards him, angry and incensed and said "You wretch! Scoundrel! You have brought disrepute to our clan. Your actions have turned six generations' worth of service and devotion to dust. How dare you betray your masters and your friends? How dare you give shelter to the sworn enemies of the Chola Kingdom in your own house? How could you allow them to loot the treasure of Chola Kingdom?!"

“Because of you, the Chola Empire and its Emperor will fall, and no one will ever remember our glorious deeds. Only your treason and betrayal will be remembered,” cursed Pazhuvetarayar, his face streaming with tears.

Other Pazhuvetarayars came towards him, listing their brave deeds and sacrifices and then cursed him to their heart's content. “Traitor, how dare you betray your clan thus? How dare you betray your king thus? All our sacrifices have now turned to dust. How could all our efforts come to this?”

The Pazhuvetarayars vanished. Next came the Malayamans and Kodumbalur Vellars.

“There you are! Vainglorious villain. Weren't you proud that it was your clan that made kings out of the Cholas? What do you have to say now? Thanks to you, they are destroyed. Where is your pride now?” They laughed at him.

Behind them, the people of the Chola kingdom, who had gathered around, started throwing stones and sand at him. Suddenly Emperor Sundara Chola was there. He parted the crowds and reached him with faltering steps.

He looked angrily at the Vellars and Malayamans and said, “How dare you throw stones at the brave Pazhuvetarayar?! How dare you call him a traitor? If he is indeed a traitor, then we will be destroyed, and it doesn't matter. Don't blame him. Lord Treasurer, come, let's go to the palace.”

The crowds vanished and Emperor Sundara Chola disappeared, too. Next came his brother Kalanthaka Kanda, “Anna, how could you betray the emperor thus? He trusted us so much. How can we give sanctuary to the snake that has come to destroy the Chola clan?” he asked and disappeared.

Next, the young and handsome soldiers like Vandiya Devan, Kandanmaran, and Parthibendra Pallavan came and encircled him,

“Your hair and moustache have turned white and yet, your desires run young. You sought your destruction thanks to your lust for a woman. What’s the use of those glorious scars you bear on your body? What do they say now? Would you still call them gifts of victory or signs of betrayal?” They asked and laughed loudly.

Incensed by their taunt, the old man tried to draw his sword, but it was missing. Just then, Princess Kundavai arrived. She stood over him with a protective stance and said, “Grandfather, ignore their remarks. Banish the snake that you are protecting in your palace and people will stop taunting you thus!”

They vanished and were replaced by the women of the Pazhuvur clan. Hundreds and thousands of women belonging to six generations of the past surrounded him.

“Ayyo! Why did you shame our clan’s name so? How will we wash away the stain of betrayal you have tainted us with? Is this why we sacrificed our fathers, brothers, husbands, and sons? We bore them in our womb for nine months only to send them away to deadly battles and wars. They gave their blood and life for the Chola Kingdom and won glory for this clan. Your actions have wiped all their efforts in one second!” they wailed.

“Women! Go back to your anthappuram. This clan will not be shamed because of me,” he tried to tell them, but they pointed towards Lord Yama, who was coming towards him on his black buffalo with his spear, mace, and noose in one hand.

He said, “Pazhuvetarayara, thanks to you I was able to claim the lives of Sundara Chola and his sons in one day! I am much obliged to you.”

“No! No! I didn’t help you and will never help you. I will stop you. Yama! Stop right there. Stop!” he shouted and tried to stop Lord Yama. Then he realized that something heavy was pressing down on him, making him immobile.

“Do you see now! We were right,” said the women from the Pazhuvur clan, and started wailing again. Pazhuvetarayar felt that their wailing was increasing by the minute and was unable to bear it even for a moment, he tried to console them, but his voice was drowned in their cries. He tried to shut his ears but couldn’t move his arms or lift them.

With great effort, he tried to move his arms. And that’s when his eyes opened. He immediately remembered where he was, and realized that whatever he had experienced so far were dreams. But he could still hear the distant wails. He listened intently and realized that it was not the wailing of women but the howling of wolves.

Just before he lost consciousness again, he had also heard the Pandya rebels’ conversation.

“The old man is dead!”

“Check carefully. He is tenacious. Even Lord Yama will be afraid to near him!”

“Even if Lord Yama is scared to near him, the wolves will not be scared. Whatever life is left in him will be consumed by them. Come morning, only the bones will remain...”

“Thank God, you pushed the roof in. Otherwise, I would have died. The old man almost killed me.”

“Are you able to move these stones? Let’s see.”

After a while, the same voice said, “It’s impossible to move the stones. We have built a new Pallipadai for this enemy with the stones of the old enemy,” said the Mandiravadi and laughed with merriment.

“If you are done laughing, come, let’s go. If the boat floats away, we will be stranded in these woods and can’t cross Kollidam!”

The old man heard this and understood his predicament. He took stock of the situation. The roof of the Pallipadai had caved in and had fallen on him, but he was still able to breathe.

How?

Thankfully, when the roof came down, a nearby tree, too, had fallen. It bore the weight of the stones and had also protected his head. The old man was amazed by his own stamina and wondered how he had borne the weight of the tree and the heavy stones of the mandapam.

Will I survive this? Is there any purpose to my life?

I must survive somehow and avert the danger that is looming over the Chola royal family. If I fail, my clan and my descendants will suffer infamy and disgrace for generations to come. Even in the nether worlds, my ancestors will curse me. I have no choice but to move this tree and the stones.

Ayyo! How long have I been unconscious? Have the assassins claimed their kill? What if the danger that I wish to avert has already occurred?

By then, he also realized that the growls of the wolves were nearing him. He could feel and hear the hot breath of the wolves over the stones.

These wolves too think that Pazhuvetarayar is fair game for them. Let me see how they make a meal of me.

With resolute determination, using all the residual strength in his body, Pazhuvetarayar pushed at the tree and stones. Slowly, inch by inch, the tree moved, and the stones slipped away. His growls had scared the wolves and they had moved away from the site.

It took almost an hour for him to move the tree and the stones, and eventually, he was able to climb out from under them. He

stumbled and lay down to rest awhile, taking long breaths.

He looked up to see the sky and the stars dotting it. A few scattered clouds were there, and they too were dispersing fast. In the north, he could see the comet whose tail had shrunk. Even ten days ago, the comet dominated the skies from one end to the other with its long tail. He wondered why the tail had disappeared and what its significance could be.

He then looked around and found that the wolves had not yet disappeared. They were at a distance, probably biding their time. Their eyes blinked red in the darkness of the woods.

They are waiting for this old man to die! That's good. At least these wolves have some respect left for me.

Suddenly a flash of light was seen around the woods. Pazhuvetarayar shut his eyes, unable to bear the glare of the light. It was not lightning.

What else could it be?

He looked up and saw that the comet was not in its usual place. It had disappeared. What does it mean? What does this signify? Does this mean disasters for the world? Could this mean someone in the royal family will die?

As to the truth of it, he would learn that tomorrow. Not tomorrow. Today. It was already dawn and the sun was rising. By tonight, three people from the royal family might be killed, and only he knew about this. Only he could stop these assassinations. If he succeeded, he would win over the comet's evil omen. If he didn't...

That is not an option. I have to stop the assassinations somehow.

His first duty was to save Prince Aditya Karikalan. If something were to happen to him, he would be blamed. He had to cross the Kollidam River and reach Kadambur as soon as possible. Before

that, if he could reach Kudanthai and send messages to Thanjavur and Nagapattinam, he might avert the mishaps that might occur.

The old man tried to get up. He was bleeding from multiple wounds all over his body. His chest was bruised, and he was hurting all over. One of his legs was sprained and was swelling rapidly.

Gritting his teeth against the excruciating pain, the old man got up. Thankfully, the wolves had disappeared when the comet's tail had fallen. He looked around carefully and started walking in the direction of Kudanthai.

Walking carefully, he hobbled over fallen trees and flooded woods. He didn't sit down or rest. His determination to stop the assassinations made him forget the excruciating pain from his wounds. He reached Kudanthai after about two hours. He didn't want to enter the main part of the town. The people might surround him, and then it would be impossible to go anywhere.

He thought that it would be better to find someone in the town's suburbs and send messages to Thanjavur and Nagapattinam. That's when he remembered there was an astrologer near the Durga Temple. It was a secluded place, and Kudanthai Jodhidar was an astute man known to both the royal family and the Prime Minister.

Aha! Is there any truth to astrology? This might just be the right time to find out.

Thinking thus, Pazhuvetarayar walked towards the Durga Temple and the astrologer's house situated next to it. As he neared it, he saw that the big tree next to the temple had fallen. The next thing that he saw was a two-horse chariot that stood near the temple.

It was an unusual chariot. The top of the vehicle was shaped like a boat. This was used specifically during times of flood if they had to cross a river then. If the water level was high, they could detach the boat from the chariot and remove the yoke of the horse. The people on the chariot could row the boat and escape the water, while the

horses could swim and escape. These chariots were not available for everyone and were primarily used by the royal family and their courtiers.

Those who have come in this chariot are probably inside the astrologer's house seeking consultation.

Who could it be? Shall I ask the charioteer? No! He will get scared. Let me straight away go into the house. Whoever is in the house, I will request them to give me the chariot. I would reach Kadambur faster while riding the vehicle than on foot.

As he neared the entrance, he could hear women's voices. And the old man felt unnerved wondering who it could be.

Whose voice that could be? Could it be Princess Kundavai? Why is she here? Why did she come here now, of all times?

After a few minutes, he changed his mind. If it was indeed Kundavai, it was a good thing after all. He could inform her about the impending assassination attempts and his burden would lessen. That clever young woman will take the necessary precautions and warn her father and brother. With her help, he could go back to Kadambur and attempt to save Karikalan.

As he entered the courtyard of the house, the astrologer's disciple – the same one who had earlier stopped Vandiya Devan – tried to stop him too.

Pazhuvetarayar was unrecognizable in his tattered clothes and battered body.

The disciple said, 'Stop!' and tried to prevent him from entering, but Pazhuvetarayar grunted in response and threw the disciple out of the house. Grunting and growling like a mad elephant, the old man entered the house.

Chapter 13: Kundavai Asks For a Boon

Princess Kundavai and Vanathi were inside the astrologer's house when Pazhuvetarayar arrived. Kundavai was in distress. That morning, they couldn't find Mandakini or Poonguzhali. Kundavai had gone to meet the Prime Minister and there she had heard the news about Arulmozhi, that he had to emerge from the Viharam during the storm. And with his identity revealed, he was being brought to Thanjavur by thousands of people in a victory procession. This news distressed her even further as she felt that something disastrous was in the works.

She wanted to meet her brother and tell him all about the shocking events that had happened in Thanjavur. If he were to reach Thanjavur with a huge number of people, the Pazhuvur forces will stop him from entering the fort. In the meanwhile, she had also learned that Budvikrama Kesari was back from Elangai and had reached Kodumbalur with his army. If they both came to Thanjavur, a civil war was imminent which would cause further pain to her father and might even lead to his death.

The kingdom was in turmoil due to the devastating storm that had raged everywhere, and the people were angry for various reasons. They just need a reason to revolt now, and a civil war might begin at the slightest provocation. She wanted to take any step necessary to stop this from happening. She wanted to stop Arulmozhi from coming to Thanjavur and make him stay in Pazhaiarai for a while. She wanted to get Pazhuvetarayar to meet Arulmozhi and formally inform him that her brother was not interested in ruling the kingdom, and then take him to Thanjavur.

Thinking thus, Kundavai left the Thanjavur palace to return to Pazhaiarai. She hadn't informed her father about these plans, but had taken her mother and the Prime Minister into confidence, and left with Vanathi. On the way, she wanted to consult Kudanthai

Jodhidar once again. It is but natural that worried people consult an astrologer about the future.

As usual, she had left her chariot in front of the temple and had gone to the astrologer's house. Just when she had begun telling the astrologer about her problems, they could hear the struggle happening in the courtyard of the house. Kundavai recognized Pazhuvetarayar's stately grunt and war growl. They saw the way he had thrown out the astrologer's disciple on the street.

How did he come here? What is he doing here? Could he have come here to consult the astrologer? Maybe if we hear what he says, it might give us some insights into what he is planning. With the kingdom and the royal family in a constant state of worry, it would do good for everyone if we knew what Pazhuvetarayar's intentions are. This is a great opportunity to know about that. God knows what he would think if he learned that Vanathi and I are here. It's best to hide ourselves until he is here...

Thinking thus, Kundavai grabbed Vanathi's hand, signalled to the astrologer about her intentions and went to the next room. The next minute, Pazhuvetarayar burst into the room with great agitation. Kudanthai Jodhidar immediately got up and respectfully welcomed him inside. Pazhuvetarayar looked around the room in surprise and disappointment, and then turned towards the astrologer, saying, "Jodhidarey, do you know who I am? I am Periya Pazhuvetarayar, the Lord Treasurer. Why are you staring at me like that? Am I so unrecognizable? You need to help me now. I have a big task for you. But first, if you have something to eat, bring it to me. I am very hungry. I will tell you everything while I eat."

Surprised and worried by Pazhuvetarayar's entrance, the astrologer said, "Ayya, I don't know what help I can do for you. I am but a poor, simple man. My house is small, and my means are limited. But whatever I have here is yours. I will get you some food – it may not be as good as what you are accustomed to, but that's all I have. Please sit down. Oh, God! I don't even have a proper chair to seat you in this house. My apologies if I didn't welcome you properly.

I was taken by surprise. Please sit down on this wooden plank here.” He pointed towards the seat that Kundavai had been occupying a few minutes ago.

Pazhuvetarayar didn’t fail to notice the flowers that were lying on the seat as he said, “Jodhidarey, I don’t have time to sit. If you have something to eat, give it to me. Or else wrap it in a leaf and hand it over, I will eat it later. I need to send an urgent message to Thanjavur, to my brother Kalanthaka Kandan. Bring me a palm leaf and a pen. No... there is no time for all that. I will give you my signet ring. Can you take that and go to Thanjavur immediately? If you can’t go, can you send your disciple who was at the entrance – bit of a rogue that he was – to Thanjavur?”

“I will act as per your orders. My disciple and I can both go to Thanjavur if you so wish. But first, please sit down and have some refreshments at this poor man’s house!”

“Jodhidarey, why do you call yourself poor and simple? I have heard that queens and princesses often visit you for consultations. Only I have not come to you to know my fortunes. It was a mistake. If I had done that, maybe things might have happened differently and we could have avoided many disasters!”

“Ayya, what happened to you? Were you caught in the storm and the floods? I heard that the Kollidam riverbank broke... My Lord, Is Nandini Devi safe? Was she with you when this disaster happened?”

Pazhuvetarayar laughed dangerously when he heard Nandini’s name and said, “No... No. Nandini is safe. She didn’t drown in the Kollidam floods. She is still in Kadambur palace, but I can’t tell you if she would be alive until tomorrow this time. Jodhidarey, you have the horoscopes of everyone in the royal family, right? Do you have the horoscope of the woman who I stupidly married in my old age?”

Agitated by his question, the astrologer said, “My Lord, are you testing me? I don’t have Nandini Devi’s horoscope with me. But if I can get her time of birth and place, I can cast her chart.”

“Don’t bother, I will write Nandini’s horoscope. I have decided to end her life with these very hands that had claimed her as my wife. If you know about other people’s horoscopes, tell me something about it. How does the emperor’s lifeline look? Why do you shake your head thus? You won’t tell. You still think that I am testing you. I am thinking that maybe astrology is just a bunch of lies.

Leave the horoscope aside! What do you think about the comet that we have been seeing in the sky for a while? Today morning, it disappeared, do you know about it? What does it signify? Will there be any danger to the kingdom? Does it mean there is a danger to the emperor and his sons? If your astrology can’t even predict this, then what’s the point of all this?”

“My Lord, please do not come to such conclusions. There is a rule that we astrologers follow. We are not supposed to see the future of kingdoms. This morning, the comet disappeared, and I did see a sudden glow when its tail fell. I have been noting that the comet’s tail had been shrinking for a few days now. When a comet disappears, danger to the royal family is imminent, but this is not told in astrology. It is what people generally believe in. I do not believe in it. Why, even today morning, I heard that the emperor is in good health...”

“That’s good news. If we can keep the emperor alive until tomorrow, we can avert the danger. Have you heard anything about Ponniyin Selvar?”

“I heard that the prince has reached Thiruvaroor. Thousands of people are around him and I learned that he is being taken to Thanjavur against his wishes!”

“Aha! If only they could take him to Thanjavur safely, it would be good for us. But can they? Even amid thousands of people, Lord Yama can’t be stopped. Even if you can’t predict anything, I can predict something accurately. There is great danger awaiting the emperor and his sons today. Lord Yama is inching towards them. For the emperor, the danger awaits in the path that lies in the treasure

chamber dungeon that leads to the main palace. An assassin is hiding there, waiting to strike him down at the right time. For Prince Arulmozhi, Lord Yama is hiding in the mahout's elephant goad. It is your responsibility now, to warn them and save them from imminent death. Let your disciple take my signet ring to Thanjavur while you go to Thirubaroor and warn the prince. Will you go immediately?"

The astrologer was astounded. He didn't know how to respond to Pazhuvetarayar. He didn't know if the Lord Treasurer was of sound mind. Though the old man's speech was agitated and disturbed, he detected truth at its foundation. He knew that Princess Kundavai must have heard all this, and resolved to get her opinion on the matter. In the meantime, he had to get rid of the old man somehow.

"With the blessings of Mother Durga, I will try my utmost to follow your orders," he said. And at the same time, Pazhuvetarayar's keen ears could hear the tinkle of anklets from the next room.

He said, "Aha! Looks like Mother Durga has indeed given her permission. I can now return to Kadambur. I will leave immediately..."

"My Lord, you said you were hungry. Please let me get some food..."

"No... my hunger and thirst are gone. I need to go to Kadambur immediately. There is a chariot in front of the temple, whose is it? I am going to take it. Once I reach Kollidam, I will return the chariot, though I will need to retain the boat..."

"Ayya, that chariot... please take pity on me and don't take it."

"Jodhidarey, why are you worrying thus? I am taking that chariot to save the life of the Crown Prince. Mother Durga will give her permission for this too. You will soon hear the sound of her anklets again that will signal her approval..."

Even as Pazhuvetarayar was saying this, Kundavai opened the door and came out followed by Vanathi. Pazhuvetarayar was not surprised.

“Princess, I guessed correctly. I knew that you were in the next room. I didn’t have the nerve to face you, that’s why I was speaking so loudly... so that you could hear what I have to say. Did you hear me?”

“Ayya, forgive me. I didn’t know for sure that it was you who had come to the house. That’s why I hid in the next room and inadvertently heard everything you said.”

“Devi, you have done nothing to beg my forgiveness. On the other hand, it is I who should beg for your forgiveness. That said, I doubt if I am even entitled to your forgiveness. Today, if I can go to Kadambur and save the Crown Prince, I gain the right to seek your forgiveness. For the past three years, this old man’s eyes were shut, thanks to lust, lies and love. You tried your utmost to open my eyes and help me see reality. Last night, thanks to Mother Durga’s grace, my eyes opened. I overheard the Pandya rebels and learned the truth. I allowed that snake to stay in my palace and plot the destruction of the Cholas. Thanks to her, I was ready to betray my clan, my emperor. She used the Chola treasury to provide funds to these rebels. That wretched woman will meet her end tonight at my hands. Only then this fire within my heart will be quenched...”

Kundavai then did something unexpected. She fell at Pazhuvetarayar’s feet. Surprised and shocked, he didn’t know how to react. She then got up and said, “Ayya, I seek a boon from you!”

“Princess, are you testing me, perchance? Don’t, please. I have committed many sins and I don’t know how to atone for them. Before that, the most important thing to do is to save your father and brothers from the assassins. Once they are safe, I will come to you and demand that you punish me for my sins, and will atone for them in any way you wish.”

“Ayya, I am no one to give you punishments or suggest atonements. You are like my grandfather and my father regards you above everyone else. I truly seek a boon from you...”

“If that is so, ask immediately. We don’t have time to waste with idle words...”

“Promise me that you will give me this boon.”

“After what I did to you and your family, there is nothing that I can possibly give you. But I do promise to give you whatever you want.”

“You must not cause any harm to Nandini Devi. That’s what I seek as a boon!”

“Princess, what are you saying? If I don’t punish the woman who has betrayed me and turned me into a traitor, how else can I atone for my sins? She is the leader of these rebels! If I don’t punish her, how can I get the rest of them? She will meet her end in my hands. I will choke the life out of her after I pour the hatred I am feeling in my heart and make her realize that she couldn’t fool me until the end. I will butcher her with my sword. Anything less than that would not be a just punishment for her. After I slay her, I will punish myself appropriately. Go, princess, try and save your father and brother from these dangers...”

“I will try, ayya! But before I go, I also have to save the life of my sister. Nandini Devi is my older sister. If you harm her, you will be harming the Chola royal family!”

Shocked by her words, Pazhuvetarayar mumbled, “Am I still dreaming?”

“No. You are not dreaming. If you remember some of the past events, do you remember when Arulmozhi drowned in the Ponni River and was saved by Kaveri Amman? It was Nandini Devi’s mother who had saved him. Do you know why my father faints

whenever he sees Nandini? That's because he thought he was seeing Nandini's mother, who he believed to be dead."

Pazhuvetarayar remembered other incidents, too. He remembered when he had taken Nandini to face Sundara Chola in the dead of the night and the way the emperor had wailed. He remembered Nandini's explanations for the emperor's reactions and realized the truth in what Kundavai was saying.

"Devi, now I realize what you are saying. Fate is indeed toying with us. If Nandini is your older sister, then she is Karikalan's sister too. Are you the only one who knows about this or does anybody else also know? Does the emperor know?"

"Until two days ago, the emperor believed that Nandini's mother was dead. The day before yesterday, when Mandakini Devi herself came in front of him, he thought she was a ghost and threw a lamp at her. It was only afterwards that he realized that she was alive after all..."

"Does Karikalan know that Nandini is his sister?"

"By now, he must know the truth. I sent him a message through the Prince of Vallam."

"You mean Vandiya Devan?"

"Yes!"

"I don't think he told the prince. And even if he did, I don't think Karikalan would have believed him. Even I am finding it hard to believe. Nandini may not know this. And even if she knows, it doesn't matter. They will seek their vengeance no matter what. They will try to assassinate the crown prince tonight. Your revelations have entrusted me with a greater responsibility. I have to stop Nandini from killing her own brother. I must leave for Kadambur immediately. I am taking your chariot with me. You are now responsible for keeping your younger brother and father safe from these assassins."

“Ayya, I will leave for Thanjavur immediately. I will procure a chariot from Pazhaiarai and leave immediately. We don’t have to worry about Ponniyin Selvan. His stars are fortunate, and they will protect him from harm!”

“Princess! Don’t depend on astrology so much and become complacent. Astrologers will never tell you the entire truth even if they know it. They will tell you half-truths concealed within cleverly chosen words that could be interpreted in any way. And when an untoward incident happens, they will say, ‘we told you so’. And even if you were to believe in their predictions, don’t ever put your trust in an astrologer.”

Saying thus, Pazhuvetarayar left the house. Within a few minutes of his departure, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi entered the house, saying, “Yes, yes, I agree wholeheartedly to what Lord Treasurer just said. Even if you believe in astrology, never put your trust in astrologers!”

Chapter 14: Vanathi's Vow

Startled by Azhwarkadiyan's entry, Kundavai asked, "Thirumalai, how did you come here, and why?"

"Devi, it is all because of this astrologer's dubious predictions. I asked him this morning if my work will proceed smoothly, and he said, 'it will.' But here I am, unable to even move away from here. That's why I agreed with Pazhuvetarayar when he said, 'do not trust the astrologer!' That's why I came back. I wanted to know if this man was a fraud. And that's when I heard Pazhuvetarayar's voice inside and I got suspicious of the astrologer too. But then, I didn't expect you to be here as well!"

"Yes, you wouldn't have expected me here. But what important work was this that you needed to consult an astrologer for? Is it a secret?"

"There are no secrets from you, Devi. Upon the emperor's commands, the prime minister asked me to go to Nagapattinam to bring back Prince Arulmozhivarman. And on the way, he asked me to hand over a message to Sembiyanmadevi as well. When did you start from Thanjavur?"

"Right after dawn broke. Why do you ask?"

"I wanted to check if you knew whether the Kodumbalur army had laid a siege on Thanjavur fort yet."

"What!" exclaimed Kundavai.

"Yes, Devi, didn't you know? Last night, when the prime minister returned to his palace, he had two messages waiting for him. One was from Nagapattinam, where we learned that the prince was on his way to Thanjavur with thousands of people in tow...."

“I heard that in the morning when I met him. I wanted to meet him on his way and halt his journey. What was the other message?”

Azhwarkadiyan looked at Vanathi and said, “Devi, why did you bring this Kodumbalur princess with you? I am hesitant to tell you the second message in her presence...”

“Thirumalai, don’t you know she is my confidential companion and friend? I keep no secrets from her. What was the second message?”

“I hesitate because this concerns the princess. Her uncle, Budivikrama Kesari, is on the way to Thanjavur with a huge army. The prime minister also got a message from the commander where he had charged the Pazhuvur brothers with imprisoning the emperor in Thanjavur and the prince at some secret location. He demanded that Periya Pazhuvetarayar resigns from his position as the Lord Treasurer and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar as the commander of the fort. He demanded that they release the prince and hand him over to him, or else his army would lay siege to the fort by this evening. Devi, the army is marching towards Thanjavur from the west and south, didn’t you know this?”

“I didn’t know. The prime minister didn’t tell me anything about it, either.”

“If you had known, you probably wouldn’t have left the fort. More importantly, I think he wanted to get the Kodumbalur Princess out of the fort...”

“But why? What could have happened if she was there?”

“Chinna Pazhuvetarayar could even imprison this princess!”

“Will he dare to do that? Are you really telling me that he would have done it?”

“Yes, Devi. If you had heard the whole message, you would understand why!”

“What else was in the message?”

“He demanded that Prince Arulmozhivarman must marry Princess Vanathi immediately, and since Aditya Karikalar doesn’t wish to rule the kingdom, Ponniyin Selvar must be announced as the next heir apparent and the crown prince. And if his demands were not met, he threatened to raze the Thanjavur Fort to the ground within three days. He also claims that the people of the Chola Kingdom support him unequivocally.”

Angered by the actions of her uncle, Vanathi exclaimed, “Has my uncle gone mad?”

“Why are you so angry, Vanathi? Your uncle has only revealed to everyone the cherished wish of many people. Ever since the Pazhuvur brothers tried to pass the kingdom to Madhuranthakan, your uncle and my grandfather have started saying the same thing.”

“Yes, Devi! I think Thirukkoyalur Malayaman must also have brought his army to Kadambur’s gates. I inferred that from what the prime minister was saying...”

“But neither of them knows what I have learned today. I need to speak to both of them to stop this war from starting. I don’t know how I am going to do that...”

“Devi, the situation has gone out of hands. I don’t think we can stop this Mahabharata war from happening...”

“You are right when you call it the Mahabharata war, Thirumalai. This is indeed a fratricidal war that will tear this kingdom apart. My great-grandsire, Emperor Paranthaka, married a woman from the Pazhuvur clan. His daughter, my grandmother’s sister, married a Kodumbalur King. My grandfather Aringzha Cholan married a Kodumbalur princess too. My father married Thirukkoyalur

Malayaman's daughter. All three clans are intermarried with the Chola royal family, intermingling our blood. And yet, today, they are after each other's blood. What do you say to this? This war will end the Chola kingdom forever..."

"Akka, I don't really care about all this. Let them have their bloody wars. But what possessed my uncle to drag my name into all this? I want to meet him immediately and fight with him about this!"

"What's the point, my dear? Your uncle is not going to listen to you or me. Only Arulmozhi can talk to your uncle and my grandfather and resolve this situation. Thirumalai! Why did you return? Where is Arulmozhi now?"

"He was supposed to start from Thiruvarur, but the flood has halted his progress. I wanted to go beyond Pazhalarai, but was not able to. That's why I came back. The Kodamurattu River is flooded, and the flood waters are flowing everywhere like an ocean."

"The waters will recede, and after that Arulmozhi will be able to come here. But by then, I fear something untoward might happen in Thanjavur. Thirumalai! Can you return immediately to Thanjavur and give my message to Kodumabalar Vellar? Request him not to hold the Thanjavur Fort on siege until the prince returns. Will you do that?"

"Akka, can I go to Thanjavur along with him?"

"What will you do by going back to Thanjavur?"

"I want to go and fight with my uncle."

"What will you tell him? Do you think he is going to stop this siege just because you ask him to?"

"Let him have his fight, I don't really care. I will insist that he not drag my name through all this."

“How is he dragging your name in this?”

“Didn’t you hear what this Veera Vaishnavan said, akka?” she said and bowed her head shyly.

“What did he say about you? Thirumalai, what did you say?”

“The Commander has demanded that the prince marry her immediately. I think she is referring to that.”

“Vanathi, why are you objecting to that? Don’t you want to marry my brother?”

“Whether or not I want to is not the question here. Why is my uncle placing the demand for this marriage and his ascension to the Chola throne together? This war effort looks like a grand plan to make me the queen of this realm. That’s what I am objecting to.”

That when they heard a woman’s voice that said, “Looks like the Kodumbalur Princess doesn’t want to ascend the throne?”

Everybody looked at the entrance, startled, and found Poonguzhali entering.

Kundavai looked at her in surprise and said, “How did you come, girl? This morning we searched all over the palace for you and your aunt. Where is she?”

“Forgive me, Devi! My aunt took me through the Pazhuvur palace’s dungeon passage and asked me to leave the fort immediately. I think she didn’t like me staying at the palace even for a day. And I didn’t want to stay at the palace, either. When the Kodumbalur Princess is saying no to the throne, why would people like me want to stay at the palace?”

“Girl, I asked you something and you are giving me an entirely different answer. Your mind is not thinking straight...”

“Akka, her mind is straight enough. She is saying all this deliberately just to insult me. She believes that I want to ascend the Chola throne as its queen and that’s why I wish to marry your brother. That’s what she thinks...”

“Only a woman will know what another woman is thinking...”

“Girls! Stop this immediately. You don’t seem to know the gravity of the situation, and here you are talking about inconsequential things... Poonguzhali, where is your aunt right now?”

“She is inside the dungeons beneath the Pazhuvur palace...”

“Why is she there?”

“There is an assassin waiting in the dungeons. Aha! We frightened the wits out of him this morning! He thought that we both were ghosts and ran for his life everywhere...” said Poonguzhali and laughed merrily.

Kundavai watched her with trepidation and decided that she was delusional.

“Tell me more! Who is he? Why is he hiding there? How did you both know about his presence?”

“I don’t know how she knew, Devi. My aunt might be mute and deaf, but her intuitive powers are strong. And she somehow knew that this assassin had come to kill someone at the palace. Devi, do you know why my aunt was trying to break the hands of the ten-headed Ravana? When my aunt attempted to break his hands, you thought that she was mad and deranged. But she is not mad. Hidden beneath the hands of Ravana is a path to the dungeon that goes to Pazhuvur palace!”

“Aha! We didn’t know that!” exclaimed Kundavai.

“Now we know how Mandakini Devi suddenly appeared in the palace,” said Thirumalai.

“And we didn’t know the existence of this secret dungeon or its entrance! Alright then! Why didn’t you come back to the palace and warn us about this? Why did you leave your aunt alone in the dungeon?”

“My aunt insisted that I leave. She said she will take care of the assassin herself.”

“Why? Why would she send you away? Has she sent you on another errand?”

“Yes, Devi.”

“What errand?”

“My aunt felt that Prince Arulmozhi is in danger and asked me to go to him...”

“Aha! So, you were on the way to meet the prince! Then why did you stop and come here?”

“No, Devi, I will tell the truth. I have decided not to get involved in these affairs anymore. I wanted to go back to Kodi Karai. On the way, this Veera Vaishnavan met me, and we ended up here... if I had known you were here, I wouldn’t have come.”

“My girl, why are you leaving us so suddenly? What have the palace folk done to you that you are so angry with us?”

“No one has said or done anything to me. I have no such complaints. Just as some people don’t wish to ascend the throne, I too do not wish to live in the palace!” she said cheekily and winked at Vanathi.

Angered by her taunting, Vanathi took a step forward and said, “Akka, she is targeting me repeatedly for her malicious humour.

Listen to me now. I swear on your feet and call upon the skies and the earth to bear witness to this vow that I take. If Ponniyin Selvar were to escape the assassins and come back unscathed and claim my hand in marriage... I will never sit beside him on the throne as his queen. This is my holy vow!"

Chapter 15: The Roof Floats

No one expected Vanathi to make such a vow, and it startled them beyond words. Kundavai looked at her with a pitying glance and asked, “Girl, why did you take such a vow? Are you out of your mind?”

“No, akka, I am not out of my mind. This is a decision that I had taken long back. I just declared it in the public, that’s all.”

Before Kundavai could respond to that, Poonguzhali laughed merrily and then within a few seconds, her laughter turned into sobs. And then she started singing her favourite song ‘Alai Kadal’. Her strange actions made Kundavai wonder if she had indeed lost her sanity.

Kundavai looked at Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and said, “Thirumalai, these two girls are driving me mad. Tell me something, why did you come back and why did you bring her here?”

“I started from here to meet Ponniyin Selvar, but all the rivers are in spate with flood waters. I found that she, too, was stranded like me. So we came here to get a boat. She said that if we get a boat, she could take me to Thiruvarur. That’s why we came back here. When I saw your chariot and boat, I thought I could ask you if I can borrow them, but Pazhuvetarayar took that along with him.”

“What do you think we should do now? You heard what Pazhuvetarayar told me, right?”

“Yes, Devi! Ever since I heard him, every minute we spend here seems like a year to me. Whatever this girl said correlates with what Pazhuvetarayar said. Even the prime minister doesn’t know about this assassin hiding in Pazhuvur palace. My suggestion is that you take the Kodumbalur Princess with you to Thanjavur. If the Kodumbalur forces have already laid siege at the fort, only you can

Speak some sense into them and go inside. Having the Kodumbalur Princess with you will make things easy for you. In the meantime, I will pacify this girl and procure a boat which we will take to Thiruvavur. I have already sent the astrologer's disciple to get a boat."

Vanathi suddenly got up and said, "No, I will go to Ponniyin Sevar... even if I have to die, I will lay my life at his feet!"

Hearing this, Poonguzhali said, "Vaishnavarey, I will not come with you. I must go to Kodi Karai. My lovers await me there. They are calling to me the beautiful fire bubbles that appear and vanish within minutes. I even showed Vandiya Devar my lovers and I need to go back to them..."

Until then, the astrologer, who had not participated in any of these conversations and was watching with bewildered surprise, spoke, "Please... please, everybody stop talking for a moment!"

Everyone fell silent. That's when they heard the other noise. The noise of rushing water and roaring waves.

"Woe to me, that you women had to come to my house today. I predict fortunes for everyone around me, and yet I failed to warn you about this," wailed the astrologer.

"Ayya, what danger are you talking about?"

"Devi, this morning, my disciple said that Arisalaru was flooded and if the bank breaks, the flood waters will wash away my house. Come outside, let's see what's happening," saying thus, he fled the house. Behind him, everyone came to the entrance.

"There... look there."

He pointed in the southwest direction, where a wall of water was fast rushing towards the street.

“Come everyone. Let’s try and climb the mandapam of Amman temple. There is no other way to escape this!”

Poonguzhali suddenly seemed to have come back to her senses. She said, “Devi, this is nothing. I have handled far worse storms. We will survive this. Don’t worry!” Saying thus, she ran ahead of the others and got on top of the mandapam.

By now, the flood waters had reached the temple. With the waters reaching up to their knees. The astrologer and Nambi somehow scrambled atop the temple walls while Kundavai and Vanathi were still down.

Poonguzhali helped Kundavai by pulling her up by her arms. Vanathi, who was trying to get on the wall, fell back twice in the water. Kundavai and Poonguzhali tried to hoist her up together. When Vanathi looked up and saw who was helping her, she saw Poonguzhali was holding her hand and immediately shook it away, resulting in Kundavai losing the grasp on her other hand. She fell again, but by now the waters had reached her neck and she was borne by the flowing waters. The waters took her up to the roof of the astrologer’s house. She clutched the roof and held on to dear life.

Shocked by the turn of events, the people on the mandapam shouted encouraging words to the poor girl, asking her to hold the roof tightly. They thought that they could rescue her once the boat arrives.

Vanathi held the thatched roof of the astrologer’s house tightly. Soon, it felt as though the roof was moving. Yes, the rushing waters had submerged the house and had demolished the walls, but the roof started floating on the water. Clutching the roof tightly, she shouted, “Akka, I am going to see him. I am going to Ponniyin Selvar. Mother Kaveri is going to take me to him.”

She hoped that the others had heard whatever was saying. Most importantly, if that boat girl heard her, it would be satisfying indeed.

Thinking thus, she floated on the roof that took her through the floods that were coursing through the streets.

Chapter 16: When Poonguzhali Leapt

There is a reason why the Chola Kingdom is a verdant land of greenery and agriculture. The rivers that feed its soil make it rich and fertile. But when the flood comes in during adverse weather conditions, the water level increases. This is how the river water travels through the canals and irrigates the fields. That's why many canals are built along the riverbed all through the kingdom, allowing the water to naturally irrigate the fields. But these had to be built in a planned manner, ensuring that the water flows to the fields and not everywhere else, lest the land becomes a marshy area.

The great Chola King Karikala Vallavan put to work the prisoners of war that he had captured to build canals from the rivers to the fields. Karikalan also constructed the Kallanai Dam in Srirangam^[3] in 150AD. Thanks to this dam, the water levels of the river Kaveri and its tributaries rose, allowing the canals to irrigate the fields. This is how the Chola kings of yore had ensured that their kingdom was green, lush, and fertile.

Just as nature had helped the Chola Kingdom to become fertile, there are also times when it played havoc. Storms and hurricanes that originated in the seas east of the Chola Kingdom would sometimes travel north through the shores and cause heavy rains in either the Krishna-Godavari belt or near the Kalinga Kingdom. Sometimes, it would enter the Chola Kingdom and cause destruction before travelling west. This has happened many times in the past and some instances, it has caused the sea to rise high and claim many cities situated near it.

The submerging of Poompuhar (also known as Kaveripattinam) is not a mere myth but a historical fact. Storms and heavy rains cause the waters to break the banks, flooding cities, towns and villages, and the people would seek shelter in temples. The famous Vijayalaya Chola's son, Aditya Chola, had built 108 temples right

from where River Kaveri originated to the point where it joined the sea. The purpose of building temples was two-fold. The original purpose was to worship God and the second one was to provide the people with a sanctuary in case of floods.

Many times, thanks to these floods, the direction of the river changes. And this has happened many times to tributary rivers – Kudamurattu and Arisalaru.

Now let's come back to our story.

The storm that forced Prince Arulmozhi to jump into the sea to save Vandiya Devan travelled through the coast and weakened near the Kalinga Kingdom. The storm that caused the submerging of the Nagapattinam Chudamani Viharam turned towards the Chola Kingdom and caused destruction all through the regions of Kaveri, finally reaching the Kongu region where it dissipated. Heavy rains followed the storm in its wake, and as we travel west, the rains intensified. The storm, followed by torrential rain, increased the water levels causing dangerous floods to break the banks.

The people of the Chola Kingdom were used to these kinds of incidents and were always prepared to deal with them. They would always seek shelter in temples that were built on high ground and wait for the flood waters to recede. They were pragmatic people who would look to the future and build their life anew, rather than complain and whine about the past. Those who lose their homes would seek shelter with their neighbours who lived on higher ground and once the flood waters recede, they would build new homes and resume their lives. The Chola people were known for their resourcefulness and positive attitude. And that's why they were able to achieve so much in their lifetimes.

When Vanathi first fell from the mandapam into the flood waters, everyone was worried that she might float away. But when she got onto the roof, they were a bit relieved. Kundavai cheered a bit. She, who had always tried to instil confidence and self-assurance in that

girl and often tested her resolve, was curious to know how she would handle herself in this situation.

We can only conclude that Kundavai's training had good results because, for a while, Vanathi had not been having her fainting spells.

Kundavai didn't plan this danger for her, but she hoped that her training would help her keep calm until they devised a plan to help her escape.

Will she get scared? Will she faint? No, no. She will remain calm and patiently hold on to the roof until help is at hand.

While Kundavai's thoughts ran like this, Nambi exclaimed, "Devi, it looks like the roof is moving!"

"Something is wrong with your eyes. The flood water is moving, not the roof!" Even as Kundavai spoke this she, too, felt that the roof was moving.

"Devi, look carefully, the roof is indeed moving!"

"Jodhidarey, when will your disciple come with the boat?" asked Azhwarkadiyan.

"Enough, let's not depend on the astrologer and his disciple anymore. Thirumalai, if there is anything that you can do in this situation, then do it. Or else, I must jump into the flood waters and try and save this girl. I will not abandon her to the fates!"

"Devi, one must not lose their sense of balance, especially when one is in danger. You know this better than I do. I can jump into the water and swim towards her. But in the end, I too will end up clutching the same roof. The roof now is able to hold the weight of the Kodumbalur Princess. But if I were to hold it too, it might break taking everyone down... Let's think this through."

Poonguzhali laughed and said, "By the time this Vaishnavan thinks this through, Kodumbalur Princess will be dead and gone!"

Nambi shot back, saying, "If that happens, this boat girl will be very happy!"

This incensed Poonguzhali and he continued, "Nothing untoward will happen to her. Maha Vishnu will protect her. Look there, the astrologer's disciple is coming with the boat!"

The boat was indeed coming towards them, but its progress was slow as the disciple had to row against the flow of water while Vanathi's roof was rapidly floating away with her. They tried to signal the disciple, asking him to go after Vanathi but he thought that they were asking him to come fast and tried to row the boat faster.

Poonguzhali turned towards Kundavai and said, "Devi, permit me to go to the boat. I will turn it towards the princess and bring her back safely."

Kundavai hesitated. It was Poonguzhali's interference that led to this danger.

"Devi, trust me. It is due to my negligence that the princess fell into the water. I will bring her back, it's my responsibility."

"Girl, I do trust you! It is Vanathi that I do not trust to come with you!"

"Aha! You think that she may not get on the boat if I was in it. Don't worry, then I will get down from it and make sure gets in!" Saying this, Poonguzhali jumped into the water and started swimming toward the boat.

Kundavai looked at the astrologer and said, "Today, I lost all my faith in your predictions..."

“But today, I have gained more belief in my own skill and predictions. According to Princess Vanathi’s horoscope, there was a great threat to her life. I feared that it might come through Pazhuvetarayar, and was surprised when it didn’t. She will overcome it for sure. Her most unusual lines... I have never seen them before. All my predictions about her will come true. You will see...”

“That’s very nice. How will these predictions come true? Even if she survives this flood, didn’t you hear the vow that she took at your house a few minutes ago?”

“It doesn’t matter what vow she takes! my predictions about her will come true or else I will throw all the horoscopes that I had painstakingly collected into the flood waters. That’s my vow...”

“Jodhidarey, your palm leaves and horoscopes are already claimed by Mother Kaveri...” Nambi interjected.

Realizing that the Nambi was telling the truth, the astrologer mumbled, “Nonetheless, my predictions will come true. You will see...”

Chapter 17: The Wrath of the Elephant

A few chapters ago, we left the prince in Nagapattinam where he was forced to accept the hospitality of the townspeople. They laid a feast for him and after partaking in it a beautifully decorated elephant was brought to the palace, and he started his journey again. With him were thousands of people who had declared that they would come along with him to Thanjavur. The previous night, the prince and his procession had reached Thiruvarur.

The people at Thiruvarur already knew of the arrival of the prince and had prepared a welcome reception for him. The town was decorated with flags and flowers. The four main streets were packed with crowds that were gathered to catch a glimpse of their dear prince. The Chola palace was readied for his stay, and a feast was prepared for the prince and the people with him.

The storm had passed through Thiruvarur the previous night. But despite the devastation it wrecked, people enthusiastically prepared to welcome the prince. The streets were overrun by musicians, drummers and street performers who hailed the prince and the brave Cholas.

While the Chola kings were the primary patrons of the Chidambaram temple, they also gave many grants and gold to the Thyagaraja Temple in Thiruvaru^[4]. This was the first time that the prince was visiting this town, hence the townspeople insisted that he visit the temple. With his mind disturbed and his heart in distress, he couldn't engage with the Lord in residence. But he didn't object or refuse their invitation. After partaking in the prasadam, he asked the priest, "Why is the Lord named Thyagarajar here?"

To answer his question, the priest described how Lord Shiva had sacrificed himself many times to make and preserve the world. He listed the many sacrifices that Shiva had made just so that the living beings in the three worlds could survive. To help his devotees, he

undertook rigorous austerities and meditated for ages together. To help the Devas, he married Uma. He even became a beggar and got beaten by the Pandya king. That's why Lord Shiva is named 'Thyagarajar'. The priest related this story and reminded him of how his ancestors like 'Manu Nidhi Cholan' had sacrificed his own son to grant justice to a cow.

The priest's description of Lord Shiva as a supreme God who had sacrificed his all for his devotees touched the prince's heart deeply. For so long, he had been in awe of the sacrifices that Lord Buddha had made, but he never really thought of Lord Shiva in the same vein. He had also heard of the legend of Christ, who was crucified and who sacrificed his soul by taking on the sins of the people. Ruminating deeply about his situation, he was saddened by the fact that people were trying to express their love for him by trying to crown him as their king and he wondered how he could escape them and leave the place immediately.

After the temple visit, there was a huge feast spread for him and many entertainments were presented for his pleasure. Though his mind and heart were not engaged in these activities, he participated enthusiastically.

It was almost midnight when the festivities ended, and he came to the Chola Palace only to be greeted by bad tidings. He learned that in the west of the Chola kingdom the storm had wreaked havoc, flooding River Kaveri and its tributaries. With all the rivers in spate and flooded, it would be impossible to continue his journey with so many people in tow. The town leaders advised him to stay for two more days at Thiruvarur and resume his journey after the flood waters receded.

The prince was restless and wanted to reach Thanjavur immediately. Even the flooded rivers couldn't temper his determination. But he knew that if he were to travel with thousands of people behind him, his journey would be interrupted by the natural hurdles that the storm had caused. If he could travel alone on an elephant, he might be able to reach Thanjavur faster. Crossing

flooded rivers would be easy while travelling on an elephant. That apart, the prince had never feared the waters of Ponni. It had, after all, nurtured him since he was young.

The real challenge was to escape the love of these people. That's when he remembered how Rama had left Ayodhya when he set out to the forest. Rama had left at the crack of the dawn before his beloved people could awaken and had escaped from them.

Maybe he could do the same. Either way, it would be better to warn the mahout and ask him to keep the elephant ready for the journey.

Thinking thus, he asked the palace servant to bring the mahout to him. The servant searched for him and then came back saying that the mahout was missing.

The prince said, "He might have gone to see the festivities on the street. Bring him to me as soon as he is back or send someone to search and find him!"

"Yes, my lord. A boatman name Murugayyan wants to meet you urgently and is very insistent that he sees you," said the servant.

The prince felt remorse for having forgotten about Murugayyan. He might even be of assistance in his plan to escape the place. Thinking thus, he asked the servant to immediately bring the boatman to him.

The boatman came inside, fell at the prince's feet, and started crying. The prince sighed heavily and tried to console him, and find out what had distressed him so. Piecing the information that he gave, the prince found out the following –

Murugayyan had not met his wife Rakkammal since they left Nagapattinam. When the procession reached Thiruvavarur, he mingled in the crowd to see if he could spot her there. After roaming through

the streets of the town, he finally found her going with another man through the lanes. The man with her was the prince's mahout!

Suspicious about her character and her virtue, he had followed them through the lanes until they came upon another man who joined them. Together, they walked towards the fields and to the outskirts of the town – towards the cremation grounds. The second man who joined them applied ash on his body and then started chanting mantras.

And then he looked at the mahout and proclaimed, "You are in grave danger. There will be a threat to your life tomorrow!"

The mahout trembled from limb to limb at this proclamation and asked, "What danger? What threat? How can I protect myself if I don't anything about the danger?"

"Your elephant will become mad suddenly and throw you away. The people will turn against you thinking that you were the reason for the madness, and will kill you right there!"

"Ayyo, what do I do now? How can I escape this?"

"Tomorrow, don't go near the elephant."

"How is that possible? I will be punished for neglecting my duties," wailed the poor mahout.

"Then, come to my house. I will give you a talisman. Wear that and do not carry the 'elephant goad' tomorrow!"

"Alright, I will do as you say, will the prince be in any danger tomorrow?"

"How can I tell that to you? If the prince comes and asks me, I will tell him!"

After this, Murugayyan had run away from there to the palace to warn the prince about the elephant's madness.

After narrating all this, the devoted boatman started crying in the earnest. The prince tried to console him saying, “Why are you crying? You have already warned me about the danger and that gives me time to take appropriate precautions!”

“Ayya, my wife’s involvement in all these matters is distressing me beyond words. All my doubts regarding her character have come back, and I truly don’t know what to think now!”

“I will speak to her and set her right, don’t worry. Now, you need to find this mahout for me and bring him here...”

After Murugayyan left, the prince thought deeply about what he had just heard. He wondered if this could be another assassination attempt by the Pandya rebels. He decided what he would do the next day and retired for the night.

The next morning, the prince was up early, and he came down to the courtyard. The elephant that was tied there greeted him affectionately by lifting its trunk and caressing him with love.

Will this elephant go mad today? But there are no signs of madness.

Stroking the elephant lovingly, the prince asked the palace servants, “Where is the mahout?”

Immediately, many voices carried the same question. Many people had already gathered in the courtyard wanting to accompany the prince again. The throng of the crowd was increasing by the minute, and Murugayyan was trying to come through it unsuccessfully. Noticing him, the prince signalled him to come closer. The crowd parted automatically to let him through.

Murugayyan informed him that he had spent the night combing the streets for the mahout but couldn’t find him. Instead, he found his wife, who refuted everything and blamed him for doubting her.

“Don’t worry about it, Murugayya. Remove the elephant’s chains from its legs.”

Even as he was removing the chains, there rose a shout from among the crowd, “Here is the mahout!” “Here he is...”

The mahout was running towards them with his elephant goad in hand. The crowd parted for him, allowing him to come to the courtyard.

Ponniyin Selvar sighed in relief and looked at him. The previous night’s adventures had indeed taken a toll on him. He looked visibly frightened of the beast that he was supposed to control. He came near the elephant and touched its trunk. The beast immediately wound its trunk around and lifted him high to the sky and threw him like a ragged doll.

Immediately a shout arose among the crowd. “The elephant has gone mad,” and the people started running madly in all directions.

Chapter 18: The Fooled Mahout

They say that 'opportunity is yet another name for God'. In other words, when God wants us to achieve something, he sends us opportunities and if we utilize them well, will help us achieve our goals. In history, when we read about great heroes, statesmen, kings, emperors, and warriors, we see that they have used many such opportunities well and achieved greatness.

Some believe that God showers them with great opportunities because they were born under the shadow of fortunate stars, while others believe that good horoscopes and good fates provide them with these opportunities.

To quote an example, if Mahatma Gandhi had not gone to South Africa, would he have become the 'father of our nation'? Great men like Chandra Gupta, Vikramaditya, Julius Caesar, Napoleon, the Duke of Wellington, Joseph Stalin and so on got many opportunities in their lives which they utilized well to achieve greatness.

That said, one cannot conclude that God doesn't present others with equal opportunities. He does, but ultimately, it's on us to utilize them well. Many who do not grab these moments find that these opportunities slip through their hand. Crores of people who get opportunities to achieve greatness fail to recognize it and then live to regret it all through their ordinary lives. Very few people have the rare ability to spot these opportunities and utilize them well, and it is they who achieve greatness and etch their names in history.

This could be why even people born at the same time at the exact same second have very different lives.

The prince was staring at one such opportunity. When the elephant suddenly threw the mahout away, a shout arose, "The elephant has gone mad, run for your lives."

The prince realized that this was an opportunity that he could not waste. If he had not utilized it, this story would have taken a very different turn.

The prince noticed that the mahout who had approached was an imposter who had neared the elephant with evil intentions. The noble beast had recognized it instinctively and had thrown him away.

If he were to stop and find out who that false mahout was and what his intentions were, he would lose this opportunity. This was his chance to escape these people and reach Thanjavur immediately.

He immediately turned to Murugayyan, whispered something in his ears, and climbed on his back to mount the elephant. Hoisting himself on the elephant skilfully, he then loosened the decorated seat that was made ready for him on its back. It fell with a crash. Simultaneously he whispered something to the elephant, and the beast immediately raised its trunk menacingly and let out a roaring trumpet and started running.

Right on cue, Murugayyan cried out, “Ayyo, the elephant has gone mad. Run, everyone! Run...”

Total panic ensued in the next few moments when people dispersed quickly and ran through lanes to escape the mad beast. Some tried to get into their houses and closed the doors behind them. Everyone knew that there is no way to control a mad elephant and even the bravest of soldiers couldn't hope to hold their own against the beast.

The prince made the elephant run until they had left Thiruvarur far behind. Instead of going towards the king's road that led to Thanjavur, he turned the elephant in the northwest direction. He wanted to stop at Pazhaiarai and meet his sister before he resumed his journey to Thanjavur. By breaking his journey thus, he wanted to ensure that he was not followed by the people from Thiruvarur. The advantage of travelling by an elephant is that he could pave his own

way towards his destination and not depend on a road which might be besieged by people who might resolutely follow him.

Thinking thus, he set the elephant on narrow forest paths in the general direction of where Pazhaiarai lay. The elephant went on its merry way, paving a path of its own, crossing flooded lakes, rivers, and woods. The prince heaved a sigh of relief and felt as though he was free after a long stint in prison. His enthusiasm and hope soared as he made good progress on his journey. He felt that he had just crossed an important milestone in his life.

At Thiruvavarur, after the elephant ran amok, Murugayyan played his part well and raised the panic that finally dispersed the crowd. He ran out of the palace shouting and asking people to run away. He started running in the general direction where the elephant had thrown the false mahout. At a short distance from the palace was the famous Kamalalayam temple tank^[5] in Thiruvavarur. He went to the tank and looked around. Many people had sought shelter beside the tank from the menacing elephant. Some had even sought refuge inside the water. He found one man swimming towards the steps. It was the same man who had acted as the sorcerer to scare the real mahout the previous evening. The same man who had come to the palace with the elephant goad, posing as the mahout.

What happened to his elephant goad? Did it fall into the tank?

“Royal mahout! Thank God you survived. Where is your elephant goad?”

Revadasan looked at Murugayyan and said, “What are you talking about? I was just having a bath in the tank?”

“Is that so? Are you not the royal mahout? Then where is the mahout?”

“How will I know? Why are you asking me all this?”

“Listen to me, why are you trying to trick me? I saw you last night with the real mahout and my wife Rakkammal. You are the sorcerer who took him to the cemetery and told him that the elephant will become mad today. And how come you forgot your own warning and came there with the elephant goad? But never mind, where is my wife Rakkammal? And the real mahout?”

Revadasan was shocked by Murugayyan’s accusations, and he slightly panicked and said, “Are you mad? I don’t know any Rakkammal or mahout.” He then looked around for means to escape the enraged boatman.

“Yes indeed. I am mad. Just as mad as the elephant. Tell me where the mahout is or else...”

Revadasan smiled at him and said, “You think I am a sorcerer. But in truth, you are the one who knows everything, and it seems impossible to hide anything from you. I came to the palace to warn the prince about the elephant, but instead, the beast turned on me. Your wife and the real mahout are in a house, and I can take you there if you want. What happened to the prince? Is he safe?”

“He is safe. He sent me to bring you and the mahout to him!”

“I saved the prince. I deserve a good reward from him. You must put in a word... aha what’s that?” He exclaimed.

Buried within a shrub they saw the mahout’s elephant goad. Revadasan started running towards it, but Murugayyan was faster. He got there first and carefully lifted the goad out of the shrub. But when he turned Revadasan was gone!

Murugayyan searched for him unsuccessfully, but he had vanished among the crowds of people at the tank. Next, he decided to go and check the house where he had seen Revadasan the previous evening. Walking through the streets, he saw people standing in groups and talking about the elephant’s madness.

“There was someone on the back of the elephant,” someone said, while others countered him saying, “how could that be? Didn’t the elephant throw the mahout far away? After that, it started running. Who could have got on its back? How is that possible?”

Talking thus, many were moving towards the palace to check if their prince was safe. Murugayyan went in the opposite direction and reached the street where he had seen Revadasan joining Rakkammal and the mahout the previous evening. That house alone was locked, and he could hear a faint moaning sound coming from inside. There was a dilapidated house next to it. He got on the walls of the house and then jumped inside the courtyard of the other house that he wanted to search. There, he found the poor mahout with his hands and legs bound to a pillar. He was trying to gnaw the ropes that bound him, and in between, he was also shouting for help.

The mahout recognized Murugayyan immediately. He had seen him since their journey began in Nagapattinam and knew that the boatman was close to the prince.

“Murugayya! Release me, please. Those scoundrels, they said they will give a talisman and then bound me here. Is the prince safe?”

Murugayyan released him and then told him whatever transpired earlier that morning. The mahout then began his tale. Rakkammal and Revadasan had brought him to the house, promising to give him a talisman to keep him safe from danger. He said that the sorcerer was chanting mantras using a special sambrani^[6] which made him sleepy. When he woke up, he found himself tied to the pillar.

They both left the house and headed toward the palace. The crowd was bigger than ever at the palace. Their prince was missing, and the people were getting worried. No one knew what had happened to him. In the panic that ensued after the elephant turned mad, most of them tried to save their skin rather than stick around and watch what happened. Though, some people insisted that they thought they saw someone on the back of the elephant. Soon, many

said the same thing and they concluded that the prince must have gotten on the elephant. They knew that the prince was skilled with elephant training and that he knew the language of elephants and concluded that he must have taken it out to tame it.

Just then, Murugayyan and the royal mahout reached there and narrated their story. Now they had something new to discuss. The false mahout who had come in with the elephant goad must be an assassin. And who else must have sent him but the Pazhuvur brothers? Angered by their assumptions, some people resolved to go to Thanjavur as they had originally planned, while some planned to follow the elephant's path and pursue the prince.

Chapter 19: Thirunallam

Floating on the thatched roof of the astrologer's hut, Vanathi held on to the roof for her life as the flood waters took her through a tumultuous route. The flood waters were heading her towards the west. Her progress was alternatively slow or rapid depending on the water currents. In places where the water currents were strong, the roof would swivel her around rapidly.

Sometimes she would be taken through waterways that didn't seem too deep. Vanathi would then turn around and see the water level by checking out a mandapam on the riverbank. But before she could decide whether to get down from the roof, the water would bear her away fast towards another destination.

To tell the truth, Vanathi was not keen on getting down from the floating roof. She intuitively felt that the Ponni River was taking her to meet the prince. Pazhuvetarayar's warning about the prince was uppermost on her mind and she genuinely believed that she was being borne away by the flood waters just so that she could warn him.

Aha! That boat girl is so headstrong, vain, and controlling. She talks as though she has more say in the affairs of the prince. But then, she did rescue the prince and he is alive because of her.

No! Never! She heard the astrologer talk about the prince. The time of his birth and the position of his stars has ensured that he faces these dangers but there won't be any danger to his life. The sea and the flood waters can't drown the prince who was born to rule this world. Fates ensured that he escaped these dangers and sent someone like Poonguzhali to save him. That doesn't mean that his life is forfeit to her.

If only I got a chance to save the prince...

Sometimes, when the roof got stuck in the water current and swirled around, Vanathi saw a boat at a distance rowed by a man and a woman. She suspected that the woman might be Poonguzhali, coming to rescue her on the boat.

Enough! Wasn't it enough that the prince owed his life to her? I don't want to be in the same position. I don't want to be rescued by that girl.

As she floated, it would seem as though the boat might catch up with her after all, but the flood waters relentlessly bore her away, intent on reaching the sea. The flood was moving towards the southern banks of River Kaveri.

Vanathi finally recognized where she was heading. The flood waters were going towards Arisalaru. She looked around and remembered the place, having visited it many times with Princess Kundavai. She was now nearing Thirunallam. The dowager queen Sembiyanmadevi wanted to renovate the Shiva temple here in memory of her Lord husband. She also remembered the Chola palace that stood at the banks of the river. She had visited the place along with Princess Kundavai and the Queen. There was a beautiful garden that adjoined the palace, and her favourite pastime was to sit there, listening to the melodies sung by the birds and the bees. She also remembered an incident that happened there... etched in her memory forever.

Chapter 20: The Little Birds

In the early days of Vanathi's arrival at Pazhaiarai, she was often spellbound by the natural beauty and the bountiful greenery that she saw there. They were sights that she rarely saw in her kingdom. There were no rivers in Kodumbalur, only lakes and ponds which would fill up during the monsoon and become dry during the scorching summer. It was in Pazhaiarai that she saw flowing rivers with strong water currents. She took great pleasure in watching lotus flowers blooming near the riverbeds and getting caught in the river currents and being sucked into the waters to their unfathomable depths.

Once, Vanathi went along with Princess Kundavai to the Chola Palace at Thirunallam (these days Thirunallam is known as Konerirajapuram^[7] on invitation from the dowager queen Sembiyanmadevi. While Princess Kundavai and the Queen would indulge in deep discussions about the inner meanings of hymns, slokas, and poems written about Lord Shiva, Vanathi would often find herself in the beautiful garden grounds of the palace. She preferred to wander in the gardens or sit under a tree to watch the beautiful lotus flowers blooming and the bees humming around them. She also loved to walk along the banks of river Kaveri that flowed alongside the palace and watch the beautiful Kadamba^[8] flowers getting caught in the currents and being dragged through the rivers. *Truly, where else could she see such sights?!*

Once, while at the palace, Kundavai and Sembiyanmadevi were immersed in deep discussion, and the Princess told Vanathi, "My dear, why don't you go to the garden? I will come there in a short while!"

Vanathi, who didn't need an excuse to go to the garden, literally skipped her way to the place. After roaming around for a while, she came upon the lotus pond. There were many Mahua trees in that

location. She sat under one of the trees, enjoying the sweet-smelling flowers that were falling from it. She realized that she had never been so happy or content ever in her life before.

From where she sat, she could see the riverbed and waters flowing through the trees that dotted the bank. She could also see a young man swimming through the river and floating on his back with a languid grace. Vanathi stared at him with fascination and noted how his fair complexion and powerful frame seemed to add beauty to the panorama of the view. After staring at him for a few seconds she reprimanded herself...

Chi! How can I blatantly stare at a man like this?

Yet, her eyes didn't heed her mind and her gaze went again towards the young man. Bashful by nature, Vanathi couldn't help herself as she looked again at him. After some time, she got angry with herself and her lack of self-control and thought of leaving the place. And that's when something else happened there that drew her attention away from the young man.

The tree under which she was sitting had a bird's nest. And the small birds within it were screeching with panic. Vanathi looked up to see why they were panicking and noticed a large cat inching its way through the branches towards the nest. With every step of the cat, the little birds were getting more agitated and screeching with terror.

Moved by the plight of the little birds, Vanathi shouted "Ayyo! Ayyo!"

Within a few moments, someone came running from the riverbed. It was the young man who ran demanding, "What happened?"

At the same time, the parents of the little birds flew in from somewhere and were trying to save their children. They flew around the little nest and tried to peck the cat away. While the mother tried to shield its children, the father woodpecker tried to fight the feline monster that was trying to eat the little ones. The cat was

unperturbed by their efforts and kept moving towards the nest. The valiant fight put up by the birds' parents moved Vanathi's heart and reminded her of her parents whom she had lost in her childhood.

The cat, meanwhile, had neared the nest and had put a paw inside it, resulting in more cacophony from the birds. And Vanathi too inadvertently shouted. By now, the young man had neared her and Vanathi felt too shy to answer his question. Instead, she pointed towards the tree.

Until then, the young man, who had probably thought that Vanathi was in some sort of danger, looked at where she was pointing and smiled at her. His handsome mien and endearing smile almost made her forget the plight of the birds. But the young man didn't tarry around. He went under the tree and tried to shoo the cat away. The cat was impervious to his threats and intimidation. It looked down and growled at the young man instead.

"This seems like a monstrous cat indeed," he said and took a pebble from the ground and threw it at the cat. The pebble didn't strike the cat but managed to scare it away. It jumped onto another branch of the same tree and then jumped down and ran away.

By then, there was a new threat to the little birds. Thanks to the cat, the nest was slipping out of the branch on which it had been built and was almost hanging from the tree. The woodpecker's parents were hovering around it, trying to rescue the little birds from falling. Even with a gentle breeze, the nest might fall, and with it, the little 'just hatched' birds would die when they hit the ground from that distance.

The young man saw all this and decided what to do within a moment. He initially thought of climbing the tree but decided against it. Next, he looked at Vanathi and said, "Girl, come and stand under the tree. If the nest falls, hold the end of your saree and catch the little birds. I will be back shortly," and ran from there.

Just as he promised, he was back within a short time. But this time, he was sitting on an elephant's back. Vanathi understood what he was planning to do, so she moved from there and sat down near the lotus pond and watched the spectacle. The young man brought the elephant near the tree and then gently took the hanging nest from the tree with the little birds securely sitting within. The woodpeckers raised a huge ruckus and followed him as he goaded the elephant towards another branch of the tree, where he placed the nest in a secure position. Elated by the turn of events, the woodpeckers cooed with great enthusiasm.

The young man searched for Vanathi and shouted, "Girl, where did you go?"

Shy and self-conscious, Vanathi didn't answer his call and sat demurely by the pond. Then the young man came down from the elephant and searched around. Vanathi thought about something and laughed out aloud. Hearing her laugh, the young man came near the pond and said, "Why are you laughing? What happened here that you are laughing so much?"

Bashful about talking to a stranger, Vanathi looked down, unable to see his face or meet his eyes. The young man persisted, "Girl, why did you laugh? Won't you tell me?"

She smiled and answered, "Nothing. I was just wondering how brave you were. You brought an elephant to fight with a cat!"

Hearing this, the young man too laughed out aloud and said, "Was it really a cat? By the way, you were screaming, I thought it was a tiger!"

Feeling less bashful now, Vanathi said, "Is that so? Why would I be scared of a tiger? Aren't we under the protection of the tiger flag in this Chola Kingdom? Are you from the Pandya Kingdom?"

Her reply elicited a smile from the young man, and he said, "Girl, I was born in this Chola Kingdom, and have gone to wars from my

land. Who are you? Where are you from? You seem like someone who talks a lot!”

“Speak respectfully, mahout! What do you care who I am? Why do you ask?”

“Alright! I will not ask. Looks like you are a high-born maiden. I will take my leave now,” he said and turned to leave.

Vanathi, who had lost her shyness by now asked him, “Listen! Will you take me on your elephant?”

“Alright, I will take you on the elephant for a price. What will you give me in return?”

“Price? I can get you a post in my palace in Kodumbalur or speak to my uncle and make you the head of our elephant-mounted troops!”

“Oh! So, you are a Kodumbalur Princess,” said the young man. His face now wore a scowl and his smile vanished.

“Why? Is something wrong with being a Kodumbalur Princess? Can’t I get on your elephant?”

“Nothing of that sort. There are many elephants and a huge number of mahouts in the Kodumbalur army. They don’t need me,” saying thus, the young man walked away as though he was in a hurry to get away from her. Vanathi watched him leave, hoping that he might turn back, but he didn’t.

Vanathi could never forget this incident. She would always wonder what had happened to that young man after that. The way he brought the elephant to help save the little birds often elicited laughter. She would smile to herself and daydream about him. She also felt a little angry with him for the way he ended their conversation upon learning that she was Kodumbalur princess.

Everyone knew that Prince Arulmozhivarman was expected to arrive at Thiruvallam to meet his dear sister. Just like the other women in the palace, even Vanathi was eager to meet the prince who had captured the hearts of the Chola people. Though the prince had come to the palace to meet his sister, he didn't come to the anthappuram. And unlike other women in the palace, Vanathi did not create an opportunity and meet the prince. It was on the last day of his visit that she happened to see the prince from the upper-level balcony of the palace. He was on his elephant starting his journey and Vanathi could hardly believe her eyes.

The young man who she had mistaken to be a mahout and had teased turned out to be the prince of the realm!

Vanathi asked people around her numerous times to confirm whether the 'mahout' was indeed the prince. And when she learned the truth, there was no end to the shame she felt.

She spent many hours regretting the words that she had spoken to him. She remembered how she had offered a mahout's post to the prince who was born to rule this world! Though she felt like laughing at the irony, she also felt like crying at her foolish behaviour. She believed that the prince had been offended by her upstart behaviour and the way she thought he was a mahout. He probably thought that she was a girl bereft of any womanly qualities of modesty. Shamed and mortified by her behaviour, Vanathi thought of ending her life many times by throwing herself into a well or a lake. She tried unsuccessfully to confess this to Princess Kundavai but could never summon the nerve to do it. Kundavai might have asked her about this if the prince had told her about the incident. But since Kundavai didn't ask her, she could only surmise that the prince had spared her the shame and was grateful to him. She swore to herself that she would one day seek forgiveness from the prince for her behaviour that day.

After they went back to Pazhaiarai, whenever there was an opportunity for her to meet the prince, she avoided it. The palace

womenfolk and Princess Kundavai, who didn't know anything about the Thirunallam incident, thought that she was extremely shy.

Vanathi also knew that there were many other reasons why the prince might be angry and disgusted with her. Many truly believed that the prince would one day become an emperor and rule the kingdom and this belief led her uncle to send her to Pazhaiarai so that she could be married to him. She had heard this indirectly from Kundavai and also from her uncle as well. Kundavai and her companions teased her incessantly about this and told her, "That's why you don't want to meet him." When they teased her so, Vanathi was disgusted with herself, and she could not help but remember the way the prince had scowled his face when he learned who she was.

Right after this, when the prince was to return to Elangai, Kundavai had organized a special pooja at the palace and all the womenfolk were to perform an aarti to send off the prince. Vanathi couldn't refuse to participate in this, and she was also eager to see the prince before he left. She hoped that she might convey her regrets and apologies through her eyes to the prince. But when the time came, her body shook, and limbs trembled, and she fainted in front of him. And we know what happened after that.

Even as she floated on the thatched roof, these memories from Thirunallam came back to her mind. She knew that the prince had sympathy and affection for her, but there was also something that blocked him from expressing it to her. She knew why he couldn't do that. Many knew that his sister and her uncle had planned to get her married to him. Even the boat girl knew about it. That's why the prince felt that she would be foisted on him one day and he would have to marry her out of obligation. It was this thought that blocked any affection that he might feel for her and had blighted her life.

But if the prince were to learn about the vow that she made, wouldn't it change his attitude towards her?

But how would he know of it? Maybe I can tell him about it myself. But I go speechless in his presence! I will have to somehow

gather some courage and tell him about it. If you were to ascend the throne, I will not sit beside you. I have made a sacred vow. I will not ascend the throne with you. But if you could come to me as a mere mahout and take me on the elephant, I will consider it as my good fortune and not want anything else in my life.

That's a good decision, but will I ever get to meet him again? Where will these flood waters dump me? Will I die before I meet him again? No, I will survive. There! I can see the riverbed. There is the Chola palace where the prince came to me on the elephant to save those little birds. It looks like all that happened just yesterday.

What am I seeing? There is an elephant and a mahout on top of it. The elephant is moving with ease, not bothered about the flood or the water currents! The elephant was headed towards the west and was walking along the riverbed. Vanathi looked at the mahout carefully and had to chide herself for imagining that it could be the prince.

I once mistakenly assumed the prince to be a mahout but that doesn't mean that all mahouts would turn out to be princes. Even then, if it is an ordinary mahout, I might seek his help to get off this roof. The elephant can help me reach the river bank and if I were to tell him who I am, he might take me to the prince.

Thinking thus, she called out "Mahout! Mahout!"

But he didn't hear her or didn't bother to turn around. The elephant was walking very fast and soon it turned a bend and was out of their sight.

Before Vanathi could be disappointed about this missed opportunity to seek help from the mahout, something dangerous was happening to the thatched roof. It was spinning wildly and swirling her around madly. The water current was very strong at that place and was taking the roof towards the trees on the river bank. The gnarled roots of the trees spread under the river and she realized that once the roof hit the roots, it will break into pieces and she

would be borne away by the water, or she might die struck by the roots. She soon saw another possible way to die. Between the tree roots was a crocodile with its mouth wide open.

Is it a real crocodile or a stuffed one? Or am I imagining this?

The roof was now nearing the tree and Vanathi resigned herself to her fate closed her eyes and murmured a prayer, "Mother Durga, I have no one else but you. Give me refuge at your feet!"

Chapter 21: When Life Hung by a Thread

There are some moments in our life that seem to last a lifetime. One such moment happened to Vanathi right then. She closed her eyes tightly and got ready to give up her life at the feet of Mother Durga. But then she felt a huge jolt and opened her eyes. The thatched roof on which she lay had rammed with a tree's root and disintegrated. Vanathi had gotten stuck in between two roots and escaped from the river current that was fast consuming the remnants of the roof. With her body stuck between the roots, the currents were powerfully dragging her feet and her saree.

Vanathi somehow mustered enough strength and held onto the roots to escape the water current that was trying to drown her in its vortex. She raised herself with difficulty from the water and held onto the branches that were hanging low and then slowly climbed onto one of them. Right after she climbed the tree, a splashing sound was heard, and Vanathi looked down to see that the crocodile she had earlier seen had come searching for her. Vanathi made herself comfortable on the sturdy tree branch and then occupied herself by squeezing water out of her saree.

The crocodile settled under the tree on which Vanathi was perched, waiting for its prey to climb down. Vanathi was cheerful about the way she had escaped without panicking or fainting. She spoke to the only creature that was near her.

"Listen to me, crocodile! Don't wait for me to get down. That's not going to happen. Go and look for some other prey!"

Hearing her speak, the crocodile slashed its tail, bared its teeth and stared at her with unblinking eyes.

"Oh! So, you will not leave me?! Is that so?"

Vanathi looked around her. Her situation was precarious, to say the least. The tree that she had climbed had low-hanging branches on the river side, but none on the other side of the land. Even if she were to jump and land, the crocodile was waiting for her near the tree while the river currents were strong enough to drown her on the other side.

The long exposure to water and wind made her tremble, and she sat down on the branch because her limbs became numb with cold.

‘Chi! What’s wrong with my legs? Why are they trembling so?’ Then she looked at the crocodile and wondered, *‘who is more patient? Me or the crocodile?’*

Just then, she heard the trumpeting of an elephant. It must be the same elephant that had crossed the river earlier. It seemed to be coming her way. At the same time, she could see the boat that had been following her for so long. Yes, it was the astrologer’s disciple and Poonguzhali.

Finally, it will be that headstrong boat girl who will rescue me!

Poonguzhali had already spotted Vanathi and said, “Princess, that’s a nice spot to hide. Come down quickly. Do you know who is coming here in that elephant?”

Vanathi suddenly realized that her intuition was correct after all. But she didn’t say it aloud. Instead, she said, “No I don’t know!”

“It’s the prince. The one who you came in search of...”

Unable to remain stationary in the water due to the floods started, the boat started moving away from the tree. But Poonguzhali was unwilling to move away, so she jumped into the water and swam towards the tree.

Vanathi watched her in horror and then realized that Poonguzhali had not seen the crocodile that had stationed itself under the tree.

Spouting gibberish in her panic, Vanathi shouted, “Crocodile!!”

Poonguzhali saw the large beast with its jaw wide open. There was no way to escape it. Poonguzhali was a very brave girl who could handle herself well in the face of danger. But nerve and courage can fall short when faced with a ferocious crocodile in such close quarters. The only option left for the boat girl was to get back to the boat, but the astrologer’s disciple had taken it away due to the current and he didn’t yet know her precarious position.

On one side, Poonguzhali was caught in the current that was quickly dragging her down. And on the other, the crocodile had started moving toward her. To make matters worse, one end of her saree was stuck in the roots.

Vanathi, who saw all this from the top of the tree, forgot the bitterness and the poisoned words of the boat girl that had prompted her to take a sacred vow of not ascending the throne. At that moment, she could only focus on helping the girl who had saved the prince’s life.

The prince is coming here now, and if something were to happen to Poonguzhali what will he think about me? Didn’t she come all the way here just to save me?

In an instant, Vanathi decided what to do. She climbed down to a lower branch, lay on it, and grabbed Poonguzhali’s hair. Poonguzhali immediately understood what Vanathi wanted to do and raised her arms. Vanathi bent down to grab Poonguzhali onto the branch. Now they both were perched on the same branch, which was unable to hold their weight. Vanathi moved to the higher branch, holding Poonguzhali tightly.

The crocodile – which had yet again been robbed of its prey – came out of the water and waited below the tree with its maw wide open. That’s when the branch on which Poonguzhali was standing started to break, leaving her hanging. Only Vanathi, who was holding

her hands from the branch above, was saving her from imminent death.

Vanathi's soft hands held on to Poonguzhali's arms tightly. Anguished by the thought that the boat girl will slip out of her hands and fall into the waiting mouth of the crocodile made her hold Poonguzhali tightly.

If I fail to save her and she falls, I too will fall along with her and become the crocodile's prey.

She could see the elephant nearing her and prayed to the gods to give her enough strength to hold Poonguzhali safely. The elephant was nearing them with a blaring trumpeting sound and it seemed to have scared the crocodile back into the water.

Vanathi saw the elephant and the man who was riding it. She murmured, "Mahout, why don't you save these helpless women just as you save those little birds!"

No, I can't hold this girl anymore. My arms are going to fall, tire and we are going to tumble down. My God, this girl's name is Poonguzhali but she weighs so much! It feels as though I am holding someone made of iron!

"Mahout! Mahout! Why won't you come fast?" she muttered with her eyes tightly closed.

Just then Poonguzhali screamed, which made Vanathi hold her more tightly as she thought that the crocodile had got her.

"Vanathi, leave her hand..." cried the prince, and Vanathi let go of the burden that she had been holding. She finally opened her eyes and saw the elephant holding Poonguzhali by its trunks and placing her away from the tree.

Relieved and happy, Vanathi was surprised about her own mental strength in the face of danger and sorely missed Princess

Kundavai's presence. She had never thought that she would be able to handle any dangerous situation with such courage and was surprised by her fortitude.

Next, she wondered if the prince would leave her on the tree and turn away with Poonguzhali. If he did that, it would be the right punishment for her.

No, no, the elephant was coming towards her with its trunk outstretched. She closed her eyes once more and soon, she was in the air and the elephant placed her gently on the ground next to Poonguzhali.

Instinctively, she turned toward the boat girl and embraced her with relief. Poonguzhali's eyes filled with tears and said, "Princess, I came all this way to save you from the river floods and ended up getting saved by you instead. I owe my life to you."

"Poonguzhali, I didn't save you. It's the mahout who saved both of us. We should be thanking him,"

"I am not too attached to this life of mine, but I didn't want to die before I could give my aunt's message to the prince," said Poonguzhali

Vanathi looked at the prince and mischievously asked, "Mahout, will take us on your elephant?" And then she started laughing.

Chapter 22: Happiness and Despair

On hearing Vanathi's question, the prince smiled and got down from the elephant.

"Aha! Riding an elephant is very tough. Getting on its back is hard, but getting down is even harder. But we have no choice but to endure these hardships sometimes..."

"Some people will endure such hardship for many trivial things, like saving a bird's nest!"

"Do you still remember that incident Vanathi? I thought you had forgotten about it since you never brought it up before!"

"Those who go around the world performing many brave feats of glory may not remember such incidents... but what choice do women in the palace have? They have nothing to do but remember these incidents ceaselessly. I do remember you coming to the birds' rescue, and then, when you learned that I was from Kodumbalur, I remember you scowling and leaving as fast as you can!"

"There was a reason for that, Vanathi!"

"The same reason applies even now. You are the emperor's son who will one day rule the world. I am the orphaned daughter of a dead chieftain..."

"Vanathi, you are not being fair with me. Nonetheless, now is not the time to discuss it. Tell me how you ended up here, and that too alone. Poonguzhali told me that you came floating on a thatched roof. How did that happen? And how come Poonguzhali is here?"

"Thanks for remembering that I am here, too. If I can speak to you for a few moments, I will leave this place immediately!"

We don't know how both the women had gained so much confidence to speak to the prince so boldly.

"Samudra Kumari, you are saying that I forgot about you. How could that be? I was calling you, and yet you didn't turn around. And you came to the tree and got stuck with the crocodile and finally I find you hanging from the tree... I will never forget the sight of Vanathi desperately holding you, unable to bear your weight! But how did both of you end up here? Tell me quickly!"

"Prince! Your sister and I started this morning from Thanjavur to try and stop you from coming there. Your sister fears that if you were to come there, a civil war will ensue between the warring chieftains."

"Where is my sister now?"

"She is at Kudanthai..."

"How did you come here then?"

"On our way, we halted our journey at the Kudanthai Jodhidhar's house. That's when the Kaveri riverbank broke and the Kudanthai town got flooded. The floods carried away the astrologer's house. Prince, I know that you consider River Kaveri as your mother, but the destruction and havoc that the river has caused are catastrophic for many!"

"Vanathi! Don't blame Mother Kaveri thus. The love that she has for the Chola Kingdom has no limits that's why she sometimes breaks her barriers and engulfs us. Many might even blame the Sea God for this catastrophe, but you will not hear a word from Samudra Kumari about it..."

"Forgive me! I will not blame Mother Kaveri again. When we were at the astrologer's house, the river flooded the town and carried away the astrologer's house with it. Everyone got onto the roof of the temple, but I failed to do so because of my stupidity and fell into the

water. I got onto the thatched roof of the astrologer's house and came floating here..."

"Very interesting. So Poonguzhali came after you to rescue you, and finally, my elephant had to rescue both of you. You have no idea how intelligent this beast is. It picked both of you like flowers and placed you gently on the ground... Do you know what it did this morning? When the mahout came late today, it picked that man and threw him far... I doubt if he survived the fall."

"Oh, God! What are you saying? I wanted to ask you about it myself."

"What did you want to ask?"

"I wanted to ask if you had any danger from the mahout and his elephant goad!"

"Yes, there was danger, but it was averted by the elephant. But how did you know about it? Did the astrologer predict this? Does my sister still believe all this nonsense?"

"The astrologer didn't predict this. Even if he did, we wouldn't believe it. It was Periya Pazhuvetarayar who told us about this."

"What? When did he say that?"

"Yes, Prince! When we were in the astrologer's house, Periya Pazhuvetarayar came there suddenly and told us about the dangers that you will face. He spoke about dangers from mahout and his poisoned elephant goad."

"Aha! This is most shocking. How did he know about it? Has he become an astrologer too? Or could it be true... what everyone is suspecting. Did he plan for me to be assassinated?"

"No, Prince. He didn't plan this. He heard the Pandya conspirators talking about this plan and warned Princess Kundavai

about it!”

“Aha! Did he say anything else?”

“Yes, and it is dreadful to even think about it. He said that the Pandya Conspirators were planning to kill you, the emperor, and the crown prince on the same day. He said he will go to Kadambur to save the crown prince and warned Princess Kundavai to save you and the emperor.”

“If his warning has come true in my case, then it must hold truth for others. Samudra Kumari, you wanted to say something...”

“Yes, Prince. My aunt, Mandakini Devi, has tasked me to bring you to Thanjavur immediately!”

“Aha, I wanted to ask you about it. I undertook this journey for her sake. I heard that someone had kidnapped her near Thanjavur, is that true?”

“Yes, but the Prime Minister’s intentions were not malicious!”

“Aha, so this was Anirudhar’s work. He must have done this to take your aunt to my father. Did he succeed in his mission, Samudra Kumari? Did your aunt and my father meet?”

“Yes, they met.”

“My dream has been fulfilled. You couldn’t have given me happier news than this. So long as your aunt is next to my father, nothing can happen to him. You know the special powers of intuition that she has...”

“Yes, I know that. And until she stays close to him, he will not be in any danger but...”

“But what?”

“I don’t know how to tell you this. My aunt feels that her death is nearing and wants to see you once before she breathes her last!”

“My God! What are you saying? First, you give me the happiest of all news and then throw me in despair with such words. I will not tarry anymore. Vanathi, convey my apologies to Princess Kundavai, I need to leave immediately!”

Chapter 23: Battle Forces Arrive

It was a momentous day for the people of Thanjavur. They even forgot the damages they had suffered from the storm because their beloved prince had not just survived the seas but was also on his way to Thanjavur. Rumours of his survival and his appearance in Nagapattinam started making the rounds. Their elation knew no bounds when they learned that the people of Nagapattinam were bringing him to Thanjavur in an elaborate victory procession, intending to crown him the next emperor.

At first, many thought that it was just a rumour. But soon, many people who had seen the prince in Nagapattinam had come to Thanjavur and were swearing the truthfulness of the information.

After the news was confirmed, a storm of activity happened in the city. The people started decorating the city to make it fit for a welcome reception of the prince. Musicians, dancers, and entertainers started gathering in all the streets. Women and young girls started decorating their hair and competed to look their best when the prince arrived. A few others stationed themselves on all the four main roads that led to the city in anticipation of watching the prince's arrival despite the ridicule of many.

While the city outside the fort was readying itself for the prince's arrival, there was a flurry of activity happening inside the fort as well. In the morning, the fort gates opened to allow the people and tradesmen to enter and sell their wares as usual. The number of petitioners who had come to petition for damages that they had endured due to the storm was also less that day. The Velkarar army too entered the fort as was their usual routine.

Suddenly the fort gates were closed. Not just closed, but latched with thick large bars to prevent forceful entry. They were never closed in the mid-afternoon ever. It was unprecedented. Those who approached the fort gates with questions were driven away. The

soldiers also removed the bridges that were laid on the moats of the fort, making it impossible for anybody to approach the fort. When the people learned that all the gates and bridges that led to the fort have been shut and removed, they were shocked.

What's happening? Why are the fort gates closed? Is there an enemy invasion? But there are no enemies for the Chola Kingdom in any direction. Who would dare to approach the capital city and that too when all the rivers of Kaveri are in spate?

Some feared that the fort was closed to bar entry to Ponniyin Selvar and many felt that this could be true. As this rumour spread like wildfire the anger and resentment against the Pazhuvur brothers rose among the people.

Who are these Pazhuvetarayars to bar entry to a prince born in the lineage of Vijayala Chola? If they dare to do this, we will raze the walls of this fort...

Such were the murmurs from the enraged people of Thanjavur.

The city became rife with rumours and gossip. No one really knows how a rumour spreads and how it assumes a life of its own. Suddenly, people heard that Emperor Sundara Chola was dead. Some quoted the disappearance of the comet as proof that this rumour was true.

If this is true, then what are they going to do next? Will there be a fight for the throne of the Cholas? Will the Cholas separate into two different factions? Will this fratricidal fight destroy this kingdom? Will the enemies of Cholas rise again?

While the people of Thanjavur spoke amongst themselves thus, there rose a shout 'the forces are coming' leading people to climb tall trees and buildings to check out the truth for themselves. What they saw shocked and surprised them a lot.

Three royal roads led from Thanjavur in the western and south-western directions. One road led from Kodumbalur to Rameswaram and the other went through Madurai into the Pandya Kingdom. The other led from Uraiyur to Karur and went all the way to the Chera Kingdom.

Armed forces were coming towards Thanjavur from all these three roads. Soldiers in full battle-gear, armoured and armed, came marching through these roads. Thankfully, at the head of the army, the soldiers were bearing a large tiger flag signifying that these were Chola forces but why are they marching towards Thanjavur and why?

As the forces came closer, the people of Thanjavur were able to learn more about the armies approaching them. These were the forces under the command of Kodumbalur Budivikrama Kesari in Elangai and along with them were the Therinja Kaikola Padai and Aringzha Chola forces who were fighting in Elangai as well.

The people of Thanjavur soon figured out that it was Budivikrama Kesari coming to Thanjavur with his forces. And the reason for his arrival and his forces was easy to discern. Everyone in the kingdom knew that the commander wanted his brother's daughter Vanathi to marry Ponniyin Selvar. With the prince being brought to Thanjavur by the people to be crowned as the next emperor, and the commander arriving with his forces, it was easy to deduce that he is coming to ensure that the prince ascended the throne next.

The people were also aware of the fact that the Pazhuvur brothers and the chieftains who supported them wanted Prince Madhuranthakan to be the next emperor. And since Budivikrama Kesari as coming there to ensure that their dear prince ruled the kingdom next, the people of Thanjavur became most enthusiastic and prepared to welcome the forces.

Thanjavur, at that time, had many feasting halls and guesthouses maintained by rich merchants such as – Kodumbalur Manik Gramathar, Thirupurambayam Vallanjiyar, Uraiyur Dharma Vanigar.

And they opened their halls for the armed forces and decided to offer them food and refreshments.

The people of Thanjavur became more excited by these developments and spent the day anticipating and talking about the events that would soon unfold in the city. The Kodumbalur army and the other forces surrounded the Thanjavur fort. And soon the soldiers set camps all around the fort and people went to these camps and socialized with the soldiers.

By evening, all the armed forces had arrived and had surrounded the fort from three directions except for the Vadavaru River, which flowed close to the fort and was in spate due to the storm.

The main northern entrance of Thanjavur fort is familiar to us. That's the entrance by which Nandini's palanquin entered the fort. And that's how Vandiya Devan too entered the fort. At a short distance from this entrance, Kodumbalur Budivikrama Kesari set his camp. After reconnoitring the fort, he returned to his camp an hour after dusk had set in. Over a hundred people were waiting for him at the camp. The commanders of his forces, Kaikola Padai commanders, Pandya commanders and Kongu commanders were among those who waited. Along with them were many merchants; most prominent among them were merchant representatives from Nana Desa Tisaiyayirattu Ainnutruvar^[9], who were instrumental in growing the Cholas' clout in trade and merchandise. They were influential and powerful enough to commission warships with soldiers to accompany their merchant ships, to keep them safe from pirates. Apart from them, prosperous merchants of Thanjavur too were waiting for the prince at the camp.

Chapter 24: The Council

After greeting those who had gathered at his camp, Kodumbalur Budivikrama Kesari addressed the council thus.

“I think all those who I had invited have gathered here, except for Thirukkoyalur Malayaman, who I am sure has a valid reason for absenting himself. We have gathered here to discuss a dangerous undertaking today.

“Everyone gathered here is devoted to the Cholas and Sundara Chola’s family. We owe them fealty and we have proved our loyalty to them many times. Despite that, many are likely to accuse us of conspiring to act against the wishes of the emperor. They may even accuse us of bringing armed forces to attack the emperor.

“But for some time now, we have not been able to learn the wishes of the emperor. Nor have we had access to his presence. We can’t meet him privately and learn what he wants. It’s been told that the emperor is kept in isolation in the Thanjavur fort due to his illness. But like everybody, even I suspect that he might have been imprisoned by the Pazhuvur brothers. I know not what you think about this...” said the commander, placing the question before the council.

Everybody then agreed to his surmise and said, “Yes... yes, we agree with you. We think that the emperor is in a prison in Thanjavur!”

“Then we are all in agreement here and we can work towards the same goal. We have close ties to the royal Chola line. Since the time of Vijayalaya Chola, we have helped build this kingdom to its present state of power, and it is a point of pride for all of us to be allied to the Cholas. And our goal would be to ensure the Cholas rule the kingdom forever and not those who conspire against them.

The enemies of the Chola Kingdom have imprisoned the emperor for three years in the fort. When we demand a reason for his isolation, we are told that he is not well. Emperor Sundara Chola, who is a direct descendent of the great Vijayalaya Chola. The king who bore 99 scars on his body. Didn't he carve a victory out of a certain defeat? He fought for the kingdom even when he was paralysed waist down, armed with two long swords. Wherever he went, there were mounds of heads. And we are told that our emperor, who is from the same lineage is sick, unable to give an audience except for a select few! Is this believable?

"I fear that the emperor has lost his mental faculties thanks to the sorcery of our enemies. They might have tricked him with black magic and cursed his mind to act against his family and his true friends. If he was in his right mind, would he sideline his own sons, who are warriors akin to Bheema and Arjuna and favour Prince Madhuranthakan, who has never seen a war in his life, and want him to become the next emperor?"

When he paused for a while, people who had gathered there asked, "How do we know that is the emperor's wish?"

"We don't really know if that is his 'wish'. We only get to hear what the Pazhuvur brothers are saying. Unfortunately, Prime Minister Anirudha Brahmarayar too is believing this and seems to support this!"

Someone at the council then said, "Maybe he has also joined hands with the enemy!"

"That could be true, too! Who knows?! Today, in the city of Thanjavur, you have all heard the rumours that are floating around. But I do not believe them. I do think that we will be able to meet the emperor when he is alive and well. And when we do, we will get his final word on who he wants to crown as the next emperor. But if he insists that the reign should pass on to Madhuranthakan, will you accept his mandate?"

“No! We will not accept it!” shouted the men gathered there.

“I will not accept it either. If the emperor is in his right mind, he would not turn against his own sons. But my suspicion is that evil magic has been used to change his mind. During the reign of Emperor Paranthaka I, the question of succession was settled, and it was Sundara Chola and his heirs who would ascend the throne after him. Emperor Paranthaka willed this in front of his chieftains, I heard it myself and I am sure many others might have too.

“King Gandaradithan and the dowager queen Sembiyanmadevi tried to keep Madhuranthakan away from the affairs of the kingdom and wanted to immerse him in the worship of Lord Shiva instead. There must be a very strong reason for them to do this. In such a case, why does Madhuranthakan wish to ascend the throne now?

“The emperor is not in his right mind. Let me give another example of this.

“My brother went to Elangai to punish the meddling king of that island kingdom and wanted to teach him a lesson to never interfere in our wars. We failed to send him enough supplies on time, and he sacrificed his life on the battlefield.

“To avenge this defeat, Prince Arulmozhivarman and I went to Elangai and we routed King Mahindan and sent him running to Rohana mountains and captured Anuradhapuram. You all know that Lord Treasurer Periya Pazhuvetarayar didn’t cooperate with us and did not send enough supplies for our soldiers. The council of merchants here and your guild... it was you who helped us in the time of our need. Despite your generosity, our soldiers had to endure many a hardship due to lack of supplies and yet gave our kingdom a victory that we are proud of. How do you think that happened?

“That’s because they fought for someone they truly loved and believed in; Ponniyin Selvar. And how did Sundara Chola reward such a victorious son? By branding him as a traitor and usurper and accusing him of trying to snatch Elangai, the emperor sanctioned the

Pazhuvur brothers to imprison him. Do you really think, any father in his right mind would issue an order like this?”

“Commander, you are again talking about the emperor’s orders. Do you really think the emperor gave those orders? Is there any proof?”

“There is no proof indeed, and I am here to find the truth behind those orders. And if those orders were decreed without the emperor’s approval and consent, can you imagine the dangerous situation the kingdom is in today? Think about it.

“You know the imperial soldiers who were sent to Elangai to imprison the prince, they refused and revolted against these orders, and they mutinied against their Kalapathy^[10]. But the prince, on hearing about these orders, took Pallava Parthibendran’s ship to come back home. But when the ship was caught in the storm, the prince went missing. Many believed that he had drowned in the sea, but I didn’t. The Lord of the Sea will not dare to harm the prince who was born to rule the world.

I believe that the prince must have realized that arrangements must have been made to imprison him after he came ashore. Therefore, he went into hiding so he could reveal himself when the time was right. Many amongst you, too, probably thought the same. Thankfully, the prince emerged from hiding during the storm in Nagapattinam and the people are bringing him here to crown him as the next emperor. After hearing this, I gathered our forces and brought them here to lend my support to the people’s wishes. Unfortunately, our enemies have once again shown their true face...”

“What? What are you saying?” asked the people gathered at the council

“I heard it just before I came to this council. This morning at Thiruvarur, just before the prince mounted his elephant, the beast became mad and threw the mahout to his death. And in the resulting confusion, the prince went missing...”

His announcement horrified the men at the council, and they exclaimed, “How could this happen? Has God joined our enemies too?!”

The commander raised his hand to appeal for silence and said, “I too was distressed beyond words when I heard this news. I somehow managed to calm myself and came to this council. I have witnessed the prince’s bravery on the battlefield, and it is not easy to trap someone who builds brilliant strategies like him. I truly believe that we will soon hear some good news about the prince. Until then, I want to know what we can do here and get your counsel for the same...”

Following the commander’s request for counsel and advise, the gathered men there came up with a list of demands. The foremost of their demands was that they must be allowed to meet the emperor in private where they could learn his wishes regarding his succession. And if the emperor wished to pass on the crown to Madhuranthakan instead of his own sons, then they would place a petition before him saying that they do not support his ascension as the next emperor. The other demands were that either he should remove the Pazhuvur brothers from their posts in the royal court or move back to Pazhaiarai.

Aditya Karikalan is the ‘Crown Prince’ and the throne belongs to him next. But if he wants to renounce the crown of his own volition, then, Ponniyin Selvar should succeed the emperor next. They wanted the emperor to declare this so that there is no room for doubt at a later point in time.

If they were unable to meet the emperor and if the fort gates were not opened for them, they decided to lay siege to the fort and wait.

A few impatient commanders suggested, “Why wait until they open the gates? Let’s get our soldiers to force open the gates to scale on the walls.”

To this suggestion, many others said that it would be best to wait until they heard more news about the prince. Some also wanted to send word to Aditya Karikalan and bring him to Thanjavur to join them.

“There is no point in waiting. The forces under the command of Periya Pazhuvetarayar are stationed in Mazha Nadu near the Kollidam river. All the rivers are in spate due to the storm, and it would be impossible for the army to cross. Now is the right time to attack the fort and release the emperor from his prison,” said one of the commanders.

While a debate rose around this, a soldier hurried inside the camp and whispered something in the commander’s ears. The commander immediately got up and said, “Continue your discussion, I will be back shortly.”

Chapter 25: The Fort Gates

After exiting his camp, the Commander mounted his horse and rode towards the northern gate of Thanjavur Fort. He saw that an elephant was meandering its way towards the northern entrance. There was a mahout and two women who rode the elephant.

The mahout blew his horn and announced in a loud voice, “Here comes the cherished daughter of Kodumbalur Paranthaka Siriya Vellar, the commander of Chola forces martyred in Elangai. Here comes the beloved companion and trusted friend of Princess Kundavai Devi. Here comes the beloved niece of Kodumbalur Budivikrama Kesari! Make way for the Princess!”

Saying thus, he blew his horn again.

Once the elephant stood in front of the northern gates near the drawbridge, the mahout once again blew his horn and announced, “The Kodumbalur Princess, Vanathi Devi, brings an important message from Princess Kundavai to the Emperor. She also has a message from the Lord Treasurer Periya Pazhuvetarayar, to his brother Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. Open the fort gates and let us in. Make way for Princess Vanathi Devi and her companion Poonguzhali Devi.”

Hearing this, Commander Budivikrama Kesari was shocked. He also felt that he had heard the mahout’s voice somewhere before. But he dismissed it, thinking, ‘now is not the time for trivial thoughts’ and focussed his attention on the women who were riding the elephant. He wanted to confirm whether it was indeed Vanathi on the elephant. And if it was her, she had to be stopped from entering the fort.

If it is Vanathi on the elephant, then it would be a relief. The child could stay with me until things settle down...

A soldier on a horseback came holding a fire torch. And in its light, he saw that it was indeed Vanathi and Poonguzhali who were seated on the elephant.

“Vanathi... Child,” started the Commander, only to be interrupted by the Mahout’s horn. Irritated at the interruption, the Commander tried to silence him, but Vanathi leaned on the elephant and said something to the mahout, who stopped blowing the horn.

“Uncle... is that you? So, whatever I heard was not a rumour but the truth.”

“Yes, child, it’s me. But what’s this? Why did Princess Kundavai send you here? Couldn’t see find anybody else?”

“Yes, uncle. She sent me for a specific reason. If she were to send somebody else, your forces might have stopped them, and the fort gates may not be opened for them. By sending me, she hoped to make sure her messages reached the emperor. And she made Poonguzhali accompany me as well.”

“I know about this boat girl. She is very clever. But what’s this message that you have brought and why would she send you in the dead of the night? Is the message very urgent?”

“It is an urgent message, uncle. I brought a message about Ponniyin Selvar for the emperor.”

“About Ponniyin Selvar? What do you know about him?”

“Oh, I know a lot about him. He is a brave warrior who doesn’t fear his enemies. No one can drown him in the river or at sea. He cherishes his friends and is grateful to those who help him. He is devoted to his parents and respects his sister’s counsel. He has no desire to rule any kingdom...”

“Enough! Enough! I did not ask all that. Do you know where the prince is right now?”

“Yes, I do, uncle. I know where he is right now, but I am sorry I cannot divulge that information to you!”

“What! You won’t tell even me? Is this really you, Vanathi?”

“Yes, it is me, uncle. I have made a vow not to divulge any information about the prince.”

The commander couldn’t believe his ears and his anger was boundless.

“Girl, I thought that Princess Kundavai would bring you up in a good manner in my absence. But I was wrong. You have grown to become a headstrong, mannerless girl. Enough! Get down from the elephant! You are going back to Kodumbalur this instant!”

“Uncle, I have no wish to come to Thanjavur. I don’t even want to touch the city’s land! That’s why I came on an elephant. Do not come very close to this beast. It becomes mad, sometimes. Today morning, it threw a man who had come very close to it. Let me complete my mission. Let me deliver the messages that I have been tasked with, and after that, I will come to you. You can send me to Kodumbalur or even to the place where my late father is. I don’t really care. Right now, do not stop me from entering the fort!”

Commander Budivikrama Kesari thought for a while and said, “Child, alright! I will not stop you from entering the fort. But what will do you if they do not open the fort gates for you?”

“Uncle, why have you brought your forces here? If they do not open the gates for me, let them break it open...”

The commander smiled at his niece when he heard her reply and said, “Child, you spoke just as a Kodumbalur Princess should. If the need arises, I will do just as you said, but I don’t think it will come to that. Who is this Chinna Pazhuvetarayan to bar entry to the beloved companion and friend of Princess Kundavai? He won’t dare refuse entry. But do give them a message from me as well. If he harms you

in any way whilst you are inside the fort, I will destroy his entire clan. Tell him that I have come here with the forces to meet the emperor. And if we are not allowed entry by tomorrow morning, we will raze this fort to the ground and gain entry.”

“I will give him your message, uncle!”

After this, the mahout started blowing his horn again.

“Open the gates for the Kodumbalur Princess. Open the gates!” he shouted.

Chapter 26: Vanathi's Entry

Inside the fort, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was distressed beyond words. Since morning, he had been receiving one bad news after another. With his elder brother missing, he was finding it difficult to decide on the next course of action.

The most distressing news was that Periya Pazhuvetarayar had left Kadambur Palace and began travelling to Thanjavur two days ago. That night, the storm had passed through the Chola Kingdom and the Kollidam River was flooded. He heard that many boats and their passengers drowned in the flood waters during the storm. Unfortunately, even Periya Pazhuvetarayar's boat met with the same fate, as confirmed by one of the soldiers who had survived the incident. He had been brought to Thanjavur, where he informed the commander about the flood and their unsuccessful search for the Lord Treasurer along the banks of the Kollidam River.

The next news was about Prince Arulmozhivarmar. He learned that the prince had emerged from Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam where he had remained hidden for a while. Now, apparently, the people were bringing him to Thanjavur in a victory procession and intended to crown him the emperor. A spy who had come along with the procession had crossed the flooded river somehow to come to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and inform him about the prince's progress to Thiruvarur.

Right after this, the commander received news from Kadambur Sambuvarayar, who had sent a warning to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar about Thirukkovalur Malayaman who was mustering his forces south of Kollidam; he also added that it was becoming impossible to live with Aditya Karikalan at Kadambur and that the prince had become more crazed than ever. He requested that Periya Pazhuvetarayar come back to Kadambur immediately.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar never reached Thanjavur in the first place, then how can he start for Kadambur again? Could he have drowned in the waters of Kollidam? Did Kollidam claim the life of the most illustrious warrior of Chola history? Such were the anguished thoughts of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

As if these were not enough, his spies had now brought the most distressing news that he heard all morning. They informed him that from the northern direction a huge army headed by Commander Budivikrama Kesari could be seen marching towards the fort. And soon, soldiers armed to the teeth were seen on the three main roads that led to the city. Right after he heard this, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar ordered his soldiers to shut all the gates of the fort and pull up the drawbridge of the moat. No one was allowed inside the fort; nor could anyone go out.

He appointed the Velkarar army to guard the emperor's palace and instructed his own men to man the fort.

He wanted to inform about these developments to the emperor, but he wanted to do it in the presence of the prime minister. While it was true that he didn't have much confidence that the prime minister would take his side, he was happy that Anirudhar was also currently inside the fort. This meant that the prime minister couldn't do anything without his knowledge. With his elder brother missing in action, the commander didn't want to get blamed for anything untoward that might happen, so he pretended to consult the prime minister for everything. He felt that it would be best if the prime minister was also in the room when he informed the emperor about the recent developments.

He believed that Budivikrama Kesari was marching towards Thanjavur to marry his niece to Prince Arulmozhi and to capture the capital city with his strength of arms. If he were to inform the emperor about this, he might not believe him. But if the prime minister corroborated it, then the emperor would have to believe him.

Even the prime minister was distressed by the turn of events that morning. He didn't approve of Princess Kundavai leaving the fort that morning. When he learned that Mandakini Devi and Poonguzhali were missing since the morning, he became worried. 'Where could they have gone? How did they go missing?' he mulled deeply over these questions without any answers.

When he learned that Budivikrama Kesari was marching towards Thanjavur, he became more distressed and worried. When Chinna Pazhuvetarayar came to him and asked if they could inform the emperor about these developments, he discouraged it.

"The emperor is disturbed today. I just got the information from the queen's maid now. If we were to tell him about Budivikrama Kesari, he might burst a nerve in his brain and his life will be in danger. As it is, there is a rumour spreading in the city about the emperor's death. Imagine the consequences if that came true at this time. Our enemies will rejoice if such a thing were to happen. Let's wait and watch what happens. In the meantime, it would be good to ascertain Budivikrama Kesari's intentions and what he hopes to achieve by laying siege to the fort. Let's also get confirmed reports about what happened to Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Ponniyin Selvar before we meet the emperor."

In this instance, the prime minister's advice to wait seemed reasonable to the commander.

"Then I will leave it to you to inform the emperor. I will take care of the fort security," said the commander and left.

The commander started touring the fort to oversee the security and to prepare it for a long siege. He also started stationing soldiers on the fort walls to thwart any enemy soldiers' attempts to scale the walls and made provisions to fortify the gates of the fort to prepare their defence if the forces tried to ram and gain entry. He also surveyed the fort walls for disrepair and gave instructions to repair them immediately.

While he set this in motion, he was also actively thinking about how to get messages safely in and out of the fort. There were two secret passages out of the fort. One was through the treasure chamber of Periya Pazhuvetarayar. But it would be impossible to use this passage right then, as it exited near the Vadavaru river which was flooded. If anyone attempted to open the passageway here, the treasure chamber would be flooded.

The other passage was from the prime minister's palace, but no one could exit the fort through that way without the commander's knowledge. The exit for that passage was near the fort wall and the commander stationed soldiers near the passage and resolved to send his spies out to get confirmed reports about the fates of Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Ponniyin Selvar.

While the Commander was thus occupied, a soldier came running to him with the most unusual news. At the northern gate, two women and a mahout on an elephant were demanding entry into the fort. When he learned that one of the women was Princess Vanathi, his irritation and anger knew no bounds.

What nerve! How dare she request entry into the fort, especially when her uncle had laid siege to it?

His first instinct was to refuse her entry. But by the time he made his way to the northern entrance he had changed his mind.

What harm can a little girl do to me? Why should I fear her and deny her entry? This doesn't sit well with my image as a brave warrior.

That apart, he was also curious to know why she had come to the fort during such a time.

He climbed onto the ramparts of the fort near the northern entrance to see their approach. As informed, there was a mahout and two women on the elephant. He also saw Budivikrama Kesari talking to them and was able to hear some of the conversation.

Budivikrama Kesari tried to stop her from entering the fort, but Vanathi stubbornly refused to listen to him and was steadfast in her resolve. Their conversation cemented his decision to grant her entry.

After Budivikrama Kesari moved aside, the elephant stepped near the drawbridge. The mahout blew his horn and shouted, "Open the gates for Princess Vanathi. She has brought important messages from Princess Kundavai to the emperor and also bears messages from Periya Pazhuvetarayar to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. Open the gates for Vanathi Devi!"

When Chinna Pazhuvetarayar heard the mahout's announcement, he knew that he had to let her in. He was intrigued by the fact that Periya Pazhuvetarayar would send messages through her, of all people.

Surely there is some trick involved here but what can this little girl do to me?

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar signalled the gatekeeper, who blew his horn. A few soldiers carrying fire torches appeared on the ramparts. In the light of the fire torches, one could see how prepared the Pazhuvur soldiers were to take on their enemies. Archers were stationed in a row all along the ramparts with their arrows aimed at the elephant.

"We will open the gate for the Kodumbalur princess. Only the elephant and those who are mounted on it can enter the fort. If anyone else tries to follow, they will die instantly," said a thundering voice.

Hearing this, Budivikrama Kesari instructed his soldiers to move back further. The drawbridge was lowered, and the elephant stepped onto it and moved towards the fort entrance slowly. The fort gates opened with a huge sound and the elephant moved in. The drawbridge was pulled up again, almost immediately.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar brought his elephant closer to Vanathi's elephant and welcomed her formally, "Welcome, Princess!, Welcome to Thanjavur. You came here despite your uncle's attempts to stop you. I thank you for that. Have no fears about your safety while you are here. We will protect you at all costs..."

"Ayya, I have no such fear. I am here just to deliver the messages, after which I don't even care if you throw me in the dungeons!"

Chapter 27: Stop There!

When Vanathi spoke about the dungeons, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was reminded of the past. He dispensed with the ceremony and said, "Yes, you went to the dungeons once, didn't you? To know the fate of the spy...."

"No, Ayya! We went there to learn about the messenger who the Crown Prince had sent..."

"That's what you thought. How will you know whether he was a messenger or a spy? You are a small girl. I don't wish to argue about that with you. But did you find out anything at all when you were in the dungeons?"

"No, the man who we wanted to meet got released even before we went there. The Pazhuvur queen's orders preceded yours and even you didn't realize that he had been released!"

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar bit his lips to hold his tongue. His brother had allowed his queen to wield power indiscriminately, and the result was that young girls like Vanathi had no respect for them anymore. He retorted, "But for your part, you also released a madman, didn't you?"

"Ayya, if you are referring to Senthan Amuthan as a madman, you will be surprised to know how much this Chola Kingdom is indebted to him!"

"Girl, nothing is going to surprise me anymore. The long list of people to whom this kingdom owes its glory doesn't surprise me anymore. I am done with it. Even you have come here to do some 'great good' to this kingdom haven't you?"

"Yes, Ayya. If it was not important, do you think your brother will send me here? 'Me', who doesn't know anything?"

“I am wondering about the state of my brother’s deprecating intelligence every day. It seems to be growing beyond imagination. One can deduce that from the fact that he sent you, of all people, here. Quick, tell me your message!”

“He said, ‘We have been careless about the Pandya rebels. They are indeed active and will try to assassinate the emperor today. Watch over him carefully.’”

Hearing her message, Kalanthaka Kandar smiled and said, “So this is the urgent message that he sent me? It’s not something that I didn’t know before. I thought he might have sent a message about your uncle’s wish to attack the fort. If my brother can take care of the forces outside, I can take care of the emperor’s security inside. Neither Princess Kundavai nor you need to worry about this!”

“Ayya, your brother knew that you might dismiss this warning outright, that’s why he also said that you had previously warned him about a ‘Mandiravadi’ who used to visit the Pazhuvur queen, and he didn’t heed your warning back then and was angry with you for suspecting her. He said, ‘Thambi, I have committed a grave crime. That Mandiravadi Ravidasan is a Pandya rebel and the head of Pandya Abathuuthavigal who have sworn a sacred vow to avenge the gory death of their king. One of their men will try to assassinate the emperor today. Don’t be careless. Guard the emperor carefully.’ This was his message. I have discharged my duty now.”

Kalanthaka Kandar was indeed surprised. This type of message could only have come from his brother.

“Girl, if this message is true, then why is he not here? Why did he send you?”

“He didn’t send me. He gave this message to Princess Kundavai, and she sent me here. Since the Crown Prince’s life was also in danger, he went to Kadambur to save him!”

“From where? Where did you meet my brother?”

“We met him at the Kudanthai Jodhidar’s house. It seems like you are still suspicious of me. Let me explain. Your brother was travelling through the Kollidam River when the boat capsized, and he had to take refuge in a Pallipadai, where he heard the Pandya rebels discuss the assassinations that they had planned. Ayya, should we still discuss all this here, or shall we go to the palace?”

“Girl, it doesn’t matter what these rebels have planned. They cannot enter the fort without me knowing about it. I allowed you entry only because you are a mere girl!”

“What if these rebels are already inside the fort, biding their time?”

“Impossible....”

“Then it’s on your head, I have discharged my...”

“Yes, you have discharged your duty. You can return now...”

“No, Ayya! I have discharged one of my duties. I need to meet the emperor and give him the message from Princess Kundavai!”

“You can give that message to me. I will make sure that he receives it.”

“Not possible. Princess Kundavai has asked me to give this message to the emperor personally. Here is her signet ring...”

“Ah, signet rings are available with anybody today, there is no way to find out who gave it to you. Your uncle has laid a siege to this fort today and you have come inside. How can I believe you?”

“You really fear that a mere girl like me could cause harm to you?”

“Girl, we from the Pazhuvur clan know not what ‘fear’ means!”

“If that’s so, then allow me to go to the palace. Come along with me, you are so suspicious...”

“The emperor is very troubled today...”

“Ayya, I have brought news that would soothe and gladden the emperor’s heart. Later when you learn about that, you will regret stopping me here like this!”

“Girl, have you brought news about the young prince Arulmozhi?”

“Yes, commander...”

“Aha! How is he? Where is he now? Did the Pandya rebels try to assassinate him as well?”

“Yes, the Pandya rebels tried their utmost to kill him, but he escaped and is well. I hope you are happy to hear it?”

“Good question. Why wouldn’t I be happy to hear it? Come... I don’t want to waste my time talking to you. Come to the palace and give your message to the emperor.”

Saying thus, the commander led his elephant towards the palace. He was most eager to hear the news about Ponninyin Selvar. He had never really considered the young prince as a competition to his own son-in-law. He also knew that the emperor was favourably disposed towards Madhuranthakan and Prince Arulmozhi was devoted to his father and would not defy his words. His only worry was that Kundavai should not meddle in this and do something untoward.

Is Princess Kundavai influencing her brother again and sending a message that would change the emperor’s mind? Could she have really sent a message with the Kodumbalur Princess? But knowing the emperor as he did, he knew that the emperor wouldn’t keep any message a secret from him. If only he knew what Arulmozhi was up to, then it would be easy to prepare contingency plans to counter them.

Thinking thus, he also resolved to inform the emperor about Budivikrama Kesari's treacherous act of invading and laying a siege on Thanjavur fort.

Both the elephants arrived at the palace gates. The commander nimbly jumped down from the elephant's back while the other elephant bent its legs upon the mahout's prodding and both the women and the mahout got down.

The commander called the head of the guards and asked him to open the palace doors for the women.

Kalanthaka Kandar was very much disturbed by his brother's message. He tried to dismiss it, but couldn't. His brother's warning about Mandiravadi Ravidasan was not something he could dismiss and ignore. He was aware of the Pandya rebels but didn't really imagine them having a foothold within the Thanjavur fort.

He had believed that Nandini had been regularly meeting the Mandiravadi to use sorcery to entice his brother and to create a wedge between them. Vanathi's message gave a different spin to Nandini's actions, and it worried him incredibly. But what can this Mandiravadi do anyway? No one can meet the emperor without his permission. The emperor doesn't leave his bed chamber. Unsettled by his brother's message, the Commander nonetheless decided to increase the security around the emperor's palace.

For the past two days, many had entered the fort citing the storm and damage reparations as their excuse. Most of them came to meet the prime minister and he didn't know if all of them had left the fort.

It was a good thing that the fort gates closed today. If any of these people had evil intentions toward the emperor, it would be easy to investigate and imprison them...

Thinking thus, he called the leader of the guards and tasked them to search the fort for suspicious characters and arrest them. Next, he

sent for the commander of the Velkarar army wanting them to guard the emperor's palace all through the night.

After issuing these commands, Kalanthaka Kandar turned towards the palace to check if the women had entered and found them on the steps of the courtyard, moving inside the palace. But... who is this behind them? His turban looked just like the one that their mahout had been wearing.

Aha! Why is the mahout following these women inside the palace? What work does he have inside? Why does he have to meet the emperor?

What if he is a Pandya rebel? What if he had fooled these girls to gain entry to the palace? Did he just trick me to fulfil his murderous mission? Will I be fooled so easily? Could Budivikrama Kesari be involved in this plot to assassinate the emperor?

Within moments, the commander moved towards the mahout and held him from behind, "You there! Stop," he growled, and demanded, "Why are you going inside? What work can a mahout have inside the palace?"

Saying thus he locked the mahout's hands with his iron grip.

Hearing his growl and angry demands, the women who were walking in front turned around. They looked surprised, but were smiling! Vanathi stepped forward and said, "Ayya... ayya... he is... he is..." but the commander didn't turn towards her or even hear her. He was furious at the thought that someone could dare to trick him and gain entry to the palace.

Noticing the agitated behaviour of the women and the mahout, he had another horrifying thought.

What if this mahout is that spy who had escaped him earlier? What nerve! He thought he could trick him again and escape from the fort!

He tightened his grip on the mahout and demanded again, "You, there! Tell me the truth. Who are you? Are you really a mahout or are you the spy who escaped from me? You will not escape me again," saying thus he turned the man around to see his face.

That's when he saw the handsome mien of the mahout in the light of the lamps that were lit in the palace.

"Commander, I am also a mahout but I have never tried to escape you ever. I came here to surrender myself to you!"

The commander looked at him better, heard his voice, and stood speechless. His hands fell back of their own volition, releasing the man while the world crashed around him.

It was Prince Arulmozhi who was standing before him in the guise of a mahout.

Chapter 28: A Roar Ensues

Ponniyin Selvar's handsome persona had the kind of charm that renders people speechless. In this instance, the prince did not even seem angry. He looked like Lord Krishna who had been caught stealing butter and had no intention of escaping Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, who was known for his bravery, felt his hands tremble and he also started sweating. His hands automatically came together, and he bowed deeply to the prince, "Ponniyin Selva, winner of Eezham^[11], beloved son of Ponni, what is this? Why did you punish me like this? What did I do to deserve this? Please forgive me for not recognizing the beloved prince of the Chola Kingdom. I was blind despite being gifted with eyesight?" said the commander, his voice trembling.

As the commander continued to entreat for forgiveness, the prince stopped him and said, "Commander, what's this? What crime have you committed for me to forgive you? I am but a mere boy here at your command!"

"The hands that held you like a criminal; they deserve to be chopped off. The tongue that spoke disrespectfully to you deserves to be sliced..."

"Enough! Stop berating yourself in this manner. You merely did your duty. Why should I punish you for that? It was I who came disguised as a mahout. It was but natural for you to mistake me as one!"

"Yes, I didn't expect that you will come here thus. But why this disguise? How could you do this to me? Why did you rob me of the opportunity to welcome the beloved prince of this realm, returning victorious from Elangai with drums reverberating in the eight cardinal directions?!"

“This is not the right time for all that. Didn’t you hear what the Kodumbalur Princess said a few minutes ago? I think the Pandya rebels are out for revenge and we need to be careful!”

“Do you perchance think that I have joined these rebels?”

“God! On the contrary, I was appreciating the security arrangements that you have made to protect my father. I want to meet him first and then...”

“Ayya, did you perchance think that I would stop you from meeting your father? Did someone poison your ears about me?”

“I would never think that of you, Commander!”

“Then why this disguise?”

“How else could I have come here? Think about it. The fort is surrounded by the Kodumbalur forces and Budivikrama Kesari himself has come here. You do know why he is here...”

“Do you see why I had to shut the fort gates? Do you blame me for acting thus?”

“You defended the fort well. Shutting the gates was the right thing to do. But do you now see why I had to come in this disguise? Periya Vellar is hellbent on achieving his objectives and I had no option but to come in this disguise. And I brought the Kodumbalur princess here so I could get inside the fort. Thankfully, her uncle didn’t notice me, but your sharp eyes did!”

“I was blind that I didn’t recognize you immediately. I humbly request you to forgive the words that I inadvertently spoke when I thought you were the mahout!”

“Please do not talk thus. I have the same respect and devotion towards you that I have towards my father. You had sent men to Elangai to imprison me...”

“My God! Will I ever send soldiers to imprison you? It was your father who sent them, he wanted to see you immediately...”

“Don’t I know that, Commander? When they came to Elangai, I was told that this was not emperor’s commands but yours...”

“Our enemies must have poisoned your ears thus...”

“I told them that even if it was the command of the Pazhuvur lords, I would abide by it. I crossed the seas and came here in disguise, but I wouldn’t have seen my father without your permission!”

“Prince, are you still testing me? Who am I to give you permission to meet your father? If you want me to accompany you, I will come, or else I will stand here waiting for your orders...”

“Commander, it looks like you may have to stand here after all. We have spent too much time talking here in the open. Look there...” he said and pointed to the scene that was unfolding.

The soldiers who were manning the fort, the palace guards, and even some of the soldiers from the Velkarar army had gathered there and they were nearing the place where the commander and the prince were standing. They were gazing intently at the prince who was standing under the light of the huge torch lit in the palace.

And when they saw that it was indeed their beloved prince who was standing on the steps of the palace, a huge roar ensued. “Hail Ponniyin Selvar! Glory to Prince Arulmozhi! Hail the brave warrior who won Elangai!”

Hearing their hails, many others too were drawn to the scene. And soon a huge crowd had gathered in front of the palace.

“Commander, now do you see why I came here in this disguise? We shouldn’t have stopped here to talk. That’s why I didn’t want to reveal myself to you before I entered the palace!”

“I can see that now, prince. I will take care of this matter while you meet your father.”

Chapter 29: Consequences of Suspicion

After the prince entered the palace, the commander came toward the gathered crowd and the Velkarar army.

“Why are you people shouting thus? Don’t you know that the emperor is ill? And if that’s not enough, we have been besieged by the enemy! Do you not know that?” he demanded sternly.

The Velkarar Army Commander answered saying, “Are we really besieged by the enemy forces? Since when did the Velkarar forces become our enemy?”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar tried to control his rising anger and said, “You should ask this question to them. If they are not the enemy, then why did they besiege the fort?”

“We heard that he has come to crown the young prince as the next emperor!”

“Do you agree to that?” asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

The Velkarar Commander then turned towards his soldiers and asked, “What do you say to this?”

The soldiers shouted, “Yes, we agree. Hail Ponniyin Selvar! Hail Arulmozhivarmar!” and their voices reverberated strongly from all directions.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s face became red, and his moustache trembled in rage. He tried to control his anger and speak calmly.

“So, the crowning of the next emperor must be according to Periya Vellar’s wishes and your wishes. Doesn’t the emperor have any say in this matter?”

One of the soldiers then asked, “Commander, is the emperor still alive? Are you sure?”

“What kind of question is this?”

“We are hearing many rumours about his ill health, and we couldn’t see him today. That’s why we are worried about him,” said the Velkarar army commander.

“I told you why you couldn’t meet him. The emperor is very much disturbed and troubled, and he has refused to give audience to anyone!”

“Can you at least tell us why he is disturbed and why he didn’t wish to see anyone?”

“He was troubled by the fact that there was no news about the young prince. And now that the prince is back here...”

“We want to see the prince,” cried one of the soldiers.

The other soldiers too demanded the same, “Yes, we want to see the prince!!”

“Let the prince meet his father first. Afterwards, if he wishes, he will come and meet you!”

“Are you sure about that? What if you send him to the dungeons?”

If this had been any other occasion or a regular day, such insolence and disrespect from the Velkarar soldiers would have triggered a skirmish. But for some reason, even the Pazhuvur soldiers were subdued and didn’t counter them.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s hand went automatically to his sword. He wanted to strike down the soldier who had the temerity to question him thus. But he controlled his anger and laughed uproariously, saying, “You all heard his question, right? Good. I have

no authority to crown the prince as the next emperor, nor send him to the dungeons. That right lies with the emperor. And if we will be taking him to the dungeons, we will go by this way, and you can see him then.”

He then turned around and walked towards the palace, ignoring the shouts that rose after his announcement.

At the entrance, he found Poonguzhali standing alone.

“Girl, why are you standing here? Did they not allow you to go inside?”

“No one stopped me. I didn’t want to go inside!”

“Why?”

“The prince and his father are meeting after a long time. I didn’t want to intrude!”

“Alright, at least you believe that the emperor is still alive. I am happy about it...”

“I just saw that he was alive and well with my own eyes.”

“Why don’t you go and tell those soldiers who are standing there about it? They believe that the emperor is no more...”

“So far there is no proof to substantiate their belief. But one never knows what can happen next!”

“Girl, even you have decided to cause trouble and agitate me? Has the whole world gone mad?”

“Commander, many have called me ‘mad.’ What is more... I have called myself mad too. But you would be surprised to learn that the prince was able to come inside this fort and meet his father when he is still alive only because he lent ears to my idea...”

“What is this? You just saw the emperor, didn’t you? People believe stupid rumours all the time! Or are you talking like this because you know something?”

“It’s not only the astrologers and people who fear for the emperor’s life. Didn’t you hear the message that your brother sent you?”

“How do I know if that message is true?”

“Commander, why would the Kodumbalur Princess lie to you?”

“Who knows? Maybe she wants to be the next queen?!”

“Even I used to think about her thus. But I had to change my mind when I heard the vow she took this morning...”

“Or maybe even you might have such a wish!”

“Commander, I am a stupid girl who shouldn’t be talking to the likes of you.”

Kalanthaka Kandar immediately relented and said, “Girl, don’t get angry. Tell me whatever you wanted to say!”

“Yes, I have to say it or else I will regret it later and you will regret it, too. Ayya, if something were to happen to the emperor, the entire kingdom will lay the blame on your feet. Even your own soldiers will not spare you!”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar scowled at her and said, “If something like that were to happen, I will not wait until people start blaming me. I will behead myself for failing my duty. When the Velkarar army soldiers took their blood oath, I was at their head leading them during that.”

“How can that help anyone? This Chola Kingdom will not only lose its emperor but also a brave commander. Instead, don’t you think it would be better if we are careful?”

“Girl, do you think I am not careful enough? Look around you. There are soldiers stationed all around the fort and around the palace as well. Even the Prime Minister cannot enter the place without my knowledge.”

“I know, Commander! But what if the danger comes from inside the palace?”

“What are you blabbering? Do you think the palace women here would feed poison to the emperor and kill him? Or do you perhaps suspect that Kodumbalur princess who just went in with the prince?”

“Oh god! Those who suspect that gentle girl will be doomed forever. Besides, she is not clever enough to plan things like this. Ayya, there is a dungeon passage that goes inside the palace, right?”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was startled. He said, “Woman, how do you know about it? Except for a few select people, no one knows about this. Those who did, are already dead!”

“Commander, I knew about it only this morning. In that dungeon, I saw a Pandya conspirator armed with a spear...”

“My god! What are you saying? Do you know where that dungeon leads to?”

“Yes, it goes through the treasure chamber...”

“Aha! If what you say is true, then it’s the handiwork of that demoness that my brother had married. I warned him so many times! Ayyo, girl, are you sure about this? How did you know about the dungeon path?”

“I learned about it when my aunt took me through that path today!”

“Who is your aunt?”

“She is the woman whom the Prime Minister brought to Thanjavur in the palanquin that was sent from the Pazhuvur palace. Commander, while we are talking about it here...”

“Yes, you are right. I will immediately go to the Pazhuvur palace and make arrangements. In the meanwhile, you...”

“I will stay right here and keep watch...”

“Aha, how could I believe you? You could be working with these Pandya conspirators for all I know. You could be deceiving me...”

“Commander, then come along with me. Let’s get a fire torch, and we both can go and search the dungeons. On our way there, I will tell you everything I know!”

The commander immediately turned toward his soldiers and gave them some instructions. Some of them were asked to go to the Pazhuvur palace and one of them handed over a fire torch.

“Girl, lead the way. I want to see if you are telling the truth!”

The commander didn’t really believe Poonguzhali. He thought that she was trying to deceive him with falsehoods.

Maybe she wants to learn the location of the dungeons and their secrets from me! What if she wants to bring the Kodumbalur soldiers through the passage inside the fort? If she hopes to deceive me thus, then she will be punished most severely. If she thinks that she can deceive me like they did my brother, she is in for a surprise. Let her lead the way and I will check if she really knows the way to the dungeons. If a Pandya assassin is really found there, I will finish him like a jackal caught in a trap. My god! If there is really an assassin there, then the emperor’s life is truly in danger.

Thinking thus the commander walked behind Poonguzhali, who was literally racing through the palace. He was surprised by the speed in her gait.

Yes, Poonguzhali was very agitated and disturbed. Her instincts were screaming danger and her pace automatically picked up speed.

For a while, many extraordinary incidents had been happening in Poonguzhali's life but none of them could compare to what happened that day.

Early that morning, her aunt had woken her up from sleep. She saw a man's face looking down at them from the balcony above. Signalling her to be silent, her aunt walked towards the garden of statues. She went towards the same Ravana statue that she had been trying to break earlier. They could see the face of the same man who was looking down at them at the women's quarters near the Ravana's head and his arms.

That's when Poonguzhali realized that there was an entrance under Ravana's head. Mandakini Devi first entered via the secret entrance and Poonguzhali followed her inside. At first, Poonguzhali couldn't see anything in the pitch-black darkness of the dungeons. Mandakini gripped her hand tightly and took her through the dungeon path. It led into another mandapam which was also shrouded in darkness. They carefully climbed the steps to reach the mandapam and moved inside slowly. At the far end of the mandapam, through a small window situated on the top, a little light permeated the chamber.

The man whom Mandakini had followed inside was nowhere in sight and there were a thousand places to hide and escape in the dark dungeon.

What if that man found us before we found him? What if he killed us?

Even as Poonguzhali was thinking thus, Mandakini let out a scream which was part human and part animal-like. Right on cue, after she elicited that scream, a wail was heard, and the shadow of a man was seen, running indiscriminately. Poonguzhali realized that it must be the same man who had been watching them from the

balcony at the palace, who was now scared out of his wits and was fleeing away from the hair-raising scream that was following him.

Mandakini kept him on the run by screaming at regular intervals. He was now headed towards a large ornate door on which he banged for a long time. Soon, the door opened, and a woman stood at the entrance. The man told the woman something, but she seemed to hesitate. Then he proceeded to threaten her with something, after which she left. He waited near the entrance for her to return. After a while, the woman returned with a lamp in hand. Mandakini and Poonguzhali hid behind a large pillar and in the light of the lamp, they also saw the man who had looked terrified.

The man and the woman entered the dungeons again and Poonguzhali could hear their conversation.

“Where is this ghost that you keep seeing here? Looks like you have been well and truly terrified. If you are so scared of ghosts, why did you agree to this sort of work?”

Poonguzhali wondered ‘what sort of work’ the woman was referring to, as she didn’t really understand what the man was doing in the dungeons. After the man and woman disappeared inside the dungeon, Mandakini dragged her towards the entrance of the dungeon and opened the door carefully. Poonguzhali saw that they were in someone’s garden, but didn’t know whose palace grounds they had emerged onto. They moved towards the palace walls crossing the fallen trees and near the wall, her aunt used sign language to tell her this message.

I am nearing the end of my life. I wish to see the prince before I die. Give him this message and bring him back.

Poonguzhali was devoted to her aunt, and her first instinct was to stay beside her and protect her. But she had never refused her aunt anything and the prospect of meeting the prince again appealed to her. She took leave of her aunt and scaled over the palace walls. She then reached the fort entrance and exited the fort. At the fort

entrance, she met Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, who was under orders from the prime minister to meet the prince. They decided to join forces and travel together.

That day, luck favoured her in every step of her journey. When they reached Kudanthai, they saw Kundavai Devi's chariot and went inside the house to get more information about the prince. That's where they saw Periya Pazhuvetarayar and learned about the assassination plans hatched by the Pandya conspirators. When the Lord Treasurer spoke about an assassin hiding in the treasure chamber that lead towards the palace, she could connect the dots with what she had seen that morning.

When he spoke about the dangers that the prince would face, her heart worried about it. Amidst all this, Vanathi's vow of not ascending the throne gave her conflicted thoughts and feelings. She went after the Kodumbalur princess to rescue her from the flood water and fortuitously met the prince there.

One of the things that gave her immense satisfaction was the fact that the prince accepted her idea and travelled to Thanjavur. While they were discussing the possible dangers they could face, she couldn't help remembering how the prince had taken her alone on the elephant to reach the coast of Yaanai Iravu in Elangai and how he had tricked the Kodumbalur Commander into thinking that the elephant had gone mad. She proposed that he disguise himself as a mahout again and accompany Vanathi and herself to the fort on the elephant. People would think that he was the mahout and wouldn't spare him a glance.

The prince enthusiastically applauded her for this idea and said, "Samudra Kumari, that's a great idea. You are clever enough to be the prime minister of a kingdom!" Pleased by the fact that she was able to help the prince, she recalled his words again and again and felt happy.

Despite the fact everything had gone according to plan, she was disheartened and disappointed to see that her aunt was not in the

emperor's chambers. What was the point of bringing the prince all the way here when she couldn't find her aunt here? Whenever she thought about her aunt's words, 'my end is nearing,' she felt alarmed and found her panic rising. She couldn't even ask anyone at the palace about her. One after another, dreadful thoughts came and disappeared in her mind.

What if that scoundrel hiding in the dungeons had killed her aunt?

Poonguzhali wanted to go to the dungeon entrance situated in the hall of statues in the palace gardens, but the entire palace was agog with excitement over the prince's arrival. Servants, handmaidens, and palace women were ecstatic about the prince's arrival, and many were coming to the emperor's chambers to see him. With such excitement making the rounds, Poonguzhali couldn't go to the palace gardens without being stopped or questioned. She was also not very enthusiastic about going back to the dungeons alone. Though she was naturally brave and had survived many dangerous situations, she couldn't forget the helplessness she had felt in the darkness of the dungeon. That's why she thought it would be best to take the commander along with her.

Convincing the commander about the assassin hiding in the dungeon took a while and she was in a panic now.

What if she was too late?

It was that thought that made her race through the palace. She hoped that her aunt was safe. She instinctively felt as though some great danger was inching its way towards them.

Just before they could enter the hall of statues, she saw a dark shadow darting towards the upper levels of the palace. She stopped in her tracks to discern that she was indeed seeing a man inching his way towards the balcony.

"Girl, why are you stopping here? Are you afraid that your lies and falsehood would be exposed soon?" asked the commander.

The commander's words prompted her to move towards the hall of statues and there she pointed out the entrance to the dungeons between the hands of the Ravana.

Stunned by the fact that she did know where the entrance to the dungeon lay, the Commander said, "Alright, get into the tunnel now!"

For some reason, Poonguzhali hesitated and her body trembled. And that's when they heard Mandakini's shrieks and wails coming from the emperor's chambers. She immediately ignored the Commander's words and ran back towards the anthappuram. When she reached the emperor's bed chamber, the scene that unfolded there would be etched in her heart forever.

The emperor was lying on the bed and was looking at his youngest son fondly. His hands were clasped in the prince's hands. Mandakini was in front of them, wailing and shrieking, while Vanathi and the empress stood on the other side of the bed astonished and shocked.

Everyone was looking at Mandakini and didn't notice the spear that was thrown down at the emperor. Poonguzhali leapt towards her aunt.

Chapter 30: She Became a Goddess

No matter how fast one could run, it is impossible to outrun a spear that had already been thrown and was headed towards someone. The spear struck Mandakini in her stomach, and she fell with a wail. Horrified by the turn of events, everyone tried to go near the fallen woman.

Just then, they could hear someone throwing a few things from the balcony, and the large lamp kept near the emperor's bed extinguished, enveloping the chamber in total darkness. Confusion and chaos ensued with a crackle of voices heard outside the room as the women moved around in bewilderment. Sounds of someone jumping, and clatters of things were also heard adding confusion to the chaos.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar growled, "Someone, bring a lamp immediately!"

Suddenly a woman shouted. "Aha! Ayyo!" It seemed like the empress's voice, and everyone panicked and feared what else has happened there.

Poonguzhali was still moving towards her fallen aunt, but someone was already sitting beside her and was holding her in their arms, crying profusely. She could hear their heart-breaking sobs and her aunt's painful moans.

Just then Chinna Pazhuvetarayar shouted, "Who is that? Don't run!"

Poonguzhali could guess who was running away from there. Just then, two servant maids came inside the chamber with two lamps lit and the scene that unfolded there immersed everyone in surprise and shock.

Paralyzed from the waist down for the past three years, the emperor, who had been unable to move out of his bed, had somehow reached Mandakini and was holding her in his hands. The prince too was next to him. The spear had struck her hard and her blood was soaking the floor and the emperor who was holding her.

Vanamadevi was standing next to the emperor's bed looking shocked and overwhelmed. A dagger was embedded to its hilt on the emperor's pillow. Stunned by the fact that her husband had moved from the bed at the right time, she looked at the mute woman on the floor who had averted the assassin's murderous assault.

Tears streaming from his eyes, the prince comforted Mandakini Devi while the emperor sobbed piteously.

Poonguzhali saw all this and understood what had transpired there in those few seconds. The assassin who had thrown the spear down on the emperor immediately realized that Mandakini had thrown herself in front of it, saving the emperor's life. He then threw down some of the items that were lying strewn on the palace balcony and extinguished the lamps in the chamber. He then jumped down from there and attempted to fulfil his mission again by stabbing the emperor with his dagger. Realizing that the emperor was still vulnerable to the assassin, Vanamadevi quickly moved toward the bed and panicked when she found her husband missing. That's when the assassin, after striking at the pillow threw the empress aside to escape from the room. And then she had screamed, "Aha! Ayyo!"

Next, the assassin had moved towards the door and encountered Chinna Pazhuvetarayar who had shouted, "Who is that? Don't run!"

Having correctly guessed the chain of events, Poonguzhali's first instinct was to run after the assassin. But her aunt was breathing her last in front of her and she couldn't leave her there alone. She sat down next to her and cried, "Athai! Athai!" and sobbed pitifully.

“Ayyo, you knew this would happen. You foretold your own death and the wretch that I am, left you alone and went away,” cried Poonguzhali.

But Mandakini didn't even turn towards her beloved niece. Her eyes were devouring the emperor, who was holding her broken body. She didn't even spare a glance for the prince who was crying and holding her hand.

When Poonguzhali started wailing in earnest, the prince turned toward her and asked, “Poonguzhali, what is this? Have you forgotten where you are and in whose presence?”

Poonguzhali tried to control her anguish and stood up, “Prince, I have no one else in this world, except my aunt!”

The prince wiped his tears and said, “Poonguzhali, she might be your aunt! To me, she is much more than my own mother. She sent for me and yet she didn't even look at me once. Do you know why? She and my father, who got separated thirty years ago, have united for the first time. And I think we should give them the privacy to talk to each other whilst they still have the time!”

He glanced at the others in the room and said, “Woman, I am indebted to you. You have helped me many times in the past. But today, you brought me here to witness the union of my parents. And for that, I am truly grateful to you. Samudra Kumari, do you know what your aunt has done today? She stood in front of my father and allowed the spear to pierce her instead. She is giving up her life to save him. Not once but twice. When my father saw that the spear had struck her, his legs regained life and he instinctively ran towards her. And that's how she saved him again. The assassin jumped down from that balcony and tried to kill him again but found the bed empty!

“Look at my mother, standing there aghast and stunned. When she saw the assassin's spear striking down your aunt, she moved towards my father to save him from the next assault. She too wanted

to give up her life for him, just like your aunt and panicked when she found the bed empty. If my father had not moved away from the bed today, I might have lost both my parents to that murderous villain. Do you now realize what your aunt has done for us? If that assassin had fulfilled his intent and killed the emperor. this kingdom would fall and the Pazhuvur clan would be blamed for its downfall. Your aunt didn't save my parents alone, she saved the Pazhuvur clan from the dishonour and ignominy that they could never hope to wipe off their history. She saved the Chola kingdom and has become a Goddess for the Chola clan.

“Poonguzhali, I will not cry anymore for your aunt and neither should you. She saved her husband and embraced death in his stead. She fulfilled her life's mission and now she is giving up her life in his arms lying on his lap.”

The prince then looked around and found that everyone was listening to him with rapt attention. He continued....

“Poonguzhali, you will not be orphaned today if your aunt dies. I am indebted to you and will always be grateful to you. And even if I were to forget this, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar will not forget. Do you realize how you have helped him today? If the emperor had died at the hands of the assassin, the world would have believed that the commander was complicit in this dastardly act. Kodumbalur Budivikrama Kesari is already at the fort gates with his army, and he would destroy the Pazhuvur clan. And what's more, if I had not come inside the fort thanks to your help, even I would have doubted the commander. I am sure he is more indebted to you than anybody else. You can claim any prize from him, and he would be happy to give it away. He might even give you half of his possessions and wealth....”

The prince was looking at the commander when he said this. his intent was to let him know that he had failed in his duty. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar realized the truth in the prince's words and within a few seconds, the brave self-possessed man who was always sure of himself transformed into someone who was shameful of his actions.

His face lost its assertive authoritative glow, and he looked humiliated; like a soldier who had fled the battlefield to escape death in the war.

Poonguzhali, who had been anguished and heartbroken when the prince started speaking, reclaimed her anger and rage when he spoke about the prize that she could claim from Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

“Prince, I don’t need anybody! Nor do I want to claim a prize from anyone. Samudra Rajan is waiting for me, and my boat is near the canal. I will leave now. If my aunt survives... no that’s impossible. She knew that she would die soon and she even told me so. If ever you and the Kodumbalur princess came to Kodi Karai...” she said, and looked at Vanathi and found her staring back at them with her beautiful sad eyes.

“What am I saying? I will take your leave now...” saying thus, Poonguzhali moved towards the door.

Stunned and dumbfounded by the events that happened around her, Vanathi moved toward Poonguzhali and said, “My dear friend, where are you going? I am an orphan too...”

Before she could continue Poonguzhali said, “Devi, I am not your friend! Nor are you an orphan like me. Princess Kundavai will be here soon...”

That’s when Vanathi remembered the princess and said, “Ayyo, we need to inform her about all this!”

“Why do you worry about that? If you send word to your uncle at the gates, he would make sure the princess is informed,” Poonguzhali said moving towards the door.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar barred her exit and said, “Girl, Ponniyin Selvar is right. You and your aunt have saved the Pazhuvur clan

from ignominy and disgrace. I am indebted to you. Whatever prize you want from me, is yours to claim!”

Poonguzhali smiled at him grimly and said, “Commander, some people here are happy about the fact that the emperor escaped the assassin’s spear. Some are happy that the emperor regained the use of his legs. Some are happy that their clan escaped disgrace. No one is worried about my aunt’s fate except me. I am going after the assassin who killed my aunt. Allow me to go!”

The commander started when he heard this.

“Girl, I concede defeat and yield to you. I have been standing here witless while the assassin has escaped. I can still be blamed for allowing the assassin to escape. I should never have doubted your words in the first place. Come, let’s go after him. Where do you think he might have gone? Yes, to the underground passage. Come along and help me. I don’t wish to show other people that passage. Wait until I get my hands on him...”

Saying thus, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar grabbed Poonguzhali’s hands and pulled her along to run towards the underground passage in the palace gardens.

The rest of the people in the room stood away as they watched the emperor and the dying woman in his arms. The emperor hardly noticed anybody else in the room. He had eyes only for Mandakini Devi.

Is it possible to live thirty years of life with someone within a few minutes? That’s what the emperor and Mandakini were trying to do. They shared grief, happiness, disappointments, and bitter moments that they had undergone in the time they had been apart. Mandakini conveyed the trials and tribulations that she had undergone through her eyes. When they first met in the past, Sundara Chola had learned to communicate with her through signs and also instinctively knew what she was trying to say by reading her eyes. In those few moments that they shared, the emperor regained the ability to talk to

her and was able to flawlessly understand what she was trying to say.

Mandakini didn't have much to say.

'I have no grievances against you. You are an emperor while I am just a fisherman's daughter – a mute and deaf woman. I didn't want to come in front of you. That's why I have been hiding for many years. I satisfied myself by looking at you from afar. I am fortunate that when I am about to breathe my last, I find myself in your arms. What more do I need?'

Her eyes conveyed this message again and again to the emperor while her face glowed with happiness. She seemed to be beyond pain and didn't seem to notice that the spear was bleeding her out steadily. Her soul was ready to fly, so why would she worry about the cage where she was trapped?

Sundara Chola too seemed to have forgotten his disability and that's how he was able to get out of his bed and rush to the woman he had abandoned all those years ago.

But unlike Mandakini, Sundara Chola had much to tell her. Whatever he was telling her through his eyes, he reiterated them through his lips. The others in the room didn't understand what he was saying but Mandakini could comprehend them, and she acknowledged his words wherever she agreed with them and vociferously shook her head to protest when she disagreed with him, smiled at him serenely when she was happy with what he said and consoled him when he felt sad.

"My beloved, you are giving up your life for me. How long do you think I will live after you are gone? I am a stone-hearted man. I accept it. All those who are fated to rule a kingdom need to become stone-hearted. I abandoned you at Boodha Theevu and regretted it all my life. And because of that, I committed many other crimes. Do you remember how happy we were on that island? It was almost like a paradise. If only we could have stayed there forever...

“Fates conspired against me and so did my own relatives, courtiers, and friends. When they crowned me as the heir apparent, I came after you to Kodi Karai. I was told that you had jumped from the lighthouse and drowned in the sea. My own dear friend Anirudhan betrayed and lied to me. He later told me that someone had saved you after you had jumped into the sea. And though Anirudhan knew about this, he didn’t tell me. I thought you were really gone. And whenever I saw you after that, I thought I was seeing your ghost. I thought you had come back to haunt me and to make me feel guilty about abandoning me. I blamed you for trying to drown my dear son while you were the one who had saved his life. Aha! If only I had known earlier that you were still alive, things would have been so different. Do you really think I would have given you up for this kingdom? Never...”

Thus, Sundara Chola said many things and his lips mumbled all the unsaid words that he had locked in his heart for many years. He finally said, “Two days ago, when you came in front of me, I threw a lamp at you. And whenever I happened to see you, I acted as though I was disgusted by you. Forgive me for that. I was bitter. Your ‘ghost’ had tormented me for years. I have seen you many times in this very chamber and I thought you were cursing my children. And even seeing you in flesh and blood in front of me didn’t allay my doubts. You came here as a guardian deity to save me. I didn’t know this at that time. My daughter Kundavai tried to explain it to me, but I didn’t listen to her. Ayyo! How foolish can I be? Forgive me for everything!

“How can I express the love that I have for you in my heart? You told me that I should not anoint my son as the next emperor, and I can see that you were right. You said that because you wanted me to do the right thing. But the people here told me a lot of things and I couldn’t really believe it. They told me that you had given birth to a child. If that is true, tell me where he is. I will do whatever I can for him and repent for the sins that I committed against you.”

When Sundara Chola said that, Mandakini Devi stared at him for a while and then turned towards the prince, who immediately rushed

near them. Mandakini touched the prince's face and then turned towards his father to say, "This is my son."

She did this three or four times to make sure they understood and then closed her eyes. Moments later, her head slipped down from the emperor's lap and she breathed her last.

No one had ever seen the emperor sob so piteously ever or wail so loudly. They saw it today. The prince held his sorrow at bay and tried to console his father.

"Dear father, don't grieve for my mother's death. She didn't die, she turned into a goddess, and we will worship her thus."

But the emperor couldn't stop crying. Maybe, he instinctively knew that something more distressing and devastating was happening at the same time and his tears wouldn't stop.

The prince's words about Mandakini Devi becoming a Goddess were not mere words. Later in the future, when he ascended the throne as Raja Raja Cholan, he built a temple in Thanjavur in her memory as the 'Queen of Eezham.'

For many years, it was known as the 'Sinhala Nachiyar' Temple. With the passing of time, it became known as 'Singachiyar Temple' which still stands to this day in Thanjavur.

Chapter 31: The Time Has Come

If we were to conclude this story after the distressing events of yesterday, it would have been a fitting end. Many of the readers might have expected that. But unfortunately, we cannot do that. We have to narrate the tragic events that transpired in Kadambur around the same time – in fact, at the same hour.

Nandini was pacing across the floor in her chambers. Her agitated state of mind reflected in her nervous energy as she strode from one end to another. Her ears listened intently to the sound of footsteps while her lips were continuously intoning ‘the time has come.’ Her limbs were trembling as were her lips, while her eyes and eyebrows twitched with anticipation. Sometimes, her entire body would tremble with excitement and apprehension.

Nandini’s bed-chamber had a large bed which was fitted with curtains that hid it completely from outsiders. She moved towards it and parted a curtain. There, on the bed, lay the sword that she had been praying to. It was long and sharp and seemed to have a life of its own. Its edges gleamed in the light of the lamps and it seemed as though it was on fire. One would be surprised by the fact that it didn’t set the bed on fire.

Nandini held the sword near the lamp and examined it in its light carefully. And then she embraced it lovingly and kissed it passionately. And not just that, she also conversed with the sword.

“Heavenly sword! It’s time for you to show your prowess. You won’t fail me, will you? No. You won’t fail me. I fear that my own hands might fail me.” Then she looked at her hands and said, “Hands, will you stay steady and strong? But why are you shaking now? What will you do when the time comes?! No! No! there is no point in trusting you. I need to get another pair of hands!”

Suddenly, Nandini's body started trembling and she shook like she was possessed. She looked up the roof and said, "You have come! I am glad you came at the right time. Pandya's head! Why are you hovering near the roof? Come down here, my king, my love. There is no one here but me your slave. Why are you staring at me like this? Won't you say a word? Don't you remember that you told me that if I survived this, you would make me your queen? I never forgot your words, my love. Nor have I forgotten my promise to you. It's time for me to deliver on that promise. Do you know how long I waited for this moment, and the myriad roles that I had to play to get here? You do know what I have done, right? You were watching all the while. Watch me now with your unblinking eyes as I fulfil my promise to you. Will you leave me alone after that, or will you hover around me until I ascend the Pandya throne as you promised me once? Will you ever allow me to sleep? What do you say – that you will promise to leave me if I fulfil my promise to you? No! No! I don't want the crown or the throne. They brought a boy from somewhere, saying that he is your son. We have crowned him as the next emperor. You will be satisfied if I avenge your gory death and you will go to the warrior's heaven. There, you will find many women like me, and you will take one of them...What! Are you saying 'no'? Alright, we will debate this later. Someone is coming, my love, disappear for now and I will keep this sword aside."

Someone was indeed approaching her chamber. And just as she was placing the sword on the bed, Manimegalai came inside the room. Nandini looked up and said, "Is that you, Manimegalai? Come..."

Her voice was calm and gentle. Within a few seconds, she had undergone a transformation!

"Akka, what is this? You are forever keeping that sword in your hand!"

"What else to do? When men are such savage lecherous beasts, we have no option but to seek the protection of the sword!"

“Devi, I am ready to stand with you always. Don’t you have faith in me?”

“If I didn’t have faith in you, would I ever reveal my secrets to you? I trust only you completely, but you are powerless to stop your own brother...”

“Akka, I have decided. He is not my brother at all...”

“Why do you talk thus? He is your brother no matter...”

“What kind of brother is he? He is a self-centred man who is trying to force me to marry someone just so that I serve his purpose. If he was truly my brother, would he ever do that?”

“My dear sister, why do you say that? Maybe he is trying to get you married to the prince for your benefit?”

“He is not thinking about me or my preferences in this!”

“Really, do you think so? You would be the empress of a kingdom that stretches from Elangai to Vada Pennai. Wouldn’t a brother want his sister to be the empress of such a kingdom?”

“Not at all. He thinks he could wield power in the kingdom through my position. He is hoping to become the Prime Minister or Lord Treasurer, like your husband,” said Manimegalai and hesitated, “Akka...”

“What is it, Manimegalai? Why do you hesitate to say anything to me? You said you loved me a lot, didn’t you?”

“Akka, you don’t need to have doubts about that at all. In this world, there are only two people whom I love unconditionally. You are one of them!”

“And who is the other?”

“You know it yourself. Why do you ask?”

“My dear sister, I hope you are happy. Haven’t you heard in epics and stories that when a girl falls in love, she wants to talk about it to someone? That’s why we have close confidants and friends!”

“That is true, akka. You are that close friend to whom I can reveal my secrets. But I came here to tell you about something else. It is worrying news...”

Nandini was startled and asked, “What happened?”

She was now worried that there might be some hurdle or complication that might thwart her plans of revenge.

“Akka, I heard that Lord Treasurer Pazhuvetarayar has not reached Thanjavur. On the way...”

“What happened on the way? Is he returning to Kadambur?” asked Nandini with fear dripping from her voice.

“If he had returned, it would have been better. That day, when we were at the lake, the storm that struck us also blew across Kollidam River and his boat got stuck in it...”

“What happened to him?” asked Nandini. Her voice now didn’t have the fear it earlier had, but she seemed nonetheless worried.

“The boat capsized before it reached the other side.”

“Ayyo!”

“Those who survived and reached the other side and searched for him but didn’t find him!”

Manimegalai thought that Nandini would start crying after hearing this news and was poised to console her. But she was disappointed. Nandini didn’t cry; nor did she show any emotion. She instead asked, “Who told you all this?” in a disbelieving tone.

“One of the men who had gone with your husband has returned and he brought this news. My brother was wondering how to bring this news to you and was asking the prince about it. I thought it would be better if I bring this news to you instead,” saying thus, Manimegalai started sobbing. Nandini hugged her tightly and tried to console her saying, “My dear girl, I learned today how much love you bear in your heart for me. Don’t cry.”

Manimegalai looked at Nandini with surprise and she thought that Nandini was stone-hearted for not showing any emotions. Nandini realized this and said, “Dear sister, you came rushing here to console me, but here I had to comfort you. Don’t worry about Pazhuvetarayar, I am sure he is safe. If some danger befell him, I would immediately know about it. That’s why I am not worried about him. Tell me more about this in detail, I have another doubt in my heart!”

“What doubt, akka?”

“I am afraid that your brother and that Pallavan might try to harm my Lord Husband. What if they are preparing the ground and telling everyone that he was in a dangerous situation earlier so they could execute some devious plan later on?”

“I don’t understand, akka. Why would they want to cause harm to your husband?”

“You are but a mere child, Manimegalai. Didn’t I tell you earlier that your brother and that Pallavan have lecherous thoughts about me? Why do you think I always keep this sword next to me?”

“Yes, you told me. But please don’t call Kandanmaran my brother anymore. I have decided to sever ties with him... but even then, why should they cause harm to your husband?”

“Sister, can’t you understand their motives? They think that I will be pleased if they kill my husband, and I would be amenable to fulfilling their carnal desires. I had no inkling that your brother could

be so lecherous. If I had known, I would never have allowed him inside my palace and helped him heal.”

“Akka, I will henceforth not leave you alone even for a second. If either of those men come here, they will fall prey to this dagger!”

“Manimegalai, don’t worry about those two. I am not scared of their intentions. I can protect my honour and send them away with a lesson that they would never forget. It is the prince who is worrying me. But thanks to you, he is no longer a threat!”

“What do you mean by ‘thanks to you’?”

“The prince is attracted to you. Haven’t you noticed it, Manimegalai? Didn’t he stop the Vanar prince from nearing you and save you himself in the lake from the tiger? Even after that, I have been noticing his behaviour towards you. How come you didn’t know this?”

“Yes, I have noticed. But I fear the prince. My body starts trembling whenever he nears me. On top of that, that man who calls himself my brother is constantly at my back...”

“He wants you to marry the prince?”

“Yes, whenever he catches me alone, he starts lecturing me so much so that...”

“You want to marry the prince just so that you can stop him from lecturing you?”

“Even you have joined them...” said Manimegalai and started sobbing.

Nandini consoled her and said, “I just teased you, and here you are crying in earnest!” When Manimegalai’s tears reduced to whimpers, Nandini said, “My dear, search your heart and tell me...”

Don't you like the prince even a bit? Don't you wish to be the empress of this Chola Kingdom?"

"It doesn't matter how many times you ask me this question, akka. I have no such wish."

"Then, it is true that you have indeed lost your heart to Vandiya Devan!"

"Yes, akka. But I am not sure what he thinks..."

"It doesn't matter what he thinks. Only if he stays alive will you know about it..."

Shocked by her words Manimegalai asked, "What are you saying akka?"

"Manimegalai, you don't understand the truth yet. You are worried about me and my Lord Husband. But you don't have to be. You know how powerful my husband is. The emperor doesn't heed the words of his prime minister, advisors, or his own sons. Young men like your brother who dismiss my husband as an old man can't match his prowess. That's why I am not worried about him. My dear, I have been in many dangerous situations and can protect myself from the evil intentions of men. Truthfully, I am only worried about you. You have so much love and regard for me that I am anxious that no danger should befall you. When you entered this room a little while ago, I was thinking about it."

"Akka, I don't understand what you are saying. Why should I be in danger?"

"You innocent girl! Don't you realize that there is no great danger for a woman than being married to the wrong man?"

"That will never happen."

“Your brother has decided that you will be wed to the prince. Your father too has agreed to it!”

“What if they had agreed? What can they do if I do not agree to their scheme?”

“You are talking like a child now. You belong to a clan that serves the Cholas. Do you really think that your permission will be sought to get you married to the crown prince of the realm? And if the prince wishes to marry you, who indeed can stop him!”

“Why not? I will tell him the truth and stop him!”

“What will you tell him?”

“That I am not interested in marrying him!”

“If he asks you why?”

“I will tell the truth. I will tell him that I have lost my heart to his friend Vandiya Devan...”

“Stupid girl, you don’t have to tell them this. They already know the truth...”

“If they already know about it, then why are they insisting that I marry the prince? If they continue, I too have a dagger with me,” saying thus, Manimegalai removed a dagger that she had kept tucked in the sari folds around her waist.

“My dear sister! I don’t know whether to laugh or cry at your foolishness!”

“What did I say?”

“You think that they will insist that you marry the prince by pressurizing you? They won’t do that. instead, they will remove the obstacle that is preventing you from yielding to their wishes!”

“What are you saying, akka?”

“I am saying that the man to whom you have lost your heart is in danger!”

“Ayyo!”

“Your brother hates him already. Vandiya Devar has told the prince about the secret meeting that happened here a few months ago. On top of that, he believes that Vandiya Devar tried to stab him in the back. That Pallavan, too, is angry with him....”

“What if they are angry with him? How can it affect him? He is a great warrior too!”

“So what if he is a great warrior? If he is surrounded by these murderers suddenly, how long can he struggle?”

“Ayyo, are you saying that they will murder him?”

“Not just murder him, they will make sure he is dismembered and fed to dogs and wolves!”

“Oh my god! That’s horrifying!”

“If you find it horrifying to listen, what will you do when they actually do it?”

“Akka, my heart trembles even to hear this. Do you really think they would dare to do such a thing? Is he not the prince’s close friend and confidante?”

“Have you not heard that people often turn against their close friends when their mind is poisoned? That’s what your brother and that Pallavan have done. They have turned the prince against him...”

“Scoundrels! But how do you know all this?”

“Today morning, that Pallavan came here to take his leave...”

“Where is that wretch going?”

“Not very far. Didn’t you hear that Thirukkoyalur Malayaman is gathering a huge army and is on his way here?”

“Yes, I heard that. But I was wondering why he is coming!”

“You are the reason. Today, the prince said, ‘if you don’t marry Manimegalai to me, I will get Malayaman’s army to raze this palace to the dust!’”. That’s when your brother said, ‘we have no objections, but it’s your friend who stands as a hurdle!’ The prince then said, ‘Can’t you take care of this hurdle?’ To this, your lovely brother said, ‘Yes, we can take care, provided you agree to it!’

“I spoke at length with that Pallavan to know more about what had happened at the meeting. For sure, your lover’s life is in danger, and only you can do something to help him or else you will be widowed even before you wed him!”

Hearing this, Manimegalai trembled with fear and worry gnawed her heart.

“Ayyo, I need to warn him somehow!”

“You could try it, but you just said he is a great warrior. Do you really think that he would heed your words and leave?”

“Only you can help me. I can’t think clearly. Tell me how I can save his life.”

“I was thinking about this when you came here but even, I was confused and didn’t know what to do. Thankfully, we can use the news that you got to our advantage...”

“The news that I got? What news?”

“You said my husband’s boat capsized and that he is not found yet.”

“Yes...”

“I will request Vandiya Devar to go and learn about my husband’s fate. Even you ask this for me. He won’t be able to reject a request from two women. I think that the only way to save him now would be to get him out of this palace. After he leaves, you can speak to your brother and father without fearing any consequences and tell them that you love another person and cannot marry the prince. I will also put in a word and tell the prince that he would taint his clan’s reputation by forcing an unwilling girl to marry him...”

“And if they don’t listen to you, I still have a dagger in my hand!”

“Alright! You do know where he is, right? Go to him immediately. If that is not possible, send your maid or that Edupankari. We need to get him out of the palace immediately!”

“Even if he agrees to leave the palace, what if he is stopped by my brother?”

“Why should your brother know of this? We can send him out through the same underground passage using which he came inside the palace earlier. Go fast, sister. The longer he stays here, the more he is courting danger. Your brother can get him murdered anytime.”

“I will go now. I will somehow convince him and bring him here!”

After Manimegalai left, the secret door that led to the underground passage opened and a beastly face was seen. It was the Mandiravadi.

“Ravidasa! Are you back?”

“Yes, I am back, and the time for our revenge is at hand!”

Chapter 32: The Last Stage

Nandini bolted the main door that led into her chambers, took a lighted lamp, and went inside the secret Hunters' Chambers that adjoined her room.

Mandiravadi stood there, waiting there for her. Ravidasan already possessed a frightful face. And now he sported many wounds and bruises that made him look more hideous than ever.

Startled by this, Nandini asked, "Mandiravadi, what is this? How did you get all these injuries?"

"Queen, why are you so surprised? Did you perchance imagine that we live in comforts and sleep on soft beds and partake in delicious meals? It is indeed a miracle that Parameshwaran and I escaped with her our lives. Truly, our emperor's benevolent ghost kept watch over us and saved our lives."

"No... his ghost always keeps me company. Even an hour ago, it was here asking me if I would fulfil my vow and avenge his death!"

"Queen, what did you tell him?"

"I told him that either I would avenge his death today or else die trying!"

"Then, it is good that we came rushing here despite the hurdles. We waited so long, but for what? What's the use of you dying? Our primary objective must be to eliminate our enemy. If you think, you cannot go through it..."

"Who said I cannot do it? I will fulfil my vow and then I will give up my life!"

“No! No! there are many things to accomplish after you fulfil the vow. We need to publicly crown Veera Pandyan’s heir in Madurai...”

“I think you can take care of all that. Tonight, we will fulfil our vow. And with that, my life in this world will end!”

“Queen, we need to carry the treasures that lie in the underground treasure chamber to the Pandya Kingdom. I need your help to do that!”

“Do you want me to deceive my husband even after I fulfil the vow?”

“Devi, who is your husband?”

“The man who married me braving the jeers of the world. The man who has so far fulfilled even my most flippant wish.

“Devi, Pazhuvetarayar is not your husband. Every night, Veera Pandiyar comes in my dreams and tells me that you are his consort and that I should treat you like the empress!”

“Ravidasa, let’s not talk about him. You didn’t tell me how you got all these injuries!”

“Last night, when we were in the woods of Kollidam, an old tiger attacked us. Though it was old, its claws and teeth were sharp!”

“How did you escape?”

“Do you remember the Pallipadai where we crowned the Pandya prince? We pushed the dilapidated roof on the head of the tiger and escaped.”

“That’s unfortunate. You can’t face even an old tiger and win it!”

“We accept our shortcomings, Devi. That’s why we didn’t dare confront a young tiger like Aditya Karikalan and had to resort to trickery and scheming. Devi, if we miss our opportunity tonight, we

will not get another. If Karikalan gets news about his brother and his father, he will be alerted to our attempts!”

“Mandiravadi, what about the emperor and the young prince? Did you get any definite news?”

“I am sure they must have been eliminated by now!”

“When you went to Elangai, you and Devaralan said the same thing...”

“At Elangai, we were followed by that mad mute woman who was saving the prince. That’s why we couldn’t kill him there!”

“You said that the Vanar prince died in the sea, but he too came back unscathed!”

“We got a chance to finish him off at the Pallipadai forest, but you stopped us!”

“There is an important reason for that...”

“We don’t know what that reason is... but after escaping us from there, he has been guarding the prince like armour!”

“You don’t have to worry about him now.”

“We don’t have a choice but to worry. If we lose this opportunity today, then we will not get another. Devi, what arrangements have you made? What should we do?”

“Right now, if none of you come here and disturbs me, it would be of great help!”

“We cannot do that...”

“Don’t you trust me?”

“We are here because we completely trust you. We want to take you away from here immediately after you fulfil the vow. We will help you overcome any obstacles. You just have to summon us, and we will be there!”

“I don’t think there are any hurdles in my plan, and I do not wish to live after I fulfil my vow!”

“No!! You will need to accompany us.”

“Mandiravadi, I will not live in Pazhuvetarayar’s palace even for a minute after I fulfil my vow...”

“Then, you should come along with us!”

“How will you take me away?”

“This underground passage leads to an Ayyanar temple, and we have the Pazhuvur Queen’s Palanquin waiting there. Edupankari brought it out of the palace saying that it needs to be repaired. We will carry the ‘Devi’ who helped us fulfil our oath to avenge the prince who ingloriously beheaded our king!”

“How many of you are here?”

“Four of us are waiting here,” said Ravidasan. He clapped his hands and the men revealed themselves from behind the stuffed dead animals that were kept there.

“Where is Parameshwaran?” asked Nandini.

“I have stationed him at the Ayyanar temple. We found a Kalamugan there, meditating, who we had to drive away. I have asked him to stay there on the lookout to make sure he didn’t return!”

“Why are we so worried about the Kalamugan? Shouldn’t we worry about Periya Pazhuvetarayar? Have you heard the news?”

Ravidasan got startled and asked her, “What news?”

“When he left Kadambur to go to Thanjavur, his boat capsized in Kollidam when the storm struck. Those who survived searched for him in vain, and haven’t found any trace of him yet. One of the men who survived came here to inform Sambuvarayar about this mishap!”

“My god! So, this was his fate! Why didn’t you tell me this important news first?”

“I don’t believe it, Mandiravadi. I don’t think Pazhuvetarayar died by drowning in the Kollidam River.”

“I don’t believe it either, Devi.”

“What if he survives and comes ashore on this side? What if he comes back here tonight? What do we do then?”

“Devi, don’t worry about it. I remember now. I saw a tall man walking on the royal road that led to Thanjavur. He seemed dishevelled and his clothes were torn and dirty. Since it was dark, we couldn’t identify who it was. Now when I think back, I think that man might be Periya Pazhuvetarayar.”

“Then you are certain that he won’t come back here tonight?”

“I am certain he won’t come here. Now, what do you want us to do?”

“Mandiravadi, I want you to wait here. No matter who comes to my chambers or how many voices you hear, you are not to enter. If you do, our mission can’t be fulfilled. I will summon you when my vow is fulfilled. And then you can come!”

“Devi, how will you summon us?”

“Mandiravadi, it’s been many years since I laughed out loud. You wouldn’t have ever heard me laughing...”

“I heard you laughing only once. When that wicked young man Vandiya Devan met you for the first time!”

“Aha! You still remember that incident. Good! Today, when I laugh uproariously like that, it means I have completed my mission and you can come inside the chambers through the secret entrance. But remember, now when I meet Vandiya Devan, I might laugh again, think nothing of it!”

“Devi, I am not able to discern what your intentions are...”

“If you wait a while, you will understand everything. If by chance, there is some hurdle, you will hear me crying and you will need to come immediately!”

“Alright, Devi. But we do not wish to hear you crying. We want to hear you laughing!”

Chapter 33: Oh God! Ghost

Almost about the same time, Vandiya Devan found himself in the palace gardens of Kadambur. It was a beautiful place with flowers blooming all over and the heady scent of jasmine and parijatham^[12] gave the gardens an ethereal feel. The cool breeze that blew across the garden carried the scents of the flowers, making Vandiya Devan long thus, “If only this was the Pazhaiarai gardens and if only I could hear the tinkling sounds of Kundavai’s anklets. My fate is indeed cruel to be stuck like this at Kadambur palace and along with a mad prince!”

That evening, the prince had turned on him viciously and said, “I don’t want to see your face ever. I will decide your fate tomorrow. Leave now.”

The prince’s words had hurt him because this was the first time the prince had spoken thus to him.

But it was no use blaming the prince. His mind was wavering wildly, and he alternated between sorrow, mad fury, sudden enmity, and rare friendliness. His changing behaviour made it impossible for anyone to have a normal conversation with him and his companions didn’t know to manage him.

The reason for the unusually mad behaviour from this prince was the news that they had been getting right from the morning. Sambuvarayar came to him with the news that Malayaman was coming to Kadambur with his huge army and to lodge his complaints about the old man’s behaviour and mistrust.

“Malayaman is a doddering old man. He is more than eighty years old. Why are you scared of his arrival?”

“Prince, we belong to Kolli Malai Val Vil Orri’s clan. We know not what fear is. I am hesitating because of your presence. If you

agree...”

“You will take your forces to fight my grandsire... isn’t that so? Sambuvararayey! It was ‘I’ who asked him to bring his army here!”

“But why?”

“You have me here at your mercy. What if something were to happen to me? What then?”

“My prince, if you are harbouring this suspicion within your heart, then I will...”

“Then, you are saying I should leave this palace immediately...”

“Ayya, this is your kingdom. This is your palace. At the top of it, you will find the tiger flag flying high. Who am I to ask you to leave? My family and I will leave the palace. You and Malayaman can stay here without any concerns for your safety!”

“Is that so? You are insinuating that those from the Val Vil Orri’s clan are fearless while those from the clan of Vijayalaya Chola are cowards!”

“Who doesn’t know of your glorious deeds and the bravery?! Didn’t you enter the battlefield at the tender age of twelve and vanquish the enemy? Don’t we know how you chased Veera Pandyan and beheaded him when you were eighteen?”

Hearing this, Karikalan said, “Ayya! I know what you are trying to say. You are saying that I chased a man who was running away from the battlefield and beheaded him. You are mocking me, aren’t you? That seductive Pazhuvur ghost is behind all this. It is she who is spreading such vile rumours!” And he laughed out aloud.

Sambuvarayar berated himself for even talking to the prince in the first place.

“My prince, no matter what I say, you interpret it differently. I will not say anything anymore. You can do whatever you feel is appropriate, I will take your leave!”

“You can take my leave, but remember one thing. You are not to leave this palace for any reason. I will not allow you to. Until I understand your reasons for participating in the conspiracy that you hatched in this palace against me, four months ago, I will not leave this place and nor will I allow you to leave!”

Sambuvarayar looked at the prince with his lips trembling. His body was trembling with anger and his eyes were filled with tears.

Seeing this, Parthibendra Pallavan sought to calm things down. He said, “My prince, just as the Cholas are well known for their bravery, they are also acknowledged as fair and just rulers. You are not being fair to the king of Kolli Malai. You have hurt the sensibilities of this old man. He has already given you the justification and explanation for the midnight conference that happened here four months ago, and you agreed, too. The chieftains and kings came together to discuss who should succeed to the throne, only because you have been refusing to go to Thanjavur for the past three years. If you agree to take over the reins of the kingdom, why would these kings look for another heir? Do you really think they would select someone who has never seen a battlefield in his entire life over someone like you?”

Hearing this, the prince said, “That is true. It would indeed be difficult to select another heir when I am still alive. That’s why they want to kill me here,” and he laughed uproariously.

“Parthibendra! Don’t I know that you too have joined forces with these people? That day in the forest, don’t I know that you and Kandanmaran were right behind me, aiming the spear at my back? Thankfully my only true friend Vandiya Devan was right beside me, or else you might have killed me long ago!”

Parthibendran shot a murderous glance at Vandiya Devan and said, "Ayya, this scoundrel has poisoned your heart against me. If you think that I might betray our friendship and cause you harm, that second, I will..."

"Pallava, how can I prove the treason that you bear in your heart? Answer my question first. You and Kandanmaran invited me to this palace only because of that Pazhuvur queen. Will you deny the truth?"

"Prince, there is no cause to deny it. Yes, we did invite you here because of the good intentions that the Pazhuvur Queen bears in her heart. She wanted us to bring you here because she wanted to wed Kandanmaran's sister to you and save this kingdom from fratricidal strife. Nothing would give us more pleasure than to see you ascend the ancient throne of the Cholas. By all means, go ahead and accuse me of anything as you see fit, but I will not tolerate it if you blame the Pazhuvur queen. I will slay anyone who does that right here with this sword of mine," saying thus Parthibendran drew his sword dramatically.

At that, Kandanmaran entered the room saying, "I can respond to that!"

"My prince, I have brought happy news for you. Ponniyin Selvar is alive. He survived the storm and has been staying at the Nagapattinam Choodamani Viharam. Due to the storm that raged there, he had to emerge from his hiding place. We heard that thousands of people are now bringing him to Thanjavur in a huge procession!"

Kandanmaran thought that the prince would be happy and cheerful to hear this news, but he was disappointed when Karikalan's ire turned somewhere else.

"What! Arulmozhi is going to Thanjavur! That too with thousands of people! Vallavareya! You said that he won't emerge out of the

Viharam until I say so. Now, what's happening here? Why is he going to Thanjavur?"

Vandiya Devan interjected and said, "Ayya, that's the assurance Princess Kundavai gave me. But I don't know if the circumstances changed later. If you wish, I can go to and..."

"Aha! So you too will leave me! That's good! Everyone has turned against me. I know why Arulmozhi is going towards Thanjavur. We can thank Kodumbalur Vellar for that. He wants to get his niece married to him and wants to crown him as the next emperor. I also heard that Kodumbalur Vellar is approaching Thanjavur with his huge army. I think even my sister is complicit in this plot. Even you are involved in this, as well..."

Vandiya Devan then said, "Prince, forgive me. Neither Princess Kundavai nor Prince Arulmozhi entertain such thoughts. If you so wish, I can go and learn the truth behind these events..."

"Oh yes, you naturally want to leave me and join them in their plot. Kandanmara, throw him into your most secure underground prison in this palace," said Karikalan.

But when he noticed that Kandanmaran was approaching Vandiya Devan with a gleeful expression, he changed his order and said, "No, don't. We the Cholas do not punish someone until their crime is proven. Vallavareya! I don't wish to see your face today. That's your punishment. I will decide whether to send you to Thanjavur or the prison tomorrow. Now, don't stand in front of me, leave immediately!"

When Vandiya Devan looked at the prince, he signalled with his eyes to indicate that all this was just a game and that he was not banishing him for real. But our hero felt that he needed some space away from the maddened prince. He bowed his head and said, "As you wish, my prince," and he withdrew.

Later that evening, Vandiya Devan learned that Sambuvarayar and Parthibendran left the palace to meet Thirukkovalur Malayaman and invite him to the palace. He also learned that the prince and Parthibendran were closeted for long in their chambers discussing something in confidence. Vandiya Devan felt extremely depressed by the turn of events. He wondered what the prince will tell him the next day.

Will he ask him to go to Thanjavur or to Pazhaiarai? If only he could send him back to Pazhaiarai, it would be so good!

He hated living in Kadambur. Here, people lived as though they had lost something vital in their life. There was no laughter, merriment, or enjoyment in anything. Come dusk, the palace did not even look as though it was fit for people to live. It resembled abandoned palaces where ghosts and ghouls haunted.

When will I leave this place behind?

Just when he thought this, a woman's voice wailed loudly, "Ayyo! Ghost!"

Chapter 34: Please Leave....

When Vandiya Devan heard a woman's voice screaming 'Ayyo! Ghost!' he immediately started running towards the sound. On his way, he realized that the voice belonged to Manimegalai, which made him wonder what could have scared her so. He could discern real fear and horror in that scream. And if one were to conclude there was no such thing as ghosts, then the question of what could have scared her so much remained to be answered.

If I were to approach her, will I get into trouble? Her brother is looking for an opportunity to get rid of me. Aditya Karikalar is maddened and God knows what that Pazhuvur Queen has planned in her scheming heart.

With his heart troubled, he didn't really notice where he was going. He slipped on the root of a tree and fell. His upper garment got caught in the shrub nearby. He sat up gingerly and tried to remove it from the thorny bush, startled that the tree had accomplished what many in their life could not.

Just then he heard another voice calling out, "Amma! Amma! Where are you?"

It belonged to Chandramathi, Manimegalai's maid.

Manimegalai replied to her, "I am here by the lily pond. Come here fast!"

Vandiya Devan could hear the jingling of the anklets that Chandramathi wore. The lily pond that Manimegalai had mentioned was at the centre of the palace garden. The pond was shaped like a lily flower and a few lilies grew there. He must have fallen somewhere near the pond. Since it was already dark, they hadn't noticed him or they might have laughed at his foolishness. Now that Manimegalai had Chandramathi to give her company, so he need

not linger there. Thinking thus, he wanted to silently slip away from there.

Before he could leave, he heard their conversation as well.

“Amma, why did you scream so loudly?” asked Chandramathi.

“Look at that wall. I thought I saw something or someone on it. It had matted locks and a long, flowing beard. And on his neck, I saw a garland of skulls! It was a horrifying sight! It vanished after I shouted!”

“I think you are seeing things, princess. There is no ghost or ghou here. Moreover, no one can scale the palace walls. They are built so high!”

“No! I am not seeing things. If I did see things, I won’t be seeing this...”

“For sure, you will be seeing a handsome face that can only be compared to Manmadhan^[13]!”

“Chi! Will you mock me even now?”

“When should I mock you then? It’s a beautiful evening. The flowers are blooming everywhere, and you are near the lovely lily pond, waiting for your handsome prince and instead, a ghost comes with an overflowing beard and moustache!”

“And if that were not enough, even you have come here!”

“Maybe that ghost ran away after seeing me. Indeed, which ghost will linger around when Kadambur Palace maid Chandramathi is around?”

“Chandramathi, I am not joking. I really saw a horrifying man on the top of the palace wall. It doesn’t matter if you don’t believe me. What happened to the task I gave you?”

“I couldn’t finish it, Princess...”

“Why?”

“I only saw the Kanchi prince and the Kadambur prince in the council room. The Vanar prince is nowhere to be seen.”

“Do you think they might have sent him somewhere?”

“I don’t think so. Your father and the Pallava prince have gone to meet Malayaman. I checked with Edupankari and found that Karikalar had shouted at the Vanar Prince...”

“I think he has gone mad. He seems to be shouting at everyone...”

“The prince apparently said, ‘Don’t show your face to me again today. Come tomorrow...’”

“Then where do you think he might have gone?” asked Manimegalai.

“He might be roaming somewhere within these palace grounds. Maybe it was him, wearing a disguise and trying to scare you...”

“No. I know that many people in this palace are wearing a disguise, but not him. He doesn’t deceive people...”

“This is how foolish women like us get trapped in the love of these men!”

“Be that as it may, I want to go and search for him again. He must be somewhere here. Take Edupankari’s help if needed...”

“Princess, I don’t like that Edupankari. The way he stares at me is very creepy and I am a bit frightened of him.”

“Didn’t you just say that you are not afraid of ghosts and ghouls? And now you are saying that you fear Edupankari. No matter... don’t

tell him anything. You go and search for him yourself.”

“Until then...”

“Until then, I will stay here...”

“What if that ghost returns?”

“Then I will take your name and drive him away!”

After this conversation, Vandiya Devan could hear Chandramathi leaving. The conversation that he heard made him think about many things. He wondered who that ghost could be. Azhwarkadiyan Nambi had earlier donned a similar disguise and had come in search of him once.

Could it be him, he wondered. Did he perchance arrive from Thanjavur with an important message for him? Did he wear this disguise so that no one in Kadambur would recognize him?

Why is Manimegalai so eager to meet him? Why would she send her maid to search for him?

He was aware of her feelings for him. That was why he studiously avoided going anywhere near her. He didn't want to anger her brother further. But Manimegalai waiting for him in the palace garden meant something serious was afoot. If she didn't have something of import to tell him, she would not risk her brother's ire and her father's anger thus.

Could she be in danger? Maybe Nandini had sent her with a message for him? My god! Manimegalai was so right when she said that the people in Kadambur palace wore lots of disguises and hid venomous things in their hearts. God knows how that Pazhuvur queen wants to use this innocent girl. Maybe this girl has realized that woman's evil intentions! Maybe she wants my help to save her from some danger?

Vandiya Devan remembered how Manimegalai helped him once before. And if she were seeking his help then, he would be bound by gratitude to aid her. Either way, now was the right time to approach her.

Who knows? Maybe she could help him escape this palace. Let me go to her and ask her why she seeks me.

Manimegalai was sitting placidly on a glazed seat placed near the lily pond. The sky was strewn with stars, and their reflection could be seen on the pond. Dense trees surrounded the pond and the heady scent of night blossoming flowers added fragrance to the beautiful scenery.

Hearing footsteps behind her, Manimegalai stood up, startled, and would have fallen into the pond. Vandiya Devan, who had approached her fast, instinctively held her and moved her away from the pond.

“Princess, it’s me,” he said.

Shy that he was holding her so close, she naturally tried to free herself from his grip but couldn’t. In the resultant struggle, it looked as though she would fall into the pond. He held her closer and tried to steady her.

Manimegalai struggled a bit more and then shook his hands off, saying, “Don’t touch me. Leave me be!”

Vandiya Devan moved away from her and said, “Forgive me, Princess!”

Manimegalai, who was yet to recover from his touch, said, “Why should I forgive you?”

“For startling you by appearing so suddenly!”

“Why did you grab me like this?”

“So that you don’t fall into the pond!”

“How nice! You didn’t bother to save me when I fell in the lake, but you spring into action to save me from a pond which is hardly knee deep!”

“That was my mistake...”

“You didn’t do anything. The mistake is mine.”

“Why do you say that? I think you are speaking thus because you are angry with me about something?”

“That day, you came into the room through the hunters’ chambers and startled me. I should have raised an alarm that day and should have told my father about you.”

“You saved me from a grave danger that day. I am forever in your debt...”

“I will never forget the way you are trying to repay that debt. I have never seen such ingratitude ever in my life...”

“Princess, your accusation is unwarranted. How did you decide I have no gratitude?”

“You told me that day that some murderers were after you. I went to the hunters’ chambers to check, but you left me without taking my leave, like a thief...”

“You are saying that I escaped from here like a thief...”

“Not like a thief. I think you were the thief.”

“Princess, you know not the kind of danger I faced that day...”

“No one is stopping you from telling me about it.”

“I escaped that day because your maid Chandramathi was coming through the main entrance. I hid in the music room and found that there was a door from there that led to the terrace. I wanted to stay hidden from her eyes, and inadvertently found an escape route.”

“Yes, then you vanished without a trace.”

“I didn’t vanish. I ran through the terrace and jumped over the palace walls. That day, if I had been caught, my mission would have been ruined and you would have gotten a good scolding from everyone!”

“My god, you are so worried about me!”

“You are right. I am worried about you...”

“Then why didn’t you tell me all this before? You have been here for many days...”

“I was looking for the right time.”

“Why do you lie thus? You haven’t so much looked at me ever since you came here...”

“Sister...”

“I am not your sister...”

“You are the sister of my friend, Kandanmaran, therefore you are like my sister.”

“Kandanmaran is not my brother, nor is he your friend. He is our enemy!”

“Princess, you know the truth of it. Until a few days ago, Kandanmaran was my good friend. And now he has become my sworn enemy. Parthibendran is on the lookout to get rid of me for good. Prince Aditya Karikalar keeps changing his behaviour all the time, swinging between friendship and enmity. I know not what

danger I will face the next minute. That's why I haven't approached you to express my gratitude."

"Ayya, I am glad that you are so keen on self-preservation."

"Princess, I don't really care for my life. I don't want you to court danger because of me. That's what worries me."

"Oh yes, you are indeed worried about me. My god! Chandramathi would often tell me that men are scheming scoundrels. You just proved her words true..."

"I don't care about what she says. The truth is that I will not forget you, nor will I forget the help you rendered the other day."

Manimegalai thought about what he said for a while and then said, "Ayya! Can you repeat what you said just now?"

"If you want, I can repeat it a thousand times more. Until there is life in this body, I will never forget the help that you gave me that day," said Vandiya Devan.

"No matter how many times you repeat that you can fulfil this resolution only if there is life in your body."

"Princess, what do you think I should do then?"

"You should try and save your life. If not for your sake, then at least for mine!"

"Princess! What are you saying..."

"Ayya, tell me the truth. A few moments ago, didn't you hear the conversation that I was having with my maid?"

"Forgive me, princess. I came running towards you when I heard you shouting. By then Chandramathi had come and I inadvertently heard your conversation..."

“I sent her to search for your whereabouts and to bring you to me!”

“I heard that. That’s why I approached you...”

“How nice? Or else why would you come near me anyway! But I am not so stone-hearted. I still wanted to help you. I couldn’t sit still and allow you to court danger.”

“Princess, I do realize my dangerous situation. Do you think I am facing any new danger that I know nothing about?”

“Ayya, I want you to leave this palace immediately...”

“You want me to run away from danger?”

“One should not run away from the battlefield. But there is no shame in running away from those who conspire behind your back!”

“Who is conspiring behind my back?”

“Who else? Kandanmaran and Parthibendran...”

“Why should I fear them and run away?”

“I cannot sit by quietly and watch my brother cause you harm.”

“Princess, how can you claim responsibility for Kandanmaran’s actions?”

“What if they wish to cause you harm because of me?”

“If I were to suffer on your behalf, I will consider myself fortunate. It is an opportunity to express my gratitude for the help you rendered me.”

“Nandini Devi was right after all!”

“Aha! What did the Pazhuvur Queen say to you?”

“She told me that you wouldn’t listen to reason if I requested you to save yourself and that I should think of something else. Ayya, will you come with me? The Pazhuvur Queen has an urgent task for you and wishes to speak to you.”

“You do know what that urgent task is, right?”

“Yes. We heard that Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s boat capsized in Kollidam River in the storm...”

“Yes, I heard that too!”

“Nandini Devi wants you to go and find the truth about this.”

Vandiya Devan thought about this request and asked, “Didn’t the Pazhuvur Queen tell you not to mention this to me before you took me in her presence?”

“Yes.”

“Then why did you mention this to me now?”

“I am very confused. Until a few days ago, I had no such confusion. I had no doubts or suspicions. Now that’s not so. I suspect everyone and everything...”

“Looks like things have come to this end right from the time you met me.”

“In a way, you are right. When the Pazhuvur Queen asked me to bring you to her, I had no doubts about it but after I left her presence, I had many that make me suspect her motivations...”

“What doubts did you have, Princess?”

“I suspect that even she wishes to harm you...”

“Why do you think thus? Why would she want to harm me?”

“I don’t know the answer, but her behaviour has become suspicious with every passing day. I see her often with a long sword and I heard her speaking to it as well...”

“I do not fear the sword that a woman wields. What is more dangerous...”

“...are the eyes of a woman that are sharper than a sword? Yes. That’s what all men say. Ayya, I am not asking you to fear just the sword. Do you remember the first time you came into the room through the hunters’ chambers?”

“I remember it well!”

“You said you were pursued by murderers and I went into the hunters’ chambers to check the truth. There I found some men hiding behind the stuffed animals. At that time, I couldn’t discern if they had come chasing after you or if you had brought them there. And I couldn’t report that to anyone because that would mean revealing information about you...”

“I just now realise how much you have helped me!”

“I didn’t tell you all this to remind you of that. When I was with Nandini Devi earlier, she asked me to bring you to her. But after I left her presence, I had a doubt and returned to her chambers, but she had bolted the door from inside. But I could hear her talking to someone. I fear that some men are waiting inside the hunters’ chambers, and they have some connection to the Pazhuvur Queen.”

That’s when Vandiya Devan realized what Manimegalai was trying to tell him. His instincts had long been telling him that something dangerous would happen soon, and Manimegalai’s suspicions about Nandini and the fact that her men were hiding in the hunters’ chambers proved that his instincts were right.

“Princess, I need your help!”

“Tell me what you need.”

“Princess, there is a way that leads inside the palace through the hunters’ chambers that goes straight to Nandini’s room. There is another way that leads to that underground passage, right?”

“Yes, there is a way that the servants use. Whenever guests come to our palace, my father takes them through that passage.”

“Princess, can you take me to the hunters’ chambers through that passage?”

“Why?”

“I want to find out who are the people that are hiding there, and learn why they have come!”

“I came here so that I could help you escape from danger, but here you are, asking me to lead you there.”

“I am armed with a sword, princess. And I think that it is best to confront the danger that we know is present rather than wait for it to strike us. I would rather face what’s waiting for me.”

“If you agree to my condition, I will take you there!”

“What condition?”

“I will come with you, too. I too am armed with this dagger!” said Manimegalai and showed her dagger.

Vandiya Devan agreed to her condition and they left the palace gardens and walked towards the hidden passageway. She led him through an isolated portion of the palace and came upon a closed door. She made him wait there and brought a lamp. When she opened the door, steps could be seen going down to a narrow passageway. They both walked down the steps.

Suddenly, Manimegalai stopped and whispered, “Wait! I can hear footsteps! Do you hear them too?”

Chapter 35: Monkey's Grip

Vandiya Devan listened carefully. He could hear the footsteps, too. Sometimes, it felt as though they were coming near to where he and Manimegalai were standing. And to other times, they receded. After listening intently for some time, he could hear them retreating.

"Ayya, do you really want to go forward? Don't you think it's better if we leave?"

"Princess, I do not retreat from any course of action that I take..."

"Then you really do have a monkey's grip!"

"Don't you remember how your maid Chandramathi spoke about my monkey face? Well, my grip should match my face!"

Vandiya Devan, who was behind Manimegalai until then, now tried to come in front of her. And Manimegalai, who was not expecting that, bumped into him and dropped the lamp that she was holding. The lamp fell down a few steps before them and extinguished, leaving them enveloped in darkness.

"Princess, what have you done?"

"Why did you try to go ahead of me?"

"In times of danger, I am not in the habit of placing women before me."

"If you could tell me all your habits and behaviours, it would be easy for me to act accordingly!"

"I will surely tell you, princess, when I get the time!"

"Why don't you tell me now? Come, let's go back to the gardens where we can sit and talk..."

“If you are scared of the dark, why don’t you return to the palace?”

“When I have the company of a warrior like you, why would I be scared?”

“Then come on, let’s go. What’s the use of standing here?”

Saying thus, Vandiya Devan tried to go ahead, but he lost his footing and almost fell. Manimegalai held him tight and steadied him on his feet.

“Ayya, I know this path well. There are many steep steps and narrow passageways. I have been through this pathway many times, and I know where to turn, slow down and when to move carefully. So even if you are a great warrior, you will need to hold my hand and follow my lead. If insist on leading the way, you will not reach the hunters’ chambers. You will fall somewhere and break your leg!”

“As the princess commands,” said Vandiya Devan.

In the darkness that surrounded them, Manimegalai clutched Vandiya Devan’s stone-cold hand and moved ahead. She wondered, ‘he is not scared of murderers and enemies but looks like he is scared of holding my hand!’

They moved slowly in the dark passageway that seemed to stretch endlessly in front of them.

“The way to hell is probably like this, with nary a light!” he said.

“Oh! Then you have already been to hell and have returned?”

“I haven’t been to hell or heaven, but I have heard my elders say thus!”

“And their elders must have told them so as well...”

Vandiya Devan couldn't help but wonder how Manimegalai, who was painfully shy once, had become bold and conversant.

"The way to hell will be dark, but what will the path to heaven look like?"

"It will be resplendent with lights. There will be the brilliance of crores of suns!"

"If that is so, then I would prefer to go to hell. If one sun is enough to blind you, then can you imagine what crores of suns will do."

"Even then, you will finally end up in hell if you take that path."

"If a warrior like you accompanies me, who knows I might end up in heaven instead of hell..."

"And if I go along the path holding a princess's hand like yourself, even hell might seem like heaven," said Vandiya Devan, and then immediately bit his lips for having said something that this girl might misconstrue.

"Your hand is stone-cold, and it doesn't seem as though you are on your way to heaven but to a murderer's den."

"Princess, you are probably right. Who knows, we may end up in a murderer's den at the end of this path..."

"It was you who said, 'I do not retreat from any course of action that I take.' Who knows how many murderers might lay waiting for us at the hunters' chambers?!"

"I don't care about how many murderers we will find there. I can take care of them. What if Kandanmaran were to see us now, hand in hand, walking thus in the dark? That's what worries me!"

"Ayya, until I am alive, my brother cannot cause you any harm. One half of my dream has come true... and who knows, maybe the other half too might come true!"

Just then they heard a door being locked. Startled, they stood still and then Manimegalai whispered, “We are near the hunters’ chambers!”

Just then, they could see a faint light moving toward them. And soon, the light became brighter. Manimegalai immediately shrugged Vandiya Devan’s hand off and stood away from him. The next instant, they saw Edupankari with a lamp in one hand and a large, twisted blade in the other. When he saw them together, he acted as though he was surprised beyond words, but his playacting didn’t fool the hero and his companion.

“Amma, Ayya, why are you here alone in this darkness? If you had only commanded, this slave would have brought a lamp! Where are you going?”

“Edupankari! Malayaman’s forces are on their way to Kadambur. That’s why I set out with Prince of Vallam to check if the palace gates and the underground passages are secure and locked.”

“This is surprising indeed! Even I was checking the same thing.”

“The lamp that we brought fell and was extinguished. I saw some light around here and thought it might be you...”

“The young master asked me to check if the underground passage is locked properly and it is. Come, Devi, let’s leave now.”

“You can give the lamp in your hand and go. I am taking this prince to the hunters’ chamber and getting him a spear. He lost his spear in the Kollidam floods. Who knows, we may have to fight the Malayaman forces...”

“Yes, Devi. War is upon us. So, it would be prudent not to take strangers to the hunters’ chambers. I am not saying that you don’t know...”

“That is true, but he is not a stranger. He is your young master’s friend. And who knows, we might forge a new relationship too. Give that lamp to me and leave,” ordered Manimegalai.

Edupankari handed over the lamp with great reluctance and withdrew.

Vandiya Devan and Manimegalai went ahead in the passageway that would lead them to hunters’ chambers when they heard an owl hooting.

“What is this? How could an owl come inside the palace?” wondered Manimegalai.

“Who knows, maybe the dead owl in the hunters’ cabin came alive. Once before, didn’t the monkey come alive when he looked at the princess?”

There was a lock on the door that led inside the hunters’ chamber. Manimegalai used the key that she had brought to unlock it and opened the door slightly. They both then stepped inside the room. At first, they could only see the stuffed animals that we had earlier seen – elephants, bears, tigers, deer, crocodiles, and owls. But soon, they could spot men half hidden behind these animals.

Just then, the door they had just entered through was shut with great force. Vandiya Devan sprang towards it to investigate when someone held him tightly from behind and pushed him towards the tailless monkey that he had hidden behind earlier. Two hands from behind the monkey held him fast and strong, and he realized how strong a monkey’s grip could really be. He tried to draw his sword but was immobilized completely by the two men who didn’t allow him any movement. When they removed his sword, Manimegalai shouted ‘Ayyo’ loudly and tried to run towards him. A man stepped forward with a sharp dagger and held it in front of Manimegalai menacingly.

“Don’t shout! If you listen to what we tell you and do not raise an alarm, you will escape with your life intact. If you don’t heed us, you will lose your life for sure. First, this insolent young man will lose his life!”

That voice belonged to Ravidasan.

“Princess! Be silent! Let’s learn why these people are here and what they want!”

Chapter 36: Pandyan's Queen

They bound Vandiya Devan to the tailless monkey and Manimegalai to the antlers of the deer beside the monkey.

"Mandiravadi, only I am your enemy. Why are you tying the Kadambur princess too? Let her go..."

Ravidasan looked at him and said, "Wait, Thambi! You have interfered a lot in our work and yet we allowed you to escape with your life intact. But you still chose to follow us and hinder our mission..."

Vandiya Devan laughed out loud.

"Why do you laugh? Are you enjoying the tight embrace of that monkey?"

"No, I am laughing at what you just said!"

"What did I say that caused you so much mirth?"

"You say that I am interfering in your work, but I can say the same of you. You keep interfering in my work, too. Right now, I have come along with Kadambur princess on important work, and here you have interfered in it and bound me to this monkey!"

"Oh! If you think that it is us who keep interfering in your work, then so be it. But this will be the last time that such a situation would occur. If you survive tonight, you will never see us again!"

"If that is so, then I will need to try my utmost to survive this night. Why don't you give me a potent mantra that would help me survive this ordeal?"

“Certainly. All that you need to do is stay silent and not react to anything that might occur in the chambers beyond. Just stay silent and you might just survive tonight.”

“Why this special love for me? Why do you allow me to escape every time?”

“Right question. It is indeed foolishness to let you escape. But we did it because of our Devi’s orders...”

“Who is your Devi?”

“You still don’t know? It’s Pandimadevi^[14]. The brave queen of our emperor Veera Pandyan, Nandini Devi!”

“A brave queen indeed!”

“You! Insolent boy! One more disrespectful word about our Queen, you will lose your life...”

“It is you who is disrespecting her. How are you calling somebody else’s wife as your Pandyan’s queen?”

“So what? Didn’t Sita stay at Ravana’s palace for some time?”

“But Rama won her back, didn’t he?”

“Even we are here to take our queen back with us. Her imprisonment at the Pazhuvur palace will soon end and the reason why she had bound herself in that prison will soon be revealed when our mission is fulfilled.”

“What mission is that?”

“If you are patient for a little while, you will know. But if you want to do mischief and get up to your usual tricks, you will lose your life! And what more, this princess too will die...”

Saying thus, the Mandiravadi tried to move towards the opposite wall when Vandiya Devan called out to him.

“Mandiravadi! Tell me one more thing!” said Vandiya Devan.

Ravidasan turned around and said, “Thambi, henceforth don’t call me Mandiravadi.”

“Then how should I address you?”

“Call me respectfully as ‘Prime Minister!’”

“Ayya, may I know which great kingdom you are the prime minister of?”

“Haven’t you realized it yet? I am the Prime Minister of the great Pandya Empire. You did witness the coronation ceremony of our emperor.”

“Yes, I did, but I thought I was hallucinating!”

“Is that why you didn’t tell anybody about it?”

“I told a few people. But they thought that I was indeed hallucinating, or I might have had a bad dream.”

“Aha! Let them believe that. That’s why we allowed you to escape, because we knew no one would believe you, anyway.”

“Mandiravadi, is that the only reason why you allowed me to escape?”

“What else?”

“Didn’t your queen intercede on my behalf?”

“Then you wait patiently until she does so again!”

“Mandiravadi, your queen asked me to come to her chambers. That’s why I came along with this Kadambur princess...”

“There are many ways to reach the queen’s chambers, why did you come this way?”

“I don’t have to tell you why I came this way. If your queen asks, I will explain it to her!”

“Then you will need to wait until the queen comes and asks.”

“Mandiravadi! Release me and the Kadambur princess immediately. Or else...”

“Or else what will you do?”

“I will shout so much that the very foundation of these chambers will shake!”

“If you do, these three sharp spears will tear your body to pieces. You have been warned!”

Vandiya Devan looked around the hunters’ chambers. Ravidasan’s three men were indeed ready with their spears to spring on him.

“Thambi, you are an intelligent boy. I even had hopes of enlisting you for our cause, but you fell under the charms of that Pazhaiarai enchantress. Be that as it may. If you want to survive, don’t shout. If you do, you will be silenced!”

After warning Vandiya Devan, Ravidasan went near the elephant head that was fixed on the wall. He stood for a while there and tried to listen to what was happening in the room. Next, he twisted the elephant’s long trunk.

A small door opened on the wall, and they were able to see Nandini’s chamber which was situated beyond the wall. Several

lamps were lit, and the rays of the full moon were also entering the chambers alighting the room.

Vandiya Devan turned towards Manimegalai and found that she had managed to hack the ropes that were binding her using the small dagger that was hidden in her waist. The lamp that Manimegalai had procured from Edupankari was kept in a corner and its light didn't fall on Manimegalai.

Moreover, Ravidasan's men were watching Vandiya Devan like a hawk and had ignored the Kadambur Princess totally.

Vandiya Devan then noticed that Manimegalai had completely freed herself from the ropes that bound her.

He immediately hooted like an owl. The men who were watching were taken aback at first. And Ravidasan, who was looking into the chambers, was stunned by Vandiya Devan's action.

"Aha! It's you who is doing it," he said and sprang towards Vandiya Devan.

The second he took his hand off the elephant's trunk, the trapdoor closed, and darkness enveloped the hunters' chambers.

Ravidasan's men sprang toward Vandiya Devan with their spears aimed to kill. One of them was stopped by a stag with huge antlers. The other was attacked by a huge bear, while another was caught by a crocodile intent on its prey.

Incapacitated suddenly by these lifeless beasts, the men couldn't react quickly and were even stunned momentarily. Manimegalai quickly cut the ropes that bound Vandiya Devan and he threw the monkey on the men as well.

The men got up slowly, disoriented and stunned by the sudden attack only to face Vandiya Devan, who had procured a spear and was aiming at them fiercely.

That's when the door to the hunter chambers opened, revealing Nandini's bed chambers. And the next instant, Nandini herself entered, asking, "Mandiravadi, what is this foolishness? What is happening here?"

Chapter 37: Iron Heart Relents

Nandini was astonished to see Vandiya Devan and Manimegalai inside the hunters' chambers.

"Oh! How come you both are here?" she asked.

"Devi, I came because you had requested my presence. After coming here, I realized that I shouldn't have listened to a woman's advice in the first place!"

"Akka, I didn't advise him at all. I merely requested him to come with me to see you."

Nandini quickly got over her astonishment and said, "My dear friend, when a woman places a request before a man, they think that we are advising them!"

"Requests from you are more like commands. She said that you wanted to see me and dragged me through this way to meet you. And consequently, these murderers attacked me here," said Vandiya Devan.

"Ayya, from what I can see here, it doesn't seem like these people are murderers. It looks like you might have murdered them instead!"

"Akka, these men are indeed murderers. They bound him to the monkey a few minutes ago."

Nandini smiled slightly at her and said, "Manimegalai, didn't you tell me that he was hiding behind this monkey? These men probably got to know about it somehow!"

"That's not true, Akka. The day before you arrived here, I told you that I saw some men in the hunters' chambers. These were the men

I saw. That day, they came to pursue him. But thankfully, he escaped from them!”

“But today, you brought him back here again! Why did you bring him to my chambers through this way?”

“Akka, I heard my brother say that he would be visiting you soon. I didn’t want them to meet there so I brought him through this way. And in a way, it was good that we came here because we have now learned about the presence of these murderers...”

“Sister, these men are not murderers, nor are they here to kill him. Many times, in the past, he was captured by them, but they let him go free. You can learn the truth of it from him!”

“If that is true, then who are these men and why are they here? Do you really know them? They said that they are here to take you away, is that right?”

“Yes, my friend, that is true. I will tell you everything in detail. Let’s retire to my room. Let these men stay here!”

Then she turned towards the Mandiravadi and said, “Ravidasa, if you or your men cause harm to these two people, I will consider it as harm done on my person. No matter where you meet them and under what circumstances, it doesn’t matter. You will not harm them.”

Ravidasan said, “Devi, forgive me. This young man knows our secret call. Didn’t you hear the hooting of the owl?”

“That means he is one of us. Mandiravadi, what’s happened to your sharp brain? Be that as it may... until I say otherwise, I don’t want any commotion here. Remember that!”

Saying thus, Nandini, Vandiya Devan, and Manimegalai entered Nandini’s chambers through the elephant trap door.

“Sister! You were clever indeed. It is good that you came through the hunters’ chambers. Your brother left my presence just now saying that he would bring the prince here. You both need to leave before he arrives,” said Nandini.

“Akka, what is this? You wanted him to go and find out whether your husband is alive or not, but now you are saying that you are leaving?”

“I have changed my mind after speaking to your brother. It doesn’t matter if Pazhuvetarayar is alive or not. I cannot live here anymore. This warrior cannot stay here, either. It’s too dangerous. If you are not worried about your life, at least leave for the sake of this girl,” said Nandini.

“Akka, if he is leaving, ask him to take me along with him, too. After you both leave, I can’t live in this prison anymore...”

“Princess, you haven’t understood the Pazhuvur Queen’s intent. If I leave, you can marry the crown prince and become the empress of this kingdom.”

“No, you are wrong. You are misrepresenting my intentions. I will never wish the misfortune of marrying Aditya Karikalan on any girl, least of all Manimegalai, who I love more than my life. I would never wish a husband like the crown prince for her. If you leave now, you may be fortunate enough to claim this girl’s hand in marriage later on in your life. Manimegalai, if you truly love this young man, ask him to leave immediately.”

“Queen, I am ready to leave. But I wish you would grant me something that you hold in your possession!”

“Ayya, what do I have that you would like to possess? Tell me?”

“I want the sword which has the fish emblem. If you give that to me, I will leave immediately. You do know that my own sword got lost in Kollidam...”

“Ayya, the hunters’ chamber is filled with countless swords and spears. You can select any one of them and be on your way. Why would you want a sword that I carry to protect myself?”

“Devi, do you really keep that sword with you just to protect your life? Tell me the truth?”

“I keep it with me to protect my honour which is more precious than my life.”

“Devi, then you have no other motive to keep it with you?”

“What other motive will I have?”

“How about wanting to avenge the death of Veera Pandyan?”

“I thought you won’t talk about it in the presence of Manimegalai, but no matter. Manimegalai, it’s best that you know the truth of why I came to Kadambur palace.”

Saying thus, Nandini picked the sword that she had kept on the bed.

“I didn’t come here to find a solution for the fratricidal strife that is tearing this kingdom apart, nor did I come here to divide the kingdom between Madhuranthakan and Aditya Karikalan. I didn’t come here to enjoy the hospitality of Kadambur palace. Dear sister, nor did I come here to arrange your marriage.

“I came here to avenge the death of Veera Pandyan and to slay the murderous villain who killed him ingloriously. I swore a holy vow on this sword that I would avenge the death of my king, and I will either fulfil my vow tonight or give up my life instead,” spoke Nandini passionately.

“You want me to leave the palace only because you know I will not let anything happen to the prince,” said Vandiya Devan.

“Aha! So, you are going to prevent me from fulfilling my vow. Go ahead and try it. Why don’t you run to the prince and ask him not to come here tonight?”

“Devi, I cannot reason with the prince. It is impossible. That’s why I have come to you. To beg you to give up this oath and to prevent you from committing a sin.”

“Sin! What is ‘sin’? Let’s ask my friend here. Manimegalai, you tell me. You have lost your heart to a man who is lying hurt and harmless on a bed, and his enemy comes there, wanting to kill him. And you fall at his feet, begging for your lover’s life but he pushes you aside and kills your beloved. Would you call it a ‘sin’ to kill this enemy?”

“Never. But I will not fall at his feet and beg for mercy. I would take my dagger and kill the enemy before he could harm my lover!”

Vandiya Devan looked at Manimegalai and asked, “Princess, what if that ‘enemy’ happens to be your own brother?”

“Even if it was my own brother, I would do the same,” said Manimegalai.

“Well said, my sweet!” said Nandini, pleased with Manimegalai.

“Princess, you know not what you are saying. Irrespective of the misunderstanding that you might have with Kandanmaran, you will never raise your arm to kill him!”

Nandini and Manimegalai looked at each other, and then Nandini said, “What sort of question is this? I am not seeking to kill my brother. When we first met, you mentioned my brother Thirumalai, and that’s why I trusted you and allowed you to escape death many times. If I fail in my mission today and give up my life, please ask Thirumalai to forgive me. Though I didn’t listen to him, I never forgot him.”

“Devi, why this drama? Thirumalai is not your brother, nor are you his sister!”

“Then who is my brother?”

“Your brother is Aditya Karikalan. That’s why I am trying to save you from the grave sin of killing your sibling. I beg you, please hand over Veera Pandyan’s sword to me and give up this oath...”

“You told the prince this story about us being siblings, didn’t you? Did he believe you?” asked Nandini with a derisive smile.

“It looked as though he believed me, but I know not what lies at the bottom of his heart.”

“I know his heart. He is impressed by the prowess of creative imagination of that seductress who lives in Pazhaiarai!”

“Devi, what I told you is neither my imagination nor Princess Kundavai’s. I saw with my own eyes in Elangai...”

“What did you see?”

“A goddess who can’t speak or hear. She saved our lives many times. While we were walking on the streets of Anuradhapuram, we were near a dilapidated palace, and she suddenly called us from across the street. Right after we moved, the palace collapsed. If we had not moved, we would have been buried in the rubble. Ponniyin Selvar worships her as the Goddess of Cholas...”

“Ayya, what’s the connection between this story and me? You should have told this to Kundavai, whose only aim in life is to crown her brother Arulmozhi as the emperor of this kingdom. She would have been happy. Why tell me?”

“There is a reason why I am telling you this. When I saw her for the first time in the moonlight, I thought to myself, ‘How could the Pazhuvur queen come here?’. You look just like that woman. If you

got rid of your jewels and unbound your hair, there would nary be a difference.”

“And why should I believe you? I very well know about the power of your imagination. You could be imagining this as well!”

“Devi, I swear... I am not imagining or lying.”

“It doesn’t matter how much you swear, I can’t believe you.”

“Devi, you are lying when you say that you don’t believe me. You know the truth and you have been using it to your benefit for long. In Thanjavur, when we first met, this Mandiravadi came there hooting like an owl. You asked me to hide myself for a while, and I inadvertently discovered the open door to the underground dungeon. That’s where I saw many strange things...”

“What strange things?”

“I saw Kandanmaran go along with Madhuranthakan through the passage...”

“So what?”

“Right after that, I saw you and Periya Pazhuvetarayar go somewhere. At that time, I couldn’t guess where you were going. But later, I understood what was happening. You were on your way to the emperor’s palace to act like your mother’s ghost and to torment the emperor.”

Until then, Nandini who had stood up to him defiantly, lost colour and felt weak in her limbs and sat down in one of the seats.

“Ayya, what else did you learn?”

“You met Kandanmaran when he returned from escorting the prince, and he said something to your Lord Husband, who signalled to the guard who was holding the fire torch,”

“What signal?”

“You probably know all about it. He signalled the guard to kill Kandanmaran, but I killed the guard and saved his life. As a result, I was accused of betraying my friend.”

Nandini looked at Manimegalai and asked Vandiya Devan, “Ayya, aren’t you saying these things to confuse this girl?”

“Devi, I haven’t talked about these things to anybody. If you hand over the sword that you hold in your hands, I will never tell anybody about this hereafter either.”

“I will not hand over the sword, Ayya. Do your worst. Go and tell anybody who would care to listen. Add more imagination to your stories and narrate them to the world, I don’t care. Why don’t go right now to the prince and stop him from coming here? Why are you bothering me? Leave my presence immediately,” she exclaimed, tears streaming through her face.

“Devi, I know the prince. It’s impossible to reason with him. If I try to stop him from coming here, it will result in more stubbornness. That’s why I am begging you...”

“Why are you begging me? What right do you have? Even if I were to accept that my mother roams through the woods of Elangai like a mad woman, why should I give up my vow to avenge my beloved’s death? Didn’t the emperor deceive my mother, resulting in her madness? Why should I relent and forgive his children for all the harm that they have done to me and my clan? I now have one more reason to avenge their behaviour towards me!”

“No, Devi. Your mother will never approve of you seeking revenge against the emperor’s children who she loves as her own. If you were to kill one of his children, do you think she is going to be happy about it? She would curse you if she ever learned that you killed one of his children. She would haunt you for the rest of your

life. Though she cannot speak, one angry gaze from her eyes will haunt you forever...”

Streams of tears poured out of Nandini’s eyes. She looked up in distress, as though seeing something on the roof and said, “Mother... Veera Pandyan’s head and body haunts me all the time, would you join them and do the same?” saying thus, she closed her eyes as though she could no longer bear to see the horror in front of her. For a few minutes, they could only hear the sounds of her sobbing disconsolately.

Manimegalai looked at Vandiya Devan and said, “Ayya, I never knew that you were so stone-hearted.”

Nandini removed her hands from her face and said, “Don’t blame him, Manimegalai. He is trying to save me from committing a grave sin. He is trying to save me. And yet, it gives me nothing but pain.”

Then she looked at Vandiya Devan and said, “Ayya, you have achieved what no one could have. Here, as you wished, I will hand over the sword to you.” Saying thus, she held the sword out to him.

But when Vandiya Devan put his hand forward to receive it, she drew back and said, “Ayya, before you receive this sword, tell me if you can help me. If I leave without fulfilling my vow, the men in the hunters’ chambers will not spare me. They will burn me alive on a funeral pyre. But I am not even worried about my fate, I want to meet my mother before I die. Vandiya Devarey! I told you that I didn’t believe in your words. That’s not true. I do believe that you are telling the truth. My mother is roaming through the woods of Elangai... and I have seen her myself too!”

“How? When?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“When I was young, I would wake up suddenly from a deep sleep and find a woman staring at me. She would vanish immediately. I was surprised and also disturbed by this. I used to look at myself in the mirror often, and I knew my facial features well. And when I

found that the woman looked just like me, I was surprised by it. I used to wonder if my spirit had come out of my body and was looking back at me. I used to wonder if I was dead and that thought disturbed me greatly. Sometimes, I used to wonder if I was dreaming of the woman's face and worry if I was losing my mind. When I attained maturity, I realized that I had indeed seen a real woman and her identity became known to me through the people around me. When I saw Sundara Chola's reaction to seeing me that day, I was convinced that what I suspected was right. I also learned many things from when Azhwarkadiyan would slip inadvertently; that I resembled my mother greatly and that she was in Elangai, roaming like a mad woman. Right from the time I learned this, all I want to do is to meet her once and lie on her lap and cry to my heart's content.

"Ayya, your words today have increased my desire to see her. If you promise to take me to my mother, I will hand over this Pandya sword to you and forget my oath," said Nandini with tears streaming through her eyes.

Vandiya Devan was privately worried about what Nandini was demanding.

Why is she asking this? Is this a trick? Or is she serious?

Manimegalai looked at Vandiya Devan and said, "Ayya, please promise akka that you will fulfil her wish."

Vandiya Devan, with great hesitation, said, "I will see what I can do!"

"Then we need to leave immediately before the prince arrives here. But how do we go? We can't go via the main entrance. We might even meet Kandanmaran and Aditya Karikalan there."

"I will take you through the hunters' chambers, come with me," said Vandiya Devan.

“Akka, I will also come with you. Please take me too,” said Manimegalai.

Nandini didn't respond to her and instead said, “I do not wish to go through the hunters' chambers. Ravidasan and his men will not spare us!”

“Devi, if you can hand over that sword to me, I can take care of Ravidasan and his men,” said Vandiya Devan.

“No! That would unnecessarily complicate things. Manimegalai, is there any other way to escape from this place?” asked Nandini.

Manimegalai creased her forehead, thought for a while, and then said, “Akka, I am not sure if there is another way, but why don't you ask him? The last time he was here, he vanished without a trace. Ask him how did that.”

Nandini turned and looked at Vandiya Devan.

“Yes, Devi. There is a way and I discovered it accidentally. You will need to jump from one terrace to another and then finally jump over the palace walls. I am not sure if you can do that. instead, I would rather face Ravidasan and his men and make our way through the underground passage.”

Then Manimegalai said, “Ayyo, it looks like they are close!”

Everyone stopped talking and listened intently.

“Ayya, please hide in the hunters' chambers immediately,” begged Nandini.

“I have a better place to hide myself, Devi. Please hand over the sword to me,” said Vandiya Devan.

Nandini raised her hands to give the sword to him but it slipped and fell with a huge clamour.

Chapter 38: Was it all an act?

When the sword slipped from Nandini's hands and fell with a resounding noise, they could hear her sorrow-tinged laughter along with it. Hassled and harried, she said, "Ayya, it looks like God is willing something else. Leave the sword here and hide yourself!"

Vandiya Devan ignored her and bent down and tried to lift the sword by its blade. But its sharp edge claimed its prey and wounded his finger. He dropped the sword and rose. Nandini noticed that he had been hurt and said, "I will keep my word to you. I will not slay my own brother. Please leave now. If he were to see you here..."

Manimegalai too joined in and said, "Please leave! Please leave immediately!"

They could now hear the approaching footsteps closer than before. Vandiya Devan reluctantly moved towards the music room and disappeared within it.

Manimegalai watched him leave with great surprise. Nandini said to her, "Sister! You too hide behind the curtains of the bed and leave silently when we are talking."

The minute Manimegalai hid herself, Aditya Karikalan and Kandanmaran entered the chambers. Karikalan looked around the room carefully and neared Nandini. He saw a movement behind the curtains but reacted as though he had not seen it.

When he came near Nandini, he saw the beautiful glowing sword that lay at her feet and then looked at her face. Nandini couldn't stand the intensity of his gaze that seemed to probe within her heart for answers. She averted her gaze and bent down to pick up the sword. Reading her intentions, he picked up the sword before she could and said, "Devi, we heard the sound of this sword even as we

neared your chambers. It must have slipped from your hands and fallen. Looks like you were ready with your sword to greet us here.”

“Isn’t it appropriate to greet a young tiger like yourself with a warrior’s sword?”

“Ferocious tigers and lions need claws and nails but a beautiful spotted deer doesn’t need them, that’s why God didn’t provide them with it!”

“But God gave the deer sharp antlers to protect itself, and I am sure there will be many opportunities when the deer is happy to possess them. Please hand back the sword to me.”

“No! No! Your hands were not fashioned to bear swords. These hands are better suited to make garland and bear flowers!”

“Prince! There was a time when these hands were making garlands. I have made many garlands and waited for the ‘one’ who would claim them but in vain. There was a time when I had many such dreams and wishes, but it’s been many years since I have given up on them. I am but an orphan and I have no choice but to bear arms such as this. Ayya, would you deprive me of this support as well?”

“Devi, how could you call yourself an orphan? Don’t you know there are scores of young men who would do anything to gain your grace? Even if you were to kick them away, they would be pleased to serve you!”

“That’s why I need the sword. I would rather cut my legs than let them touch any of these men.”

“Why do you speak thus? We will lose the tinkle of your anklets that is immersing this palace in such joy! What would Periya Pazhuvetarayar say if he heard you speak thus?”

“Ayya, who worries about him here? A growl from that old lion is enough to scatter an entire pride of young ones. Ever since the news about his disappearance came, young lions are becoming bolder. That’s why I have this sword – to protect my honour and his name. He braved ridicule and married me and gave me the protection of his name and clan. But now I have to seek the help of this sword. That’s why I have learnt the art of wielding it!”

“Devi, is that the only reason to have this sword with you? Are you really praying to this sword so that it can protect your honour and your husband’s? Do you keep it with you just to keep a check on foolish young men who approach you with foolish intentions?”

“What other reason would I have to keep this sword with me?”

“Many reasons. You might want to seek vengeance, especially from those who foolishly refused your request one day and caused you excruciating pain and torment. You could use this sword to slay him and fulfil your oath.”

“Prince, I once thought the same. That’s why I have been worshipping this sword and was waiting for the right time to use it. But when the right time came, I lost the power in my hands and my resolve weakened. From now on, I am determined to use this sword to protect my honour and my husband’s honour. I beg you, please hand it back to me!”

“Devi, I could take on that responsibility. I will ensure no one causes any harm to your honour or that of your husband’s and punish those who dare to.”

“It would be impossible for you to do so. Surely you wouldn’t punish your own friends to protect the honour of this orphaned woman!”

“Why not? I can do it, Nandini! That day, at the lake, you told me about Vandiya Devan and his dishonourable actions but I didn’t believe you. Later, when Kandanmaran said the same, I couldn’t

help but realize the truth of your words. Even if you are ready to forgive fiends like him, I am not ready to do that. Tell me where he is... you won't tell? No matter. I know where he is. I am not blind..." growling thus, Karikalan turned towards the curtains. Nandini fell at his feet and begged, "Prince, please... please don't!"

"Nandini, save your sympathy for other people. I will not spare those who act like my friend and deceive me thus," shouted Karikalan, moving towards the curtains.

Nandini hurriedly got up and looked around with great agitation. She noticed Kandanmaran standing at the doorway and said, "Ayyo! Please stop him!"

But Kandanmaran smiled at her and didn't move from his post.

Karikalan lifted his sword in one hand and moved the curtain with the other, only to find Manimegalai standing there with a dagger in her hand. When Karikalan advanced toward her, she shouted in a piercing voice and the prince froze in his tracks. The next instant, he used the sword to tear through the curtains.

"So, it was this tigress behind the curtains! My god! She really has sharp claws," he declared and laughed uproariously.

Next, he turned towards Kandanmaran and said, "My friend, please take your sister away from here and leave her with your mother. We know not how many tiger cubs she would give birth to in the future! Thankfully, she didn't fall prey to this Pandyan sword, or else our kingdom would have lost the ferocious tigers and tigresses born of her womb!"

Manimegalai, who had indeed charged at him like a tigress, became shy when she heard his words. When Kandanmaran moved towards her to take her away, she moved ahead of him and left the room. After the brother and sister left the room, Karikalan looked at Nandini and said, "Devi, I have successfully got rid of both of them

through a small drama. At least now, let's open our hearts and talk frankly."

Nandini looked at him with great astonishment and said, "Prince, was that a drama? I really thought it was for real!"

"Nandini, I always thought that none in this world could rival you in acting, but if you were taken in by my acting, then I should take pride in my prowess. And yet, when I went near Manimegalai with my sword ready to strike, you didn't stop me. Why? Did you want me to kill her? Along with all the grave sins that I have committed, I might as well kill a woman too, is that what you thought?"

"Shiva, Shiva! I have true love for that innocent girl. Will I sit quietly and watch you kill her? I was sure that you would realize who is behind the curtains once you parted them."

Karikalan laughed at her words.

"What's the meaning of this?" demanded Nandini.

"Your very explanation is enough for me to kill her, Nandini."

"I cannot understand the meaning of your words."

"Don't you know that whoever your true love is – whether it is a man or woman – will immediately become my foremost enemy?"

"I do, but I didn't think that you would cause harm to this innocent girl!"

"Or you could have devised other plans. If I had really killed Manimegalai, her brother would have killed me in retaliation... Or Manimegalai herself could have stabbed me with the dagger that she had in hand!"

"Ayyo! Why are you imagining such horrible things?"

“Imagination? Your intent is far more horrible than whatever I could imagine. Tell me the truth! Don’t enrage me anymore. Why did you invite me here? Why did you send Pazhuvetarayar back to Thanjavur? You didn’t come here to conduct peace talks or to arrange my marriage to Manimegalai. Don’t even say it. I will not believe a word of it. If I had, I would never have come here...”

“Then why did you come, Prince? What made you come here? What did you hope to accomplish?”

“Hope? There is no room for hope in my heart; only heart-breaking misery and grief. I want to leave this kingdom... I want to leave this world. I came here to see you one last time and to take your leave. You once asked me for a boon. You fell at my feet and begged me piteously with folded hands... but the fool that I was, I refused you. I have been regretting my actions ever since, and if there is a way to redeem myself from that grave sin, I would like to do it. Nandini, tell me truly, is there any redemption for me? Tell me how I can make amends,” asked Karikalan, his face etched with grief and regret.

“Prince, there is no redemption for that. You cannot grant life to those who are dead. That is beyond your power.”

“It is impossible to bring back the dead, but we can give up our life to make amends for the sin committed.... Look here, why did you come here? Why did you make Pazhuvetarayar leave for Thanjavur? Don’t imagine that I don’t know your intent. Right from our childhood, I have had the strange gift of knowing exactly what you think.

“You begged for Veera Pandyan’s life to enrage me and to make me act in a despicable manner. You married Pazhuvetarayar just to torture me. You couldn’t stand the fact that I have been living peacefully in Kanchi. That’s why you asked me to come here, so you could fulfil your oath and kill me with this Pandya sword. That’s why I have sent Kandanmaran and his sister away. Here, take the sword and kill me,” said Karikalan, handing her the sword.

Nandini took the sword with trembling hands. Her body was also trembling while tears streamed from her eyes and she tried to control her sobbing.

“Nandini what’s this? Why are you hesitating now? What has happened to you? Even though you were raised in a priest’s family, you were born in a family that cherishes bravery. Will a lioness raised by goats lose its resolve and become meek?

“Look here, I know your intent. You need not use Vandiya Devan, Kandanmaran, or Parthibendra Pallavan to fulfil your oath. You don’t have to turn me against my friends and hope that I would die in their hands. You can fulfil your oath with your own hands. Do it before somebody else comes here.

“Kandanmaran might come back here anytime. Parthibendran too is due back anytime and my grandsire might come along with him too, who knows? I don’t believe that Pazhuvetarayar died in the Kollidam flood. He, too, might come back here anytime. You will not get a better opportunity. By killing me, you will be ending my torment, which would be a blessed release for me!”

Nandini tried to control her rising sobs and whimpered, “Prince, you are right about my intentions and the reasons why I invited you here. But now that the time has come to fulfil my oath, my hands are trembling and my heart has lost its resolve. When I heard your footsteps, the sword slipped from my hand and fell. See how my hands are shaking,” she said and showed her hands that were trembling with emotion.

“Yes, I can see that. But I can’t help but wonder what brought this transformation. I used to think that Brahma created your heart with Vajrayudham’s^[15] leftover metal; strong, rigid, and unbending. What caused your heart to melt thus?”

“It’s because of the news that your friend Vandiya Devan brought.”

“Aha! Do you mean the news that you and I are siblings? That day, by the lake, you said you didn’t believe it. You said it was yet another ruse to separate us.”

“I didn’t want to believe it, but he told me another piece of news today and I can’t help but believe it!”

“Aha! What did he say? Another story?”

“He told me the news about my mother – that she roams through the island of Elangai. There is no cause to doubt what he said. Prince, I once asked you for a boon and you didn’t grant it to me. You said you regret your actions to this day. I am asking you for a boon today, will you at least grant that?”

“If you can tell me what you want, I can think about granting it!”

“Prince, I did swear a holy vow to avenge Veera Pandyan’s death. I wanted to kill you with this sword and fulfil my oath. And if that were not possible, I had promised to kill myself. I cannot kill you... my hands don’t have the strength, nor will my heart allow it. I could kill myself with this sword, but what if I am unsuccessful? But you can help me fulfil my vow. You can kill me with this sword and release me from this bondage.”

Saying thus, Nandini presented the sword again to Karikalan, and he took it back again and laughed loudly and menacingly.

Chapter 39: Darkness Enveloped

Karikalan's maniacal laughter raised goosebumps in Vandiya Devan's body. He couldn't shake off the instinct that was telling him that something catastrophic would soon be happening there. He could almost imagine Yama, the lord of death, waiting at the door of Nandini's chambers with his noose ready.

Whose life will Lord Yama claim? Will it be the maddened Karikalan or the deranged Nandini? Or will it be both? Will the brother kill the sister or the sister kill the brother? Didn't Princess Kundavai send me here to prevent this very scenario? But I did my best to stop them. I told them about their relationship and tried to change both their mind to give up thoughts of revenge. Did my interference bear any fruit? Can I stop Karikalan and Nandini from killing each other? Or will I die in the attempt? Will my death bring some sense into their maddened minds?

Such were the despairing thoughts that passed through Vandiya Devan's mind. He decided to stay hidden for a little while more.

When Karikalan's laughter subsided, Nandini said, "Ayya, I have not done anything in my entire life that might have given anyone pleasure. I am glad that at least in my death, you will find reason enough to laugh and make merry."

"Yes, Nandini. Today is a good day. When I left Kanchi, I did make up my mind. But I was worried that my heart might lose its resolve when I met you. But you have handed over the sword to me with your own hands," he said and laughed again bitterly.

"Prince, today is a good day for me as well. There is no greater pleasure than being killed by your hands. I once dreamed of being garlanded by you, while you claim me as your own. But I am glad that you will at least place that sword on my neck and claim my life. What are you waiting for? Go ahead, do it!"

“We have waited all our lives for this, a few more minutes will not matter. Nandini, look at me... and tell me the truth. Why should I garland you with this sword? Why can't I claim you with a garland of flowers? Didn't we dream about it years ago? Who is standing in our way now? Tell me, and I will claim their lives with this sword and fulfil our dream!”

“No! There is no one standing in our way. I don't want you to kill anyone else because of me. It is my own fate that is preventing us from fulfilling our dreams.”

“What if I were to change that fate? Don't blame fate. I will rewrite your fate... You just have to tell me!”

Nandini interjected and said, “Ayya, maybe you could rewrite my fate. But what about my birth? Can you change that?”

“What are you asking, Nandini? You were raised in a priest's family, therefore I was discouraged from pursuing any kind of relationship with you by my family. Or are you referring to the fact that you were not born in that priest's family in the first place?”

“I am not talking about that, prince. I am referring to the news that your friend Vandiya Devan brought. The news that Princess Kundavai sent to you urgently – that I am your sister. Have you forgotten about it already?”

“Nandini! You didn't believe that news and said that it was yet another trick to separate us. I thought about it too and came to the same conclusion. If you wish to know that for certain...”

“No! No! I have no doubts about that news at all. There is no blood relation between us, prince.”

“Then, what is it that separates us Nandini?”

“I am married to Pazhuvetarayar, who you consider as your grandsire. Isn't that enough?”

“Nandini, do you want me to believe that story? For the world, you might have married that old man. But you never really were his wife. Remember when we met at your palace in Thanjavur? When I reminded you of our cherished dream you said you would agree to it if I were to kill your husband and imprison my father and sister. Such horrible demands! I thought you were a demoness craving my blood and left the place. Even after I returned to Kanchi, you haunted me with your tears, your seductive smile, and your demented wishes...”

“Prince, how dare you blame me for your hallucinations? You conjured them through the guilt that you felt because of the grievous harm you did to me. And did you think that I was happily enjoying the luxury of palace life?” demanded Nandini, reclaiming the anger and determination that she had lost earlier.

When Vandiya Devan heard her speak thus, he got frightened. His body trembled with anxiety and fear.

Karikalan too raised his voice and said, “Are you saying that you too have faced hardships? Then why are we talking thus, wasting our time? Tell me now, that you are ready to renounce everything and come with me. I will turn my back on this kingdom, on my people, my family, my friends, and take you across the sea. We will build our life anew on an island away from this place. You are more valuable to me than any kingdom...”

“Prince, you are willing to turn your back on everything but you will not agree to instate this low-born woman on the Chola throne as your queen?”

“Woman, I can ask the same question back to you. Is this throne more valuable to you than my love? When we were young, the love that you showered on me... was it just an act so that I take you as my queen?”

“Aha! You can assume that if you so wish. Yes, I craved the luxuries of the palace and wanted to wield power and claim the

deference of the people. That's why I married Pazhuvetarayar. And that's why I tried to save the life of Veera Pandyan."

"You demoness! Why do you take his name now?" growled Karikalan. And before Nandini could reply, he continued, "Aha, now I know everything. I now understand all your schemes. You take that scoundrel's name now to enrage me so that I would be forced to kill you for real. That's when the young men that you have mesmerized here will save you by killing me. Isn't that your plan? You rakshashi! Where is that Vandiya Devan? Where have you hidden him? He is the reason you are refusing to escape with me. That's why you sent Pazhuvetarayar away from here. You have been planning all this along with that wretch.... Aha, the fool that I am to be deceived thus. Where is that Vandiya Devan? Where is your new lover?"

Shouting thus, Karikalan started searching for Vandiya Devan in the room. And when he neared the music room, Nandini fell at his feet and begged, "Prince, listen to me. Your accusations about Vandiya Devan are unfounded. Even this Earth will not bear it then. If you cause him any harm, you will be committing a grave sin and my friend Manimegalai will give up her life. Prince, please calm down. Why don't you look into my heart? You will only see yourself... that's a promise!"

Nandini's words pacified Karikalan a bit and he said, "If that is so, then what's stopping you from coming with me now? Why are you inciting me to kill you again and again? Tell me!"

"There is no room for anyone else in my heart other than you. While this is true, we cannot fulfil our dreams, and I cannot come with you. I cannot renounce everything and marry you. There is a reason why we cannot do that.

"Yes, my prince, I came here to tell you that truth and seek your forgiveness. I wanted to beg you to marry someone who would befit your station. And yet, I hesitated to tell you the truth because I didn't want to increase your wrath and was afraid of what will happen. If you promise to remain calm, I will tell you the truth!"

“Tell me, Nandini, I will remain calm. A moment ago, you advised me to marry somebody else and live happily. I didn’t even get angry on hearing that. What else is going to anger me more? But don’t give me imaginary tales, tell me the truth!”

“Prince, my whole life is somebody’s cruel imagination. I have weaved many an imaginary tale in my life. Some of them I told to escape death, and some I told to finish my mission. From today onwards, I don’t have to do all that. Today, the life that I have led so far – filled with lies, imagination, and deceit – is going to end. I did not reveal many a truth to you because I didn’t want to cause you any more pain. I tried to make you hate me by telling you many horrible tales and by placing impossible demands on you. I was caught in a struggle between the oath that I swore and the love that I bore for you in my heart. You know not the wounds that I carry in my heart. Alas, today, my struggle will finally end. I will tell you the truth about me. After hearing that, I hope you would kill me with your own hands. But please do not cause harm to anybody else. Don’t commit any more sins...”

“Sins! Is there any sin left that I haven’t committed yet? It is no matter. Tell me, Nandini. What is this truth that stops us from fulfilling our childhood dream? Tell me this truth! No matter how bitter it is I am prepared to listen to it.

“When I suspected that someone was behind that curtain, I was incensed, suspicious and enraged. But the moment I found that it was indeed Manimegalai, my anger vanished. Until we know the truth, we are confused, afraid and angry. But the minute we learn it, the turmoil in our hearts vanishes. Tell me this truth, Nandini. And no matter how bitter it is, it might just quiet my heart and give me peace!”

“Prince, I sincerely pray that the truth about me brings peace to your heart. But when you hear it, you will realize that it will be impossible for me to marry you or come away with you. You will also learn that only death can release me from this burden of life. Vandiya Devar brought me news about my mother. I have no reason to

disbelieve him. I have known for a long that my mother roams through the island of Elangai like a mad woman. Many have told me about it, and I have also found that many have confused me with my mother due to the resemblance in our appearance. A few years ago, I learned why my mother became this mad demented creature. I haven't told this anyone... No one knows this except me. But now I will tell you. I beg of you, please do not get angry. Stay calm as you promised me earlier."

After talking thus, she neared Karikalan and said, "My father was...." And started crying.

Karikalan stood there as though stung by thousands of scorpions.

"No! No! No! You are lying. This is the biggest lie I have heard you utter," he bellowed. But in the next instant, he calmed down and said, "Yes, Nandini, yes. You are telling the truth. Now I know the extent of the struggle that you underwent. I understand your confusion, your anger, and the reason behind your impossible demands. I now realize how grievous the wounds of your heart are. That day when you begged at my feet, I refused you, what a grave injustice I did to you!

"Nandini, there is redemption for all types of sins but there is none for the grievous harm that I have caused you. We cannot realize any of our dreams, and the barrier between us will remain forever. Ayyo, how did you bear this sorrow in your heart for so many years? How did you tolerate the fact that I walked this earth after acting so despicably towards you? Good! There is only one redemption available for me. Here, Nandini! Here is my redemption..."

Vandiya Devan was listening intently to their conversation from the music room. In between, whenever Karikalan became enraged, he thought he should intervene, but he also feared the consequences. He couldn't hear clearly when Nandini revealed the truth about her father, but he could guess what she might have said,

which was enough to jolt him. It wouldn't be far from the truth to say he had never encountered such a shocking truth ever in his life.

In the end, when Karikalan spoke calmly accepting what Nandini had said, his anticipation grew a hundredfold. Until Karikalan was raging and shouting, he didn't fear for his life. But he grew anxious when the prince spoke softly. Wondering what the prince might do, he leaned out of the music room to see what they were doing.

But Karikalan and Nandini were not in his line of sight. He saw another horrible sight in the mirror that was placed right opposite the music room. The door to the hunters' chambers had opened and through that, Ravidasan's beastly face could be seen. The next instant, Ravidasan opened the door completely and a tiger's head and its body were seen. Seeing that, Vandiya Devan sprang alive. The confusion that reigned in his heart and mind vanished.

But something stopped him. A huge arm snaked through his neck and held him in an iron grip. He tilted his head to see who that was. It was a large-boned Kala Mugan with matted locks, a large beard, and a garland of skulls.

Who is he? Where did he spring from? I am not able to escape his grip! I am not able to breathe.

Vandiya Devan tried his utmost to shake off the Kala Mugan and escaped from his grip with great difficulty only to fall down and hit his head on the ground. He closed his eyes to see hundreds of suns and lost consciousness.

The Kala Mugan stepped over Vandiya Devan and entered the room. Nandini, startled and stunned, turned towards the music room and watched in horror as the figure marched towards her with an unsheathed sword in hand. Her eyes bulging with horror and astonishment, she tried to compose herself and call for help. She wiped her tears and looked in front of her. Karikalan lay stabbed, with the sword of Veera Pandya sticking from his body.

That's when Nandini made an inhuman sound. It was a sound where laughter and wails were mixed together. The Kala Mugan, in the meanwhile, neared her menacingly saying, "Nandini, you demoness, did you fulfil your vow?"

At the same time, Ravidasan, who had hidden inside the skin of the tiger saw the Kala Mugan and threw the tiger on the lamp that was kept in the room. That was the only light in the room, and his actions resulted in extinguishing the lamp enveloping the chamber in darkness. Just before the lamp died, Manimegalai's scared face could be seen. And the next instant she fled the room, uttering a shriek.

Darkness overtook the room and the only sounds that one could hear were the sorrowful sobs, the groans of someone who was dying, and the moans of someone wounded. Many footsteps were heard running through the chambers.

Chapter 40: 'I killed Him'

The Thiruvallangadu copper plates, while describing the royal line of the Cholas, wrote this about Aditya Karikalan:

'He rose to the sky in his desire to see the heavens and the darkness enveloped the Earth.'

This was written to describe the death of Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan; the one who had beheaded Veera Pandyan.

Nandini's chamber, where the prince lay dead, was also enveloped in darkness. The same darkness also clouded Vandiya Devan, who had lost consciousness after being strangled by the Kala Mugan. As he slowly regained consciousness, he opened his eyes and looked around. But the inky black darkness was so dense that he couldn't understand where he was lying and in what condition.

His head was aching from his fall and his throat was paining. He couldn't breathe properly.

Why is my head aching so? What about this throat pain? Why am I having difficulty breathing properly? What happened to me? Aha! That Kala Mugan! Did I really see him? Did he really choke my throat to kill or did he want to silence me? Why?

But where did I want to go and why was I stopped? Ah yes, now I remember. I wanted to go to Aditya Karikalar. Ayyo! What happened to him? What happened to Nandini? What did Ravidasan do? What did the Kala Mugan do after incapacitating me?

Where am I? Am I in an underground prison or in the passage that led from hunters' chambers? Why is this so dark?

He remembered that he was near the music room when the Kala Mugan had attacked him.

Am I still there? Or was I moved elsewhere? How do I find out?

He spread his arms and tried to find out where he was lying. He found something next to him. Feeling it with his hands, he found that it was a twisted blade dagger. This type of dagger was more powerful than a normal one and it never missed its target.

Where did I see this dagger? Yes, I saw it in the hands of Edupankari!

That's when he remembered everything that transpired that evening.

How did this dagger come here? Why is the blade wet? Is it water or oil? Or could it be blood? If it is blood, then whose blood? Could it be his own?

Thinking thus, he checked himself and found that he didn't suffer from a dagger wound. Nor was he bleeding.

Then whose blood is coating the blade of this dagger? Why was it placed near him? He didn't kill anybody with it. He had not even taken it in his hand before. Who could have used it? Could it be Edupankari? Did Edupankari dress like that Kala Mugan?

He immediately rejected the idea.

No, Edupankari can't be that tall, muscular man by any means.

What's that I am hearing? Footsteps! I hope whoever is coming brings a lamp along with them. They might just step over me in this darkness.

Vandiya Devan sat up and took that dagger in his hand and asked, "Who is there?"

He couldn't recognize his own voice! It was most unlike and different. The Kala Mugan had indeed strangled him so well that he couldn't recognize his own voice! He couldn't raise his voice again.

After much difficulty, he asked again, "Who is there?" It sounded like the whimper of a wounded animal rather than a question.

He then heard the same footsteps retreating. They probably got scared after hearing his voice, thinking that it was a beast. Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan laughed. But even his laughter was unrecognizable to himself.

Good. It's not of any use if I were to sit quietly here. I need to get up and investigate where I am and what's happening around me.

Thinking thus, he got up. He felt shaky and his limbs were trembling from the shock and exhaustion. He spread out his hands and started walking, hoping to find something that would give him a clue about what had happened.

Soon his gaze fell on a slight ray of light on a large mirror that was fixed on the wall. He recognized it as the same mirror where he last saw Ravidasan opening the hunters' chambers and entering the room hidden under a tiger's skin.

So I am still in Nandini's chambers. But why is it so dark? Where are the people who were here a little while ago? What happened to them? Why is this room so silent?

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan moved ahead with staggering steps, only to fall again. This time around, he fell on something soft so he didn't hurt himself. He felt around to see what broke his fall and realized that he had fallen on the tiger skin that Ravidasan had camouflaged himself with earlier.

When he fell down again, the dagger that he held slipped from his hand. When he started searching for it, he found something soft

lying nearby, which increased his fear and anxiety a hundredfold. He was now afraid of what he would discover.

Could this be a body? He wondered, horrified and afraid to speculate whose body it could be. With growing desperation and despair, he touched the body again.

Yes, it was a human body. He had stumbled and fallen down when he had stepped on the hand of the body.

He now removed the tiger's skin that was thrown on the body and looked at it carefully in the scant light of the moon's reflection in the mirror.

Ayyo! It is Aditya Karikalar! No. it's his dead body!

Horror, despair, and grief came in waves and choked Vandiya Devan's throat and his eyes were filled with tears.

He checked the prince's body for any sign of life, but he had long been dead! The blood that was flowing from the prince's body soaked his hands.

Shocked by his discovery, Vandiya Devan now could only think about Princess Kundavai, who had sent him here to protect the prince from any harm. He had completely failed in his mission.

How will I ever show my face to her again? I did try my utmost to prevent this, but fate and destiny succeeded.

He gently raised Karikalan's head and placed it in his lap. He didn't know what to do next. He didn't even think of calling anyone for help, though even if he wanted to there was no strength left in his voice.

The prince is dead and I have failed in my mission. I can never show my face to Kundavai again.

His thoughts moved around in circles and he didn't know how long he sat there, numb with grief and shock.

He came out of his stupor when he heard footsteps approaching the main entrance of the room. He laid Karikalan back on the ground and got up. A group of ten or eleven men entered the room. Two of them carried a fire torch while the others were armed with spears and swords. They were headed by Kandanmaran and his father.

All the men looked horrified by what they found in the room. Horror and fear were writ in their faces, but Kandanmaran was angry and wrathful. The minute he saw Vandiya Devan there, he immediately shouted, "You wretch! Traitor! Backstabber! I thought you might have escaped too."

Next, he turned towards his father and said, "Father, look at him. The murderer stands in front of you. He is the traitor who acted like our friend and has double-crossed us. He is the one who has brought never-ending shame to our clan. Look at his face. There is guilt written there!"

Sambuvarayar didn't react to Kandanmaran's tirade. Instead, he sat down near the prince's body and stared at it with horrified eyes.

"Ayyo! Fate has been very cruel to us indeed! Why did this have to happen in our palace? Our clan will be forever tainted. We will be accused of inviting him to the palace for a feast, only to kill him!" wailing thus, Sambuvarayar struck his head multiple times with his own hands in grief and desperation.

"Father, we will not be blamed for this. Here stands the murderer who slew the prince. Here is the dagger that he used to kill him. See the blood that coats that blade. When I came there earlier, he was not here. I think he tried to flee, but was unsuccessful and came back here. Or maybe he came back to check if there is any life left in the prince's body and to strangle him to death perhaps. Father! How do we punish this traitor? I can't think of a fitting punishment that

would make him answer for his crimes..." cried Kandanmaran, with anger and desperation.

Vandiya Devan could only stare at his erstwhile friend while he accused him of the prince's murder. In his grief, he didn't even realise his precarious position. Nor did he think that he would be blamed for the prince's murder.

Aha! Kandanmaran is blaming me for the murder of the prince! Earlier he had blamed me for stabbing him in the back and now I will be accused as a traitor!

That Pazhuvur seductress! This was her plan all along. That's why she let me escape from her murderous gang... so that I can be accused for their crimes. In one stroke, she had not only fulfilled her oath but had also settled her scores with princess Kundavai. Where is that beautiful ghost? How did she escape? She must have run away with Mandiravadi and his gang through the underground passage...

Next, his thoughts sprang in another direction.

I didn't kill Aditya Karikalar. Then who might have killed him? Was it Nandini? Was it Ravidasan? Or was it that Kala Mugan? Could it be Manimegalai who he saw in the mirror right before he lost consciousness? Could it be Edupankari, who had brought this twisted blade? Did Kandanmaran strike at Aditya Karikalar just to gain Nandini's favour and now shift the blame on me instead? Could it be possible that the prince killed himself after hearing Nandini's confession about her father?

Lost in such thoughts, Vandiya Devan was jolted back to reality when he heard Kandanmaran shout again.

"Guards, what are you looking at? Hold him and tie him with ropes."

Looking at his old friend with grief and despair, he said, "Kandanmara! What is this? Do you really believe I would murder the prince? And why should I murder him? What do I gain out of this? Friend..."

"No! I am not your friend. I want to cut off that tongue that would call me thus. Do you ask what you gain? You would gain the favour of Nandini Devi. That's why you did this traitorous act. Where is that Pazhuvur snake? Where did she escape?"

"Kandanmara, I truly don't know where she is. I was unconscious for a long time. I regained consciousness just before you entered the room, and there was no one here. She might have escaped through the hunters' chambers. Four of her men, Veera Pandyan's bodyguards, were waiting in the hunter's chambers. She might have left with them!"

"So she betrayed you in the end and escaped, is it? But do not tell me that you don't know anything about this. You were enamoured by her beauty and were ready to do anything to gain her favour. The prince knew about this and had told me. Even Nandini herself knew this and had complained to the prince about it. You probably thought that killing the prince might please her! Or maybe she dared you to do it and you did the deed! It is a sin to even look at your face!" he declared.

"Kandanmara! I swear I didn't kill the prince. I was tasked to protect him by princess Kundavai..."

"You said this and deceived the prince, and then killed him. Or else why would you come to this room? How did you come?"

"Kandanmara! I came here to protect the prince from the assassins and failed in my mission. But I am not responsible for his death. If you want you can ask your sister Manimegalai. It was she who..."

“You wretch! Don’t take my sister’s name. Don’t you dare talk about her. If you do, I will strangle you right now...” shouted Kandanmaran and shook Vandiya Devan through the ropes that bound him.

Sambuvarayar, who was drowned in his own grief, then looked up hearing his son screaming. Kandanmaran looked at him and said, “Father, what do you think we should do with this murderer? This traitor has brought shame and disgrace to our clan. If you permit, I will tear him to pieces right away...”

Sambuvarayar looked up, but he didn’t see his son. Instead, his gaze fell on the curtains hung behind the bed, which were moving. The next instant, someone emerged from behind the curtains. He couldn’t immediately see who it was due to the tears that had gathered in his eyes. He blinked away the tears and found that it was his own daughter who had stepped out from hiding.

“Manimegalai! How did you come here?” he asked, and this prompted Kandanmaran to turn around and see his sister.

“Father, I have been here for long. Please do not accuse him of murdering the prince. Please tell my brother not to harm him. He didn’t commit this murder!”

Kandanmaran looked at his father and said, “Father, did you hear this? Do you see how much influence this scoundrel has on my own sister? She says that ‘he didn’t commit this murder!’” He sneered.

“Yes, anna, I can say this for sure. He didn’t commit this murder,” said Manimegalai forcefully.

Kandanmaran struggled to check his rising wrath and shame, and shouted, “Sister, shut your mouth. You are not in the right frame of mind. You shouldn’t have come here in the first place. Go back to the anthappuram where the other women are gathered!”

“No, anna, my mind is not confused. It is you who is confused. Or else you wouldn’t accuse him of this murder!”

“Witless girl! Why are you supporting this murderous fiend?”

“Because he is not a murderous fiend!”

Kandanmaran laughed at her words derisively and asked, “If he is not the murderer, then who is? Who murdered the prince? Did you murder him?”

“Yes, I murdered him. I used this sword to murder him!”

Her words drowned everyone present there in guilt and despair, as they looked at each other’s faces.

Kandanmaran went near his sister and examined the sword that she held, and then snatched it from her hand and said, “Father, listen to this. She cannot even lift this sword, leave alone wield it. And she says that she used it to kill the prince. She couldn’t have even removed it from the prince’s body. And look at its blade. It’s clean. She is saying this to save Vandiya Devan. Why is she lying for his sake? Why is she so worried about him? This scoundrel has meddled with her brains and heart. Look at his face! His guilt is written on it.”

Kandanmaran was right. Vandiya Devan’s face was clouded by guilt, despair, and sorrow. He spoke with great difficulty and said, “Kandanmara, you are right. I am guilty and your sister is saying all this because she wishes to save me.

“Princess, I remain eternally grateful to you and will never forget the brotherly love that you have towards me. But right now, you need to listen to your brother and go back to the anthappuram!”

When Kandanmaran heard this, his anger reached its peak and his eyes reddened as though sparks might fly out of them. He said, “You wretch! How dare you make recommendations for me? Who do

you think you are? So you are saying that she has more brotherly love towards you than me? Who really is her brother? Me or you? And why? What kind of witchery did you do to make her listen to you? You deserve to die just for this. I will kill you with the sword that she had in her hands. I hope that gives you great pleasure,” shouted Kandanmaran and sprang on Vandiya Devan with the sword held high.

Chapter 41: Fire Spreads

Sambuvarayar sprang towards his son and held his hand, saying, "You fool! What are you trying to do?"

"Father, what's wrong in killing this traitor?" asked Kandanmaran.

"What's wrong? If you kill him now, won't they blame us for killing the prince and him, too? Our entire clan will be in disgrace and we will be accused of killing them both. Can't you understand even this?"

"Who would dare to accuse us like this? Will they hope to live after blaming us thus?" demanded Kandanmaran.

"Ayyo, foolish boy! Will you show your fearlessness and daring in this? Woe to me that I agreed to all your stupid suggestions and plans. That's what brought this disaster to my house and my clan. It was you who invited Periya Pazhuvetarayar and other chieftains here. You made Pazhuvetarayar also bring Madhuranthakan here. And thanks to your dear friend here, everyone knows about the conspiracy that was hatched here. After that, it was you who brought Aditya Karikalan here. Ayyo! I never imagined that all our plans would come to this. Malayaman is our deadly enemy and he has brought his army to our gates. What do you think he will do if he hears about this? Pazhuvetarayar is not here either..." wailed Sambuvarayar and struck his head with his hands in despair.

Kandanmaran calmed down on hearing his father's despair and said, "Father, don't grieve. I will try and resolve the problems that I have caused. Tell me what to do!"

"First, take this girl to anthappuram and leave her with the womenfolk. If she says something in the meantime, shut her mouth and tie her hands and legs. Or else, lock her in the secret room!"

Manimegalai shivered when she saw her father's rage. She realized that Vandiya Devan was not in any immediate danger, so she said, "Father, forgive me. Kandanmaran need not take me anywhere. I will go to the anthappuram myself and be with the womenfolk!"

After they left, Sambuvarayar said to his men, "Tie him to the bed tightly."

Vandiya Devan didn't protest his orders and allowed himself to be tied to the leg of the bed. After they tied him up, he said, "Ayya, I was Karikalan's confidant and friend. What did I gain by murdering him? His real assassins have escaped through the underground passage. Please try and find them. I have seen these assassins. I can hunt them down and bring them back to face justice. I swear I will not escape!"

"If you are speaking the truth, then what were you doing when Karikalan was being murdered?" asked Sambuvarayar.

"Ayya, when Karikalar and Nandini were talking, the assassins entered the room suddenly. When I tried to intervene, a huge Kala Mugan strangled me and I lost consciousness. When I regained consciousness, Karikalar was lying murdered here!"

Just then, they heard a huge commotion: shrieks and shouts coming from outside the palace walls. Sambuvarayar heard it intently and said, "Alright, even if you were telling the truth, wait here awhile. Let me investigate what this commotion is all about, and then I will come and hear the rest of your story. In the meantime, you can give company to your dear friend, the crown prince," said Sambuvarayar and left the room. When he did, he also instructed the guards to lock the door to the chambers from outside.

Darkness enveloped the chamber yet again. Indescribable grief filled Vandiya Devan's heart. He remembered everything that transpired at the Kadambur palace when he came there a few months ago! He remembered what the people spoke about the

comet and how they expected Sundara Chola to breathe his last. They had assumed this because Sundara Chola had been ill for a long time. That led to the discussion amongst the people and the courtiers about who would ascend the throne next. Powerful lords and chieftains came to this very palace to discuss succession.

But the unexpected had happened. The young, vigorous, and valiant warrior Aditya Karikalar has died and there lies his lifeless body. But the sick and paralysed Sundara Chola is still alive, but for how long? What would happen to him when he learns that his son has been murdered?

Ayyo! How eager he was to see his valorous son! Karikalar had built a beautiful golden palace for his parents to stay in. How unfortunate that the prince couldn't host his parents at the palace and see them live there!

God knows what else is going to happen because of the prince's death. The entire kingdom is going to be plunged into sorrow. It will result in more clashes and conflicts among the chieftains. A huge fight is going to erupt between the chieftains and lords, that's for sure. The shouts that I heard a few moments ago must be from Malayaman's army. Why did they shout thus? Are they planning to attack this Kadambur palace? Could it be because the news about the prince's death has already reached them?

Aha! How is Sambuvarayar going to manage this?

Even as this question rose in his mind, he knew the answer to it.

Of course, he would manage all this by blaming me entirely for the murder of the prince. But will Malayaman believe him? Irrespective of whether they believe him or not, this tragedy occurred in his palace. Malayaman must know what had happened at this palace. And even if he didn't, Azhwarkadiyan must have told him about it. That's probably why he brought his forces to the gates of this palace.

Vandiya Devan knew how much Malayaman loved his grandson.

God knows what he would do when he heard the news. He might destroy the entire Sambuvarayar race in retaliation and raze this palace to the dust.

Poor Kandanmaran, we were such good friends and now he hates me so much. Thanks to that Pazhuvur snake, all his love and affection for me has turned into vicious hate.

But what's the point in blaming her? Her story is quite sad too. How can I blame her? It's the game of fate.

Fate! Fate!

What about Manimegalai's fate? Why did she love me so much? Why did she have to try to save me and lie saying, 'I killed him'? How can I ever repay her?

Vandiya Devan laughed at himself.

How stupid I must be to think that I could repay her! What's the point in feeling sympathy for others? Is there anything more pitiful than my situation? They are going to accuse me of murdering prince Aditya Karikalan. I have no proof of my innocence. Nandini, Ravidasan, and their murderous gang have vanished. No one was even attempting to capture them. Even if they were caught, they might say that I was in their gang from the beginning and had conspired to commit this murder along with them.

What will be the punishment for murdering the crown prince? They will not just kill me... They will make an example out of me so that no one ever thinks about doing such a thing ever. It doesn't matter what they do to me, but wouldn't the worse punishment be the fact that Princess Kundavai and Ponniyin Selvar will think that I had murdered their brother?

My god! Did I escape from all those dangers that I faced in these four months only to be accused thus...

Vandiya Devan didn't know long he sat there thinking depressing thoughts about his precarious position. Suddenly he saw a wisp of smoke spreading in the room and that broke his chain of thought.

What is this smoke? Where is it coming from?

Soon he could see some light coming from somewhere and he could see the lifeless body of Aditya Karikalar. The doors were locked, so it couldn't be a fire torch.

Where is this light coming from?

He looked around the room carefully and found that the smoke was originating from the hunters' chambers along with the light as well.

Why are smoke and light coming from the hunters' chambers? Did a fire start there? Did Nandini and her gang of murderers start a fire in the chambers when they fled from here? Or did the lamp that Manimegalai and I left in the hunter's chambers somehow cause this fire?

Soon the smoke spread everywhere, and it was becoming difficult to see anything. The fire was now trying to consume the wooden wall that was erected between the hunter's chambers and Nandini's room. Soon the fire would spread in the room...

For some time, Vandiya Devan remained unmoved, watching the fire's progress. At first, he thought this might be the best solution for everyone's problems. The fire would perform his last rites too along with the prince. But he soon changed his mind. He didn't want to die without clearing his name. He didn't care who believed him or not, but Princess Kundavai and Ponniyin Selvar should not believe that he had done this heinous crime. He needed to stay alive at least to

convince them of his innocence. Another reason was the fact that Karikalar didn't deserve this, to be burnt in this palace.

I cannot allow this valorous prince's lifeless body to burn in this palace. His parents, brother, sister, friends, and the people should at least see his body and pay their last respects. Yes... yes, I failed my mission and couldn't save him when he was alive. I should make an effort and at least save his body. I cannot allow him to be consumed by this fire. He was the emperor's son and I should ensure that the people get to do his last rites accordingly.

Until then, Vandiya Devan didn't attempt to free himself from the ropes that bound him to the bedstead. He didn't even check how they had tied him. He did now and found that both his legs and his entire body were bound to the bed's leg tightly, making it impossible to untie the ropes. He tried to bite through the ropes but found it impossible. Next, he tried to shake his body to loosen the ropes and found that the bed too was moving due to that. That's when he got the idea. He moved the bed towards the wall that was now on fire. If the bed caught fire, his ropes too would be on fire in no time.

But moving the bed was not an easy task. He had to move it inch by inch, but he made good progress. The fire was now leaping through the cracks in the door that separated the hunter's cabin and Nandini's room. Soon, the bed and its curtains caught fire and finally, his ropes were on fire. He immediately tried to free himself from them even while the flames burned his skin. Soon, he could free his hands and he hurriedly untied his legs. His eyes burned from the smoke and he couldn't breathe properly.

Looks like I will also die in this blaze! It might not be such a bad idea after all. I couldn't save the prince, I will at least get to die with him instead.

No, no... I should not give way to such thoughts. It doesn't matter if I die, but I should somehow try and save his body from these flames. I cannot allow him to be consumed by the fire ingloriously. I will be cursed for eternity if I don't even make an attempt. I should

hand over the prince's body to his grandfather, convince him of my innocence and vow to bring his murderers to justice. Only after fulfilling my vow can I think of giving up my life...

The room was now filled with smoke and nothing could be seen. Vandiya Devan crawled on the ground, trying to reach the prince's body. When he found the prince, he lifted his body and placed him on his shoulders.

Now he had to plan his escape from this room. It was impossible to use the hunters' chambers. The place was probably burnt to cinders. The main entrance to Nandini's chambers was shut and locked from the outside. He banged on the door shouting, "Fire! Fire! Open the door immediately!" But there was no response or sound from outside.

I am a fool! I should get out through the music room! And I have tarried so long!

Thinking thus he turned again. The room was on fire and the smoke was unbearable. He couldn't see anything. But he moved towards the direction where the music room was situated. On the way, he stepped on the twisted blade that he had held in his hand earlier.

There is some mystery about this blade. Let me take it.

Thinking thus, he bent down and picked up the blade. Just then, a burning ember fell on his shoulder. He shook it down and approached the music room. It was impossible to climb the stairs while carrying the prince's body. He placed the body on the first step, opened the trapdoor on the roof, and then pulled the prince to the terrace. By then, the fire had reached the music room.

If I had tarried even for a second, even this escape route would have been lost to me.

For a while, he stayed on the terrace, gulping the fresh air that was blowing there. He was almost half dead with exhaustion and was tempted to stay there for some more time. But he knew he can't risk it. With the fire consuming the room below, the upper portions of the palace could collapse any minute.

He got up, placed Karikalar's body again on his shoulder, and started running through the terrace. Earlier, when he had escaped from the palace, he had jumped from one mandapam to another and then used a long pole to vault himself over the palace walls.

Could I do that now? Especially when I am carrying the prince's body?

That's when he heard the huge shouts that were coming from around the palace.

Aha! It looks like Malayaman's soldiers are attacking the palace! They are trying to force through the gates of the palace. The soldiers have already breached through the palace walls and are jumping inside. Did Malayaman issue commands to attack after knowing that his grandson is dead? If that were true, what would the soldiers do when they see me approach with the prince's dead body? Wouldn't they kill me instantly? I should be careful lest they see me. I should approach only Malayaman and hand over his grandson's body to him. After that, it doesn't matter what happens...

After that, Vandiya Devan walked slowly and carefully, hiding in the shadows of mandapam and through the dark corners of the terrace. He approached the courtyard where the chieftains had conducted their midnight conference all those months ago. Wondering how to get down from there, Vandiya Devan looked around the perimeter of the wall and found a ladder that was kept there. He saw a man waiting below.

Why is this ladder here? What would happen if I were to use it? But what choice do I have now anyway? I have to go down along

with the prince's body somehow and escape. Thankfully, I have this dagger with me.

Just then, there was a huge sound at the entrance of the palace and the man who was waiting below the ladder moved away from there. Thanking his stars, Vandiya Devan quickly got down the ladder. And just when he jumped down from the last step the man who was waiting there returned.

“Sami, you delayed so much,” said the man. Vandiya Devan immediately recognized Edupankari's voice and he also instinctively knew who he had been waiting for.

Edupankari too now recognized Vandiya Devan and asked in surprise, “It's you! Who is that on your shoulder?”

“Yes, it's me. The disciple of Kala Mugan. He sent me ahead with the sacrifice due to Rana Bhadra Kali and said he would come later. He asked you to wait here. He gave this twisted blade too so that you would know I am his disciple!”

Edupankari said suspiciously, “You didn't tell me about this before! But why is Sami taking so long? How will we escape from here? Malayaman's soldiers have surrounded the palace and many have already breached the walls!”

“So what? If it is crowded, it would be easy to escape. You don't have to teach our Samiyar all that. He knows everything. You wait here until he comes. I will wait in the garden until then.”

Saying thus, Vandiya Devan started walking toward the garden. After he left Edupankari's line of sight, he changed directions and moved towards the palace gates.

Chapter 42: Malayaman's Anguish

After Sambuvarayar left Nandini's chambers, he met his son privately and said, "Son, our clan faces a great challenge, the likes of which we have never faced before. We can escape with our honour intact only if you heed my words!"

Karikalan's death had sunk Kandanmaran into great despair and he now realized the folly of his actions, especially when he tried to kill Vandiya Devan.

"Father, it's because of my foolishness that we had to see this day. I will heed your words from now on. Please command me!"

"You will immediately leave this palace. There is an underground passage in my chambers, under my bedstead. You will take that passage and exit this palace immediately!"

"Father, why are you sending me away, especially now?"

"My boy, you seem to have forgotten the promise you gave me just a moment ago. You are my only heir and the successor to the Val Vil Orri clan, and the keeper of the Kolli Malai mountains. If needed, you will go to the mountains and remain hidden there. Once Prince Madhuranthakan's succession is confirmed, I will send you word and you can come back!"

"Forgive me, father. I cannot hide. I am the scion of Val Vil Orri and do you really want people to remember us as cowards who hid in the face of danger? If you want, I am ready to sacrifice my life right now, but do not ask me to hide!"

Sambuvarayar thought for a while and said, "Son, I was testing you. Now I know that you don't want to hide. I will send you on a dangerous task. Take the underground passage and get out of the palace. Don't go to Kolli Malai but to Thanjavur. Periya

Pazhuvetarayar will be there. Apprise him of what had happened here. And if he isn't there inform Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and Madhuranthakan..."

"But what should I tell them?"

"What do you mean 'what should I tell them?' Tell them about Karikalar's death and that fate has provided us with an opportunity to execute our plans. Tell them that now is the time to gather our forces together. Vellar and Malayaman are going to be against us, but this is our chance to crush their power!"

"What should I tell them if they ask how Karikalar died?"

"What else to say? Tell them that Vandiya Devan murdered Karikalar. Remember one thing, Vandiya Devan had gone to Elangai and met Ponniyin Selvar and came back to meet Princess Kundavai. We know that Ponniyin Selvar hid in Nagapattinam and has now emerged. You will spread the rumour that Ponniyin Selvar sent Vandiya Devan to kill Karikalar so that he can ascend the throne without any opposition. Also, add that Princess Kundavai might have had a hand in it. Tell all this to Pazhuvetarayar and Madhuranthakan."

"Father, whatever you say could be the truth. I cannot put anything past a traitor like Vandiya Devan!"

"Possibly, but the Pazhuvur queen has vanished as well, and we need to know where she went. Vandiya Devan is blaming her and the Pandya conspirators for the murder of the prince!"

"Those who stand accused will try to shift the blame to others. I now understand everything. Princess Kundavai hates the Pazhuvur queen and she might have arranged the kidnapping of Nandini right after her men murdered Karikalar. It seems as though the prime minister, too, has a hand in this conspiracy. Ayyo! Woe to us for not understanding this treachery!"

“Kandanmara, there is no point in regretting the past. We need to look to the future. You need to leave immediately for Thanjavur. Pazhuvetarayar and Madhuranthakan need to know about Karikalar’s death before others know about it. You know the underground passage route that goes inside the fort. Use that and reach them before the news spreads.”

“Yes, I know the route.”

“Then leave immediately...”

“I will leave right away. But my sister Manimegalai, I am worried about her...”

“You don’t have to worry about her. She will not blabber like that anymore. If she tries, I will kill her with my own hands!”

“Ayyo, that’s what I am afraid of.”

“No, I know how to change her mind. Fate is indeed strange. We first thought we would marry her to Madhuranthakan, and then to Karikalar. Karikalar lies dead today, but thankfully, Manimegalai’s heart didn’t engage with the prince. We can after all pursue our original course of action and wed her to Madhuranthakan...”

“But it looks like Manimegalai has lost her heart to that scoundrel!”

“Nothing of that sort. Manimegalai is not of the age where she knows her heart. I will take care of her. You need to leave immediately.”

That’s when they heard the thundering shouts and clamour of steel at the palace gates. Kandanmaran said, “Father, what is this? Looks like Malayaman has come to our gates with his army. What did that old man say when you met him in the evening?”

“He gave me very good news. He said he was elated by the news that Manimegalai will be wed to Aditya Karikalan. He had got his granddaughter along as well and wants to wed her to the prince at the same mandap. When I invited him to the palace, he said he will come tomorrow at an auspicious time. Looks like his army is here to celebrate the upcoming nuptials!” saying thus, Sambuvarayar tried to laugh but couldn’t.

“Come... come, you shouldn’t tarry here anymore. I will take you to the underground passage myself. Get a horse on the way somehow and don’t stop anywhere.”

Sambuvarayar took him to the underground passage and escorted him until they reached the perimeter of their palace walls. He then embraced his son lovingly, blessed him and asked, “Do you want the lamp?”

To this Kandanmaran said, “No. I know this route well. I can go in the dark.”

Sambuvarayar stood there until he disappeared in the dark and then made his way to the hunter’s chambers. For a while, he stood there listening to see if any sounds were coming from the adjoining room. But everything was silent.

He stood hesitating, as though debating with himself about what he was about to do next. He sighed heavily and then put his plans into motion. He placed the lamp that he had brought in an appropriate place and made sure it was blazing bright. He then exited the underground passage through another route and went to the front portion of his palace. The women of his anthappuram stood there in great despair. They had learned about Karikalan’s death thanks to Manimegalai.

“Women, our clan is facing a great danger. You need to be ready to leave this palace at any minute. You might have to spend many days in the forest or the mountains... so be ready to face hardships. Collect all your jewels and clothes and gather here immediately, I

don't want to hear any weeping or crying from you..." said Sambuvarayar sternly.

After talking to them, he went to the palace gates and wanted to climb to the watch tower to see the commotion outside. But before he could do that, the gates broke open and soldiers poured in, trampling on the Kadambur palace guards. Many soldiers had by then scaled the palace walls from outside and were jumping into the palace courtyard.

Fear and despair clouded Sambuvarayar's heart as he watched more and more soldiers enter his palace.

Did Malayaman learn about his grandson's murder? How is it possible? But that's fine. Let him know. He will learn about it soon enough. If I could stall them here for about half an hour, my plan will be executed.

Sambuvarayar stood in the courtyard that led into the palace. He had unsheathed his sword and held it ready. With him were a few guards, armed with spears and swords and a man holding a fire torch.

Malayaman and Parthibendran followed their soldiers on horseback and entered the palace. When they saw Sambuvarayar, they came towards him and Malayaman asked, "Sambuvararayarey! What is this I am hearing? Would you stoop to such treachery? Oh! You are standing here with your sword unsheathed. What are you planning to do?"

"I should be asking that question to you. What's your motive? Why did your army attack my palace and break down my gates? A few hours ago, when I invited you here, you said you will come at an auspicious hour tomorrow!"

"Sambuvararayarey, the auspicious hour has arrived now. Where is my grandson? Where is the crown prince? Where is that valorous warrior who beheaded Veera Pandyan?"

“How will I know where he is? I don’t talk to that disrespectful boy. I told you about his behaviour earlier when we met. And Parthibendran knows it too!”

“How dare you? Bring the crown prince here immediately, or I will raze this palace of yours to the ground and pound it to dust.”

“Parthibendra! What’s wrong with this old man? Has he lost his mind? Who am I to bring the prince here? And who is he to demand that I bring the prince here? Has he come here to imprison the prince?”

Parthibendran replied to him calmly, “Sambuvarayarey, don’t get agitated. There is a reason why the old man is so furious. See this message, and you will understand.” He handed over a palm leaf message to him.

Sambuvarayar took the message and read it in the light of the fire torch. It said –

Prince Aditya Karikalar’s life is in danger. Come immediately with your forces and protect him.

When Sambuvarayar read the message, he started sweating and trembling.

“What is this? Someone is scheming against us. who could have written this message?” he demanded.

“Who cares who wrote this message? Where is the prince? Bring him to us or take us to him. Or else shall I ask my soldiers to search for him!”

“Alright. I will take you to where the prince is. I heard that he had gone to Nandini’s chambers. Parthibendra, you know where that is. Why don’t you take him there?”

“Yes, thatha... come, I will take you there!”

Saying thus, he turned towards the palace in the direction where the anthappuram was located and exclaimed, "Ayyo! What is this?" Everyone looked in that direction and found a ball of fire lapping at the roof of the palace. Dark smoke started spreading around. People started shouting scrambling in their hurry to move away from the fire.

Parthibendran turned towards Sambuvarayar and said, "Sambuvarayarey! I didn't believe this message at first, but now I do. Something is wrong here. There is treason and betrayal afoot. Thatha! Please imprison him and hold him here! I will search for the prince and bring him here!"

Sambuvarayar recovered fast and said, "Parthibendra, yes, indeed treason and betrayal are afoot. But it is you who is doing it. You both barged in here after breaking down my palace gates. You might have commanded your soldiers to set fire to my palace. Wait and watch while we avenge this betrayal..."

Parthibendran didn't hear his warning but began running towards the palace. At the same time, the women of Kadambur anthappuram gathered in the courtyard as instructed by Sambuvarayar. They were in great despair and were distressed beyond words, but none of them cried or wailed. Some of them now saw the fire that was spreading through their living quarters and pointed it out to the others. Manimegalai, who was present among the women, looked at the fire with horror and cried, "Fire! Fire! Oh, God! He is still there!" And then started running in that direction.

Sambuvarayar caught her from behind and gave her a resounding slap on her face which shocked her to the core. She was his darling child and he had never raised his hand on her before. She stood there like a statue, watching her father with wild eyes.

Sambuvarayar, who now regretted his impulsive action, said to her slowly, "Wicked girl! Didn't I warn you not to anger me?" And then he pointed towards someone and said, "There, do you see? You don't have to run wild towards the fire..."

Everyone looked in the direction where he pointed and saw Vandiya Devan walking slowly towards them. Even Malayaman, who was watching Sambuvarayar chide his daughter, looked at where he pointed. Vandiya Devan was dragging himself to where they stood and he was holding someone on his shoulders.

Watching his slow progress, Malayaman felt anxiety, fear and dread in equal measures and his body trembled. The anticipation of finding who Vandiya Devan was bringing seemed too much to bear. Even after he neared them, Malayaman couldn't bring himself to ask him any questions. His mouth dried and his throat choked with emotion.

Vandiya Devan looked at Malayaman and said, "Ayya, here is the prince. I failed to protect him from betrayal and treason. I was only able to save his body from being consumed by the fire. Please take him..." He gently put Karikalan's body down and fell unconscious.

Malayaman looked at his grandson for a long while. He sat down by his body and started sobbing convulsively. He beat his chest and head with his hardened arms and wailed aloud.

"My child... I came here to see you dressed as a groom and here you lie dead... woe to me!"

Broken and shattered in grief, Malayaman recounted Aditya Karikalan's birth and the festivities that happened when he was born. How he raised the child as his own, taught him how to wield arms and how to defeat the enemy. He then narrated Karikalan's valorous deeds in the Sevur War even when he was 16 years of age.

"Why didn't you die in the Pandya war and attain warrior's heaven? Why did you have to fall prey to treason and betrayal at this traitor's palace? Woe to me... it was I who sent you here. I thought that you needed new friends and an alliance. I thought if he got his daughter married to you, then he would support your claim. I thought I was sending you to a friend's palace. And instead, I sent you to

Yama's abode. It was 'I' who killed you. I am the traitor!" wailed the distraught old man.

The next instant, he shook his sorrow off and shouted with fury at Sambuvarayar, "Tell me the truth! How did the prince die? It is impossible for anyone to kill him in an outright fight. How many murderers did it take for you to slay him? Where did you keep them hidden and how did this happen?"

Sambuvarayar retorted back angrily, "Old man, I don't know how he died. You better ask the man who came bearing his lifeless body!"

"Adey! How dare you talk thus? The crown prince of the realm dies in your palace, and you are feigning innocence. Let me see if you reply thus when the emperor asks the same question to you. Guards, imprison this Sambuvarayar! Raze his palace to the ground! Destroy everything..." ranted Malayaman.

That's when Malayaman saw that Parthibendran had returned. He said, "Ayya, there is no need for us to raze this palace. Lord Agni [\[16\]](#) has taken on the task himself..."

That's when they saw that the small fire that they had seen at the end of the women's quarters had spread all through the palace. Huge balls of smoke were emanating from the blaze. As the fire consumed everything, Kadambur soldiers and Malayaman's forces stood there watching the spectacle helplessly.

"Alright! The Lord Agni is indeed doing our work for us. Let's leave immediately. The emperor had not seen his son in three years. My daughter Vanamadevi had been sending message after message asking me to bring her son to her. Let them at least see his lifeless body. Let's take him to his parents. Let's go to Thanjavur. Bring this traitor too... Let the emperor decide how to punish him," said Malayaman, pointing at Sambuvarayar.

Chapter 43: Once Again, Kollida Karai

On the northern banks of the Kollidam River, in a village called Thirunarayur, the ashram of Thirunarayur Nambi was situated. At the entrance of this ashram, a palanquin could be seen with its bearers and royal guards. At a short distance from the entrance, a huge crowd was gathered and they were intently listening to a debate that was taking place between two people.

If we were to join the crowd to see who was in the midst of it, debating, then we would find some old friends. One was Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and the other was the Saivar that we met at the beginning of this novel in Kadambur. He was the primary disciple of Thirunarayur Nambi, who managed his ashram.

The dowager queen Sembiyanmadevi had come to visit Thirunarayur Nambi. And when she expressed a wish to talk to the saint in private, all his disciples exited the premises and waited outside. That's when our Saivar saw Azhwarkadiyan Nambi. And he was naturally incensed. After all, he had been defeated and ridiculed when he attempted to debate with the Nambi earlier.

"You false devotee! What are you doing here? Why are you not in a place where they serve pongal^[17] or puliyodarai^[18]?" demanded the Saivar angrily.

"I have already eaten enough pongal and puliyodarai. I came here after hearing that in your Saiva ashram, only ash is given as food and that everyone is sick after eating it. But you poor things! What else could do? Your Lord Shiva ate poison because he couldn't get any food. Had our Maha Vishnu's sister Parvathi Devi not strangled his throat, God knows what his fate might have been!"

"Veera Vaishnava! Stop such malicious lies. Don't fly high like your lord. Didn't he fly high to see our Lord and yet couldn't find where he began?"

“Now that’s a malicious lie if ever there was one. When our Lord took the Vamana avatar and measured three strides of his feet, your Lord Shiva’s beginning and end must be encompassed within it!”

“From the fact that your Maha Vishnu had to take birth ten different times, can’t we understand what he was about? That too, imagine taking birth as a fish and a tortoise...”

“That’s what you know. Do you know why he had to be born as a fish? To bring back the Vedas that were drowned in the great sea...” saying thus, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi sang an Azhwar’s song that extolled Maha Vishnu’s avatars.

“My dear man, your Azhwars are just 12 in number whereas our Nayanmars are 63. Don’t forget that.”

“Interesting! That’s like saying, the Pandavas were just five of them while the Kauravas were 100 in number!”

“Loud-mouthed wretch! How dare you compare our Nayanmars with the Kauravas? It is your Azhwars who are named after ghosts and ghouls^[19].”

“It looks like you have forgotten that your Nayanmars are also called ‘bootha ganangal’!”

While this debate raged on, supporters on both sides cheered them on. But they fell silent when they saw Sembiyanmadevi emerge out of the ashram, followed by Thirunarayur Nambi.

Sembiyanmadevi took her leave from Thirunarayur Nambi and then approached Azhwarkadiyan, saying, “Thirumalai, you have started fighting here as well...”

“No, Devi, we were just debating. And I swear it was this Veera Saivar who baited me into it. The people loved our debate and were cheering us madly. And it also ensured that they didn’t enter the ashram and disturb you while you consulted Thirunarayur Nambi!”

“Thirumalai, there is no hierarchy among gods, and neither should we create them. It will confuse the common folk and call them to question their faith. My father-in-law, the Great Paranthaka I, gave gold from his treasury to the Chidambaram temple and also gave equal amounts of grants to Veera Narayana Temple. I think it would do us good if we could follow his footsteps...”

Saying thus, the queen got inside her palanquin, which moved in the western direction. Her guards followed her behind while Azhwarkadiyan walked beside her palanquin.

After walking for a while Azhwarkadiyan asked the queen, “Devi, what was the outcome of your meeting with Thirunarayur Nambi?”

“I was able to reach the right decision, Thirumalai, and my mind and heart are free of indecision. If there is no other way to stop Madhuranthakan from ascending the throne, I will have to tell the truth. That was Thirunarayur Nambi’s advise and I completely agree with him!”

“The prime minister was right. He thought that Thirunarayur Nambi would say the same. Devi, it is good that you came here today, because you may have to take a decision regarding this immediately. I have just heard the most distressing news from Kadambur. People hereabouts don’t know about it yet, or else they would have gone to the prince’s funeral procession instead of gathering here!”

“Thirumalai! What are you saying? Which prince and what funeral procession?”

“Forgive me, Devi. Something tragic has occurred and it is something that has never happened in the Chola dynasty. I heard that Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan has been killed in the Kadambur palace, which has also burned down. They are bringing the body of the prince to Thanjavur for his last rites. And I also heard that Malayaman had imprisoned Sambuvarayar and his family and is bringing them to Thanjavur. Over one lakh people have joined the

funeral procession. It would be good if we can cross the Kollidam river before they arrive...”

“Thirumalai! This is indeed distressing news! People were rightly worried about the comet that appeared in the sky! It has indeed taken a royal life! Aha! That peerless warrior! I can’t believe that God would write this in his fate! How many dreams did we have about his future? Aha, what will happen to the emperor when he learns this? His health is already failing. And to know that he has lost his son will devastate him. Only Lord Shiva should protect him and give him the inner strength to bear this loss...”

“Devi, while the prince’s death is a huge loss to the royal family, I fear that the kingdom will be torn asunder due to this...”

“How so, Thirumalai? Do you think the Lords and Chieftains will fight over the succession?”

“You know why they will fight. Some will take your son’s claim to the throne, while others would want Prince Arulmozhi to ascend after the emperor. Kodumbalur Vellar’s army has already laid siege to Thanjavur fort. And when this funeral procession reaches Thanjavur, God knows what’s going to happen. Pazhuvetarayar and his supporters are already gathering their forces to resist Vellar and Malayaman. We don’t know when they will declare war against each other. I fear that blood will flow in the waters of the Kaveri River! This great kingdom that was built by Vijayalaya, Paranthaka and your husband will soon be destroyed due to fratricidal strife. Even the prime minister, whose intelligence has no match in this kingdom, is beyond distressed and doesn’t know how to stop this...”

“Thirumalai, I will stop this from happening. I know how to do that. That’s why I came to meet Thirunarayur Nambi, so that I can take some hard decisions. We will see a civil war only if there is competition between Madhuranthakan and Arulmozhiarman, isn’t it?”

“Yes, Devi. I know not how we can stop this civil war. Aditya Karikalar was older than your son, and that impeded Madhuranthakan’s succession. Now that the prince is gone, there is nothing to stop the prince. Arulmozhivarman is younger than your son, but Vellar and Malayaman are going to insist that he succeed next. The Pazhuvur brothers are never going to accept that...”

“Thirumalai, I don’t care who accepts it or not. Madhuranthakan will never ascend the throne. I will ensure that. I will uphold my promise to my husband at all costs. If it is decided that Madhuranthakan will not ascend the throne, then there is no cause for a civil war, right?”

“Yes, Devi. Only you can save this kingdom from utter devastation...”

“Nothing is in my hands. It is Lord Shiva who has to give us the fortitude to do the right thing...”

For some time, they travelled silently. When they were nearing the banks, the queen asked Thirumalai, “You said that the prince died in Kadambur. That itself is a tragedy one cannot imagine. Do you know how he died? Did he kill himself or was he slain by someone?”

“Devi, there are many rumours about his death. Since it happened in Sambuvarayar’s palace, he is suspected to have had a hand in this. Malayaman has imprisoned him and his family and is bringing them to stand trial. His son Kandanmaran escaped, I believe...”

“I don’t believe that Sambuvarayar would do something like this. No matter how deep one’s enmity is, Sambuvarayar will never kill a guest staying under his roof, that too the crown prince of the realm. But he must know what happened there. What does he say?”

“Devi, do you remember the Vanar Prince Vandiya Devan who had come to Pazhaiarai?”

“Yes, I remember. What about him?”

“I heard that he was next to the prince’s lifeless body and Sambuvarayar blames him for the prince’s death.”

“Thirumalai, I refuse to believe that, too. I have seen that young man...”

“I know, Devi, but the circumstances are against him...”

“Ayyo, Kundavai had so much trust in that young man! She will be distraught if she learns that he is accused of her brother’s death...”

“Devi, I wanted to tell you that. When you reach Kudanthai, it would be prudent to take her along with you to Thanjavur.”

“Yes, that’s my intention. Kundavai is waiting for me there.”

“It’s best that she learns all this from you, rather than from others...”

“Then, you are not coming with me?”

“Devi, with your permission, I will take your leave near the southern banks of Kollidam...”

“Where are you going?”

“There is some mystery that surrounds Karikalar’s death. I am going to investigate it.”

“How will you do it?”

“Devi, I told you earlier about the Pandya rebels who are conspiring against our kingdom. I saw one of them near the southern banks. I know where they meet secretly and would like to follow them!”

“Alright, you have my leave to go. What shall I tell Kundavai? I am very worried about her!”

“Tell her not to worry about the accusation against Vandiya Devan and that I have gone to find the real murderers...”

“May the lord bless your journey with success,” blessed the queen, and the Nambi took her leave. After reaching the southern banks, Nambi took a small boat and rowed himself across the river.

Chapter 44: In the Mountain Caves

After reaching the southern banks of Kollidam, Thirumalai travelled west. The flood waters were still receding, but the storm had created much havoc. At last, he reached Thirupurambayam and found that the town had bravely withstood the worst of the storm and floods. When looking around the town, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi was reminded of a legend about Thirupurambayam, which narrated how the place didn't drown even when the entire world was inundated with a great flood. Thinking thus, he neared the woods where Ganga King's Pallipadai was located.

Many trees had been uprooted, making the woods more chaotic than ever. But there were still enough trees to hide behind. Hiding behind one, he saw three men and one woman standing in front of the Pallipadai temple. They were known to him. The men were part of Ravidasan's gang, who he had seen earlier at this Pallipadai. They were Soman Sambavan, Gramavithan, and Edupankari. The woman was Murugayyan's wife Rakkammal.

Edupankari was saying something to them and on hearing that, all of them cheered. Then Soman Sambavan said, "Alright, then let's also go to Pachai Malai^[20]. It will take about two days to reach there."

When Azhwarkadiyan heard this, he decided that he had to get to Pachai Malai before them. When he turned around to leave, he was shocked to see a dagger menacingly close to his chest. But then he saw that it was Poonguzhali who was holding it. They both smiled at each other even while they were surprised to find each other in the woods.

After the Pandya rebels left the place, Azhwarkadiyan asked, "Poonguzhali, when did you leave Thanjavur and why have you come here?"

“I came here to avenge...”

“Avenge what? And why?”

“One of these three people killed my aunt. I came here pursuing him and was shocked to find my brother’s wife along with him. Before I could do anything about it, I saw you. What do we do now? Will you help me? I want to go after them and avenge my aunt!”

“My god! How horrible! Do you mean Mandakini Devi! The mute queen! Why would anyone kill her?”

“Their intention was to kill the emperor, but my aunt intervened and bore the spear that was hurled on him...”

“Oh! So Mandakini Devi sacrificed her life to save the life of the emperor! When did this happen? Tell me everything in detail...”

“These murderers are escaping and you want me to tell you everything in detail!”

“Poonguzhali, I know where they are going. It’s best that we allow them to get there. I can guess who we will find there, and I can find the information that I want to find while you can avenge your aunt...”

“Alright, then let’s leave immediately. On the way, I will tell you everything that happened in Thanjavur.”

They took the boat and crossed the Kollidam River and travelled in the northwest direction towards Pachai Malai. After travelling for three days and three nights, they neared the mountain ranges and the woods that surrounded them. The woods in these parts were so dense that they couldn’t easily find where the Pandya rebels were hiding. Both were dejected by their failure and wondered whether travelling here had been a waste of time.

That’s when they heard the hoot of an owl. And in reply, another owl hooted too! The sound was emanating from a clearing where a

group of people had gathered. Some of them were cooking food under the sky in large pots while others were gathered around those who had joined them. The newly arrived rebel seemed to be giving them some surprising news.

Ravidasan was already there and he seemed to be telling the newly arrived rebels something. He pointed towards a mountain cave that was situated at the foot of the hills. Azhwarkadiyan saw that and decided what to do next. He turned to Poonguzhali and said, "Poonguzhali, I think that the people I came searching for are inside that mountain cave. I will go inside the cave now. But if any of these people enter the cave, warn me."

"I cannot hoot like an owl, but I can make a cuckoo bird's sound!"

The mountain cave was artificially ventilated and widened to allow light and air to enter. When Azhwarkadiyan entered the cave, he saw a most unusual scene. Periya Pazhuvetarayar was dressed like a Kala Mugan wearing tiger skin. Beside him lay a garland of skulls. Pale and gaunt, there were many wounds on his body and he seemed to have lost a lot of blood. He had been laid on the ground and it seemed as though he had regained consciousness just now and was trying to sit up. Disoriented and bewildered, he looked around in confusion, wondering where he was.

Next to him was Nandini. She now wore no jewels and her hair was unbound and free. And yet, this merely enhanced her beauty. Her seductive allure was more powerful than ever.

She looked at her husband and said, "Ayya, please drink this gruel..." her voice was tinged with pity and concern that she felt for him.

Pazhuvetarayar looked at her. Delight, happiness, and pleasure brightened his face and he smiled at her, saying, "Nandini, my queen! Was it you that spoke just now? Did I hear your voice just now? Where are we right now? Did you just bring me back from death's door? Did you save my life, just as Savithri saved

Sathyavan's life^[21] once? When I was regaining consciousness, did I find you touching my chest? Since we wed, you refused to touch me! Have you changed your mind after all? Give me that gruel. For me, it will be nothing less than nectar from the heavens!"

Saying thus, he took the pot of gruel from Nandini's hand. And then, suddenly, his expression changed and his voice deepened, tinged with impotent anger and wrath. He said, "Demoness, wretch! How dare you touch me? Were you trying to kill me and did I wake up before you could accomplish that? Is this really gruel or poison? Even if you gave me nectar, it will be venomous poison for me," said Pazhuvetarayar and threw the pot against the wall, where it splintered and fell.

Chapter 45: Give me Leave

Periya Pazhuvetarayar's angry outburst didn't shock Nandini at all. It was something she had expected. For the past three years, the old man who had been a puppet in her hands had finally regained his senses. And the strings that were controlling him had been severed. Nandini was not surprised by his reaction, and there was nothing that he could give her now. He was of no use to her.

She bowed with reverence in front of him and said, "There was a time when you compared anything I said to the sweetest honey you tasted. But today, you might find me distasteful, and my words tinged with poison. Nonetheless, I seek your permission to say a few words before I take your leave for good.

"You, who once called me your 'beautiful love' is now calling me a 'demoness'. I agree. I am a demoness who had been deceiving you for the past three years. You gave me sanctuary when I was roaming through the woods alone. You made queens and princesses pay me homage and respect me. You fought with your brother for me. Your love for me only increased whenever the people around us, friends and relatives included, ridiculed you for marrying me.

"You trusted me and gave me everything, but I deceived you most treacherously. I stayed at your palace only to fulfil my oath. I did many things behind your back. I frequently met the Pandya Abathuuthavigal. I mesmerized the senses of young men like Kandanmaran and Parthibendran and used them to serve my purpose.

"Ayya, but I didn't deceive you in one thing. I didn't besmirch your honour by consorting with these men. And until I live, I will be true to you..."

"Nandini, what are you talking about? Is there any other disgrace worse than this for my clan? With this hand.... With this hand... you

used to have a sword. Why don't you chop my hand with it? No.... no I still have some work left. Very important work. Don't take my words seriously and chop my hands."

"My lord, I couldn't use that sword even on the man who I swore I would kill. I was worried that I might lose the opportunity... And that's when you came to my aid..."

"You wretch! How dare you say that I aided you. If I had known that something like this would happen, I would never have come there. Oh, God! Why didn't you kill me when I was thrown in the flood waters?"

"My lord, you didn't come there to aid me! Nor did I ask you to. You and your clan have served the Cholas for many centuries while my goal was to avenge the Cholas for what they did to Veera Pandyan. That's why I didn't reveal my true purpose to you. There were many times when I did think that I could avenge the Cholas through you. Today, I might seem like a demoness to you. But there have been many instances when you stood intoxicated by my beauty... and I did think then, that maybe I could fulfil my vow through you. But I dismissed the idea immediately. I didn't want you to do this traitorous act and invite unending disgrace and humiliation.

"That's why I strived hard to send you away to Thanjavur. But fate brought you back at an opportune time. It was fate that brought you to me, all because you suspected me of not being true to you. If you had wanted to stop me from fulfilling my vow, you would have come there openly. But you suspected me of having an amoral, amorous relationship. That's why you came in disguise. I hope that you have realized that, at least on that count, I didn't deceive you. If not, then I can assure you now about it. I was true to you. And that's why fate sent you to me to help me at an hour when I needed you the most..."

"Nandini, enough. You are torturing me with your words. Instead, kill me. I have no strength in my arms or in my heart to stop you. If you can't wield the sword, then poison that gruel and give it to me..."

“My Lord... forgive me. No. You can't forgive me in this birth. Let me tell you something. In the next birth, we will not remember our past deeds. You will not know that I deceived you. That I took gold from your treasury to fulfil my oath. You will not remember what happened in Kadambur. We both will forget everything that happened in this birth. I will wed you in the next birth, and be your true wife. That will be my prayer for the rest of my life in this birth, that I become your wife again in the next...”

Hearing her words, Periya Pazhuvetarayar, overcome with emotion said, “Nandini, please leave immediately. If you continue to talk thus, I will lose my mind again and will fail in my duty again. You have caused enough harm, please leave immediately.”

“My Lord, forgive me. If I had listened to the advice of my companions, we would have escaped long ago to Kongu Nadu. But I didn't have the heart to leave, abandoning you when you were wounded. You fainted after we came out of the Kadambur palace. My men wanted to leave you there and run away, but I made them carry you instead. And we brought you here after walking continuously for three days. Here, too, they wanted us to proceed to Kolli Malai, but I was adamant. I insisted that we wait until you regain consciousness and I can take your leave now.

“You tried to kill me and there were more than enough reasons for that. But fate intervened and I saved your life instead. Just now, you threw the pot of gruel I gave you suspecting that it might be poison. But do you know, for the past three days, it was I who kept you alive when you were unconscious?

“You let me stay in your palace as your queen for three years and I am indebted to you for that. But I cherished the opportunity that I got to serve you these three days. Please give me leave...”

“Nandini, why do you ask my permission? Leave... If you stay here any longer my mind will lose its resolve.”

“Yes, you might want to kill me again. But if you wish to do so, then I will consider it as a boon. You did come there to kill me, right? That’s why you were in disguise?”

“You were wrong. I didn’t come there in disguise because I suspected you. I feared that if I appeared in front of you as Periya Pazhuvetarayar, then you will beguile my senses again. I didn’t want to give you that opportunity. I wanted to kill you when you are shocked so that you didn’t have the chance to talk your way out of it. I threatened Edupankari, took his dagger from him and came there. That’s not all.

“I didn’t want to shame myself by killing you as Periya Pazhuvetarayar. I feared people would say that the old man suspected his young wife and killed her due to a jealous rage. So I disguised myself as Kala Mugan. But you were right when you said that fate decided something else. I cannot kill you now. But before you leave, tell me something. If I had not intervened then, what would have happened? How would you have fulfilled your vow?”

“Yes... I have to tell you about it. Your anger made me forget it. Before you left Kadambur, I promised you that the prince will not lose his life through my hands, and I strived very hard to keep it. I thought I could fulfil my vow through Kandanmaran, Manimegalai, or Vandiya Devan. I had much faith in Manimegalai. I thought that when Karikalan, maddened with anger, found Vandiya Devan who was hidden there for other reasons, will try to end his life, and then Manimegalai would kill him in retaliation. Vandiya Devan would take the blame on his head to save Manimegalai, and thus I would have avenged Princess Kundavai too. But fate intervened and the prince killed himself...”

“No, Nandini... no. Karikalan didn’t kill himself. Will you fool me still?”

“My Lord, if you had not thrown Edupankari’s dagger, Karikalar would have killed himself using the Veera Pandyan’s sword.”

“Yes, if I had but tarried a second, I would not have committed such a treasonous act. I would have suspected you, instead. Nandini, fate intervened and we cannot change what has happened. But it has also done something good for us.

“You said you wanted to be my wife in the next birth. I haven’t heard anything sweeter than that even from you. When I am ready to give up my spirit, those are the words that I would recall and die. But in this birth, you and I cannot live together anymore. Please leave now. But before you do, if you have any more of that gruel that I threw in my anger, please give it to me. If not, at least give me water!”

“Ayya, I am forever indebted to you for sparing my life,” said Nandini and brought him another pot of gruel.

Azhwarkadiyan decided to slip away. He had learned whatever he had wanted to learn, and lingering there would be dangerous. He decided to think of what to do next after exiting the cave.

Chapter 46: Azhwarkadiyan in Danger

Azhwarkadiyan came back from the mountain cave, sat beside Poonguzhali and said, “My work is done. Shall we leave?”

“Vaishnavarey, if your work is done, you can leave immediately. My work is still not completed!”

“Why did you come?”

“I came here searching for the scoundrel who killed my aunt!”

“Is he not here among these conspirators?”

“He is there...”

“Then?”

“I didn’t come here to get his darshan and gain his grace. I came here to kill him...”

“Who are we to punish these men for their transgressions? God is there to mete out punishments...”

“I have grave doubts about the existence of a God. Even if he is there, I doubt if he punishes such sinners...”

“Alright. Let’s not discuss God. Kings of this world and their officials hold the right to punish these men.”

“How do we know that the kings and their men will do their work at all?”

“Is there a way to find out whether they do it or not?”

“Vaishnavarey! There stands the murderer who killed my aunt. A woman who couldn’t hear or speak. A woman who had been

unfortunate all her life. And when she died, the emperor, his womenfolk, his officials, and his commander stood there... immobile, and allowed her assassin to escape..."

"Poonguzhali, didn't they take any effort to catch Soman Sambavan?"

"They stood in shock, watching the emperor and my aunt. The emperor, who had rejected my aunt all his life, held her in his arms and cried. It was only after I said that I am going after the murderer that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar came with me. But he too returned when we reached the underground passage!"

"Why?"

"While we were running through the underground passage, we heard a wailing sound. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar moved towards it, caught a man, and shouted, 'I have caught the murderer!' But the man said, 'No... no... I am not a murderer.' When Chinna Pazhuvetarayar realized who the man was, he was shocked and said, 'Ayyo, what are you doing here? If people knew that you were here, they would think that it was you who had tried to assassinate the emperor'. Hearing this, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's dear son-in-law asked with great interest, 'Is the emperor dead, then?' Chinna Pazhuvetarayar then said, 'Wicked boy, come with me before anybody else sees you!' And he dragged his son-in-law away. I then pursued the murderer alone through the underground passage and came all the way here. Do you want me to leave without fulfilling my vow?"

"Girl, you should have been born a man. You have the strength in arms and the steadfastness of mind to carve an empire of your own. Anyway, leave that alone. Tell me something. If someone was trying to kill one person but inadvertently and unintentionally kills another, will he be blamed for the murder?"

"I don't understand your question. The man has committed murder..."

“How can you say that? You must have heard the stories of Ramayana. Dasarathar hears the sound of water, and thinking that the elephant is drinking, he lets loose his arrow which kills a rishi’s son. Was he punished for his murder? No. Take this Soman Sambavan for an example. He threw his spear intending to kill the emperor, and your aunt came in between, intercepting the weapon with her body. In other words, one can even infer that your aunt committed suicide. How can we say that Soman Sambavan murdered your aunt?”

“Vaishnavarey, your sense of justice is quite strange!”

“It’s not my sense of justice. It’s how the world is functioning right now. We see people who have committed sins living happy lives, and those who are innocent and guileless suffering grave injustices and living unhappy lives. There must be some sort of justice that Lord Sriman Narayana is meting out to them for them to be thus!”

“You and your Narayana can go to hell for all I care. I will mete out the justice as I know it right...”

“Poonguzhali, I didn’t say this just to stop you. There, in that mountain cave, are two people, and one of them killed Aditya Karikalar. But it was not his intention to kill the prince. He was trying to kill someone else, but the dagger unintentionally killed the prince. Would you call him a murderer?”

“Vaishnavarey, don’t confuse me anymore. Who is there in the mountain cave?”

“A peerless warrior who fought in 24 wars and bears 64 scars on his body. The Lord Treasurer who has the authority to levy taxes and command the treasury of the Cholas. Leader of the most powerful clan in the Chola kingdom and Nandini Devi’s husband, Periya Pazhuvetarayar is there in that mountain cave...”

When Azhwarkadiyan said this aloud, almost as though he was heralding the Lord Treasurer, the Pandya conspirators heard him.

They came running towards him. Seeing Ravidasan, Revadasan, Edupankari, and Soman Sambavan come towards them, Poonguzhali slipped into the woods and hid herself. Bearing a huge staff in his hand, Ravidasan came near Azhwarkadiyan and said, “False Vaishnavaney! Finally, we have caught you successfully. We attempted three assassinations but were successful only in one. But those failures will not bother us anymore. After searching for three years, we have finally caught you! That is enough. You cannot escape us anymore!”

Azhwarkadiyan shouted his reply, “My dear fellow, who are you searching for and who did you find? It is all Narayana’s Maya. Without him, not even a leaf will move in this world. Ravidasa, listen to me. It’s time that you discard and abandon all your worthless Gods and come into the fold of Lord Narayana. Through his grace, you will find a place in Vaikuntam. Now, there, everybody sing along with me...” saying thus he started singing the ‘Narayananey Nam Deivam’ song.

Laughing at his antics, Ravidasan said, “Vaishnavaney, what about Lord Shiva? Will I not attain a place in heaven if I pray to him?”

Azhwarkadiyan, with great enthusiasm, said, “Lord Shiva is a destroyer, while Narayana is the preserver. He came all the way from Vaikuntam to save a mere elephant from the crocodile^[22], didn’t he?”

“Even so, didn’t your Narayana kill the crocodile to save the elephant? What about Hiranyakashipu, Hiranyakshan, Sisupalan, Kamsan^[23]... didn’t your Narayana kill them all?”

“Yes, he did slay them but they finally attained a place in Vaikuntam^[24]. While your Lord Shiva destroys everyone using his third eye and doesn’t grant them a place in heaven!”

“Alright, stop your stories. Let your Narayanan come and save you from us,” saying this, Ravidasan raised his short staff menacingly.

Poonguzhali then took out her dagger and thought of helping Azhwarkadiyan. But just then, a woman emerged out of the mountain cave and was running down the cliff. Poonguzhali looked at her transfixed because she resembled her aunt in everything. 'No, this can't be my aunt. This is the Pazhuvur queen!' she said to herself.

Nandini had by then reached Azhwarkadiyan and she held Ravidasan's hands.

"Don't. Don't harm my brother. Ravidasa, do you consider me your queen? If yes, then you will lower your staff!"

Azhwarkadiyan then said, "Sister, they cannot harm me in any way. My Narayanan will save me!"

Ravidasan laughed and asked, "How will he save you? Will he come out of this tree and save you, like how he emerged out of the pillar to save Prahalad?[\[25\]](#)"

"Mandiravadi, you have no faith in my words. Look at that Ayyanar temple. Do you see the mud horses in front of the temple? They will soon come alive and multiply. Three horses will become three hundred and will come here to rescue me soon!"

Everyone looked in the direction where he was pointing and stood transfixed by what they saw. There were indeed hundreds of horses coming towards them from the Ayyanar temple, bearing armed soldiers.

Chapter 47: Nandini Vanishes

Everyone stood transfixed when they saw the thundering horses coming toward them. It was Ravidasan who regained his senses first.

“Devi, I warned you many times about this false Vaishnavan. I told you that he was a spy and asked you not to believe his words. See what he has done now. He has brought soldiers after us, but they can’t catch us if we leave now. Let’s climb the cliff before they arrive!”

Azhwarkadiyan then said, “Nandini! Don’t go with these scoundrels. You have caused enough harm through your association with them...”

Nandini then looked at Azhwarkadiyan and said, “Thirumalai, I have been asking you for one thing for many years. Do you remember? I asked you to take me to my mother. If you promise to do so, I will come with you or else I will go with them!”

“Nandini, I cannot do that. It is beyond my...” Before Azhwarkadiyan could complete his sentence, Ravidasan said, “Who is he to take you there... don’t believe him. I will take you to your mother. Come...”

“Yes... he is right. He will take you to the abode of Yama, where he sent your mother. Don’t go with them. End your association with them right now. One of these men killed your mother. Look at the Mandiravadi’s face! Can’t you tell he is a murderer?” Azhwarkadiyan demanded.

Ravidasan looked enraged and his face twisted as he shouted, “Lies! Lies!”

Nandini, who had until a moment ago looked peaceful and calm, became agitated. Sparks flew from her eyes when she turned towards Azhwarkadiyan and asked, “Thirumalai, is this true? Is my mother really dead? I can’t meet her ever?!”

“If you don’t believe me, ask this girl here. She saw it herself. Soman Sambavan threw his spear, and your mother died in front of her. She came here pursuing him... Poonguzhali, come here and tell the truth!”

Poonguzhali stepped forward and said, “Yes, I saw it with my eyes, and I came here in pursuit of the murderer. I wanted to avenge my aunt’s death!”

Nandini heard her and laughed with maddened anger. “So you came to avenge, did you? Didn’t you know how well I avenged my enemy? Wasn’t that enough?” she asked. Then she turned towards Ravidasan and asked, “Traitor! Scoundrel! Did you do this?”

“Queen, you are mistaken. We didn’t deceive you. Soman Sambavan aimed at the emperor and threw the spear, but that mad mute woman came in between and died. What could he do about it? Now, are you coming along with us or not? The horses are nearing us!”

Nandini didn’t hear him. Instead, she sat down there. With her hands on her face, she sobbed disconsolately. And in intervals, she laughed wildly...

Ravidasan looked at her for a while and then told his men, “Let’s go up the cliff. We cannot rely on the queen anymore...”

The next instant, everyone ran towards the mountain cliff and Ravidasan turned towards the Vaishnavan and said, “False Vaishnava! Here is something to remember us by,” saying thus, he brought down his staff on Nambi’s head and then ran.

Azhwarkadiyan soothed his head where the blow was struck, saying “Namo Narayana!” Ravidasan and his men were soon entering the mountain cave. And within no time, they could be seen at the apex of the cliff from where a waterfall flowed down.

The horses finally reached them. Since many huge boulders and stones dotted the area, it was difficult for the horses to come there fast. Among the first to arrive were Kandanmaran and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. Behind them came Senthana Amuthan, who was tied to a horse.

Azhwarkadiyan welcomed them saying, “Thank god you came at the right time!”

Kandanmaran and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar dismounted from their horses and came near him. They first saw Nandini, who was sitting there wailing and crying, miserable in her sorrow.

Kandanmaran neared her and tried to tell her something, but he couldn't say anything.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked at the Vaishnavan and asked, “Vaishnavaney! When did you come here and why?”

“Commander, I came in search of the same person you are searching for. Periya Pazhuvetarayar is there in that mountain cave!”

“Truly, is he still alive?” asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, delighted and relieved.

“Yes, truly he is alive. Lord Yama is indeed scared to come near your brother. These murderers couldn't do anything to him,” he said and pointed out to Ravidasan and his men atop the cliff.

“Who are they, and why are you calling them murderers?” asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

“They are the Pandya conspirators. They are the ones who tried to assassinate the emperor, and they are the murderers who killed Aditya Karikalar,” said Thirumalai.

“No, no, it was Vandiya Devan who killed the crown prince. Are you trying to defend your dear friend with these lies?” Kandanmaran objected.

“Fool, be quiet!” thundered Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. And then, he turned towards Thirumalai and asked, “Did they try to kill my brother too? How did he escape?”

“Thanks to the Pazhuvur queen, he escaped these murderers...”

“Why is the Pazhuvur queen crying thus?”

“She just learned that her mother was killed by these assassins. Why can’t you ask all these questions later?”

“Yes... yes, I must first go and meet my brother. Go to him and tell him that I have come here.”

Even after all this, the respect and devotion that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had towards his brother were undiminished, and he hesitated to appear before him unannounced.

“Ayya, your brother will not go anywhere. I will announce your arrival. But aren’t you going to do anything about these murderers?”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar struck his head with his palm and said, “Yes, I lost my mind once before, and allowed the emperor’s assassin to escape!”

“He can’t escape anywhere. He is right there on the cliff. Order your men to go after them!”

The commander immediately ordered his men to pursue the men on the cliff. His men dismounted from their horses and reached the foot of the mountain cave, only to encounter boulders rained on them

by the men on the cliff. A few of them were injured by the rain of boulders, while the others hid themselves to escape from them.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar asked Thirumalai, "Do you know how they climbed the cliff?"

"They entered the cave under the cliff and soon they were on the top of the cliff. There might be a secret path to the top inside the cave. Come, let's go check," saying thus Azhwarkadiyan neared the mountain cave followed by Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

Just then, a tall man stumbled out of the mountain cave and watched them approach. It took a while for Chinna Pazhuvetarayar to recognize his brother.

With his body covered in wounds and his pallor pale and gaunt, Periya Pazhuvetarayar was indeed unrecognizable. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar ran to him and embraced him lovingly, "Anna..."

Tears flowed from Periya Pazhuvetarayar's eyes and he mumbled, "Thambi, you warned me many times, and yet I ignored you and here I stand, disgraced!"

When Azhwarkadiyan and Kandanmaran tried to enter the cave, Periya Pazhuvetarayar stopped them and asked, "Where are you going?"

"The murderers entered this cave..."

"Which murderers?"

"Mandiravadi Ravidasan and his men..."

"They are not murderers," said Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

"There, see... didn't I tell you that Vandiya Devan is the murderer?" Kandanmaran demanded.

“How did this foolish young man come here?” asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

“It was Kandanmaran who brought the news from Kadambur!”

“What news?”

“That Prince Karikalar is dead, and that now is the time to gather our forces and rally support to crown Madhuranthakan as the next emperor. This was the message that Sambuvarayar sent through his son.”

“Aha... is that so?” said Periya Pazhuvetarayar without any enthusiasm. And then he asked his brother, “What’s the situation in Thanjavur?”

“Anna, I have lots to tell you. But first, please sit down. You are wounded and weak.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar sat down at the entrance of the cave.

“Ayya, if you could give us way, we would like to find out if there is a way to go to the top of the cliff through the cave,” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

“Why?” asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

“Ravidasan and his men entered this cave and were able to climb to the top of the cliff very fast. I think there is a path inside the cave...”

“There is no use entering the cave. Ravidasan and his men have toppled many boulders from the top and have closed that path. One of the boulders almost fell on me. It was sheer luck that I escaped. You both go and find out if there is any other way to the top!”

After Kandanmaran and Azhwarkadiyan left, Periya Pazhuvetarayar noticed Senthan Amuthan and Poonguzhali and asked, “Who are they? Why are they here?”

“That girl is called Poonguzhali. She is the daughter of Thyaga Vida Karaiyar, the guardian of Kodi Karai lighthouse. She came here in pursuit of the assassin who had murdered her aunt. Senthan Amuthan is her cousin. He came searching for her. It was he who guided us to this place...”

“Tell me everything that happened in Thanjavur,” asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar and his brother narrated the story of how an assassin had been hiding in the underground passage that connected the treasury and the emperor’s palace and how he had aimed a spear at the emperor, which was thwarted by the mad mute woman who died in his stead.

“Anna, in the meanwhile, Kodumbalur Vellar had brought his forces to Thanjavur and had laid a siege. Since you were not there, I didn’t know whether to resist him or not. The emperor couldn’t be consulted, either. Thankfully the prime minister was inside the fort and he asked me to defend the fort against his forces. So we were preparing to fortify the walls. Thankfully, that’s when Prince Arulmozhivarmar and the Kodumbalur Princess Vanathi came inside the fort. Vanathi had brought an urgent message from Princess Kundavai, while the prince came disguised as a mahout. I thought it might be a good idea to allow Vanathi entry and keep her inside the fort. At the entrance of the palace, I discovered that the mahout was Prince Arulmozhi himself.

“Anna, there is indeed something special about the prince. For a moment, even I came under his charm. My hands automatically came together in salutation, and I had to invite him inside. I am not surprised that the people of the Chola kingdom have so much love and affection for the prince.”

“Enough! That is evident from what you just said. I always knew that the news about the prince’s death was false. Why did he come there disguised? Did you find out?”

“The prince came disguised because he knew that Kodumbalur Vellar would not allow him to go inside the fort. His forces and

soldiers too might have stopped him. I can't help but admire his actions. After he came inside, just when he was talking to the emperor, the assassin struck. He aimed and threw his spear at the emperor. Thankfully, that mad mute woman came in between and saved his life and our clan from never-ending disgrace!"

Hearing this, Periya Pazhuvetarayar said, "Our clan is still disgraced..."

"Anna, what did you say?" asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

"Nothing. What happened next?" asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

"What happened next can only be described as a miracle. The emperor, who couldn't move his legs for the past three years, suddenly got up and went to the wounded mute woman. He then took her in his arms and started crying. We were all transfixed by this. It was only after this boat girl Poonguzhali said that she would go after the assassin that we regained our senses, and came in pursuit of them. And through her, I was fortunate to meet you alive..."

Periya Pazhuvetarayar became emotional when he heard that and said, "Thambi, I have heard of many devoted brothers in our epics, but none of them can compare with you. Alright, tell me what happened next?"

"I followed Poonguzhali into the dungeon passage, and while we were pursuing the murderer, I found someone there. I first thought he was the assassin, but it was Madhuranthakan."

"What was he doing in the dungeon passage?"

"I don't know why he was there. He didn't give me a satisfactory answer for his presence there. I was afraid that people might see him there and conclude that he is the assassin!"

"Could that be true?"

“No. Madhuranthakan is not capable of orchestrating something like this. Moreover, I saw the assassin myself, and it was not the prince. But he didn’t agree to come out of the treasury dungeon so easily. I had to threaten him with dire consequences and drag him out of the dungeon. I left him at his palace and placed some guards around him lest he went back to the dungeon again. After that, I was planning to go back there and pursue the assassin. But someone had spread the rumour that the emperor is dead and that someone had killed him.

“This was enough for Vellar to launch an attack on the fort. The Vellar and the Kai Kolla Padai joined forces to attack the fort, and our men were not ready for this attack. And I was not present at the fort entrance to command them, either. The Vellar soldiers had by then started scaling the fort walls, and they breached our entrance and poured in. when I heard this, I headed to the fort entrance. By then, 16000 soldiers had forced their entry inside while we were just 2000 men. And yet they fought so valiantly.

“I went to the entrance, stopped the fight, and gathered our men in one place. I then decided that there was no point in staying there, and started to leave with our soldiers. They tried to stop us, but we slew many of their soldiers and exited the fort. Before leaving, we sent a message to Kodumbalur Vellar saying, ‘If they dared to cause harm to any of our family members or Prince Madhuranthakan, we will destroy their entire clan.’”

I thought that you might be in Kadambur, and headed there to join you. But we met Kandanmaran near the Kudamurattu River. When he told me that it had been many days since you left Kadambur, I was shocked. And when he learned that you never reached Thanjavur in the first place, we got seriously worried. Then I asked him what news his father had sent, and he told me that Prince Karikalar was dead and that this is our opportunity to rally our forces together and attempt to crown Madhuranthakan as the next emperor. It seemed like sound advice to me. I thought you might be someplace, doing the same. I stationed our soldiers near

Thirupurambayam and sent out messages to all the chieftains who had taken a vow to support Madhuranthakan's ascension - Mazhavereyar, Mazhapadi Thanavan, Kunrathur Perunilakezhar, Mammudi Pallavareyar, Thenthongi Kalingarayer, Vanangamudi Munnaireyar, Devasenathipati Puvareyar and others... I have asked them to bring their forces and join us at Thirupurambayam.

"Anna, don't worry. We will destroy Malayaman and this Vellar and instate Madhuranthakan as the next emperor."

Periya Pazhuvetarayar heard him unenthusiastically. Soon his attention was diverted to something else.

"Thambi, who is that crying there?"

"Anna, can't you tell that it is the Pazhuvur Queen Nandini Devi? I learned that she saved your life with great difficulty. Anna, do forgive me and forget everything bad I told you about her. I heard that the Mandiravadi Ravidasan and his men tried to kill you but she saved your life, is that true?"

"Yes, that's true. If Nandini had not taken care of me for the past three days, you wouldn't have seen me alive, and the world would not know the truth!"

"When I didn't recognize the great qualities of our queen, how would the world about it indeed?" mused Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar didn't react to that. Instead, he said, "Why is Nandini still here? I thought she must have left with the men when they climbed to the cliff through the cave?"

"How would she leave you and go with them, Anna?" asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

"How did you find out that we are here?" asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

“While we were at Thirupurambayam, Kandanmaran was near the banks of the Kollidam River. There he found Senthana Amuthan trying to take a boat into the river. I had earlier imprisoned him for helping Vandiya Devan, and Kandanmaran too didn’t trust him. When we interrogated him, we learned about you. Senthana Amuthan was in pursuit of his cousin Poonguzhali, who had sternly told him not to follow her. But he persisted and was coming after her without her knowledge. In the woods of Thirupurambayam, he heard a few conspirators talk and learned that Ravidasan and his men had imprisoned you and had taken you to Pachai Malai. After learning that you were in the clutches of the Pandya conspirators, Kandanmaran and I decided to come here with fifty soldiers, and this boy Amuthan too was adamant about coming with us so we tied him to a horse and brought him along. Thankfully, we found you alive here.

“Anna, let us leave now. We will take you along with us carefully. By now, a huge army might have gathered at Thirupurambayam. We will take back the Thanjavur fort within a day...”

“Yes, we need to go to Thanjavur immediately,” saying thus, Periya Pazhuvetarayar got up slowly and haltingly walked toward his queen.

Nandini, who had until then been sitting on the rock lamenting the death of her mother, got up when she heard Periya Pazhuvetarayar approach. That’s when she noticed what was happening around her. She looked around her with her eyes wild and lost.

Azhwarkadiyan, who was standing close to her, then whispered to her, “Nandini, say yes, I will renounce my work at the kingdom and leave with you. We can go north to Haridwar, Ayodhya, and Rishikesh. We can sing poems of Aandal and spread Vaishnavism and spend our lives happily and chant the name of Narayana...”

Nandini looked at him with tears welling in her eyes and said, “Thirumalai, your affection towards me hasn’t changed despite the way I have treated you. Your Narayana will bless you...”

At the same time, Poonguzhali and Senthana Amuthan were conversing.

“There look at the Pazhuvur queen, doesn’t she look exactly like our aunt?”

“Yes, indeed, she looks just like our aunt with her hair flowing unbound...”

“From now on, she will be my aunt. I will be devoted to her...”

“I will join you in this, too, Poonguzhali...”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar had by then reached Nandini. She took a step towards him and fell to her knees and touched his feet with reverence. And then she looked at him with devotion. Next, her eyes fell on the horses that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s men had left there. She mounted one of the horses and whipped it hard. The horse sprang forward and started galloping. Until then, those who had gathered hadn’t expected her to do that. And when they tried to give a chase, Periya Pazhuvetarayar stopped them saying, “Stop!”

Shocked by the sudden turn of events, everyone watched her leave silently. Periya Pazhuvetarayar stood there until the horse disappeared from his line of sight.

Yes, Nandini has indeed disappeared, and we will not see her in this story again. But who knows, we might probably meet her at a different place in a different situation!

Chapter 48: You Are Not My Son

Aditya Karikalan's funeral procession was attended by lakhs of people, on the banks of the Kaveri River in Thanjavur. In those days, warriors were glorified, and to honour their death, people would plant seeds of such glory in the next generation of warriors. The Chola Kingdom that had gained power during the time of Vijayalaya Chola saw many glorious warriors after him too. Peerless warriors like Aditya Cholan and Paranthaka Cholan were seen ascending the throne of the Chola Kingdom. Paranthakar's sons included the valorous Rajadhithan, who lost his life in the Thakkolam war while on his elephant. His son Aringzha Chola, too, was a peerless warrior, and his son Paranthaka II brought back the lost glories of the Chola Kingdom.

Aditya Karikalan was unlike any of his ancestors. He had become a battle-hardened warrior at a very young age. At the tender age of 12 years, he entered the battlefield in the Sevur War and vanquished his enemies. The people could only compare him to Abhimanyu, Arjuna's son from Mahabharata.^[26]

This great warrior had not come to Thanjavur for the past three years. There were many rumours about that. Many said that the nobles and powerful chieftains had conspired against him and had stopped him from coming there. Some said that Karikalan had vowed to conquer lands all the way up to the Himalayas, where he wanted to plant the Cholas' tiger flag like his namesake^[27]. And until he fulfilled his vow, he didn't want to return to Thanjavur. But the Pazhuvur brothers were hindering his plans of conquests.

While the people thought thus about the crown prince, when they suddenly heard that the prince had died in Kadambur palace, killed by deceit, they couldn't control their emotions. They gathered in lakhs to be with the brave prince on his last journey.

By the time the prince's funeral procession reached Thanjavur, lakhs and lakhs of people had joined them. The soldiers from the Vellar and Kai Kola armies too had joined this procession. The prime minister had decided that it would be disastrous to allow them inside the fort, especially when the emperor and his family were drowned in grief and sorrow. So he decided to hold the funeral outside the fort and brought the royal family out.

When the people saw their emperor after more than three years, they shouted in grief. It was said that during the reign of Sundara Chola, sounds of grief, weeping, or wailing were never heard in the kingdom. That was, until the death of Aditya Karikalan. On that day, the people grieved with their emperor and shared his deep sorrow for losing a valiant son and a great warrior. They compared the emperor to Arjuna who, too, lost his peerless son Abhimanyu in the Mahabharat War when he stood alone, unarmed and defenceless against his enemies.

The people turned their anger against the nobles who had supported Madhuranthakan's claim and decided that it was them that had killed the crown prince through treason and deceit. To support this surmise, they pointed out how prince Madhuranthakan didn't come out of the fort to attend the funeral. Nor did the Pazhuvur brothers make an appearance. To incense their anger further, they also heard that the Pazhuvur brothers were rallying their forces along with other noblemen.

This news angered the people so much that they didn't disperse even after the funeral rites were completed. They lingered near the site where Karikalan's body was burned, long after the royal family went inside the fort.

They started shouting, "Down with Madhuranthakan!" "Down with the Pazhuvur brothers!"

And very soon, some sections of the crowd turned violent. They moved towards the fort, broke it open, and entered the city within. First, they moved to Pazhuvur palace and started shouting in front of

it. Upon the orders of the prime minister, the Velkarar army tried to disperse the crowd. But when the crowd heard that the prince Madhuranthakan was hiding in the prime minister's palace, they moved there quickly and shouted, 'Bring that coward Madhuranthakan outside!'

Incidentally, Madhuranthakan was actually inside the prime minister's palace, and he trembled when he heard the crowds outside baying for his blood. He said to Anirudhar, "Ayya, please find a way to send me out of this fort now. I know that there is a secret passageway from your palace that leads outside. Allow me to escape through that and I will join my friends who support my claim. If you could do this favour, I will retain you as my prime minister when I ascend the throne!"

"Why are we discussing the ascension now? Sundara Cholar is still alive and well..."

"Didn't you see the emperor's face when he returned after cremating his son? He was pale and ghost-like. He is drowned in grief and sorrow, and will not live much longer. Either Arulmozhi or I should ascend the throne of this kingdom soon. Even Sundara Chola wishes that I assume kingship after him. But only you and my mother are objecting to this!"

"Prince, there is a reason why your mother is objecting to your ascension. Listen to what people are shouting outside. It doesn't matter if Sundara Cholar wishes for you to ascend the throne! It's the people's wishes that matter..." said the prime minister and then looked outside the window and said, "Aha what is this?"

The people gathered outside were now shouting, "Hail Ponniyin Selvar! Long live Arulmozhi varmar!"

Prince Arulmozhi was soon seen on a horse, and the crowd had gathered around him hailing him madly. They now started following the prince. There was no one in front of the prime minister's house.

Madhuranthakan, who was watching all this with jealous rage, now asked himself, “Aha, what kind of magic does this boy have?”

Anirudhar then asked him, “Prince! That day, when Chinna Pazhuvetarayar went inside the dungeon passage in pursuit of the emperor’s assassin, what were you doing there?”

“When Arulmozhi came inside the fort disguised as a mahout, I felt very dejected. I felt that he and I can’t stay at the same place together. So I wanted to leave. I went to the Pazhuvur palace and was standing near the dark place that led to the treasury when I saw a man emerge from there. He approached me and said, ‘Prince! Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Kandanmaran sent me here to fetch you. They said they have gathered a huge army to support your claim!’ I felt a bit suspicious about him.

I told him, ‘If there is a huge army at their disposal, why should I come out of the fort? Ask them to defeat the Vellar army that is surrounding us and help me ascend the throne!’

That man then said, ‘Prince, that’s not all. There is a huge mystery surrounding your birth. No one here is going to dare to tell you that, but I can!’

“If that is so, then come, let’s go immediately!’ I said. He replied, ‘I need to give an urgent message to the prime minister. I will return here immediately. In the meanwhile, why don’t you go and hide in the treasury and wait for me?’ I agreed and went inside the treasury and waited in the dungeon passage for him, but he didn’t come.

“Prime minister, did that man come and meet you? What could be this mystery that surrounds my birth?” asked Madhuranthakan.

“Prince, only your mother, Sembiyanmadevi, can tell you about it. Though I am privy to this secret, I cannot reveal it to you!”

Right as he said that, they heard another commotion at his palace gates. Anirudhar looked out of the window and said, “Aha,

your mother has arrived here!”

On her arrival, Sembianmadevi was welcomed by the womenfolk at Anirudhar’s palace, and she came to the first floor where the prime minister and her son were talking. The queen’s face was shadowed with grief and lines of worry formed on her forehead. She sat down for a while, looking miserable.

“Ayya, my husband left his mortal coils for the abode of Shiva, and I alone have to strive to make his wishes come true. I truly wish he was beside me now!”

Hearing her words, Madhuranthakan answered her angrily, “Why do you look so miserable and sad? Surely, I am going to ascend the throne now. Two hurdles prevented me from fulfilling my dreams. One of them is dead. Arulmozhi is younger than me, and the emperor will not declare him as his heir. My second hurdle is you. if you rescind your objections and accept my ascension, everything will be fine. Why do you stand against your own son? Isn’t this unnatural?”

“My child! It is unnatural for a mother to stand against the wishes of her son, but I am bound by my husband’s words and I cannot disregard his commands. Listen to me, you desire this kingdom out of ignorance! But truly, there is no greater responsibility or burden than reigning a kingdom. It is a life that is devoid of peace and contentment. Instead, turn your heart towards God. Let’s leave this place immediately. Let’s go all the way to Kailasa mountain and seek Lord Shiva’s grace...”

“Aha, it’s time you start your pilgrimage to Kailasa, but I am still young! And I haven’t seen or experienced any good things in life. You raised me like a fool and I grew up believing that there was nothing more to life than chanting ‘shiva, shiva’ and smearing one’s body with ashes. With the grace of Lord Shiva, this kingdom is within my grasp. Why should I give it up?”

“Child, the kingdom that looks to be within your grasp comes to you with great dangers. You said that one of the hurdles that stood between you and the throne was destroyed with the death of Aditya Karikalan, but didn’t you hear what the crowds were shouting just a few moments ago? They are baying for your blood. They blame you and the Pazhuvur clan for the death of the prince. Do you think they will ever accept you as their emperor?”

“Amma, the people will forget all that soon. Once I ascend the throne, they will accept me as their emperor. Let me tell you another piece of news. Listen to this. Do you know who stands accused of Karikalan’s murder? It’s Vandiya Devan, who was Arulmozhi’s friend. He was found in the room where Karikalan was slain. Arulmozhi sent his friend to kill his brother so that he can grab the throne. If the people come to know about this, what do you think will happen to him?”

Hearing these words, Sembiyanmadevi’s anger knew no bounds. Sparks flying out of her eyes, she said, “You wretch! How dare you say such words about the prince? Arulmozhi is ready to give up any claim he has towards this kingdom and wants to instate you as the next emperor. And here you are, accusing him of murdering his own brother. If you talk thus again, not even the worst hells will be enough punishment for you!”

When Madhuranthakan heard this, he sprang up and shouted, “Demoness, you will curse your own son and bless his enemies! Could you really be my mother? No! You can’t be my mother!”

That’s when Sembiyanmadevi said, “Child, I never wanted to tell you this ever, but you have forced my hand because of your stubbornness. Truly, I am not your mother. Nor are you my son...”

Madhuranthakan, shocked by her words, asked, “My suspicions have indeed come true. If I am not your son, then who is my mother? Whose son am I?”

The queen looked at the prime minister and said, “Ayya, please tell him everything. Don’t make me narrate my own shame...”

The prime minister then looked at Madhuranthakan and said, “Prince, you have broken the heart of the woman who had raised you lovingly from the day you were born. You anyway had to know this truth some day or the other, so it’s better that you know it today!

In the early days of her marriage, Sembiyanmadevi wished for a child of her own who would one day inherit the Chola crown. When she was pregnant, her husband Emperor Gandaradhithar was away! And that’s when the two sisters who were mute and deaf were staying in the palace gardens. One of the sisters was also pregnant and was expecting to deliver her child any time soon. When Sembiyanmadevi had gone on a pilgrimage, she found the pregnant woman abandoned, and so she took pity on her and brought her to the palace. And when she learned that the pregnant woman’s sister was in Thanjavur, she called her to the palace to aid her.

Hearing that Sembiyanmadevi had given birth, the prime minister Anirudha Brahmarayar paid a visit to the palace, delighted by the fact that a new royal child had been born! But he found the queen in despair. When she saw him, she cried disconsolately because the child born to her was stillborn.

“Ayya, what will I tell my husband if he comes and asks?’ she cried to Anirudhar. Unable to bear her grief, Anirudhar proposed a solution. The pregnant woman in the palace gardens had given birth to twin children. He spoke to the mute woman and told her to leave the children at the palace. He also assured her that the children will be brought up well in the palace. At first, the woman refused to abandon the children. But after some time, she ran away. The prime minister asked her sister to switch the babies and told her to bury the dead child somewhere. He then took the girl child along with him and gave her to his disciple Azhwarkadiyan Nambi’s father, asking him to raise her as their own.

Sembiyanmadevi then felt guilty about what she had done, and one day, she admitted the truth to her husband. But he didn't get angry with her. Instead, he said, 'Woman, it doesn't matter whose child it is. It was given to us by Lord Shiva. You can raise him as you would raise your real son, but we cannot allow him to ascend the Chola throne. That would be deceit that my ancestors will never forgive. So let's raise him as a devout Shaivite and keep him away from the affairs of the kingdom. We should not support any claim that would come forth to put him on the throne. And if such a thing were to happen, even if I were not alive then, you should stand firm and ensure that he doesn't ascend the throne.'"

After narrating this tale, the prime minister said, "Madhuranthaka, you are neither Gandaradhithar's son, nor is Sembiyanmadevi your mother. You are the son of a mad mute woman who was roaming around in the palace. Sembiyanmadevi raised you lovingly, showering you with a hundred times more care and affection than she would have shown her own son. The least you could do is to heed her words and give up your desire for the throne."

Chapter 49: The Unfortunate

Madhuranthakan heard the tale with stunned silence. The prime minister's revelations left him dazed. He rose suddenly and said, "Prime Minister, this is some trick of your scheming brain. You want Arulmozhi to ascend the throne next, that's why you have concocted tales like this. You then meddled with my mother's heart and made her believe these vicious lies. Brahmarayarey, what harm have I ever done to you? Why are you doing this to me? Just because you want to achieve your goals, will you seize from me my own parentage? I wonder if anybody else in this world would have experienced such treachery! No! No! This cannot be your work alone. Princess Kundavai and Arulmozhi must have put you up to it..."

Anirudhar heard his outburst calmly and said, "Prince, if I had indeed hatched such a vicious scheme, I needn't have saved your life when you were abandoned in the woods. Why did I rescue you then? And don't talk thus about Prince Arulmozhi. Do you know what he is doing right now? He is talking to the soldiers surrounding this fort and telling them that you, his uncle, are the rightful heir, and their demands to instate him as the emperor are not right!"

"Then, this news that you just told me... does Arulmozhi know about it?"

"Arulmozhi doesn't know about it. Nor does anybody else..."

"Why do you have to tell anybody? Prime minister, if only you could keep quiet about this... the emperor gave you ten acres of land, I will write over the entire Pandya kingdom in your name..."

"Ayya, you don't have to hand over the Pandya kingdom to silence me. Your mother's orders will seal my lips forever."

Madhuranthakan looked at his mother pleadingly.

“Child, the prime minister is right. He knew my secret twenty years ago. He told me then, ‘Queen, this is your secret! And unless you choose to tell someone, no one will know it. They will never learn it from me.’ He has kept my secret all these years. He has sworn a holy oath to serve the emperor. And despite that, he has not told him anything about this. If I agree to your ascension to the throne, he would keep this truth a secret forever!”

“Yes, Devi. I would have kept quiet but I would have resigned from my service by then. I cannot serve the realm truly after knowing the truth...”

“But there is no need for you to do so. Madhuranthakan is going to give up his claim to the throne and reject any attempts made to instate him as the next emperor. Child, heed my words and agree to this,” said Sembiyanmadevi.

“Mother, then it is just you who stands between me and the throne? Even if I were to agree that I am not your true-born son, you raised me so for twenty years. Why are you doing this to me? What harm have I ever done to you?”

“Child, you have never done any harm to me. It is I who am harming you. Don’t I know that? I raised you as my loving son. And today, I have been forced to tell you that you are not my son! I know how hurt you are after hearing those words.

“I would never have revealed this secret to you. It was never my intention to do so. But I promised my husband that I would not allow you to ascend the throne. And I will never deceive the royal Chola clan by agreeing to instate a prince not born of the royal line as the emperor. Nor will I ever be a party to such an act.

“Do you think I was happy to declare that you are not my son? I had to harden my heart and say those words. I didn’t want to reveal that even a few moments ago. I was confused and bewildered. I didn’t know what my dharma was. I went to Nambiyandar Nambi and he told me that ‘All are children in this world are yours to claim. I

know that you will never distinguish between your adopted son and a son of your womb. Give everything that you possess to the son who you raised so lovingly, but the throne to a kingdom is a different matter altogether. If through our lie, we are depriving someone of their true claim to the kingdom, that would be a sinful act. Acting thus would also mean that you are being false to your clan and ancestors. If such a situation were to arise, it is best to tell the truth to everyone. That is your dharma.' This is what he said. Child, do you really think that I will get any pleasure in declaring to the world and the emperor that you are not my son?"

Madhuranthakan then rose and fell at his mother's feet and held it tight, saying, "Mother, I don't want this kingdom or this throne! If you want me to stay here, I will be here, or else I will go on a pilgrimage. But please do not tell anyone that I am not your son. If you tell this to anyone, I will not be able to bear the shame!"

Sembiyanmadevi, with tears falling from her eyes, raised her son and hugged him tightly. She then made him sit next to her and said, "Child, I tried to raise you as a Shiva devotee just so we didn't have to see this day in life. I failed in my mission and someone poisoned your mind and made you crave this kingdom.

"Everything is in your hands now. Declare to the world, saying, 'I don't want this kingdom and let Arulmozhi be the next heir.' Announce this publicly and there is no reason for me to tell anyone else that 'you are not my son.' I say this knowing that I am hurting you, but I don't have a choice. Declare that you are ready to renounce your claim, here in the prime minister's presence today. And also after three days, when the council of courtiers and nobles will gather. Announce your intention to not claim the throne and not to listen to any ill advice that these power-hungry nobles might deign to give. If you promise to do that, neither I nor the prime minister will ever reveal the secret of your birth. You will continue to be my loving son, and we will travel together on pilgrimages and renovate as many Shiva temples as possible. Arulmozhi is devoted to me. I

raised him too, just as I raised you. He will not have any objections to what I propose.”

Hearing this, Madhuranthakan put his hands on his head and lamented, “Aha! Only now I am able to understand the many memories that I have had since my childhood. They have been giving me great grief since I was young. But only now do I know what they mean. Is there a more unfortunate being than myself in this world? I know not under what unfortunate star I was born, that I have lost my parentage, clan, lineage, relatives, and friends. I lost this kingdom and the throne on which sat the glorious kings of yore. I have lost my friends... yes, indeed! Who would want to be friends with me once they know the truth? All those who took an oath to stand by me will definitely abandon me once they know the truth. Yes... there is no other unfortunate being like me in this world. Amma, my mind is confused. I can't think clearly. Give me two days, and I will give you my answer.”

“Child, what's there to think? I say this by hardening my heart. You will need to declare publicly that you will not ascend the throne, or I will have to publicly declare that you are not my son. Either way, you cannot ascend the throne. So there really is no other choice in front of you. What's there to think about this?” asked Sembiyanmadevi.

The prime minister then said, “Devi, there is no harm in giving the prince two days. Let him think through this and make his decision. In three days, the council for the noblemen will be held. Let him think and tell us his answer before that.”

“Amma! Amma! Does anybody else know about this secret?” asked Madhuranthakan suddenly, with an eagerness that hinted that some dangerous plan was coursing through his mind.

Sembiyanmadevi noted his eagerness and said, “Apart from us, only three people know this secret. Your father Gandaradhithar, who is no more, and the twin sisters. One of them is your birth mother who died two days ago while trying to save the emperor's life. I

wanted to tell this truth to you when I saw her body in the palace. But I couldn't bring myself to do it and hurt you more.

"Child, if you wish to mourn your birth mother, do so. But she only gave birth to you and abandoned you immediately, and didn't even attempt to see you again. She had lost her mind and was not in her senses!"

"No, even if you had told this earlier, I wouldn't have gone near her. I cannot imagine anybody else but you as my mother. Who is the other person who knows the truth?"

"The other person is your birth mother's sister. She, too, is mute and deaf. She was the one who switched the babies. She will not say anything to anyone. She lives on the outskirts of Thanjavur. And she, too, has a son. The mother and son have a garden and they are providing flowers to many temples in Thanjavur. I have given them a royal grant for this service."

"Aha! I know about them. Both the mother and the son as well. The son is a friend to that traitor Vandiya Devan and had once helped him escape this fort. Amma, does the son know anything about this secret?"

"No, my son. She promised me that she would never reveal this secret to anyone. Apart from her, only the prime minister and I know this!"

Strange evil thoughts were coursing through Madhuranthakan's mind then. He thought that if the prime minister and his mother were to die, then there would be no one left who knew the secret of his birth.

I am not beholden to the prime minister in any way. This woman is not my real mother. Then why should I show compassion and pity for them? Aha! That man who came out of the dungeon... he said he would tell me the truth of my birth. Who was he? Why did he ask me to come and hide in the dungeon? It was he who had tried to kill the

emperor and inadvertently killed that mad mute woman. These people say that she was my mother. If that was true then who is my father?

Aha! Is this prime minister trying to trick me again? Could Sundara Chola be my father in truth? How do I get to the bottom of this?

“Child, I will leave now. Think carefully and decide what you will do. Do remember that I raised you with more love and care than your own mother, who had abandoned you at birth. Give up this kingdom and aspire to find grace in Lord Shiva’s compassion through your devotion...”

Just then, something unexpected happened. Arulmozhivarman came inside the room and immediately bowed to Sembiyanmadevi.

“Devi, I pray that you give me the same blessing that you gave to your son. I wish to renounce this kingdom and pray that my heart gets engaged in Shiva devotion so much that I am able to make some place in Shiva’s abode along with my grandfather. Please bless me thus!”

Hearing this, the prime minister and the queen stood transfixed and shocked.

“Devi, forgive me. I inadvertently heard whatever you were telling your son. I made the people who had surrounded this palace leave the fort, and was coming back here to consult with the prime minister about what to do next. When I heard your voice, I thought it was a lucky coincidence that you were here.

“You were uncharacteristically loud, while my uncle Madhuranthakar was shouting most of the time. I didn’t know if this was an opportune time to meet you. That’s when I heard one part of your conversation. Devi, you were saying that among the living, Senthana Amuthan’s mother, the prime minister, and yourself were

the only ones who knew about the secret of Madhuranthakar's birth. That's not right. My sister and I knew about it long back.

"I met Mandakini Devi many times while I was in Elangai. There, she told me these secrets through some paintings that she had drawn. And when I came back here, I told my sister too. And that's when we both came to a decision. Madhuranthakar might not be your own son, but he was raised by you, and he is also the son of Kaveri Amman who saved my life many times. She gave her own life to save the emperor's life.

Madhuranthakar has equal rights to this throne as anybody else. And if there are any other concerns about his claim to the throne, I will champion his cause. I hereby sacrifice any claim that I might have, at your feet. You don't have to proclaim publicly that he is not your son, and my uncle doesn't have to sacrifice his claim, either."

Hearing Arulmozhi speak, we can say that the people in the room were never more surprised than ever before in their lives.

"Prince, your words are worthy of an epic tale. They need to be immortalized in gold and stone so that the people remember the sacrifice that you wish to make. But this decision has to be made in front of the emperor, nobles, and chieftains. We should also think about the fact that if the truth comes out later, what will be the repercussions of that? Prince, the council will convene in three days. And until then, let's all think through this carefully."

Chapter 50: Kundavai's Anguish

Kundavai was born amidst wealth and opulence. She was as beautiful as the celestial Rathi, as intelligent as Goddess Saraswathi, and as lucky as Goddess Lakshmi herself. Right from her own father – the emperor – to the common folks, everyone respected and admired her. Everyone was eager to fulfil her wishes and yearned for such an opportunity to please her. The noblemen and courtiers of the Chola Kingdom longed to send their daughters to be her maidservants while all the ruling kings of Bharata Kadam wanted her hand in marriage.

It is indeed unfortunate that some like Kundavai, who had been so fortunate since her birth, should face one devastating blow after another. All her warnings to Karikalan had been ignored. Karikalan, who had always heeded her wise counsel, chose to ignore it, and went to Kadambur palace, where he was killed mysteriously. She had truly believed that Nandini was their sister, and she wished to avenge Karikalan. If she had truly fulfilled her vow, there was no greater ignominy or disgrace for their clan than that. And no one knew what happened to her after the crown prince died.

Drowned in her grief of losing her brother, Kundavai couldn't forget Karikalan's face: valorous, handsome, and brave, he had given up his life just as bravely as he had led his life as a warrior.

He had so many dreams! How many times did he tell me that he wanted to go all the way to the Himalayas and plant the Chola flag there just as his namesake did? A man with such lofty dreams was reduced to a mere handful of ash and dust within half an hour! From this ash and dust will emerge hundreds and thousands of warriors who would spread the fame of Chola glory all around the world. They would travel in ships to faraway lands and bring those kingdoms under the yoke of the tiger flag. Wherever they go, they will build huge temples that would stand the test of time and proclaim the greatness of the Cholas. They would spread the culture of Tamil, its

literature, and its sects of Saivism and Vaishnavam among the populace. And wherever they go, the immortal Tamil cry 'Vettri Vel, Veera Vel' will reverberate.

These weren't mere dreams. These could become real through Arulmozhivarman, whose horoscope proclaimed the greatness that he would attain one day.

But there were many hurdles. Ah! There was no dearth of hurdles. God knows what these noblemen and chieftains were planning. Malayaman and Vellar are determined to set Arulmozhi on the throne, while the Pazhuvur brothers and their companions were gathering their forces to support Madhuranthakan's claim to the throne. The emperor was anguished by the successive deaths of Mandakini and Karikalan and was refusing to talk to anybody. He blamed himself for their deaths and held his past sins responsible for their untimely deaths. No one was able to console him or provide him with a balm to soothe his soul. Even his own daughter hesitated to approach him then! What can be said about others?

On the other hand, Prince Arulmozhi was determined to give up his claim to the throne, crown Madhuranthakan as the next emperor, and take the Chola fleet across the seas to start his victory campaign. But there was a hurdle there, too. For some reason, Queen Sembiyanmadevi was set against her son ascending the throne. And when asked for a reason, she said she was acting according to the late king's commands.

God knows how these problems will ever be solved.

As if this were not enough, Kundavai was plagued by another worry. Vandiya Devan, the man who had captured her heart, was now shut in the underground dungeon prison, accused of killing her brother. That Pallava prince Parthibendran was dead set at pinning the blame on Vandiya Devan.

Her grandsire Malayaman might listen to her, but it would complicate things if she were to interfere and ask that Vandiya Devar

be set free, that too when he stands accused of such a grave crime. Wouldn't people ask why she was so partial to him? Wouldn't they say that she probably cares more about the Vanar prince than her own brother? That Parthibendran is capable of spreading such rumours. Kandanmaran and his father claim that they found Vandiya Devan next to the prince as he lay slain. This could be true. Vandiya Devar was asked not to leave the prince alone at any time, and he probably fulfilled this request of hers. But must have failed to save the prince from his murderers.

But how do I get to the bottom of this? If I were to go to the underground prison to meet him or bring him here, it would lead to unwanted rumours and baseless lies. No one would dare to spread lies about me. Even if they do, I don't really care! But they might try to blame Arulmozhi and say that he was behind Karikalan's death. I shouldn't act hastily and provide fodder for their lies...

Oh, God! I didn't have many worries or troubles since the time I was born. Was it only to face them all at once?

Kundavai's anguish about her brother's death and her worries about the kingdom wounded her heart, giving her unbearable pain. And right since she knew that Vandiya Devan was being accused as the murderer, she was finding it difficult to sleep at night. She was constantly thinking of ways to resolve the rising conflicts but discarded them one after another.

She closed herself off with her thoughts and refused to discuss them even with her close friend and confidante Vanathi. Vanathi, who understood the Kundavai's misery, remained by her side like a shadow and didn't intrude.

That day, Vanathi, who largely remained silent by her side, came to her and said, "Akka, there is a girl who has come to meet you. She is disconsolate and miserable and is crying a lot!"

Kundavai heard her and said, "Didn't you ask who she is and why she has come?"

“I did. But I am afraid you might get irritated when you hear it. Her name is Manimegalai. She is the daughter of Sambuvarayar. They have imprisoned her family at Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s palace. But she escaped somehow and came here to meet you. When I asked her about it, she said she would tell whatever she came here to tell only to you. If you were to look at her, you too will feel sorry for her!”

“Then are you accusing me of being stone-hearted?” asked Kundavai angrily.

“Yes, you do have a stone heart, akka. Otherwise, would you allow the Vanar Prince to languish in the prison thus?”

“Alright, bring that girl here,” said Kundavai.

Vanathi hurriedly left the princess’s presence to bring Manimegalai.

Chapter 51: Manimegalai asks a Boon

Bewildered and lost, Manimegalai came in Kundavai's presence, misery personified. Vanathi had not exaggerated when she said that we would feel sorry for her. She was indeed looking miserable and desperate. Her eyes were swollen and had become red from constant crying.

But for some reason, Kundavai didn't feel any pity for her. She couldn't help but remember that all the recent misfortunes that the kingdom was facing were due to the midnight conference that happened in Kadambur a while ago. And lastly, her valorous brother fell dead in their palace! This incensed her anger tenfold.

She also remembered another piece of information about Manimegalai. Vandiya Devan and Kandanmaran were old friends, and it was due to that friendship that the Vanar prince happened to stay in the Kadambur palace when he learnt about the conspiracy hatched by the noblemen. At one point, Kandanmaran had plans to wed his sister to Vandiya Devan... it must be this girl.

Once she remembered this information, she looked at the girl with renewed interest.

Aha! Why has this girl come here? Has she come here to petition for her brother and father? When Karikalan was invited to Kadambur, there was a proposal to wed this girl to her brother. Did this girl perchance lose her heart to Karikalan? Is that why she is here?

What if... what if it was something else? I am sure Kandanmaran would have told her about Vandiya Devan. She must have met him several times before, and this time he stayed at her palace for many days. Has she lost her heart to him perchance? If so, then it can be presumed that he must have rejected her. Is she here to accuse Vandiya Devan...

While these thoughts coursed through Kundavai's mind, she looked at Manimegalai with her sharp eyes. And the poor girl, unable to bear the intensity of the princess's gaze, looked down with tears falling from her eyes.

"Girl, why do you cry thus? Your brother is still alive, isn't he? It's my brother who has lost his life. But do you see me crying? We women who belong to the brave race of Cholas do not cry when their menfolk attain a warrior's death!"

Manimegalai looked up and said, "Devi, if my brother had died in the war, I wouldn't have cried, either. But the one who died..."

Kundavai concluded that the girl had indeed lost her heart to Karikalan, and that was what she was hesitating to reveal. When she realized this, her heart relented, and she said, "Girl, strengthen your heart. Yes, indeed, it was my brother who died in your palace. But why should you cry about that? Are you grieving because this tragedy occurred in your palace? But how can it be your responsibility? The elders in your family owe us an explanation for what had happened..."

"No, Devi! It was my responsibility. That's why I am not able to control my anguish and despair. My heart breaks into pieces every time when I realize that I killed that great warrior with my dagger!"

Startled by Manimegalai's strange confession, Kundavai asked, "Girl, what are you blabbering? Have you lost your mind?"

"No, no, I haven't lost my mind. Nor am I blabbering. Let me tell you what happened. I killed Aditya Karikalar. I came here to confess my crime and to seek punishment..."

"What's this you are saying? You are disgracing my valorous brother and dishonouring his memory by claiming that you killed him. Do you really want me to believe that a small girl like you killed that peerless warrior? Who taught you these things?"

“No one taught me anything, Devi. No one believes what I am saying. My brothers and father refuse to listen to anything I say...”

“Why are you lying? It’s your brother and father who sent you here, didn’t they, and asked you to claim that you killed Karikalan? Or you probably came here of your own accord to save their lives and let your imagination run riot to tell me such a tale...”

“Devi, why would I try to save them? They tried to marry me off against my wishes. First, they brought Madhuranthaka Devar and said ‘you will marry him’ and then, one day, suddenly, they brought Aditya Karikalar and said, ‘you will marry the crown prince and become the empress of this realm’. They tried to sacrifice me thus at the altar of their ambition. So why would I petition on their behalf, and why would I confess to a crime that they have committed? Never...”

“Girl, everything that you just said is incredibly strange and bizarre. Kings far and wide wanted to wed their daughters to my brother, and you say that your father and brother were trying to sacrifice you? Why do you say that?”

“Devi, I don’t have any sister by birth. I consider you as my sister and open my heart to you...”

“How dare you claim me as your sister, even while you say you killed my brother?” asked Kundavai harshly.

“I do have that right. Your brother considered me as his own sister. He wrote about it, too. That’s what is breaking my heart. To think that I killed him. That’s why I came here to seek punishment for my crimes,” saying thus, Manimegalai started sobbing piteously.

Kundavai turned to Vanathi and whispered, “Looks like this girl has really lost her mind. What will we do if she becomes wild?”

Vanathi said, “Akka, I am worried about the same. Please don’t get angry. Let’s speak to her calmly and send her away!”

Kundavai turned to Manimegalai and said, "Girl, fate has made a mockery of our lives and we cannot change the past. Don't cry. Consider me as your own sister. You wanted to tell me something, right? If you want to tell it now, you can go ahead. Or else you can tell me later!"

"No... no, I should tell you now. Akka, you are a woman, you will understand what I am trying to tell you. No matter how much one explains this to the men, they will not understand. Imagine if you have lost your heart to someone, and he stands in front of you unarmed, and his enemy is trying to kill him with a sword in hand. In this situation what would you do? If that woman bears true love in her heart for her beloved, what do you think she should do? Will she see her beloved man being cut to pieces in front of her eyes?"

Kundavai was now reminded of Mandakini, and her eyes welled up with tears.

"How will she stand there without doing something? Won't she help him somehow, even at the cost of losing her own life?"

When Manimegalai heard her, she lamented, "Alas, I had no one with me to give me such advice. I had only that wretch, Nandini, who was plotting revenge. Thanks to her, I killed a man who considered me his sister and was planning to get me married to my beloved. I killed him with these very hands..."

Kundavai looked at Vanathi and whispered, "I think her madness is going to peak anytime soon!"

She then looked at Manimegalai and said, "Girl, don't cry like this. Tell me what happened. And if you don't want to talk about it now, you can tell me later!"

"No, no, I need to tell you everything now. My brother Kandanmaran told me about his friend for many years. A few months ago, he came to our palace. And when I saw him first, I lost my heart to him and started considering him as my future husband..."

Kundavai's voice shook when she asked this question next, "Who is this lucky man that stole your heart thus?"

"No, he is not lucky. Right from the time I lost my heart to him, he also seemed to have gotten my unfortunate stars. Today, he is imprisoned in the underground prison in Thanjavur. Akka, the women in the Pazhuvur palace said that the underground prison is a dangerous place from where the prisoners never come out once they are locked up, is that true?"

"That's a lie, girl. A few months ago, Vanathi and I went to the prison to meet someone!"

"Devi, can I go to the underground prison and meet him?"

"You haven't yet told me who he is?"

"He is the prince of Vanar, his name is Vandiya Devan!"

Kundavai and Vanathi looked at each other, and then Vanathi asked Manimegalai, "Why are you so worried about the Vanar Prince? What is your relationship with him?"

Manimegalai retorted back in anger, "Who are you to ask this question to me?" And then, she immediately calmed down and said, "You are Kodumbalur Vanathi, aren't you? It is your uncle who holds the underground prison under guard. I beg of you, please give me a boon. Please tell your uncle to release Vandiya Devan immediately. Imprison me instead, and send me to prison. When I am admitting my crime, why won't you listen to me? Devi, I fall at your feet, please give me this boon. If Vellar doesn't give me any justice, I would like to petition to the emperor. Please help me meet him!"

Kundavai's heart was overwhelmed with emotions. Here she was, hesitating to even go and see the prince who had captured her heart, while this girl was ready to accept the murder charge!

But how much of what says can I believe? Is she saying this just so that Vandiya Devar gets released from prison, or could she have really killed Karikalan thanks to that demoness Nandini?

No, she can't have killed my brother. It's impossible. She is saying this just to save Vandiya Devar's life. No, no one will believe her and release Vandiya Devar based on what she says.

But there is a mystery behind Karikalan's death. Could I unravel the truth with her help?

"Manimegalai, I admire the steadfastness of your heart and devotion to your beloved. The way you are trying to protect that man you love deserves a place in history. Unfortunately, there are no poets here to compose a song on you. But even if I believed in your words, the world around us will not. Your brother and father claim that they found Vandiya Devar near Karikalan's slain body. Do you think people will believe them or you? There is an additional reason for them not believing your words.

"It was I who sent Vandiya Devar to my brother, to stop him from going to Kadambur. And despite that, if he went there, I had instructed him to remain by his side and protect him. When Karikalan died, Vandiya Devar was beside him. And that means he has failed in his duty. He should have given up his life to save his master's life. Even if he didn't kill my brother, he has indeed failed in his duty. And for that transgression, he will be punished!"

"Devi, he didn't fail in his duty."

"Is there any other proof other than what you are saying?"

"I do have proof in your brother's own hand," saying thus, Manimegalai took out a message that she had hidden in her sari folds.

Kundavai looked at the olai with great interest. It was indeed written by Karikalan, in his own hand. He didn't use a scribe,

probably because he wanted to keep whatever he had written private, and the message was addressed to her.

To my esteemed sister, Kundavai Devi, the dear daughter of Emperor Sundara Chola written by Crown Prince Aditya Karikalan.

'It's been many years since I slept at night. I committed a heinous crime three years ago. I slew an enemy who had surrendered to me and stood helpless. And since then, the woman who had begged for his life and his spirit has been tormenting me every second.

Early this morning, when I looked up at the sky, I saw the comet's tail fall to the ground and vanish. At that moment, my spirit parted from my body. I sincerely hope that this ill omen doesn't touch my brother and father and that it takes me alone.

When we were young, you and I dreamed many things about how we will bring glory to this kingdom. I may not be able to fulfil those dreams, but my brother will take them forward and make them a reality. He was born to rule the three worlds and Vandiya Devan will be an apt companion for him.

Devi, I am glad that Vandiya Devan has completed whatever mission you set for him satisfactorily! Or else, you wouldn't have sent him here to save me from my fate.

Sister, if something were to happen to me here, it is my fate and my stubbornness that should be held responsible, and not Vandiya Devan. Just as you instructed, he tried his utmost to stop me from coming to Kadambur. After coming here, he is shadowing me constantly. To fulfil his mission, he befriended this girl, her name is Manimegalai, and tries to reach in advance all those places where I am planning to visit.

He is trying his utmost to save me from my fate! But is it possible?

I have heard that a cobra's mesmerizing beauty is so potent that small animals go to it on their own to be devoured. I, too, am going to Nandini in the same way. You have warned me saying that she is our sister. But I am not able to believe that. Yet, there is some mystery about her. And that's why I am going to learn about it today. No matter what happens to me, don't blame Vandiya Devan. He is doing everything that he can to fulfil the mission you have set him on.

Sister, that seductress Nandini has mesmerized the senses of both Kandanmaran and Parthibendran. Only Vandiya Devan has escaped her clutches!

I know not how to reward him for all that he has done for us. At this palace, there is a very clever girl called Manimegalai, who is dear to me as my own sister. I thought that it might be a good idea to wed Manimegalai to Vandiya Devan. But I know not what you will think about that. My dear sister, I am going to hand over this olai to that girl. Thankfully, she doesn't know to read. I leave it for you to decide what you wish to do about these two.

In our family, there is no one to match your intelligence. I didn't heed your words this time, and I am going to face the consequences of that. Let my brother at least heed your wise words and fulfil the dreams that we had for this glorious kingdom.'

At this point, the message came to an end and Kundavai wiped the tears that were escaping her eyes. She asked Manimegalai, "Girl, how did you get this olai? Who gave it to you?"

"Devi, the prince himself gave it to me. Nandini had poisoned my ears about him, and I thought that he was giving me a 'love message' through this olai. I thought I would burn it, but was also curious to see what he has written and kept it with myself. Later, I asked my friend Chandramathi to read it for me. When I realized that

he had considered me his sister, my heart broke into smithereens. Devi, please punish me harshly like you would punish a murderer!”

Manimegalai’s agitation and distress made it clear to Kundavai that she was claiming to have killed Karikalar just so she could save Vandiya Devar. And yet, the olai she had brought could help Vandiya Devar and get him out of the prison. If this girl could just keep her mouth shut and not say anything, she could use the olai to help Vandiya Devar.

“Manimegalai, are you still saying that you killed my brother?”

“Yes, Devi!”

“You just told me that you read this olai. If you had, then you know that my brother considered you as his ‘dear sister.’ Then why would you kill him?”

“Had I read the olai before, I would not have killed him. I did the deed without knowing what lay in his heart. That wretch, Nandini, had poisoned my mind...”

“How did she poison your mind?”

“She kept saying that Karikalar was angry with Vandiya Devar, and that he might kill him too. And just as she claimed, Karikalar too went around the room searching for Vandiya Devar, with his sword in hand. He shouted ‘Where is Vandiya Devar? I am going to kill him now!’ I truly believed that he would kill him, and used the dagger in my hand to kill the prince.”

“Girl, you need to stop that tale. I refuse to believe that my valorous brother was killed by a mere girl like you!”

“Devi, then who would have killed the prince? Next to Karikalar’s body, only two of us were there. Vandiya Devar and myself. And if the prince of Vallam is not the murderer, then it must be me.”

“You are dishonouring my brother’s memory by saying this. Think about this! Just as you are trying to save the Vanar prince, he too might accept the accusation and say that he killed the crown prince. Do you really think he might sit there quietly while you take the blame on your head? In your case, they might not punish you, since you are a woman. But they will not spare him. For the crime of killing a royal prince, he will be publicly executed on the streets of Thanjavur...”

Hearing this, Manimegalai lost control and started crying in earnest. “Akka, only you can save him now,” she sobbed.

Chapter 52: Restrictions to Freedom

Kundavai didn't know how to console the distraught Manimegalai. She herself was anguished and distressed by Manimegalai's revelations, and she didn't know how to resolve the situation.

Just then, a huge shout rose in front of the palace.

"Vanathi, check what's happening. These people are not concerned about the emperor's health and are disturbing peace with every chance they get!"

Vanathi went to the balcony to check what was happening, and then came back hurriedly to the room. "Akka, he is coming!" she said.

"Who is coming?" asked Kundavai with a smile.

"Your brother, akka!"

Kundavai immediately said, "Alright, take this girl away for now." But when Vanathi hesitated, she said, "Go fast, he won't leave without seeing you. I will send for you!"

Right after Vanathi took Manimegalai away, Ponniyin Selvar entered the room.

"Thambi, what is this? Wherever you go, crowds are gathering around you, and they start shouting. Today, you brought these crowds right up to the palace. Imagine how hurtful all this would be to our father?!"

"What do I do, akka? Do you think it gives me any pleasure to see these crowds demanding that I ascend the throne even before my brother's body turned into ashes? I am tempted to run away from here, but I am hesitating only because it will cause more problems.

The people will then blame Madhuranthakan and the chieftains for murdering me. That's the only thought that is stopping me from running away from this mayhem..."

"Yes, don't even think about it. Forget about what the people will think, our father's heart will shatter. He is devastated by the tragic deaths of Mandakini Devi and our brother. If you were to go missing again, he will be lost in despair!"

"That's why I am not going. Instead, I am trying to change the mind of the people. Wherever I go, I tell the people that our uncle is the rightful heir and they listen to me and nod their heads. But the minute I come away from there, Malayaman and Vellar come there and change their mind again, and they start their demands again. Akka, I came here to talk about these old men. You need to talk to them and change their mind. They are not listening to reason!"

"I have tried to change their mind, but they are stubborn. We need to try something else!"

"Akka, you might have forgotten to tell Vellar one news. If you did, maybe he might not be so keen to see me ascend the throne!"

"What is that, Thambi?"

"You should tell him about your friend Vanathi's vow about not ascending the throne with me. If you tell him that, he may not be so eager to crown me the emperor!"

"Thambi, do you really think that I didn't tell him about it? I did, and this was his response. 'Just because this girl foolishly swore a vow, should we allow this kingdom to go to ruins? There are kings in the entire Bharata Kadam waiting to give their daughters in marriage to Arulmozhi!' Saying this, he looked at Vanathi angrily. Poor girl, she got scared!"

Arulmozhi smiled at her and said, "I hope she didn't fall into a faint..." And he looked around, hoping to see her.

“I have sent Vanathi on an errand,” said Kundavai.

“Akka, if you and Vanathi are on my side, then we can manage somehow. We should speak to the emperor. These old men will only listen to him!”

“There is a hurdle there, too. Sembiyanmadevi hasn’t given her consent for her son to ascend the throne. If she remains stubborn, what will our father do? I am worried about his health and state of mind. The confusion that is reigning regarding succession matters is distressing him so much that I am afraid he might lose his mind. That’s why I am hesitating to talk about this to him!”

“Then we both have to talk to Sembiyanmadevi and try to change her mind. The reason why she is stubborn against Madhuranthakan’s ascension is exactly as we had guessed. I met her a little while ago at the prime minister’s house. She had just then revealed to Madhuranthakan that he was not her son. You should have seen our uncle’s handsome face then. He became so incensed that he looked like a demon. Thank God, I reached there on time...”

“Is that so? What happened next?” asked Kundavai.

“I stood before our grandmother and said, ‘Devi, I know that Madhuranthakar is not the son of your womb, but you raised him lovingly and he is your son in all ways but one. So he is the rightful heir to this kingdom.’”

“What did our grandmother say to that?”

“I didn’t wait for a reply. I left before they could say anything!”

“Thambi, didn’t you tell them that Madhuranthakar has other rights on the throne? Even if he is not the son of Sembiyanmadevi, he is our father’s son through Mandakini Devi. Didn’t you tell them about this?”

“I didn’t tell them about it, akka.”

“Why? Did you think it would be disgraceful to accept this truth, or were you intending to tell this later?”

“No, akka. We don’t really have any proof of what we have believed so far...”

“What are you saying?”

“Yes, akka! The prime minister knows about this. It was two years after our father returned from Elangai that Madhuranthakan and Nandini were born to Mandakini Devi. Therefore, we can safely conclude that they are not our siblings!”

Kundavai remained transfixed after hearing the prince’s revelation and said, “Arulmozhi! You knew this, and you still want to sacrifice your rightful claim to the throne?”

“Yes, akka. Madhuranthakar is Mandakini Devi’s son and was raised by Sembiyanmadevi. I am not interested in ascending the throne, and Vanathi has refused to sit beside me there...”

“Thambi, in Ramayana, when Bharatar refused to accept the kingdom that he got, Guhan said, ‘A thousand Ramas will not equal you in character’. The people of this kingdom will one day say, ‘A thousand Bharatas will not equal you in character.’”

“I don’t care what they say about me. If they could only leave me alone now, I would be happy. Akka, I have come up with an idea. I wanted your opinion about it!”

“What idea?”

“You do know that the Pazhuvur clan is gathering their forces near Kudanthai!”

“Yes, and I also heard that many chieftains who support their cause have joined them. But I also heard that it is a very small army.

If our grandsire and Vellar army were to meet them on the battlefield, they would be routed within an hour... that's what they are saying."

"That's why I have come up with an idea, to avoid anything like this from happening. I thought I would take a horse and ride to their camp and give myself up. They will definitely imprison me. After which, there is nothing that our grandsire or Vellar can do..."

Kundavai introspected on her brother's idea and said, "It is a good idea, Thambi, but there are many dangers in this!"

"What dangers?"

"If you were to go the Pazhuvur camp by yourself, within a few hours, the soldiers will start shouting, 'Victory to Ponniyin Selva, our next emperor' and demand that you ascend the throne next. Instead of imprisoning you, they might imprison the Pazhuvur brothers!"

Arulmozhi was taken aback by Kundavai's prediction and said, "Yes, there is that danger. Maybe I can go there in disguise like how I came inside this fort..."

"No matter what disguise you wear, Thambi, you will be found within an hour and everyone will know about it."

Arulmozhi's face lost colour.

"Akka, what should I do, then? Why was I born? Am I here just to trouble people? Why didn't I die when I fell in the Kaveri?"

"Thambi, who knows? The kingdom and the throne that you wish to avoid at any cost might just come to you despite all these hurdles. The stars of your birth are ensuring that you become the reigning king..."

"Akka, have you joined our grandsire's camp, then? You have changed your mind?"

“No, our grandsire has not swayed my mind. But the last olai of our brother has done that. He wrote that you will fulfil all his dreams... and when I read that...” Kundavai’s voice broke and tears fell from her eyes as she handed Karikalan’s Olai to the prince.

The prince read the olai, and he too shed tears at the end of it.

“Thambi, I don’t care what you think about me! But I am happy that Madhuranthakan and Nandini do not belong to the Chola clan. And after knowing that, I don’t think I can accept someone who doesn’t belong to our lineage as the next heir. Though I have great respect and devotion for Sembiyanmadevi and Mandakini Devi, I cannot accept Madhuranthakan’s ascension over the true heir of the Chola clan...”

“Akka, what are you saying? A few moments ago, I told Sembiyanmadevi, Madhuranthakar, and the prime minister that I am ready to renounce the crown. I have told the same in front of thousands of soldiers, hoping to persuade them to give up their demands. Do you want me to go back on my word?” asked Arulmozhi, outraged by his sister’s sudden turnaround.

“Thambi, only Goddess Durga can guide us in the right direction. I know not how to resolve this situation. If only Aditya Karikalan had heeded my words, then we wouldn’t be in this situation at all. I still can’t believe that he would be killed thus!”

“How did you get this olai, akka? Who brought it to you? You didn’t tell me about this earlier!”

“I got it just a few moments ago. Sambuvarayar’s daughter Manimegalai brought this to me.”

“I have heard about her. How did she get this olai in the first place?”

“She is here. You can ask her directly, though I don’t know how much we can rely on her words!”

Right from the time Arulmozhi came there, Kundavai had been wanting to bring Manimegalai in front of him, and tell him about Vandiya Devan's imprisonment. Now she found the correct opportunity to do that. She called out to Vanathi, who brought Manimegalai in front of the prince.

Manimegalai's face was lined with sorrow and her eyes were tinged with tears. Looking at her condition, the prince concluded that the girl had enough reason to despair.

"Thambi, this is Manimegalai. She brought our brother's olai. Ask her yourself how she got it."

"Sister, you brought us the last olai that our brother wrote to us. For that, you have our never-ending gratitude..."

Before the prince could complete his sentence, Manimegalai bowed down before him and said, "Prince... are you truly grateful to me?" And she started crying.

"Akka, why is this girl crying like this? Is she grieving the fact that our brother died in her home?"

"No, thambi. She has something else in mind. Manimegalai, tell the prince whatever you told me," coaxed Kundavai.

"Ayya, I killed your brother. Imprison me in the underground prison and release him please..." begged Manimegalai.

Startled by her words, Arulmozhi looked at his sister and said, "Akka, what's this girl saying? Has she lost her mind?"

"She hasn't lost her mind yet, thambi. But if we don't release Vandiya Devar from the underground prison she might just lose it!"

"What? What? Who is in the underground prison?" asked the prince in surprise.

“Thambi, have you perchance forgotten the Vanar Prince who I sent to Elangai to fetch you back here?”

Arulmozhi looked at her as though he had woken up just now from a deep sleep. Right from the time he came to the Thanjavur fort, the disastrous events that had occurred one after another had engaged his mind completely. Karikalan’s tragic end and the confusion regarding the succession had left him preoccupied and distracted so much so that he had failed to check out what had happened to his friend.

He got up and with great agitation, asked, “Who has dared to shut my dear friend Vandiya Devar in the underground prison and why?”

Kundavai then apprised him of what had happened to his friend. After hearing all that had transpired, he said, “Akka, you will not find another ungrateful creature like me in this world. I failed to check what had happened to him. And those who have shut him in prison are the true criminals. I know the devotion that he bore towards our brother. What foolishness is this? This girl has taught us a lesson by trying to take the murder charges on her head to save him. I am ashamed of myself, and can’t look at this girl again. I will go immediately to the prison and release him. You please console Sambuvarayar’s daughter...”

When he reached the doorway, suddenly Malayaman and Vellar appeared. Their sudden appearance and intimidating stance caused the prince to stop in his tracks.

Vellar, who bore a spear in his hand, held it across to stop the prince from leaving the room. Behind him, Malayaman too drew his sword and held it onto the ground to stop the prince from advancing.

Ponniyin Selvar looked at them in surprise and demanded, “Commander! What is this? Will you imprison me too?”

“Prince, right now we are stopping you from going to the underground prison. And if needed, we may even imprison you...”

The prince didn't know if they were saying this in earnest, but he was in no mood for amusements. He demanded angrily, “What's your authority? How dare you stop me?”

“On whose authority are you trying to release someone from the underground prison?”

“Commander! Don't I have the authority? Have you forgotten who I am? Or have you forgotten who you are?”

“I haven't forgotten myself, nor have I forgotten who you are. I am the commander of this fort and the guardian of the underground prison. You are the prince of the realm, and yet, you don't have the authority to release someone who has been charged with the murder of your brother. That authority lies only with the emperor or with his rightful heir who would ascend the throne next. As things stand, you have been going around declaring that you would renounce your claim. Therefore, you have no authority to release anyone from the prison,” said Kodumbalur Vellar.

“Child, Vellar is right. Ever since Chinna Pazhuvetarayar ran away, he has taken charge of the fort and the underground prison. And therefore, you have no authority to release anyone!”

Ponniyin Selvar stood stunned by their words, and Manimegalai's heart-rending whimpers filled the room.

Chapter 53: Vanathi's Idea

Hearing their war of words, Kundavai stepped towards the doorway and said, "Thatha, mama, should we discuss all this at the doorway? Come inside. Arulmozhi will not go against your wishes!"

Malayaman and Vellar came inside.

"Devi, if the prince agrees to ascend the throne, there is no problem, of course. We will await his commands. The emperor wants to be relieved of this burden, and he wishes to retire to Kanchi and spend his last days at the gold palace that Karikalar has built," said Vellar.

"Mama, before you came here, I was explaining the situation to the prince. But in between, this girl came and petitioned and the prince sought to relieve her sorrow by releasing the Vanar prince!"

"Who is this girl? Why is she crying?" asked Vellar.

"Don't you recognize her? This is Manimegalai, daughter of Sambuvarayar..."

"Oh! She is crying because her father is in the prison. Girl, don't cry. The emperor has ordered his release. Even as I speak, Parthibendran must be releasing him from the underground prison..." said Malayaman.

"Thatha, this girl is not just worried about her father, she is also worried about the prince of Vallam. She is saying 'I killed Karikalar! Imprison me and release Vandiya Devar!'"

"Aha, if she really means that, we can shut her in the underground prison too, but we cannot release Vandiya Devan!"

Manimegalai whimpered her response to Kundavai, “That’s what I am requesting, too. Take me to the prison and shut me there along with him...”

Kodumbalur Vellar tapped his head and said, “This girl has lost her mind!”

“Uncle, she has not lost her mind. It’s you and Thirukkoyalur Malayaman who have lost your minds. Vandiya Devar is Ponniyin Selvar’s dear friend. He took Princess Kundavai’s message to Elangai, and fetched him back home. He was also a close and trusted friend of the crown prince. It is madness to charge him with the murder of the prince.”

“Aha! When did this girl become so chatty, that too in front of the elders? Vanathi! Is this what you learned from Princess Kundavai? Don’t open your mouth when your elders are talking. If someone asks you a question, you can answer them. Or else be silent.” Vellar reprimanded his niece sternly.

Malayaman said, “Why are you scolding that child so much? I believe she is saying whatever is there in everybody’s mind!”

“Mama, it is pointless trying to tell Vanathi anything. Tomorrow, she will be the empress of this realm, and we will be duty bound to obey her commands!”

“If only Arulmozhi agrees, then there is no problem at all. He can command us to release everyone shut in the underground prison on the coronation day,” said Malayaman.

“He can also shut us in the prison if he so wishes,” said Vellar.

“Ayya, you both are my elders, and it pains me to disregard your orders. But we are wasting time here talking about unwanted things...” said the prince. And before he could complete the sentence, Kodumbalur Vellar interjected and said, “Prince, it is

important to decide and come to a consensus about the succession. That's the most important thing to do right now..."

"You seem to have forgotten that the emperor is still alive!" said the prince.

"No, we haven't forgotten. We came here after meeting him. He said that he wanted to resolve the succession issue immediately, and then go to Kanchi and retire from public life!"

"I will go to the emperor right away, and get his authorization to release Vandiya Devar. After that, you both will not have any objections, right?"

"Prince, I would suggest against talking to the emperor about Vandiya Devan. He is convinced that Vandiya Devan along with Nandini and the Pandya rebels treasonously killed the crown prince!"

"Aha, who poisoned his mind thus?"

"Not us, prince. It was Parthibendran who has persuaded to him believe this."

"Then I will go to the Pallava prince and ask him for proof to support his accusation!"

"The Pallava prince has now gone to the underground prison to free Sambuvarayar. And after that, the emperor tasked him to go to Kudanthai and meet the Pazhuvur brothers and invite them and other noble chieftains for the council meeting that would convene in three days. At the council meeting, all the questions about the succession will be addressed and the emperor expressly said that he wishes to crown Madhuranthakar as his heir."

Ponniyin Selvar got excited after hearing this and said, "This is very good news..."

Kodumbalur Vellar said angrily, "Not at all. The day Madhuranthakan ascends the Chola throne against the wishes of the people and the army, the destruction of this kingdom will begin!"

"There is no doubt about that. There will be confusion and chaos through the length and breadth of the kingdom," said Malayaman.

"And looks like you both will cause this confusion and chaos. But that's on your head. I will now meet the emperor and try to get his approval to release Vandiya Devar," said the prince and tried to exit the room.

"Prince, please don't go to the emperor with this request. Devi, please stop your brother," said Kodumbalur Vellar.

"Yes, my child. Listen to this old man for once," said Malayaman.

"What do you think might happen if we release him from prison?" asked Kundavai.

"Our enemies have been busy spreading malicious lies and vicious rumours among the soldiers. My tongue refuses to even repeat them. We found two men who were saying that Ponniyin Selvar wished to reign the kingdom, and therefore, he sent Vandiya Devan to kill Karikalan..."

"My god! What a shameful rumour is this?" said Kundavai, taken aback by the commander's words.

"Do you know what our soldiers did to them? They were drowning them in the Vadavaru river. I incidentally happened to go there and rescued them from certain death!"

Ponniyin Selvan interjected and said, "No one is ever going to believe this rumour. This is evident from our soldiers' reaction..."

"Maybe they will not believe it today. But you don't know how people are. A few years later, this rumour will spread again, and it

will be believed by those who do not know you. You have read the royal history of Elangai kings, and you know how viciously people fight for their claim on the throne...”

“Commander, just because a rumour might spread in the future, do you want me to allow my friend to languish in prison?”

“Not in the future, prince. Today, if you take any interest in releasing Vandiya Devan, there are people who will believe this rumour. And if the emperor were to hear it, imagine how much it will grieve him!”

Ponniyin Selvar’s face darkened like the clouds had hidden the moon. He turned to his sister and said, “Akka, what do you say?”

Kundavai’s face reflected the grief and desperation she felt in her heart. She turned to Vellar and asked, “Commander, do you know who is trying to spread such a vicious rumour?”

“I interrogated the men who I rescued from Vadavaru River, and they revealed that it was Sambuvarayar’s son Kandanmaran who asked them to spread such rumours!”

Manimegalai came forward and said, “I am ashamed of my brother. He was once a good man who came under the evil influence of the Pazhuvur queen. I killed Karikalar! Imprison me and release Vandiya Devar!”

Kundavai placed her hand on Manimegalai’s back and tried to console her, “Manimegalai, calm down. No one will believe what you are saying. Instead, they might spin some other accusation. We will need to find a solution for this somehow...”

And then, she turned towards Malayaman and Vellar and said, “Ayya, we will heed your advice for now, and will not attempt to release Vandiya Devar as it will lead to malicious rumours. Our first step to solving this would be to find the real murderers of Karikalan. I will consult with our prime minister about this. His disciple,

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, has gone in pursuit of the Pandya rebels and he might bring back some news. We still don't know what happened to Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Nandini. If we find out where they are, we might learn the truth. In the meanwhile, I will learn everything that happened in Kadambur. I would request you to ensure that Vandiya Devar gets everything he needs in the underground prison. He is not a murderer, that much we all can agree upon!"

Just then Vanathi said, "Akka, I do have an idea..."

"What idea?"

"Why don't we go to the underground prison and meet Vandiya Devar? Remember how we visited the prison earlier? We might know more about this then. Just like that, we could go today and take the Kadambur princess as well with us!"

"Commander, what do you think about your niece's idea?" asked Kundavai.

"My niece seems to be capable of saying something intelligent after all. Vandiya Devan was found with Karikalar's dead body that night. He might know what had happened and who really killed him," said Periya Vellar.

Immediately, they went to the underground prison. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had closed the mint before he left the fort. So the mint was deserted and there were very few guards there. They went through the chamber where the tigers were kept and reached the underground chamber where the prisoners were kept. There they went to the cell where Vandiya Devan was incarcerated.

But they didn't find Vandiya Devan there. In his place, the physician's son Pinagapani stood, bound to the wall. When he saw them, he wailed, "Ayyo! Ayyo! Release me... release me..."

Chapter 54: Pinagapani's Work

The physician's son Pinagapani had long ago decided that he would become a royal servant and serve the royal family. Right from the time he met Vandiya Devan, this desire of his only grew.

To fulfil his ambition, he had given up their family profession and had undertaken work for some of the royal family members, but with little success. Nandini seemed to take some interest in him and had assigned him a task. But after that, she had completely forgotten about him. When he met Kundavai Devi, she didn't talk to him properly. And when he accused Vandiya Devan of being a spy, all that he got for his efforts was a fistful of blows from him.

But when the prime minister sent for him and tasked him to bring Mandakini Devi to Thanjavur, he thought that he would finally secure himself a good post at the royal court. He was hell-bent on completing the job properly and pleasing the prime minister. After all, there was nothing that he could not achieve, if the prime minister were to favour him. Once he attained a good post, he was determined to challenge Vandiya Devan and break Poonguzhali's pride.

Thus he built many castles in the air and went to Kodi Karai. There, he befriended Rakkammal, who thought that he belonged to the Pandya rebel gang. She spoke to him about their plans and then revealed where they would find Mandakini Devi. He used her to capture Mandakini and successfully brought her to Thanjavur fort.

All through the journey, Pinagapani's mind was working overtime. He was curious about Mandakini. And while he was shut in the underground prison, a madman next to his cell told him many things. Initially, he had dismissed them as rants of a madman. But many of the things he said started making sense to him while he was on his way back to Thanjavur.

Now we know what had happened to the palanquin that bore Mandakini Devi. During the storm, Pinagapani was injured by the tree that fell on him. And after he was healed, he went to see the prime minister. By then, many tragedies had occurred. Mandakini Devi had sacrificed her life for the emperor. Aditya Karikalar was murdered. Kodumbalur Vellar had wrested the control of the Thanjavur Fort from Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and is now the commander, while the Pazhuvur forces were garrisoned near Kudanthai and the noble clans that supported them were joining forces with them. A civil war might erupt any minute between both factions.

While the prime minister was drowned in worry about what would happen next, Pinagapani went to see him. Anirudhar wanted to initially give him a prize for completing his task and then send him away.

But when the physician's son started talking about the madman that he had met in the underground prison, his interest was piqued. The madman would often tell that he knew the exact location of the ancient crown that the Pandya kings were crowned with, and the navaratna necklace that was supposedly gifted to them by Indra, the king of Gods. These were priceless heirlooms of the Pandya royal family that had been lost in Elangai for many years. Paranthaka I tried to find them but was unsuccessful.

The prime minister knew how important these heirlooms were because until they were lost, there will always be a claimant from the Pandya kingdom who would proclaim themselves to be the rightful heir and stir trouble for the Cholas. We saw an example of this when Nandini and Ravidasan crowned a small boy as the Pandya emperor in the woods of Thirupurambayam. Whenever a claimant came forward, the Elangai kings would lend their support to them. The only way to stop this is to find these legendary jewels, crown the next Chola emperor at Madurai, and place the Pandya crown on his head and present him with Indra's aaram^[28].

The prime minister was very keen to retrieve these jewels back from Elangai. Whenever the Chola army started a campaign to Elangai, he would request the Commander to send an expedition to find these jewels and bring them back to the Chola Kingdom. But no one had been successful in its quest. That's why his interest was piqued when he learned from Pinagapani that there was a madman in the underground prison who claimed to know this secret.

The physician's son also told another news that increased the prime minister's eagerness to see the madman. He said that the madman claimed that he knew a secret about a prince who everybody thought had a claim on the Chola throne but in reality was not of Chola lineage.

After hearing this, Anirudhar initially thought that he would go to the underground prison and meet this man, but he changed his mind immediately. Malayaman and Vellar didn't trust him completely. They thought he was carrying out the emperor's wishes and was supporting Madhuranthakan's claims to the throne. If he were to go to prison, they might think that he was visiting Sambuvarayar, and float rumours about him. So he decided to use Pinagapani. He gave him his signet ring and asked him to go and meet the madman.

Armed with the signet ring, Pinagapani went to the underground prison to meet the madman. When he saw Vandiya Devan in the next cell, he was elated. He tried to talk to him, but when Vandiya Devan saw him, he became enraged and cursed him to his heart's content. After that, he went to the next cell which housed the madman. Pinagapani now knew that he wasn't really a madman. He asked him to tell him his secrets – the location of the Pandya crown and Indra's aaram and the secret of the Chola prince.

But the madman flatly refused to divulge his secrets. He said, 'Come here with my release order and I will tell you only then!'

Pinagapani came back and told the prime minister about his failure, and suggested that if they could secure the madman's release, he might divulge his secrets. The prime minister felt that he

was right. He didn't want odd madmen to claim that they knew royal secrets, especially when there was much confusion about who will ascend the throne next. He felt that it would be dangerous to keep such men in prison. Instead, he felt that it would be good if he can be brought to his palace where the prime minister himself could interrogate him in private.

He then met Periya Vellar and requested him to release the madman. Vellar didn't have any objection to releasing a prisoner who was imprisoned by Chinna Pazhuvetarayar many years ago and promptly gave the release order.

Pinagapani took the release order with pride to the underground prison. First, he stopped at Vandiya Devan's cell and told him that he had gotten the release orders for him. Vandiya Devan believed him and started to thank him. And that's when Pinagapani showed his true colours. He cursed him a lot and said, 'You will find your freedom at a hangman's noose!' And then, he moved to the next cell. There, the madman spoke to him in a friendly manner. Pinagapani entered his cell and released the chains that had shackled him to the wall. He told the madman, 'Here is your release order. Now, will you tell me your secrets?'

The physician's son was eager to learn the secrets before the madman was presented to the prime minister. But the madman didn't seem too enthusiastic about getting released. He didn't really believe Pinagapani's words, and kept asking him many questions, 'Will I really be released? Who gave the order? Will I really be released from this prison? Will I be allowed to leave the fort?'

While they were talking, a few stone bricks from the wall fell, and Pinagapani turned around to see Vandiya Devan standing behind him. Before he could take his dagger out, Vandiya Devan pounced on him and started beating him. Pinagapani fought back, and soon they were fighting all over the cell. Finally, the madman threw an iron chain around his neck and held him tight.

Chapter 55: The Madman

Vandiya Devan was mostly unconscious when he was brought from Kadambur to Thanjavur in a bullock cart. The smoke inhalation at the Kadambur palace and a few burns that he had suffered on his hands and the extreme exhaustion from saving Karikalan's body from the burning place had taken their toll on him. He couldn't open his eyes.

The agony that he suffered from the burns was too much to bear. Moreover, he was trapped by the half-remembered dreams where he was taunted and tormented endlessly.

Veera Pandyan's head came in front of him and demanded, 'Adey, how dare you stand as a hurdle against the vow to avenge my beheading?'

Nandini would sometimes come dressed beautifully, and with a mesmerizing smile try to seduce his senses while at other times she would come to him with her long hair unbound, with pitiful tears. She would also come to him like a ghost and laugh hauntingly.

He would suddenly see a shadowy figure that was following Aditya Karikalar. But before he could stop that figure, a tall huge man would stop him from behind and stranglehold his neck. Right after that, Ravidasan and his men would throw him in the fire and he would feel his entire body burning.

Kandanmaran would suddenly appear and say, "Traitor, you deserve this!"

Parthibendran would then step up and ask, "When are you getting married to Kundavai? At what hour?" And he would laugh with derision. Senthana Amuthan would then come running to him to save him from the fire but the physician's son Pinagapani would hide behind the tree and hit Senthana Amuthan with a fire log.

When he felt his body burning, he craved water and wanted to shout out, 'Water!' But he couldn't move his lips and his mouth had dried. That's when Manimegalai would come to him with a golden jar of water and offer it to him. But before he could express his gratitude, she would vanish.

Aha, if only I could offer the three worlds to this woman... but I don't own even an inch of land in this one world! Wherefore could I offer three worlds?!

Then Poonguzhali was showing him her lovers...

What a strange girl! She suddenly turns towards him and says, 'Why are you here in this world? Come, I will take you to a golden place...'

'Girl, will you take me to Ponniyin Selvar?'

Immediately, he was surrounded by the fire bubbles that he saw in Kodi Karai. And Vandiya Devan closed his eyes, frightened, while he felt that he was being carried by them to Kodi Karai all the way to a cliff from where he was thrown down.

That's when Vandiya Devan opened his eyes and found that the fire bubbles that he dreamed of were from the fire torches held by some soldiers who were trying to get him on a boat. He had no clue what river it was or where he was. It could be Kollidam or Kudamurattu River. He soon lost consciousness again...

After suffering thus from half-remembered memories and dreams, Vandiya Devan suddenly felt as though he was in the midst of a roaring sea. Anytime a huge wave would throw him somewhere far...

That's when he regained full consciousness. He looked around and saw the Thanjavur fort at a distance. Hundreds of people were walking on the road surrounding the bullock cart where he lay bound. It was their cries and moans that he had heard, and it sounded like

the sea. That's when he realized that he was in the midst of the funeral procession of Aditya Karikalan.

Within a few minutes, the crowd disappeared towards the cremation ground where the last rites for the crown prince were being performed. The bullock cart carrying Sambuvarayar and Vandiya Devan entered the Thanjavur fort.

Aha! I can't even attend the funeral rites of that great prince and pay my respects. How unfortunate! And what's more, they are going to charge me with his murder! What an irony! Wasn't I trying to prevent his death?

And it was I who made sure that his family and friends had a chance to bid him farewell by saving his lifeless body from the fire at Kadambur palace. And they are going to shut me in the underground prison where murderers, thieves, and spies are incarcerated.

But Ponniyin Selvar and Princess Kundavai will hear about it soon and will come rushing to the prison to release him. They will praise him when they know the efforts that he took to protect the prince...

But will they really come here for me? They will be devastated by the loss of such an illustrious brother. And why would they come here for me? Will they believe me when I tell them that I am innocent? Will they be friends with me again?

When he was finally brought to the underground prison and taken through the mint, what little hope he held in his heart diminished. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had closed the mint before he left the fort, and there were very few guards there.

He also noted the absence of Pazhuvur flags. In their stead, there were many Kodumbalur flags.

Kodumbalur Vellar had replaced the Pazhuvur guards with his men, and they were staring at him and Sambuvarayar and speaking

amongst themselves, “This is Kadambur Sambuvarayar... this is Vandiya Devan, the traitors who murdered the Crown Prince!”

When they took him through the chambers where the tigers roamed, they seemed like the symbols of power and ruthlessness of the Chola kings. As they neared the cells, he lost all hope and knew that he would never leave this place. They might remove his body once his life was gone.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had always been suspicious of him. Parthibendran had always mistrusted him, while Malayaman only believed whatever he said. He was sure that the Pazhuvur brothers would speak on behalf of Sambuvarayar and release him soon.

But who would speak on my behalf? No one.

Instead, they would be happy to accuse him and shut him in the prison for eternity.

Will there be a trial where I would be allowed to speak? No, there will not be a trial. If there was one, then the truth about Nandini, Ravidasan, and the Pandya rebels will be revealed. No one would want that. Instead, they will want me to languish in prison forever or publicly execute me in the streets of Thanjavur.

My God! What dreams did I have when I first came to Thanjavur? How happy I was to undertake one adventure after another! What happiness I felt after meeting Kundavai and Vanathi at the Kudanthai Jodhidhar's house.

At that time, I feared that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar might imprison me in the underground prison, and now it has become a reality. I was flying free like a bird with nary a care in this world and they have caught and shut me in this dark cell! How can I live here? No... I have to find a way to end my life soon!

With such despairing thoughts swirling through his mind, Vandiya Devan sat in his cell, immobile and silent. A few moments later, he

heard someone adjusting their voice and singing ‘Ponnar Meniyaney...’^[29] in a dreadful voice.

Vandiya Devan was immediately reminded of Senthana Amuthan, who possessed a divine voice. It was definitely not him.

This man’s voice was horribly high-pitched. But why is he singing this song? My God! I can’t listen to this anymore! Isn’t this underground prison punishment enough that I have to hear this!

“Who is that singing?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“It’s me. The madman.”

“Madman, please, I beg you, stop singing.”

“Why? Don’t you like my song?”

“Who says I don’t like it? Of course, I like it.”

“You like it after I stopped singing, didn’t you?”

“You don’t really seem like a madman. Who taught you this song?”

“A few months ago, there was a boy shut in the cell you are occupying presently. He was here for just a few days, but he used to sing this song constantly, and I learnt to sing it too!”

Vandiya Devan immediately knew that it must be Senthana Amuthan who had been shut in this cell. He knew that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had imprisoned him for helping the spy.

It must be him who had stayed in this cell.

Aha! What a nice boy he was, and what a loyal friend!

“Do you know the name of the boy who stayed in this cell? Do you know?” he asked the madman.

“Why not? His name was Senthana Amuthan. Son of some mute woman. If only this world knows who he really is...”

“Then what?”

“Then this world will turn upside down...”

“If the world turns upside down, will we gain freedom from this prison?”

“Definitely...”

“Then, tell me who he really is?”

“I will not give up my secrets so easily. I will whisper this only in the ears of the Chola emperor. Tell me something, is Sundara Chola still the emperor?”

“Yes, why are you so doubtful about that?”

“A few days ago, many changes happened here. All the old guards have been replaced with new people. I know that the mint has been closed, or else we can constantly hear the sound of the coins here!”

“Why did they close the mint? Why have the guards changed?”

“Chinna Pazhuvetarayar has fled the Thanjavur fort and Kodumbalur Vellar has captured it and has become its commander. This is what I have learned from the guards...”

“Really!” Vandiya Devan was surprised by the news.

Kodumbalur Vellar knows me well. Will he believe in my innocence and release me? No... it's not possible for anyone to release a man who has been charged with the murder of the crown prince.

“What, thambi? You have become silent... shall I start singing again?” asked the madman.

“No, please. I was thinking about what you just said. If Senthana Amuthan is not the son of the mute woman, then whose son could he be?”

“Don’t ask about that. Talk about something else.”

“Why do you call yourself ‘the madman’?”

“Everyone in this prison calls me ‘the madman’.”

“Why?”

“Whoever I meet here, I tell them that I know where the ancient Pandya crown and the navaratna aaram gifted by Lord Indra are hidden in Elangai. If they free me from this prison, I can tell them where to find it. Whenever I tell them this, they call me ‘the madman.’”

“I think the people who are calling you the ‘madman’ are the ones who are really mad!”

“You believe me, then?”

“Completely. But what’s the use of me believing you? I can be of no help to you!”

“Don’t say that. The cell where you are kept is a fortunate place to be in. Whoever is shut here gets released quickly...”

“Why do you say that? Give me some examples.”

“There was a physician’s son called Pinagapani who was shut in your cell. He was released by Nandini Devi. Senthana Amuthan too was kept there, and he was released by Kundavai Devi and the Kodumbalur princess...”

Vandiya Devan released a long sigh of despair and said, “No queen or princess is ever going to come and release me...”

“If that is so, then I will grant you freedom,” said the madman.

“Truly, now you are talking like a madman!”

“No, believe me. I will grant you freedom!”

“I have no choice but to believe you...”

“Then wait until the guards give our food tonight,” said the madman enigmatically.

Chapter 56: The Right Man At the Right Place

That night, after the guards had delivered their food, Vandiya Devan waited with bated breath to hear what the madman would say. But he could only hear a scratching sound on the wall that separated his cell from the madman's.

Vandiya Devan was not scared of tigers, lions, or elephants, but he couldn't tolerate cats and rats. The scratching sound that he heard now sounded very much like rats, and he wondered how he could possibly live here with them roaming freely.

"Madman, are you sleeping?" he asked.

There was no reply from the next cell. The scratching on the wall continued, though. Suddenly, a few bricks from the wall fell, creating an entrance to the next cell, and the madman asked him, "Are you asleep?"

"No, I was not asleep. I was waiting for you! What have you done here?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"I accomplished this in six months. It took me six months to loosen the chains that bound me to the wall!"

He now climbed on the breach that he had made, and jumped into Vandiya Devan's cell with his assistance.

"What's the use of making an entrance on this wall? If you had done the same on the outer wall of this prison, we could be free."

"There is no outer wall here. The only way out of this prison is through the tiger chamber that is above us. Sometimes, when there is no one here, this chamber would be unlocked, so I thought I could probably escape from here!"

“I came here just today, and you have taken me into confidence and revealed this? What if I betray you?”

“I can tell who to believe and who I shouldn’t, through their voice. Senthana Amuthan is trustworthy while Pinagapani is not. From your voice, I decided that I could trust you. Moreover, if we have to escape, this is the right time!”

“Why?”

“I told you that the guards have changed, I heard them talking. They were talking about opening the tiger’s cage. One of them said, ‘What if the tiger springs on us when we open the cage?’ The other guard replied, ‘We will have to die then!’ I now know that they will not open the tiger’s cage. I thought I could take them by surprise and attack them suddenly. Either way, it is better to make an attempt at escaping now rather than wasting away in these cells.”

“True!”

“I thought that instead of attempting this alone, it’s better if we work together. You are not like me. You are young and appear strong. We could incapacitate the guards together and grab the key from them!”

“That’s a good idea. When do you think we should do this?”

“Wait awhile. I will tell you when the time is right.”

“I am also exhausted. We can wait for one or two days...” said Vandiya Devan.

After that, the madman asked Vandiya Devan to narrate everything that had happened since he was imprisoned.

When the madman heard that Aditya Karikalan was dead, he exclaimed, “It’s important that we escape the prison immediately!”

“Why do you say that?”

“Who do you think will be the crown prince now?”

“The emperor’s health is fragile and his heart is broken. He wishes to relinquish the throne to his successor!”

“Who will be the next emperor then?”

“A few noble chieftains wish to crown Madhuranthakar, while many others are supporting the claim of Ponniyin Selvar!”

“What does the emperor wish to do?”

“He wants to avoid conflict, and wishes to crown Madhuranthakar as the next emperor...”

“If that is true, then it is imperative that we escape this prison immediately!”

After that the ‘madman’ revealed what he knew about the Pandya crown and the Indra’s navaratna aaram to Vandiya Devan.

When Vandiya Devan asked him about the other secret about the chola prince, he said, “I will not reveal it now. If we escape from here, I will tell you. Or else, that secret will die with me!”

Vandiya Devan kept thinking about it and was continuously wondering what that secret might be. A few old memories came to his mind and disappeared before he could discern their meaning.

When Vandiya Devan saw Pinagapani at the prison, he was alarmed at first, thinking that he might upset their plans for escape. He didn’t believe even one word that Pinagapani was saying. In that matter, he and the madman were of one mind: not to believe or trust anything that Pinagapani said. They agreed that he had an ulterior motive to come there and had a plan of action in place if he comes again.

Thus, when Pinagapani came back again, they were ready. When he showed the prime minister’s signet ring to the madman and

was demanded to reveal his secrets, Vandiya Devan entered the cell through the brick wall entrance noiselessly and attacked Pinagapani.

When Pinagapani fought back, they began a fist fight in the cell. Any other time, Vandiya Devan would have won him within no time, but the wounds on his body caused by the fire had not healed yet, and his throat that the Kala Mugan had strangled, was bruised badly. This gave Pinagapani an upper hand and their fight continued. Finally, when the madman took his chains and held Pinagapani by the neck, they were able to overpower him.

Next, they dragged him to the other wall and tied him to the chains that had once held the 'madman'. While tying him, Vandiya Devan said, "Pinagapani, remember when we went to Kodi Karai searching for Sanjivini^[30] for the emperor? We didn't succeed in that mission, but your arrival was most opportune for me. I think you should continue your old profession and be a physician again. Why do you want to interfere in a spy's work and invite trouble for yourself?"

Pinagapani didn't answer. He was in shock. He hadn't even imagined that he could be attacked thus. His eyes became red and his wrath against Vandiya Devan increased tenfold.

Vandiya Devan and the 'madman' snatched the prime minister's signet ring that Pinagapani was flaunting earlier. Vandiya Devan also grabbed the turban that he was wearing and placed it on his head.

They came out of the cell and locked it securely. They walked slowly and started climbing the stairs that led to the tiger's chambers. Since they didn't know the way properly, they walked slowly, deliberating each step. At the top of the stairs, they could hear the fearsome growls of the tigers. Hesitant to step into the room, they peeped into the room to see if the guards had opened the tiger's cage.

There was only one guard in the chambers, and thankfully the cage was locked. But that's when Pinagapani started shouting and

Vandiya Devan berated himself for not silencing him. He watched the guard warily wondering if he would open the cage and set the tiger on them.

Chapter 57: Freedom

Vandiya Devan stood at the doorstep, hesitant to enter the tiger's chambers. He thought of attacking the lone guard who was sitting there and moving ahead. But at the next exit, there stood two more guards and they seemed to be signalling one another, which worried Vandiya Devan.

Are they signalling the fact that a prisoner has escaped?

Worrying thus, he stood pondering on what should be done next. Even if he attacked this guard, there were many other guards and many exits before they left the prison... he could spring towards the tiger's cage, open it, and hope to escape in the mayhem that would ensue.

While he was wondering about that course of action, the guard sitting in front of the tiger cage, said, "Oh! So you are planning to escape?" which startled Vandiya Devan.

One of the tigers growled in response. And that's when Vandiya Devan realized that the guard was talking to the tigers, and he laughed. The guard too looked at him sheepishly and laughed.

"Look at these tigers, Ayya, they are trying to intimidate us. But I am a lion who has seen many such tigers and it cannot frighten me!"

Vandiya Devan replied to him philosophically, "So long as the cage is locked, a tiger and a cat are the same," and he showed him Vellar's signet ring.

Seeing the ring, the guard said, "You can go! The prime minister's men are waiting for you outside the prison. Leave immediately!" And then he looked at the doorway they just exited and shouted, "Madman, won't you shut up?"

Noticing that the madman was trembling in fear, Vandiya Devan took his hand in his to reassure him. They moved ahead and exited the tiger's chambers. There were more guards there, and one of them commented, "Freedom, they want freedom it seems. If everyone is released, then what will we do?"

As he moved forward towards the next exit, Vandiya Devan's heart was beating fast. He was now worried about the prime minister's men who were waiting for him outside. Inside the prison, it was dark and impersonating the physician's son was easy. But outside, there was light. What if the prime minister's men find out that he was not the physician's son?

Then I will have to do something and escape. Let's see. Thankfully, this madman seems to quite intelligent and resourceful.

As they proceeded through different doorways and exits, they noticed there were very few guards. And when he showed them Vellar's signet ring, they allowed him to move on to the next gate. No one suspected anything, nor was he stopped. They finally reached the mint which was deserted except a few guards.

Vandiya Devan had by now charted a rudimentary plan in his head about the escape route. On the way, he asked the madman, "Do you want to go to the prime minister's house?"

"If I go to the prime minister's house, I will be sent back to prison. Where are you going? I will come with you..."

"If God wills it, we can go to Elangai. Call me 'Pinagapani' in front of the prime minister's men, lest they suspect. And what is your name?"

"Madman..."

"No, what's your real name? The one that your parents gave you!"

“Ah! I was named Kariya Thirumal, but friends and relatives shortened it to ‘Karuthiruman!’

“Nice name. Listen, while we are on our way to the prime minister’s house, I will touch your shoulder once. You should be ready to run with me then. Can you run fast?”

“Of course. Even the Elangai King Mahindan cannot compete with me in running!”

Vandiya Devan laughed and said, “You really are a madman, aren’t you?”

That’s when they crossed the mint and came to the main doorway of the prison. Vandiya Devan was relieved to find that there were only two men, sent by the prime minister, waiting for them. One of them was a fat man who seemed very familiar, but Vandiya Devan couldn’t remember where he had seen him.

“You are the men who the prime minister sent?” he asked.

“What, thambi? How could you forget us so fast?” asked one of them.

“No... no I was just confirming if you would be taking us to the prime minister’s house!”

Karuthiruman, remembering Vandiya Devan’s instructions said, “Pinagapani, I am scared. Will the prime minister throw me into the underground prison again?”

“No. You obviously don’t know about our prime minister. But don’t try to escape, or else we will be thrown into the prison in your stead,” he said.

After this, the fat man walked in front of them, followed by Vandiya Devan and Karuthiruman and the other man guarded their rear.

The city of Thanjavur was unusually quiet. Kodumbalur soldiers patrolled the fort and guarded it from the ramparts and the fort gates were shut firmly.

Vandiya Devan knew that it was easy to escape from the prime minister's men, but what was more important was that they should not be caught again.

When they passed by Pazhuvetarayar's palace, Vandiya Devan's anxiety heightened. The lane that he had used to escape the fort earlier was fast approaching. This lane had many twists and turns, and it led to Nandini's palace wall, which would be easy to scale using the tree branches that hung over it. After entering the palace gardens, he would enter the treasure chamber and exit the fort near the Vadavaru river. He knew no other way to escape the fort...

Soon, they were near the lane that Vandiya Devan was waiting for. Just when Vandiya Devan thought that he would touch Karuthiruman's shoulder, he spotted horses, palanquins, and palace guards coming in the opposite direction.

The procession looked like it had the members of the royal family and commanders of the fort. The prime minister's men immediately moved to the said lane, and made way for the people who were passing by. They stood before Vandiya Devan and Karuthiruman, and watched warily as the horses and palanquin passed.

First, there were a few soldiers, followed by three white horses bearing Kodumbalur Vellar, Thirukkovalur Malayaman, and Ponniyin Selvar in the middle.

Aha! He is so near me and yet he is so far!

For a second, Vandiya Devan was tempted to throw his caution to the winds and go to the prince. But will the prince show any mercy to a man who now stands accused of his brother's murder?

He probably despises me now...next to him are Vellar and Malayaman. God knows, what they would do to him!

Next, the palanquins that came after the horses drew Vandiya Devan's attention.

Aha! It's Princess Kundavai, Princess Vanathi, and Manimegalai!

He looked at them with regret and despair. Under any other circumstances, he could approach any of these women and seek help. But now, people believed that he had traitorously murdered the crown prince. Kundavai and Vanathi would be disgusted to see him.

I am glad that they have at least taken Manimegalai under their care. She would have told them about the events that led to Karikalar's murder. She had then claimed 'I murdered the prince' to save my skin! Would she say the same again, to these women? No... she wouldn't have. Or else they wouldn't have taken her along with her.

After the palanquins and the guards crossed the land, the prime minister's man said "Come, we can go now..." They resumed their journey. Vandiya Devan decided at that instant that he would make his escape now. He touched Karuthiruman's shoulder and started running through the lane. Karuthiruman too started following him from behind.

The prime minister's men gave chase. For a while, the escaped prisoners didn't even turn around, intent on putting some distance between them and the men who were chasing them. Karuthiruman turned around once and then shouted, "One of them has fallen behind. Only one man is coming after us!"

Hearing this, Vandiya Devan turned around and saw that the fat man had indeed fallen behind. But he had no intention of fighting the man who was chasing them. He signalled to Karuthiruman and started running fast.

Soon, he reached the lane where the tree branches hung over the wall. Clutching them for support, he climbed over the wall and then helped Karuthiruman as well, and then they jumped into the palace garden of Nandini Devi.

They next broke the branches that were hanging over the wall and threw them on the man who was following them. They didn't wait to check if they hit their target and continued running through the shrubs and trees that dotted the landscape until they reached the inner wall that was ahead of them. After scaling that wall, they stopped to catch their breath.

"Thank God! We have escaped," exclaimed Vandiya Devan exhausted from his efforts.

"What do you mean we have escaped? We are still inside the fort," said Karuthiruman.

"We will escape the fort too. Wait awhile!"

They now approached Pazhuvetarayar's palace and hid behind the trees. The palace was quiet and there was no one around. And yet, Vandiya Devan decided that he would enter the dark palace when it was dusk. Deciding thus, he sat on a fallen tree branch and asked Karuthiruman to sit as well.

"We can resume our journey only after dusk. Why don't you tell me your story, in the meanwhile?" asked Vandiya Devan.

"I told you earlier that I cannot reveal my secrets to you!"

"Then, I cannot take you with me..."

"What if I give you an imaginary account of my story? Would you still believe it?"

"Real or imaginary, narrate some story. We have to wait until the dusk falls! What else can we do in the meanwhile?"

Karuthiruman agreed and started telling his story. In truth, it was unlike any story that Vandiya Devan had ever heard, filled with fantastic events.

Chapter 58: Karuthiruman's Story

Karuthiruman belonged to a village situated north of Kodi Karai, called Thopputhurai.^[31] He was a boatman who made his livelihood by plying his boat to Elangai and back. 25 years ago, while he was on his way back to Thopu Thurai, he was caught in a vicious storm that brought him near the Kodi Karai lighthouse.

Near the lighthouse, he found a woman floating in the water and saved her. She was unconscious and he didn't know if she was alive or not.

Strong winds forced him to take his boat to Thirumuraikadu, where he tried to get help for the woman. He took the woman to the beach and tried to revive her, when he heard a few horses passing by the royal road. The men on the horses were royal servants and officials who tried to help him. Soon, the woman regained consciousness, and they realized she was mute and deaf from her birth.

The leader of the royal officials who had stopped there then took Karuthiruman aside and told him something strange. He gave Karuthiruman a bag of coins and asked him to take the woman back to Elangai, or to any of the islands that were nearby, and leave her there. Karuthiruman took the coins and set out with the woman to Elangai after the winds had died down.

In the middle of the sea, they had encountered something strange. They had found an exhausted man floating with just a log for support. Karuthiruman had rescued him from the sea and took him along with him. At first, the woman was wary of the new man, but later she ignored him. Karuthiruman took them to an island that was near Elangai.

On the island, they found an elderly man who claimed that the woman was his daughter. She was mute and deaf from birth, and

now she seemed to have lost her memory and couldn't recognize him. Karuthiruman explained how he had rescued and brought her there.

In the meanwhile, the man whom he had rescued, wrote a message down and asked him to deliver it to the King of Elangai. That's when Karuthiruman realized that he must be an important man. He took the message to the King of Elangai and there he found out that the man he had rescued was the Pandya King!

The King of Elangai immediately sent horses and guards to fetch the Pandya King, but Karuthiruman didn't go with them, as he was exhausted. After a few days, the Pandya King came to the palace of the King of Elangai. After resting there for a few days, both the kings rode to the mountains of Rohana^[32] and they took Karuthiruman along with them.

After exploring the mountains, they took him to a deep valley that was not easily accessible. There, inside a cave, he saw a huge treasure trove of jewels, coins, gold, and gemstones. The King of Elangai showed all that to the Pandya King, and then opened a golden chest where an ancient golden crown was kept.

It was the coronation crown of the Pandya kings. And along with it was a gemstone aaram that was presented to the first Pandya king by Indra – the king of devas.

The King of Elangai then insisted that the Pandya King take these treasures with him. The Pandya King, however, refused and asked the King of Elangai to keep the treasure safe with him until he vanquishes the Cholas completely. He requested the King of Elangai to bring the treasures to Madurai for his coronation and present them to him at his court.

After this, the Pandya King set aside some gold and gave it to Karuthiruman, asking him to take care of the deaf and mute woman. And then, he told him to come and join him in the Pandya kingdom.

When Karuthiruman reached Boodha Theevu, he couldn't find the woman or her father. They had, in the meanwhile, crossed the sea and reached Kodi Karai. At Kodi Karai, when he found her, she didn't recognize him at all. From her family members, he learned that her father had been unwell and had passed away after coming to Kodi Karai. He also found out that the guardian of the lighthouse was the mute woman's brother.

At first, she hadn't recognised anybody; neither her brother or her sister. She fell into the sea again accidentally, and after she was rescued, she regained her lost memory and was able to recognize everyone. That's when they learned that she was pregnant. And when she realized it, she was alarmed and frightened. She found solace in praying at the Kodi Karai temple, and despite many attempts from Karuthiruman, she didn't recognize him at all.

While at Kodi Karai, Karuthiruman met the mute woman's sister, Vaani. When he learned that she, too, was deaf and mute, he felt pity for her and developed affections. He expressed his wish to marry her, but before that, he had to inform the Pandya king about the mute woman.

Meanwhile, Sembiyanmadevi, the empress of Gandaradhithar came to the Kodi Karai temple to pray to the lord. She took pity on the mute woman, Mandakini, and took her along to Pazhaiarai. Vaani, her sister, went along with them, too.

Karuthiruman went to the Pandya kingdom, and there he learned that the king had gone to war. He met the king at the battlefield, who asked Karuthiruman to take another message to the King of Elangai and then make an attempt to bring the mute woman to him.

Karuthiruman went to Elangai and finished his task. And then he went to Pazhaiarai expressly to meet Vaani, the mute woman's sister. But what he found there would horrify him and turn his world upside down! He was on his way to Pazhaiarai through the banks of Arisalaru, and there he found a woman digging the ground. Next to

her was a new born infant wrapped in a swaddle cloth. And the baby was crying and moaning...

Horried by the thought that the woman was trying to bury the child alive, Karuthiruman ran to her and was disgusted to find that it was Vaani.

“Thambi, imagine how I must have felt...” said Karuthiruman.

“I can guess how you must have felt! What happened after that?” asked Vandiya Devan.

“I can’t tell you what happened after that. That’s a secret fit only for royal ears. If I had not gone to Pazhaiarai at that time, I wouldn’t have undergone all this hardship!”

“Then come on, let’s find ourselves some royal ears so that you can tell your secret,” Vandiya Devan said and laughed.

Dusk had fallen, and both the men approached the dark palace cautiously. The place was deserted, and a huge lock hung on the door. Vandiya Devan carefully opened the secret inner door and entered the palace. After Karuthiruman entered, he locked the door carefully behind them.

They walked through the passage and reached the treasure chamber. There, Vandiya Devan asked Karuthiruman, “Does the mountain cave in Rohana kingdom have such treasures?”

“The treasures at the Rohana cave are hundred times more than what you have here...”

Vandiya Devan took a few gold coins and tied them in his waistcloth, and then took the path that would lead them to the exit. There were no guards at the exit door. He carefully opened the door and looked out. The flood waters of the Vadavaru River were moving with strong currents. They both then exited the underground passage, and he closed the door carefully behind them again. He

looked at the river worriedly and wondered how to cross to the other side. That's when he saw a boat tied to the roots of a nearby tree!

Chapter 59: An Ill Omen

Vandiya Devan thought that the Goddess of Luck was favouring him again when he saw the boat on the Vadavaru River. He didn't know how to row a boat, but his companion used to row boats for a livelihood. They could take this boat all the way to Kodi Karai and escape the soldiers who are surely searching for them now.

"Did you see the boat, Karuthiruman? Somehow this boat has come to us through sheer luck. If you could row us out, this river goes all the way up to Kodi Karai. We can outfox even the soldiers sent to hunt for us," said Vandiya Devan.

Karuthiruman looked around a bit suspiciously. He felt as though something was moving near the thicket of the trees where the boat was floating. He immediately took a pebble in hand and threw it at the place; a cat emerged from the thicket and got on the boat.

Vandiya Devan laughed and said, "Boatman, truly you are braver than me..." and he picked another pebble and threw it at cat. The cat now jumped down from the boat and ran betwixt them, which caused Vandiya Devan to jump behind two steps, and disappeared behind the trees. Watching Vandiya Devan's reaction, Karuthiruman sneered at him and said, "Doesn't seem as though you are any braver than me!"

"I am scared of cats. I get goosebumps when they touch me. Anyway, now that it is gone, come, let's go," said Vandiya Devan and moved towards the boat.

"I am not scared if the cat falls on me, but I am scared when it crosses my path. It's an ill omen!"

"An ill omen? Are you joking?" said Vandiya Devan and went towards the boat.

Karuthiruman followed him hesitantly, and tried to free the boat from the tree roots where it had wedged and pushed a boat. The minute the boat moved, four men pounced on them from behind the trees. Two of them tied Vandiya Devan to the boat while two others stood guarding Karuthiruman. The soldiers were led by the fat man who had come to the prison to lead them to the prime minister's house.

Vandiya Devan lay in shock, thinking that the fat man somehow knew that he would exit the fort here and had laid a trap here to catch him! He couldn't be an ordinary soldier by any means, and he must be a good spy. He felt that he had seen the man somewhere, but couldn't recall where.

The fat man was now chiding Karuthiruman, "You spent so many years in prison and got released today. What possessed you to listen to this wicked youth and run away like this? I somehow can't bring myself to tie you up again. If you promise to listen to me, then no harm will befall you!"

Karuthiruman said, "Ayya, the prime minister released me today, and I foolishly listened to this youth instead. I will listen to whatever you say! Just don't send me back to the underground prison!"

"Yes... the prime minister wishes to ask you a few questions. If you can answer him truthfully, he will not send you back to the prison. He will reward you with gold, and you can go wherever you want. So tell me where were you two going towards?"

"We thought we could go to Elangai..."

"How nice! So you were planning your grand escape after fooling the likes of the prime minister and Vellar. But I am not surprised, because this rogue would come up with ideas like this. After all, he did escape Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's guards and flee the fort once. Anyway, we need to take this boat and row against the river current. Among my men, only one of them know to row the boat, and that too

not too well. We need your help to row against the current to take this boat towards the northern fort gate!”

“Why can’t we cross the river and walk through the banks? The water current is very strong here, it would be very difficult to row against it!”

“If we cross the river and go on foot, this wicked youth might do something and try to escape. It’s better to take the boat against the water current...”

The boat started moving with the help of Karuthiruman and the other soldier. The fat man sat next to Vandiya Devan and said, “Don’t try any of your tricks with me!”

“Ayya, it looks like you know a lot about me...”

“Of course, I do. You trapped the physician’s son in the underground prison and came out in his stead. Do you really think we didn’t notice it? After that, you ran away from us!”

Vandiya Devan acted as though he was truly surprised and said, “Ayya, truly you do know everything. I really thought that no one noticed anything that had happened in the underground prison!”

“Thambi, our prime minister has ears and eyes everywhere in this kingdom, and also in Elangai as well. It’s there in Kanchi, as well as in Kadambur, and also in the underground prison. The prime minister knew that the physician’s son is an utter fool. And that’s why he sent me after him!”

“And the prime minister seemed to know that I would exit the fort through this route. Truly his eyes and ears are extraordinary! Then he must surely know that I am innocent and that throwing me in the underground prison was a mistake.”

“That’s not the prime minister’s responsibility. The emperor will pronounce his judgement on your innocence. And for escaping his

fort, Vellar will punish you justly!”

“Ayya, where are you taking me?”

“To Kodumbalur Vellar, who is waiting at the northern entrance of the fort.”

“Really! Is the Vellar waiting for me?”

“Aha, how vain can you get? Do you really think that Kodumbalur Vellar, who captured Elangai, and is the leader of brave Kodumbalur clan, is waiting for you?”

“Then why is he waiting?”

“Parthibendran is bringing the Pazhuvur brothers and the other chieftains who had gathered at Thirupurambiyam...”

“Is Periya Pazhuvetarayar coming too?”

“Yes, even him. They say that he knows how and who killed the crown prince. After his arrival, they will start the trial. You can prove your innocence in his presence.”

Hearing this, Vandiya Devan became troubled and anxious. Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Parthibendran would definitely accuse him of murder...

God! How can I prove my innocence to the prince and the emperor? What proof do I have that will proclaim my innocence?

“Ayya, I haven’t harmed you in anyway. Why don’t you allow me to escape? I am innocent, and I didn’t murder the crown prince. I was a close confidante of the crown prince, and circumstances allowed people to assume that I am guilty of this heinous crime. You are the servant of the prime minister and you were tasked with bringing the madman. Take him and go. Please, allow me to escape,” begged Vandiya Devan.

“If I let you go, what will you give me?” asked the fat soldier.

“You will earn my gratitude. And when the time comes, I will help you too!”

“Such a time will never come! And if it did, I will not seek help from someone like you. What can you do for me now?”

Vandiya Devan remembered the gold coins that he had taken from the treasury. They were inside his waistcloth.

“I can fill your hands with gold coins,” he said.

“Aha! Really! Show me these coins first...”

“If you can loosen these ropes, I will show you. They are in my waistcloth.”

“Just don’t try any of your tricks with me,” said the soldier and loosened his bonds. Vandiya Devan looked at the soldier up close as he took out the coins from his waistcloth. He then filled the soldier’s hands with the coins.

The soldier examined the coins carefully and said, “Thambi, where did you steal these coins from? Did you take them from the treasury in the Pazhuvur dark palace, or did you somehow pilfer them from the mint? Now there will be three charges on your head. The murder charge is already there, you will now be accused of escaping prison, and theft as well. They might as well put you to death, three times...”

“Ayya, I have performed many services for the royal family. I have taken confidential messages for them many times. I almost gave up my life trying to save Karikalar. I have a right to these coins. Moreover, I took only enough to spend on my travel...”

“You can tell all this when they interrogate you!”

“Then, will you not let me go?”

“Not even if the sun starts rising in the west, and if Shiva is proven to be greater than Maha Vishnu, will I turn traitor and betray my master for a few gold coins!”

Vandiya Devan now saw what Karuthiruman was doing. The madman was looking at him intently, as though waiting for a sign from him.

He immediately released his hands from the slackened bonds, pounced on the fat man, and pulled at his moustache and turban, which came away in his hand revealing Azhwarkadiyan Nambi!

“Fake Vaishnavan! I knew it was you!”

When Azhwarkadiyan tried to save his moustache and turban, he dropped the gold coins that Vandiya Devan had filled his hands and they fell down in the boat. Vandiya Devan pulled Azhwarkadiyan down tied him in the middle with the ropes. He then grabbed the sword that Azhwarkadiyan had tied to his waist, and unsheathed it with a ring.

While Vandiya Devan was tying up Azhwarkadiyan, Karuthiruman suddenly attacked the guards who were next to him and pushed them into the river. Of the other two soldiers, one of them approached Karuthiruman and the other went towards Vandiya Devan.

Both were hesitant and afraid. Vandiya Devan swirled his sword menacingly, and the soldier who came towards him voluntarily jumped into the river. Karuthiruman hit the other soldier with the oar and tied him to the boat too.

The boat moved along with the river current and the two soldiers who fell into the river were swimming to the opposite bank.

Vandiya Devan went near Azhwarkadiyan and said, “Veera Vaishnavarey! What do you say now?”

“What do I say? All this is my Lord’s work. He is present everywhere. The one who ties me, the one who is tied, the one who is pushed, and the one who pushes too. He is everywhere, be it in pillars and in rocks. He is in your sword, too, and so is he on my shoulders!”

“Then he is present in this river’s current, too. So I can throw you into the river, right?”

“Wasn’t Prahaladan tied to a rock and drowned in the water? Did Maha Vishnu rescue him? Even if my Lord doesn’t rescue me, at least I will reach Vaikundam...”

Vandiya Devan looked at him for a while and said, “Look here, you have helped me a few times. I don’t know what your motivation was to save me, but you have aided me in the past. I don’t want to kill you. But if you want me to spare your life you will need to help me now!”

“I believe in serving others with bodily help. Why don’t you release me? I will render any help you require?”

“I don’t want any bodily help from you. We both need two horses to escape. If you can tell me some way to get the horses, I will allow you float like this in the boat and you can escape if your luck favours you!”

“You are asking me for something that I can gladly provide!”

“You know where I can get horses?”

“Yes, I know a place where two horses can be procured. Do you know where Vaani Ammai lives?”

“Who is Vaani Ammai?”

“She provides the Thanjavur Thalikulathar temple with flowers. Born mute and deaf... her son is your friend Senthana Amuthan!”

“Yes, I know their house. It’s in the garden...”

“You will find two horses there, waiting for you!”

“How?”

“One is my horse. I left it at their garden and came here. The other is Senthana Amuthan’s horse. Poor boy, he had no experience in riding horses, and that mad beast unseated him and bucked him down. He was already weak with fever, and with this fall, his health has failed and he is on his deathbed... if he recovers, it will be a miracle.”

Hearing this, Vandiya Devan looked worried and asked, “Who is looking after him?”

“His mother and Poonguzhali are with him!”

Karuthiruman suddenly interjected into this conversation and asked, “Which mother?”

Both Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan looked at him in surprise.

“What are you asking?” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

“Does Sembiyanmadevi know that Senthana Amuthan is on his deathbed?”

“Yes, it is she who is supporting them through the temple grant. But right now, everyone in the royal family are in grief. Who will indeed spare a thought for poor Senthana Amuthan?”

Vandiya Devan turned towards Karuthiruman and asked, “What do you say? Shall we meet Senthana Amuthan and his mother and then leave?”

Karuthiruman nodded his head and agreed.

“Then, let’s take this boat to the bank,” said Vandiya Devan and turned towards Azhwarkadiyan, saying, “Vaishnavaney! If there is some trick involved in all this, then I don’t really care what happens to me, but I will send you to Kailasam before I leave this world!”

“Please, don’t send me to Kailasam, send me to Vaikundam instead,” pleaded Azhwarkadiyan.

Chapter 60: Amudhan's Worry

Senthan Amuthan lay on his sick bed in his hut in the garden. His mother Vaani Ammai was busy making medicines and gruel for her son, while Poonguzhali gave it to him and helped him partake it.

Some time ago, a physician from the Sundara Chola Adhurasalai had come there to check on Senthan Amuthan. Poonguzhali asked him privately, "How is Amuthan? Will he recover?"

"He was already weak from fever that he had contracted earlier and now he went on a long journey where he had fallen down from the horse. But none of this is fatal. There is something that lies buried in his heart and that is stopping him from recovering!"

Remembering the physician's words, Poonguzhali asked him, "Amutha, what are you worried about? What is this worry that is stopping you from recovering?"

"Poonguzhali, do you want the truth or do you want me to lie?"

"Are you perchance saying that I am lying?"

"Poonguzhali, it is becoming dangerous to talk to you. If you don't talk at all, I will be happy just watching your face..."

"You would probably be happy if I were deaf and mute like my aunts..."

"Not at all; the happiness that I experience when you sing can't be compared to anything in this world. Why waste time talking? Why don't you sing a Devaram song?"

"No. Until you tell me what's worrying you, I will not sing!"

"Alright. I am worried that I might recover fast..."

“What are you saying? Here I am, praying to all the Gods that you should recover fast, and here you are saying that you don’t want to recover!”

“If I recover my health, you will leave me and go away... that’s why I don’t want to recover!”

Poonguzhali’s face blossomed with happiness, and she smiled at him while her eyes filled with tears.

“Amutha! Your affection has indeed melted my heart. I can’t bear to leave you whilst you are ill, but I can’t stay here indefinitely. I have to go...”

“Yes, the sea is calling you. But what of it? I will come with you too. If you say ‘yes’ I will drop everything and come with you and my health too will recover!”

“Amutha, I have taken a vow that stops me from saying ‘yes’ to your love!”

“What is this vow?”

“I have vowed to marry a king and sit beside as his queen. If this vow doesn’t get fulfilled, I will remain a maiden all my life!”

“Yes, Ponniyin Selvar has captured your heart! But Poonguzhali, is this even possible?”

“You are wrong. Everyone loves the prince, and has affection for him. I, too, am devoted to him and have affection for him. When we took him to Nagapattinam, remember how we both looked after him?”

“If that is so, then you don’t... desire him, is it? Are you sure about this?”

“Amutha, there is a woman who is born to wed Ponniyin Selvar, and that is Vanathi. Just because I told her something as a jest, and

she took a vow saying that she won't ever ascend the throne!"

"She who was born of royal lineage has vowed never to ascend the throne, while you are adamant about 'ascending the throne'."

"Amutha, my aunt loved a royal prince. But all her life, she remained unfortunate and miserable. I wish to enjoy that good fortune that eluded her! And why shouldn't I?"

"It is 'I' who is unfortunate because of which you took such a vow!"

"Why do you get so discouraged? Is there a rule that says that only royalty can establish a royal line? Even people from ordinary families like yourself have won kingdoms and lands through the strength of their arms. Take a vow today to win a kingdom through your prowess and skill in battle, and I will stay by your side forever!"

"Poonguzhali, I was not born to achieve such greatness. My heart doesn't get excited by war and battle. I don't want to bear arms and cause harm to anyone in this world. I wish to sing songs of Lord Shiva, and spend my days listening to his glorious stories. There is no way that we can live together. Our aspirations and ambitions are different. Desiring your love is a dream that I can never achieve. There is no reason for you to tarry here. Don't wait for me to recover, please leave," said Senthana Amuthan.

Just then, they heard footsteps outside the hut, and they stopped talking.

Chapter 61: The Engagement

When they heard sounds of footsteps outside the hut, Poonguzhali went to the door. Senthana Amuthan sighed and laid down, thinking that she would now leave him forever, and the minute she stepped out of that door, his life on this world would end. When Poonguzhali, opened the door and then locked it again, Senthana Amuthan looked at her with surprise!

This is strange! Why is she locking the door and coming back to me? Has her heart relented towards me? Even if it did, she would start talking about me carving out an empire. Her heart was one with the sea, while his was engaged with this Lord! At which common point will they ever meet? His heart was like a pond, and his love and affection for her were like ripples in the water disturbing its stillness and peace. His love for her would always be unrequited, and dreaming about her would be of no help.

Poonguzhali came back to Senthana Amuthan's bedside and gazed at him intently with her beautiful eyes. Senthana Amuthan's heart lurched and he said, "Why did you close the door and lock it? Who was outside? It could be my mother..."

"Whoever it is, let them wait until we finish our conversation. The king and the queen deserve some privacy while they converse privately!"

"King and queen? Who is the king and who is queen?" asked Senthana Amuthan, surprised by her words.

"You are the king and I am the queen. Haven't you heard a word of what I was saying, Amutha?"

"No, Poonguzhali! There is no point in trying to transform me into a battle-loving prince. Our aspirations are different and they cannot be united!"

“It’s on us to unite our aspirations...”

“That is impossible!”

“It might be impossible for you, but I can do it. Amutha! I have decided. Your love and affection are more valuable to me than any golden throne or crown. I have decided to give up my dream to marry a king and I will marry you. If you cannot agree to my conditions, I will agree to yours. I will marry you.”

Senthan Amuthan, ecstatic to hear her speak thus, couldn’t believe her words. He said, “Poonguzhali! Poonguzhali! Is this a fever dream? Are you really saying this? Or am I interpreting it differently?”

“I will repeat again if you want. Since you refuse to listen to me, I have decided to listen to you and I have changed my mind. I will marry you. Ever since I heard about my aunt’s tragic past, I felt unwanted desires. I thought that she should have been the empress of this kingdom, and since she couldn’t get her heart’s desire, why shouldn’t I pursue them? When I saw her give up her life for her beloved, that desire died within me. I learned how difficult life could be for someone who lives in the palace, and I will never be happy there giving up my freedom and independence.

“Amutha! Once you recover, we will go to Kodi Karai. There, Lord Shiva is alone and lonely. We will serve him with flowers and songs. We can also take our boat and go out to the sea. Near Elangai, there are many beautiful islands. We could go there and become the king and queen of an island. There will be no one to contest our claim to these titles... Amutha, what do you say? Do you have any objection?”

“Just one objection, that I do not deserve such happiness. Are you really saying all this seriously? I am afraid that I will be disappointed in the end... no, you are being serious. Tell me when can we leave for Kodi Karai!”

“The minute you recover, we can go to Kodi Karai!”

“I have already recovered, Poonguzhali. If you want, I can walk around and show you,” said Senthana Amuthan, getting up to walk.

Poonguzhali stopped him from rising and said, “Please take rest for today, you can get up tomorrow!”

Just then they heard someone knock on the door.

“Mother is knocking the door. Open it. Let’s tell her this good news!”

Poonguzhali opened the door, and the scene that unfolded there surprised her. It was not Vaani Ammai who had knocked, but a palace servant who withdrew respectfully after the door opened.

At a distance, she could see two palanquins kept down. Sembiyanmadevi and Madhuranthakar were standing by their side along with palace servants and guards bearing fire torches. Seeing this, Poonguzhali bowed respectfully and said, “Devi, welcome...”

“How is your aunt’s son, Poonguzhali? Where is Vaani Ammai?” asked Sembiyanmadevi and entered the hut.

Madhuranthakar didn’t enter the hut. He merely stood at a distance, waiting for his mother. But his angry eyes eagerly looked into the hut. Senthana Amuthan, realizing who was entering the hut, immediately got up and stood beside the bed.

“Devi, your arrival is very opportune indeed. We are glad to announce our news to you first. We haven’t even told my mother yet. This has happened only due to the divine blessings of Lord Shiva. Devi... Poonguzhali has finally agreed to marry me, after all these years. We seek your blessings for this. We wish to leave to Kodi Karai and perform services for Lord Shiva’s temple there,” said Senthana Amuthan.

It was hard to discern if Sembiyanmadevi was happy or sad to hear this news. Her face blossomed and she smiled at the happy couple, while her eyes filled with tears. When Amuthan and Poonguzhali bowed low and sought her blessings, she became overwrought with emotion and said, "My children, may the Lord bless you with great marital happiness!"

At that time, Vaani Ammai came there, and Sembiyanmadevi told her through sign language that she came to check on Senthana Amuthan's health, and that there she learned that he was getting married to Poonguzhali, which has delighted her a lot. Vaani Ammai too seemed to express happiness and anxiety at the same time. After speaking to them for a while, Sembiyanmadevi came out of the hut and walked back towards her palanquin.

She stopped under the tree where her son was waiting for her, and then looked around carefully, before talking to him.

"Did you see, Madhuranthaka? The son whom I had borne in my womb lives in that hut as Senthana Amuthan. When he was five years old, I learned that he was my son. When he was an eight-day-old baby, he lay lifeless and I thought he was dead. I adopted you as my son because I couldn't bear the loss of a child. I asked Vaani to bury the lifeless child. She returned to Pazhaiarai after five years, and when I saw them again, I realized that my son was alive and was being raised by her. Despite knowing this secret, I neither gave you up nor did I bring him to the palace to raise him as a son. I thought this was the Lord's way of teaching us a lesson. I raised you in his stead with more affection and care than I have ever shown to the son born of my womb. Grant me this boon for not giving you up. Tell everyone that you will not ascend the throne. Think about this... What will happen if the children from our lineage are born deaf and mute? What will happen then?"

When Sembiyanmadevi said this, Madhuranthakan's face became pale and frightened. He was a father to a girl child who was almost two years old and was yet to speak!

Stunned by this realization, Madhuranthakan stood immobile under the tree. And he heard his adoptive mother say, “Child, why are you standing here? The hour is growing late, let’s go back to the palace. You have two days to think this over carefully and give your reply!”

Madhuranthakan said, “Mother, what’s there to think? Nothing! You go ahead to the palace. In the meanwhile, I would like to talk to the son who should have grown in my stead at the palace, and head back!”

“Alright. While on your way back, close the veils of your palanquin tightly. If the Vellar soldiers see you, they might raise a shout,” said Sembiyanmadevi and walked back to her palanquin without noticing the horrible transformation that Madhuranthakan’s face had attained.

Chapter 62: A Spear Hurled

Madhuranthakan stood still under the tree for a while. He seemed to be debating with himself whether to go inside the hut or back to the palace. After a while, he went to the palanquin bearers and his guards and said something. Then he took something out of his palanquin. And then, his palanquin and the guards bearing the fire torches left.

When he approached the hut, someone emerged from the back of the tree where he had stood conversing a little while with his mother. Madhuranthakan looked at him, startled, and it was none other than Karuthiruman, the madman who escaped with Vandiya Devan. And since he still looked like a madman, Madhuranthakan got scared by his sudden appearance.

He raised the dagger that he held in his hand menacingly, and Karuthiruman held his hands and said, "Prince, please don't attack me! I am not your enemy!"

"If not my enemy, who are you? Are you my friend?"

"Yes, ayya. I am your friend."

Madhuranthakan laughed, and his laughter was a mixture of anger, sorrow, disappointment, and frustration that had claimed his life for long.

"A nice friend you are! Just when the entire world is slipping through my fingers, at least you are calling yourself 'my friend'!"

"That's right, ayya, no one in this world can help you in the way that I can..."

"What do you mean by that? Tell me fast, the hour is growing late!"

“Where do you have to go?”

“Where else, but to the palace?”

“Will you return to that palace where you have no birth right?”

Madhuranthakan was startled. With rising fear and desperation, he demanded, “Adey, what do you mean by that? What do you know? How did you find out? If you don’t answer immediately, I will...” saying thus, he raised his hand with the dagger and approached the madman.

“Ayya, don’t raise your sword on me. Use it on your enemies instead. A few moments ago, when you stood here with the queen who raised you as her son, I was standing behind the tree and you both didn’t notice me!”

“So you overheard our conversation and that’s why you accosted me?”

“No! I knew this secret many years ago. I knew that Queen Sembiyanmadevi is not your mother and that Emperor Gandaradithan is not your father either. She might have told you who your mother was, but even she can’t tell you who your father was!”

Madhuranthakan stared at him with disbelief and asked, “And you know that truth?”

“Yes, I do!”

Madhuranthakan was now afraid that the man who claimed to know the truth might also claim that he is the father. With rising disgust and horror, he demanded, “How would you know? Who are you?”

Karuthiruman neared him and whispered, “I am your father’s servant...” and then he said, “Ayya, your father is...”

When Madhuranthakan learned who his father was, his head swirled, and he would have dropped into a dead faint but for Karuthiruman, who held him tightly. With rising disbelief and shock, he asked, “Are you telling the truth? Am I really a prince?”

“Yes, ayya! I came to tell you this truth many years ago. But unfortunately, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar saw me in the palace garden and threw me in the underground prison!”

“How did you escape? When?”

“I escaped today with the help of this youth named Vandiya Devan!”

“Aha! I heard that. Isn’t he the one who now stands accused of Karikalan’s murder?”

“That’s right, but he is innocent of this charge!”

“Who cares whether he is the killer or not? Where is he now?”

“There, he is waiting for me behind the fence where two horses are also waiting for us. He must be angry because I am delaying, but I am not bothered about it. Meeting you thus unexpectedly is a lucky coincidence for me.”

“When did you come here?” asked Madhuranthakan.

“Just a while ago, we came here. We heard that there were two horses tied up in this garden. We thought we could take them and escape. While we were searching for the horses, we saw the fire torches come this way, and found the horses by their light. When we saw the palanquins and the dowager queen, we didn’t know that you would halt here and go into the hut. Vandiya Devan jumped over the fence, and I hid myself behind the tree. We saw you both go into the hut. That’s when I saw Vaani come this way. I had not met her for many years, and was talking to her in sign language behind this tree. After some time she left, too, and I stayed behind. The queen then

came and was talking to you. I happened to hear the conversation from behind the tree and met you as well...”

“Alright what do you propose to do now?”

“It is up to you, ayya. But do you really intend to go back to the palace where you have no rights? Apart from your mother, many others know the secret about your birth and that you do not belong to the Chola lineage. The prime minister and his spy Azhwarkadiyan Nambi know about this, and one day they might...”

“Yes, I have no interest in going back to the Thanjavur palace. What do you say we do?”

“Beyond the fence, there are two horses. You go towards the hut and then come to the backside near the fence. I will try and stall Vandiya Devan. You throw that dagger in your hand and kill him, and you and I can escape from this place on both the horses. We can go to Kodi Karai. The King of Elangai, Mahindan, is the enemy of the Cholas and has supported the Pandyas all his life. I know Mahindan very well, and the location of the Pandya treasures, the coronation crown and the gemstone aaram... what do you say?”

Madhuranthakan heard what Karuthiruman said quite intently. Hope rose in his heart and he started building many new castles in the air.

“Ayya, the hour is growing very late. What do you say? If we tarry anymore, Vandiya Devan might come here!”

“Do we really have to kill him?”

“If you are hesitant to kill, give me your dagger, I will kill him!”

“No, let this dagger be used for other purposes. I know about Vandiya Devan. He is a warrior. Why can’t we take him along with us?”

“We could do that but we don’t have another horse!”

“We can get another horse. I am, after all, the crown prince of the Chola Kingdom, am I not?” said the prince. He laughed and then said, “You go now and ask him to wait awhile. I will speak to the man in the hut and then come there soon.”

Karuthiruman moved towards the fence where Vandiya Devan was supposed to be hiding. It was dark by then, and the only light available was from the fire torches that someone might bring on the royal road (which was quite close). By their light, they could see that there were two large warhorses tied to the tree, but there was no sign of Vandiya Devan. Karuthiruman tried to call for him with a low voice, but there was no response.

Alright if he has gone missing on his own, then it is good for everyone.

When Vandiya Devan and Karuthiruman had come to the garden house of Senthana Amuthan, it was already dark. The lamps that were lit inside the hut gave some light outside, and helped them find their way about. Vaani Ammai, who had come to the lotus pond to fill water, looked at them with alarm. She first spotted Vandiya Devan, who she remembered as Senthana Amuthan’s friend, and she welcomed him with a smile. But when she saw Karuthiruman behind him, her face became pale and she became scared and stood immobile in shock. Karuthiruman spoke to her in sign language and tried to reassure her.

Vandiya Devan left them both and went towards the hut. Poonguzhali had just then locked the hut, so he peeped inside through the window. When he found that Senthana Amuthan was talking to Poonguzhali happily, he felt reassured of his friend’s health. He felt hesitant to disturb them while in private. And before he could make up his mind about it, Sembiyanmadevi and Madhuranthakan had come there with their entourage.

He immediately jumped over the fence and hid himself. Seeing the horses there reassured him, and he felt grateful for the fact that Azhwarkadiyan Nambi had not tried to deceive him after all. After some time, Sembianmadevi left in her palanquin and the guards too left after a while. But there was no sign of Karuthiruman. Losing his patience at the delay, Vandiya Devan jumped over the fence again and came towards the hut.

There, he saw Karuthiruman and Madhuranthakan conversing under the tree. Wondering what they could be talking about, he stood there hesitating. A few alarming thoughts flew through his mind, and one portion of the conversation also fell on his ears. When Madhuranthakan went towards the hut, without realizing what he was doing, Vandiya Devan followed him.

Madhuranthakan went to the hut and stood outside, wondering whether he should go inside or not. But when he heard peals of laughter coming from inside, he changed his mind and did not enter the hut. He turned around and started going towards the direction where Karuthiruman had jumped over the fence and was waiting for him.

Vandiya Devan sprang towards a tree to hide himself, and that's when he saw a terrifying sight. There was a window on the backside of the hut through which the lamps that were lit, provide light outside. There he saw a man standing with a short spear in his hand aiming to hurl it inside.

The man was obviously aiming to kill, because he was biding his time and taking his aim carefully. At that time, Vandiya Devan also heard the horses leaving and their hooves sounding a slow gallop.

If the horses left, he would be stranded here with no way to escape. But if he went after them, this man would fulfil his murderous intent, and he cannot stop him. Vandiya Devan's dilemma didn't last long.

Let the horses go to hell. My duty lies here...

Thinking thus, he started moving towards the man who stood there.

That's when he heard a woman shrieking from inside the hut. Vandiya Devan sprang towards the man suddenly and turned around. Instead of hurling the spear inside, he turned it on Vandiya Devan, injuring him in the ribs, and fled the place.

Chapter 63: Pinagapani's Deceit

When Ponniyin Selvar, Kundavai Devi, and others had gone to the underground prison, they didn't find Vandiya Devan there. Instead, they found a hysterical Pinagapani bound to the wall with iron chains, who was shouting, "The murderer has escaped! The madman has escaped!"

Kundavai and Vanathi recognized him and asked him what had transpired. With great agitation and anger, the physician's son narrated the events that happened a short while ago and demanded that soldiers be sent after them to hunt them down.

To his great disappointment, Ponniyin Selvar and the others didn't show any great urgency to send soldiers after the escaped prisoners. Instead, they were relieved that Vandiya Devan had managed to escape and admired his clever ingenuity. But when Manimegalai started to express her happiness about it publicly, Kundavai intervened and said, "Sister, let's not discuss this here. This is related to royal affairs, and we women should best stay away from it. You can reveal what's in your heart to me later!"

Later, when they came to the main entrance of the prison, Kodumbalur Vellar came there. By then, he had heard that something had gone wrong there, and the prisoners had escaped. After learning what had happened there, even he didn't show any urgency in catching the escaped prisoners. In his heart, he too knew that there was no truth to the charges laid on Vandiya Devan. He was also aware of the confidence and affection that the prince and princess held for Vandiya Devan. Instead of getting angry about the escaped prisoners, he marvelled at Vandiya Devan's penchant for escaping prisons.

"That youth from the Vanar Clan is very clever. In Elangai, he cleverly escaped from the prison in Maandotham just like this," said the commander, laughing.

The physician's son now unwisely intervened and said, "Ayya, shouldn't we make an effort to catch the escaped prisoners?"

"Ah, where will they run? They will be inside the fort! We will find them," said the commander carelessly.

Pinagapani, frustrated by the fact that no one was showing any outrage or anger at the fact that Vandiya Devan had escaped, shouted, "No! No! That murderer! He knows where the underground passage is, and he will use it to exit the fort!"

Incensed by his words, the commander turned on him and said, "Fool, so now you will tell me what to do? You are the reason why they have escaped. Who knows you might be colluding with them in their escape plan. Here, now imprison this fool and throw him in the underground prison," said the commander furiously to the guards who stood next to him.

Pinagapani now realized his precarious position and trembled with fear, saying, "No, ayya, I didn't collude with them in their escape. It was the prime minister who sent me here..."

Ponniyin Selvar now intervened and said, "Yes, it was the prime minister who sent him. Why don't we send him back to Anirudhar? He will punish him for his foolish actions!"

Heeding the prince's words, the commander asked the guards to escort Pinagapani back to the prime minister's house.

Unfortunately for Pinagapani, even the prime minister didn't show any urgency to retrieve the escaped prisoners. Anirudhar's long-standing habit was to never send one man for any work. If he set a task for a spy, he would always send another spy behind him to see if the task was completed properly. Since he had sent Azhwarkadiyan Nambi after Pinagapani, he was not overly worried. He knew that his disciple would either bring the prisoners back or at least get some news about them. In his heart of hearts, he ardently

wished that the escaped prisoners eluded capture and not come back ever, as it would solve many problems for them.

Therefore, when Pinagapani narrated what had happened in the underground prison and demanded, “Ayya, send four men along with me! I will bring the escaped murderers back to you,” he got a good tongue lashing from the prime minister.

“Fool, you have bungled this thoroughly. I sent you there because I didn’t want anybody else to know about the madman’s existence. If I knew that you would fail so spectacularly at this, I would have gone there myself. Now everyone in the palace has learned about the madman. And as if that were not enough, you want to announce this to everyone. Enough! You are unsuited for this work. Don’t come back here and show me your face ever! If I learn that you spoke about what happened today to anyone, I will make sure you get a public execution!” Threatened the prime minister.

Pinagapani came out of the prime minister’s house with a downcast look. The unfortunate turn of events that resulted in him losing his royal position at the prime minister’s palace turned into a rage that he channelled towards his arch nemesis, Vandiya Devan. He felt that his entire life was blighted by the existence of Vandiya Devan, whose sole aim was to earn him disrespect and condemnation from his masters who he wished to please. Because of him, the commander and the prime minister blamed him now. He was resolved to hunt down the escaped prisoners and bring them back to justice.

If the others wish to remain careless, let them be so. I will avenge Vandiya Devan for my shattered dreams. If the madman wants to escape, let him go. But I will not spare Vandiya Devan for the harm that he has caused me...

Deciding thus, Pinagapani exited the fort. He truly believed that Vandiya Devan would not be inside the fort for long. He was certain that Vandiya Devan knew where the underground passage led and he would use it to exit the fort. Pinagapani himself didn’t know where

the passage exited but guessed that it would end somewhere near the fort walls. And he might get a chance to catch them both while they emerged out of the passage.

Thinking thus, Pinagapani started circling the fort, watching out for any entrance that might open near the fort walls. He saw Vellar's men patrolling the fort. And if challenged, he could show them the prime minister's signet ring that he still had in his possession. But it would delay and hinder his quest. So whenever the patrolling soldiers came, he would hide behind the trees or shrubs. While he was hiding behind a shrub like this, he noticed two men hiding behind the shrubs ahead of him, and one of them bore a long sword. Suspecting that they might be Vandiya Devan and the madman, Pinagapani started following them at a distance.

He didn't want to stop and challenge them. And since one of them had a sword, he hesitated. He wanted to confirm whether they were the escaped prisoners and then try and catch them. He had a short spear on his person, and this time around, he was determined to end the life of his arch-enemy Vandiya Devan.

There, I can see the north fort entrance! What's happening there? Why are there so many palanquins, horses, and elephants?

An entourage of soldiers and guards bearing fire torches were gathered near the fort entrance and Pinagapani didn't know whether they were entering or exiting the fort.

While he was watching the fort entrance, the men that he was following disappeared.

God! Where did they go? Did they enter a lane and go missing? Could they have gone to the royal road? Would escaped prisoners dare to take the royal road? Where else could they go?

That's when he remembered that Senthana Amuthan's house was situated near the fort's northern entrance. He also remembered that

Vandiya Devan had hidden himself in Amuthan's house when he had earlier escaped from the fort.

Yes, yes, they must have gone to Senthana Amuthan's house. God knows what that cunning Vandiya Devan has planned!

Pinagapani now went towards the garden house. It was very dark, and therefore difficult to find the path that led towards his house. When he arrived there, he was surprised to see palanquins and guards waiting in the garden. Hesitant to move ahead, he hid himself and waited in the garden. After some time the palanquins and the guards left the place.

Pinagapani surveyed the garden and the house carefully. Beyond the fence, he could see the heads of two horses and his impatience increased. He tip-toed towards the hut and saw two people standing under the tree and talking. He was now convinced that it must be the escaped prisoners that he was hunting down. He wondered how there were two horses ready here for the prisoners to escape! Is the royal family personally helping them escape? Could it be because the madman was claiming that he knew a royal secret? Are they allowing him to escape so that he doesn't publicly reveal his secrets?

Pinagapani peeped from behind the tree where he was hiding and carefully looked at the men who were conversing under the tree. One of them was definitely the madman. He could recognize his dreadful voice from anywhere. Then the other man must be Vandiya Devan... except, it was not. It looked like...

How strange! What is Prince Madhuranthakan doing here? There is no doubt about the fact that it was him.

He could see the prince's crown, silk upper cloth, pearl aarams, and bracelets that adorned the prince.

Why is Prince Madhuranthakan talking to this madman? What could they possibly converse about?

Who cares anyway? Where is my sworn enemy, Vandiya Devan? He must be somewhere nearby. The man who bore that sword... it must be him. No doubt about it. Could he be near the horses that are tied near the fence? Is he waiting on one of them, ready to escape the minute the madman returned? Yes, that's it. It is Prince Madhuranthakan who is aiding them in their escape. Maybe he murdered Karikalar at the behest of Prince Madhuranthakan! And now that they were about to escape, the prince is sending a message along with the madman to Vandiya Devan. How do I prove the truth of this to others?

With Pinagapani's twisted brain spouting such theories, he thought that for what it is worth it would be best to go to the horses and check. And if he found Vandiya Devan there, he would kill him right there. After that, he could catch this madman and scare the truth out of him. He couldn't near the fence from where he stood. It would expose him to the men who were under the tree, and he would have to cross the lotus pond too. Therefore, he decided to go to the rear side of the hut and cross the fence there.

When he neared the rear of the hut, from the window, he could hear the voices of Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali. Right from the time he met Poonguzhali at Kodi Karai, he desired her love and attention. She was the primary reason for his jealous rage against Vandiya Devan. Later, when he went to Kodi Karai to capture Mandakini, he learned that Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali were travelling together, and he was furious at him too.

Now when he saw Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali conversing happily with one another with nary a care, he couldn't contain his jealous rage. When he actually heard their conversation about getting married and travelling to Kodi Karai, he reached the peak of his fury and anger.

Chi, will the son of this mute woman finally attain the beautiful Poonguzhali?

Pinagapani was utterly disgusted by the thought, and at that moment Vandiya Devan and the madman were forgotten. He forgot his determination to catch the escaped prisoners. He was now determined to send this singing beggar to Kailasam first and take care of other things...

Thinking thus, he took his short spear and aimed it at Senthana Amuthan through the window. Poonguzhali, who saw the spear glinting through the window, shrieked. Senthana Amuthan turned towards the window to see what had scared her. That was the moment Pinagapani was waiting for. Just when he was ready to hurl the spear, he heard someone behind him. In reflex, he turned around and the spear struck the man, who crumpled to the floor. Pinagapani then ran from there.

At the same time, he heard the slow gallop of the horses. It must be Vandiya Devan and the madman who are escaping.

Then the man who was trying to stop me just now was Prince Madhuranthakan!

The horror that Pinagapani felt when he realized that he had probably killed the prince was indescribable. Just then, he could hear the shouts of "Aha! Ayyo!" from behind and realized that the Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali had probably come out of their hut to see the prince drowning in his own blood. Pinagapani ran madly from the garden house. His first priority was to move away from the scene of the crime and his second was to catch the prisoners who escaped.

Outside Senthana Amuthan's hut, Poonguzhali brought a lamp to see who had fallen there. And to their horror, they discovered Vandiya Devan in a pool of blood. They carefully lifted him and took him inside the hut. They were relieved by the fact that he had not died from his wounds, and Vaani Ammai started preparing her herbs to apply on his wound.

Chapter 64: Tell the Truth

After Vandiya Devan left Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, the boat floated along the river for a while, and then came near the banks. Nambi's men, who had fallen into the river during their altercation, came and joined him.

But Nambi didn't get down from the boat. He lay there with the ropes loosely bound to give an impression that he was still tied to it and asked the others to hide. In truth, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi intended to allow Vandiya Devan and Karuthiruman to escape. He knew that the prime minister too was of the same mind.

The presence of both these men at Thanjavur would lead to dangerous consequences. And any investigation into the past could have unwanted repercussions. The prime minister was convinced of Vandiya Devan's innocence, but if he was put to trial, many uncomfortable truths might be revealed and hearts would be broken.

Revealing the truth to the public right then would be most unwise. Arulmozhivarman would lose a good friend, the Chola Kingdom would lose a great warrior and a clever strategist. The prime minister was also aware of Kundavai's state of heart when it came to Vandiya Devan, while Manimegalai was quite vocal about her affections for him.

Thinking thus, he had decided that it was best if Vandiya Devan could escape from Thanjavur.

After getting the horses at Senthana Amuthan's house, he anticipated that they would ride through the banks of the Vadavaru River. If they come by that route, they could go all the way to the Pamani River, where the Vadavaru River joined it, and they would reach Kodi Karai quickly. He wanted to give a message to Vandiya Devan before they left, and that's why he lay there on the boat waiting for them.

When the escaped prisoners took more time than anticipated, he thought, 'I was wrong. Maybe they are taking another route to Kodi Karai! Or could something else have occurred that had thwarted their plans?'

Just when Thirumalai thought of getting down from the boat, he heard galloping horses coming their way. He immediately lay down, bound.

When the horses came near, he shouted, "Who goes there? Please, stop for a minute! Please untie my ropes!"

The horses galloped by him without stopping. On the first horse was Karuthiruman, therefore the second horse should bear Vandiya Devan. Realizing this, Nambi shouted, "Vandiya Deva! Vandiya Deva! Stop please!"

When the second horse passed by him, he was shocked to see who was on it, and almost doubted his eyes.

A few minutes later, one horse alone came back, and Karuthiruman unmounted and came towards the bank and said, "Poor you! You are still bound to this boat! You have helped us a lot. That's why I came back to untie you. Don't get up to any tricks..." saying thus, he tried to get on the boat when Azhwarkadiyan Nambi pounced on him and fell him to the ground.

Karuthiruman, who didn't expect this, lay still shocked and said piteously, "Ayyo! Please let me go. I came here with the good intention of untying you, and here you are, attacking me. There, your friend Vandiya Devan was just now telling me what a good friend you are. What will he think to see you attacking me thus? Let me go!"

Azhwarkadiyan demanded, "Adey, what an audacious liar you are. Who is on that horse? Tell me. If you do, I will let you go! Or else I won't spare you!"

“Yes, that’s not Vandiya Devan. I can’t trick you. I accept that. It’s Prince Madhuranthakan who is on the horse. Spare me, please, I will get the prince to give you a reward!”

“Forget the reward, where is Vandiya Devan?”

“He vanished. He said he would stay by the horses, but we couldn’t find him!”

“Where are you going?”

“The same place where I was planning to go with Vandiya Devan...”

“You mean Elangai?”

“Yes!”

“Why is Madhuranthakar coming along with you?”

“How will I know that? You should ask him. He just said that he would come with me!”

Now Azhwarkadiyan sat on Karuthiruman’s chest and asked, “Tell me the truth! Who are Madhuranthakar’s parents?”

“What kind of question is this? He is the son of Sembiyanmadevi... No, no, don’t strangle me so. He is the son of the mute woman named Mandakini!”

“Who is Madhuranthakan’s father? Tell me truth, or else you won’t be spared!”

Karuthiruman replied to this in a low whisper.

“Good! You have saved yourself. Tell me one more thing, and I will release you. Who are Senthana Amuthan’s parents?”

“Why do you ask? You seem to know everything...”

“Is he the son of Gandaradhithar and Sembiyanmadevi?”

“Yes, and I am the reason why he is alive today. The Deaf and mute Vaani was about to bury the child when I stopped her and showed her that the baby was alive. At least for that, you need to spare me now!”

“Truly, I am sparing your life because of that one action of yours,” said Azhwarkadiyan and got up.

Karuthiruman got up, ran with doddering legs towards his horse, mounted it and galloped away.

Chapter 65: Ayyo! Ghost

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi gathered his men and started towards the northern fort entrance. The readers must have realized why he didn't want his men about when he was threatening Karuthiruman. He wanted Karuthiruman to confirm certain secrets that he was privy to, and didn't want others to listen in.

After they reached half the distance, he saw a man running hysterically on the road. After colliding with the Nambi, the man tried to run again but Azhwarkadiyan held him in a vice grip, looked at him carefully, and said, "Adey! Pinagapani! Where are you running like this?"

"Oh! It's you, Vaishnavaney! I thought it was a ghost or a ghoul and got scared. Good that you came here. From where are you coming? Did you see two horses bearing men..."

"Yes, I saw them. What about it? What is it to you?"

"What is it to me, you ask? If you but knew who they were, you won't ask this question. Did you recognize at least one of them?"

"One of them seemed vaguely familiar but I dismissed my fears..."

"Who? Who did you think it was?"

"I thought he looked like Vandiya Devan, but I decided that it can't be!"

"My god! It was indeed Vandiya Devan!"

"What are you blabbering? Isn't Vandiya Devan shut in the underground prison?"

“He was shut in the prison but he escaped along with the madman, after tying me in the cell in his stead!”

“Good for them. What were you doing when they were tying you up, and why did you go to the prison in the first place?”

“I went there on the prime minister’s orders. You too serve him, don’t you? Come with me, let’s catch the prisoners and bring them back!”

“Why are you so hell bent on catching them? What is it to you and me if they flee?”

“Indeed! The prime minister does have some good men around him. If everyone had this attitude, then this kingdom will perish for sure. Vandiya Devan is accused of treasonously murdering the crown prince, and that’s not all. A little while ago, he seemed to have killed another man near Senthana Amuthan’s hut with his short spear.”

“What are you saying? Who did he kill?”

“I didn’t wait to see who he killed. I came in pursuit of him. Alright, if you don’t want to help me, then at least let me go after them!”

“Physician’s son, I have seen many fools in my life, but none can compare with the likes of you. They are on horseback, escaping capital punishment, and you are going after them on foot! But who am I to say these things to you? Go after them...”

“You are right, that’s why I asked you to join me, but you refused!”

“What can I do to help you? I tried to stop the men on the horses, and one of them whipped me instead. I do not have experience in fighting. Maybe you... what is that in your hand? Is that blood?”

“They attacked me in the prison and injured me, they are murderous fiends!”

“Great, and here you are, going after them on foot. When they could do this to you in the prison, where there are many guards, imagine what would happen if they get their hands on you alone!”

“Then, what is it that you suggest?”

“I am not suggesting anything. But if I were in your position, I would go back and inform the commander, take a few men on horseback, arm myself to the teeth, and then resume the man hunt!”

Pinagapani thought for a while. He had either grievously injured or killed someone at Senthana Amuthan’s hut. It could be Prince Madhuranthakan! The thought that he might have killed a prince made him tremble with fear. But it was indeed foolish to go after the prisoners on foot. If it turned out that it was indeed Prince Madhuranthakan who had fallen prey to this short spear, then it would be better to lay the blame on Vandiya Devan’s head. After all, he already stood accused of murdering one prince. And he surely wouldn’t flinch to kill another. After deciding thus, he genuinely started believing that it was indeed Vandiya Devan who had killed Prince Madhuranthakan.

“Vaishnavaney! You are right. I will come with you, if you agree to help me. If you can speak to the right people and send some soldiers on horseback, it would be good. I don’t want to talk to anybody there. I asked the commander and the prime minister to send some men along with me to capture the fleeing prisoners, and they chided me instead and called me a fool. I can’t discern their motives...”

“What other motive would they have? They don’t trust you to do this work, that’s all. When the prisoners could trick you while inside the prison and escape, it is hard to trust that you would catch them and bring them back!”

“I wished to win their trust back, that’s why I ran after the prisoners alone. After all, they have to stop at Kodi Karai and there I know all the hiding places that Vandiya Devan will use, and I have people there who can help me...”

“If that is so, then go. I am sure you will catch them!”

“Even so, I think it’s better if we get a few soldiers on horseback to help. Will you help me?”

By now, they had come near the northern entrance of the fort. At a distance, on the royal road, mounted elephants, horses, foot soldiers could be seen nearing the fort. At the fort entrance, Kodumbalur Vellar, Thirukkoyalur Malayaman and Prime Minister Anirudhar could be seen waiting.

“There, our master is waiting by the fort entrance! Shall we go to him?” asked Azhwarkadiyan.

Pinagapani hesitated to approach the prime minister and said, “I told them once, but to no avail. Maybe if you were to tell them that you saw the prisoners fleeing, they might believe you. Even so, I doubt if they would send me along to catch them!”

“You are right. And they are gathered here for a different reason, and now is not the time to approach them with this matter. There, it looks like the Pazhuvur brothers and Sambuvarayar are coming. And along with them are Kandanmaran and Parthibendra Pallavan. Let’s go to them. They would be interested in hunting down Vandiya Devan...”

The procession soon neared them. First came the heralds who announced the approach of the Pazhuvetarayars, Kadambur Sambuvarayar, Mazhavereyar, Erattaikudai Rajaliyar, Parthibendra Pallavan, and other noble chieftains. Gongs and drums played at intervals, announcing their arrival. At the head of the procession, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, Kandanmaran and Parthibendra Pallavan could be seen riding white horses. Behind them, Periya Pazhuvetarayar and Sambuvarayar could be seen on the mounted elephants. The noble chieftains could be seen either on elephants or horses. And the rear of the procession had thousands of soldiers marching with their swords and spears.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar spotted the Vaishnavan and stopped his horse by him. “Vaishnavaney! Do you bring a message from the prime minister?”

“Commander, I bring no news from the prime minister. He is waiting for you at the fort entrance but there is something important that you ought to know!”

“What? What is it?” asked Kandanmara and the Pallavan.

“Vandiya Devan has escaped from the underground prison!”

“How is that possible? Is he Indrajith^[33], to disappear and vanish at will?!” Chinna Pazhuvetarayar asked with great astonishment.

“This a conspiracy! Someone must have surely helped him escape,” said Parthibendran.

“This must be the handiwork of Kodumbalur Vellar,” said Kandanmaran darkly.

“Even if he had escaped, where will he go? He must be inside the fort...” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

“That’s what Vellar said as well, but the prime minister bid me to keep an eye outside the fort as well. The prime minister is worried about the Kadambur clan and wishes to keep them safe from unwanted accusations...”

“At least there is one person who is worried about us. That is very satisfying indeed!”

“Vaishnavaney, tell me truth. Did you come here to capture the prisoners or to help them flee?” asked Parthibendran, who was always suspicious about the Nambi.

“Ayya, if the circumstances were different, I would have given you a different answer. But now is not the time to fight amongst

ourselves. Here, this physician's son has brought news that two men on horseback were seen riding on the royal road. He swears that it was Vandiya Devan and Karuthiruman. Even I saw two horses racing through the road that way!"

"Pinagapani, is the Vaishnavan telling the truth?" asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

"I swear it's the truth!"

"Then why didn't you go to Vellar and the prime minister and inform them?"

"They both are furious with me!"

"And why is that?"

"They think that it was I who helped the prisoners escape!"

"How?"

"There was a prisoner who was claiming that he knew where the Pandya coronation crown and the navaratna aaram were hidden in Elangai. The prime minister sent me to release him. But at the prison, Vandiya Devan and the madman attacked me and bound me to the cell and escaped!"

Hearing his tale, Parthibendran laughed and said, "Looks like the prime minister couldn't find anybody else, so he had to send a fool like you to the prison..."

Pinagapani, now furious, said angrily, "Ayya, I didn't come here to be mocked. I came here seeking help."

"What help do you seek?"

"Send four or five soldiers with me, and give me a horse too. I will bring them back to face justice. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar knows me

well, and I have fulfilled my tasks with great dedication..." said Pinagapani.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar turned towards Parthibendran and said, "What do you say?"

"Send the soldiers with him. The emperor tasked me with bringing you and other noble chieftains to the fort, or else I would go with them myself. It is imperative that we find Vandiya Devan and bring him back!"

Kandanmaran then said, "I will undertake the responsibility of bringing that scoundrel back. Even if he is the death's door, I will drag him back, I promise!"

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar agreed to this plan of action, and said that he would inform Sambuvarayar about this. They immediately mobilized four to five soldiers and horses, provided Pinagapani with a horse, too, and started their pursuit along the royal road laid by the banks of Vadavaru River.

Madhuranthakan was inexperienced with riding horses. While Karuthiruman knew how to ride, his long incarceration had weakened his body. But they both had renewed hope and dreams that they wish to fulfil, and that helped them ignore the hardships they would eventually face.

They rode hard until midnight, and stopped when they saw a rope bridge tied across the river. Karuthiruman knew that soldiers will soon be deployed to pursue them. So he thought it would be best to cross the river there and then take another route to reach Kodi Karai. He was also worried about another thing. He didn't think that Madhuranthakan could handle the horse and cross the river at the same time. He thought he could ask the prince to cross the river using the rope bridge, and then take both the horses across the river.

Madhuranthakan agreed to this idea. And before they could put it to action, they thought they would rest awhile. They sat down under a tree to catch their breath. The river water flowed steadily with strong water currents, while on the sky the clouds cleared away to reveal the stars. Madhuranthakan, who had until then slept on comfortable beds and soft cushions, rued his fate for sitting under the tree with nary a roof. He was now worried and depressed about his fate and the days to come...

Karuthiruman understood Madhuranthakan's struggle and fears, and sought to bolster his heart. He told that King Mahindan was a staunch ally of the Pandyas and once Madhuranthakan joined him in Elangai, they could raise a strong army to resist the Cholas. Mahindan was also guarding the ancient treasures of Pandya kings. The coronation crown of the Pandyas and the gemstone aaram presented to them by Indra, the King of Devas, was hidden in Elangai. And he knew its location. Mahindan himself could coronate Madhuranthakan as the next Pandya emperor!

By then, confusion and chaos will reach its pinnacle in the Chola Kingdom. Noble clans and chieftains will surely fight amongst themselves and raze the kingdom to dust. One faction will blame the Pazhuvetarayars and Sambuvarayars for killing Aditya Karikalan, while they in turn will blame the Vellar and Malayaman for killing Madhuranthakan. His disappearance from the fort at this crucial time will be interpreted thus. And prince Arulmozhivarman will be ultimately blamed for both these murders, and these rumours will eventually kill the regard and affection that the people have for him.

While the Chola kingdom was embroiled in such intrigues and chaos, the Elangai King Mahindan will raise a huge army and invade the Cholas, and destroy their race. They will then capture Madurai and perform a coronation ceremony for Madhuranthakan where he will be ceremoniously crowned as the emperor...

As Karuthiruman spoke, Madhuranthakan's spirits rose and his daydreams took shape. He could see himself getting coronated, and almost hear the gongs of victory and drums heralding his kingship.

He could hear the people cheering him as 'Victory to Pandya Emperor!'

While he lingered in this day dream, they heard the sound of galloping horses. Soon, they could see the light of the fire torches too. Karuthiruman was shocked to see that their pursuers had reached the spot so fast. He sprang to his feet immediately and said, "Prince, get up fast. Get on your horse! We need to cross the river before they arrive!"

He immediately mounted his horse. And when he saw Madhuranthakan struggling to mount his steed, he said, "Ayya, why don't you cross the river over the rope bridge while I bring both our horses across the river?"

"That's nice! Do you think I am a coward? If I cannot manage to cross this river with just a mere horse, how do you think I can cross the sea and get to Elangai? And from where will we raise armies to oust the chola kingdom and ascend the Pandya throne?" said Madhuranthakan bravely and the slowly got on his mount.

Both the horses got into the river and started crossing the river. In the middle, Madhuranthakan's horse suddenly kneeled down, and was starting to float with the water current. Scared by its action, Karuthiruman screamed, 'Ayyo' but it immediately responded to his goading and started crossing the river again.

While Madhuranthakan too had gotten scared by the horse's action, he didn't show it outside and instead said to Karuthiruman, "This is nothing. Why are you getting scared over small things?"

It seemed as if Madhuranthakan's horse was wounded. Unlike the other horse, it didn't cross the river quickly, and tried to float in the river water. Madhuranthakan found it very difficult to goad it towards the bank. And, on the other end, the sound of the galloping horses was coming closer.

Until Madhuranthakan was halfway through the river, Karuthiruman was with him. After that, he crossed the river quickly and tied his horse to the nearby tree, and then crossed over to the other side. He then cut some ropes that were hanging from the bridge and then knotted them together to make a bigger rope. One end of the rope he tied to the bridge, and the other end he crossed the road and tied to a tree that stood opposite to the bridge.

The shadows of the trees and the surrounding darkness would make it impossible for the coming riders to see that a rope had been tied across the road. That too, these galloping horses were speeding through the road. And by blocking them thus, he hoped to gain some time for Madhuranthakan, who was still crossing the river. He wondered whether he should cross back to the other side, but thought better of it and climbed a nearby tree and waited.

Madhuranthakan was nearing the bank. And in a few more minutes, he would be able to climb the river bank along with the horse. Even before this thought could vanish, the speeding horses came through the road. There were five to six horsemen, and two were in the forefront. They fell prey to Karuthiruman's rope. Stalled suddenly by the rope, the men fell forward on their heads, while their horses broke their legs.

Watching this from above, Karuthiruman unconsciously laughed out aloud. 'Ha Ha Ha!'

One of the men who had fallen from a horse now got scared and shouted, 'Ayyo! Ghost!'

From his voice, Karuthiruman learned that it was the physician's son, Pinagapani. The minute he realized this, he wished that Pinagapani had broken his neck in the accident. The other man who had fallen from the horse was not hurt either. That was our old friend Kandanmaran. Unperturbed by the sudden turn of events, he sprang up from the ground.

Chapter 66: Madhuranthakan Vanishes

Despite falling down unexpectedly from the horse, Kandanmaran sprang up with his spear in his hand. He had already seen that the second man was crossing the river and was about to reach the opposite banks. Undoubtedly, it was Vandiya Devan.

The deep affection and friendship that he had felt for Vandiya Devan once upon a time had now transformed into deep loathing and resentment. He felt that Vandiya Devan had betrayed him on many counts, and he was the sole reason why their clan had to face so much hardships, disgrace, and shame.

Vandiya Devan stayed in Kadambur palace just for a night and had found out about their midnight conference, and had told many in the royal family about it. Not because he had any devotion for them, but to ingratiate himself into their confidence, only to betray them later. There was no doubt in his heart that Vandiya Devan had been helping the Pandya rebels right from the beginning. He was not sure whether he murdered Karikalan at the behest of Nandini or to further his own ambitions.

Kandanmaran also accepted that he too had been caught in Nandini's web of deceit and lust but he didn't kill anybody to please her!

More than all this, Kandanmaran was most incensed with Vandiya Devan for corrupting his innocent sister's heart. He had dreamt of setting her as the next empress of the kingdom. But thanks to Vandiya Devan, today she was roaming around hysterically claiming 'I have killed Karikalan.' He was determined not to allow this murderer to escape justice. If it were not possible to bring him back alive, it was better to kill the scoundrel and attain some measure of peace from it. This was Kandanmaran's state of mind when he started on this manhunt.

When his horse fell prey to Karuthiruman's trick, it broke its legs and would surely not survive the journey. Even Pinagapani's horse suffered the same fate. On the other side, Vandiya Devan was nearing the river bank. It would be impossible to catch him if he crossed the river successfully. So, it would be better if he could finish him once and for all, decided Kandanmaran.

These thoughts coursed through Kandanmaran's mind within a few seconds. And when he got up from his fall, he had his spear in his hand. He planted his legs firmly on the ground and aimed carefully at the man crossing the river, hurling his spear with all his strength.

The spear flew with a screeching sound through the air and hit Madhuranthakan on his back. Madhuranthakan fell from his horse into the river. His horse alone reached the shore, and with great difficulty climbed onto the river bank. Karuthiruman, who was watching all this from the tree, was horrified. He didn't think that the men would recover from falling headlong from their horses. And even if they did, he thought they would be maimed or gravely injured. He didn't imagine that one of the men would recover fast enough to throw a spear across the river and hit the prince.

Angered by the sudden turn of events, Karuthiruman sprang from the tree, crying aloud, and threw Kandanmaran to the ground with sudden strength. When Pinagapani sought to help Kandanmaran, he turned all his anger and frustration on the physician's son and plunged his dagger into his heart before running towards the rope bridge. The horses that were following Kandanmaran and Pinagapani were now approaching. They had seen what had happened to the men who had come ahead, and were already slowing their horses. They also noted one man running on the rope bridge.

Kandanmaran shouted at the approaching men, "Catch that prisoner! Catch the man running on the bridge!"

The men stopped their horses near the bridge and pursued Karuthiruman. Kandanmaran was in shock from having been felled to the ground again. He got up slowly and started following the men. Pinagapani, bleeding profusely got up and tried to get up and follow the men on the bridge. But soon, his steps faltered and his vision darkened, and he fell into the river unnoticed by the men ahead. He died with many unfulfilled ambitions and dark desires that were forever buried in the river.

After attacking Kandanmaran and injuring Pinagapani, Karuthiruman ran to the rope bridge. Halfway through the bridge, he noticed that the men on the horses had reached the mouth of the bridge. He immediately did something strange. He had the dagger that he had used on Pinagapani a short while ago. He sliced the ropes under the planks, and dropped the planks down the river. He did the same to other planks behind him, all the while steadying himself on the other side.

Kandanmaran's men, who were now running on the bridge, didn't notice Karuthiruman's handiwork. They fell into the river. Kandanmaran alone escaped when he noticed what had happened to his men, who were now trying to reach the other bank to continue their pursuit. Two of the men who had almost drowned, couldn't reach the other side. They somehow got hold of the floating planks and reached where Kandanmaran stood.

Kandanmaran first gave them a good tongue-lashing, and then realizing that they couldn't swim across the river, he bid them to collect the planks that were floating and used twigs and ropes that had fallen from the bridge to fashion a rudimentary raft. He used tree branches to propel this and cross the river and reach the other side.

There they met the men who had swum across and were waiting for them. They said that just as they were climbing onto the river bank, they heard two horses galloping away, and the man on the bridge had long since disappeared in the darkness. Since there was no point in pursuing the men on foot, they waited for the others.

Kandanmaran did not relish the idea of stopping his pursuit. He stood there taking stock of what had happened in the last few minutes. The man on the bridge must be the madman that Pinagapani was talking about. Tying the rope across the road was his handiwork. He must have done it to help Vandiya Devan escape, and had served as his lookout by waiting for them on the tree.

The man who fell prey to his spear must have been Vandiya Devan. There was no doubt about it. He thought he would be at peace if he could find his dead body and maybe take it all the way to Thanjavur!

Ah! At least I will gain the glory of killing a vicious enemy of the Chola kingdom!

Through Vandiya Devan's death, he hoped to wash the stain of disgrace that had clung to Sambuvarayar clan since the death of the prince. The very fact that Vandiya Devan had tried to escape proved his guilt and if that could be proven beyond doubt, his clan could escape the charge of treason.

Thinking thus, Kandanmaran went downstream, hoping to see Vandiya Devan's body floating by the banks. But he was disappointed. He and his men then walked long along the banks, trying to find his lifeless body floating in the water. Finally they came to a spot where the river water was falling into a valley as a water fall.

If Vandiya Devan's lifeless body had come all the way here, it might have fallen into the ravine below and would take many days before it emerged out of the water. Or it might disappear within the depths of the water. Even while he was thinking thus, he saw a black object floating and falling down the waterfall.

My God! That must be Vandiya Devan's body! Finally, this earth has been relieved of a scoundrel. May the Lord forgive his heinous sins... but no, they are too grave to forgive. He will bear the consequences of his sin, even in his next birth!

Be that as it may, Vandiya Devan is dead and gone and my quest is over. It's time to return to Thanjavur...

Aha! He didn't know that he was in for huge disappointment and shock when he reached Thanjavur. When he learns that it was not Vandiya Devan but Prince Madhuranthakan who he had killed through his spear, wouldn't the ground slip from under his feet?

Chapter 67: I Don't Desire This Earthly Kingdom

Once the procession of the noble chieftains passed them, going to the fort entrance, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi mobilized his men and started towards the garden house of Senthana Amuthan. Near the garden, he found Madhuranthakan's palanquin, with its bearers and guards waiting under the tree for their master to return. He then entered the garden and asked his men to search everywhere noiselessly. Then he went near the hut alone and put his ears to the door to hear what was happening inside. He could hear Poonguzhali and Senthana Amuthan's worried tones, and in between, he could also hear someone moaning with pain.

His men came back after searching the garden, and brought some things for his inspection. Nambi inspected them in the light emanating out of the door hinges. They belonged to Madhuranthakan. His prince's crown, gemstone aaram, ornate bracelet, and his silk upper cloth. Nambi examined them and his face reflected the satisfaction that he felt in his heart.

"Alright, you can stop searching. Gather all the men here and ask them to carry a weapon and be ready for anything," he told his men and then knocked the door.

"Who is that? What do you want?" asked Poonguzhali from inside.

"Devi, this is Azhwarkadiyan Nambi here! Please open the door immediately, I have some urgent work!"

Instead of opening the door, Poonguzhali came to the entrance and said, "What kind of urgent work would you have with us? We are devotees of Shiva, while you are a Veera Vaishnavan. You do know that the master of this house is unwell. Then why are you here that at night, disturbing us?"

“Yes, Poonguzhali, I am indeed a Veera Vaishnavan. And that’s why I am here to destroy my enemies and protect my friends. Open the door immediately, or else I will have to kick it down.”

“So, you are a great warrior, are you now? And you have come here to show your bravado, is it?” demanded Poonguzhali, opening the hut’s door with a bang which indicated how furious she was with them.

She cast an angry glance at the Nambi, and then saw the armed men behind him. She was startled. “Ayya, what is this? Who are these people? Are they with you? Did you bring them here?”

“Yes, they have come with me here on a royal errand. And if you hinder their work, you will be charged and punished,” warned Azhwarkadiyan.

“Royal errand and royal punishment! I am sick of hearing these words. I can’t leave this city fast enough and go back to Kodi Karai, where we can only hear the sea roaring. Anyway, please leave your men outside. You alone could come inside. I know not what royal errand you have in this hut. Amuthan is lying down, and is unwell. If he sees your men, he will get worried and his health will deteriorate!”

Azhwarkadiyan entered the hut and bolted the door behind him. And then he looked at Poonguzhali with great astonishment and said, “I am surprised. Since when did you become sick of royal affairs? What happened to your dream of marrying a prince and ascending the throne as his queen? If you were to fulfil this dream, then you cannot stay away from royal affairs!”

“Ayya Vaishnavarey! I have abandoned that dream. In these few days, I have realized the pain that the royalty undergoes, and how difficult it is to manage a kingdom. I am now determined to be at least ten paces away from royalty and royal affairs.

“Vaishnavarey! I have some good news for you. I have decided to marry my cousin, Senthana Amuthan. We sought the blessings of

Queen Sembiyanmadevi, who was here a short while ago. Once Amuthan recovers his health, we will go to Kodi Karai for good...”

“Aha, that’s a good decision indeed. Our azhwars have sung a verse where they say that I don’t want riches or fortune or this material world. I would rather be a fish in the pond where my lord’s temple stands...”

“Just like that even you wish to renounce this material world and go away to Kodi Karai and be with the fishes in the sea. But who knows, if your destiny demands that you must bear the crown of a kingdom and ascend the throne, there is nothing that you can do to stop that...” said Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

“Enough of your mocking! Tell me why are you here!”

“Ammani,^[34] have you lost your desire for this material world or do you perchance want to leave this world altogether? That’s what I wish to know!”

“What sort of question is this? Of course, we wish to live in this world. We just decided to get married today. Vaishnavarey, give us your blessings and pray that Amuthan recovers fast so that we can get married immediately.”

“I am ready to give my blessings and pray for his good health too, but my blessing and wishes will not go waste. If you both wish to live in this world, then tell me why you helped those who were escaping the underground prison,” he asked.

Poonguzhali acted surprised and asked, “What are you saying? We didn’t know anything. We didn’t help anyone escape...”

“Vandiya Devan, who stands accused of Karikalar’s murder, has escaped from the underground prison along with Karuthiruman, who was known as the ‘madman’. We tracked them all the way here. They seem to have taken two horses that were tied in the garden. I also noticed blood and many footsteps all around your garden

house. It looked as though many people had come here. The prime minister has some regard and sympathy for you both. That's why he sent me here. Or else if Vellar's soldiers had come here, they would be escorting you to the underground prison," said Azhwarkadiyan.

"Do convey our gratitude to the prime minister. We need just two days. By then Amuthan would recover, and we will go to Kodi Karai. Until then, please help us and keep these soldiers away from here," requested Poonguzhali.

"I can help you only if you tell me the truth. Tell me who came here apart you three?"

"You came here just now. And a few hours ago, Sembiyanmadevi and Prince Madhuranthakar came to check on Amuthan's health. There are soldiers to be seen everywhere in this city nowadays. How would we know who came here? Vaishnavarey, I can, however, give you a definite answer for the first question you asked. We didn't aid any prisoner to escape from here!"

"Is that true? Will you swear?"

"I swear, we didn't help anyone escape from here!"

"If that's true, then Vandiya Devan must be hiding here..." And even before he could finish that sentence, a painful moan emanated from under Senthan Amuthan's cot.

Chapter 68: A Prince for a Day

Hearing that sound, Azhwarkadiyan asked, “Aha! I knew it. Just like your Lord Shiva, his devotees too are up to their old tricks...” He tried to go near the cot.

Poonguzhali took out her dagger and said menacingly, “Vaishnavaney! You take great pleasure in abusing Lord Shiva. I will slay you right here. If you take one more step, you will be sent to Vaikundam!”

Senthan Amuthan got up from the cot and said, “Poonguzhali, put down your dagger. Lord Shiva’s greatness will not be diminished just because this Vaishnavan abuses Him. We will not achieve anything through falsehoods. Let’s seek his help instead. Remember! He, too, is Vandiya Devan’s friend!”

“There you go... After all, mere Shiva devotees can’t hope to deceive those who worship Lord Krishna... if we surrender ourselves completely to Him, He will protect us from all evil. Didn’t the Lord come all the way from Vaikundam just to save a mere elephant...”

“By the time your Lord comes here, your friend might leave this earthly plane,” said Poonguzhali and went towards the cot.

Under the cot, Vandiya Devan lay bleeding under a bundle of old clothes. They lifted him and set him carefully on the cot. He was unconscious, but was moaning steadily. That reassured his friends that he was still alive.

Vaani Ammai had boiled a few herbs which she doused with turmeric and came near the cot to treat his wounds. Senthan Amuthan and Azhwarkadiyan Nambi held Vandiya Devan’s legs and hands tightly, while Vaani Ammai applied the herbs on his wound, and Poonguzhali tied the bandage carefully. Groggy with pain, Vandiya Devan opened his eyes, moaning softly. When he saw

Azhwarkadiyan, he said, “Vaishnavaney! You have finally deceived me! You made me come here and then sent an assassin after me...” And he became senseless again.

Azhwarkadiyan looked awkwardly at Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali, worried that they might believe Vandiya Devan’s half-conscious words and think that he had indeed deceived him. But Poonguzhali’s smile indicated that she didn’t believe Vandiya Devan.

“Vaishnavarey, did you send Vandiya Devar here?” she asked.

“Yes, but I didn’t send anyone to kill him!”

“Alright, then why did you send him here?”

“I sent him here so that he could escape. There were two horses ready at the garden for him and his friend...”

“Then how did you find out that he didn’t escape? How did you know that he was here?”

“I saw someone else escape on the horses that I had kept for him. That’s why I suspected that he might be here!”

“Well, your Lord Vishnu plans one thing while Lord Shiva executes some other plan instead!”

“Ammani, what happened here? How did our friend get wounded?”

“Vaishnavarey, I know not why you sent him here. But if he had not come here on time, I would have been widowed even before I was married!”

When Poonguzhali said that, both Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and Senthana Amuthan asked, “What? What are you saying?” with great astonishment.

Poonguzhali turned towards Amuthan and said, “Yes, I didn’t tell you. There was someone trying to aim a short spear at you from the window. That’s when Vandiya Devan accosted him, and took the spear meant for you and saved your life...”

Tears gathered in Senthana Amuthan’s eyes and he said, “Ayyo, did my friend court this danger because of me?”

“So what? Didn’t you court many dangers to help him escape?” asked Poonguzhali.

“Ammani, it is indeed rare to repay one’s goodness with a good deed. Most often, it is sufficient if we don’t do any harm to those who are good to us. Vandiya Devan did indeed come here at the right time and save him. But what is that you were saying about being widowed? I didn’t understand!”

“Yes, Vaishnavarey. We decided today to get married and got the blessings of Sembiyanmadevi. And within a few hours, his life is endangered. Even I couldn’t have stopped that spear. If it had found its mark, what would be my fate? Wouldn’t I be a widow even before I wed?”

“Maha Vishnu’s grace will always be on you. Sembiyanmadevi’s blessings will not go waste. You will wed this righteous youth and live happy for long. But why would anyone want to kill this gentle young man? Did you see the man who aimed the spear?”

“Of course I did. It was that scoundrel, the physician’s son Pinagapani. The wretch who kidnapped and brought my aunt here just so that she could be killed. God knows what else will happen in this Chola Kingdom!”

“This is nothing. This kingdom will soon be fraught with wars, conflicts, and skirmishes. Fights are going to erupt between all the noble clans, and people are going to take sides and fight one another on the streets. Only Maha Vishnu, in His divine grace, has the power to avert this disaster and save us all...”

“Vaishnavarey, why do you say such words? Can't you say something positive?” asked Senthana Amuthan.

“Let the kingdom perish for all I care. Let's start for Kodi Karai immediately,” said Poonguzhali.

“We can leave immediately. But what about this friend of mine? What will we do about him?”

“You cannot save him. The soldiers are already searching for him everywhere, and soon they will be here too. I don't know what excuse I would give to my own men who are waiting outside.”

“Vaishnavarey, you are very intelligent. The prime minister himself depends on your intellect. Why can't you come up with an idea to save this Prince of Vallam? My cousin and I will be grateful to you, forever,” requested Poonguzhali.

“Devi, that's not so easy!”

“Ayya, you seem to be becoming more respectful towards me by the hour. Until yesterday, I was just the ‘boat girl,’ a few moments ago, you addressed me as ‘Ammani’ and now you call me ‘devi’. If you continue thus, you will soon call me ‘princess,’ I am sure...”

“Yes, Ammani. If you really wish to save this Prince of Vallam, there is just one way. This man who will wed you soon has to become a prince for a day. And if he is the ‘prince’ then undoubtedly, you are the ‘princess.’”

“Vaishnavarey, is this a joke? Why should I become a prince for a day?” asked Senthana Amuthan, reacting to Azhwarkadiyan's outrageous suggestion.

“I am going to tell you something that only I know... first let me show you something,” said Azhwarkadiyan and opened the bundle that he had brought inside.

Madhuranthakan's crown and jewels sparkled in the dim light of the lamps in the hut. Senthana Amuthan gaped and said, "Aha, these belong to Prince Madhuranthakan. We saw him wearing these just a few hours ago."

"Where did you find this?" asked Poonguzhali.

"I found them near the fence of the garden. I know more about these. While I was coming along the Vadavaru royal road, I saw two horses racing past me. They were the same horses that I had left here for Vandiya Devan and his friend who had escaped along with him... the madman. You know him too, don't you?" Nambi asked Senthana Amuthan.

"Yes, he is the madman who was forever telling people that he knew where the treasures of the Pandya kingdom are hidden!"

"Yes, him. One of the horses bore the madman and the other bore Prince Madhuranthakan. When I came here, my suspicions got confirmed."

"How strange! Why should Prince Madhuranthakan remove his jewels and leave with the madman?"

"I don't understand it, either. I am going to speak to the prime minister and mobilize men to go after them. But before that, I am afraid that a crisis might brew here..."

"What do you mean?"

"As we speak, the Pazhuvetarayars and their supporters and noble clans are at the fort entrance, being welcomed by Kodumbalur Vellar. The emperor had invited them to attend the council meeting, where the succession matters will be discussed.

But before they begin, the Pazhuvetarayars will demand 'Where is Madhuranthakan?' And when they learn that he has gone missing, they will charge Kodumbalur Vellar with his murder. Periya Vellar will

deny their accusation, but he will have no proof. This will spark a civil war that we are anticipating, and will embroil the entire kingdom in fratricidal strife,” said Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

“Let’s leave this place before all that happens...”

“That is impossible!”

“What are you saying then?”

“Let Senthana Amuthan wear this crown and jewels, and dress himself with this silk upper cloth. The elephant that brought Ponniyin Selvar is nearby. I can bring it here and let Senthana Amuthan mount it. I will instruct my men to shout ‘Victory to Madhuranthaka Devar,’ and walk around the elephant. Madhuranthakar’s palanquin is waiting nearby. We can take Vandiya Devan in that, while Poonguzhali devi walks beside it. Leave the rest to me, I will take care of it,” said Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

“What kind of mad idea is this?” asked Senthana Amuthan.

“Do you really think that no one will recognize him if he wore the crown?” asked Poonguzhali.

“On this dark night, who is going to look carefully at someone mounted on an elephant? If they are suspicious about something, only then they will observe carefully. Don’t worry, I will come along with you and escort you to the prime minister’s palace. This is the only way to save this Prince of Vallam!”

After arguing unsuccessfully with the Vaishnavan, Senthana Amuthan agreed to his suggestion with great hesitation.

Chapter 69: A Sword for a Sword

When the members of the Pazhuvur clan along with the Sambuvarayar clan neared the Thanjavur fort, it seemed as though an ocean had come there.

“Great Warrior! Slayer of Mara Pandyan. Victorious in 24 wars and bearer of 64 brave scars! The Treasurer of the Chola Kingdom, Periya Pazhuvetarayar, is here! Make way...” announced the herald, amidst the sound of drums and gongs.

Starting with Periya Pazhuvetarayar, the herald announced the arrival of all the noble chieftains who had arrived with him. In the same way, the heralds in the opposite camp announced the arrival of Thirukkoyalur Malayaman and Kodumbalur Vellar at the entrance of the fort.

When Pazhuvetarayar saw that Malayaman, Vellar, and Anirudhar were standing at the entrance, courtesy decreed that they, too, dismount from their horses and elephants. And Chinna Pazhuvetarayar felt that it was a slight to their honour, to make them dismount the steeds before entering. He thought that Vellar had done this deliberately. In the meanwhile, Vellar had taken on the onus of welcoming the Pazhuvur clan and had requested the others that he may be allowed to do the talking.

Anticipating that he might have to speak to some of the chieftains before they were allowed in, Vellar stood at the entrance. But instead of barring entry, he stood at the side and welcomed them.

“Welcome! Welcome! Kings, Chieftains, and Noblemen who carry the burden of this kingdom. Welcome to the fort! May your arrival bring auspicious tidings to the Chola clan and its people,” he said.

Incensed by his words, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar said, “Yes, our arrival will be auspicious indeed, and your departure will definitely do

good to the people!”

Hearing this, Vellar’s eyes reddened, and he growled his reply, “Ayya, the Kodumbalur clan has always set out on army campaigns in all four cardinal directions, for the glory of the Chola Kingdom. That’s what we live for. My own brother died on the Elangai battlefield. I myself was in Elangai until a few months ago, avenging my brother’s death. We don’t sit in one place and say that we are here to guard the kingdom’s treasure and the womenfolk in the anthappuram. If your arrival and my departure spells good for the kingdom, then so be it...”

The prime minister now intervened and said, “Noble Chieftains, there is indeed no doubt that your arrival here will do good to the kingdom. Everyone here has bled for this kingdom, and have sacrificed your young sons to win victories for the Chola Kingdom. The emperor and this kingdom need your support and strength in arms. The disagreements and conflicts that have erupted amongst you have distressed the emperor greatly. He has set aside his grief and sorrow of losing a valorous son like Aditya Karikalar, and has invited you here to settle the matters of succession. Kings and Noblemen! Allow me to place a humble request to you now. The emperor is beyond distressed by the death of Aditya Karikalar. And at such a moment, don’t add more grief to his heart through your disputes!”

The prime minister’s impassioned speech touched the hearts of the noblemen gathered there. They realized that now was not the time to display their enmity. They had to stand together and support the emperor.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar immediately asked, “Prime minister! We are ready to act as per the emperor’s wishes. When can we meet him? Do you think he can give us an audience tonight? We would like to know of his wishes directly from him!”

“Commander, you have placed a valid request, and I am sure the emperor will fulfil it. But as you know, the emperor’s physical and

emotional pain increases during the night. Moreover, before he could convey his decision to everyone here, he wishes to speak with Sembiyanmadevi and try to change her mind one last time. By the end of tomorrow, the emperor will invite you all for a council meeting. For tonight, he wishes you to stay within the fort. Those of you who have palaces within the fort, do stay there. And those for who don't, I would be happy to provide guest palaces for them and their entourage."

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar intervened and said, "Prime minister! We don't need any accommodation tonight. If the emperor is going to see us tomorrow night, then what's the point of entering the fort today? We are used to sleeping under the open skies..."

"Why would you want to sleep under the open skies when you have your own palace within the fort?"

"Commander Kalanthaka Kandar is probably afraid to come back to the fort..." commented Periya Vellar maliciously.

"Fear! How does it look? Is it black or white? Does it have horns or wings? Maybe Periya Vellar might know this, seeing that he has come back from Elangai abandoning our war campaign midway..." retorted Chinna Pazhuvetarayar viciously.

The prime minister looked helplessly at the warring chiefs and thought that it was futile to try and achieve peace amongst them. That's when Periya Pazhuvetarayar came forward. The rest of them respectfully made way for him.

"Thambi, Periya Vellar is of Pari Vallal's lineage^[35]. They will never go back on their promise. When they are assuring us their protection while inside the fort, why should we be worried?" asked Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

"Anna, we don't need neither the protection of nor any assurance from others. We have thirty thousand soldiers, and their swords and spears are protection enough for us. I was the commander of this

fort. And until I get that command back, I will not step into this fort..." said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar adamantly.

Periya Vellar looked at Periya Pazhuvetarayar and said, "Ayya, if the emperor gives an order to transfer the fort command, I am ready to do it!"

"Did he take control of the fort because of emperor's orders?" asked Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

"No, I took control of it through the strength of my arms," said Periya Vellar.

"Then, I will capture the fort back with my sword. Let's have it out right here..." said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. He would have unsheathed his sword right then, but his brother blocked his hands and said, "Thambi, now is not the time to lift your sword. Remember, the emperor invited us here for a reason."

"Anna, how can we trust him and enter this fort? What if he imprisons us once we are inside? After all, he captured my command by attacking us suddenly..."

"Didn't you trust him and leave our families inside the fort? You trusted him and left Prince Madhuranthakar inside..." Periya Pazhuvetarayar pointed out.

"I am now fearing the worst. If I learn that Madhuranthakar has been harmed, I will kill every single person who belongs to Kodumbalur clan..." shouted Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

Until then, Periya Vellar had been patiently listening to the Pazhuvur brothers debate their entry into the fort. But now he was getting incensed enough to give the former commander of the fort the war that he sought.

Thankfully, just then, their attention was diverted by someone's approach. The prime minister too had moved aside to talk to his

disciple Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, who was giving him some secret news. When he returned, he heard Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's fears about Prince Madhuranthakar's safety inside the fort and said, "Commander, why do you fear the prince's safety? No one will harm him. A few hours ago, the prince along with his mother left the fort to check on Senthana Amuthan's health... the man who the dowager queen is supporting through temple grants...." And before the prime minister could continue, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar interrupted him.

"Yes, both the mother and son came out of the fort but only the mother went back inside..." said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

"Aha! I wonder how you know that!" said the prime minister.

"Prime minister, are you under the impression that only you possess intelligent spies? Where is Prince Madhuranthakar? He has not come back to the fort yet?" demanded Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

The prime minister smiled at him. And at the same time, they could hear hails, "Victory to Prince Madhuranthakar!" near the fort entrance. Everyone looked at the procession that was coming near the fort entrance. An elephant was at the head of the procession with 'Prince Madhuranthakar' mounted on it. Behind the elephant, a veiled palanquin was following, and the guards around them were hailing the prince with great enthusiasm.

"Commander, there was some delay in the prince's return to the fort. His mother, the queen, wanted him to bring Senthana Amuthan to the fort. He is at death's door after falling from a horse. The queen wanted him brought inside the fort in the palanquin. The prince fulfilled the queen's wish and brought him in his own palanquin. He then mounted the elephant and returned to the fort. Either way, after he is crowned as the emperor, he would have to mount the royal elephant and meet his people. I suppose, he is rehearsing for that day!" said the prime minister.

Chapter 70: The Fort Command

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked at the elephant and the palanquin that were now entering the fort with great attention and then said, "This is quite strange."

"What is strange?" asked the prime minister.

"It's quite strange that the prince is entering the fort with so much commotion. He is a very diffident and shy, and abhors this kind of fanfare that would grab people's attention. And he always prefers to travel in the palanquin!"

"At some point, he should stop being shy. After all, he will soon ascend the throne."

"Has it been decided that the prince will ascend the throne? Who made this decision?"

"Why, the emperor has decided! If all the chieftains come to the council meeting and agree to this decision..."

"What's the point in emperor or us agreeing to this? It's the Kodumbalur forces that have to agree. I am surprised that Prince Madhuranthakar would want to go into a fort that is under their command with such fanfare..." saying this, he stepped forward as though he would follow the elephant.

But he changed his mind, turned towards his brother, and said, "Anna, I have no objection if you wish to enter the fort. But I cannot come. Until a few days ago, this fort was under my command. And unless I get it back, I will not step inside. You can meet the emperor and learn what he has decided. And until then, I will stay outside with our army. Moreover, Kandanmaran has gone pursuing Vandiya Devan, and I want to know what message he brings back. It is important that we find the prisoners, and also conduct a thorough

enquiry on how they escaped the underground prison and who helped them. Do forgive me...”

Periya Vellar tried to respond to that, but Periya Pazhuvetarayar intervened and said, “Commander, this fool’s brain is addled. Let him do whatever he wants! Come, let’s go inside...”

But the next day morning, when the emperor was apprised of these details, he insisted that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar must be a part of the council meeting.

“Noble lords! Though I trust each one of you, I had placed greater trust on Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. Why is he not here? If he is not present here, there is no point in discussing anything.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar then said, “My Lord, forgive me! My brother will assent to any decision that I agree with.”

“Lord Treasurer, we know that your brother is as devoted as Lakshman was to his brother Ram, but why didn’t he come? He has always attended all important council meetings and has given his counsel. I have never taken any decision without consulting him. Why didn’t he come?” demanded the emperor.

“My Lord, I can provide an explanation for that. Unfortunately, Kalanthaka Kandar has defied his brother’s commands, and is refusing to come inside. Periya Pazhuvetarayar tried his utmost to convince but he refused!”

“However, he did say that he would agree to any decision that is taken here in his absence,” said Parthibendran.

“Nonetheless, I want to know the precise reason why he refused to come here. Is he suspecting some foul play?” asked the emperor.

“Yes, indeed. He is suspicious about everything. He is also worried about Prince Madhuranthakan’s safety inside the fort. And

he is also suspicious about how Vandiya Devan could escape the underground prison.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar now adjusted his voice and said, “My Lord, there might be valid reasons for my brother’s suspicion but I will not comment about them here. I will, however, tell you why he is refusing to enter the fort. For many years, he commanded this fort. And today, it is controlled by Periya Vellar. Therefore he is refusing to step inside. His arrogance is indeed intolerable. And what can we do to stop it?”

“Why? We can do justice to him and right the wrong...” replied the emperor.

When the others heard the emperor, they stayed quiet for a while. The emperor continued, “Noble lords, my clan is glorious. But more than its glory in the war, it is our penchant for justice that we are known for. One of my ancestors granted justice to a cow when he learned that his son had killed its calf by riding a chariot over it. He didn’t hesitate to proclaim a death sentence against his son. Do you think I should be unlike my ancestors and not do justice? It was wrong of Periya Vellar to attack this fort and wrest the command from Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. I forgot my duty and didn’t right this wrong because of the tragic news of Karikalan’s death. Commander, it is my wish to transfer the command back to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.”

Periya Vellar sat there, immobile, and maintained a stony silence.

Thirukkovalur Malayaman came forward and said, “Ayya, I don’t think Chinna Pazhuvetarayar discharged his duties properly when he was the commander of this fort. Under his watch, an assassin was able to come inside the fort, all the way to the emperor’s chambers. And he managed to hurl a spear at you, which was thwarted by a mute, deaf woman. What if she had not been there? Can you imagine the consequences? The armoury of this fort has countless spears and swords to arm hundreds of soldiers. And yet, what was the use? What was the Velkarar army doing? If the commander had

discharged his duty properly, it wouldn't have come to this. I don't think it was wrong of Periya Vellar to capture the fort and its command."

"Uncle, indeed nothing can be done if the fates have willed it. Were you able to save your dear grandson's life? He died irrespective of all the efforts from your end," said the emperor.

"We were awaiting the arrival of Periya Pazhuvetarayar. And now that he is here, we can start our inquiry about the crown prince's murder," said Periya Vellar.

"Before we start the trial, it is important to establish who was responsible for Vandiya Devan's escape from the underground prison," said Parthibendran.

"My Lord, the prime minister will provide an explanation for this," said Periya Vellar.

"My friend Kandanmaran has assumed this responsibility and has gone in pursuit of the escaped prisoners," said Parthibendran.

During this conversation, there were two women in the room. One was the empress Vanamadevi and the other was Kundavai Devi. When she heard that Kandanmaran had gone in pursuit of Vandiya Devan, her face lost colour. And when the prime minister saw this, he said, "Pallava Kumara! Your friend Kandanmaran might be good in other matters, but I am not sure if there is any use in trusting him to bring back the escaped prisoners. He couldn't protect the crown prince while he was staying at their home in Kadambur... and how do you think he would catch the fleeing prisoners? I don't think so!" He looked directly at Kundavai when he said this.

"Also, I have heard that Kandanmaran and Vandiya Devan are good friends," said Periya Vellar.

"That was long ago, My Lord. We are not friends with anyone who seeks to betray and cause harm to the Chola clan," explained

Sambuvarayar.

“Let’s not discuss this now. Hasn’t the prime minister agreed to bring back Vandiya Devan? Can we discuss about giving the fort command back now to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar?” asked the emperor.

“If the emperor wishes it, then I am ready to do as he commands,” said Periya Vellar but his displeasure was evident from his voice.

“Kodumbalur Vellare! You are older than me and have more experience. I consider you as my father. I cannot command you. I can express my wish and you can take into consideration what others here think about this matter and act accordingly.”

“I don’t think we should give the command back to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. In my opinion, he has failed in his duty,” said Malayaman.

“What does the prime minister say?” queried the emperor.

“We can’t change the past. There are many practical difficulties if the command of the fort were to change hands now. My suggestion would be that we decide the succession matters first and then decide this later.”

“We cannot decide the succession matters without Chinna Pazhuvetarayar present, that’s for sure. Lord Treasurer, what do you say?”

“I agree with Malayaman. My brother has indeed failed in his duty as the fort commander. Therefore, there is no need to hand over the fort command to him,” said Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

Everyone gathered there knew how devoted the Pazhuvur brothers were to each other and to hear Periya Pazhuvetarayar talk thus about his brother surprised them all. But what was more surprising was the emperor’s defence of his former commander.

“Dhanadigari! Chinna Pazhuvetarayar did not fail in his duty. You and I failed to heed his warnings and remained careless. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar kept warning me about the Pandya rebels and their attempts to destroy our clan. He suspected that they were associated with someone from inside the fort, and felt that they were receiving support from someone inside the palace itself. He suggested that we bar the underground passage that connected my palace to the Lord Treasurer’s, and move the royal treasure to a secure location. Everyone here knows how devoted Kalanthaka Kandar is to his brother, but he started complaining about him to me. He told me that his brother is being deceived and that the Pandya rebels are visiting someone at his palace. He wanted his brother to vacate his palace and move away somewhere else... these were some of his ideas. But neither Dhanadigari nor I listened to him...”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar cleared his throat and said, “My Lord, you failed to say many other things just to save me from embarrassment. But I can’t keep quiet about them now. You didn’t wish to shame me in front of others, but I have to talk about it. My brother warned me several times about Nandini, the woman who had mesmerized me into marrying her. He told me that a Mandiravadi comes often to meet her, and that he was the leader of the Pandya rebels. I was deeply entranced by her beauty, and was blind to what was happening around me. I didn’t heed his warning. And yet, he did fail in his duty. If he knew for sure that Nandini was associated with the Pandya rebels, he should have killed her and that Mandiravadi as well. And if I had resisted, he should have killed me as well. That’s how he has failed in his duty....” said Periya Pazhuvetarayar and his words raised goosebumps in those gathered there.

Everyone fell silent when they realized the depth of pain and agony that was buried in his words.

“Dhanadigari! Your brother Chinna Pazhuvetarayar would have done this, but for me. It was I who stopped him. I told him not to show his face to me if he ever were to bring any complaints about you or your queen to me. I outright rejected his suggestion to remove

you from your palace and shift the Velkarar army there. I asked him why should I live like this, fearing attack from all directions. The state of my health and mind made me complacent, and I didn't want to live thus. Mama! Whatever misfortunes that my family and my clan have faced are not because of you or your brother. It was my own doing..."

When the emperor said this, tears streamed out of Periya Pazhuvetarayar's eyes and he said, "Yes, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is not at fault. The first time, when Vandiya Devan came to this fort, he warned me. He said that he met the Pazhuvur queen outside the fort, and had procured my signet ring from her. He suspected him to be allied with the Pandya rebels and believed that someone from my palace helped him escape the fort. But I didn't heed his words. And consequently, the prime minister and even your daughter were fooled by this young man, and they sent many important messages through him..."

Anirudhar intervened and said, "Even if I got fooled by Vandiya Devan, the princess is not someone who can be deceived so easily. While it is true that she sent him to Elangai, she also made sure that my disciple, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, went after him to keep an eye on his activities..."

"Be that as it may, even if you both were not fooled by this young man, it doesn't negate the fact that he did escape the underground prison now. Do you think this could have happened if Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was in command? They would have never escaped the prison or the fort. Commander, please call Chinna Pazhuvetarayar here and hand over the fort's command to him. If you wish to consider this as my command, then so be it," said the emperor sternly.

"As you command, My Lord. May we take your leave?" asked Periya Vellar. His voice betrayed the suppressed anger that he felt in his heart. He thought that the emperor was partial to the Pazhuvur brothers and would bear any transgression that they commit.

“Yes, you all can leave now. We can meet again once Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is back in the fort. I need to discuss the succession matter with the dowager queen. I need more time to do that.”

Before everybody left, Parthibendran said, “Ayya, I would like to remind the prime minister that he has undertaken the task of bringing back Vandiya Devan, who has betrayed us. Aditya Karikalar was not just the crown prince. He was also my close friend and I will not sit quiet and forget about his tragic death. We should hold a trial and punish those who killed him.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar cleared his throat, and everybody expected him to say something. But he changed his mind and withdrew with everybody else.

That very evening, the command of the fort was entrusted back to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. At first, he had many objections to it and many suspicions too. But upon Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s insistence, he agreed to take back the command. As soon as he took command, he evicted most of the Kodumbalur soldiers, barring a few, and brought his men to man the fort walls as before.

These changes brought much chaos and confusion to the kingdom and led to many conflicts and skirmishes between Pazhuvur and Kodumbalur soldiers, which spilled over to the common people as well. What began as a war of words soon became fist fights and the entire kingdom became one big fighting pit, where the factions supporting Madhuranthakar and Ponniyin Selvar fought with one another. For the next three days, the people who were divided over their loyalties took the kingdom to the brink of destruction as they fought amongst themselves.

Chapter 71: Born of the Womb

After Sundara Chola sent word multiple times to Sembiyanmadevi, the dowager queen came to see him. When he learnt that she was on her way, the emperor walked all the way to the entrance of the palace, ceremoniously greeted her and brought her to his throne room respectfully.

“Ayya, my heart is wounded by the tragedy that has overtaken our family. But amidst all this grief, I am happy to see that your health has improved. I will pray for your long life...” said Sembiyanmadevi.

“Mother... you are referring to the fact that I have regained the use of my legs. Yes, that satisfies me, indeed. For three years, I couldn't get up and pay my respects to you whenever you visited me. But today, I was able to walk all the way to the palace entrance and welcome you here. This is due to that mute and deaf woman, whose affection and love helped me gain my legs again. But I do not wish to live for long, so do not bless me with a long life! Instead, pray that I reach the abode of Shiva soon!”

“Your ancestors have either attained the warriors' heaven or have reached the abode of Shiva. And when the time comes you, too, will go there. Lord Shiva's bootha ganams^[36] will personally come and take you to His abode. But you have so much more to do in this earthly plane. And when the right time comes, you will find a seat beside your ancestors. Under your just rule, your people are living happily and with great prosperity. The onerous task of renovating the Shiva Temples all around the kingdom is progressing, thanks to you. That's why Shaivites, Vaishnavas, Buddhists and Jains are praying for your long life!”

“Mother, their prayers will only result in extending the grief that I now bear in my heart. I lost the most valorous son ever born in this

Chola kingdom. Why should I live anymore in this world? Why didn't I breathe my last before he died?"

"Ayya, of all the grief that one experiences in this world, grieving for one's child is the worst. But we cannot rewrite what fate had set in store for us. Krishna was an avatar of Maha Vishnu, the one who preserves this world. All through the war, he stood steadfast by his friend and companion Arjuna. But was he able to save the life of the warrior sons of Arjuna – Aravanan and Abhimanyu? And didn't Arjuna live even after losing such valorous sons? Didn't Krishna tell him that 'to save this world, you need to keep living'? The same advice will hold good for you, too."

"Mother, Abhimanyu died in the war and attained warrior's heaven!"

"Your son is no less than Abhimanyu. When he was twelve, he entered the battlefield for the first time and earned glories that no one had won in your lineage. At the age of eighteen, he beheaded Veera Pandyan and etched his name in history. Abhimanyu was indeed killed in the war by his enemies, who attacked him when he was unarmed and Karikalan was isolated by murderers and killed treasonously..."

"Mother, I do wish to learn how he was killed. If I know that, maybe I might find some peace..."

"Learning that will only increase your grief. His fate was written thus, and the ill omen that the comet brought vanished through his death. We lost a valorous son, and this kingdom a great warrior. An inquiry in his death will bring you no peace."

"Mother, unless we hold a formal inquiry, the suspicions and doubts will abound. I am particularly pained by the fact that the people are accusing Periya Pazhuvetarayar, our Lord Treasurer who bore the burden of this kingdom for so long..."

"Then, you could ask him about this and learn the truth..."

“Who can dare ask Periya Pazhuvetarayar about this? I don't have that courage. He is also consumed by grief and guilt. I know not how he became embroiled in all this, but unless he volunteers information on his own, no one can ask him about it.

“Mother, in Thakkolam War, do you remember... after the death of my uncle, when our forces lost heart and were withdrawing from the battlefield, it was Periya Pazhuvetarayar who rallied our soldiers and gave them the courage to stand against Kannara Devan! He turned a sure defeat into a glorious victory. If he had not done that, we would not have a kingdom to reign today. He earned 64 scars in that battle and yet was unfazed by his injuries. After that, I told him not to go to war again and made him the ‘Lord Treasurer’ of this kingdom.

“Such a man, who I respect as mine own father! Who would indeed dare to ask him the truth?”

“Then, is there any other way to learn the truth?”

“I thought I would question Vandiya Devan about it. They say that he was found near Karikalan's lifeless body. But now he, too, has escaped the underground prison and is missing. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar blames the prime minister for this and I do believe he has the right of it...”

Kundavai, who was silent until then, spoke out, “Father, the prime minister has also agreed to bring the escaped prisoners back...”

“Child, the prime minister has assumed many responsibilities and has not fulfilled them. Sambuvarayar's son has gone after them, and that is a cause of concern. Kandanmaran is a reckless soldier. And that too now, when his entire clan is accused of the crown prince's death, I fear that he might do something untoward...”

“Ayya, forget the past and look ahead to the future,” said Sembiyanmadevi.

“Mother, that’s why I invited you here. Help me with your wise counsel!”

“Ayya, you have the most intelligent ministers, courtiers, and noble lords with you who can give you wise counsel. What can this poor woman do for you? Even when my Lord Husband was alive and reigned in this kingdom, I did not intervene in royal affairs. Since his passing, I have immersed myself in my practices of worship. What counsel can I give you?”

“Devi, do not be annoyed with me. The women from our clan do not stay away from royal affairs. Look at my daughter here... No one in the kingdom can match her intellect!”

“Forgive me, ayya! but I was not born in the Chola clan. I am from Mazhavereyar clan.”

“It doesn’t matter what clan a woman belongs to. If she is intelligent, she will help them flourish. But some women are stubborn and adamant about having their way, and they pave way for destruction. Devi, would you want to belong to the first category or the second?”

When the emperor asked her thus, Sembiyanmadevi reacted as though she had stepped on fire. “Ayya, what are you saying? Why would the Chola clan get destroyed because of my stubbornness? What harm could I possibly do?” she asked, with tears streaming through her eyes.

“Devi, forgive me if my tone was harsh. The fact that I am alive and well, while my beloved son is dead and gone is tormenting me day and night. But do you know what is even more painful than that? This kingdom that was built by my ancestors might be destroyed during my time, and I would be alive to see it. Karikalan had built a golden palace in Kanchi for me and was inviting me to come there. But I didn’t go. I used my ill health as an excuse, but the real reason was the fact that I didn’t want people to think that I have lost faith in the Pazhuvur brothers and I was afraid of the consequences that

would come from that. Now, I feel that if I had perhaps gone to Kanchi, maybe my son might be alive today.”

“You are a powerful emperor. But even you cannot rewrite what’s written in one’s fate.”

“Yes, mother, I cannot rewrite fate. But I wish I had seen him alive at least once and known the grief that he bore in his heart. If you are wondering why I am saying all this to you... there is a reason for it. My ancestor Vijayalaya Chola and my grandsire Paranthakar bled to create this kingdom. And I cannot see it disintegrate during my time just because I want to fulfil my wishes. For some reason, the Pazhuvur brothers didn’t like Karikalan and sought to crown my brother and Gandaradhithar’s son as the next emperor. There is nothing wrong with their attempts to do so. After all, Madhuranthakan is the virtuous son of my uncle, whose piety and goodness are incomparable. And therefore, he has all rights to this ancient throne. To tell the truth, it was wrong of me to ascend the throne in the first place. At that time, I acceded to this because all the elders were advising me to do so. But if I had refused and installed Madhuranthakan as the emperor, I might probably have been spared all this grief and not have lost my dear son. I don’t want to see my kingdom destroyed due to fratricidal strife. And now, I seek your help to avoid this calamity!”

Sembiyanmadevi wiped the tears coursing through her eyes and said, “I do not agree with anything that you say. After my husband passed away, my brother-in-law and your father Aringzha Chola became the emperor. And after him, you ascended the throne. This is what your grandsire wished for. My Lord Husband became the emperor because he couldn’t refuse his father’s mandate, and didn’t wish to cause him any more grief. But his heart was not in ruling the kingdom. Instead, he wished to pray to Lord Shiva in peace. And during his rule, the kingdom did indeed shrink and many of our old enemies became active. When you became the emperor, you expanded the kingdom again and ensured that our enemies did not raise their heads again. One of the main reasons for your success

was the valorous deeds of your dear son Karikalan. We acknowledged his victories and made him the crown prince. How can you ask me to change what is already established, and give my assent to crown my son instead? Even if I agree, will the people agree?

“Ayya, you say that the kingdom will be destroyed by fratricidal strife but wouldn’t the same have occurred if we had set Karikalan aside and had crowned Madhuranthakan instead? Won’t the kingdom be destroyed then?”

“Yes, mother, that’s why I hesitated. I wanted to arrange things in a manner that would have pacified everyone. But before that, fate intervened and Karikalan lost his life. Mother, what should I do next? Please tell me. I cannot bear the burden of this kingdom anymore. I wish to hand it over to someone and fulfil Karikalan’s last wish. He has built a golden palace for me in Kanchi. I wish to retire there and spend my last days in peace. Tell me, who should I crown next? Arulmozhi is younger than Madhuranthakan. Kodumbalur Vellar and Malayaman are insisting that I crown Arulmozhi as the emperor. But this is against dharma, and I will not be a party to it. Nor should you support it. Mother, please help me. Please agree to Madhuranthakan’s ascension to the throne. Once I have your approval, I can convince Malayaman and Vellar and the rest of the kingdom as well.”

“Ayya, do not ask for my approval, because I cannot act against my husband’s wishes! However, I have decided not to intervene in any royal affair. Therefore, you are free to ask Madhuranthakan about this. And if he agrees, do as you please!”

“Yes, yes, we should talk to Madhuranthakan as well... Mother, we need your help there as well. Where is Madhuranthakan?” asked the emperor.

Sembiyanmadevi looked at him with strange emotions welling in her heart and said, “Where is Madhuranthakan? For the past three days, I have been asking this question, as well. Ayya, where is my

son? Can you ask the fort commander Chinna Pazhuvetarayar about his whereabouts?”

“Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, too, is asking the same question. He says that you conspired with the prime minister to make Madhuranthakan go missing! I will call them both here, with your permission,” said the emperor.

“Please do so! I will ask them myself,” said the queen.

Kundavai immediately went to the doorway and sent a message through the guards to bring both the men to the throne room. Within a few minutes, they arrived.

The emperor looked at Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and said, “Commander, Queen Sembiyanmadevi is asking the same question that you have been asking. She asks of us, ‘Where is my son?’ Please tell us what you know of this matter and tell us about your suspicions.”

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked at Sembiyanmadevi and said, “Devi, your piety and godliness are well known to all. And just as the people venerate you for your devotion, I have great respect for you. Therefore, please do not think that I am accusing you of anything.

“Everyone knows that you didn’t wish that your son should ascend the throne. For sure, no one here can love the prince more than yourself. And yet there are many mysterious things that I want answers for. That too, when the emperor has asked me to produce Madhuranthakar here, it becomes imperative that I bring my suspicions here.

“Three days ago, you went out of this fort along with your son, to visit Senthana Amuthan’s hut and enquire after his health. After some time, you returned alone to the fort. Later that night, I was standing near the fort entrance along with my brother, talking to Periya Vellar. When I was enquiring after the well-being of Madhuranthakar, an entourage of an elephant and palanquin with guards entered the fort.

The guards were enthusiastically hailing 'Madhuranthakar,' and that's when prime minister pointed out to me that the prince was atop the elephant. I had my suspicions about it even then.

"Later the fort command came back to me. Madhuranthakar would normally stay at my palace while inside the fort, and I assumed that he was there that night. But next day, I found that he didn't come to my palace. I asked everyone and searched everywhere only to find that he is missing, which is a baffling mystery because I saw him enter.

"Please forgive me for saying this. I fear that Queen Sembiyanmadevi and the prime minister conspired together and told Madhuranthakar something that distressed him so much that he has run away from the fort, and possibly from this kingdom. Again, if I am wrong, then please forgive me!"

Sembiyanmadevi, her voice breaking with emotion, said, "Commander, I swear by Lord Shiva, I didn't conspire with the prime minister. I didn't even speak to the prime minister about my son. It is true that I went to Senthana Amuthan's hut that evening. Madhuranthakan said he would come later, and that was the last time I saw him. For the past three days, I have been searching for him as well..."

"I accept your explanation, devi! Then the prime minister should explain this mystery!"

"What mystery?" asked the prime minister.

"The mysterious disappearance of Prince Madhuranthakar!"

"Commander, didn't you say that you searched everybody's palace in this fort?"

"Yes, except for your palace, I searched everywhere."

"Why did you spare my palace alone?"

“Out of respect, because you are the prime minister of this kingdom.”

“Aha! That means you haven’t discharged your duty properly. Nonetheless, I would like to say that I didn’t conspire with Sembiyanmadevi. Nor did she tell me anything about her son now. But there is one thing that I would like to reveal. The respectful Devi’s son, born of her womb, has been staying in my palace for the past three days, and is now waiting outside this chamber for an audience. If you wish, I can bring him inside.”

When the prime minister declared thus, everyone was shocked. The emperor said, “Prime minister! What is this? Devi’s son doesn’t need my permission to enter the throne room! Please bring him inside immediately!”

The prime minister went near the doorway and clapped his hands. In the next instant, Senthana Amuthan entered the throne room, followed by Azhwarkadiyan Nambi.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked at this and demanded, “Is this a joke?”

But he was confused when Sembiyanmadevi stretched her hands out with love and affection and cried, “My son!”

Senthana Amuthan said, “Mother, I am indeed fortunate that you chose to finally acknowledge me as your son. My prayers have finally been answered!” And he approached his mother.

The mother embraced her son, who would one day reign the kingdom as ‘Uthama Chola.’

Chapter 72: Race to Sacrifice

Historical inscriptions remember Sembiyanmadevi as the devoted life partner of Emperor Gandaradithar, and the mother who bore in her womb the emperor 'Madhuranthaka Devar Uttama Cholar.'

Mothers bear their children in their womb for nine months and deliver them to this world. Some women love children who are not born in their womb and raise them lovingly as their own. Sembiyanmadevi, for many years, had raised another woman's son as her own. And someone who probably knew this truth had written this inscription, perhaps!

When Uthama Cholar was five years old, Sembiyanmadevi happened to meet Vaani Ammai. The queen asked about her welfare and that of her son lovingly. But for some reason, Vaani was very reluctant and scared to talk about the son. At first, Sembiyanmadevi thought that there were other reasons for her reaction. And because Vaani was mute and deaf, it was difficult to communicate with her.

Since Vaani had been helpful to her in the past, the queen decided to help her too. She gave them grants and a garden hut so they could provide flowers to Thalikulathar temple, thus ensuring that they lived peacefully without having to struggle for their livelihood.

When she watched Senthana Amuthan gain knowledge and piety and grow up as a virtuous son, the queen's love for him grew as well. She also had a strange suspicion about him that she couldn't shake off. Try as she might, her suspicions grew every day, and with them the memory of the son who was 'born of her womb' was growing strong.

At last, she decided to ask Vaani Ammai about the past. She called her to the palace and questioned her privately. She wanted to know where Vaani had buried the stillborn child, as she wanted to

raise a memorial temple there. At first, Vaani hesitated to reply. But she finally broke down and told her the truth. The infant believed to be dead was actually alive, and it was Karuthiruman who told her this. Fearing the consequences of returning to the palace then, she had taken the infant along with her to Thirumuraikadi, along with Karuthiruman. There, she had lived with him for a few years, after which Karuthiruman went missing. That's when she decided to come back to Pazhaiarai.

When Sembiyanmadevi learned that Senthana Amuthan was indeed her son, she was thrilled, but also scared. Her natural instinct was to go to him and acknowledge him as her son and embrace him. But she sought to control that instinct, because she was afraid of the repercussions if the truth were revealed. She prayed hard to control her maternal instincts and attained realization that 'all children belong to the Lord!'

How does it matter if he grows in the palace or in a hut! This world is a 'maya' woven by the Lord to beguile us. What's more important are the lessons that we learn from our time here. My lord husband abhorred the material comforts of being born in the royal family, and lived a simple life whilst in the palace. That's probably why his son is living in the hut, serving the lord with flowers and songs.

Ever since Sembiyanmadevi learned the truth, she was doubly determined not to allow Madhuranthakan to ascend the throne. Her husband, Gandaradithar, had asked her to promise the same when she had confessed the truth, "Devi, in the eyes of our Lord, the son born of your womb and that of an orphaned woman are the same. Therefore, raise this child as your own. But he cannot ascend the Chola throne. If such a situation arises, stay firm and do not give in. Confess your truth to everyone..."

Sembiyanmadevi had long ago decided that she would fulfil this promise no matter what circumstances arose. But her husband had passed away without knowing that their own son was being raised as

Vaani's child. She often wondered what he might have said if he had learned that their son was growing up in a hut.

But she accepted the situation as God's will.

It is God's will that a deaf and mute woman's son should grow up in the palace, while an emperor's son be raised in a hut. I cannot acknowledge him now and bring him to the palace. This will only hurt Madhuranthakan's feelings...

It was her piety and devotion to Lord Shiva that allowed her remain unfazed and impartial despite knowing the truth. Yet, there were many moments when she couldn't forget the son that she gave birth to. But she suppressed her emotions with great difficulty.

Have you seen a flood that had been held back by a dam for long? When the barriers are removed, it overwhelms everyone. That's what happened to Sembiyanmadevi now.

When the prime minister said, 'Devi's son born of her womb,' the barriers in her heart broke. And within those few moments, she relived the experience of carrying her son in her womb, and her maternal instincts rose. She couldn't stop herself from crying out for her son and embracing him to her heart.

After a while, realization struck her, and she wondered about Amuthan's words when he had said, 'you have finally acknowledged me.' *What did that mean? Had he always known that I was his mother? Did he choose to stay away from me despite knowing this truth?*

Sembiyanmadevi pulled herself together with great difficulty and said, "Son, did you know that I was the wretch who had given birth to you? Were you angry with me for abandoning you? Is that why you never asked me about it?"

Hearing her, Senthana Amuthan replied emotionally, "Mother! I have known for a while that I was your child, born of your womb. I

was praying to my Lord, hoping that you would one day acknowledge me as your son. And I was trying to be worthy of such an honour. I was meditating at the feet of Lord Shiva to make me worthy enough so that you could call me your son one day. Even if you had not called me now, I would have come to you eventually. But I was waiting for the succession matters to be settled before I could claim you as my mother. That's the only claim that I am interested in.

“Mother, I was ready to sacrifice Poonguzhali, who had captured my heart. But thankfully, the Samudra Kumari changed her mind and agreed to marry me.

“Mother, three days ago, I faced death right after we sought your blessings. A worthy friend of mine saved me from that, and gave me a new lease of life. But I didn't express my gratitude to him properly for what he did. But today, I realized how much I owe him, because he made it possible for me to see this day, when you called me your son. This is enough for me. I do not seek anything else, or claim anything more. I do not wish for anybody else to know this truth, as it will only result in more confusion and chaos in the kingdom! Mother, please give us leave. I wish to go to Kodi Karai along with Poonguzhali.”

Senthan Amuthan's impassioned speech reduced Sembiyanmadevi into a puddle of tears. She embraced him again and said, “Child, you are indeed my son... you are the son of my dear husband Gandaradithan, who was blessed by Lord Shiva's grace!”

Sundara Chola, Kundavai, the prime minister, and Chinna Pazhuvetarayar were in shock. They understood the ramifications of the truth that had been revealed in that room and didn't know how to react.

Kundavai was the first to recover from this shock, and she said, “Father, do you understand now why Sembiyanmadevi was dead against Madhuranthakar ascending the throne?”

Sundar Chola said, “I understand now, but surely, she will not have any objection to crowning her true born son, now that the truth has been revealed?”

Hearing this, Sembiyanmadevi said with great agitation, “My Lord! Didn’t you hear what my son said just now? He doesn’t claim the crown. Nor does he want this news to spread beyond this room. He will repeat this again, for you to hear!”

“Yes, my Lord. There is enough confusion and chaos in this kingdom. I do not wish to cause any new confusion. Please give us leave! Please bless me and Poonguzhali, who has agreed to marry me. We wish to leave for Kodi Karai immediately... Poonguzhali! come here,” he called out.

Poonguzhali entered the room. And together, they sought the blessings of Sembiyanmadevi and the emperor and said, “Please give us leave... Mother! We would like to go to Kodi Karai immediately!”

Sembiyanmadevi took up their request and said, “My lord, please allow them to leave. I will go to Kodi Karai whenever I am able to and stay with them!”

Sundara Chola said, “That’s impossible. I will not give leave...”

The prime minister now intervened and said, “My Lord, we don’t have to decide anything now. Let them stay at my palace for a while. While Devi’s son has come back to us, unfortunately Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s son-in-law is still missing. We should wait until we get some definite news about this whereabouts. Until then, let this secret remain within the confines of these four walls!”

“But we will need to inform Arulmozhi about this,” said Kundavai.

Hearing this, Senthana Amuthan pleaded, “Please do not that. Don’t tell him!”

Finally, the emperor said, "Devi, you have finally gotten your true son back. I do not wish to part you from him so soon. Let him stay either in my palace or in the prime minister's palace for a while. After we have finally decided on the succession issue, we can think about sending them to Kodi Karai. Until then, apart from the people here, let nobody else know about this secret."

Chapter 73: Vanathi's Mischief

Prince Arulmozhivarman was worried and troubled by the conflicts that had sprung all over the kingdom, thanks to the confusion in the issue of succession. And when he tried to calm things down among the people, it had an adverse effect on them. They would immediately hail him as the next emperor!

Whereever the prince heard hailing calls like 'Defeat the Vellar!' he would go there to garner their support. But they, too, would immediately shift their support and start hailing, "Victory to Ponniyin Selvar! And may he be the next emperor!"

What was troubling the prince was that his efforts to change the people's mind were strengthening their resolve to instate him as the next emperor. And with Madhuranthakar missing for a few days, he was worried about the repercussions that his absence would bring. He knew that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was blaming Periya Vellar for his uncle's disappearance, and the prince had his own doubts about it. Periya Vellar and Malayaman were hell-bent on installing him as the next emperor. And it seemed as though the prime minister, too, had joined hands with him in this matter.

Could these people have hidden my uncle in some place? Or could they have caused harm to his life?!

Vellar and Malayaman, in turn, held the Pazhuvur brothers responsible for the death of his brother, Karikalan. They could have harmed prince Madhuranthakan in retaliation for the crown prince's death.

Aha! They will go ahead and act recklessly. But in the end, all accusations and slurs would land on my head!

The prince knew that today, the people hailed him and showered their love and affection on him. But public opinion was fickle, and

likely to change with the blink of an eye. The same people are very likely to blame him for harming his uncle to claim kingship. They might even suspect him for the murder of his own brother.

My God! Did Mandakini Devi save my life only so that I will be accused as a kin slayer?

He prayed to the soul of that devi, and beseeched her to save him once again from swirling accusations and conspiracy.

Devi, please save me from what could turn to be the worst accusation anyone can lay at my door!

The prince had read the dark history of the Elangai royal family and the way close kith and kin killed one another in their race to attain kingship. He was horrified by the fact that the same kind of accusation could be laid on his head. This made him anxious and distressed beyond words.

He didn't have anyone trustworthy around him to converse about all things that were troubling him. He felt as though everyone around him was conspiring against him. Some of them were truly against him, and would love to see him fail, while others thought that they were doing good but were making him responsible for more crimes committed by others.

In such a situation, the prince didn't know whom to believe and to whom he could talk confidentially. He couldn't even take his own sister into confidence and tell her about his inner turmoil. He felt that she, too, was involved in some conspiracy surrounding him.

And what was more... even her loving companion, Vanathi, too seemed secretly involved in something. She seemed to be hiding something and had been acting mysteriously.

When he saw Vanathi glancing around her warily and walking determinedly, he started following her. She went through long winding corridors, past many courtyards and rooms, and then took a

secret passage that seemed to lead to a secluded portion in the palace. The prince was now convinced that she was indeed going to the place where Madhuranthakar was being held captive. With each step, his curiosity and anger increased.

The secret passage led them to a palace where she finally entered a room and tried to bolt it shut behind her. The prince immediately sprang forward and wedged a foot in to stop her from closing the door. He held her hand tightly and said, “Vanathi, your tricks will not work on me. Who have you hidden here?”

But Vanathi didn’t get alarmed. Instead smiled at him and said, “Ayya, indeed my tricks have worked on you. if I had called you directly, you wouldn’t have come at all. Step inside and see who is hiding here!”

The prince stepped inside, expecting to see Madhuranthakar. But he was pleasantly surprised to see Vandiya Devan, who was unfortunately lying injured on the bed. When Vandiya Devan saw him enter, he immediately sat up on the bed, “Ayya, please come and grant me freedom from these women. I have been expecting you for the past two days!”

Ponniyin Selvar moved towards his friend, sat beside him, and said, “My friend, what is this? How did you come here? I thought that by now, you must be in Elangai. And I was thinking of joining you soon there!”

“Yes, ayya! I should have been in Elangai by now, searching for the Pandya treasures – the ancient crown and the Indra aaram. My plans were foiled when I saved Senthana Amuthan from Pinagapani, who was trying to kill him with a short spear. He instead turned the spear on me, piercing my chest, and I lost consciousness. When I regained my senses, I found myself here. Please help me escape from here, or else I will be accused for the death of my master and your dear brother, Karikalar!”

Vanathi intervened and said, "Ayya, what he says is not right. If he runs away from here, he will be accused. The charges against him will be considered true. Your sister, thinks that he should stay here until the truth is revealed!"

"She is right, my friend. If you try to escape now, this murder charge will be definitely laid on your head. And they might suspect that I too am complicit in this. Instead, I think it would best to clear your name once and for all. To start with, tell me what happened in Kadambur."

When Vandiya Devan narrated everything that he had witnessed on that fateful day, the prince couldn't decide who indeed could have killed his brother.

Chapter 74: I Claim the Crown

In the end, Vandiya Devan said, "Ayya, there is only man who can prove my innocence by telling the truth, and that is Periya Pazhuvetarayar. I think it was him who had come there while I was hiding in the music room, and rendered me unconscious. No one else could have come there. He must have suspected Nandini's character. That's why he came there dressed as the Kalamuga Saivar. Edupankari, who belonged to the same sect, must have aided him.

"But that great warrior didn't like me right from the time I first met him. And his dislike only increased with time... he is not going to come forward and reveal the truth just to save my life. If I happened to die accused of this charge, he would probably be happy.

"Therefore, my prince, please allow me to escape. If possible, I will go to Elangai and search for the Pandya treasures. Or else, lift your sword and kill me right here. But do not let me die publicly, being accused of killing my master who had great affection for me. Such a death would be shameful for me. I would rather that you cut me down or let this princess give me poison instead of medicine.

"She and your sister took pity on this orphan and brought me back from death's door. But I am not going to thank them for doing that."

Vanathi replied to Vandiya Devan, saying, "Listen to him, ayya! This great warrior doesn't want a warrior's death in the battlefield, and instead craves to be poisoned to death by women!"

"Prince, I can't bear the rebukes and reproaches that I have had to hear from both the women. Instead, I would rather die drinking poison from their hands!"

The prince had been listening to all this without paying much attention. He seemed to be thinking about something else very intently. He finally rose, saying, "Aha! I have decided. I will become the next emperor after my father. The people and soldiers of this kingdom want me to ascend the throne next. And I will fulfil their wishes! Do you know why? Just so that I can clear your name and clear you of this murder charge. If this will result in someone suspecting me of having a hand in this conspiracy, then so be it. I will turn it against these lords, and say that they invited my brother to Kadambur just to murder him. I can charge these lords for their treason and punish them accordingly. I will take the crown myself and become the next emperor. I will risk offending my father and sister rather than sending you back to prison bearing this murder charge!"

Vanathi listened to him with great enthusiasm and said, "What a pity that your sister was not here to hear to this declaration! Please tell this again in her presence!"

"I will say this in front of everyone and will also make it happen..."

Vandiya Devan, overcome with emotions by the prince's declaration, wiped his tears and said, "Ayya, if you have decided thus just to save this orphan, then this Chola kingdom is indeed fortunate. To tell the truth, Prince Madhuranthakar, as far as I know, doesn't deserve this throne. A man who travels in veiled palanquins like a woman, and a coward who tried to conspire against his kingdom, should not ascend the throne that had seated the glorious kings like Vijayalaya Chola and Paranthaka. It is indeed not surprising that the people of this kingdom didn't wish for him to rule them!"

"Maybe he realized this himself and has disappeared," said Vanathi.

"Yes, I am going to stop searching for him, and will proceed as decided to ascend the throne!"

Just then, Kundavai, who entered the room said, “Thambi, forget about it. You cannot ascend the throne. Remember, Vanathi has sworn an oath that she would not sit beside you on the throne. I will not watch you crown yourself as an emperor with another woman seated beside you!”

“Akka, all you need to do is to close your eyes at that moment. I can help you shut your eyes,” said Vanathi playfully.

The prince looked at his sister and said, “Akka, just because your friend has sworn such an oath, do you think it is fair that the kingdom should suffer? Our father wishes to retire to Kanchi and is adamant about it! And before leaving, he wants to crown the next emperor. Madhuranthaka Devar has disappeared. As things stand, it looks like that I cannot escape this responsibility. The entire kingdom has been plunged into chaos and confusion and we cannot allow it to fester any longer.”

“Thambi, I brought good news. Madhuranthaka Devar has come out of hiding. We are indeed fortunate that he has come back to us. It is only due to the blessings of our ancestors that such a thing has happened! You don’t have to worry about the kingdom. Even if he refuses, we should convince him to accept this kingdom and become the next emperor,” said Kundavai.

Kundavai’s enthusiasm and happiness surprised the others. Though the princess had always indicated that she would support Madhuranthakan’s ascension, they didn’t know that she was this happy about it.

Ponniyin Selvar overcame his surprise and asked, “Devi, where was he hiding, and how did he appear again?”

“He was with us all this time, and yet, we failed to recognize him. Thambi, no matter what you say, the prince born of Sembiyanmadevi’s womb is the rightful heir to the Chola throne. Do not dream of crowning yourself as the emperor.

“Do you know what happened four days ago? Our uncle was in grave danger when an assassin tried to kill him. And do you know who saved his life, almost died in that effort, and spared us the grief of another tragic death?” Kundavai asked, looking at Vandiya Devan. Her gaze which was filled with love, affection, sympathy, and respect, made him speechless.

Ponniyin Selvar was now extremely surprised. He said, “What is this, akka? I didn’t know about this! Nor did my friend say anything!”

“He wouldn’t have said anything, because he doesn’t know how much the Chola Kingdom owes him for saving the life of its heir.”

“Akka, don’t keep us in suspense anymore. Tell me in detail whatever has happened! And I want to know how Vandiya Devar could have saved Madhuranthakar from any danger. And where is our uncle now?”

“Ponniyin Selva, in a few minutes, he will be here. I have asked him to be brought here. You can learn the truth from him or from Poonguzhali, who witnessed everything.... There now, I can hear them coming.”

Yes, they could hear someone approaching. The door opened and four people came inside the room – Senthana Amuthan, Poonguzhali, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi, and the Prime Minister. Senthana Amuthan alone was dressed differently. On his head shone a prince’s crown, and he was dressed in silk and wore jewels befitting a prince.

Arulmozhiarman looked at them and asked, “Akka, you said that Madhuranthakar would be coming? Where is he?”

“Thambi, Madhuranthakar is right here, in front of you. He is the true born son of Sembianmadevi and our uncle by relation. For many years, he lived incognito as Senthana Amuthan. And thanks to the blessings of our ancestors, he has come back to us. Four days ago, his life was in grave danger. An attempt was made on his life,

which was foiled by Vandiya Devar who saved his life and performed great service for the Chola clan. The prime minister's disciple, Thirumalai, helped him and brought him inside the fort despite knowing that he is a Saivar..."

Nambi intervened and said, "Devi, I have no intention of helping this Saivar. I brought him inside the fort on the elephant because only then we could save the life of the Vallam prince and bring him in the palanquin!"

"Yes, yes! Thirumalai too did a great service to the kingdom. When he gave the prince's crown and jewels to Senthana Amuthan, he didn't know that he was bringing the real heir to the throne inside the fort... or maybe he did know the truth. I can't tell for sure! Be that as it may. The man who we believed to be Madhuranthakar is not our real uncle. Senthana Amuthan is the true born son of Sembiyanmadevi.

Fates had written it this way, and he was raised in a hut. But even then we were surprised to see him display the qualities that we cherish and value in our clan. Do you remember how he helped the Prince of Vallam escape from Thanjavur? And thambi, can we forget how he, along with Poonguzhali, took you to Nagapattinam and saved your life? After all these years, Sembiyanmadevi acknowledged him in front of everyone. And he, too, revealed that he was her son.

"Thambi, today is an auspicious day and I welcome him to our palace. No! No! I welcome him to his own palace. I invite him to our family, and request him to live with us. Though, it is only proper to celebrate this occasion with great pomp, unfortunately, now is not the time for that. I think it would do good if we keep this news amongst ourselves, or else it will lead to confusion.

"Chithappa^[37], Come here! You have come back to us after many years. Whenever my brothers come back from a victorious campaign, I welcome them thus, by applying the holy ash and vermilion in their forehead. Therefore, I will welcome you back in the

same manner,” saying thus, Kundavai applied sacred ash and vermilion on Senthan Amuthan’s forehead, following which Azhwarkadiyan Nambi and the Prime Minister hailed him thus, “Long live Madhuranthaka Devar!” “Long live the Virtuous Chola Prince!”

When Kundavai had started talking initially, the prince was overwhelmed by shock and surprise. He also thought that maybe this was a deliberate ruse by Kundavai, but not for long. Her impassioned speech was born out of real emotions that she was feeling in her heart. When the prince realized this, the emotions that Kundavai felt rose in his heart as well.

After Kundavai applied the thilakam^[38] on Senthan Amuthan’s forehead, the prince approached him and embraced him lovingly, saying, “Chithappa, you were dear to me even before I knew you were my uncle. I had also wished for a brother like you. I guess it is our blood bond that made me feel thus!”

Vandiya Devan now said, “Aha, I had my own doubts. I knew that somewhere, hidden within this Shiva devotee, there might be a royal prince. Or else will anyone help an orphan like me to escape? My dear prince, please help me escape this place again. I am sorry that I will be missing your coronation ceremony. But I am beyond happy to learn one thing. Not even Senthan Amuthan’s ascension to the throne gives me that much satisfaction. It is indeed very satisfying to see Poonguzhali Devi’s dream come true. Even she might not have expected that her dream would be realized so soon!”

Kundavai interrupted and said, “Ayya, if you can keep quiet and rest for a few more days, it would do good to you. If you wished to escape, you need to conserve your strength.”

Then she turned towards Arulmozhivarmar and said, “Thambi, this is the reason why our grandmother was dead against Madhuranthakar ascending the throne. Even we were not happy about that Madhuranthakar becoming the emperor. He didn’t have any qualities that made him worthy of our clan. Despite our grandmother’s efforts, his devotion for Shiva was farcical. He was

neither brave or valorous. And yet, we had somehow managed to accept the fact that he would be next emperor.

“But we don’t have to do any of that with this new Madhuranthakar. He is indeed the worthy son of our grandmother and the rightful heir. And it would be indeed satisfying to him ascend the throne. And that’s not all, I would very much love to see Poonguzhali become the queen of this realm. Prime minister, please make the arrangements for the coronation ceremony, without any delay!”

“Devi, Periya Pazhuvetarayar should now come forward and tell us what happened at Kadambur. And we also need to find out what happened to the other Madhuranthakar. Until then, we cannot think about the coronation ceremony!”

“I will speak to Periya Pazhuvetarayar. And it’s your responsibility to find the old Madhuranthakar.”

Senthan Amuthan then addressed Ponniyin Selvar and said, “Prince, you are calling me ‘chithappa’ respectfully. The others are addressing me as ‘prince.’ But I cannot call you as ‘my son’ or suddenly consider myself as the prince.

“I have a request to everybody here. I was incarcerated in the underground prison for helping Vandiya Devar escape. That’s when I learned the truth that was revealed here earlier today. The madman who was in the next cell said ‘the mute woman’s son is growing up in the palace while the royal child is being raised in the mute woman’s hut.’ That’s when I learned my real identity and also understood why Sembiyanmadevi loved me so much. My only wish was that she claims me as her son and that got fulfilled today. That’s it, I do not wish for anything else!”

“Prince, it doesn’t matter whether you wish for it or not. We need to act rightfully and justly...”

“Aha, do act rightfully and justly by all means. But I have already decided long back. Whenever Poonguzhali said ‘I will marry a prince and become the queen of the realm,’ and rejected my love because of this, I was tempted to tell her, ‘Woman, I am a prince. And tomorrow, if I so wished, this realm could become mine,’ but I didn’t. I prayed long and hard to Lord Shiva to remove any desire to rule the kingdom and become an emperor. I was ready to sacrifice my love for her, just to fulfil this determination. Thankfully, this Samudra Kumari changed her mind and gave up her worthless desire and agreed to marry this poor shiva devotee!”

Poonguzhali now intervened and said, “Ayya, what do you mean by worthless? I deserve to be the queen of the three worlds if I put my mind to it. But I gave it up and agreed to marry you and live a simple life!”

“Well said, Poonguzhali, and that alone makes you worthy to become the queen of this realm. You don’t have to give up on your dream anymore. Tell this groom of yours to agree to fulfil our wishes. Chithappa, the fact that you were determined to give up this throne, especially after knowing the truth, shows that you are a true son of Sembiyanmadevi. But now, we are requesting you earnestly to take this mantle. My brother requests the same, and my friend Vanathi will convince her uncle for this. Then why wouldn’t you agree to this?”

“Devi, you all want me to become the emperor. But do you know what the people of this kingdom wish for? You probably wouldn’t know, but I know because I have lived amongst them for many years. Everyone wishes for Ponniyin Selvar to ascend the throne next. Be it in the Pandya region or the Pallava regions, and even all the way to Elangai, everyone wants him to be emperor. I cannot swim against this tide of opinion. And even if I wish, how can I rule this kingdom?”

“Do you know how much hate the man you call as ‘old Madhuranthakar’ has earned? I know it. Will you make me a target

of such hate? Why would you do that to me? I haven't harmed any of you at all..."

Before anybody else could respond to that, Arulmozhivarmar said, "Let's stop discussing this. Before all of you came into this room, I announced that 'I would become the emperor,' and I am determined to fulfil that. I now know what my uncle wishes for! Let's not discuss this anymore!"

Chapter 75: Dangerous Consequences

That day, a confidential council meet was convened and Sundara Chola was on his throne. His queen Vanamadevi, the dowager queen Sembiyanmadevi, Princess Kundavai, and Princess Vanathi were also present. Standing a little way from them was Poonguzhali.

In the court, the Pazhuvur brothers, Malayaman, Periya Vellar, Parthibendra Pallavan, Prince Arulmozhi, and Senthana Amuthan – reborn as Prince Madhuranthakar – were also there. The prime minister and his disciple Azhwarkadiyan Nambi were also present.

The emperor looked at them for a while and said, “Has everyone arrived? I do not see the Kadambur ruler here!”

“Kandanmaran arrived just now. They both will arrive here soon.”

“Oh! Has Kandanmaran returned? What news does he bring? Did he manage to catch the escaped prisoners?”

“No, my Lord. He couldn’t get them. But he says that he has killed Vandiya Devan. But the second prisoner, the madman, apparently escaped.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar grunted in anger, looking like he wanted to say something, but he didn’t say anything.

The emperor said, “I know not what other dangerous consequences will occur due to my sins...Prime minister, you know what lies in my heart. I have called all the people whom I deeply respect and love here. Only you can articulate my opinions and thoughts clearly to them.”

“As you wish, my Lord,” said the prime minister. He turned around to face everyone in the court and said, “For many years, the emperor has borne a festering wound in his heart. His valorous son,

who can only be compared to Arjuna or Bheema, has died tragically. And the circumstances surrounding his death are still unknown. For the past three years, our emperor had not seen the prince. The prince was sending message after message, inviting him to come to Kanchi and stay at the golden palace, but the emperor didn't go.

"Here at Thanjavur, he was under the protection of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, and the kingdom was rife with rumours. He didn't wish to leave Thanjavur lest people misconstrue his actions to mean that he has lost confidence in the Pazhuvur brothers. And I have no qualms in revealing something that our emperor might not reveal. I hope the noble lords forgive me for saying this.

"For the past few years, our emperor has been struggling with his failing health. He lost the use of his legs which pained him a lot, but what was more painful for him was the conflicts that rose among the noble clans and chieftains.

"Each one of you fought against our enemies under the leadership of Rajadhithar during the Thakkolam War. When the prince fell dead, you stood there, rallied the forces, and turned a certain defeat into victory. You saved this Chola kingdom from utter destruction. You fought together as one army and captured the regions that we lost to the enemy.

"During the Sevoor war, you fought the Pandyas and brought their entire kingdom under our direct rule. Next, you vanquished the Elangai King Mahindan and made him run away from his own kingdom.

"All this could be accomplished only because you stood together united and worked for the good of the kingdom rather than your individual glories.

"All this changed in the past few years. For some reason, you have become divided into two factions. The emperor strived hard to unite both the factions, but his efforts didn't yield any results. When he learned that the issue of his succession caused this division

amongst you, he decided to consult everyone again to resolve the matter peacefully, though none of you brought this to him directly. He had planned to retire to Kanchi after resolving the matter amicably amongst you.

“He had decided that he would be succeeded by Prince Madhuranthakar and wanted Prince Karikalar to accept this decision. That’s why he wanted the crown prince to come to Thanjavur. But before any of this could be done, many tragic events took place.

“Truly, when the emperor heard that Karikalar had been invited to Kadambur, he was elated. He thought that through this, the conflicts and division would end amicably. He thought that if Karikalar were to wed Sambuvarayar’s daughter, you will unite once again and resolving the issue of succession would become easy.

“Many among you too had the same good intention, and that’s why Thirukkovalur Malayaman didn’t protest Karikalar’s decision to go to Kadambur. But all our dreams shattered in Kadambur, and the prince died tragically...”

“Are we going to inquire about his death or not? It would be better if you could make it clear now,” asked Malayaman.

“Yes, without learning about it, there is no point in discussing anything else,” agreed Periya Vellar.

“Noble Lords, the past can’t be changed. What’s the point of dwelling in it? It’s time to move ahead,” said the prime minister.

“How is this possible? The Chola clan is known for their righteousness and true justice. In this kingdom, even if a poor orphan loses his or her life, there is an inquiry about how it happened. And if someone is responsible for the death, they are brought to trial and justice is meted out to them. And here, we are talking about the crown prince, who would have succeeded our emperor. How can we not inquire about his death?”

Sundara Chola now sighed deeply and said, “Kodumbalur mama! Listen to me. No one here can be more grief-stricken or anguished about the death of Karikalan than myself. And yet, I do not wish to inquire after his death because I know for sure that no one here is responsible for it. I lost my son because of the sins I committed and I am ready to atone for it. Tell me what I should do!”

“My Lord, when you say this, it would appear as though you are trying to shield someone from facing justice. As things stand, various rumours are floating around about the prince’s death. It is important that the culprits, whoever they may be, are brought to justice and sentenced duly,” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar.

“Well said! If we fail to do this, the people will lose faith in justice,” said Parthibendra Pallavan.

“Noble Lords! Why is there so much discussion and counter discussion over this matter? Do forgive me if I am overstepping. The guilty party has already been punished. The man who had killed Aditya Karikalar and turned my sister into a raving lunatic has been punished. I have killed that scoundrel, Vandiya Devan. What more is there to inquire?” asked Kandanmaran.

Kandanmaran had arrived there when the prime minister was speaking, but no one had noticed his arrival, and when he spoke everyone turned around and looked at him. Periya Pazhuvetarayar murmured, “Fool! Woe to Kadambur Sambuvarayar for begetting such a son!”

Prime Minister Anirudhar now said, “Kandanmara! Did you look at who you killed properly? You pursued them during the night. Are you really sure you killed Vandiya Devan?”

“Prime minister, I know that you have no faith in my prowess. So what if it was dark? Do you think I will not know Vandiya Devan?”

“He, too, is a warrior. Didn’t he fight with you?”

“Yes, I knew that you would raise doubts about my bravery too. That’s why I came here to petition to the emperor. My Lord, I went in pursuit of two fugitives. One of them was a madman who was in our prison for many years. The other was Vandiya Devan. The madman tried to stall me from pursuing his friend who was crossing the river. But I overcame him, hurled my spear, and killed him. It must be Vandiya Devan who was crossing the river, I am sure of it.”

“Did you bring his lifeless body, by any chance?”

“If I had known that you would doubt me so, I would have searched for more time by the Vadavaru River, but that would mean missing this council meeting!”

“Yes, indeed, your absence would have been a big loss,” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar sarcastically.

“Thambi, why are you so hell-bent on catching Vandiya Devan? What’s he to you?” asked Periya Vellar.

“Are you really asking this question? The crown prince died tragically in our house. If I didn’t catch the real culprit, wouldn’t you suspect me and my father?”

“My boy, Kandanmara, no matter who suspects this, I have no doubts about it. I know how devoted your father is to me. Anyway, where is your father?”

“My Lord, I have to admit our shame. When I was telling my father that I had killed Vandiya Devan, my sister happened to hear it. And she turned hysterical and tried to kill me with her dagger. My father is trying to calm her down. He will be here shortly, but he did ask me to tell you that whatever is decided here, he would accept it!”

“Your sister was already saying that she killed Karikalan, was she not?” asked Malayaman.

“Yes, she was trying to save Vandiya Devan from the murder charge. She was not fully mad then. But now, her madness has peaked. Our clan is indeed unfortunate!”

“Kandanmara, you say with such assurance that Vandiya Devar killed Karikalan. Did you witness him commit this murder? Or did someone tell you?” asked the prime minister.

“Ayya, his actions revealed his guilt. He was found at the Pazhuvur queen’s anthappuram. Why would he go there if not to kill the prince? And if he is not guilty, why did he escape from the underground prison?” asked Kandanmaran.

“I would like to remind everyone here that the prime minister had accepted the responsibility of bringing back the prisoners who had escaped,” said Parthibendra Pallavan.

“But Kandanmaran didn’t bring back Vandiya Devan to face trial. Instead, he killed him and left his body to rot in the Vadavaru River!”

Just then, Kandanmaran’s father Sambuvarayar entered the room. His grave face was tinged with indescribable sorrow. Kandanmaran neared him and whispered, “How is she?”

Sambuvarayar replied loudly, “Still the same. I have asked your mother to take care of her.”

The emperor said, “Ayya, if you wish to be with your daughter now, then do so! We can postpone this council meeting for a later time.”

“No, my Lord! There is no use. I cannot console her. If that Vandiya Devan could somehow regain his life and come back, maybe that would help,” said Sambuvarayar, revealing the deep sorrow that weighed his heart.

The prime minister said, “Ayya, we know how grief-stricken you are due to the death of the prince in your house. The emperor knows

that you are in no way responsible for this tragedy. However, the kingdom is in turmoil and there are many rumours about his death that need to be put to rest. If we know for sure how his death occurred, it would help us. Do you know anything about this? Your son says that it was Vandiya Devan who killed the prince, what do you think?"

Sambuvarayar seemed to be in shock. He turned around, looked at everybody, and then saw Kandanmaran and said, "Yes, this fool said the same thing then too. But I didn't believe it then, nor do I believe it now. I listened to him and invited the prince to my palace only to earn disgrace and shame for my family and clan!"

The old man Malayaman intervened and said, "Sambuvarayarey, don't distress yourself. You invited my grandson with good intentions. And no one here is trying to blame you for his tragic death. That's why we are trying to learn the truth. If you can help us, it would be good!"

"How can I help? My son says one thing, while my daughter says something contrary to that. I don't know whom to believe. It's as though I have been blinded and abandoned in the woods. If you really need to know the truth, ask the Dhanadhigari, Periya Pazhuvetarayar. He is the reason for all this. It was he who brought Madhuranthaka Devar secretly to Kadambur. He asked me to wed my daughter to Madhuranthakar. That's when the dreaded Shani^[39] entered our life. Now I hear that Madhuranthakar has disappeared! After that, Pazhuvetarayar brought his queen to Kadambur and made me invite Karikalar to my palace. And then he left both of them and went away. Ask him why he went, and who he was planning to bring next? Ask him what happened to his queen and where she disappeared?"

Thus, Sambuvarayar gave vent to the grief and distress that he bore in his heart. Hearing this, the emperor intervened, "Enough! This is why I didn't want an enquiry about my son's death. But none of you would listen. I knew that this would give birth to new conflicts and divisions amongst you. Sambuvarayarey! I do not hold you

responsible for my son's death, even though he died in your own palace. That's why I asked the commander to release you from the prison immediately. My own sins are responsible for the death of my valourous son. No one else is responsible for it. You don't have to give me any explanation. Nor does Periya Pazhuvetarayar owe me one!"

Periya Pazhuvetarayar cleared his throat in his customary way and spoke loudly, "My Lord, forgive me, but I cannot be silent for long. I have to reveal the truth as I know it, and I cannot hide it anymore from everyone. I thought I would fulfil my oath without revealing the truth. I had long back taken an oath that if I cannot save the Chola royal clan from danger, then I would behead myself. I couldn't save Aditya Karikalan, therefore I have to sacrifice my life. But before that, I would like to reveal the truth as I know it, or else it will result in unwanted suspicions and accusations."

When Periya Pazhuvetarayar said this, there was silence in the room. Everyone's heart felt heavy laden with sorrow.

The emperor now said, "Mama^[40], why do you have to talk about all this? Will this bring back those who died? I know that you have not knowingly committed any treason. Therefore, let's forget what has occurred in the past and look to the future."

"No, I have to talk about the past because, only then you will know what kind of treason I was planning. It was Durga Devi who stopped me and opened my eyes. I owe her a sacrifice! Please, listen to what I have to say," said Periya Pazhuvetarayar.

After that, Periya Pazhuvetarayar recounted everything that had happened in the past three years, starting from meeting Nandini on the streets, and his subsequent lust for her beauty. He narrated how his brother had warned him about Nandini, which he had ignored. He also told how he started changing under Nandini's influence and how he started conspiring along with the other lords to install Madhuranthakar as the heir to the throne instead of Karikalan. He then confessed to taking Madhuranthakar to Kadambur in the veiled

palanquin, and to meeting his henchmen and loyal lords to hatch a plot against the emperor.

He said that the first germ of suspicion that he had about Nandini was due to Vandiya Devan. And through him, he started suspecting that she might be associated with the Pandya rebels who had sworn to avenge their dead king.

He also said that many times, when he tried to discern the truth, his lust for Nandini clouded his brains. Finally he spoke about the mishaps that befell him when he was traveling in Kollidam and how he escaped the flood waters only to learn about the Pandya rebels and their plans to assassinate Karikalan in Kadambur. After learning about this, he had dashed to Kadambur, intent on saving the prince. He went there incognito as a Kala Mugan and had entered Nandini's chambers through the music room. He had wanted to overhear the conversation between Nandini and Karikalan. But before he could do anything Karikalan fell dead. When he sprang forward to bear him, he was attacked by Nandini's men, and he finally woke up in the mountain cave in Pachai Malai.

"My lord, I have committed treason against your clan. I gave space to the Pandya rebels in mine own palace and allowed them to take your gold to conspire against you and your children. They had planned to assassinate you and your children on the same day. You were saved by a mute goddess, while Ponniyin Selvar was saved by an elephant. I tried to save Karikalan, and failed. I am solely responsible for his tragic death!

"Ayya, I will now fulfil the oath that I took in the shrine of Durga Parameshwari!" declared Periya Pazhuvetarayar, unsheathed his long sword and tried to use it on himself.

While the others watched him, shocked, Ponniyin Selvar who had been slowly nearing him step by step right from the time he started his confession, sprang forward and held his hand tightly.

“Ayya, please don’t. Chola emperors have been traditionally crowned by the strong hands of Pazhuvur lords. For my coronation, too, I would expect you to place the crown on my head. Until then, please be patient...” declared the prince and everyone was surprised to hear him say it.

Chapter 76: When Vadavaru Returned

In this long story, you might have noticed that many of the characters talk and behave in a certain way at first, and then say something that is contrary to their behaviour. You cannot fault the author for this, because human nature doesn't remain the same ever. It is mutable and changes according to circumstances.

It is, therefore, not surprising that people speak and behave in a certain manner one day and do something completely unexpected of them the very next day. When we introduced Periya Pazhuvetarayar to the audience, he was a powerful lord who led the conspiracy against the emperor. Today, he is remorseful of the past and is confessing publicly to his crimes and tries to behead himself.

Sambuvarayar burns down his own palace only to ensure that he and his clan were not accused of murdering Aditya Karikalan. He was also initially happy to accuse Vandiya Devan for Karikalan's murder, and used his son to that end. Now that the emperor had convinced him that he wouldn't be blamed for the murder and on learning the depth of affection that Manimegalai bore for Vandiya Devan, he spoke differently.

Prince Madhuranthakar was introduced at the beginning of this story hiding in a veiled palanquin, and we later led the readers to believe that he would ascend the throne as Uttama Cholan. We didn't reveal the secret earlier because it had to be revealed at the right time. The prime minister, who was privy to many secrets, had believed for long that Madhuranthakar should ascend the throne. That was because he didn't know the chronology of many events. Therefore, he thought that though the old Madhuranthakar was not the son of Gandaradithar, he was still the son of Sundara Chola, born to Mandakini. Therefore he, too, had to behave in a duplicitous manner.

In our entire story, Prince Arulmozhivarman, who was known for his honesty and integrity also behaved in a manner that was contrary to what he had been saying so long. Right from the time we met him, he is resolute about not wanting kingship. But he too had to bow down to circumstances and declare that he would be the next emperor.

Yes, the prince's words had a profound impact on those who had gathered there. First, they felt a measure of peace because the most nagging question about succession had been resolved. Even those who were against the prince knew that he was the worthiest successor to the Chola throne. And with the entire kingdom wishing that he ascends the throne, it would be a disaster if they went against the people's wishes. But despite knowing that, they didn't ask the prince to take the throne. Now, when the prince came forward and said that he would ascend the throne and that Periya Pazhuvetarayar should crown him, they felt a measure of peace and happiness, and felt that this was after all the right decision to take, and that they didn't have to worry about the kingdom anymore.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar looked at the prince and understood the meaning of his words. His eyes filled with tears, and his body trembled with emotion. He controlled his emotions with great difficulty and said, "My prince, Ponniyin Selva, your words have given me immense happiness. I wanted to request you to take the throne. But since I am a traitor to your clan, I didn't think I had the right to request. Your grandfather, Gandaradithar, gave clear instructions about the royal succession. He was adamant that after him, only his brother and his heirs should ascend the throne. The enmity that arose within our clans led us to defy that arrangement, and we tried to crown Madhuranthakar as the next emperor. Even your own father wanted to do that. I shudder to think what a big disaster it would have been if our plans had worked!

"Prince, only you have right to this ancient throne of the Cholas. When you were a young child, I held you in these very arms. When I saw the lines of kingship in your hands, I would proudly declare to

everyone that you would one day rule this world. I have narrated the miraculous story of River Kaveri saving your life numerous times proudly.

“In the past three years, love, lust, anger, and jealousy blinded my eyes and turned me a traitor. It is you who should ascend the throne, because you are the rightful heir. But I have lost the right to crown you as the emperor. These hands belong to a traitor now. The only thing left for me to do would be to sacrifice my life...”

“No! No! You cannot do that!” said many voices in the throne room.

Sundara Chola got emotional and said, “Mama, what is this you are saying? How can you do this? What this is treason that you are talking about? All that you did was attempt to crown my cousin and uncle’s son Madhuranthakan as the next heir. How can that be construed as treason? Gandaradithar’s son has more rights to ascend the throne than my own son. Even now, if you could allow me to reveal what lies in my heart...”

The prime minister intervened and said, “My Lord, the entire kingdom is united in their demand to see Ponniyin Selvar ascend the throne. Even Madhuranthaka Devar, who lived incognito for so long, wishes to see him take the throne. Now Ponniyin Selvar is also determined to listen to the people and become the next emperor. Therefore, it is not prudent to discuss any other alternative...”

“If any of you want to discuss an alternative, then I will not accept such an idea,” said Senthana Amuthan.

“My son is right. There is no need to think about an alternative...” said Sembiyanmadevi, agreeing with her son.

“Mother! There is no one here who will act against your wishes. We are in God’s hands and let him run our lives as he wishes. But I am objecting to Pazhuvur mama’s assertion that he has committed treason against us. How can an attempt to crown your son be

construed as treason? And he wishes to give up his life over that, which I cannot allow.”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar cleared his throat again and said, “Ayya, you do not know the dangerous consequences of my actions. If my plan had but succeeded. I wanted to give up my life without admitting it. I hesitated because I didn’t want to hurt my brother, who is single-minded in his devotion to this kingdom. My Lord, listen to the truth. The old Madhuranthakar, who we thought was the son of Gandaradithar, is in reality the son of our old enemy, Veera Pandyan!”

“What!” “No, it cannot be!” “What are you saying?” were some of the reactions from the people who heard this revelation.

“It might be hard to believe this. Even I might not have believed this if I had not heard it directly with mine own ears. My lord, I am forced to admit my shame again. The woman who I married three years ago, and whose beauty had enslaved me thus... she was Veera Pandyan’s daughter! I heard her tell this to Karikalan. She had married me and come to my palace to seek revenge, and to avenge the death of Veera Pandyan. She was biding her time for the past three years. She and her men, the Pandya Abathuthavigal^[41] had planned to instate Veera Pandyan’s son on the throne. It is only due to the mercy of Goddess Durga that we averted this disaster. The Goddess sent that Vandiya Devan just to open my eyes and see the reality. I wanted to learn many other things from him, but Sambuvarayar’s son killed him and threw him in the river! Fool!”

Everyone was shocked to hear Pazhuvetarayar talk thus. And Kandanmaran, incensed by his support to Vandiya Devan, asked, “Either way, that Vandiya Devan is associated with the Abathuuthavigal, what’s so wrong if I had killed him with my spear?”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar turned towards him angrily, but the prime minister interjected and said, “Ayya, he says that he has killed Vandiya Devan. But how do we know that it was indeed Vandiya Devan?”

Parthibendra Pallavan now said, "If Vadavaru River floods flows in the western direction, it might bring his body along... maybe then the truth will be revealed."

"Who knows, maybe the Vadavaru flood might return his body..." mused the prime minister.

Just as though he wished to prove the prime minister's words true, Vandiya Devan entered the throne room. His clothes were wet, as though he had indeed swum through the Vadavaru river. His unkempt looks and disoriented expression indeed gave the impression that he had been raised from death magically.

The prime minister looked at him in astonishment and exclaimed, "Aha, Vadavaru River has indeed returned and has brought the dead back to life!"

Now, we need to inform the readers how Vandiya Devan happened to come there in that state. After Ponniyin Selvar and Kundavai left him alone to recuperate, he felt depressed by his situation. The fact that he was an object of pity and sympathy troubled him greatly. He felt trapped in the palace and thought that it was worse than the underground prison. Even if he escaped the murder charges laid against him, thanks to the prince, people will always suspect him of murdering Karikalar. Kundavai might pity him, but it would be impossible to think of any other relationship between them. It was quite impossible for someone like him to marry the dear sister of the prince who will be crowned as the next emperor. The people around him will treat him as a servant who was forgiven despite his transgressions. The court, lords and commanders will disrespect him and look at him with disgust. And what's more, the royalty had its quirks. Today, the prince is his dear friend. But tomorrow, he might turn into his enemy.

Aha! If only I had followed the original plan, I would have reached Kodi Karai by now and maybe even Elangai. Who took those horses when I was attacked by Pinagapani? One was definitely the madman, Karuthiruman. Ah, he is not a madman, for sure. He is a

crafty strategist. Who could have gone with him? The old Madhuranthakar disappeared on the same day. Could he be the second man who fled on the horse that day? If people here know the truth about old Madhuranthakar, how will they react? The fact that Karuthiruman and old Madhuranthakar disappeared at the same time is significant. If they both manage to reach Elangai safely, then Pandya's son will attain his father's treasures. With the help of King Mahindan, they will raise an army to attack our forces... only I can stop them but I am trapped here...

Thinking thus, Vandiya Devan was pacing through the room. From time to time, he would stop by the only window that was in the room and look out of it eagerly. He was kept in a room on the upper levels of the palace that was secluded away from others. When he looked down, he could see the Vadavaru River flowing through. The palace walls met the outer walls of the fort. If he were to jump into the river, the waters will bear him out of the fort. The palace was situated near the river so it helped the women there to bathe in seclusion. But he didn't know how to reach the entrance of the bathing area. Maybe the womenfolk might know, but he couldn't ask anyone... While he stood thinking about ways and means to escape, he saw something that shocked him.

The adjoining palace grounds could also be seen from his window. There, he spotted a woman running with her hair dishevelled and matted.

Aha! Isn't that Periya Pazhuvetarayar's palace? Yes, it is. But who is this woman who is running across it? My God! Is that Manimegalai? What has happened to her? Why is she running like this?

Behind her, he could see a few women and an older lady who looked like her mother. But they were trailing behind her, and Manimegalai was now scaling the wall with the help of a nearby tree and had climbed to the top. In her hand, he could see a dagger that gleamed in the sunlight!

My god! What is she planning to do?

Even before he could finish that thought, she plunged headlong into the river. At this, he couldn't help but remember the time when he and Karikalan had gone to rescue the women from the wounded tiger. He remembered Manimegalai's disappointment when Karikalan had stopped him from rescuing her and had instead sent him to Nandini. He could not watch this anymore, so he ran outside the room, climbed onto the balcony, and jumped into the river.

After plunging deep into the river, he surfaced and looked around. Near to where he had jumped, some steps led into the palace. At a distance, he could see Manimegalai floating. And the flowing waters brought her towards him. He moved closer to the palace steps and waited for her to come to him.

Aha! Is she alive? Ayyo! Will I be unfortunate enough to bear the lifeless body of another person who had loved me? My god, this girl loved me so much.

He could almost hear the sad love song that she had sung in Veera Narayana lake that day, and her voice floated through the waters and gave him indescribable grief.

He swam towards her floating body and lifted her in his arms.

Dear Gods! Please save this girl's life. If you do, I will visit every single temple in Thanjavur and prostrate myself at their shrines. I will be eternally grateful and fall at the feet of all the gods, Vishnu, Shivan, Durga, Ayyanar... this innocent girl knows no guile. Please save her life...

Praying to all the gods, Vandiya Devan carried Manimegalai on the steps. He was gasping for each breath. He had lost a lot of blood when Pinagapani attacked him, and he couldn't carry the heavy burden of Manimegalai's body. Finding it impossible to carry her any further, he placed her on the top of the steps and tried to revive her. He could see that she was alive, but barely. He didn't have the

energy to revive her. He needed another woman to help her. He thought of going to the palace and finding someone to help her.

He went inside the palace and found the main door closed. He threw his body on the door and opened it by force. The door opened into a narrow corridor, which seemed deserted. There was no one about. He shouted, "Is there no one here? Is there no one to save a woman?"

He then started running in desperation and reached a mandapam which was guarded by two soldiers. They tried to stop him, but he tossed them aside and entered the room. He was astonished to see the emperor sitting on his throne. And thankfully, he saw Poonguzhali there. He then cried, "Poonguzhali, Manimegalai fell into the river, please help her!"

Chapter 77: The Giant Tree Falls

The entrance door that Vandiya Devan had used was generally used by the palace women to enter the throne room. Therefore, he found himself among the women, and the first person that he saw there was Poonguzhali. When he told her about Manimegalai, Kundavai and Vanathi, who were nearby, heard him, and they immediately went out of the corridor. They followed his wet footsteps to trace his way and reach Manimegalai.

The rest of the people in the throne room didn't really hear him. They just heard him cry 'help,' while some others couldn't even discern that. Some really thought that he had regained his life by some magic and had entered the room. It seemed too much of a coincidence that he made an entrance right after the prime minister said, 'Vadavaru might return his body...'

Needless to say, his wet appearance gave them that illusion. But the illusion broke when palace guards came after him and held him, saying, "My Lord, this madman came running through the corridor. And when we tried to stop him, he threw us down."

And they tried to drag him away.

My god! This Vandiya Devan surely has nine lives! Looks like he can escape any kind of dangerous situation...

Thus thought Parthibendra Pallavan. His anger knew no bounds. He instantly sprang towards him.

It was obvious that he came here without really knowing where he was going. But I will not allow him to escape again.

And without even considering the fact that he was in the presence of the emperor, he held Vandiya Devan's shoulder and brought him forward roughly.

“He is not a madman, he is a murderer. The traitorous scoundrel who killed Aditya Karikalar,” he said, and signalled the guards to withdraw.

Kandanmaran too rushed near Vandiya Devan and held him by his other shoulder. And they both now brought him near the emperor’s throne.

The emperor looked at Vandiya Devan with pity and said, “Are you really saying that this boy killed my son? I cannot believe it. This is the same boy who came here bearing Karikalan’s message.”

“Yes, ayya! He brought the crown prince’s message earlier. He also met Nandini Devi and spoke to her secretly. And he is also the same boy who escaped this fort. And now he has escaped our underground prison...” said Chinna Pazhuvetarayar

“It was he who stabbed me in the back and left me for dead,” added Kandanmaran.

The prime minister interjected and said, “Didn’t you say a while ago that you aimed at his back and killed him with your spear?”

“Yes, I did, but I didn’t know that you would revive him and bring him back here!”

Ponniyin Selvar, until then, had been sitting still and trying to control his anger. He thought that Vandiya Devan had tried to escape yet again. And since he didn’t know to swim well enough, he had ended up back at the palace. And without knowing where to go, had inadvertently entered the throne room. When he heard Kandanmaran’s words, he got up and neared his father, and with great dignity, said, “Father, this prince of Vallam is my dear friend. I owe my life to him. He saved me from many great dangers in Elangai. I am glad that he is back with us, alive. If anybody dares to accuse him, then they are directly accusing me, as well!”

His manner and tone of voice made everyone pause in their tracks.

The prime minister then said, "Prince, think carefully. Kandanmaran claimed earlier that he killed Vandiya Devar, but he has now appeared here somehow. Either way, he has been charged with murder. Therefore it is only prudent that we enquire about his role in Karikalan's death and reveal the truth..."

Parthibendran added, "Yes, ayya. You will ascend the throne tomorrow and you have the right to punish or forgive anybody. But it is not right to do away with an enquiry. It will give rise to suspicions and doubts..."

Kandanmaran also said, "Prince, you should also think about one thing. There is a rumour going about that says that you sent this Vandiya Devan to kill your brother so that you can ascend the throne. Your actions should not make such rumours easy to believe..."

Kandanmaran's words had a profound impact on the people there. They were shocked and outraged by its intent. Sambuvarayar recovered fast from his shock, went near his son, and slapped him hard, saying, "Fool! You will be the reason for our destruction. Truly, I have never seen anyone spout more nonsense than, you do!"

Kandanmaran looked at his father with bloodshot eyes and his lips were trembling. In the next instant, we don't know what he might have done, but Periya Pazhuvetarayar came near Sambuvarayar and held him back from attacking his son.

"Sambuvarayarey, your son has atoned for all the stupid things he did so far. He has indeed performed great service for the Chola clan. And when you know about it, you will be proud of your son. Forgive his foolish actions..." said Periya Pazhuvetarayar, and moved Sambuvarayar away from his son.

Then he turned towards Kandanmaran and said, “You said that you hurled your spear on Vandiya Devan while he was crossing the river. Are you sure it was really him that you saw?”

The prime minister intervened and said, “Ayya, there is something that my disciple has to say about this matter!”

“My Lords, I would like to confess a truth here. This Prince of Vallam did not flee on the horse in the first place. He saved his friend, the true Madhuranthakar, from an assassin’s spear and was wounded in that effort. I brought him inside the fort, and he has been here for the past four days. So Kandanmaran couldn’t have killed him with his spear!”

Periya Pazhuvetarayar turned towards Sambuvarayar and said, “I thought the same. Sambuvarayarey, do forgive your son’s foolish actions. I think the man he killed with his spear is Veera Pandyan’s son. The old Madhuranthakar disappeared around the same time, and I think he is the one who fled on the horse that day. God is indeed great to have saved this kingdom from disaster!”

Even before the shock caused by his words could wear off, he addressed the emperor.

“My Lord, I request that you listen to these last words of mine. The ill-fated comet that appeared in our skies has claimed its victim, and the great valorous Karikalar died. But I have great hopes for our kingdom, which was built by your ancestors and mine. It will grow, thrive, and prosper, and will remain etched in history for long. That’s why the gods have saved us from a big disaster through this young man, Vandiya Devan.

“Thanks to him, I realized the truth of my situation and the web of deceit that Nandini had woven around me. When we met at the Kadambur palace, this young man came there by chance. That day, for the first time, I felt shameful that I had to hide something from a boy like him. Later, my brother told me that he had met Nandini outside the fort and that she had helped him escape as well. This

made me question many things around me, and my suspicions about her activities grew.

“But sometimes, I would be drawn into the web of love that she had skilfully woven to veil my mind. Despite her efforts to beguile my senses, my goddess Durga tried to warn me many times and tried to draw me back into the light. In the end, it was due to her grace that I happened to hear the conversation between the Abathuuthavigal. And if I had not heard it with mine own ears, I wouldn’t have believed it.

“When I finally realized that I was being lied to and deceived in the worst possible way, your daughter, Kundavai Devi, confused me even more. She said that Nandini was her sister and asked me not to harm her. And I wondered if she, too, had been deceived.

“That’s why I disguised myself as a Kala Mugan and went to Kadambur. Listen to my shame! I had also become the leader of Kala Mugan sect. Nandini had also planted another poisonous seed in my mind. She said that I should seize the throne of Cholas and become the emperor myself. Our plan was to crown Madhuranthakar as the emperor. And after a few years, we would drive him away and I would become the emperor. The Kala Mugars too approved of this plan, and were egging me towards it.

“Edupankari, who was a servant in Kadambur palace, was one of the Abathuuthavigal who was spying for them. And he also belonged to the Kala Muga sect. I threatened him and learned that the Abathuuthavigal were waiting in the hunters’ chambers that adjoined Nandini’s room. When I learned that Karikalar had gone to Nandini’s room and that Manimegalai and Vandiya Devan were also hiding there, I wanted to overhear their conversation and learn the truth about Nandini.

“There was a secret way to enter Nandini’s chambers through the music room. I reached there at the right time, because I heard her tell Karikalar who her father was, and also learned the deadly plot they had hatched to avenge the death of Veera Pandyan. I also

learned that Karikalar was honourable and noble in his character with nary a blemish. I tried to foil their plans but failed to win over fates. Karikalar fell dead, in front of my eyes...”

Confessing thus, Periya Pazhuvetarayar hid his face with his hands and sobbed piteously. No one dared to speak a word as they watched the old man break down to pieces. He valiantly tried to control his grief and removed his hands from his face, saying, “The fates claimed Karikalar’s life. But thankfully, Ponniyin Selvar escaped a great danger, thanks to Goddess Durga’s grace. My Lord, Prime Minister and friends, please support Ponniyin Selvar’s ascension. This kingdom will indeed achieve greatness under his rule!”

The prime minister said, “Ayya, your words will indeed come true. We were afraid that the prince himself might be against this decision. But thankfully, he has agreed to ascend the throne. But you didn’t tell us how Karikalar died?”

“Why do you ask that? No matter whose hand killed him, it was the fates that claimed his life,” said the old man, his voice trembling in sorrow.

“If we do not know that, then the charges against this young man will remain, and we would be forced to punish him for the prince’s death!”

“Aha, who dares to blame him thus?”

“It is Kandanmaran and Parthibendran who are accusing him of this!”

“Aha! Utter fools! Kandanmara! Parthibendra! Why do you accuse this young man for the prince’s murder?”

The prime minister answered his question and said, “This young man was hiding in Nandini’s chambers. Manimegalai was also hiding there, and she claims that it was she who had killed Karikalar. But there was no blood stain on the dagger that she carried. It was

obvious that she had said that to save Vandiya Devan from this accusation. She could have seen Vandiya Devan kill the prince from where he was hidden.”

“If Manimegalai didn’t kill the prince, then how could Vandiya Devan have killed him? With what weapon?”

“He killed him with this twisted dagger that is still stained with the prince’s blood,” said Parthibendran, and took the twisted dagger that he had in his possession. After Vandiya Devan lost consciousness at Kadambur, Parthibendran had taken the dagger in his possession as proof of Vandiya Devan’s crime.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar turned towards him and said, “Here, give that dagger to me...” And he took the dagger in his hand. He looked at it carefully and murmured, “Aha! This is Edupankari’s dagger!

“Kandanmara! Parthibendra! We should go around this Vandiya Devan three times and bow to him. You both were beguiled and entranced by that she-demon, just like me. Only Vandiya Devan escaped her web of seduction. He did not use this dagger and kill the prince.”

“How are you saying this with such certainty?” asked the prime minister.

“Yes, I can say this for certain, because I knew who hurled this dagger and killed the prince!”

“Who? Who?”

“Yes, yes, I need to reveal that. If I didn’t do that, your suspicions and doubts will not be erased. Listen to me! This boy was hiding in the music room. I came down the stairs and saw him hiding. I was worried that he might make a sound, so I held his neck in a stranglehold and made him faint. He definitely would not have known who had killed Karikalar.”

“Who? Who killed the prince?”

“It was I who took that dagger from Edupankari and it was I who hurled this dagger. Yes, this right hand, that coronates the Chola emperor, hurled this dagger. Not on the prince, but on Nandini. I had wanted to end the life of that she-demon who had deceived and betrayed me... but I missed my mark and the dagger hit the prince!”

People exclaimed “Ayyo! Aha!” when they heard the old man’s confession.

“The hundred years of service that we did for the Chola clan has been erased due to my actions. I know not how I will redeem our clan from this disgrace!”

“Anna! I will erase the disgrace!” growled Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. He sprang near his brother after unsheathing his long sword.

“We both took an oath to avenge those who betray the Chola clan. I will fulfil this oath and remove this disgrace from our clan,” shouted Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, lifting his sword.

“No! No! Please don’t shed blood here,” exclaimed Sundara Chola.

Prince Arulmozhivarmar and the prime minister rushed near Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and held his hands back. Periya Pazhuvetarayar looked at his brother and said, “Thambi, I myself will erase this disgrace to our clan. I will not leave this task to you. I don’t want you to be known as the ‘one who killed his brother’. Here, let me fulfil my oath to Goddess Durga!”

And within the blink of an eye, used the twisted dagger to strike himself in the chest. Earlier, after he had declared that he wanted to kill himself, he had sheathed his long sword which led people to believe that he had dropped the idea. Nobody expected him to use the twisted dagger that he took from Parthibendran on himself.

The prince, who was holding Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, sprang towards him saying, “No, don’t!”

But it was too late. Periya Pazhuvetarayar had fulfilled his oath, and he fell down like a giant tree. Some rushed towards him while the others ran towards the emperor, who too had fainted on his throne.

The council meeting ended thus.

That night, many came to meet Periya Pazhuvetarayar while he breathed his last. The emperor, Prince Arulmozhivarmar, Princess Kundavai, and the prime minister came to meet him. They didn’t talk about anything that had happened in the past three years and instead spoke about the glorious deeds of the old man and the great service that he had performed for the kingdom. They spoke proudly about how he turned a sure defeat at Thakkolam into a glorious victory through his brave deeds, and how he rallied the chola forces to fight the enemy. And they spoke of how, as the Lord Treasurer of the Chola Kingdom, he ensured that people were prosperous and happy.

After talking thus, they withdrew, but didn’t leave. Instead they hid themselves in his chamber. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar then brought Azhwarkadiyan Nambi to his chambers and made him sit next to his brother, and then sat with him. Periya Pazhuvetarayar’s eyes were darkening. And with an effort, he looked at the Vaishnavan and said, “Aha, why did this Vaishnavan come here? Thambi, I do not wish to go to Vaikuntam. I wish to reach the abode of Shiva!”

“Ayya, tomorrow is the holy day of Vaikunta Ekadashi. Even if you wish to reach the abode of Shiva, you will need to pass by Vaikuntam!”

“No! No! You go and tell your Maha Vishnu...”

“Ayya, I didn’t come as the messenger of Maha Vishnu. I brought message from my sister...”

“Who is this sister?”

“The sister who I raised for many years, Nandini. Ayya, Nandini asked me to express her thanks to you for taking the entire blame of Karikalan’s death on your head. She wanted me to thank you for the love that you showed her, and asked me to tell you that she would never forget your kindness!”

“Aha! Does she really think that I did all this for her? Let her be happy thinking thus. No matter how much she betrayed and deceived me, even I cannot forget her. After all, she is the daughter of that Goddess who gave up her life to save the emperor. God knows she might just come searching me in my next birth!”

The old man smiled and said, “Vaishnavaney! I have to tell this truth to someone, so I will tell you. The twisted dagger that I hurled, didn’t kill the prince. He fell down even before that. I took the murder charge on my head not because I wanted to save Nandini. Come closer, I will tell you why I did it.

“Your friend Vandiya Devan, is a very good boy! This Chola clan owes him much. And he has captured the heart of our Princess Kundavai. I was unnecessarily angry with the princess, and as redemption I took the entire blame on my head and gave up my life. Otherwise, someone or the other will keep accusing him for Karikalan’s death. Now, no one will dare do that. Vaishnavaney! Someday, tell this to the princess and ask her to forgive me for hating her.”

The old man’s breath started rasping from talking for long. Azhwarkadiyan Nambi was overcome with emotion while tears coursed through Kundavai’s eyes.

“Vaishnavaney! There is one more thing. Tell this to the prime minister. We need to somehow bring back the Pandya treasures – the ancient crown and the navaratna aaram – from Elangai. Send Vandiya Devan for this task. Maybe you, too, can go with him. After

retrieving these treasures, Ponniyin Selvar should go to Madurai and crown himself with these symbols of the Pandyas.

“Tell the prince one more thing. Let the disgrace and dishonour that I brought to my clan end with my death. Ask him not to blame my brother for this. He will not find anybody else who will serve the Chola clan that bravely.

“Devi! Durga Parameshwari! I have fulfilled my oath! Here I come. Save the chola clan!” whispered Periya Pazhuvetarayar, with his voice failing. And his spirit departed the earthly plane.

Chapter 78: Friends Part

That day, four horses were nearing the Kollidam River. The horses bore four warriors who we already know; Parthibendra Pallavan, Kandanmaran, Arulmozhivarman, and Vandiya Devan. The first two warriors were journeying north and had come to the Kollidam River to take a boat across, while the other two had come along to bid farewell. When they reached the banks of the Kollidam, all four of them dismounted from their horses.

“Kandanmara! Have you resolved all your misunderstanding and differences of opinion with your friend? Or are you still angry with him?”

“What’s there to be angry about? I can only feel sorry for the way I treated him, and feel grateful to him for forgiving me despite all the harm that I did to him. He saved my sister’s life from when she fell into the river, and I will be grateful to him forever for that. I am surprised at myself for acting the way I did. If only I had gotten my sister married to him as I had initially decided, she wouldn’t have become insane today,” said Kandanmaran.

“Why do you talk thus? She has merely lost her memory because of the shock of falling into the river. She will be fine after a few days,” said the prince.

“It doesn’t seem like a memory loss. She remembers everything, and is able to recognize everyone but myself and Vandiya Devan. When I think about the love that she bore towards me, my heart splinters into thousand pieces. When she wails ‘I have killed my dear brother with mine own hand,’ and wails, I feel helpless,” said Kandanmaran.

“But why does she wail so? You are well and alive,” said the prince.

“Yes, I am alive, but I wish I was dead. Yes, ayya! She thinks that I killed Vandiya Devan and in retaliation she had killed me. She sometimes wails for my death, and sometimes grieves for Vandiya Devan, crying, ‘Will the flood waters bring back my beloved?’ No matter how much I try to convince her, she has failed to recognize me or my friend here. She asks, ‘Who are you? Do you know the Prince of Vallam?’ to Vandiya Devan himself!”

“Is that so?” exclaimed the prince, turning towards Vandiya Devan whose eyes were flooded with tears.

“Aha! It’s rather unfortunate that she doesn’t know that Vandiya Devan is no longer the ‘Prince of Vallam’ but has been made the ‘King of Vallam’,” said Parthibendra Pallavan.

Hearing this, Kandanmaran looked surprised and Prince Arulmozhivarman said, “Yes, indeed. The emperor has decided to return the kingdom of Vanagapadi to your friend and anoint him as the ‘King of Vallam’. He has also decided to grant you the Vaithumbarayar kingdom that adjoins Vanagapadi. Henceforth, you both have to live right next to each other. Just make sure you remain friends forever!”

“The emperor is most generous. This means I don’t have to go back to Kadambur,” said Kandanmaran with enthusiasm.

“There’s no need for you to return to Kadambur. There, you will only find your old palace burnt beyond recognition. And if you return there, you will only be plagued by old memories. Instead, build a new palace on the southern banks of Pallar and live there. Once your sister recovers her health, you can bring her there, too!”

“My prince, I doubt if my sister will come back to us. Your grandmother Sembianmadevi has promised to take her along on a pilgrimage. Manimegalai, too, has agreed to go with her. Even today, the queen has taken her along to Thiruvaiyaru!”

“Yes, it was indeed a large group that went to Thiruvaiyaru. My newlywed uncle and aunt have also gone there. Isn’t this strange that I have to consider Poonguzhali as my aunt henceforth?” asked the prince.

“I haven’t seen a more modest wedding in the Chola royal family as Madhuranthakar and Poonguzhali’s wedding!” said Parthibendra Pallavan.

“Even my coronation will be a modest celebration,” said the prince.

“That’s impossible!” exclaimed Vandiya Devan.

Startled, Ponniyin Selvar turned towards his friend and asked, “What is impossible? My coronation?”

Vandiya Devan reduced his tone and said, “No, prince! I meant it will not be a modest affair. The people have already begun to talk about your coronation!”

“My prince, don’t you want us here for your coronation? We hear that it will held during the month of Thai^[42] and here you are, sending us away. Vandiya Devan is indeed very fortunate. He is going to be here...” said Kandanmaran.

“Nothing of that sort. I will be sending Vandiya Devar to Elangai soon. Friends, remember one thing. Trust me, my coronation will not happen without the presence of my friends,” declared Ponniyin Selvar.

“Thanks for saying that, ayya. As soon as the date is fixed, do send us a message. We will come back immediately!”

“My dear friend! Why do you worry? Like I said, my coronation will not happen without your presence. But don’t forget why I am becoming the emperor of this kingdom. Not to spend time in beautiful gardens...”

“Friends...ever since I went to Elangai, I have had many dreams about the future of this kingdom. I have told you before, but I will repeat them again. I want this kingdom to rise again to the same heights that it once reached under my grandfather Paranthakan I's rule. We should expand the kingdom in all four directions. In the north, we need to go all the way to the banks of Ganga. In the south, we should go beyond Elangai all the way to Sri Vijaya kingdom. In the west, beyond the mountains there are many islands where we should plant our flag and capture the lands.

“I hear that in the Chera Kingdom, a new Chera king has appeared and I wouldn't be surprised if a new Pandya king would emerge as well. And they will be supported by the Elangai kings. That's why it is imperative that we search for Mahindan's forces in Elangai and vanquish them completely and bring the entire island kingdom under our control.

“My dreams don't just stop with expansion of the kingdom. I want to raise huge temples in the Chola Kingdom that would compete with huge stupas of Elangai. Future generations should be amazed by our vision and must wonder how we managed to build such temples.

“Friends, these are not mere dreams but my plans for future which I will fulfil during my lifetime. And each one of you will help me fulfil these dreams.

“Parthibendrarey! My brother was the last Northern Commander of our forces, I have given that position to you, and I am hoping that you will fulfil your responsibilities just as my brother did. The tragic death of my brother has probably stirred the dreams of our enemies. I am sure the Vengai and Rashtrakuta clans were hoping that we would be embroiled in a civil war, and that our noble chieftains and lords will fight amongst themselves over the succession. This also means that our soldiers should guard the borders like an armour that guards our body.

“Pallavarey! Do make due arrangements to guard the border and install Kandanmaran as the commander, and then return

immediately to Kanchi. Prepare the gold palace that my brother has built to receive the emperor. He wishes to travel to Kanchi immediately after I am crowned!"

When Kandanmaran heard this, his eyes filled with happy tears, said, "Prince! I am yet to prove my worth to you. How are you appointing me as the border commander already? Am I worthy of such a responsibility?"

"My friend, God has given me the power to discern who would be suitable for what task. Just as I have made you the Northern Commander, I have appointed your friend as the Southern Commander. I am sure you both will fulfil your responsibilities well!"

"I think it's a good idea to keep one of them in northern and the other in southern direction. If they are together – and if you are not there, either – they might start fighting," said Parthibendran.

"Ayya! That will never happen!" exclaimed Kandanmaran. Then he turned towards Vandiya Devan and said, "My friend, I hope you have forgiven me for all the harm that I did you?"

Vandiya Devan, instead of replying, embraced him fondly, and the friends shed a few tears over their shared grief. After a while, Parthibendran and Kandanmaran took a boat that had been readied for them.

The prince and Vandiya Devan waited until the boat went halfway through the river and then returned to their horses and to go back to Thanjavur.

Chapter 79: An Unexpected Meeting on the Road

The people knew that the coronation date for Ponniyin Selvar had already been fixed, and they were eagerly preparing for it. The emperor Sundara Chola was heartbroken due to the tragic deaths of Aditya Karikalan and Mandakini Devi, and finally Periya Pazhuvetarayar's fulfilment of his oath. Despite his grief, he found a measure of peace when all the noble lords agreed to the ascension of Ponniyin Selvar.

In the first week of the month of Thai, the emperor wished to crown his son and retire to Kanchi immediately after that. He looked forward to living his remaining days in Kanchi, at the gold palace that his older son had built for him. Therefore, the emperor wished that the coronation be a modest affair.

Prince Arulmozhivarman was in complete agreement with his father on this matter, and therefore he decided not to go out in public until the coronation. On their return to Thanjavur, the direct route would take them through Thanjavur, which the prince wanted to avoid. If he went into the town, the townspeople would gather around him and start hailing him. Therefore, they passed by the outskirts of the town and crossed the river in a secluded place. Once they reached Kudamurattu River, they travelled along the banks and reached the Thanjavur royal road.

The beautiful vista of the five tributaries of Kaveri River feeding the lands and turning them fertile and green was a sight to watch, especially in the month of Margazhi^[43]. The rivers were no longer in spate, and the river bed could be seen in some places. Paddy fields, coconut groves, and gardens with blossoming flowers were seen everywhere. In many places, full-grown corn could be seen leaning to one side, unable to bear the burden and ready to be harvested.

Canals and irrigation waterways dug by farmers were full of water and in them, they could see lotus and lily flowers blossoming.

Vandiya Devan enjoyed seeing these beautiful sights. The prince turned towards him and said, “My friend, have you ever seen a more beautiful place than the Chola Kingdom? To become the emperor of such a kingdom is a blessing. I can’t believe I was refusing this for so long. It truly surprises me!”

“I am not surprised, ayya. I have heard from my elders that royalty do have a fickle mind...”

“You are really wicked and ungrateful, too. You haven’t even thanked me for making you the commander of Elangai forces! And here you are, abusing me instead!”

“It is very much to your advantage if you are fickle-minded where people are concerned. Today, you are condemning someone to death and tomorrow, you change your mind and make him your commander. Your glory will increase through your fickle mind. The people will hail you thus, ‘Aha! See how generous and kind-hearted our emperor is!’”

“Alright, but what about when I reverse the situation? I could make you the commander today and then condemn you to death tomorrow!”

“Even so, they will say, ‘Our emperor delivers justice no matter who the accused is... He is Manu Needhi Cholan, reborn in this world!’”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed and said, “If that is so, then you won’t be surprised if I were to grab the kingdom of Vanagamudi and the post of commander back from you!”

“I will not be surprised or distressed. Even now, I am not sure if this post of commander is an honour or a ruse to banish me away from this beautiful Chola kingdom. I have my own doubts about it!”

“To tell you the truth, I wish I could make you my prime minister and keep you beside me at all times. But it does not look like Anirudhar would give up his post!”

“If that is the only reason, then I can request the prime minister...”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed again and said, “No... that’s not the only reason. There are other reasons.”

“I thought so!”

“What did you think?”

“That you have one thing in your mind and you say something else altogether!”

“Prince of Vallam, can you prove this accusation?”

“Of course, I can. You know very well that your coronation will take place on the first week of Thai (month) and yet you told our friends who just now parted that ‘My coronation will not take place without you!’ What should I infer from this?”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed again and said, “Yes, there was a time when I would reveal whatever ran in my mind. But ever since I met you, I am learning tricks and strategies!”

“Please do not praise me so. Truly, is there any trick or strategy that you do not know? After all, didn’t you trick everyone successfully about the elephant’s madness? And what about fooling everyone as the elephant’s mahout!”

“Alright then, by all means, you can learn a few tricks from me...”

“Is that why you are sending me off to Elangai, lest I learn all your tricks?”

“My friend, perchance, don’t you wish to go to Elangai?”

“Who said that? I am eager to leave immediately for Elangai, or even the island kingdoms that are beyond Elangai. The sooner you send me, the better.”

“So you are saying you are happy to leave me...”

“Yes, ayya. I have come to the conclusion that if we stay away from royalty, there is a better chance of being their friends for a long time, and not lose it.”

“Then you are in for a disappointment!”

“Are you saying that I cannot be your friend for long, even I stay far way?”

“No, no, I meant that you will not be separated from me for long, because I will be joining you soon in Elangai. And then we both can travel beyond to other island kingdoms. I am bit disappointed about the fact that we cannot take Samudra Kumari along with us...”

“Ayya, you told me that you learned many tricks and strategies from me, while I learnt to speak the truth from you. Shall I tell you what I am thinking right now?”

“By all means, do!”

“You are taking this kingdom from my dear friend and your uncle Senthana Amuthan, and are going to ascend the throne as its emperor. There is much justification for doing this, because the people, noble lords, and everybody wishes you to do so. But if you try to snatch Poonguzhali from him, there cannot be any excuse for that. You must not forget that Poonguzhali is your uncle’s wife now!”

Ponniyin Selvar laughed and said, “Seems like you will now compare me to the ten-headed Ravana,” and then he asked seriously, “You spoke for your friend, and that’s to be expected. But what is Poonguzhali’s plight? Did she really marry my uncle of her own wish and will?”

“There is no doubt about it. Prince, you might be the emperor of this Chola kingdom, or the ruler of the three worlds. But you cannot make Poonguzhali do something against her wishes. I know the depth of affection that she has for Sembiyanmadevi’s son, and I have seen the same love only with one more person!”

“And where did you find it? If you think you can reveal it, then tell me!”

“Where else, but with Kodumbalur princess Vanathi!”

“Lies! Did you forget your resolution of speaking only the truth? Why are lying when clearly there is something else in your mind?”

“No! I told you exactly what I am thinking!”

“Then, you haven’t seen such love anywhere else?”

“I can only say no!”

“You scoundrel! Heartless fiend! You are forgetting the woman who dared to sacrifice her life for you, and has since lost her mind. And you don’t think that her love for you was deep?”

Vandiya Devan fell silent for a while and said, “Prince, you are misinterpreting what I said. I sympathize with Manimegalai’s plight, and am grieving in my heart for her. But I am not the reason why she lost her mind. That was her brother’s doing. Moreover, we both are now dead to her. What’s the use of talking about it?”

“Forgive me for talking angrily....” began Ponniyin Selvar.

“I am neither offended nor surprised. This is exactly why I wish to leave for Elangai immediately, to get away from your sudden bursts of anger!”

“There is another reason why we are sending you to Elangai!”

“Yes, my Lord?”

“My sister feels that Manimegalai might recognize you if you stay away for a while and come back...”

“Now I know that your sister is keener about sending me away than yourself. There... the person we are talking about is coming our way...”

They both were near the royal road that meandered towards Thiruvaiyaru. And, on the road, an entourage could be seen with soldiers and guards ahead of and behind a palanquin that bore Princesses Kundavai and Vanathi. When both the princesses saw the friends, their faces blossomed.

Chapter 80: Lover of Nilamagal

As their horses neared the princesses' palanquin, Vandiya Devan called out, "Careful, lest the princesses' wild palanquin collide with our tame horses!"

Almost at the same place, he had earlier collided his horse with Nandini's palanquin and had shouted 'palanquin is colliding with my horse'. It had been less than six months since that incident... and in that time, so many important events had taken place!

Kundavai overcame the happiness that she felt from Vandiya Devan's words and addressed the prince. "Thambi, it looks as though you both were discussing a happy matter. You both look very happy..."

"Yes, akka, we were indeed discussing something happy. But unfortunately, that will not give any happiness to your friend here. We were talking about my marriage, and the fact that my wedding date is nearing. We met the woman that I would be marrying and were discussing her beauty and graceful looks..."

The beautiful faces of both the princesses lost their glow immediately. Vanathi looked down, while Kundavai's face alternatively showed anger, surprise, and fear, "What kind of shameless talk is this? What pleasure do you get from hurting this girl's heart?"

Vanathi looked up and said, "Akka, what are you saying? I am not hurt!"

Ponniyin Selvar smiled silently without reacting to any of this, while Kundavai asked him one question after another, "You went to the banks of Kollidam? Whom did you meet there? What's her name? Which clan does she belong to?"

Vandiya Devan intervened and said, “Devi, we didn’t meet any woman that the prince would wed. We were talking about this beautiful Chola kingdom and the five tributaries that feed this land and make it green. We were merely discussing about the beauty of this kingdom. And since the coronation day is nearing, the prince was saying, how much he loved this land...”

“Aha! My brother didn’t know to talk thus before! I think you are teaching him...”

“My friend, do you see now? I did tell you that I learned some tricks and strategies from you, now even my sister seems to think so!”

“What is this? Both sister and brother are colluding with each other to blame me thus...”

“Oh, there are many other accusations against you, which my brother might not have told you. We cannot discuss this in the middle of the road.”

Vandiya Devan replied, “My suspicions have been proven right!”

“What did you suspect?”

“I suspected that I was being banished from this kingdom. That’s why I have been named the commander of Elangai.”

“Do you see, akka, how much faith he has in us? He thinks that we are not grateful to him!”

“That is true. We are indeed not grateful to him!”

“What is this? You too are saying the same thing!”

“We must express our gratitude to strangers, not to our own friends. Do you remember what the great poet Valluvar^[44] said,

udukkai izhandhavan kaipoala aangae

idukkaN kaLaivadhaam natpu

When your garment is slipping away from your body, one hand helps the other to tie it again, so should we express gratitude to the hand?”

“Devi, there is no need of gratitude, I just wish that I will not be punished!”

“Thambi, you both need to remember one thing. Our brother, Aditya Karikalan, sent him to me to help me. I haven’t relieved him of that service yet!”

“There is no need to relieve him, akka! You can make him serve you as long as he lives,” said the prince.

“I need him to do many things for me in Elangai,” said the princess.

“Devi, I will present myself to you before I take leave...”

“Then you will have to come to Pazhaiarai!”

The prince now asked with great surprise, “Akka, where are you going?”

“We are going to Thiruvaiyaru. Today is the auspicious day of Margazhi Thiruvadirai^[45]. Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali left this morning with Sembiyanmadevi. Will you be coming?”

“No, we are not coming. We wanted to avoid going into Thiruvaiyaru town. That’s why we travelled along the west banks!”

“They say that Appar had a vision of Kailasam in Thiruvaiyaru on this auspicious day. But looks like you both don’t want to come at all. Have you become Veera Vaishnavas, by any chance?”

“No, but if I were to go to Thiruvaiyaru, then I would have to go there just as Appar Perumal did...”

“How did Appar go?”

“He has told this in his Devaram song, ‘Yadum Suvadu Padamal’. He came there without any entourage, nor did he reveal his identity as Thirunavukarasar. He came there with flowers and holy water to present to the Lord and joined the scores of ordinary devotees who had gathered there. That’s how he had the vision of Kailasam. If we go there with our royal entourage and guards, we cannot see the Lord, and we will be hindering other people’s worship as well, for people will gather around us!”

“Yes, that’s true! But it applies only to you. When people see you, they do indeed abandon everything and gather around you. But we are not in such danger. Nor will we go in the midst of the crowd. When the procession of the Lord begins, we will be at balcony of our palace. And from there, we will see the Lord as he passes us by!”

“Akka, do you remember one song? It described how the Lord created all the stars, planets, and the entire universe but to bind him only to Thiruvadirai star is so meaningless. Do you remember it?”

“Yes, I do. But if Lord created all the stars, then Thiruvadirai too is one of them!”

“Alright, when are you returning to Thanjavur?”

“We are not returning right now. We are going to Pazhaiarai from Thiruvaiyaru...”

“What? Are you not going to be there for my coronation?” asked the prince with great surprise.

“What work do we have at your coronation? What will Vanathi and I will do there?”

“Aha, but without you, my coronation will not take place!”

“Why will it not take place? Thankfully, your coronation date was not selected by someone who belonged to the same lineage^[46] as the one who selected the date for Rama’s coronation!”

“I don’t believe in good or auspicious days, akka. I believe that all days when you do your duty and fulfil your responsibilities are good days. And the days when one is lazy are bad days...”

“May your entire life see only such good days. We will now take your leave. We will pray to the Lord and Goddess for you!”

“What will you pray for?”

“That your love for ‘Nilamagal’ thrives and you would be successful, and that your coronation take place without any hurdles, and that your heart never wavers from your duty and righteous behaviour that embodies our clan!”

“Then you are definitely not going to be at my coronation ceremony!”

“We will see the ceremony through our minds’ eyes!”

“Akka, you are giving too much importance to this Kodumbalur Princess’s stubborn behaviour. Do you really think that the world will come to an end because she refuses to ascend the throne with me? Her stubbornness will have dangerous consequences... I will be forced to ascend the throne with another woman by my side, so don’t blame me if that happens!”

“I have never blamed him, nor will I ever blame him, akka,” said the Kodumbalur princess.

“Even if you do, he is not going to listen. His desire for the land surpasses everything.”

“Don’t forget it was you who planted this desire in my heart. Haven’t you told me many times that you love this land so much that

you don't wish to marry and leave it?"

"Yes, but then, you used to tell me that there are many other beautiful kingdoms out there. But under the influence of this Vallam prince, you have turned into the lover of this Nilamagal!"

"My God! Now even that accusation is being laid on my head!"

"You have borne many other grave accusations on your head. This is nothing. Thambi, the hour is growing late, and we have been talking for long. The procession in Thiruvaiyaru will start soon. We will take your leave now," said Kundavai and signalled her palanquin bearers to proceed.

The prince and Vandiya Devan watched them go for a while and then turned their horses towards Thanjavur. The prince said to Vandiya Devan, "My friend, I don't think these women are going to Thiruvaiyaru to visit the temple. I have heard that Kudanthai Jodhidar has now shifted to Thiruvaiyaru. I think they are on their way to consult him!"

"Ayya, looks like you are a bigger astrologer than Kudanthai Jodhidar!"

Chapter 81: The Cat and the Parrot

Ponniyin Selvar was right when he said that the women were on their way to meet the astrologer. When the princesses reached the Chola palace in Thiruvaiyaru and learned that Sembiyanmadevi, along with her son and daughter-in-law had gone to the temple, they left the word there that they too would go to the temple. They then took only one soldier as their guard and went searching for the astrologer's house. Yes, Kudanthai Jodhidar had indeed shifted to Thiruvaiyaru after he lost his house to the floods. In the east of the town, near the banks of the Kaveri, he had built a new home and was living there.

Maybe he had learned through his astrology that in future, Thanjavur would be the seat of power. That's probably why he chose Thiruvaiyaru to settle in. When the princesses reached the astrologer's house, they could hear a sweet voice welcoming them thus, "Welcome, dancing queens! Welcome, queens of art!"

Pleasantly surprised by this welcome, the princesses were now eager to see who had welcome them thus. Earlier, the astrologer had a rude disciple who often gave offence.

When they saw a parrot shut within its cage and hung from the roof, they knew who had welcomed them. The parrot turned its head, looked at them, and said again, "Welcome... dancing queens, welcome."

Hearing the parrot's voice and the sound from the anklets of the women, the astrologer came to the courtyard to see who had come. He was startled to see them and welcomed them, "Devi, welcome. This hut has become blessed indeed by your arrival!"

And the parrot too repeated the same, 'This hut has become blessed...'

Incensed by the parrot's behaviour, the astrologer chided it, "Be quiet. Don't open your mouth!"

"Ayya, why do you scold that bird? It has indeed welcomed us beautifully. Looks like every day, this hut is indeed becoming blessed by 'dancing queens and princesses!'" said Kundavai.

The parrot took the opportunity to repeat what it had been taught, and said, "Welcome, dancing queens, welcome!"

The astrologer scolded the parrot again and said, "Devi, forgive me. When Sambandha Perumal^[47] came to this town, he saw many halls built for dancers, and describes the sound of anklets that he would hear everywhere in this town. From that day to this day, things haven't changed much. Even today, those who wish to learn the divine dance of Natarajar come here to learn the art. And many of them come here to consult me as well. That's why I taught this naughty parrot a few welcoming words!"

"Well, I am not seeing any of those dancing queens here today!"

"Devi, today is the auspicious day of Thiruvadirai. Therefore all the dancers have gone to the temple to perform. But this hut is indeed fortunate today because real princesses have come here. I am indeed fortunate," and then he added, "Please sit here and tell me what you wish to know. I will do my best to tell you what I know."

The princesses sat down in front of him, and Kundavai sighed loudly and said, "Jodhidharey! What do I ask? I think I should only ask if there is any truth in this astrology!"

"Devi, what can I say? For those who believe in it, astrology is the absolute truth. And for those who don't it's nothing but a lie!"

"I had believed in it completely, Jodhidarey. But astrology has indeed failed me miserably!"

"Devi, how has it failed you?"

“Indeed, which prediction of yours has ever come true? Did you ever tell me that my brother would die so tragically?”

“Devi, I did tell you... but beyond a few subtle hints, I cannot outrightly warn you, especially those belonging to the royal family. Then wouldn't you suspect me of being associated with Pandya Abathuuthavigal? We can only warn thus, ‘a grave danger is coming’ or ‘the stars are showing unfortunate events.’ But beyond that, we are not allowed to say anything more. Moreover, I never had Aditya Karikalar's horoscope with me. I have never seen it!”

“Even if you had seen it, you wouldn't have told us. And even if you did tell us, we couldn't have prevented it...”

“How can I do that, Devi? I am not Brahma. Even he cannot erase and change the fate that we are born with!”

“If that is so, then what's the point of an astrologer, then?”

“Devi, how can you ask this question? If people like you do not consult poor astrologers like me, how will I survive, and how will this hut become blessed by princesses like you?” said the astrologer, which elicited laughter from Kundavai. It even coaxed a smile from Vanathi.

“Jodhidharey! Do you perchance talk thus to everyone who comes here?”

“Will I say this to everybody? They say that you are the personification of Goddess Saraswathi and Goddess Lakshmi, and dare I hope to win an argument with you? But devi, you cannot decide the usefulness of astrology based on predictions that I never made. You should make this decision based on the predictions that I have made. Didn't I tell you about the lucky horoscope of Ponniyin Selvar? No matter what has happened in between... in the end, he is going to ascend the throne. I hear that an auspicious date has been selected for the coronation!”

“Ayya, didn’t anyone come to you to select the date?”

“No, devi, but the royal court has its priests and astrologers. And what’s more, prime minister Anirudhar himself is much skilled in astrology!”

“Yes, they have selected the seventh date of the month of Thai. Is that an auspicious date?”

“It’s a very auspicious day. And indeed. they have selected it carefully!”

“It might be an auspicious day for the coronation... but can you tell if the coronation will actually happen that day?”

“What are you asking, devi? Why wouldn’t the coronation happen that day?”

“A very auspicious day was selected for Shri Rama’s coronation, but he didn’t get coronated that day...”

“Devi, though Shri Rama’s coronation didn’t happen on the appointed day, it was a very significant day for him, nonetheless. It was the day, the Ramayanam was born. Either way, devi, why would you doubt this? It looks as though you wish that the coronation doesn’t happen that day?”

“You have guessed it right!”

“But the entire world believes that no one is happier than Kundavai Devi, about her brother’s ascension to the throne!”

“Yes, I should justly be elated by this, but this Kodumbalur princess’s foolish oath has robbed me of any pleasure that I might feel. Do you remember the oath that she swore in Kudanthai at your house?”

“Oath? Many disastrous events happened that day, and I cannot remember clearly what happened!”

“Just because that boat girl Poonguzhali said something to her out jealousy, she took an oath saying ‘until I live, I will not ascend the throne!’ Well, it’s not possible to ascend the throne after one has lost their life, can they?”

“Not possible...”

“I think this oath incited Goddess Kaveri to flood your house and took her away with Her as a punishment...”

“Yes... I remember now. But I thought that it was said playfully!”

“No, it was an oath taken in earnest. She is adamant about not ascending the throne, and says that my brother should indeed marry another woman and make her his empress, while she would stay in his palace and be his servant. I cannot bear to hear all this. Jodhidharey! Do you remember what you predicted about this girl?”

The astrologer’s face blossomed and he said, “Devi, that day, Goddess Kaveri took all the horoscopes that I had collected. There were birth charts of many princes, princesses, kings, and queens... But I remember this girl’s horoscope very well. It is etched in my heart. I can still see the astonishing lines of her palm, and this I can say with certainty! My prediction about her will definitely come true!”

“Do you remember what you told about this girl?”

“Why not? The man who marries this girl, would wed Goddess Lakshmi and Goddess Bhumi devi, and would be the most fortunate man in the world. Queens and princesses around the world would pray for an audience with her. The son who will be born of her womb will plant the flag of victory. He would be victorious in every endeavour...”

“Ayya, when you say such things, my worry increases...”

The astrologer sat upright and said, “Devi, why do you worry? There is no need to worry about the Chola clan any more... Do you

know today is a very special day?”

“Yes, today is a special day for Lord Shiva. The star of Thiruvadirai!”

“It is the most fortunate and special day for the Cholas. And not just the Cholas, for the entire Tamil Nadu. Devi, listen to me... In a few years, in the month of Margazhi, there will be a miracle. A child will be born who will be the very embodiment of Maha Vishnu. Through that child, this Chola kingdom is going to attain indescribable greatness. I cannot tell you what glories you will witness. I may not be alive then, but you will definitely see it happen in your lifetime!”

While the astrologer spoke thus with great conviction, Kundavai listened to him with rapt attention. Suddenly, they were startled to hear the parrot screeching desperately. A cat was on the roof, trying to pounce on the bird’s cage. Vanathi immediately snatched one of the palm leaf manuscripts that the astrologer had placed there and threw it at the cat, saying, “Akka, indeed astrology is quite useful. I was able to save this beautiful parrot with the help of the astrologer’s palm leaf horoscopes. Or else that wicked cat might have torn the parrot’s wings!”

Chapter 82: The Chinese Merchants

From the days of yore, people all over the world have been curious to know what might happen in the future. Be it the poor or the rich, people have always had an intense curiosity to learn what is to come. Astrologers, soothsayers, palmists, and diviners have lived in all societies and have thrived. At the same time, there have been many who didn't believe in any of these and were vociferous in their dislike of these arts.

Intelligent and brilliant, Kundavai often struggled with her own beliefs in astrology. And yet, whenever she was worried about the Chola Kingdom, her anxiety brought her to the astrologer's house.

To tell the truth, by then, Kundavai should have attained a measure of peace that her father had experienced. Many tragic and unexpected events had occurred, but they had resulted in the decision that Arulmozhi will ascend the throne after his father. We know the love that Kundavai bore for her brother right from the time he was born. She strongly believed that the Chola empire will attain great heights under his reign and that the Shanku Chakra^[48] lines in his palm will not fail. The way Mandakini Devi saved his life when he fell into the river and many other miraculous incidents related to him had bolstered her belief. And now, they were nearing the time when all her dreams with respect to her brother would be finally realized.... yet she was neither happy nor at peace.

And just as astrologers sang praises about Arulmozhi's extraordinary horoscope, they also spoke highly of Vanathi's horoscope. Now, we don't know if they really examined the time and position of planets and made these predictions, or if they said it because they thought Kundavai would be pleased to hear it. But there is also the fact that every astrologer who saw Vanathi's horoscope said the same thing. And when everyone says the same thing, it does come true. We might have seen many instances of this

in our life. A few other people have an extraordinary gift that whatever they say (however improbable) becomes the truth.

Kudanthai Jodhidhar, too, made an extraordinary prediction that day. He said with great certainty that Margazhi Thiruvadirai day would be extremely auspicious for the Chola clan.

And two years after this prediction, a male child was born on Margazhi Thiruvadirai day. That child would grow up to become one of the great rulers in the annals of history, on par with Chitrugupta Maurya, Ashoka, Vikramaditya, Harshvardhan... Assuming the name Rajendran, this child would one day rule a kingdom that would stretch from Elangai to the banks of Ganga, and from the island kingdom of Sri Vijaya to Lakshadweep.

Thus, the astrologer's words came true. But the day he predicted this, Kundavai didn't really believe his words, while Vanathi's anger rose with every word that he uttered. She threw his palm leaf manuscript on the cat and declared that 'astrology is indeed useful!'

The astrologer turned towards her and said, "Princess! They say that for a true warrior, even a blade of grass becomes a potent weapon. That's why this palm leaf olai gained the power to save a creature's life... only because you touched it. Your hands will one day provide sanctuary and save many lives..."

Vanathi turned towards Kundavai and said, "Akka, this astrologer knows how to flatter well. Come let's go!"

"Devi, you may not like my words today. But one day, in the future, you will see that all my predictions have come true. Please do not forget this poor old man then!"

Kundavai intervened and said, "Jodhidarey! It's not that this girl doesn't like your words. She is probably happy to hear your predictions. She is merely angry because she took an oath recklessly, and is expressing that anger by throwing your olai. You can ignore it!"

“The anger that good people feel will beget good results. She saved my sweet parrot with this, so I am not offended!”

Kundavai then spoke for a while to the astrologer, wanting to know when Arulmozhi will get married. There was a reason why she was worried about it.

The day before, Commander Periya Vellar had come to take his leave and said, “Devi, I am leaving for Kodumbalur... Can I take my brother’s daughter Vanathi along with me?”

Kundavai was startled and she asked, “Mama, why are you leaving in such a hurry? Won’t you stay until the coronation?”

“Devi, I will come back here to attend the coronation. Why should I stay here until then? When I came to Thanjavur, I brought my army along with me. But thankfully, our wish is being fulfilled without resorting to war. The prince has agreed to ascend the throne, and the rest of the noble lords too have agreed to this. So now there is no need for an army. Besides, it has been a strain on the Thanjavur people to feed my army. Therefore, I have decided to leave with my army and station them in small groups...”

“That’s fine then! But why do you want to take Vanathi along with you?”

“Devi, there is a reason for that. Yesterday, all the noble lords and chieftains met together and took a decision. Your grandfather Aringzhan Chola’s father Paranthakar, married six women who hailed from different clans; Kodumbalur, Miladudaiyar, Pazhvur, Mazhavarayar, and Sambuvarayar. Your grandfather Aringzhan Chola too married many women from different clans, and the foremost among them was your grandmother Kalyani Devi who belonged to Vaithumbarayar clan. But your father did not follow this noble tradition, and married only your mother. That was the main reason for many frustrations and disappointments among them. Therefore, we have decided that any new emperor who ascends the

throne will marry a girl from each of our clans. We have decided to request Ponniyin Selvar after the coronation ceremony is done.

“Now you will understand why I wish to take Vanathi with me. If I leave her here, my peers might suspect that I am acting against what we had decided!”

When Kundavai heard this, she was incensed. But she controlled her anger and said, “You once requested me to look after your brother’s daughter like a parent would. Have you forgotten that? I will not send Vanathi back to Kodumbalur. I cannot stay away from her even for a minute. If you wish, I will go back to Pazhaiarai with her and miss the coronation ceremony. Please don’t talk about the marriage issues now. Once the coronation ceremony is completed, you can place your request to the prince!”

The commander agreed and left. This was one of the main reasons why Kundavai came to see the astrologer that day and asked him about Arulmozhi’s marriage.

But Vanathi was recollecting another old incident of which birds and a cat were also a part. There had also been an elephant and his mahout in that!

The cat had tried to loot a bird’s nest and tried to eat the young barely-hatched chicks. The parents birds arrived to save their young ones from the wild cat. Vanathi had shrieked in fear seeing this. And hearing her voice, a youth who had been bathing in the river came to her aid. When he saw that it was the birds that needed help, he came back in an elephant, drove away the cat and saved the bird’s nest.

Vanathi had thought that the young man was an ordinary mahout. It was only later that she learned that he was Ponniyin Selvar.

Aha! If only he had been an ordinary mahout or a soldier! No, he happens to be the emperor’s son! That’s why I have to undergo so much grief and heartache. That’s why girls of my age and people like

Poonguzhali think that I wish to ascend the throne, and waste no time in slandering my name...

With Vanathi immersed in such thoughts and Kundavai worrying about the future, they could hear someone outside the astrologer's house. A voice called out "Do you want to buy China silk? China silk?"

Kundavai realised that it was indeed time that she left, and got up to leave. The astrologer's disciple came inside and said, "Swami! Two Chinese merchants have come. They wish to consult you. Shall I ask them to come tomorrow?"

Kundavai immediately said, "No need. They can come now. We are leaving," and took Vanathi's hand and left the astrologer's house.

When they stepped outside, they could see an elephant, atop which were two merchants with huge bundles of clothing. The merchants seemed to be talking to the mahout about something. Kundavai didn't really notice them much and left for the Chola palace immediately.

Chapter 83: Appar's Vision

That day, even as dusk fell, a grand procession started from Thiruvaiyaru Aiyarappar Temple. And Lord Shiva, who was named Aiyarappar, and his consort Aram Vallaranda Nayaki, were seated on a vehicle made of silver and decorated like Kailasam where they reside.

At the head of the procession were huge elephants, camels, and large bullocks and oxen. The drummers and musicians heralded the arrival of the Lord in all directions. Behind them came many who bore the banners, flags, and emblems that belonged to the temple to signify who was indeed coming behind them. They were followed by countless musicians who played beautiful music. Dancers danced whenever the procession stopped, where they gave a brief performance. Vehicles bearing Nandi, Chandikeshwaran and Lord Murugan with his wives Valli and Devayani came next. And in the end, Parvathi and Parameshwaran came to delight of the devotees.

At the rear of the procession came a huge crowd bearing all sorts of musical instruments, drums, veena. And the musicians sang the divine Devaram songs of Appar, Sambandar and Sundarar. The streets were filled with people watching this procession, and the Lord and his consort made slow progress on the wide streets of Thiruvaiyaru. The people too got on elephants or camels and went with the procession to listen to the beautiful songs sung by the musicians, or to watch the dancers perform, while many attained a divine bliss just to see their Lord come of the temple.

Countless fire torches gleamed in the streets and gave an illusion of a dream. Kundavai, Vanathi and Poonguzhali sat in the balcony of their palace, watching the procession as it wound through the street, and praying as each vehicle passed them by.

In the procession, they also spotted an elephant bearing the two Chinese merchants who were behaving oddly. They would often get

down from the elephant, mingle in the crowd, and then get back on the elephant.

Are these really Chinese merchants or spies?

Kundavai wondered thus, and there was a reason for it. The chaos and confusion that reigned for a while in the Chola Kingdom was known to all the neighbouring kingdoms. And she feared that these merchants might be sent by an enemy kingdom to spy on them.

Kundavai shared her doubts and fears with Vanathi. And Poonguzhali, who stood nearby, heard her and said, “They approached me at the temple and asked, ‘Do you want China silk?’ I said that the princesses from Thanjavur are coming, and have asked them to come to the palace. So maybe they will come here. You can clear your doubts then!”

At that time, the vehicle bearing Aiyarappar and his concert Aram Valartha Nayaki stopped at the entrance of Chola Palace. The Lord was greeted by Sembiyanmadevi and her son Madhuranthakar who were at the head of the procession. After praying to the Lord and doing an aarathi, the Lord’s vehicle moved ahead, and mother and son went inside the palace. When they saw that the princesses were watching the procession from balcony, they too made their way there.

They spoke for a while about the many sights they saw at the procession, and then Sembiyanmadevi looked at her son and said, “Child! There is a Devaram that describes Apapr’s vision when he visited Thiruvaiyaru. Will you sing that for me? I was not very satisfied when the musicians sang it at the procession!”

When both the princesses and Poonguzhali requested the same, Senthana Amuthan, who we will address as Madhuranthakan henceforth, sang the following song –

Madar Pirai Kaniyanai

Malayan Magalodum Padi^[49]

Starting thus, Madhuranthakan sang the ten stanzas of this beautiful song and the women heard him with rapt attention and immersed themselves in the magic of his voice and the song.

After the song ended, everyone was silent for a while. And then Kundavai turned towards Sembianmadevi and said, “Devi, you once told me the story behind this Devaram song. Can you tell that story now so that everyone hears it?”

And when the others too insisted that she must relate this story, the dowager queen narrated it thus.

Appar Swami despite his old age, wanted to travel to Kailasam and see Lord Shiva and Parvathi. He started traveling north, but soon his frail body failed him. He couldn't move even a step and he fell down. Then an elderly man appeared in front of him and said, “Apparey, why do you wish to go to Kailasam? Go to Thiruvaiyaru, situated at the banks of Ponni River. That is Kailasam on this Earth,” and vanished.

Heeding the elderly man's advice, Appar came back to Thiruvaiyaru. Even as he neared the town, his heart was filled with bliss. He saw many devotees going to the Aiyarappar temple bearing flowers and water from the Kaveri River, and singing praises of the lord. Appar joined them and on the way, he saw two elephants: a male tusker and a female elephant. To his eyes, they appeared as Lord Shiva and Goddess Parvathi! As he neared the temple, he saw many species of animals as pairs of male and female. There was bliss everywhere. The male and the female of each species were harmoniously in love with each other. The peacock lovingly danced with the peahen while male and female cuckoo birds sang beautifully together. A male boar could be seen with a female boar. A male crane and a female crane were flying happily with abandon. Male and female parrots were conversing sweetly. A bull and a cow were walking together.

Thus, Appar Swami saw many beings in both their male and female forms. And to his eyes, they seemed like Shiva and Shakti, the divine male and female unified and in harmony. Wherever he looked, he could see both the forms, and he realized that, 'This entire world is Kailasam! Therefore there is nowhere else that one needs to go!'

He walked through the streets of Thiruvaiyaru in utter bliss and watched as Aiyarappar and his consort Aram Valartha Nayaki came towards him in a procession. And whatever he experienced that day, he wrote them as songs and said he realised a profound truth at Thiruvaiyaru. He wrote that he saw many wondrous things that he had never seen in his life....at the end of each song.

Everyone listened with rapt attention to Sembiyanmadevi's explanation of Appar's vision, and then Princess Vanathi asked her a doubt, "Amma, Appar Swami saw divine love in the animals and birds. But why didn't he say anything about men and women?"

Poonguzhali then interjected and said, "Among men and women, there is no love without any material expectations. That's why Appar Swami didn't think they are worth mentioning!"

"That's not right, child. If Appar Swami had met you and my son, he would have probably included it in his song," said Sembiyanmadevi.

Hearing this, everyone agreed.

Just then, there was some commotion at the palace gates. A guard came inside and said, "Two Chinese merchants have come, and they are insisting that they will leave only after meeting the princesses!"

Kundavai became irritated and angry at their audacious behaviour, "Who are they to insist anything? Ask them to leave immediately!"

Poonguzhali interjected and said, “Princess, forgive me, it was I who asked them to come here...”

“Then, so be it. Ask them to come!”

After a few minutes, the merchants entered the palace bearing their wares in huge bundles of cloth.

Chapter 84: The Coronation Gift

The Chinese merchants wore huge turbans and sported large beards. There were very few lamps on the terrace of the palace and the light was dim. Therefore, the women of the palace couldn't see their faces properly or discern their ages. The suspicion that Kundavai had earlier expressed became stronger now. She bid the servant who brought them in thus, "These lamps are not enough to assess the quality of the silk. We need fire torches. Bring them immediately!"

Madhuranthakar interjected and said, "I will send more fire torches," and left the terrace along with his mother.

Kundavai looked at the merchants and asked, "Ayya! Why are you in such a hurry to sell these wares? Couldn't you come tomorrow in daylight? Why come in the night to sell silk?"

"Princesses! We came to Thanjavur many days ago. Despite many efforts, we couldn't come to the palace to meet you. Day after tomorrow, a ship leaves Nagapattinam port and we need to be on it. That's why we were in a hurry to meet you," said one of the merchants.

Though his voice was a bit strange, his command over the Tamil language was perfect and this surprised everyone.

"Ayya, you speak the Tamil language quite well!" commented Kundavai.

"I have been in this Chola Kingdom for a while now, and managed to learn little bit of the Tamil language. I like Tamil and the land of Tamils as well!"

"Then why are you hurrying back to your kingdom? Can't you stay here until the coronation?"

“If we miss the ship that leaves from Nagapattinam, we don’t know when the next ship will travel to our homeland. These days, the frequency of ships traveling from Nagapattinam has become less!”

“Why is that?”

“Don’t you know that, Devi? Ship travel is not easy nowadays, nor is it safe. The seas have become a haven of pirates. Fierce Arab pirates have become a menace for the ships traveling in eastern and western seas. Nowadays, they are seen even in the sea ports and on the coasts where they hide and attack any merchant ship that sails in their direction. They fight with such savagery and do not spare anyone on the ship. And after slaying everyone, they loot the merchandise. That’s why merchant ships nowadays can’t travel alone. They leave in groups of twenty or so. That’s why we need to be on that ship day after tomorrow. If we miss it, then God knows how long it will take for the next group of ships to leave these shores. Devis, please see our wares of silk...”

Saying thus, the Chinese merchant opened his bundle and his companion too opened the wares...

“Ayya! We cannot see your wares now. There is no point in showing us anything. It would be difficult for us to discern the quality of your wares without daylight. Moreover, we haven’t brought enough gold to buy these from you,” said Kundavai.

The first merchant who spoke there made an exaggerated show of surprise, and brought his palms together in salutation, saying, “Princess, we didn’t bring our ware here to sell! Indeed, what a word to say! If you agree to take these silks and wear them, we will indeed be the most fortunate beings in this world. We brought them to you as coronation gift!”

“Then you have come to the wrong place. None of us here is getting coronated. It is Ponniyin Selvar who is getting crowned as the next emperor. You should take these gifts to him!”

“No, Devi! We have come to the right place. Everyone says that if you wish to gain the favour of Prince Arulmozhi, then you must please Princess Kundavai, and gain her favour.”

Everyone laughed on hearing this.

“What do you mean ‘everyone’? Who says this?”

“Why, devi, today at the procession, many people were saying this. They said that the Ponniyin Selvar is devoted to his sister and that he listens to everything that she says. Do ask my companion if this is true!”

His companion, who had been silent for so long, agreed, “Yes, princesses! That is true. Many even said, ‘Though Ponniyin Selvar is being coronated, in reality, it is Princess Kundavai who would be ascending the throne. Henceforth, the Chola Kingdom will be ruled by a woman, and it will be a good rule!’

All the princesses now laughed again.

“Therefore, princesses, please accept these as our coronation gifts,” said the merchant. And his companion added, “Do accept them and forward our petition to the prince!”

“What petition? What do you need from Ponniyin Selvar? Please tell me that first!”

“Devi, we have many aspirations from him. Not just us, all merchants and people living on islands from these shores to the China mainland have many expectations from Ponniyin Selvar. During the times of Emperor Paranthaka Chola, the seas were safe for travel. Except for natural hazards arising from swirling storms and winds, there was no other danger to the ships or the people. There were no pirates around. Just as the merchants hereabouts travel without fear on the King’s Road, we too were travelling on our ships without worrying about anything.

“In the past, Chola merchant ships have travelled to Manakavaram, Mayirudikam, Mappalam, Elamuridesam, Sri Vijayam, and Kambojam, and have bartered their wares with the local merchants and brought precious goods back to the Chola kingdom. They also came to our kingdom in China and traded without any fear or danger. Those days are long gone.

“Devi, we would like to tell you the truth. We are not certain if we will go home safely if we take such precious wares with us. We might be waylaid by these savage Arab pirates who wouldn’t hesitate to kill us just to loot these. Instead of losing these to them, we would rather gift them to you!”

Kundavai, who had listened to the merchant’s tale with rapt attention, now asked, “Do you think that Ponniyin Selvar would be able to help you? Do you think he can destroy these pirates who roam the open sea and make sea voyages safe for merchants just like it was during our great grandfather’s times? Do you think the people of Manakavaram, Mayirudikam, Mappalam, Elamuridesam, Sri Vijayam, and Kambojam would sing the praise of our prince?”

“Not just us, princess... the entire merchant community of Chola kingdom are certain that only our prince can do this. We had gone to meet an astrologer a short while ago, he too said the same thing!”

“What did he say?”

“He said that Ponniyin Selvar will sail with a big fleet of ships and vanquish the pirates and make sea travel safe for merchants. This Chola Kingdom will become as glorious as it was during the reign of Paranthakan I. He also said that the princesses of Chola Kingdom must not hinder his plans in any way!”

“Is that all he said, or did he badmouth the princesses in any other way?”

“Devi, he didn’t badmouth you! Who would indeed dare to say anything about Kundavai Devi and Vanathi Devi? And that too an

astrologer who depends on your grace for his livelihood, will he badmouth you?”

“What else did the astrologer say?”

“He told us that the princesses had visited him just then and that they will get married very soon. Devis, if you have any objection to accepting these silks as coronation gifts, please do accept them as our wedding presents,” said the first Chinese Merchant.

Hearing this, Vanathi said, “Akka, these merchants are just looking for trouble. Ask them to leave!”

“Wait, Vanathi, let’s see how far they go,” said Kundavai. She then turned towards the merchants and said, “Ayya, we saw an elephant outside the astrologer’s house, I assume that was you?”

“Yes, Devi, it was fortunate that we went to the astrologer! We got an opportunity to meet you also immediately. We heard of your arrival from the astrologer, and his prediction that we would meet you also came true instantly! If only all his predictions about Kodumbalur princess also come true it would drive away all our worries!”

Vanathi again interjected and said, “Akka, please ask them to leave!”

“Ayya, you joined today’s procession on your elephant and, in between, you dismounted from its back many times to mingle with the crowds...”

“Yes, we wanted to learn what the people were thinking about the upcoming coronation...”

“What were the people talking about? Are they happy and satisfied that Ponniyin Selvar is ascending the throne?”

“No one was talking about the coronation at all...”

“Then what are they talking about?”

“They were all talking about Madhuranthaka Devar’s depth of devotion to Lord Shiva!”

“There you go! Do tell us such good things... Poonguzhali, did you hear that?” exclaimed Kundavai and then said, “What else did they say about Madhuranthaka Devar?”

“They were talking about his noble character and the way he sacrificed a kingdom that was his by right. They were appreciative of the way he said that he will not ascend the throne!”

“Are they talking about why he rejected the throne?”

“They say that Madhuranthaka Devar fell in love with a girl who plies a boat for a living and insisted that he would marry her and make her the empress. That’s why the noble lords and chieftains withdrew their support and decided that he will not ascend the throne next, and gave the throne to Ponniyin Selvar instead. Devis, is that fortunate boat girl here? If yes, then we would like to gift her with silks!”

Poonguzhali interjected, “Devi, the Kodumbalur princess was right, these merchants are indeed looking for trouble. Do ask them to leave!”

“Wait, Poonguzhali, why are you getting angry? These merchants are not talking anything bad about you! They are praising you!”

“I don’t want them to praise me or badmouth me. And I don’t want any gifts from them,” said Poonguzhali, getting up to leave.

“Devi, are you that fortunate woman? Aha! Whatever the people were saying is true, then.”

“What else were they talking about?” asked Poonguzhali with a smile.

“Someone in the crowd said, “Madhuranthaka Devar sacrificed the Chola Kingdom for Poonguzhali Devi’ and in response, somebody said, “If I had nine kingdoms in my possession, I wouldn’t hesitate to sacrifice it for Poonguzhali Devi!’ And now I completely agree with what he said,” said the Chinese Merchant.

Poonguzhali, with mock anger, said, “Devi, do punish this upstart merchant or I will complain about him to Ponniyin Selvar myself!”

Just then, Madhuranthaka Devar came back to the terrace bearing flowers after finishing his evening prayers. He had heard the last words of the merchant, and he said, “There is nothing wrong with what this merchant is saying. Indeed I agree with him too!”

Hearing this, the merchant turned towards Madhuranthaka Devar. And Poonguzhali neared him and said, “Well if a real merchant were to say this, then it’s fine. But how can we agree to anything that this false merchant says?”

And she pulled at the merchant’s large turban. Along with the turban, the merchant’s beard too tumbled down, to reveal Vandiya Devan’s face.

Vandiya Devan immediately ran towards his companion and tried to hide behind him. But in his rush, the other man’s beard and turban too fell, to reveal the beaming face of Ponniyin Selvar.

All three women laughed aloud for a long while, unable to control their mirth. After a while, when Sembiyanmadevi came to the terrace, they narrated the entire thing again and had a hearty laugh...

“Amma, when I saw them near the temple, I suspected something! That’s why I asked them to come to the palace!”

“Yes, I recognized my friend too. That’s why I left them here and went to do my evening pooja...”

“Vanathi, you and I are apparently the only ones who got fooled by this drama enacted by these men!”

“Akka, why did they disguise themselves thus? We should ask that first!”

“There is no need to ask, Vanathi. My brother, until a while ago, didn’t know anything about fooling others. Now he has learned how to lie and fool others by wearing disguises...”

“Devi, please don’t blame Vandiya Devan for this. Disguising as Chinese Merchants was entirely my idea...”

“Yes, the very fact that you think it is a good idea to fool everyone wearing the disguise is because of the company you keep. But you don’t have to do this anymore...”

“Akka, the great saint Thiruvalluvar has written many poems about truthfulness. But he has also said in one of his couplets,

Poimaiyum Vaaimai Yitaththa Puraidheerndha

Nanmai Payakkum Enin

Even falsehood has the nature of truth, if it confers a benefit that is free from fault.”

“Well, when Valluvar sang that poem, he definitely wouldn’t have thought that you would utilize it thus!”

“Leave Thiruvalluvar alone, didn’t Lord Rama try a ruse on the people who were following him into exile, and trick them by taking a chariot towards Ayodhya, and then ask Sumathra^[50] to take them towards the banks of Ganga?”

“Thambi, if you are trying to become like Shri Rama, in all ways, then I am happy. Never mind that... What did you learn through this disguise? Will you tell me?”

“We were able to learn the people’s true state of mind, thanks to this disguise!”

“What did you learn about the people’s state of mind?”

“We learnt a lot, akka. The most important thing that we learned was that the people wish that our kingdom would attain the glories that we achieved during our great grandfather’s reign. And whatever we told you when we were disguised as merchants is true, even though our disguise was false. After meeting you on the road, we went back to Thanjavur. And there, near the entrance, we met the real Chinese merchants. We bought all these silks from them and came back here, dressed like them. All the news that we told about the fierce Arab warriors and their savagery was based on the information that they told us. My friend and I also experienced their savagery when we were in Elangai.

“Devi, we will be leaving soon to Elangai, right after the coronation. There, once we settle things, we will be taking a fleet of ships to the island kingdoms on the high seas beyond Elangai. We know not if we will come back alive, or die in these foreign shores. Until we leave, we would like you all to stay with us, and then bid us farewell with your blessing. That’s why I followed you in such a hurry!”

Hearing her brother speak thus, Kundavai’s eyes filled with tears, and everyone became emotional. Poonguzhali then said, “Why is there a war? Why can’t people live happily without hating one another?”

“Daughter, what you are saying is wrong. Until this world exists, war, too, will exist. Even Lord Shiva and Mahavishnu had to go to war to save and preserve dharma. And those who are born to establish dharma must go to war,” said Sembianmadevi and her words surprised everyone.

Chapter 85: The Statue's Inner Meaning

Madhuranthaka Devar looked at his mother and asked, “Amma, there are some who can’t stop themselves from warring. My friends Vandiya Devar and Ponniyin Selvar belong to that class. While you believe a day to be wasted if you did not spend it in quiet contemplation about God and His mercy, it is indeed surprising to hear you defend war and conflict!”

Sembiyanmadevi then said, “My dear child, no matter who vilifies war and warring characteristics in people, it isn’t fair for you to say anything disparaging about it. And neither should Poonguzhali. It is due to these very warring qualities of the Prince of Vallam that you are alive today, delighting me with your beautiful songs on Lord Shiva.”

“Mother, forget about me saving your son’s life, I cannot forget how your son and daughter-in-law saved my life. It was indeed due to Poonguzhali Devi’s warring qualities that I am alive today,” said Vandiya Devan.

“It is Lord Shiva and Goddess Parameshwari who run our lives, without their grace, how can we save each other?” asked Madhuranthakar.

“Child, even the most compassionate Lord Shiva had to go to war many times. Goddess Jaganmatha^[51] Durga Parameshwari too had to take up arms to annihilate demons and evil forces. In this holy town, you will find Goddess Aram Valartha Nayaki in the temple as Lord Shiva’s consort, but when you look closely at the temple wall and its statues, you will also notice she is depicted as Mahishasura Mardini^[52] too...”

“Yes, mother, I saw it and was surprised as to why the Goddess was depicted as slaying a bull. Isn’t she the Mother Goddess of our universe who protects everyone?”

“Yes, the temple statue depicts the mother as vanquishing Mahishasura^[53], and after she has conquered this evil demon, she appears peaceful and content. In Mamallapuram, there is a cave with a beautiful statue of Druga Devi who is depicted as fierce, angry, and wrathful, and it makes you wonder why this Goddess who protects this entire world, should she fight a mere bull... And why is she celebrated for vanquishing the bull, of all creatures? Child, there is a deep inherent meaning hidden within the statue, but you need a certain maturity, curiosity, and interest to understand and appreciate it!”

“Devi, I know not if we have the maturity, but we do have the curiosity and interest to hear you explain it to us. Why, even Vandiya Devar is listening to you with rapt attention without looking at someone else,” said Arulmozhi mischievously.

His words drew laughter as everyone knew that he was remarking on Vandiya Devan’s habit of stealing glances at Kundavai.

“Since you all seem interested, I will tell you. Right from the days of yore, you must have heard about the many wars fought between the Devas and Asuras. There are many wars, where Maha Vishnu had to take different avatars to fight against Rakshashas. Right from the time this universe came into existence, the divine and evil forces have been at war. Many ask... Then why did God create the evil forces in the first place? But to find an answer for that question is beyond our capabilities. Maybe it is one of God’s games... we don’t know.

“But we do know that divine and evil forces are constantly at war. Sometimes, it seems as though the Asura forces are winning, and that they would overwhelm all things divine and rule over this world for long. Asuras like Surapadman, Hiranyan, and Ravana ruled over this world for thousands of years. And yet, they did meet their end within minutes!”

“Yes, indeed. The ten-headed Ravana who made slaves out of all the devas, found his end at the hands of a mere mortal and a few

monkeys, who vanquished his race and his seed,” said Madhuranthakar.

“Therefore, when we see the asura forces winning, we should not become discouraged. We should firmly believe that one day, the divine forces would be victorious and fight for dharma and truth, and they will find that God stands with them.”

“Mother! You were telling about Mahishasura,” reminded Poonguzhali.

“Yes, daughter! Thank God you reminded me! There are two types of asura forces that exist in this world. One is witless and the other is intelligent. Our elders classified Mahishasura with the witless. Have you seen the wild bull run amok? The bull gains the strength of an elephant and can savagely kill any animal that comes in its way. These witless Asuras are like that bull. They gain wild strength through their anger and rage. Sometimes, we have seen such witless asuras sit on the throne and rule over us. When Mahishasura sat on the throne of the devas and reigned, there was chaos and confusion in all three worlds. He cast out tomes of literature and arts. Any skill that required us to use our wits were despised and desecrated. He razed to dust many statues, temples, and monumental towers. He asked his asura forces to destroy everything. Devas, ascetics, sages, and men and women trembled with fear.

“Many started worshiping him and accepted his edicts, which only increased Mahishasura’s arrogance and foolishness. It is indeed a deadly combination. When everyone in the world wailed, unable to bear the atrocities of this asura, Durga Parameshwari opened her eyes and took the form of Goddess Maha Kali and vanquished Mahishasura and freed the world from slavery. Devas and even the asuras, heaved a sigh of relief and gave their thanks to Durga Parameshwari.

“My children, even today, such witless asura forces do exist. They say that in the north west direction of Bharata Kadam, such

forces have become active. I heard that they fight with great savagery, putting to sword anybody who opposes them, and have been destroying temples and statues of gods. There is no powerful emperor in the north who can stop these forces! And I hope in this divine land of Tamils, these forces never enter. But if they do, the warriors of our clan must be ready to vanquish them!”

“Yes, mother! We will be ready. What about the second type of asura forces?”

“The second type are intelligent, and use it to do sinful work. They would win boons from the Gods through their penance and use those boons to do evil. What did the Tripuras do? They used their powers to create a world for their own. They would fly to distant kingdoms and lands and destroy them. Soorapadman had a unique power. No matter how many times his head was chopped, another head will appear in its stead. Rakshashas like Ravana, Indrajith, and Kumbhakarna would fly to the clouds, become invisible, and hurl astras at their enemies.

Our elders have classified these asuric forces that are intelligent as ‘Muyalagan’^[54]. Whenever Lord Shiva performs his cosmic dance, you should also remember Muyalagan, who lies at his feet. If the Lord is not careful, Muyalagan might give him the slip and escape. Muyalagan is the very depiction of the fact that divine and evil forces exist, and have been fighting each other for a long time. Children, that’s why we cannot ever say, we don’t want war!”

“Devi, you have explained many things that we never really understood before. Pray, what do you wish us to do?” asked Ponniyin Selvar.

“My children, I can only say that you should always stand for the divine forces and fight against evil. I cannot command you. Only your conscience can command you. So listen to it and act as it commands. A little while ago, you said that pirates have become a menace, terrorising the merchant ships. It is the dharma of the royal warriors like you to vanquish these pirates and provide safe seas for

our merchants. Today, if we ignore these threats, the same pirates will make their way into our lands. If my Lord Husband were here today, he too would give you the same advice!”

“Devi, we have learned your wishes, and we will act accordingly,” said Arulmozhivarmar.

“Ponniyin Selva, if you wish to act as per my wishes, then I would like to say one more thing!”

“Devi, I don’t think I have ever acted contrary to your wishes. If I have done so, do forgive me!”

“Child, there is a difference between how you were earlier, and what you will be tomorrow. Until now, you were the favourite child of this palace and our sweet prince. We would fulfil your whims and fancies, while you would obey and respect our wishes. Tomorrow, you will be crowned the emperor of this realm, after which we are bound to act per your wishes!”

“Mother, please don’t say such things. Even after I become the emperor, I would still be your own sweet child who will listen to your wishes and fulfil them!”

“Then listen to me. This royal line needs to be secured with heirs, because our kings and emperors are always ready to give up their life in the battlefield. But they would always ensure that the clan survives through heirs of their body. Your brother Aditya Karikalan didn’t marry at all, and now this Chola clan can continue only through you. Therefore, before you go to Elangai, you must make arrangements to preserve and perpetuate your clan. Along with your coronation ceremony, prepare to get married as well. You are indeed fortunate to get a wife like Vanathi. Her fortunate stars will act as a shield for you and keep you safe from danger!”

“Devi, I am ready to wear this shield, but it is Vanathi who is refusing me. She says that she has sworn an oath not to ascend the throne with me, and is adamantly refusing to marry me!”

Just then, Poonguzhali unexpectedly interjected and said, “I don’t think you should take the Kodumbalur Princess’s words so seriously. Maybe she expects us all to coax and plead her to accept your hand. Ponniyin Selvar should probably beg a little more...” and the others laughed thinking that it was said playfully, but Vanathi alone started crying.

“Foolish girl! Why are you crying?” exclaimed Kundavai and took her away from there.

Chapter 86: Is This Real or a Dream

The next day, Madhuranthakar, Poonguzhali, and Sembiyanmadevi started for Thanjavur while Ponniyin Selvar and Vandiya Devan had intended to go to Uraiyr and Srirangam. On the way, the prince wanted to show Vandiya Devan the dam built during the time of Karikala Peruvallathan^[55].

Before they started, the prince met Kundavai to take her leave, “Akka, do you really have to go to Pazhaiarai?”

“Thambi, do you really have to go to Uraiyr? Why don’t you come to Pazhaiarai along with us?”

“No akka, we need to meet Azhwarkadiyan Nambi in Uraiyr for an important task!”

“Aha! You have changed a lot. And I suspect it’s due to the company of Vandiya Devar. You do not listen to me at all!”

“Don’t blame him unnecessarily. I am of age, and soon I will be the emperor of this kingdom... Can’t I act on anything independently?”

“Go ahead and act in any way you choose, so long as you do not try to control me or demand that I act according to your wishes...”

“Just come for the coronation ceremony and after that you can do as you please...”

“You can demand my presence after the coronation. But until then, you have no rights to demand anything of me.”

“Then, you are not coming for the coronation?”

“It depends on Vanathi’s wishes. If she wants to go, we will come there!”

“Where is that girl, akka?”

“She has gone to pray to your mother Ponni, and to seek a boon to make you more intelligent and astute!”

The prince laughed out loud and said, “May her prayer be fulfilled. I will take your leave now.”

“Thambi, I am yet to meet a more heartless man than you. Vanathi didn’t sleep at all last night and was crying. Take her leave and go. She is on the banks of Kaveri...”

“It seems like she is not the only one to have lost sleep. She seems to have deprived me of it too. If we cannot understand one another and act accordingly, tears will be the only recourse. And you wish that I marry her and torment my entire life!” said Ponniyin Selvar, moving towards the garden.

Beyond the garden, the river Kaveri flowed. And there on the last step, she was sitting. Beside her was a plate full of flowers, which she was offering one by one to the river goddess.

If she had not been offering those flowers, one might mistake her to be a golden statue. Ponniyin Selvar silently went and sat behind her on the steps. Vanathi must have realized that someone was sitting behind her, and instincts probably told her that it was Ponniyin Selvar, so she stopped offering flowers and instead sat silent.

There were dew drops on the flowers that Vanathi had brought, while her eyes too held two tears that could spill out anytime. The beautiful morning was resplendent with the golden rays of the sun falling on the river, giving an illusion that the waters were sheer silk of green.

The sounds of the river and the gentle sounds of the trees sounded like beautiful music, making the place apt for a romantic tryst. The prince stayed silent for a while and said, "Vanathi! Are you day dreaming? Did I perchance interrupt you?"

"I am probably day dreaming, but how can you interrupt it? Whether I am dreaming in the day or at night, you dominate my dreams. That's why when I see you in flesh, I am taken by surprise, because I know not if you there in reality or if I am still dreaming. That's why many times, I am speechless and fail to 'welcome' you.

"Yes, Swami, I have had many dreams about you. When I first saw you in Thiruvallam gardens, I thought that you were an ordinary mahout. Later, I had many wistful dreams where I had ardently wished that you were just a mahout who would take me along on your elephant. And it wouldn't be an ordinary elephant. It would be Devendran's white elephant Airavatham. And I would imagine you to be Indra and I would be your Indrani..."

"Then now..." Ponniyin Selvar tried to interrupt, but Vanathi stopped him and said, "Patience, my Prince! I would immediately change this imagination. When have Indra and Indrani ever been alone?! And have they ever gone on an elephant together? Aren't they forever surrounded by devas and apsaras? So I would change my imagination and wish that I had been born in the family of fishermen who ply boats for a living!"

"I know Vanathi, you are jealous of Poonguzhali!"

"That is true. I am jealous of Poonguzhali. She has realized her dream. She and her lover will soon go to Kodi Karai, and lead a happy life plying boats and worshipping Lord Kozhagar. And why wouldn't she laugh at me? Ayya, do punish me in any way you see fit... but do not make an object of ridicule for someone like Poonguzhali!"

Ponniyin Selvar now remembered whatever had happened the last night and said, "Vanathi, wait awhile. Today, Poonguzhali might

have laughed at you. But tomorrow there will come a time when you will laugh at her!”

“Swami, I do not wish to laugh at Poonguzhali or at anybody else. Let anyone come and laugh at me, I don’t mind. But I do wish to see a smile on your face sometimes. Whenever you talk to others, your face blossoms, and there is a beautiful smile on your face. But when you see me, your face wears a frown and your forehead is creased. Even now, I am scared of looking at your face!”

“Vanathi, there is a reason for it. When I see the rest of the people, I know that there are hurdles that they can throw my way, nor do I lose my peace of mind because of them. You are the only one who can make me lose my equilibrium.

“My sister said that you didn’t sleep last night. I haven’t slept for many days now. When I lay down at night, I see the stars and they remind of your eyes. When I hear the rustle of the trees, I am reminded of your delightful laughter. When a gentle breeze sweeps over my body, it feels as though you were touching me with your soft fingers, and it gives me rapturous joy.

“Vanathi, I am forever immersed in these thoughts! That’s why, when I meet you for real, I get worried that you might be a hurdle to my plans and deter me from my path. That’s why my face wears a frown when I see you!”

“Swami, you need not fear that ever. I will never become a hurdle for you...”

“You will not be a hurdle, nor can anybody stop me! Have you ever seen a stormy cloud, Vanathi? It will be filled with water and it hides lightning and thunder. The winds take this stormy cloud wherever it wants to go. Can anyone stop that cloud? No! I am just like that cloud.

“Vanathi, I am forever restless. There is something that drives my life. I see lightning in front of my eyes and hear thunder that no one

else hears. Storms, hurricanes, and gales are calling onto me. Hundreds of waves in the deep sea are issuing an invitation to me. I hear the trumpet of elephants, banging of drums, fifes, horses... they are calling onto me. Indeed, no one can stop me but they can try and make me lose my peace!”

“Swami, I will never stop you from doing anything that you like, nor will I attempt to create a hurdle. If I cannot help you in anyway, I will definitely not become a hurdle for you. That’s why I am refusing to sit beside you on the Chola throne...”

“Vanathi, though the Chola throne is great in glory, it is indeed small in size and it can accommodate only one person. Traditionally, for the empress, another throne will be placed next to mine!”

“Swami, I do not wish to sit beside you or on another throne next to yours. I do not wish to be the empress. Whoever is fortunate enough to deserve that honour can have it. But I do crave a place in your heart’s throne. And if I get it, I would consider myself the most fortunate being of the three worlds!”

“Vanathi, you have indeed asked me for something that I can easily give. You have already carved a place for yourself in my heart. I have no objection to giving it to you. But don’t you really wish to become the empress of this kingdom? Don’t you really want the empress’s crown that amazes everyone with its gold glitter? Wouldn’t you want it on your head?”

“I have no such wish. I have seen the ancient coronation crowns of the Chola emperors and I have held them in my hand too. If I were to bear them on my head, I would truly faint. I do not have the strength in my body or my soul to bear that burden.

“Swami, may those who have that fortitude of heart bear its burden. Before you go on your victory campaign, I seek another gift from you. I will gather the flowers from around the palace garden and make a garland out of them. Do garland me with it and make me your slave and then take your leave...”

“I bought a navaratna necklace from the Chinese merchants and I had thought of giving it to you as a coronation gift... Alright, I will give it off to somebody else, then. Vanathi! Let’s come to a compromise. I will gift you a garland before I leave. But whenever I leave and return, you must be there to welcome me with a garland. When I return victorious, I want you waiting here with a garland for me,” said the prince.

“Why only one garland? I will be here waiting with hundreds of garlands and so will the people of this kingdom...” said Vanathi.

Chapter 87: The Poet's Astonishment

As the date of coronation neared, the people were waiting with bated breath to participate in the festivities and see their beloved prince finally crowned as the emperor. There were no two opinions about his succession. Everyone – whether they be old, young, townsfolk or from the village, merchants, or farmers – only wanted the prince to become their emperor. They would endlessly appreciate the fortunate stars under which he was born, and the way he becomes one among them whenever he meets the people. It wouldn't be amiss to compare this to Rama's coronation day.

Kambar^[56] describes their reactions thus; Elderly women had become like Kausalya, and were excited as though their own son was getting crowned. All young women became like Seetha, as though their own husbands were becoming the king, and were keen on decking themselves with beautiful ornaments. All the old men became like Dasaratha, proud that their son would reign as king.

It does make us wonder what Rama had accomplished to gain the goodwill of people. Truly, whatever he achieved happens at a later point of time in the epic. It would be years before he would vanquish Ravana and free the world from his evil reign. Though, at the time of his coronation, the only great deed that he had performed was to vanquish the demons who were disturbing Sage Vishwamitra's penance. But there, too, the people didn't really know what had happened, nor did the sage come back to Ayodhya to tell the people about Rama's prowess.

In this world, there are those who win people's hearts through their benevolent actions. There are some who earn respect through their talent by singing, dancing, painting, or sculpting. There are some others who are loved and respected right from their birth and, with no reason or rhyme, people have great love and affections for

them. They have an inherent attraction and a magnetism that charms people instantly. This makes many people wonder thus.

Mother nature is indeed partial to this person!

But when God gives a magnetic personality to someone, he also throws many challenges and hurdles their way.

Rama who had won the hearts of the Ayodhya people, was subjected to great sorrows that no ordinary man would experience. Didn't he lose his kingdom and get banished and exiled to a dangerous forest? He also lost his lovely wife to a demon. Didn't he experience indescribable sorrows?

Just like Rama, Prince Arulmozhi too had the blessing of magnetic personality. His handsome mien charmed the people. His easy-going manners and the way he mingled with everyone without any thought of status or rank endeared him to people. Though he didn't get much opportunity to perform brave deeds in Elangai, many mythical and exaggerated tales about his bravado and adventures had spread across the kingdom, and it was not surprising that people were ready to believe in them.

Right from the time Sundara Chola became paralyzed, the people in the kingdom were worried that there will be problems in the succession of the next emperor. Soon enough, there were rumours spreading through the kingdom that the Pazhuvur brothers, Sambuvarayar, and other noble lords were conspiring to crown Madhuranthakar as the next emperor. At that time, the only thing that people knew about Maduranthakar was that, just like his father, he had renounced the material world and was deeply immersed in Shiva devotion.

Right from the times of Vijayalaya Chola, the people had seen great prosperity thanks to the victory campaigns of their great kings who brought trade and wealth back to the kingdom. Proud of their kings and their brave deeds, the people knew that the quality of their life would improve only if the border of the kingdom spread far and

wide. And they were worried if such aspirations would come to pass under the reign of Madhuranthakar, and feared that if he were to take the throne, the kingdom would be under the control of noble lords.

Though the people had great respect and regard for Aditya Karikalan, they were not very enthusiastic about his ascension, either. Karikalan didn't have an easy personality, nor did he mingle with the people. Apart from this, there were many mysterious rumours about him that took wings. Many believed that he had committed a sin and was feeling guilty about it, and that he had lost the his own father's affection and regard due to that. This and many other stories about Karikalan were floating around. When he died, the people paid their respects that was due to a great warrior, but didn't spend much moping around for his death. They blamed the ill-fated comet for his death and moved on with their life.

Periya Pazhuvetarayar's death and the manner in which it occurred had inspired great respect for him among the people. The truth about Nandini's associations with the Pandya Abathuuthavigal was now known to the people, and they pitied Pazhuvetarayar for falling under the charms of Nandini's mystic beauty. They now knew that it was through her influence that Pazhuvetarayar had conspired against Sundara Chola's sons. And after learning the truth about Nandini, his redemptive actions of accepting the blame and ending his own life as atonement for his sins had gained the people's sympathy. And before he died, he had commanded the noble lords to drop the idea of crowning Madhuranthakar, and asked them to support Ponniyin Selvar instead. This endeared the old man to the people because he had paved a way to fulfil their heart's desire.

So they would hail him thus! May his memory remain eternal! May his clan flourish and continue forever! Thus the people remembered the old man with great appreciation and gratitude.

The people didn't realize that the old Madhuranthakar had been replaced by a new man. Only the royal family, courtiers, chieftains, and noble lords knew about this. The old Madhuranthkar rarely ventured out of the palace. And even if he did, mingling with the

people was out of question. Shy and reticent by nature, he had stayed away from the people. After the noble lords started conspiring for his ascension, they would take him around in a veiled palanquin, therefore there was no opportunity for the people to make note of his appearance and notice any recognizable features. Therefore, they had no inkling that the old Madhuranthakar was replaced.

Therefore, those who saw the new Madhuranthakar at Thiruvaiyaru didn't know that he was the newly acknowledged son of Sembiyanmadevi. Though his wife, Poonguzhali, attracted the people's attention. Some said that she was Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter while others corrected them and said that she was a boat girl whom Madhuranthakar married recently.

Since it was a common practice for members of the royal family and kings to marry multiple times, the people were not surprised to hear this. There was also a rumour that Madhuranthakar refused to accept the throne despite the instigation of the noble lords, and this inspired their respect for him. And when they saw him in Thiruvaiyaru, looking dignified, calm, and devout, their respect for him increased ten-fold. There was also a rumour that he had refused the throne due to his love for the boat girl Poonguzhali. Therefore they expected Ponniyin Selvar to grant his uncle a prestigious position after his coronation.

People started arriving in Thanjavur two days before the coronation. Soon, there was a sea of people assembled outside the Thanjavur fort. The fort doors were open for all and there were no restrictions for entry or exit. The court officials feared that it would be difficult to manage the crowd if they had tried to postpone the coronation date. And for the people who had started to assemble, they tried to arrange for food and accommodation outside the fort.

Kodumbalur Vellar sent back his huge army upon orders from Ponniyin Selvar. He held back just a thousand soldiers with him, though. The army that the supporters of the Pazhuvur brother had gathered near Kudanthai was also dispersed and sent back. The

guards that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar would normally have under his command were there to guard the fort.

Vellar, Pazhuvur, and the Velkarar soldiers came together in a rare camaraderie celebrating the ascension of Ponniyin Selvar, and indulged in fun and sporting activities to the delight of the masses. They also helped the people who were coming to the capital from all over the kingdom.

The entire Thanjavur city and its outskirts were decorated beautifully and it wouldn't be a stretch of imagination if one can say that it resembled Amaravathi, Indra's city of Gods. Every family was hosting several guests at their home, as more and more people came to the capital.

Finally the sun rose on the coronation day!

The bright sun and its rays dissipated the mist and shone brilliantly on the sky, leading wise elderly women to say, 'Today is Ponniyin Selvar's coronation day, that's why the sun is also glowing gold!'

Hours before the appointed time, crowds started gathering outside the mandapam where the coronation would take place, because it would be impossible to allow everybody inside. After the coronation, as per the royal tradition, the newly crowned emperor will come around the city on the royal elephant and greet his people. But some people wanted to witness the coronation ceremony too, therefore they selected right vantage points outside the mandapam and waited.

There was a special entrance at the back of the mandapam for the royal family and their courtiers. Soon, Sundara Cholar, Vanamadevi, Sembianmadevi, Madhuranthakar, Poonguzhali, Kundavai Devi and Vanathi came to the mandapam through this entrance. But Prime Minister Anirudhar, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, Sambuvarayar, Periya Vellar, Thirukkoyalur Malayaman and other chieftains, court officials, fort commanders, prominent merchants of

the guild, Shiva gurus, head priests of Vishnu temples, royal poets, and court scribes had to push themselves through the crowd and reach the mandapam with great difficulty. Lastly, when Ponniyin Selvar and Vandiya Devan arrived on an open chariot shaped like a lotus, the crowd raised a clamour that could only be compared to thunderous roar of the sea and its waves.

The coronation ceremony commenced officially. The court officials ceremoniously brought the huge decorated plate on which was placed the coronation crown, jewelled aaram studded with precious stones, the royal sword and the sceptre held by the emperor, and went around the mandapam to seek the blessings of the elders who touched these items with reverence.

After this, the royal poet Nallan Santhamar rose, and behind him stood a woman who started stringing the yazh. In accompaniment to the yazh, the poet started singing poems heralding the greatness of Chola Kings, and started recounting brave and glorious deeds of each king in their lineage.

Since these poems were very long, we present a summary of what he sang here –

There was once an emperor named Sibi, who was born a scion of the Sun Dynasty and Manumantha's clan. This emperor kept his word to a mere pigeon and saved its life by cutting his own flesh. The kings from his lineage, took the titular name 'Sembiyan' to honour his memory. In this lineage, there came a king called 'Rajakesari' and his son won glories and became known as 'Parakesari.' The glory of these kings were such that the generations of kings who came after them were known as 'Korajakesari' or 'Koparakesari'. This clan is also fortunate to have a king like Manu Needhi Cholan, whose sense of justice was supreme, so much so that he didn't hesitate to sentence his own son to death just to give justice to a cow. After Manu Nidhi Cholan, there appeared Karikala Peruvellathan in Poompuhar, who took his huge army to the north and conquered the Himalayas and planted our flag on its highest peak. In his lineage appeared kings like Nallankilli, Nedunkilli,

Perunkilli, Kurapallithunjiya Killivallavan, Kullamurathuthunjiya Killivallavan and also the great shiva devotee, Koperuncholan, who were as devout as they were brave and attained the abode of Shiva on their death.

Just as the sun's glory was dimmed when it went behind clouds occasionally, the Pandyas and Pallavas could cloud our glories of the kings who have appeared in the sun dynasty. But these clouds went missing when our glorious Vijayalaya Chola appeared like Lord Indra bearing his thunderbolts! When Mutharaiyan saw this tiger, his rat-like forces gave up their arms and scurried away. After vanquishing them, that brave king captured Thanjavur and raised a Durga Parameshwari temple. Scores of messengers would be found in the courtyard of Thanjavur palace, bearing messages from Pallavas and Pandyas, who wanted to ally with this brave king. He helped many of these kings and won their wars for them, and gained 96 scars on his body! Vijayalaya's son, Aditya Cholar, was just like his namesake – the sun, whose very presence would dissolve the enemy clouds. At Thirupurambayam, like a tiger, he plunged into the heart of the enemy forces and vanquished the Pandyas. Later, when the Pallava King Aparajithan betrayed him despite the help rendered to him, he raised a huge army and went all the way to Thondaimandalam and slew this king by springing upon his elephant. Just like his ancestor Kochenganna, he built 72 shrines for Lord Shiva all the way from the origin of River Kaveri to Poompuhar.

And just like his father, Paranthaka Chola was born bearing Vijayalakshmi and Veeralakshmi^[57] on his shoulders. This emperor ousted the Pandyas in Vellore and conquered Madurai and Elangai and vanquished the Cheras. In the north, the Ganga Kings and the Rashtrakutas, trembled in fear when they heard the name of Paranthaka. Driven by envy, Kannara Devan from Erattai Mandalam raised a huge army that can only be compared to the seven seas, and came to test the mettle of emperor Paranthakan. Paranthakar's eldest son and the crown prince Rajadhithar took his army to a Thakkolam to fight in a war that can be compared to the likes Mahabharata war. He vanquished the great army of Kannara Devan,

and had a glorious warrior's death atop his elephant. The great emperor Paranthaka was called to the abode of Shiva after he emptied his treasury to gild the roof of the Chidambaram temple. His illustrious son, the devout Gandaraditha Devar, served the kingdom and Lord Shiva with great devotion. After his time, his dear brother Aringzhan Chola freed Thondai Mandalam from the clutches of our enemies and extended the empire all the way to Seetpuli Kingdom, and then gave up his life unable to live anymore without his brother.

Next came Sundara Cholar, who made the Veera Pandya go back to the same hole in which he was hiding from the ferocious tigers, and established peace in the kingdom. And under his glorious reign, people lived happily and prosperously.

Ponniyin Selvar is born in this lineage and from the loins of such glorious tigers, and there are indeed no words to describe him. Only the Goddess Saraswathi should come here to sing his praises because an ordinary poet like me cannot do justice to it..."

Thus Nallan Santhamar finished his poem about the Cholas. After him, poets from the North, Buddha Bikshus, Siva Gurus, and Vaishnava Gurus awaited their turn to sing and bless the new emperor. The royal priests were now worried and wondered how they could expediate the ceremonies, because the appointed time for coronation was nearing.

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar was also one of the people who worried thus. The commander was ready to crown Ponniyin Selvar with his own hands. While he restlessly worried about the poets and the elapsing time, he noticed that someone had suddenly appeared by his side. Many noticed him, and wondered how he could have come inside the Mandapam braving the thronging crowds that stood outside. But Vandiya Devan was not surprised to see him, and he also knew who that man was. It was Azhwarkadiyan Nambi in disguise. Right after he appeared, Vandiya Devan looked at Ponniyin Selvar who understood his signal.

We know not what news Azhwarkadiyan Nambi gave Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, because his expression changed immediately and he became extremely worried and anxious. He hesitated for a second and took the Nambi aside, where there was less crowd.

Noticing this, Ponniyin Selvar, who until then was listening intently to Nallan Santhanar in salutation, now said, "Dear poet! Until now you regaled us with tales of glories of my ancestors. Pray tell me, what have I accomplished to earn the right to sit on this glorious throne? And since Goddess Saraswathi is unlikely to appear here, you could try and tell everyone what my accomplishments are!"

The poet stood astonished, and didn't know what to say. Ponniyin Selvar then looked at him and said, "Ayya, I am not surprised that you are speechless and astonished. You are unable to sing my praises, because I haven't done anything so far that would merit a song or a poem. I am yet to begin my work..."

Chapter 88: The Coronation

Ponniyin Selvar continued speaking to the poet and said, “Ayya! Let me ask you one more thing. You listed my long lineage, right from Emperor Sibi. These glories are borne by those who are fortunate to be born in this clan, and Gandaradithar’s son and my uncle, Madhuranthaka Devar, has an equal claim in these glories!”

The poet accepted the prince’s argument and agreed by nodding his head. Many others in the mandapam too nodded, and turned to look at Madhuranthakar, who was seated next to Sundara Cholar. Madhuranthakar couldn’t stand the intense scrutiny of those who looked at him as though they were seeing him for the first time. Unable to bear their stares, Madhuranthakar looked down.

In the meanwhile, Azhwarkadiyan Nambi had delivered a worrying bit of news to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. The Nambi had seen Rakkammal – the boatman Murugayyan’s wife who was associated with the Pandya Abathuuthavigal – in the crowds that were entering the city for the coronation. Curious to know why she had arrived there, the Nambi followed her. But she disappeared in the crowds that had gathered outside Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s palace. While he looked around hoping to spot her, she reappeared again. And this time, there was another woman with her, who was carrying a child on her waist. And since the other woman resembled Chinna Pazhuvetarayar’s daughter, he didn’t know what to do, nor could he confirm that it was indeed the commander’s daughter. So he decided to follow them at a distance and confirm.

It was very difficult to follow them through the crowds, and Rakkammal must have sensed that he was following her, because she suddenly stopped amidst the crowds and screamed, “Ayyo! This man is troubling us! He is following us!” Immediately, the crowd turned to Azhwarkadiyan, and proceeded to chide him for his immoral behaviour.

Azhwarkadiyan had to promise them that he had indeed come there to watch the coronation, and that he was not troubling any woman. By the time he could pacify the crowd and get out of there, Rakkammal and the other woman had vanished. Azhwarkadiyan went all the way to the fort entrance, searching for them. And near the entrance, he saw the women get into a veiled palanquin. Four horsemen surrounded the palanquin and its bearers, and they left the place immediately. While Azhwarkadiyan was wondering whether to follow them, a huge crowd entered the fort, and the tide brought him all the way to the coronation mandapam. Deciding that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had to know this immediately, with great difficulty, the Nambi had entered the mandapam and approached him. The Nambi further said that he had been tasked by Ponniyin Selvar to wear a disguise and mingle among the crowds to know what they were saying.

While he was at it, he had seen Rakkammal and started following her. Only after this explanation did Chinna Pazhuvetarayar started believing him completely. He had already been worried about his daughter, the old Madhuranthakan's wife, and Azhwarkadiyan's news scared him greatly. He was now determined to go to his palace and check out the truth. He immediately left a message with the prime minister and requested him to explain to the emperor and to Ponniyin Selvar, and exited the mandapam expediently.

Azhwarkadiyan didn't have to explain to Ponniyin Selvar about this, because the prince was watching them intently even while he was speaking to Nallan Santhanar. The minute Chinna Pazhuvetarayar left the mandapam, the prince's face brightened. He turned towards his father and, with a majestic bearing, addressed him thus, "It looks like our Commander Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had to go on an important errand, but this coronation ceremony need not be postponed because of that. There are many other elders in this mandapam, great warriors who have bled for this kingdom and noble lords who have strived hard for this kingdom, who have earned their right to bless this crown and sceptre with their blessed hands. And therefore, even if I tried to crown myself with mine own hands, it

wouldn't be wrong. But before I do that, father, I would like to place a petition before all those who have gathered here.

"I am from the lineage of Emperor Sibi, who gave his flesh to save the life of a pigeon. Therefore, I claim the rights to call myself 'Sembian'. I am also from the lineage of Manu Needhi Cholan, who didn't hesitate to sentence his son to death so that he could provide justice to the cow whose calf his son had killed. Just as our ancestors have never fled a battlefield, they are also remembered for imparting justice. Born in a race that has seen such illustrious kings, how can I act in a manner that would put them to shame? How can I snatch a thing or position that should rightfully belong to another person?

"When our royal poet sang about my ancestors, they came in front of me like a vision and I could see countless Rajakesari and Parakesari, and all the great kings of my lineage. In one voice, they asked me one question, 'Son! Think again, are you really the rightful heir for this kingdom?'

"My ancestors, Vijayalaya, Aditya, Paranthaka, and Rajadhithar looked at me proudly and asked, 'Son! What have you done to deserve this throne? Tell us some of your brave deeds!'

"I was hesitant at first to respond to them, and then I fortified my heart and said, 'Dear kings and emperors, I haven't done even one great deed that you have accomplished for this kingdom. But with your blessings, I will begin my work today. I am determined to follow all that you have accomplished to make this kingdom great! And not just that, I will do things that hitherto no one has attempted, so that our future generations will be amazed at what we have achieved. I will perform such deeds that will make you proud to have me as your descendant,'. When I told my ancestors this, they smiled at me and blessed me..."

Those who heard Ponniyin Selvar's rousing speech had goosepimples rise in their body. And one of them raised a hail, 'Vettri

Vel' 'Veera Vel'^[58] 'which was picked up by everybody and the crowds waiting outside too hailed thus.

Even Ponniyin Selvar joined them and hailed the same. And after the shouts died down, he said, "Father this inspiring hail was once heard beyond the rivers Tungabhadra and Krishna during the times of your grandfather Paranthakar. Kingdoms beyond these rivers – the Vengi, Kalyan and Manya – would tremble in their limbs to hear our warriors hail thus. Many hundreds of thousands of our soldiers went in all directions in ships along with the merchants to defend them against pirates. Dear father, ever since your health failed, the tone of this victorious hail has come down. Our enemies are raising their heads from all four directions. The kings of Vengi, Kalingam, Kalyanpuram Manya Kedamum are challenging us. They are not thinking about the invaders who are coming into our lands through the north. Instead, they are driven by envy over our beautiful lands. In Elangai, Mahindan is still rallying his forces. Even if Veera Pandyan is dead, they will be on the lookout for someone from his clan and will crown them as the next Pandya king.

"Mahindan and Pandya Abathuuthavigal joined hands and slew my brave brother Aditya Karikalan, who can only be compared to the likes of Abhimanyu and Aravanan^[59]. In the west, the Chera King is readying a huge fleet of ships and an elephant army force. He is being helped by some from the west, who are building his fleet. These are new dangers that our kingdom faces today.

"Dear father, for a long time, the Arabs were great sea traders. They went all the way to the China mainland to trade, and they would often come to our shores to barter and trade their wares. These old Arab traders were courteous and generous, but it seems like they have either been eliminated or subjugated by a new breed of Arabs. And we know not if they are from the same region or from nearby kingdoms, but their savagery is indescribable. I witnessed it myself. While in Elangai, upon your commands, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar sent two ships to imprison me and to bring me back...."

Sundara Chola now interjected and asked, “My son, do you know why I sent them?”

“Father, I know why you sent them. There was confusion about the succession here, and many rumours about Pandya Abathuuthavigal who were seeking revenge... you wanted me to come back to you safe and sound, therefore you sent those ships. It was the proof of the love and affection that you bore towards me. I mentioned it here so that everyone here knows about it. There were over hundreds of our sailors who had an encounter with just ten of these Arab pirates. They were attacked most unexpectedly, and were cut down with such savagery that I can never forget it. Now, I am hearing that these new Arabs are indeed helping the Chera King build his new fleet. And not just them, even the Kalinga King is inviting them to build their ships. Their intent is clear. They wish to destroy our monopoly on the sea trade. It doesn't matter if these pirates are Arabs or from the Chera Kingdom with whom we have had many ties in the past! But our goal should be to defend our interests. To do so, we need to increase our fleets and build new ships and train our soldiers to be sailors so that they are able to fight bravely with these pirates. We need to capture the lands in the high seas and plant our tiger flag there and station our soldiers in these lands. Dear father, I have made a promise to our ancestors that I will accomplish all this. And I need your approval and that of the elders who are in this sabhai^[60]!”

After Ponniyin Selvar asked thus, Sundara Chola said, “Dear son, will I ever stop you from winning glories for our kingdom? And will the elders here ever stop you from defending our merchants and their trade?”

Hearing this, the victorious hail that was heard before started again.

“Father, you will not create a hurdle or stop me... and nor will the elders in this Sabha do that. Instead, you will bless me and send me on this campaign. But if I have to be victorious in this, my heart and mind need to be at peace. I should be convinced that I haven't done

anything that my ancestors would consider as being dishonest. I need to reassure myself that I have not grabbed something that belongs to someone else. If I do something that my conscience will not agree with, then no matter where I go, I will be plagued by guilt. How will I fight with all my vigour or be convinced that I am performing my dharma? Even earlier, there was a rumour that spread in the kingdom about me trying to usurp the Elangai throne...”

“Child, no one believed in that rumour. We know that you will not ever do such a thing,” said the emperor.

“I know that you wouldn’t believe it. But when I heard this rumour, it did indeed cause me great pain. When the Elangai Bikshus offered the throne to me, two of my friends were beside me who witnessed the fact that I had rejected it!”

The Buddha Bikshus who were in the Sabha then acknowledged the prince’s statement and said, “Yes, we were present there, too, and we know that he rejected the throne!”

“This mere rumour caused me so much pain. While I was happy that you wouldn’t believe it, there were many who believed it to be true. And now, if I were to usurp the throne that rightly belonged to another, how do you think I would feel? All through my life, I will be berating myself for doing a deed that would put my clan to shame. With this burden in my heart, I would never be able to perform any great deeds...”

For a long time, Madhuranthaka Devar who had been looking down, now looked up and tried to say something. Noticing this, Ponniyin Selvar signalled to Vandiya Devan, who immediately went and stood next to Madhuranthakar and whispered in his ears, “Friend, what’s the first line of the first Devaram song that Sundaramurthy Nayanar sang^[3] ever?

Madhuranthakar looked at him with great astonishment, and wondered what sort question this was, too at such a time! And yet,

he couldn't help but answer, "Pitha^[4] Pirai Soodi!"

Vandiya Devan feigned anger and said, "What is this? Are you calling me 'Pitha'? Aren't you the one who is in the grip of madness for a woman? Look at your wife, she is laughing at you!"

Wondering why Vandiya Devan was now baiting him for a fight, Madhuranthakar turned towards the women present in the hall. But his wife and the rest of the women were watching Ponniyin Selvar with rapt attention. When he looked at Ponniyin Selvar, this time, he had in his hands the ancient coronation crown of the Cholas.

"Commander Chinna Pazhuvetarayar is not back yet. But not to worry, I will perform the coronation ceremony myself. Father, you gave me this crown, worn by the legendary Vijayalaya Chola. Noble lords, chieftains, commanders, and the people agreed and approved this act of yours. So now, this crown is mine. And I have the right to use it in any way that I choose. There is someone here who is more worthy of this crown. He is older than me. And despite having more rights on this crown, he didn't claim it, and was instead happy to see me being crowned. He once saved my life and also the life of my dear friend, and saved this royal clan from utter destruction.

"I haven't done anything so glorious for our kingdom yet. Therefore, I crown Emperor Gandaradithar's son and my uncle Madhuranthakar Devar as the next emperor!"

Saying thus, Ponniyin Selvar went up to Madhuranthakar, who was seated next to the emperor, and placed the crown on his head. Fearing that Madhuranthakar might object to this, Vandiya Devan had placed both his hands on his shoulders lest he moved. But Madhuranthakar was speechless, and seemed incapable of any reaction except looking around him in bewilderment.

After placing the crown on his uncle's head, Ponniyin Selvar now hailed him, "Long live Koparakesari Madhuranthaka Uttama Chola!"

And soon, others followed him. “Long live Emperor Uttama Cholar!”

The prime minister, who was also taken aback by the turn of events, now started hailing him. The emperor was so overwrought with emotion that he couldn’t speak or hail. Instead, he showered his cousin with flowers that he held in his hands.

Following his lead, the womenfolk too showered him with flowers. Madhuranthakar, after recovering from his surprise, went up to his mother and sought her blessings. The dowager queen blessed him with tears welling up in her eyes and said, “Son, if this is what Lord Shiva has planned for you, who are we to refuse it?”

Ponniyin Selvar now turned towards the poets and said, “Now, you can change your poems and hails accordingly!” And they started composing new poems to hail the new emperor.

Within a short period of time, the news that Madhuranthakar was crowned as the new emperor spread among the crowds gathered there. Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan Nambi were responsible for this. They had stationed their men among the crowds, and as instructed, they roused the crowd to hail, “Long live Koparakesari Madhuranthaka Uttama Chola”. They also spread the news that Ponniyin Selvar had crowned his uncle as the next emperor and would soon build a fleet start a victory campaign. Some believed this instantly, and said that indeed only someone as benevolent as Ponniyin Selvar would act thus. While others dismissed the news as a mere rumour and said, ‘Who would reject a kingdom that is handed to them?’ And yet, that didn’t reduce the enthusiasm of the people. They too started hailing the new emperor.

Soon, the royal elephant was brought to the coronation hall. The elephant had been beautifully decorated with a golden seat on which Madhuranthakar was seated. Ponniyin Selvar himself became the mahout of the elephant and sat at its neck, riding it. Watching this spectacle, the enthusiasm of the crowd crossed all limits. They

shouted themselves hoarse ‘Long live Koparakesari Madhuranthaka Uttama Chola!’

Though they hailed the new emperor, it was Ponniyin Selvar and his noble deed that had captured their hearts. Therefore, they displayed an enthusiasm that was beyond imagination; a hundred times more than what would be expressed if Ponniyin Selvar had indeed been crowned.

Many extolled his actions as being greater than that of Karikalar, who had planted the tiger flag on the highest peak of Himalayas, and they hailed Ponniyin Selvar as the very ‘epitome of sacrifice’. The ordinary populace didn’t wait for the poets to create artistic verses. They were in a blissful state when they saw Ponniyin Selvar and the new emperor seated on the elephant. They went along with the elephant, singing, dancing, hailing, and showering them with flowers and akshadhajai^[61].

It was indeed very difficult the manoeuvre the elephant through the crowds. But Ponniyin Selvar was in no hurry. He moved through the crowds slowly and participated in the festivities. And wherever he recognized someone he knew, he would speak to them. The procession finally ended in the early hours of the dusk. The prince took the elephant through the palace streets, and suddenly there was a shower of flowers. He looked up.

“Mahout! Mahout!” called out a beautiful voice, and he found Vanathi’s lovely face smiling down at him.

“Girl, no need to be scared. The reign of Madhuranthaka Uttama Chola will see the elephant and tiger walking together, and the cat and the pigeon will be affectionate towards each other...” said Ponniyin Selvar, smiling.

Chapter 89: The Spring Came Back

More than a month and a half had passed since the coronation of Uttama Cholar. The winter season was ending, and spring had arrived on a chariot of gentle soothing winds. Parrots sat on mango trees as though comparing the colour of their noses with the scintillating red rays of the sun. The sun streamed through the Arasa Maram^[62], and gentle winds seemed to move it to the rhythm of some unknown music. The beautiful flower buds of Punnai Maram^[63] fell down to the earth and they resembled pearls of the deep sea.

Mother earth felt rejuvenated and awakened with her senses tingling in happiness. The trees that had become bare during the winter with nary a leaf or a flower now started bearing flowering buds. Creepers of jasmine flowers could be found winding their way through trees, unable to bear the burden of the flowering buds.

The water level in most rivers had gone down, and rivers became placid resembling a mirror.

The people of the Chola kingdom were happy and content. The farmers had harvested their fields and had stored their grains in the granary. There was no more confusion or indecisiveness about political matters, and that had eliminated worry from the people's lives.

People were getting ready to celebrate the spring festival, the 'Festival of Kama'. The temples, too, were readying for this festival while in all villages, stages were being built to stage plays.

Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan watched all these sights as he made his way to Pazhaiarai. This time around, he didn't have to hide or disguise himself to enter the city. He entered through the main gates of the city and reached Princess Kundavai's palace. Kundavai, along with Vanathi and all their companions, came to the palace entrance to give him a formal welcome. Kundavai then asked him to

rest and refresh himself awhile and then come to the palace gardens to meet her.

It didn't take long for Vandiya Devan to do that. After a refreshing bath and partaking food, he hastened to the palace gardens, where Kundavai was waiting for him. It's indeed tough to determine who was more eager to meet whom. They both were eager to exchange news about many things that had happened around them, but that was not the only reason for their eagerness. They were also keen to talk about their future and decide what they would do next. The spring that inspired romance in all things played around with their hearts too, and increased their ardent desires to see one another.

"Ayya, I learned that you didn't achieve complete success in your task," commented Kundavai.

"That's true Devi, and when have I ever achieved complete success in any task that I have accepted?" said Vandiya Devan with a heavy sigh.

"Don't say that. You brought my brother all the way from Elangai. That's the only reason why our kingdom escaped many disasters!"

"I exposed him to unnecessary danger, and he got the shivering fever and almost died. If not for Poonguzhali Maharani, we wouldn't have escaped with our lives. I handed the prince to Senthana Amuthan and Poonguzhali, and asked them to take him to Nagapattinam. But I never imagined that they would come back to Thanjavur and ascend the throne!"

"I will never forget that it was you who saved Uttama Cholar's life, and neither does he forget it. That's why he wants to make you the Lord Treasurer of the Chola Kingdom, the same post that our Periya Pazhuvetarayar held!"

"Please spare me..."

“Why do you say that? The post of Dhanadhigari is a position of great importance and honour. It is more powerful than the post of a commander, and even the prime minister. The emperor himself cannot make any decision without consulting the Lord Treasurer!”

“Devi, I once hid in the treasure chamber of Periya Pazhuvetarayar. There, among the piles of gold coins, I saw a spider’s web that was weaved on a man’s skull. That’s when I decided that I would never go back to that treasure chamber ever...”

Kundavai smiled at him and said, “Even if you become the Lord Treasurer, you don’t have to go to that treasure chamber again. Arulmozhi has decided to spend all the gold that had been hoarded there to build his fleet of ships, and has gotten the emperor’s approval as well...”

“I heard in Thanjavur that the new emperor, the empress and Arulmozhivarmar have gone to Kodi Karai...”

“Yes, they were very much disappointed about not being able to take you along with them!”

“I am not disappointed. I can always join them in Kodi Karai even now. However, I am sad that the prince married the Kodumbalur princess in my absence!”

“Why? Aren’t you happy that your friend got married to my friend?”

“My God! I didn’t say it like that. I am disappointed because I missed the wedding. Arulmozhi is indeed lucky to marry a girl like Vanathi. And your friend is equally fortunate to have married someone like the prince. But why so much haste?”

“That was my doing. My parents wanted to start for Kanchi, and I wanted them to get married before they left. This also satisfied Kodumbalur Vellar, and helped him recover from the shock of what

happened at the coronation. It was a huge blow to him, when Arulmozhi placed the crown on Uttama Cholar's head!"

"Indeed, it must have shocked many people!"

"Of course, we were all surprised. You friends had kept this plan very confidential..."

"Devi, I thought that he might have told this at least to you..."

"Until a few months ago, he might have told me. My brother never used to do anything without consulting me!"

"Why has he changed so much?"

"It's because of the company that he keeps! What else? He has now become an expert in hiding things and scheming intrigues..."

"Devi, don't blame me for this. Your brother was solely responsible for crowning Uttama Cholar. It was his plan, entirely. I tried to argue with him and told him that he shouldn't be deceiving everyone thus. But he countered me saying that even Rama deceived the people of Ayodhya when he left for the forest in the dead of the night. I told him that we should tell this to you at least, but he said that he wanted to do something in his life without consulting you first and earn your praises later. Devi, were you happy with what the prince did?"

"I am very happy indeed. No one else can do anything that would make me happier. And do accept my gratitude for helping him with this..."

"Devi, I thought that you were eager to see your brother ascend the throne and rule this kingdom!"

"I did have such aspirations earlier. But ever since my friend Vanathi took a vow not to ascend the throne, I changed my mind. Moreover, I was also worried about what the people would say if the

younger brother took the throne soon after the death of the older brother...”

“Yes, Devi! The tragic history of Elangai kings and their violent race to the throne influenced him greatly. But he was willing to forget that and ascend the throne just to save me from a death sentence. Thankfully, Periya Pazhuvetarayar took those charges upon his head and saved my life.”

“Yes... it is rather unfortunate. The entire Chola Kingdom misses the presence of that valiant old man!”

“It is doubly unfortunate that we have lost his brother as well...”

“Ayyo! Is he really dead? Are you sure?” asked Kundavai.

“When I took leave from him, he was barely alive. It would indeed be extraordinary for anyone to survive after falling from such heights. And when I think that, in a way, I was responsible for his death... my heart breaks!”

“Ayya, can you tell me in detail what happened that day at the coronation? I know that my brother and you had planned to remove Chinna Pazhuvetarayar from the coronation hall. Tell me what happened from then on. I couldn’t ask this to my brother, so I thought I would check with you. You both hid this plan from me because you didn’t think that a woman could keep your secret. At least now you can tell me!”

“Devi, that wasn’t the reason why we didn’t take you into confidence. Your brother wanted to do something spectacular and surprise you!”

“I wasn’t really all that surprised by what you both did. I did suspect that you were up to something, and was worried lest there was some mistake.”

“To tell you the truth, we did make a few mistakes. Though we achieved our goal, we couldn’t avoid certain repercussions. If we had taken you into confidence, maybe we could have avoided these mistakes!” said Vandiya Devan and described to Kundavai in detail how they had planned to crown Madhuranthakar as Uttama Cholar, and the intrigues and strategy they employed to make it happen.

The prince knew that if he had announced earlier that he wanted to crown Madhuranthakar, there would be many objections again. Kodumbalur Vellar and Thirukkovalur Malayaman would oppose the idea again. Periya Pazhuvetarayar, in the throes of his death, had asked them to crown Ponniyin Selvar as the emperor, and his supporters and associates would want to fulfil his last wishes. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had learned who his erstwhile son-in-law truly was, and surely he wouldn’t be keen on crowning Poonguzhali as the empress of the kingdom. Senthana Amuthan, Poonguzhali and Sembiyanmadevi too would object to this plan again and Sundara Cholar wouldn’t want to displease them.

That’s why Ponniyin Selvar kept his plan a secret until the last minute. He sent many of his courtiers and commanders out of the city, especially those who were likely to object to his plan – either out of their love for him due to their envy towards Madhuranthakar. When he needed someone to help him accomplish this, the prince confided in Vandiya Devan and they both started planning carefully.

They first sent away Kandanmaran, Parthibendra Pallavan, and Kodumbalur Vellar away from the city citing various reasons. But they couldn’t do the same to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar because, as tradition would have it, he would be the one placing the crown on the prince’s head. And wouldn’t he object if he was asked to crown Madhuranthakar instead? And if he refused, it would be considered an inauspicious moment that would blight the entire ceremony, and give rise to bitterness. Therefore, they decided that removing Chinna Pazhuvetarayar from the coronation hall was the only solution for this. But couldn’t agree upon a satisfactory reason that would cause

him to leave the hall, especially during the coronation. That's when Azhwarkadiyan Nambi came to them with interesting news.

The prince had sent Azhwarkadiyan Nambi on a mission to find out the whereabouts of Ravidasan and his Abathuuthavigal, and to check if Nandini was still with them. He was also to know where they had hidden the young child who they had crowned as the next Pandya King. The prince also asked him find out the whereabouts of Karuthiruman, and if the old Madhuranthakan was indeed killed by Kandanmaran's spear or if they had both had joined the Abathuuthavigal. They thought that Azhwarkadiyan would take a long time to find this information but surprisingly, he returned fast.

He had spotted Rakkammal near Kolli Malai. The Nambi thought that if he followed her stealthily, she would lead him to Ravidasan and his gang, but he was astonished when he found that she was going towards Thanjavur. But she was his only lead to find out more about Ravidasan. Therefore, he disguised himself and followed her. When they neared Uraiyr, they found hundreds of people on their way to Thanjavur to attend the coronation ceremony and participate in the festivities. Rakkammal joined these people and started travelling with them, and Azhwarkadiyan pursued her until they reached Thanjavur.

Inside the Thanjavur fort, he was surprised to see her circling Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's palace. He immediately brought this news to the prince and Vandiya Devan. At first, they thought it would be best to imprison Rakkammal, but gave up the idea because they wanted to learn more about her motives and why she had come to Thanjavur. They guessed that she might have brought some news to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter. They decided to not inform Chinna Pazhuvetarayar about this and to use this information during the coronation ceremony to remove the commander from the coronation hall.

When Azhwarkadiyan Nambi went back to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's palace, he couldn't spot Rakkammal there. The crowds that had gathered there were increasing by the minute.

Azhwarkadiyan stood in the crowds and looked around carefully. That's when he had seen the two women emerge out of the palace. One of them was Rakkammal, and the other had hidden her face with her saree and was carrying a child in her arms. The Nambi suspected that the woman who had hidden her face could be Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter. He was in a dilemma whether to stop them there or to pursue them.

By then, they had vanished into the crowds. Azhwarkadiyan guessed that they might be going towards the fort entrance, so he moved towards it too. Just when he arrived at the entrance, he saw them getting inside a veiled palanquin which was borne away immediately with four soldiers accompanying them. That's when he decided that he had to tell Chinna Pazhuvetarayar about this, and came back to the coronation hall.

At the same moment, Ponniyin Selvar was talking to the royal poet. After Azhwarkadiyan gave his news to the commander, he left the coronation hall immediately. First, he went to his palace and searched for his daughter, and was shocked to find her missing. That's when he completely believed Azhwarkadiyan's news. But before he could decide whether to return to the coronation hall, he heard the news that Ponniyin Selvar had crowned Madhuranthaka Devar and heard the crowd hailing the new emperor. He realized that it was futile to go back to the coronation hall then and decided to go after his daughter with a few loyal and trustworthy men. He was furious when he thought that his daughter would join Veera Pandyan's son and deceive him thus. He was determined to kill his daughter if she refused to come back with him.

That night, after the festivities of the coronation had ended, Azhwarkadiyan came back to the prince and told him what had transpired after they successfully removed Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. The prince and Vandiya Devan thought carefully about what to do next and decided that they should go after Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. The commander didn't know Ravidasan as they did and could be endangering himself by going after them alone. They also feared that

he might go to the length of killing his own daughter to stop her from joining her husband. Therefore, Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan Nambi left immediately to bring back Chinna Pazhuvetarayar safely, and also to find out about the whereabouts of Ravidasan and his Abathuuthavigal.

Thus the Nambi and Vandiya Devan went after Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, who had been taken on a long and arduous chase. They found that the Abathuuthavigal had deliberately confused the commander and had led him many times through the wrong paths and roads. They first went by the banks of Kaveri and turned west and reached the place where Amaravathi River met Kaveri River at a Sangam, and then turned southwest and reached Aanai Malai mountains, a place that borders Kongu Nadu and the Chera kingdom. After they reached the woods that surrounded the mountain, their journey became extremely difficult.

The woods in these regions were very dense and they could hear the roars of the wild beasts from four directions. Taking their horses through these woods was a tough prospect, but they couldn't abandon them lest become prey to these beasts.

They finally reached a region where that would be impossible to penetrate while mounted on horses. That's when they heard the neighing of another horse, and they found one of Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's soldiers waiting there guarding the commander's horse. The man said that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had proceeded on foot from that point on with three of his men. Vandiya Devan and Nambi asked the man to look after their horses too and started on foot. It was a long trek through forest paths where even the sun's rays couldn't pierce through the thick canopy of trees, and they couldn't see what lay in front of them.

Finally, they reached a clearing. There was a ravine there with a huge waterfall. It was extremely difficult to go ahead further. The mountain was very steep to climb, and there seemed to be no mountain path that they could take. Dejected by their failed quest, the friends decided to have a refreshing bath in the waterfall pond

and then make their way back. They thought that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar and his men might have fallen prey to the wild animals that abound the woods.

That's when they saw a very strange sight. At the peak of the mountain, where the waterfall began, they saw two men fighting and nearing the edge of the precipice! When they saw who these men were, they could recognize them easily. One of them was Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, while the other man was old Madhuranthakan!

Aha! How strange that a man who would scowl his face at a fight had learnt how to wield a sword and had confidently challenged Chinna Pazhuvetarayar for a fight! Ayyo! Why is Chinna Pazhuvetarayar withdrawing and merely parrying his strokes? Is he hurt or tired, or is he hesitant to slay his son-in-law? Ayyo! The commander doesn't seem to know that he was dangerously close to the edge of the waterfall.

Seeing this, Vandiya Devan and Azhwarkadiyan Nambi started shouting to warn the commander about his dangerous position. But it was of no use. The thunderous roar of the rushing waters could easily drown the noise of a hundred elephants, and it was quite impossible for two men to raise their voices to be heard against the gushing waters.

Even as they stood there, they watched that horrifying scene unfold in front of them and couldn't do anything to prevent it. Backing off step by step from the sword strokes of his son-in-law, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar slipped and fell off the edge of the waterfall into the deep ravine. Madhuranthakar stood for a while and looked down to see his father-in-law falling down and then disappeared from their sight. The ravine where the commander fell was very deep and it would indeed be a miracle if he had survived this fall.

But the friends wanted to see his body at least, so they ran near the ravine. But they couldn't find Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's body there. The pond where the waterfall fell was deep, and many large boulders were around it. The men were glad that his body did not

strike these boulders, resulting in a very painful and bloody death. Instead, it seemed as though he had died from drowning in the deep pool of water. They waited there for a while, hoping that his body would surface.

Soon, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's body surfaced and the friends jumped into the pool and brought his body to the bank. At first, they thought that they had rescued his lifeless body. But hoping against hope, they tried to resuscitate him. And after much effort, they succeeded in reviving Chinna Pazhuvetarayar. He couldn't talk much, but with great difficulty told them what had transpired.

Braving all the hardships, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar had climbed the mountain peak. And there, amidst hundreds of rebels, he found his daughter. Ravidasan then asked him to join them and told him that his son-in-law Madhuranthakan was the heir to the throne and that the Elangai and Chera Kings had offered their support to help them regain the Pandya Kingdom. Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, at first, didn't say anything while Ravidasan was talking, and then he accused them of being murderers and demanded that they send his daughter back with him.

To this, Ravidasan said, "If your daughter wishes to come with you, then you can take her along!"

Chinna Pazhuvetarayar looked at his daughter, but she refused to come along saying that she would embrace her husband's fate.

Enraged by her words, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar roared, "I would rather kill you with my mine own hands, rather than leave you here with them!"

That's when the old Madhuranthakan suddenly appeared with a sword in his hands and said, "Who are you to kill my wife?" He had then started sparring with Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, who was astonished by his son-in-law's actions.

As they continued to fight, the commander was conflicted and wondered whether it was fair to kill Madhuranthakan and make his daughter a widow. These thoughts prevented him from fighting with his full vigour, and that led to him slipping near the edge of the waterfall.

After narrating this to them, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar said, "I will not survive this. My end is nearing. You both leave me here and go back to the prince immediately. We need to attack Elangai and the Cheras immediately. Or else, the Pandya Kingdom will again become independent. Ponniyin Selvar must be crowned in Madurai as 'Chola Pandyan' and if we do not do this immediately, the Chola kingdom will soon be in grave danger. Go immediately!"

The friends couldn't really leave the commander in that state alone. So, it was decided that Vandiya Devan, who was faster on the horse, would return immediately while Azhwarkadiyan stayed back there.

Chapter 90: A Shower of Gold

After Vandiya Devan finished the tale of what happened in the Aanai Malai mountains, Kundavai looked at him and said, “Your tale is extraordinary and strange. It makes me wonder if it is indeed true or merely your imagination! I know that you have a great talent for telling stories. And when you stop your tale in between to look at me, I am convinced that this is all an imagination!”

Vandiya Devan looked at her from head to toe and said, “Devi, there are other places to imagine and tell a tale, but I have never used that particular skill on you. There is a reason why I stop talking in the middle...”

“And is that a big secret? Can you tell a woman about it?” asked Kundavai.

“Yes, it is not a secret that one should share with anybody, but I will tell you about it if you command!”

“You don’t need my command to tell the truth!”

“I will tell the truth, then! But don’t get angry with me later. When I am speaking to you, sometimes, I happen to look at your beautiful eyes. And I know not what magic lies in your beautiful eyes... but it stops me in the tracks and I have to struggle to get back to what I was saying!”

Kundavai’s lips parted in surprise and delight, and she blushed while her eyes laughed, “Ayya, there is no magic or anything else in my eyes. For some time, I have even stopped using kohl to decorate my eyes. You must have seen your own image in my eyes. That’s what probably surprised or astonished you thus!”

“Devi, I have seen my own image in mirrors and clear water but it has never given me any room for surprise...”

“Are you comparing my eyes to a mirror or clear water? A mirror can fog the image while the water can become muddy...”

“I can keep the mirror clean, and make sure that the water doesn’t turn muddy. But if you choose to close your eyes, there is nothing that I can do there!”

“If we stand in front of the mirror, only then we can see ourselves in the mirror. If the water is clear, only then we can see our image on it. But irrespective of whether my eyes are open or closed, your image appears in my eyes. Why do you think that is?” asked Kundavai.

Vandiya Devan felt a rapturous bliss and his voice softened with emotion, “I don’t know, Devi!”

“If you don’t know, then I will tell you. I think there is something about you that is magical. Even Nandini’s heart was affected by your magic.”

“Just a moment ago, you said words that were sweeter than nectar. But in the same breath, why would you want to take the name of that snake?”

“There was once a time when I hated Nandini, and thought that she was more poisonous than a snake. But now, when I think about her, I can feel only pity...”

“Your sympathy for Nandini is as good as feeling pity for a snake that has come to avenge the Chola clan!”

“Ayya, she is the daughter of Mandakini Devi, who has become the guardian goddess of the Chola Clan. She is the daughter of the woman who saved my brother many times, and my father from the assassin’s spear by sacrificing her own life...”

“Yes, but never forget that it was she who incited the Pandya Abathuuthavigal to carry out the assassination. It was she who came

as death incarnate for Aditya Karikalan, and it was she who had mesmerized the senses of a great warrior like Periya Pazhuvetarayar and turned him into a puppet!”

“She didn’t stop with Periya Pazhuvetarayar. She had entranced warriors like Kandanmaran and Parthibendra Pallavan, and used them like weapons, too. Despite all that, I can’t bring myself to hate her. She was, after all, born in a warriors’ clan and she did all this to wreck vengeance for Veera Pandiyan’s death. I feel guilty when I realize that I too am partly responsible for many of her sorrows and the way life turned out for her. When she was young, I made sure she left Pazhaiarai...”

“That’s a good thing you did. Don’t ever forget that she is the daughter of your enemy. Didn’t we have enough troubles with Veera Pandyan’s son growing up in the Chola palace? Imagine what might have happened if Veera Pandyan’s daughter too had grown up in the Chola palace and happened to marry Aditya Karikalan...”

“It would have been good indeed. Both these ancient clans would have become one and our enmity would have ended. But is that news true?”

“What are you asking?”

“That Nandini is indeed Veera Pandyan’s daughter?”

“I heard Nandini say this, and even Periya Pazhuvetarayar heard it. It was this truth that totally transformed Periya Pazhuvetarayar and made him so rageful. It was this truth that finally ended Aditya Karikalar’s life.”

“Think carefully! She might have said this to complete her revenge. Earlier, when she was shielding Veera Pandyan, she said something totally different. Would any woman call her father her ‘lover’?”

“Devi, Karikalar was enraged at that time! God knows what she said and what he understood. We only know what Karikalar told us later. But when she told him that ‘Veera Pandyan was my father,’ he accepted it and believed it too. And maybe she herself learned this only after Veera Pandyan died. Do you remember the attempts that she made to learn the truth of her birth? Didn’t she pretend to be her mother’s spirit and drive the emperor to the brink of madness? Didn’t your friend Vanathi see this once and faint?”

“But you do know what that madman who escaped with you from the prison told Azhwarkadiyan?”

“Of course I do. He said that he was the father of Nandini and her brother!”

“Don’t you think that could be true?”

“If that is so, then there is indeed great power behind a lie too. Our old Madhuranthakan would hide in the palace to avoid going to wars! But the minute he learned that he was Veera Pandyan’s son, he transformed into a warrior! You would have been astounded if you had seen him.

“Do you know that Chinna Pazhuvetarayar once held my shoulder with his iron grip? Whenever I remember that incident, my shoulder pains. Can you imagine old Madhuranthakan, who we thought was a coward, fighting with such a great warrior with his sword? I can’t forget that spectacle ever!”

“That’s why I am finding it difficult to believe your words...”

“It was indeed beyond belief. The man who would only travel in a veiled palanquin and who would tremble in front of the Pazhuvur brothers... who could have believed that he would dare to challenge Chinna Pazhuvetarayar to a sword fight? But it did happen and you will know that it is true when Azhwarkadiyan Nambi comes back and tells you...”

“Ayya, did you happen to see Nandini?”

“Why should I see that demoness?”

“Please don’t call her that. I will meet her one day and learn the truth about her father. But please don’t say anything wrong about her. No matter who her father was, we do know for sure who her mother was, and that is reason enough to inspire affection and regard for her. And there is yet another reason too...”

“What reason is that?”

“Nandini was in love with you. She gave you her signet ring and helped you escape from the fort. And it was she who intervened and saved your life many times from Ravidasan and his Abathuuthavigal...”

“Yes, and in the end, she made sure that Karikalar’s murder charge was laid on my head. That’s why she did all that...”

“Can’t you understand why she did that?”

“Can we reason as to why a snake bites us or why does a leopard pounces on us?”

“Nandini was not born a snake or a leopard. It was us and circumstances that made her thus. And you too were responsible for this!”

“My god! Why blame me for this? What harm did I ever do to her?”

“You didn’t do her any harm. It was she who had affection for you in her heart...”

“My God!”

“I think men are blind. They are incapable of seeing even the things that are right in front of them. Ayya, you didn’t understand

Nandini's heart, but I am able to comprehend many things now. That unfortunate woman didn't really love Veera Pandyan, nor did she have any regard for Periya Pazhuvetarayar. She also had no real love for Aditya Karikalan. She merely acted as though she had great affection for them, just so that she could ascend the throne through them."

"I know this, Devi. Trust me, there is no room for love in her vengeful heart."

"That's wrong. The minute she met you, she lost her heart to you and she felt true love. She was ready to do anything to gain your attention and love."

"Oh yes, that's why she was ready to lay the murder charge on my head too!"

"Why do you think that is? She wanted to make sure that you are never allied with the Cholas or have any kind of ties with us!"

"Yes, and that's why she ensured that I would be publicly executed for Karikalar's murder. Instead, she should have killed me with the sword that she used to keep."

"If she had wanted to kill you, she could have done it anytime. She could have signalled Ravidasan and his men anytime to overwhelm you. Trust me, if Periya Pazhuvetarayar had not taken the murder charges on his head, and if Ponniyin Selvan had not intervened, and if you had actually been brought to the streets for a public execution, Ravidasan and his Abathuuthavigal would have released you and taken you along with them. And you too might have found yourself at Aanai Malai mountains with them..."

"Thankfully, God saved me from that!"

"Yes indeed. God saved the Chola Kingdom too, or else we would have lost the service of a warrior like you!"

“Devi, the Chola kingdom is great and it has more than 500 lakh soldiers. Truly, the kingdom wouldn’t miss the service of one soldier like myself.”

“And yet you did say that our kingdom is surrounded by new enemies and dangers...”

“That is true, devi. Ravidasan is indeed very clever and a good strategist. He has successfully created two new Pandya heirs. Earlier, they had brought a young child from somewhere and had crowned him as Parangusan Nedunchezhiyan. And now Amara Bujaka Nedunchezhiyan too has appeared...”

“Who is this Amara Bujaka Nedunchezhiyan?”

“That’s the name of our old Madhuranthakan. A Pandya heir cannot possibly bear the name ‘Madhuranthakan’. When Chinna Pazhuvetarayar fell down from the waterfall, we heard the Abathuuthavigal hail him thus drowning the sound of rushing waters!”

“What’s the advantage in having two heirs to the throne?”

“If something were to happen to one of them, then the other is there to take the throne. They are planning to use one of the heirs to secure the help of the Cheras and the other to gain the support of the Elangai king.”

“Ayya, you and my brother schemed and crowned Uttama Cholar as the emperor, but I don’t think you have done any favour to him. To bear the burden of this kingdom is not going to be an easy task for Uttama Cholar.”

“True. It is indeed not an easy thing to bear the burden of this kingdom right now. But Uttama Cholar will not be bearing this burden alone. He will support his mother in temple renovation and spend his days building temples for his Lord Shiva. The burden of the kingdom

will be borne by your brother, who will also defend it from its enemies!”

“That is true. Arulmozhi is very capable indeed to bear this burden. But he is yet young and has no experience. The noble lords who bore this kingdom on their shoulders... the Pazhuvur brothers, are gone. The older brother has left this world altogether and from what you say, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar might not survive, either.”

“Even if he survives, I doubt if he would be of any use to the kingdom. He would be heartbroken and miserable thinking about his daughter and son-in-law.”

“Sambuvarayar, too, has become weak and his heart is anguished by the turn of the events. Malayaman is already an old man. And when he saw one of his grandsons rejecting the throne while the other had died, he too has lost hope and is despondent. Kodumbalur Vellar’s heart is restless and unforgiving towards Arulmozhi. He is finding it difficult to forget or forgive that my brother fooled him thus, leading him to believe that he would indeed ascend the throne, only to crown his uncle. He is not even satisfied by the fact that my brother married Vanathi. He has decided that he would never be involved in royal affairs, and has gone back to Kodumbalur to rebuild their temples. All the noble lords who conspired with the Pazhuvur brothers at the Kadambur palace have been shamed by their involvement in this conspiracy and have gone back to their kingdoms.

“Ayya, Arulmozhi needs new friends and warriors who would stand by him and support him through their warring prowess and clever political strategies...”

“Thankfully, Pallava Parthibendran is on our side,” said Vandiya Devan.

“I doubt if Arulmozhi would get his support. He is incensed by the fact that you both sent him out of the city and crowned

Madhuranthakar instead. He is also enraged to know that my brother considers you as his confidant and close friend.”

“There is some justification to his grievances. He has performed loyal service to the Chola clan for many years, while I have come only now. I can seek his forgiveness...”

“That would be like adding fuel to a raging flame,” said Kundavai.

“Parthibendra Pallavan is a great warrior. Is there no other way to pacify him?”

“He suggested a way himself and has placed his request with my father and brother!”

“The emperor wouldn’t have refused his request surely...”

“Ayya, that’s not up to the emperor! It depends on the emperor’s daughter and she has not accepted it. Yes, ayya, the Pallava Prince is indeed disgusted by the fact that a man who was once gathering flowers for the shiva temple has now ascended the throne and become the emperor. He is also horrified by the fact that a girl who was plying boats for a living has become the empress of this kingdom. Therefore he demanded that he be made the independent king of Pallava region with rights to inscribe his name as its king...”

“Aha, but how can we do that? That would be like shattering this kingdom!”

“But my father didn’t mind giving him that right. But the Pallava prince didn’t stop at that. He said that sometime in history, a Pallava princess had married a Chola Prince! Therefore, he demanded that my father wed his daughter to him...”

Hearing this, Vandiya Devan’s face became agonized and anguished. He tried to hide his reactions by turning his head to the other side. Kundavai, in the meanwhile, smiled beautifully and

stopped talking. After waiting awhile, Vandiya Devan asked, "What did the emperor say?"

"How can the emperor say anything here? That's up to his daughter. So he asked his daughter..."

"And what did the emperor's daughter say to that?"

"She refused the hand of Parthibendra Pallavan..."

"Why? Why?" demanded Vandiya Devan with great urgency.

"The emperor's daughter doesn't have to give any reason for her refusal. But she did give him one. She said that she didn't wish to leave this beautiful kingdom and move elsewhere!"

"Is that the only reason?"

"There might be other reasons, but I would tell it only to those who have genuine interest in hearing it. Why should I tell it someone who is barely interested?"

"Devi, truly I am asking this out of interest and care..."

"Those who have so much interest and care will find the answer on their own. I don't have to tell them anything specifically..."

Vandiya Devan saw Kundavai's face then, as though this was the first time that he was seeing her. The world stood still while waves came together in the sea...

With a mischievous smile playing on her lips, Kundavai said, "What do we do about menfolk who can't discern what lies in the heart of a woman? How can we expect them to unravel political intrigues and strategies of the enemies?"

Vandiya Devan remained silent for a while and then looked at her and said, "Devi, what would the emperor think if an orphaned warrior

with nary a roof above his head made the same request as Parthibendra Pallavan?”

“It doesn’t matter what he thinks. He would ask his daughter and then will reply accordingly!”

“Devi, what would the emperor’s daughter say to this?”

“Why should we talk in circles? Why don’t we go to the emperor directly and ask him about it? You will get your response immediately!”

“How can I dare to go to the emperor, who rules from Vengi to Elangai and ask for his daughter’s hand, when I have no roof above my head nor parents or relatives to speak on my behalf?”

“Since when did the Prince of Vallam become so modest? I haven’t forgotten the first time we met, when you regaled me with stories of your clan and their history. You once said that when a male child was born in Chera, Chola and Pandya clan, and if the chest of the child is broad, the womenfolk would proudly say that the great names of Vallam kings could be written on it.

“Didn’t you tell me how kings would wait in the courtyard of your palaces and see mere poets leave with gifts that they had once presented to the Vallam king as a tribute? They would exclaim, ‘That’s my crown,’ ‘That’s my horse,’ ‘That’s my umbrella!’ Why would you become so modest now?”

“It’s due to your brother’s company. Arulmozhi hates those who try to win any respect through the glories of their ancestors. He laughs at those who try to pay tribute to him saying that he belongs to the race of the sun, or that he belongs to the clan of Karikalan or that he is great grandson of Vijayalaya Cholan.

“Do you know what he told me once? He said that his ancestors had so far inscribed their glories after a rather lengthy introduction of their antecedents that began from Manu Needhi Cholan and his

glorious deeds... He said that if he ever ascends the throne, he would change this tradition, and inscribe only his achievements and glories. He felt that only then would people truly believe that these were his accomplishments rather than a poet's imagination.

“Devi, I agreed to what he said. And that's when I stopped talking about my clan's history and old stories. Therefore, I will not go to your father and regale him with my clan's stories and ask for your hand.

Your brother and I have decided to dedicate our lives to this kingdom. We are determined to extend the borders of this kingdom all the way to the Vindhya mountains in the north, the Trikona mountains in the south, the Lakshadweep islands in the west, and the island kingdoms of the far east. We will plant the chola flag in these places. Once I have realized at least some of these dreams, I will come to the emperor and demand, ‘I would like to present your daughter with this victory garland, give me your permission.’ I would go to Elangai and seek the Pandya treasure – their coronation crown and the Indra aaram – and place them at your feet and ask, ‘if you think I am worthy of your hand, then please let me become the fortunate man to claim it...”

“I can't praise your decision enough. I can clearly see the difference in the outlook of Parthibendran and yourself. But only the menfolk can do such glorious things. They can go on victory campaigns and bring glory to the kingdom. We womenfolk can't do this, and nor we do we need to do it. There was a time when they used to conduct Swayamavara for royal princesses. That practice has died down for some reason.

“Ayya, if my father were to conduct a swayamvara for me, and invite princes from all over the world, I wouldn't have garlanded any of them. I would search for that orphaned Prince of Vallam who had escaped from Thanjavur and come to my palace with the help of the temple priest, and met me stealthily at my garden. And if I find him there, I would garland him...”

Vandiya Devan sat there, looking at her transfixed. He could hear the fanfare of wedding drums and fifes playing auspicious music. From the skies, a shower of gold fell on him, drowning him in bliss. He suddenly got up, startling Kundavai.

“Didn’t you like what I said?” asked Kundavai.

“Good question. I was wondering if I heard you right or if I was dreaming! I now know that I am not dreaming. They say that the devas churned the ocean to get the nectar, and after partaking it they became immortals. I have become an immortal after hearing your words. I have been given a new life.”

Kundavai now said, “Ayya, remember one thing. Wherever you go, you will encounter many dangers. You will be warring with many and they will try their utmost to end your life through schemes and swords. If something were to happen to you, then remember one thing... a Chola Princess from this valorous clan will become a widow even before she was wedded!”

“Devi, nothing of that sort will happen. I have become an immortal who has partaken the nectar. I am not going to die. When I am lost in a dark forest with nary a light, you will be in the hut, waiting for me with a lamp to guide me back home. It is this thought that would give me courage amidst any danger. When I am in a ship lost to the sea, not knowing where I am or how long I have been lost, you will be the Dhruva star shining near the Sapta Rishi Mandal to guide me back home.

“Near the shores where huge boulders of rocks could wreck the ship to pieces, you will be the light that I will see from the lighthouse, saving me from certain death. Through your light, I will bring my boat to the shores safely. When I am lost in the desert, dying under the scorching sun with a parched tongue, you will be the oasis with cool ponds and shady trees.

“Devi, no matter where I go in this world and how many difficulties I experience, I will one day come back and claim your

hand in marriage. Until I accomplish this, I will not die, I would be an immortal!”

While Vandiya Devan spoke thus, Kundavai watched him intently without blinking her eyes. She felt as though this warrior had not said these words to her for the first time, and that she had heard him say this same thing many aeons ago, in some other life. While she was thinking about it, she heard Vanathi’s voice, “Akka! Akka!”

They both looked at Vanathi who was coming towards them.

“Akka, he has got an urgent message from Manimegalai’s brother, Kandanmaran,” she said and handed her an olai.

Chapter 91: A Faded Flower

Vandiya Devan took the message from Vanathi and said, "Princess, do you remember me? I thought that you had entirely forgotten about me!"

"Ayya, how can my husband and I possibly forget you, or the help you have rendered us?" asked Vanathi.

"Is that why you got married when I was not there?"

Vanathi smiled mischievously and said, "Well, if you had been present, our wedding might have become like Ponniyin Selvar's coronation ceremony. God knows what intrigues and schemes you might have planned?!"

"Really! Was it because me that the coronation ceremony turned out thus? You competed with the boat girl and took an oath saying, 'I will not ascend the throne!' And the boat girl became lucky. What's the use of blaming me?"

"Let her enjoy the fortune of being an empress. I am happy for her, too. But when you get married, do get the astrologer to select a good date!"

"Well, we might as well ask Kudanthai Jodhidhar to give a good date. You both believe him implicitly, don't you?"

Vanathi suddenly laughed and looked at Kundavai, saying, "I remembered something when he said 'Kudanthai Jodhidhar!'" And she laughed out aloud.

"What are you laughing at, Vanathi?! He did blabber that the child born to you would rule over the three worlds! Are you laughing about it?"

“Why do you call that a blabber? That prediction will definitely come true!” said Vandiya Devan.

Vanathi blushed and controlled her laughter, and said, “Akka, you have diverted the conversation somewhere else. Do you remember I asked the astrologer, ‘When will a suitable husband appear for Princess Kundavai?’ and the astrologer said, ‘He might jump down from the skies at this very minute!’ and to prove his point, didn’t Vandiya Devar enter the hut after fighting with the astrologer’s disciple? That’s what I remembered and laughed!”

Expressing mock anger, Kundavai suppressed her smile and said, “Enough of your laughter! Let him read his message!”

Vandiya Devan opened the message and his face became worry-stricken after reading it, which both the women noted.

“What was in the message? What did Kandanmaran say?” asked Kundavai with great interest.

“Why don’t you read this yourself?” said Vandiya Devan, handing the olai to Kundavai.

In the olai, the following message was given –

My dear friend, Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan, please do forgive the injustice that I meted out to you and all my crimes against you, and come and see my sister Manimegalai for one last time.

Kandanmaran Sambuvarayar

Kundavai read the message and said, “This is good news, in one way. This means that Manimegalai has been found!”

“What do you mean by that? Where did Manimegalai go?”

“Haven’t you heard any news about Manimegalai?”

“No. I had to thought to ask you!”

“I thought that I would tell you, but you are so stone-hearted that you didn’t even ask anything about her, and I hesitated to broach the subject.”

“Devi, since when have I become stone-hearted about Manimegalai? Am I not dead and gone for her?”

“No, you didn’t die! You have become an immortal being for her...”

“Alright! At least now, please tell me what happened!”

“It’s indeed unfortunate. Sembiyanmadevi tried her best to convince Sambuvarayar to keep Manimegalai here along with her, but he didn’t agree. He said that Kandanmaran would soon go away to the border, and that he wanted at least his daughter near him. Since their old palace in Kadambur is in ashes now, the emperor had asked him build a new palace near the Pallar River. On their way, near the Veera Narayana Dam, they stayed the night in tents. Next day, when they got up, they couldn’t find Manimegalai anywhere. They thought that she might have come here, and sent men to find out. But she didn’t come here. Since then, we have been worried about her fate. We thought that she might have killed herself by falling into the Veera Narayana Dam. We knew that Sambuvarayar’s men searched for her in vain everywhere. This olai confirms that they have indeed found her!”

“What’s the point of meeting her? She is not going to recognize me...”

“Even then, I think you should go and meet her. I wonder what Kandanmaran means by ‘one last time’,” said Kundavai worriedly.

“Akka, indeed he is really heartless, and not worthy of Manimegalai’s love. Some men do not hesitate to sacrifice a

kingdom for their beloved, while he is hesitating even to go and meet her!”

Vandiya Devan then said, “Princess, there are very few kingdoms in this world. Therefore, very few people can sacrifice their kingdoms for the love of another person. But you are right about one thing. I am not worthy of Manimegalai’s love. Manimegalai’s love and affection were worthy of a God. But I am a mere man, fraught with faults and flaws. Manimegalai’s love should be offered to a God, and not to me!”

“Even so, I think you should go and meet her once. Kandanmaran says ‘one last time’ which is worrying...” said Kundavai.

“I never said I wouldn’t go. I was merely thinking if there was any use in going because she thinks I am dead. Yet, I wonder what Kandanmaran means by ‘one last time.’ Is he going to shut her up somewhere, or will she join a Buddhist monastery and become a monk?”

“If you undertake a day’s journey, you will know the answers to these questions,” said Kundavai.

Vandiya Devan started from Pazhairai to Veera Narayanapuram. And though his journey was just a day long, to him it seemed as though he was traveling forever. One after another, many memories rose in his heart. When he had first travelled by this route, he had many dreams and aspirations in his heart. Now when he thought back, many of those dreams had been fulfilled, and many impossible things had come to pass. The prince who won the hearts of the kingdom for rejecting the crown that he got – and is now considered as the ‘Epitome of Sacrifice’ – is now his dear friend. He had captured the heart of the prince’s sister, who had inspired him to greatness. He also won the position of Commander for the Elangai forces.

Did I win all these things only because of my clever ingenuity? No. It was because I was at Kadambur at the right time, and overheard the nobles and chieftains discuss their conspiracy. All the events that had followed were due to that one event. Within these eight months, many events had transpired.

The comet that had appeared on the skies had disappeared after orchestrating Karikalar's tragic death. Could there be any connection between the comet and Karikalar? Were people right in believing that there was indeed a connection? Is there truly any connection between the stars and planets that had existed for eons with the people who appear and vanish within a few years?

Yet, without a doubt, there is Something up there that is running our lives. Otherwise, how could he have escaped from all those dangerous situations? So many people came to him at the right time, in the right place, just to help him. Who could have sent them there? Our elders say that it is God who runs our lives, and have given these gods many names, Maha Sakthi, Sivan, or Mahavishnu....

Vandiya Devan thought about all those who had helped during the most critical junctures of his life, and the fact that they had appeared there at that precise moment surprised him to the core. And when he thought about those who had helped him, he got emotional. Though Kandanmaran became his bitter enemy later, Vandiya Devan couldn't forget the help he rendered at first. Azhwarkadiyan had helped him a lot, and ironically, so had that she-demoness Nandini. He was surprised to see the regard that Kundavai still bore for that vile woman. The boat girl Poonguzhali's help can't be repaid in this lifetime, and she is indeed worthy of the throne that she sits in.

How can I repay the help that Senthana Amuthan, who is now Uttama Cholar, did for me? Is there any way to repay that? Saving him from that Pinagapani's murderous spear was nothing in comparison to what Senthana Amuthan did for me. Only through years of selfless service can I repay my gratitude for the chola clan.

Ah, what about Periya Pazhuvetarayar! I once thought that if I got the chance to meet this great warrior who bore 64 scar wounds on his body, I would be most fortunate man in this world.

And he didn't just meet him, but also earned the old man's wrath. But in the end, he redeemed himself and saved him from that terrible murder charge. He accepted that it was he who had thrown that dagger which killed Karikalar, and saved Vandiya Devan in the process. He was not just a great warrior but a great soul.

How will I ever repay my gratitude to him?

That poor girl Manimegalai! Why did she have love me so much and become mad? Why did she have to take on the murder charge on her head just to save me? It was because of that fool Kandanmaran. At first, he must have described me to that poor girl as 'Indran,' 'Chandran,' and 'Manmadan,' and that's when she must have lost her heart to me.

The day Kandanmaran told him, 'Forget about my sister. We are going to marry her into a powerful clan,' Vandiya Devan had genuinely forgotten about her. Around the same time, he had met Kundavai Devi too, so he got over the disappointment pretty fast. But unfortunately, Manimegalai didn't appear to have changed her mind and nor did she attempt to change it. She also didn't hesitate to tell everyone about it! Aha! What a gentle sweet girl she was! Modest and yet clever, and her heart was so pure, like a child! She truly was a mischievous child at heart. The fact that she thinks that Vandiya Devan was dead was better for everyone. She will lose her madness one day, and her head and heart will become lucid. She will get married to someone else and live happily.

Will this really happen? Or am I just fooling myself? Am I really responsible for her state? What could be Kandanmaran's words 'one last time' mean? Does it mean... Aha! No! it can't be.

Vandidya Devan's horse sped as fast as his thoughts did. Thankfully, there were no floods in the Kollidam River, so he didn't

need a boat to cross it, nor did he have to change his horse. He saw the Kadambur palace – burnt and filled with rubble and ashes with just a few pillars standing upright. He didn't tarry there for long, and moved on. When he reached Veera Narayanapuram, Kandanmaran's men were waiting for him. When he asked them, "Where is your master?" they said, "He is waiting for you at the dam!"

Wondering why Kandanmaran was waiting by the dam, Vandiya Devan neared it. The first time he had come there, he remembered that it was the auspicious day of *Aadi Perukku*, and so many people had gathered there to celebrate the festival. Now, there was no one by the banks of the dam. He could spot only one or two people. When he first saw the dam, it was full and the sound of the rushing waters was almost like that of the sea. Today, there was sparse water in the dam, and the sound of the water was a bare trickle that sounded like the tinkle of a dancing woman's anklets.

Vandiya Devan climbed on the banks of the dam and found that the scenery was quite different from what he had seen earlier. There was no rushing water, wanting to escape the dam's pervasive hold. There was very less water, and by the banks, there were many shrubs and flowers. The colour of the water too was not brackish red but was clear like a mirror.

From the southern direction, the water from the Vadavaru River was not flowing into the dam and nor were there any boats. Instead he could clearly see the trees and plants that bordered the banks. And here and there were a few white cranes that stood poised on one leg.

While he watched around the dam thus, Vandiya Devan noticed a boat that was coming nearer. One of the men in that boat was Kandanmaran. He immediately turned his horse towards the banks and approached the boat from the land side. Vandiya Devan leapt into the boat, and Kandanmaran made sure he got on safely and held his hand tightly. After signalling the boatmen to ply the boat, Kandanmaran looked at his friend with his eyes filled with unshed tears.

“My friend! Thank God you came so fast. If you had not come today – maybe even arrived tomorrow – you couldn’t have seen Manimegalai alive!”

Vandiya Devan had great fortitude and emotional strength in his heart. If not, it would have been impossible to jump from one adventure to another and complete his mission without caring for his life. He had never really worried about the consequences of his situational actions or the danger to his own life...that’s how he was able to survive the many dangers that he had seen in these eight months.

And yet, when Kandanmaran said those words, Vandiya Devan was shaken to the core. He realized that Kandanmaran’s words about ‘one last time’ meant the very thing that he had feared – that Manimegalai was nearing her death. His eyes were filled with tears that ran unchecked, and he asked with great difficulty, “Kandanmara! Is Manimegalai’s life in danger? How so? I thought that she had lost her memory, that too only where you and I are concerned!”

“My friend, Manimegalai has regained her memory. But I know not how long she will be alive. I am praying hard that she stays alive until she sees you,” said Kandanmaran, and then he narrated what had transpired after Manimegalai went missing.

Kandanmaran was in Kanchi, preparing the golden palace built by Aditya Karikalan for the arrival of the Sundara Chola and Vanamadevi. That’s when he learned that Sambuvarayar had left Thanjavur with Manimegalai. Following that, he learned that Manimegalai went missing near the Veera Narayana Dam. Kandanmaran immediately took permission from Parthibendran and left for Veera Narayanapuram to ascertain the fate of his sister. His father was anguished and lost, and on the brink of madness himself. A distraught Sambuvarayar could only tell him what he knew, which was pitifully less, ‘She slept in the tent at night. But come morning, we couldn’t find her.’

He said that he had sent someone to Pazhaiarai to see if she had returned there. Sambuvarayar had also sent his men to search for her in their old palace ruins at Kadambur. After hearing this, Kandanmaran started searching as well. He didn't think that she might have returned to Pazhaiarai. He feared that she might have given up her life by falling into the dam, and was determined to find at least her body. He also hoped against hope that she might be roaming in the forests that surrounded the lake.

He roamed around the lake and its forests. He searched the canals, going by a boat. After searching fruitlessly for over four days, he remembered the Neerazhi Mandapam that was situated in an island in Veera Narayana Dam. He also remembered that Manimegalai and Nandini had once gone there to play water games. And Karikalar and Vandiya Devan had also joined them while on their hunt. Together, they had spent many hours there. While it would be impossible to reach the place without a boat, she could have become prey to any of the wild animals that abound the forest around the lake. Even if she had managed to survive the forest, there were many canals and small lakes there and she had to cross all that to reach the mandapam.

Running out of options to search for her, Kandanmaran took the boat and reached the mandapam. Many painful memories surfaced when he reached there. And at first, it looked as though the mandapam was empty. Standing at the steps of the mandapam, he sighed deeply at his disappointment of not finding her there. He then heard another sigh that almost mirrored his. He immediately ran inside the mandapam. And on the other side of it, on the steps, he found her.

Hurt and bruised everywhere, she lay there with bones sticking out of her body. Her saree was torn in several places. At first, it didn't seem as though there was life in her body. She looked starved and as though she had aimlessly roamed in the forest for many days. Finding her in such a condition, Kandanmaran felt as though a thousand spears had pierced his heart.

He took her body in his arms and wailed, and then he remembered that she had sighed. He brought her water and gave her some to drink. He massaged her arms and legs, and tried to revive her with heat. After a long time, she opened her eyes, and whispered, “Anna, it’s you. I knew that I would meet you both if I come to heaven. Where is he?”

Kandanmaran tried to stem his rising despair and sobs and said, “He will be here soon!”

Kandanmaran then realized that his sister thought that she had died already, and had reached the heavens, where she had finally recognized him and was asking for his friend. He tried to pretend that they were indeed in heaven so that she didn’t receive a shock to her senses. Then he tried to keep her alive in many ways, and had sent word to his friend immediately to come there...

“My friend! I cannot thank you enough for coming here. Manimegalai will leave us soon. She is like the lamp in its last dregs – the one that would burn brightly for a while and fade away. She is holding on to her life just to see you. She thinks that we both are in heaven. I would request you not to say anything contrary to what she believes. I know that you grieve for her and that there will be tears when you meet her. But do try to control yourself and speak to her with a smile!”

By then, the boat had reached the Neerazhi Mandapam and that’s when Vandiya Devan heard a sound of yazh and a song that seemed familiar.

“Yes, my friend, it is Manimegalai who is singing and playing the yazh!”

Both of them got down from the boat. Vandiya Devan listened intently to the song and realized that she had sung this the last time they were at the same mandapam.

Vandiya Devan waited until the song ended and then climbed the steps to reach the mandapam.

The minute she saw him, she dropped the yazh and tried to run towards him, but she couldn't stand for long and would have fallen down had it not been for Vandiya Devan, who rushed to her and held her tight. He sat down and made her lie on his lap.

Manimegalai looked up at his face constantly, as if to confirm that she was indeed lying in his lap, and then whispered, "My brother didn't trick me. This heaven is not a dream and this miracle is not a lie!"

She continued to murmur the words, "Not a lie..."

"Yes, Manimegalai. This is not a dream or a lie. I have come here..." said Vandiya Devan reassuringly.

Despite trying his best to control his emotions, his eyes were filled with tears that flowed freely and they spilled on Manimegalai's face too, like pearls. Waves of grief rose through his heart and he sobbed...

Manimegalai's face glowed with happiness. Her eyes opened wide as she looked at him with astonishment. Her lips murmured some half-remembered words, but Vandiya Devan couldn't understand what she was saying.

But there was no need to understand what she was saying. Indeed, what was left for mere words when one's heart is overflowing with love?

After some time, Manimegalai's lips stopped moving. Then her eyes closed and the unnatural glow on her face dimmed, and her body gave up her spirit peacefully. A gentle wind blew through the mandapam, and a few red flowers fell from the tree.

Indeed where does the spirit go once it is released from the body? Does it become one with nature? Does it ride the music that is heard when the wind blows? Or does it go up to the heavens blissfully, hearing the music of the birds? Or does it go back to the God, the Paramatma^[64] who had created all the souls in this world?

Has it mingled with the spirit of Vandiya Devan, who was sitting like a statue? No one knows this, and those who know cannot reveal it. But we do know one thing for sure.

We will no longer see the Vandiya Devan who we knew as playful, mischievous, daring, enthusiastic, charming, and flirtatious. He had now transformed into a mature soul, with much wisdom and a calm heart, because Manimegalai had indeed merged her soul with his. And from now on whatever he does, her spirit will guide him.

Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan went on to perform many great deeds. Those who knew him remembered him with respect and reverence.

Great warrior! We will now take your leave. We do not wish to intrude on your grief and despair. Dear friend of Ponniyin Selva! May you live long! May your name live forever in the annals of Tamil history!

Epilogue

(As written by Kalki Krishnamurthy)

I wish to convey my sincere thanks and gratitude to my readers. I appreciate the patience and interest evinced by the readers for the past three and half years for this story. Honestly, we didn't think that this story would interest the readers when we initially started publishing it. Many were challenged by the complicated historical names of the characters. Thankfully, the readers surmounted that challenge as the characters slowly grew on them. Very soon, we found that no other story published in a serialized manner was read with much interest, week after week.

A year after we had started publishing this story, on the auspicious day of Aadi Perukku, many readers and friends from Paramakudi sent many letters of appreciation because our story also begins on the same day.

We received many letters of appreciation from our readers, but I have never considered them as praise due only to the author. They are also appreciative of the glorious history of Tamil culture. Truly, our history and culture deserve appreciation, and we should be rightfully proud of our heritage. For the past few years, many archaeological sites are being excavated and copper plates have been deciphered. Historians are using these as evidence to piece together the history of Tamil Nadu.

In history, no time period is completely known to us. 1400 years ago, the Pallava kings ruled over Kanchipuram for a very long time, and we now know many details about their 200-year rule.

The Chola history is also well known among historians. The history of Vijayalaya Chola was known to many and their 300-year rule was researched, though there were many gaps in information. But a few historical moments of their reign had irrefutable evidence.

One such evidence was an incident that is unheard of in any annals of history. It is a known fact that Sundara Chola's second son, Arulmozhivarman, who later ascends the throne as Raja Raja Cholan, rejected the kingdom that was given to him and crowned his uncle Uttama Cholan instead.

Thiruvallangadu inscriptions say this categorically –

The people wished for Sundara Chola and, after him his son, Arulmozhivarman, to ascend the Chola throne. But the prince respected the rights of his grandfather Gandaradithan's son and his uncle, Uttama Chola and crowned him as the emperor.

This incident has been referenced and has appeared in many other inscriptions and contemporary writings.

The people of the kingdom, the royal family, and the army commanders wished for Arulmozhivarman to take the throne, and yet he gave up his rights willingly to someone else.

Nowhere else in history is there another example of such a sacrifice. One can only compare him with Ashoka the Great, who sacrificed everything after the devastating war campaign on the Kalingas.

Arulmozhi's sacrifice is one of the most pivotal moments of this story. Every incident and every moment in this epic tale have been written keeping this pivotal incident in mind. That's why the fifth part of this novel was called 'Thyaga Sigaram' (Epitome of Sacrifice). I hope the readers realise that sacrificing the kingdom was the most difficult and noble thing that Arulmozhivarman did in this entire novel. And if any of the readers have not understood that, it is a failing on the part of the author and we seek your forgiveness for it.

We received many letters of appreciation from our readers right from the time this story was serialized, and we didn't notice any difference of opinion among the readers. But the same is not the case in the letters that we received after the story ended.

Half of them appreciated the story and the way we ended it, while others hated the fact that we ended the story and the way we did it. Many are disappointed by the fact that the story ended abruptly, and that we didn't tell them what happened to many characters later in their life. And this disappointment was expressed through their letters.

I am, however, satisfied by the fact that the readers who had expressed their dissatisfaction had wanted me to write this story more. This is a story that has been published for the past three and half years, and instead of asking 'When will you finish this story?' many have asked 'Why did you end it abruptly?'

And that is something that I am happy to hear. That said, I am regretful of the fact that I couldn't satisfy the readers thoroughly.

There are two reasons why I finished the 'Ponniyin Selvan' story thus.

1. As I said earlier, the most pivotal moment of this story was Ponniyin Selvar's sacrifice, where he gives up to another man the claim to a kingdom that rightfully belongs to him. I built the story to this conclusion, and to continue beyond that would be like adding an anti-climax to the climax.
2. Today, many readers are disappointed with the story ending thus. But I am certain if I had continued writing this tale, the same readers will ask me 'when will you finish?' There are no rules that have been laid down for novels or for 'historical fiction.' (If they exist, then I haven't read them). There is a difference between completely fictionalised novels and historical novels that are based on facts. The author can provide a satisfactory arc for characters in fiction novels. Either the hero and heroine will live happily ever after, or the hero will die on the gallows while the heroine will end her life by falling into the deep

sea. And the fate of the rest of the characters can be summarized within one paragraph.

We can take it forward and say that the happy couple lived a blessed life with many children and grandchildren... All the good characters led a happy life while the villains and those associated with them suffered greatly or died! And we could end the story satisfactorily.

Historical stories cannot be concluded thus, nor should we attempt such a thing. Historical characters, apart from those who die in the story, go beyond this epic to achieve many things later in their lives. Their victory, sorrows, failures, and disappointments cannot be chronicled in this story because many are based on supposition and lack historical proof. That's why I decided to leave the characters in the same place where I ended the story. Since many readers are gravely disappointed by this, I will endeavour to satisfy their curiosity about what happens to many characters after the story ended.

I have compiled here the many questions that the readers had asked about this epic tale. Many of the answers that I have given here are available with historical proof in Tamil history and I hope they will provide you satisfaction.

1. Does Vandiya Devan marry Princess Kundavai?

Yes, after overcoming many other challenges, Kundavai and Vandiya Devan do get married. They inspire respect and devotion among the people of the kingdom. In Thanjavur Brihadeshwara Temple, there is an inscription that says, 'Raja Raja Devar's esteemed Sister and Mahadevi of Vallavareyan Vandiya Devan Paranthaka Kundavaiyar.'

2. What happens to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar? Does he survive?

The Iron Man of the Chola Kingdom, Chinna Pazhuvetarayar, does indeed survive and returns to the court and serves the

kingdom.

3. What did Veera Vaishnavan Azhwarkadiyan Nambi do? Is he successful?

Azhwarkadiyan Nambi continues his work as a spy and learns more about Nandini and Ravidasan's activities.

4. What happened to the war campaign that Ponniyin Selvar wanted to embark on?

Vandiya Devan and Ponniyin Selvar build a huge fleet of ships and embark on a war campaign. They successfully vanquish the sea pirates and establish Chola suzerainty in many kingdoms beyond Elangai. For fifteen years, Uttama Cholar reigned as the king. And after his death, Arulmozhivarmar ascends the throne as Raja Raja Chola and reigns the kingdom for many more years.

5. What happened to Chinna Pazhuvetarayar's daughter and the old Madhuranthakan?

Old Madhuranthakan gets the support of the Elangai and Chera kings and tries to capture the old Pandya Kingdom. After Raja Raja Cholan comes to power, he wins Amara Bujaka Nedunchezhiyan in war, and the old Madhuranthakan attains warrior's heaven.

6. What happens to the young Pandya heir who Nandini had crowned in the woods of Thirupurambayam?

This young Pandya heir claims the right to the Pandya throne. He escapes from the battlefield and conspires to win the kingdom back. He is later vanquished by Raja Raja Cholan's son, Rajendra Cholan.

7. What happens to Nandini?

Nandini gives up her life after the death of her twin, Amara Bujaka Nedunchezhiyan. Before she dies, Raja Raja Cholan meets

her and she tells him the secret of her birth and the truth about Karikalan.

8. Did Kudanthai Jodhidhar's predictions about Vanathi come true?

Yes, Kudanthai Jodhidhar's predictions about Vanathi do indeed come true. (Though we don't know if he really saw this in astrology or guessed it based on probability). The son born to Vanathi ascends the throne as Rajendra Chola and attains glory as 'the Chola who won Ganga and Kadaram'. But Vanathi stays true to her vow and dies without decorating the throne. During Raja Raja Cholan's ascension, another queen named 'Ulagamahadevi' becomes the empress and sits next to Raja Raja Cholan.

9. What did the Abathuuthavigal do next?

The Pandya Abathuuthavigal tirelessly try to establish an independent Pandya kingdom. Until Nandini was alive, Aditya Karikalan's death was not formally investigated. But after she gives up her life, Raja Raja Cholan charges Ravidasana and the rest of the Abathuuthavigal and punishes them for their role in the murder by seizing their assets.

Here I also endeavour to tell you what happened to three other characters that the readers didn't really care about.

Sundara Cholar lives for three more years in Kanchi at the Golden palace and then dies there. He is known in the annals of history as 'The Chola who died in the Golden Palace.' His beloved wife and empress Vanamadevi performs sati on his funeral pyre.

Parthibendran, incensed by Kundavai's refusal of his hand, tries to seize power in Kanchi and dies in that attempt.

Kandanmaran builds a new palace on the banks of the Pallar river and performs great service for the Chola Kingdom. The Sambuvarayar clan attains many glories after his time.

I have provided these details just to please the readers. To tell the truth, there are many stories that we can write based on these incidents.

There are many glorious stories that one can write about the kings who came after Uttama Chola. Raja Raja Cholan, Rajendra Chola, Rajadhirajan, Veera Rajendran, and Kulothunga Chola were emperors whose stories of valour can inspire many epic tales.

I truly believe and hope that many more writers will write inspiring tales of bravery and valour from our Tamil History.

The End

[1] *Present day Java, Indonesia*

[2] *Present day Cambodia*

[3] *Located at a distance of 15 km from [Tiruchirapalli](#), 45 km from Thanjavur. It is the fourth oldest water diversion or water-regulator structures in the world and the oldest in India that is still in use.*

[4] **Thyagaraja Temple** is a [Shiva](#) temple, located in the town of [Thiruvarur](#) in [Tamil Nadu, India](#). Shiva is worshiped as Puttridankondar, and is represented by the [lingam](#). Daily poojas are offered to his idol referred to as Maragatha lingam. The main idol of worship is Lord Veedhi Vidangar (processional icon – Thiyagarajar), depicted as a [Somaskanda](#) form. His consort [Parvathi](#) is depicted as Kondi. The presiding deity is revered in the 7th century Saiva canonical work, the [Tevaram](#), written in Tamil by saint poets known as the [nayanars](#) and classified as [Paadal Petra Sthalam](#).

[5] *The sprawling temple tank of Thiruvarur is the largest in India and covers 16 acres of land.*

[6] *Sambrani is called benzoin resin, which is used in Hindu pooja rooms to prepare one for prayer. In this instance, the Sambrani that was used had a special incense that put one to sleep.*

[7] **Konerirajapuram** is a village in the [Mayiladuthurai](#) taluk of [Mayiladuthurai district, Tamil Nadu, India](#). It is famous for the [Uma Maheswarar Temple](#). It was also known as

Thirunallam. (Courtesy: Wikipedia)

[8] *The Cadamba is one of the important medicinal plants belonging to the Rubiaceae family. A large tree with a broad crown, and straight cylindrical bole, Kadamba is quick growing, with broad spreading branches. The flower of the tree is red to orange in colour, occurring in dense, globe-like head. (Courtesy: Wikipedia)*

[9] *A popular merchant guild during the Chola times.*

[10] *Captain of the ship*

[11] *Another ancient name for Sri Lanka*

[12] *Night Flowering Jasmine*

[13] *Hindu God of Love*

[14] *Pandyan's Queen*

[15] *Indra's (King of Devas) thunderbolt weapon*

[16] *God of Fire*

[17] *Traditional south-Indian dish made of rice and lentils.*

[18] *A delicious rice dish prepared with tamarind and served at Vaishnavite temples*

[19] *Here the Saivar is referring to Pey Alwar (also spelt as Peyalvar) and Bhoothathu Alvar. Both the Alvars were called thus for their mad devotion of Maha Vishnu. Pey or Pei and Bootham in Tamil means 'ghosts, spirits and ghouls.'*

[20] *Located 80 km north of present-day Tiruchirappalli*

[21] *Legendary couple in Hindu puranic tales. Savithri was a devoted wife to Sathyavan who she married knowing well that he would die young. When Sathyavan's death occurs, Lord Yama claims his life and is followed persistently by Savithri. Unable to persuade her to go away, Yama offers her three boons and asks her to claim any boon except that of her husband's life. Savithri, asks him to restore her father-in-law's vision and the kingdom that he had lost. The last boon she asks that she become a mother of hundred sons. Yama, exasperated by her persistence gives her the boon only to realize that he would have to give back her husband's life so that his third boon comes to fruition.*

[22] Refers to a puranic tale where Maha Vishnu came to rescue an elephant who was attacked by a crocodile in a pond

[23] According to puranic tales, the gatekeepers of Vaikuntam (abode of Vishnu) were cursed to take birth as mortals. They pray to Vishnu to lift the curse but he tells them that it is not possible. He gives them two options. To be born as devotees of Vishnu seven times or as enemies of Vishnu for three times. Jaya & Vijaya choose the second option and are born as Hiranyakashyap, Hiranyakshan, Ravana, Kumbakarna, Sisupalan, Kamsan who were killed by Maha Vishnu.

[24] Also known as Vishnuloka, Vaikuntam is the abode of Maha Vishnu, the eternal highest realm where Vishnu devotees go after liberation from their mortal coil.

[25] Maha Vishnu assumes Narasimha avatar to save his devotee Prahalad, son of the asura Hiranyakashyap.

[26] Valorous son of Pandava hero Arjuna. Abhimanyu was killed by the Kauravas in the battlefield through unfair means, when he was weapon less and alone.

[27] Karikala Cholan was an early Chola who had planted the Chola flag all the way to Himalayas.

[28] A necklace made of nine precious gems presented to a Pandya King by Indra, the King of Devas

[29] Devaram song composed by poet saint Sundaramurthy Nayanar

[30] The life-giving herb that Hanuman was asked to bring from Himalayas to revive Lakshman, brother of Lord Rama in Ramayana.

[31] Also known as Sethumadavapuram, this is a town in the south-eastern coast of Nagapattinam.

[32] Located in central Sri Lanka, the Rohana mountain is known by many names in the present day. It is called Sri Pada (footprint of Buddha) and also as Adam's Peak.

[33] Son of Ravana in Ramayana, a powerful asura well-versed in magical arts and sorcery.

[34] A respectful term to address women of high stature or royal birth.

[35] A ruler of Parambu Naadu (Border land of Tamil Nadu and Kerala) in the Sangam era who was famous for his benevolence and is famous for giving away his chariot for a

climber plant.

[36] *Honour guard of Shiva*

[37] *Father's younger brother or younger male cousins are called Chithappa in Tamil.*

[38] *Sacred mark applied on one's forehead.*

[39] *The dreaded personification of the planet Saturn, also known as Shani Eshwaran; a stern taskmaster who metes out just punishments and hardships to people based on their past deeds. In astrology, during the transit of Saturn, people face hurdles, hardships, and sorrows. But are also apparently rewarded at the end of the period.*

[40] *Means 'uncle' in Tamil. Generally used as a respectful term for older people who are related too. Technically could refer to: maternal uncle, paternal aunt's husband, elder sister's husband and so on.*

[41] *Veera Pandya's elite bodyguard army who swore to avenge his inglorious death.*

[42] *Mid-January to Mid-February according to Tamil Calendar.*

[43] *Mid-December to Mid-January according to Tamil Calendar.*

[44] *Celebrated Tamil poet and philosopher who wrote Thirukkural – a collection of epithets on edicts, politics, economics etc.*

[45] *An auspicious day in the Tamil month of Margazhi (Mid-December to Mid-January) when the star of Arudra (also known as Thiruvathirai) is on the rise and is dedicated to the cosmic dance of Lord Shiva.*

[46] *In Ramayana, Lord Rama's coronation didn't happen on the appointed date; instead, he was exiled by his father. In this context, Kundavai says thus because she is worried about the coronation of her brother.*

[47] *Known as Thirugnana Sambandar, he was a poet saint who lived in 7th Century AD. He was a child prodigy and a contemporary of Appar, who composed 16,000 hymns on Lord Shiva.*

[48] *Lines in one's palm that signifies kingship. In general, Shanku is Maha Vishnu's conch and Chakra is his discus. According to palmistry, anyone who has these lines in their hands would rule the world.*

[49] A popular devaram (thevaram) song that narrates how Appar wished to go to Kailash Mountain to see Lord Shiva and he is instead asked to go to Thiruvaiyaru, where he gets whatever he would have experienced in Kailash.

[50] In Ramayana, Sumathra was the Chief Minister of Dasaratha who drives the chariot for Rama to leave them near the forest, so that they could begin their exile.

[51] Mother of the Universe

[52] Goddess Durga who kills the asura Mahishasura and hence is known as 'Mahishasura Mardini'

[53] A deceitful demon who is slayed by Goddess Durga.

[54] Scriptures say that Muyalakan is the personification of ignorance and he is featured as an asura who lies beneath Lord Shiva's famous Natarajar form in Chidambaram Temple.

[55] Karikala Chola, one of the early Chola kings. He built the Grand Anaicut (Kallanai) in Trichy, one of the oldest dams in the world which still stands to this day. He is revered as one of the greatest Chola Kings.

[56] A medieval Tamil poet and the author of the Ramavataram, popularly known as Kamba Ramayanam – literally translates to: the version of Ramayan written by the poet Kambar.

[57] Vijayalakshmi and Veeralakshmi are the personifications of Goddess Lakshmi who bless us with victory and bravery. Vijaya is victory, and Veera is bravery in Tamil.

[58] An immortal Tamil war cry that translates to 'Brave spear' and 'Victorious Spear'; Used in context as: Victory to the brave spear!

[59] Brave son of the Pandava hero, Arjuna

[60] Audience hall/auditorium

[61] Rice grains coated in turmeric and saffron showered by elders on the youngsters during wedding or any other event symbolising blessings of prosperity.

[62] Peepul Tree

[63] Sultan Champa is a beautiful large evergreen tree native to southern coastal India, East Africa, Malaysia and Australia.

[\[64\]](#) *Supreme Self*